XENON PRESS PRESENTS

THE NINTH VEIN

a novel of Ashkarad

In the salt-choked city of Ashkarad, flesh is currency and every heartbeat is a debt. Darius Mehran, a surgeon with a borrowed heart and a ledger of sold years, is pulled into a war between the Church of the Silent Chorus and the nine veins of power buried in human flesh. To save the girl with carbon scales, he must open a door that was never meant for a person — the Ninth Vein, the throne at the root of the body politic.

FLESH · MARROW · BLOOD · BREATH · NERVE · BONE · MIND · SOUL · THRONE

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For everyone whose heart is on loan —
keep paying the interest.

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are products of the imagination or used fictitiously.
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PROLOGUE

The Last Honest Thief

The salt storm called grace was swallowing the Marrowworks whole, turning the organ docks into a graveyard of white noise. It fell the way paperwork fell in Ashkarad — steadily, indifferently, covering everything equally — and it hissed against the dock lamps until their glow was nothing but smudged halos, each one a wound of light in the fog. Darius Mehran pressed his face against the cold metal of the harvestcrate and listened to the rhythmic thud of his own gravel-heart against his ribs, a sound like stones tumbling in a jar. Twenty-seven years old, and already his body was a ledger of IOUs: the heart that had failed him at nineteen, the seven years he'd sold to Saint Ferrous Hospital to pay for its replacement, the milliliters of blood still owed to the syndicate that owned his internship — drawn monthly, at their convenience, with interest compounding every salt-moon. He had run the arithmetic so many times it had worn smooth, like a coin handled too long. Tonight's job was supposed to balance the scales. One heart, one payment, one way out of the debt-pit.

"Cut it clean, Mehran," Kael's voice crackled through the fog, thin as wire. The man was somewhere above him on the crane gantry, running cover for the crew, and the storm ate half his words and returned them salted. "No nicks. The buyer wants it singing."

Singing. Dock-slang for a heart that had been harvested right, still firm, still worth its weight on the slab. Darius adjusted his gloves, the leather worn thin at the fingertips — everything he owned was worn thin at the points where it touched his work — and let himself think, briefly, of the payment. He'd performed twelve heart transplants in his career, eleven legal and one very illegal, and each time he had felt the same fragile awe at the fist-sized muscle that kept another person alive: the way it sat in the chest like a creditor who never slept, collecting without pause, forgiving nothing. This one was different. The crate was marked with the Church's silver chalice, fresh-stenciled, the paint still tacky, and the Syndic Wardens would carve them all to pieces if they were caught — slowly, on the record, with forms. But the payment was enough to buy back his years, his autonomy, maybe even his soul if he still had one to spare. He had checked the ledger. The soul column had been empty for a long time.

The harvestcrate's seals yielded to his bone-saw with a sigh of pressurized air, long and modest, like a patient exhaling before an incision. Inside, nestled in biogel that glowed faintly where his lamp touched it, lay the heart. It was smaller than he expected, dark as a bruise, folded in on itself like a fist. And it was not alone. A black umbra lily, its petals not of flesh

but of shadow, wrapped around a central core that pulsed with a dim, violet light — slow, regular, unhurried, the pulse of something that had never once needed to hurry. It was beautiful and wrong, like something that had grown in the absence of light, the way debts grew in the absence of money. His surgeon's hands wanted to catalog it. His debtor's hands wanted to run.

"What is it?" Suri Kaveh whispered, her carbon-scaled arm gleaming in the gloom like a piece of midnight hammered flat. She knelt beside him at the crate's edge, lips moving over the count — the seconds until the next patrol sweep, timed with the practiced rhythm of a debt-courier who had scheduled her whole life to the city's tides. "Forty seconds," she breathed. "Then the walkway clears. Then it doesn't."

"Dangerous," Darius said, reaching for the reliquary. "And valuable. Don't drop it."

The glass case was cool against his palms, cool the way the Marrowworks was cool, cold as an auditor's shoulder. He lifted it free of the biogel and the lily inside seemed to breathe, its petals unfolding slightly before folding back in, a motion that repeated with the patience of tide. A low thrum resonated through the case, a vibration that matched the rhythm of his own failing heart — matched it, then corrected it, the way a creditor corrects a debtor's arithmetic. He felt the hum arrive in his teeth before he heard it. For a moment he felt a strange kinship with the thing, as if it understood what it was to be broken and held together by borrowed parts, as if it, too, were an account that refused to close.

The alarm screamed through the dock, a sound like tearing metal, and the grace itself seemed to flinch. Bone-plate enforcers emerged from the fog in a staggered line, their masks smooth as skulls, their pulse-readers whirring as they scanned for heartbeats. The machines' little styli jogged across paper, printing rhythms in tight grey waves, and where a wave broke pattern the enforcers turned as one, like weather deciding where to strike. Kael swore, dropping from the gantry, shoving a crate between them and the line. "Run! Mehran, get it to the docks!"

Darius didn't need telling twice. The reliquary clutched to his chest, he sprinted through the maze of stacked crates, counting turns the way Suri had drilled him — three left, a ramp, the shadow of the tithe-barge cradle — salt stinging his eyes, the storm swallowing the sounds of his crewmates being cut down behind him. He heard the wet thud of impact, the sharp crack of bone, and his surgeon's mind, useless and automatic, triaged each one: *not survivable; not survivable; no field kit in the world.* He could not stop. Stopping was a line item the whole crew would pay for. And beneath it all, steady and calm, came the thrum of the lily in his hands, unbothered by the audit of lives being closed around it, as if it had heard this entry before and knew how it ended.

A shot rang out, and pain exploded in his gut. Darius collapsed into a puddle of brine and blood, the reliquary slipping from his grasp — and he watched it go with the particular horror of a man watching his debt walk away. The glass case cracked against the dock's grated floor, a spiderweb of fractures spreading across its surface, fast and fine, like ink crawling through wet paper. Through the haze of pain he saw the lily inside pulse once, twice, then unfold with a sound like tearing silk. Shadowy petals unfurled, reaching for him — not waving, *reaching*, deliberate as a hand extended across a table to seal a bargain — and the cold spread through him like an entry being written in a book he could not see. The last thing he saw before darkness claimed him was the enforcer captain kneeling in the blood at the grate, still amid all the sweep and shouting, tasting it from a gloved fingertip.

Darius woke to the taste of salt and iron. Dawn was breaking over the Marrowworks, the grace having receded overnight to leave behind a city bleached white — every railing, every rope, every stacked crate furred with pale crystal, the whole industrial belt lying under a rime that looked, from a distance, like a season the world had never planned for. He was lying in a gutter, his uniform soaked through with blood and brine, and his first professional thought, before fear, before grief, was an inventory: breathing — yes; gut — and his hand found his stomach and the audit failed, because the wound was gone. The gut was a ruin of fire no longer. He sat up, wincing at muscles that ached like overworked machinery, and pressed his palm flat against his abdomen. The wound was healed over with flesh that was pale and smooth, like new leather, like skin that had never been opened at all. He knew scars. He had made a career of reading them. This one left only the memory of pain.

He remembered the enforcer's voice, calm and certain. "It chose."

The reliquary lay beside him in the gutter, the glass shattered, the lily gone. Panic seized him — he'd failed, the heart was lost, his crew was dead, and he was still in debt; every column of his life stood unbalanced, and now two of them were written in other people's blood. But then he felt it: a second rhythm beneath his own, slow and steady, like the tide in his veins. It wasn't his gravel-heart anymore; that had been a borrowed thing, always on the verge of failure, a machine he serviced with other people's money. This was something else, something alive and patient, something that beat as if it had all the time in the world and intended to use his.

He lifted his shirt. His chest was unmarked, but beneath the skin he could feel the lily's presence, a network of shadowy veins that pulsed in time with the new rhythm, dark filaments visible the way ink is visible under wet paper. It was warm, and it was hungry. He knew hunger when he felt it; he'd been feeding one for eight years.

"Hello?" he called, his voice raw, to the thing inside his own body — the absurdity of it almost made him laugh. "Are you in there?"

No answer, only the thrumming in his chest, a language he didn't understand but somehow recognized — the same rhythm he'd felt in the dock, the same calm in the chaos, the same patient correction of his failing meter. The lily had saved him. The lily had chosen him, if the captain was to be believed, and the captain had tasted the evidence. But nothing in Ashkarad saved a man for free. At what cost? He made himself ask it the way he asked it of every contract: what, and when, and paid by whom?

Darius pushed himself to his feet, and his body took the weight like it belonged to a stronger man. The pain in his gut was gone, replaced by a strange new vitality, a hum in the marrow, in the blood, in the roots of his teeth. He was alive, and he was no longer alone.

He stumbled through the waking streets of the Saltstairs, past shutters cracking open and awnings dripping salt-water, and all the while he could feel the lily's presence growing, its roots spreading through him with the slow confidence of an institution taking possession. It was learning his body, mapping his nerves, rewriting his flesh — entering itself line by line into whatever ledger it kept inside him. And in the back of his mind, he heard a voice, soft as the fall of ash.

You are mine now.

* * *

The enforcer captain stood at the edge of the dock, watching the sunrise over the white city. The blood at the grate had been washed clean by the grace, every crystal of it dissolved and carried seaward, but he could still taste it on his lips — metallic, vital, and strangely familiar, like a signature he had been shown once, long ago, in a room with no windows. He knelt again, running a gloved finger over the grate where Darius Mehran had lain, and brought the fingertip to the bone mask's mouth as if the iron itself might want a second opinion.

"It chose," he murmured, the mask hiding his smile. "As it always does."

Behind him, the bone-plate enforcers stood at attention, their pulse-readers silent, their printed slips curling in the damp — nothing on them but the ordinary heartbeats of an ordinary dock. The captain knew what they didn't: that the heart they'd been sent to retrieve was already gone, fused to the man who had stolen it, and that this was not a failure of the sweep but the sweep's entire purpose, though no order had ever said so in writing. The man who had crawled out of the gutter was now something more than human, something the Church had been waiting generations to find. Ledgers could be rewritten. Crews could be written off. A chosen vessel, once rooted, was an asset that appreciated.

The captain straightened, his gaze fixed on the horizon where the sun was bleeding into the salt sea, and the storm-light made the white city blush like something newly born.

"Bring me the others," he said, his voice calm as the grave. "The choir must be complete."

CHAPTER 1

Two Heartbeats

The gravel-heart had always been a poor substitute, but it had been his. Now it was gone, replaced by something that pulsed with a patient rhythm that was not his own. Darius Mehran sat on the edge of his cot in the Saltstairs tenement, the thin mattress sagging under his weight, and pressed a hand to the center of his chest. The flesh there was warm, almost hot, beneath his fingers—warmer than skin had any right to be. Two days since the heist, since the gut-shot that should have killed him, since the stolen reliquary had burst open like a seed and taken root in his ruined chest. Saint Ferrous Hospital would have declared him dead. The Syndic Wardens would have dragged his body to the ledgers. But he was here, in his rented room, with a second heartbeat keeping time against his ribs.

The room smelled of damp plaster, old blood, and the salt that seeped through the walls like sweat. Outside, the city was beginning to stir—footsteps in the hallway above, the distant clang of a tithe-warehouse door, the ever-present sigh of the storm-walls holding back the salt sea. Dar closed his eyes. He could still feel the bullet tearing through him, the sudden bloom of cold in his gut, the way the world had grayed at the edges. Then the reliquary—glass cool in his hands, the heart inside it dark as a bruise—and the way it had seemed to recognize him. When he'd pressed it to his wound, the thing had unfolded like a black flower, roots sinking into his flesh, knitting him closed from the inside out.

He stood, swaying slightly, and crossed to the small mirror above the washbasin. The face looking back was his, but changed. The paleness was gone, replaced by a flush that seemed to come from within. His eyes were clearer, the whites less yellowed than they'd been even a week ago. He pulled open his shirt, the fabric rough against his skin. Over his heart, where the surgeons had once grafted the gravel-heart, there was a pattern of faint, silvery veins beneath the skin—like roots, or like the veins on a leaf. They pulsed in time with the second heartbeat, a slow, deliberate rhythm that made his own pulse seem frantic by comparison.

"Hello," he said to the reflection, his voice raspy. "Or whatever you are."

The thing in his chest didn't answer, but it pulsed harder, as if in acknowledgment. Dar shuddered and turned away from the mirror. He needed to understand what had happened, what this was. He went to his small desk and spread out the few medical texts he'd managed to keep—a smuggled copy of Vahid Anousheh's discredited papers on the Nine Veins, a tattered anatomy atlas, a ledger of his own vital-debt. He flipped through Anousheh's pages, his fingers tracing the crude illustrations of the Veins. First Vein: Flesh. Wounds knit, strength swells. It

was the most basic, the most survivable. The others... the others were things of myth, or nightmares. He stopped at a page that had been heavily annotated in the margins, in a hand that wasn't his own—a reference to the Umbra Lily, a symbiotic organism that "chose its host" and "opened the path to transcendence." The note was frantic, desperate. "It is not evil. It is alien. It wants to bloom. And a bloom has a direction."

Dar slammed the book shut. Bloom. The word made his skin prickle. He went to the window and pulled back the curtain. The Saltstairs were a stacked canyon of crumbling brick and rusted iron, the windows of other tenements like eyes watching him. In the distance, the Choratorium rose like a bone-white mountain, its spires lost in the perpetual fog that clung to the upper districts. The Church of the Silent Chorus. They were the ones who had made the heart he'd stolen. They were the ones who might want it back. And if they found it... if they found what it had become...

He turned away from the window as a wave of weakness washed over him. The room seemed to tilt, and he had to grab the edge of the desk to stay upright. His breath came in short, shallow gasps. What was happening? He looked down at his hands. They were trembling. The second heartbeat in his chest had slowed to a crawl, barely there. Then he noticed the light—late afternoon sun was streaming through the window, bathing the room in a harsh, golden glare. He stumbled to the curtain and yanked it shut. The room plunged into shadow. Instantly, the weakness receded, ebbing out of his limbs. The second heartbeat picked up its pace, stronger and surer than before. A warmth spread through his chest, and he felt a strange, deep hunger—not for food, but for something else. Something vital.

He sank into his chair, breathing heavily. So. Darkness fed it. Light hurt it. It was a simple rule, but one that could get him killed. A Syndic Warden with a pulse-reader at his door would hear two hearts—one human, one something else—and that would be the end of him. Debt-prison in the seawalls. The ledgers. The thought made his stomach clench. He owed Saint Ferrous Hospital seven years of his life for the gravel-heart operation. If they found out about... this... they'd take the rest and more. He was collateral now, twice over, and one of his creditors had never signed anything at all.

He tried to focus on something else, anything else. His gaze fell on the small knife on his desk—the one he used for dissecting specimens at the hospital. He picked it up, the weight familiar in his hand. Without thinking, he dragged the blade across the palm of his other hand. A thin line of blood welled up, bright red against his pale skin. The pain was sharp, clean. But then... something else. A sudden, fierce craving in his chest, a hunger that made his mouth water and his fingers tremble. The second heartbeat was racing now, a frantic drum against his ribs. He watched, horrified, as the blood on his palm didn't just well up—it seemed to flow, to

pulse, as if drawn by something inside him, as if the wound were less an injury than an opening of an account.

He quickly pressed his palm to his shirt, trying to stem the flow. The craving subsided as the bleeding slowed, but the memory of it left him cold. It drank his blood when he was calm, and it craved it viciously when he bled. Another rule. Another way to die. He wrapped his hand in a rag, the rough fabric scraping against the wound, and leaned back in his chair. The First Vein was stirring. He could feel it—not in his strength, not yet, but in the way his body was changing, in the way it was answering to the thing inside him. Fleshy resilience. That was all for now, but it was a start. And a start was dangerous.

He needed to leave. Needed to be somewhere else, somewhere with people, where the Lily couldn't fully reveal itself. He stood, his movements easier now, stronger than they'd been before the wound. The weakness from the sunlight was gone, replaced by a steady, humming energy, an organ-hum he felt in his teeth. He pulled on his coat, the fabric stretching slightly across his shoulders. When had he gotten so broad? He shook his head. It was just the fever, the shock. He was still the same man who owed seven years to a hospital, who couldn't afford to eat meat more than once a week. He told himself that twice, and neither time did it quite balance.

He opened the door and stepped into the hallway. The air was thick with the smell of boiled cabbage and damp wool. Mrs. Gable from downstairs was sweeping her stoop, her broom scratching against the stone. She glanced up at him, her eyes widening slightly. "You're looking well, Doctor Mehran," she said, her voice raspy with age. "The fever broke?"

Dar managed a smile. "Something like that." He kept his voice low, his hand pressed against his coat, over the place where the second heartbeat pulsed beneath his ribs. He needed to get to the Undergleam, to find Suri. She was a debt-courier, she knew things, and she owed him one. If anyone could help him understand what was happening, it was her. If she didn't turn him in first.

He walked down the stairs, the worn wood groaning under his weight. Each step felt surer than the last, his muscles responding with an ease he hadn't known since he was a boy. The First Vein. Strength swells. He gripped the banister, his fingers tightening until the wood creaked. This was real. This was happening.

The street outside was chaos—pushcarts and shouting vendors, the clatter of glass funiculars high above the fog, the ever-present tang of salt and ozone. Dar pulled his collar up, trying to blend in. He kept his eyes down, his hands in his pockets, but he couldn't shake the feeling of being watched. Of being counted. Somewhere above, a census clerk was tallying the

district. He hurried through the crowd, his longer strides carrying him past the slower-moving pedestrians, until he reached the entrance to the Undergleam—a narrow alley that smelled of piss and frying fish.

The air changed as he descended. The noise of the street faded, replaced by the murmur of voices and the clink of coin. The Undergleam was a warren of stalls and shadows, a place where information was traded as freely as stolen organs. Dar scanned the crowd, his eyes searching for Suri's familiar carbon-scaled arm. He found her at a stall selling smuggled pain-killers, her arm gleaming dully in the dim light. She was counting coins with precise, economical movements, her face a mask of concentration.

"Suri," he said, his voice tight. She looked up, her sharp eyes taking him in. The recognition in them was slow, then dawning. Then confusion.

"Darius Mehran," she said, her voice flat. "You're supposed to be dead. The Gavel is putting out a bounty for the heart you stole. They say it's singing."

Dar's blood ran cold. "It's not singing. It's... it's in me." He lowered his voice further, leaning close. "I need to talk. Now."

Suri's eyes narrowed. "Talk? You cost me a job, Mehran. The Gavel doesn't like being cheated." She glanced around, then nodded toward a narrow doorway. "Five minutes. Then I'm gone."

They slipped through the doorway into a storeroom stacked with crates of expired ration packs. The air was thick with the smell of dust and decay. Suri leaned against a crate, her arms crossed. "Talk. And make it worth my while."

Dar hesitated. How could he explain? The Lily, the two heartbeats, the way his body was changing? He looked at her, at the carbon scales that sheared off her right arm at the elbow, the graft she'd pawned her skin for and never talked about. She understood bodies. She understood debt. She understood the cost.

"It chose me," he said, the words feeling inadequate. "After the heist... I was gut-shot. The heart... it opened. It fused with me." He pressed a hand to his chest. "There are two heartbeats in here, Suri. Two."

She stared at him, then slowly reached out and pressed her carbon-scaled fingers to his throat. Her touch was cold, precise. She counted, her lips moving silently. Then she frowned. "Two distinct rhythms. One human. One... something else." She pulled her hand back, her expression unreadable. "The Umbra Lily. I've heard the stories. The Silent Chorus grows them. They say they bloom."

"Not yet," Dar said quickly. "But it's changing me. I'm stronger. Faster. But light hurts it, and it... it craves blood when I bleed." He looked down at his bandaged hand. "And there's a Warden audit tomorrow. A pulse-reader. If they hear two beats..."

Suri was silent for a long moment, her gaze fixed on the floor. Then she looked up, her eyes hard. "You're in over your head, Mehran. Deep." She uncrossed her arms and reached into her pocket, pulling out a small, metal device. It looked like a child's toy, a crank with a needle and a paper feed. "A pulse-reader. I lifted it from a Warden last month. For a job. You can practice."

Dar took the device, its metal cold in his hand. "Practice?"

"See what it sounds like. See if you can fool it." Suri's voice was flat, but there was an edge of something else—worry, maybe. Or just the ledgerkeeper in her, counting the cost. "I can't help you with the Lily. But I can help you not get caught."

Dar nodded, his throat tight. "Thank you."

Suri gave him a sharp, unreadable look. "Don't thank me yet. And don't follow me. The Gavel is looking for you." She turned and slipped out the door, leaving Dar alone with the pulse-reader and the frantic drumming of two hearts in his chest.

He waited until her footsteps had faded before he left the storeroom. The Undergleam was quieter now, the vendors packing up their stalls, lamps being shuttered one by one. Dar walked back toward the Saltstairs, the pulse-reader clutched in his hand. He needed to practice. He needed to be ready for the audit. He needed to survive.

He reached his tenement and climbed the stairs to his room. The chalk outline on the floor where he'd lain bleeding was still visible, a faint white smudge on the dark wood—the city had drawn him as a finished entry, and here he stood, disputing the record. He sat on the cot, the pulse-reader on the desk in front of him. He took a deep breath, trying to calm his racing heart. The second heartbeat in his chest was steady, patient. He picked up the reader and placed the cold metal disc against his throat. He began to turn the crank.

The needle jumped at first, erratic. Then it settled into a rhythm, but it wasn't right. It was a stuttering, confused thing, like a heart trying to find its way. Dar kept turning, his knuckles white. The machine whirred, the needle scraping across the paper. Then, suddenly, it stopped. The needle froze, quivering, and the machine spat out a slip of paper. Dar snatched it up and squinted at the tiny, spidery writing.

ERROR: RHYTHM UNRESOLVED. MACHINE FAULT.

He stared at the words, his breath catching in his throat. A machine fault. The Warden would see that, shrug, and move on. He'd be safe. For now. He slumped back in his chair, the relief so intense it made him sick. He leaned over the washbasin and vomited, his stomach heaving until there was nothing left but bile and the taste of fear.

When he was done, he rinsed his mouth and splashed water on his face. He looked at his reflection in the mirror—pale, hollow-eyed, but alive. Two heartbeats. One of them wasn't his. And someone was looking for the heart he'd stolen. He walked to the window and pulled back the curtain. The sun was setting, casting long shadows across the Saltstairs. In the fading light, he saw it—chalk marks on the doorframe across the alley, drawn in the shape of a five-petaled flower. A census. A count. And one vessel was missing.

CHAPTER 2

The Courier

The door to Dar's tenement cell groaned on its rusted hinges, admitting not light but the scent of rain and carbon-scales. Suri Kaveh stood framed in the doorway, her right arm sheathed in those scales like armor, a ledger tucked under her other arm. Her eyes, sharp as broken glass, swept the room—once, twice, then fixed on Dar's chest where two heartbeats struggled beneath his skin. She had the look of a collector who has come for a payment and found the account doing something accounts should not do.

"You're breathing," she said, not a question but a statement that cost her three steps into the room. She counted them aloud. "Three steps. Fourteen tiles to the door. One dead man breathing. That's a ledger imbalance, Mehran."

Dar sat up, the movement sending a familiar ache through his ribs where the Lily had knitted him back together. "Death notices get filed wrong sometimes. Especially in the Saltstairs."

"Not this wrong." She tossed the ledger onto his cot. It landed with a wet thud, the pages swollen with humidity, ink feathering at the edges where the damp had gotten in—the city got into everything eventually, even the records of what people owed. "Your debt's called in. Thirty days. Saint Ferrous Hospital wants their payment or they send you to the ledgers." She tapped the ledger with a fingernail painted black. "I saw your death notice posted myself. Two days ago. Room 7, third floor. Same building."

Dar didn't touch the ledger. The Lily inside him pulsed, a cold knot against his ribs. It liked Suri's presence—her warmth, the steady rhythm of her blood, the way she filled the small space with her carbon-scented energy. He could feel it leaning toward her, a plant toward a window. He kept his hands flat on his knees and pretended he couldn't feel it leaning.

"Someone made a mistake," Dar said, though the lie tasted like ash in his mouth.

"No mistakes in ledgers, Mehran. Only entries." Suri circled the room, her boots whispering on the concrete. She stopped before the barred window, peering through the salt-fogged glass at the vertical city rising above them, tier upon tier of lit windows like a wall of open accounts. "I came to collect from a corpse. Instead I find a man with two heartbeats." She turned, her eyes narrowing. "Tell me how many heartbeats you have, Dar Mehran."

"One," Dar said automatically. The Lily contracted at the word, a sharp pang in his chest, as if the lie were a physical thing he'd swallowed sideways.

"Wrong answer." Suri stepped closer, close enough for Dar to see the tiny scars around her eyes—places where skin had been traded for grafts, margin notes written on her face in a ledger she never discussed. "I count everything. Steps. Debts. Heartbeats. Yours don't match the pulse-readers at the hospital. They show one. But I hear two."

Dar's throat went dry. The Lily pulsed again, this time with a different rhythm—curious, probing. It had been quiet since the heist, content in the darkness of his cell, feeding on the blood he'd lost during his recovery. But Suri's proximity had woken it, the way a struck tuning fork wakes its twin across a room.

"What do you want, Suri?" Dar asked, keeping his voice even.

"The truth," she said, "and a favor."

Dar waited.

"You're a dead man walking, Mehran. Either to the ledgers or to something worse. I can make your death notice stick. Paperwork's easy when you know the right people. In return, you run a package for me. High-grain insulin, unlicensed anesthetic, stolen sleep—through the Undergleam tonight."

"The Undergleam?" Dar frowned. "That's the Cartographer's territory. Too many eyes."

"Exactly why it's perfect." Suri smiled, a flash of white teeth in the dim light. "The Cartographer sees everything, but notices nothing if you know how to move. And you, Mehran, have hands that move quiet. I remember."

Dar did too. Six months ago, Suri had come to Saint Ferrous with her arm torn open—carbon scales ripped away, muscle and bone exposed. She'd paid in blood for a quick stitch, the minimum the tithe would buy, but Dar had worked longer than necessary, carefully layering sutures beneath the scales, reinforcing the graft, doing the kind of slow work the hospital never billed for because it never counted as payment. It had cost him three vials of his own blood to the hospital tithe, but he'd done it anyway. She had never thanked him. She had also never forgotten. With Suri, those were the same thing.

"Why me?" Dar asked, though he already suspected the answer.

"The Lily likes me," Suri said, her eyes dropping to his chest. "It's singing to me. Soft, but clear. A debt-singer's song."

Dar didn't deny it. Instead, he stood, the movement sending a wave of dizziness through him. The Lily stabilized him, a second heartbeat steadying his balance, correcting his blood pressure like a clerk quietly fixing a misfiled column. "One run. That's all."

"One run," Suri agreed, "and your death notice gets filed as 'natural causes.' No questions asked." She extended her hand. Not to shake, but for him to seal the bargain. In the palm of her hand, a small flower was drawn in chalk—the same flower Dar had seen chalked on his neighbor's doorframe that morning.

Dar hesitated, then pressed his palm against hers. The chalk smeared, leaving a gray smear on both their hands. The Lily pulsed once, hard, as if in approval. He tried not to think about what it meant, that the thing in his chest witnessed his contracts now.

Suri retrieved the parcel from a satchel under her ledger and pushed it against his chest until he took its weight. "Wire seal stays intact," she said. "If you open it, I open you. Thirty days of debt canceled, one night of work. Simple arithmetic."

* * *

The Undergleam smelled of damp stone, lamp oil, and something sweet—rotten fruit left too long in the dark. Suri moved through the narrow alleyways with the confidence of someone who knew every crack in the pavement, every shadow that shifted. Dar followed, his own steps quieter than he remembered, the Lily in his chest humming a counterpoint to Suri's counted footsteps. Between them he carried the package: a wrapped parcel of medical tins bound with wire, sealed at the seams with black wax, light as bread and worth more than his lungs.

"Sixty-three steps to the first drop," she whispered, not looking back. "Then a right through the spice market. The air gets thick there—cumin and regret. Don't breathe deep."

Dar nodded, keeping his eyes on the back of her carbon-scaled arm. The scales shifted in the dim light of the gas lamps, each one catching the glow like a tiny mirror. He wondered how much of her she'd traded away for those scales—skin, muscle, years of life. The Lily seemed curious about them too, its pulse quickening whenever she moved her arm, a dog straining at the end of a leash only Dar could feel.

They reached the spice market, a narrow canyon between crumbling buildings where air hung thick with the scent of a hundred different spices. Dar did as Suri warned, breathing shallowly, but the Lily inside him seemed to thrive on the dense air, pulling it in through his skin, feeding on the scent of cumin and turmeric and something that smelled like burnt sugar. He felt wider. That was the only word for it. As if the walls of his body had been moved outward a handspan and the world was being poured into the extra room.

"Left here," Suri said, ducking through an archway that led into darkness. "The Cartographer's territory."

The Undergleam opened before them—a warren of tunnels and stalls lit by sputtering lamps and the phosphorescent glow of certain fungi growing on the walls. Merchants sold information, stolen goods, and memories. One stall had jars of preserved fears, another of forgotten dreams, each jar labeled in a spidery hand and priced by weight. Suri moved through the crowd with practiced ease, her carbon scales parting the way like a ship's bow.

"Twenty-seven steps to the canal," she counted, not bothering to lower her voice. "Then we'll be in the clear. The Cartographer doesn't deal in contraband—only maps. We're safe."

Dar wasn't so sure. Every shadow seemed to hold eyes, every flicker of light seemed to reveal faces that turned to follow their progress. The Lily in his chest was singing now—a low, resonant hum that vibrated through his ribs and into his bones. It was the same song it had sung to Suri, but now Dar could hear it too, and it was calling him forward, toward something in the darkness ahead. He wanted to ask it to stop. He suspected it wouldn't. Debts, the Lily seemed to say, in a language older than ledgers. Everything here was payment for something.

They reached the drainage canal—a wide trench carved into the floor of the Undergleam, where runoff from the Saltstairs emptied into the sea. The air here was thick with the smell of salt and decay, and the water in the canal was black and still, a page no one had written on yet. A crowd had gathered at the railing—merchants, couriers, a few Syndic Wardens who'd clearly been paid to look the other way. All of them were staring into the water, their faces illuminated by the sputtering lamps, and not one of them was speaking. Silence, in the Undergleam, cost more than any of them could afford. They were paying it anyway.

"What is that?" Dar asked, though he already knew. The Lily was singing louder now, a chorus of one.

Suri stopped dead, her carbon scales going still. Her face, usually sharp and alert, had gone pale as salt. "No," she whispered. "Not her."

In the dark water of the canal, something was moving. Not a body, but something alive. Wet, black petals unfurled from the stone of the canal wall, pulsing with a soft, internal light, opening and closing like slow gills. Between them, something sang—a clear, harmonic voice that rose and fell with the rhythm of the tides. It was a courier's voice, familiar and terrible. A voice that used to count deliveries, swear at dockhands, laugh at bad jokes over cheap liquor. It was singing now the way glass sings when it is about to break.

Suri took a step back, her hand going to her throat. "That's Lena," she said, her voice cracking. "Lena Vance. Went into a tithe-clinic last spring. Said it was for a routine organ harvest. Never signed out."

The singing continued, beautiful and terrible, as the black petals in the canal wall pulsed in time with the melody. Dar watched, mesmerized, as the Lily in his chest began to answer the song—a counterpoint that resonated through his bones and into the stones beneath his feet. It was the same song, but different—older, deeper, full of questions it had been waiting to ask. The crowd at the railing did not move. Somewhere behind him, a jar of preserved fears cracked in its seller's hands.

Suri stared at the singing canal, her face ashen. "We have to go," she said, her voice barely a whisper. "Now."

But Dar couldn't move. His hand had drifted to his chest without his permission, pressing flat over the place where the Lily lived. The Lily was singing to the singing, and he was caught between them, a bridge of flesh and blood in a city that ran on debt and song. In the darkness of the Undergleam, surrounded by the scent of salt and decay, Dar Mehran finally understood the price of his survival. It wasn't just his own life anymore. It was the lives of others, drawn into the orbit of the symbiote in his chest, singing a song he had no choice but to follow.

CHAPTER 3

Grace

The salt storm hit like a fist to the throat, turning Ashkarad into a whiteout tomb. The city's bells fell silent one by one as it came, the tithe-bells, the market bells, even the fog-bells on the seawalls, until the only sound left was the wind itself—a wall of white howling down out of the drowned districts, carrying a payload of ground glass and old brine. The ledgers had a soft word for it. Grace, the clerks wrote, in their tidy columns: the interval when nothing could be collected, not coin, not work, not breath. The city held its ledger open and waited, like a creditor watching a debtor's door.

Dar stumbled through the Saltstairs, his collar pulled high against the grit that stung like needles. He kept his eyes down to slits, and not only because of the storm. The light was the problem—the white, blazing, sourceless light of a salt sky, pressing at his shutters even through the haze, and under it the second heartbeat in his chest had gone faint and whining, a candle dragged through wet weather. Every step felt like walking on borrowed legs. He had told himself he was going out for food, for news, for the ordinary business of the living. He had known, on some level he didn't inspect too closely, that he was going to Suri's bolt-hole, because the storm was coming and the storm meant darkness, and darkness meant the Lily would be fed and glad.

The wind howled through the alleyways, carrying the scent of brine and decay. He counted the turns to Suri's bolt-hole—three left, two down, one through the collapsed archway—counting because counting was how he kept his grip on the street while the street tried to erase itself. The city had a way of doing that in a storm, of folding its landmarks away like a merchant hiding his best stock. Twelve steps between corners. A handrail slick with salt-sweat. A shutter banging somewhere above like a heart in a glass jar. The cellar, when he reached it, was a known shelter during grace, a place where the poor huddled like mice while the rich rode their glass funiculars above the fog, sealed in their clean cars, paying for weather that couldn't touch them.

The door groaned as he pushed it open, revealing a space already crowded with bodies pressed close for warmth. A single oil lamp burned on a crate, casting long shadows that danced like nervous spirits across the curved ceiling. The room exhaled around him: boiled grain, wet wool, kerosene, the sour-sweet rot of too many people breathing in stone. A stevedore with a ruined lung sat propped against the far wall, wheezing in time with the wind, his chest playing a cracked counter-rhythm to the storm. Two children slept against each other

like books closed on the same page. An old woman was praying under her breath, not to any of the Veins but to the Choir itself, asking to be overlooked this season.

"Got room for one more?" Dar called, his voice swallowed by the storm's roar.

A woman with a child clinging to her back nodded toward a corner near the furnace grate. Dar squeezed through, brushing against damp wool and the smell of unwashed bodies, murmuring the small courtesies of tight spaces—forgive me, pardon, forgive me—until he reached the warmth radiating up through the iron grate like the palm of something buried alive.

Suri was already there, her carbon-scaled arm wrapped around a small bundle of blankets. She looked up, her eyes sharp even in the dim light.

"Thought you were dead," she said, her voice low.

"Death's a paperwork problem," Dar replied, settling beside her. "They haven't filed it yet."

Something that was almost a smile moved across her face and was gone, taxed before it could fully form. Her eyes went to his chest, to the place where his coat hung a little differently than it had before the heist, then back to his face. "You look wrong," she said. "Better than wrong. That's worse."

"I know," Dar said, because he did.

The lamp sputtered, then died, plunging them into absolute darkness. The collective gasp was followed by a shuffling as people adjusted to the black—the rustle of coats being drawn tighter, a child's whimper soothed without a word, the old woman's prayer continuing as if darkness had been the point all along. The storm hammered the door once, twice, then seemed to lean its whole white weight against the city and stay.

Dar felt it immediately—a warmth spreading through his chest, a hum that vibrated in his teeth. The Lily was in heaven. Total dark. No harsh light to weaken it. It drank the absence of photons, and Dar's senses bloomed in response, one after another, like lamps being lit in the windows of a house he'd thought empty. He could hear the heartbeats around him like cups filling—slow, fast, irregular, each a tiny drum in the symphony of survival. The stevedore's wrecked valve keeping its ruined time. The sleeping children, quick and light, two small sums that added up to nothing anyone had figured into the city's books. The woman with the child on her back, her pulse climbing each time the storm shook the door. The cellar's breath became a tangible thing, moving across his skin in waves of heat and cold, the grate exhaling up his spine while something colder flowed along the floor and pooled around his boots.

"Your heart's racing," Suri whispered beside him, her breath warm on his cheek. "Too much excitement for a dead man?"

"Just adjusting to the dark," Dar said, though he knew better. The Lily was adjusting too, and its adjustment had needs. Dark wasn't enough. It wanted blood given in the dark. Dar felt a pull, a leaning toward the warmth beside him—Suri. Her pulse was a steady thrum against his ribs, a beacon in the black, and the darkness had dissolved every wall he'd built between noticing that and surviving it. The Lily wanted what she had to give. And some cold, quiet part of him—call it hunger, call it the city, call it the patient arithmetic of survival—understood exactly how easy it would be to take.

Dar's hand trembled as he reached into his coat, fingers closing around his bone-saw. The tool was cool and familiar, its weight a comfort in the chaos, the one instrument he had never pawned even in the worst quarters. He could take what he needed without her knowing. A quick nick in her sleep, a few drops to satisfy the beast in his chest, and she would wake with a small scab and no invoice. The thought made his stomach twist. This was what the city had taught him—everything had a price, and someone always paid, and the whole art of living in Ashkarad was making sure that someone was never you. But Suri had bargained for his life, had chosen him over her employers. She wasn't a ledger entry. She was a person who counted steps and lies and debts, who had been kind when kindness was a currency she couldn't afford. He could hear her breathing. He could hear the bundle against her arm breathing. He thought about the difference between a debt and a theft, and how the ledgers never recorded the second kind, and how that had never once made it less real.

Dar made his choice. He drew the saw across his own palm instead. The pain was sharp and clean, a familiar sting, the kind a body knows how to file. He let his hand fall open, letting the blood well in the darkness. The Lily surged toward it, a hungry warmth that spread through his veins like liquid fire. It drank, and in the black, Dar felt something horrifyingly like a first kiss with something that had no mouth. The blood was light-starved, perfect, given in the dark just as the Lily craved. There was a moment—long as a held breath—when he felt it considering him, weighing the offering the way a jeweler weighs a stone, and then the sensation flipped over into something almost tender, and that was worse.

As it drank, Dar's bones began to knit denser, his marrow turning over like soil being turned for planting. A deep ache bloomed in his teeth, his jaw feeling heavy, as if his skeleton was being remade from within. He gripped his knees and rode it out, sweat cooling on his neck, the storm a distant thing now behind the roar of his own remodeling blood. Strength, enormous and quiet, settled into his frame, the way groundwater rises into a foundation—not a burst, not a gift, just a slow assertion of mass. The Marrow Vein had opened. Somewhere in

the dark of his own skull he could almost hear it: a second page in the ledger of his flesh, ruled and waiting, and the first entry already drying.

The storm raged on, but Dar barely heard it. His senses had expanded, sharpened to a painful clarity. He could hear the child's breathing, the scrape of a rat against the far wall, the slow drip of water from the ceiling—three counts, four, pause—keeping time with nobody. He could feel the cellar's breath, the way the cold air sank and the warm air rose, the whole room alive with currents that had been invisible to him that morning. He could feel the Lily inside him, not just as a presence but as a part of him, connected to his nerves, his bones, his blood, threaded through him like words through a page. It was a transformation that came with a cost—his body was becoming something else, something that could endure what should kill it. He turned his palm upward in the dark and felt the wound he had paid with, already sealing, and understood that the ledger between him and the thing in his chest was being kept in a currency he had only just begun to name.

At some point, Suri's head came to rest against his shoulder, the weight of her exhaustion finally collected in full. He didn't move. Around him the shelter's heartbeats settled one by one into the deep, uneven music of the guarded poor—sleep taken the way they took everything else, in small amounts, ready to be paid back at any moment. He sat very still in the dark, two heartbeats keeping time, and guarded the only person in Ashkarad who had ever undercharged him.

When dawn finally came, the storm lifted as suddenly as it had begun. The first light of the salt-moon filtered through the cellar's grate, casting long beams that illuminated dust motes dancing in the air—white light, thin and cold, and against his chest the Lily shrank from it, sullen, fed, returned to its ledger. Dar blinked, his eyes adjusting to the light. He looked at the wall where frost had breathed during the night, and his blood ran cold. The condensation had bloomed into the shape of petals—delicate, black, reaching toward where Suri had slept. Five of them, fanned wide, each one traced in water the storm had given and the Lily had spent. The Lily had been one bad night from choosing her.

Dar scrubbed the image away with his sleeve before she could wake, the water leaving dark streaks on the stone like a debt crossed out and not forgiven. He scrubbed until the wall showed nothing but salt and damp, and still he could see the shape of it behind his eyes, patient and perfect. He pulled his collar open a finger's width and looked down at the faint silver tracery beneath his skin, at the pale roots of something that had drunk its fill and was already dreaming of light it could not have. A bloom has a direction, the annotation had said. He was starting to understand which way his was pointed.

He understood now. The Lily wasn't just a passenger. It was a gardener, and it was planting seeds in the dark. It had praised his blood, opened his marrow, and reached for the nearest warm thing while he slept, all in one night's accounting, and it had left a signature on the wall. He had to find a way to control it before it bloomed through him—and before it chose someone else to tend.

CHAPTER 4

The Silent Chorus

The Chorus hired desperate cutters, and Dar was nothing if not desperate. Desperation was the one credential the Choratorium never ran out of, and never asked twice about. He walked through the Choratorium's bone-arched entrance, his borrowed Chorus white gloves pristine, his pulse steady beneath the borrowed coat—steady on the surface, at least, one heart keeping the rhythm the Wardens expected while the other kept a different one entirely, slower, patient, keeping its own books. The air here smelled of antiseptic and something else—copper and honey, like blood preserved in sugar. It was the smell of the place where he had spent seven years of his life paying off a heart, and he had never once noticed how sweet it was. That was the thing about institutions. You stopped smelling them the way you stopped hearing your own name.

A Clinic Custodian with bone-plating across her cheeks greeted him, her voice a smooth, practiced melody. "Welcome, cutter. We've been expecting you. The harvest floor awaits your skilled hands."

"Thank you, Custodian," Dar said, and was proud of how ordinary it came out.

The harvest floor was a cathedral of glass and brass, a forest of vitrines where debtors floated in nutrient fluid, their chests opened like books—laid open, Dar corrected himself, the way a ledger is laid open, spines cracked so the entries can be read at a glance. Some had multiple hearts beating in tandem, others had lungs grown in pairs where one should be, all wired to monitors that tracked their vital signs with the precision of a metronome. The monitors ticked in loose canon with one another, a hundred small clocks slightly out of phase, and beneath it all ran the sound Dar had grown up hearing through the walls of Saint Ferrous and never once been told the name of: the organ-hum, the building itself breathing through its pipes. Nurses moved between the vitrines with clipboards, making notations as if they were tallying inventory. Most of the floated faces were tranquil. A few were not, and the nurses did not look at those.

"Each vessel is a note in our grand composition," the Custodian explained, leading Dar past a man with three livers, each a different shade of crimson—wine-dark, rust-dark, one so pale it was nearly the color of the fluid he floated in. "By isolating the organs, we allow each to sing its purest song. Together, they create a harmony no single body could achieve."

"Of course," Dar said. His voice sounded very far away to him, like something shouted down a stairwell.

He nodded, his gaze fixed on a ledger wall where census pages were filed alphabetically, brass runners and glass fronts, the records of who belonged to whom arranged as publicly as a menu. His own page would be there, the one that flagged him as a missing vessel. He needed to find it, to steal it, to erase the record that would lead the Chorus to him. One page. One entry struck from one column, and the city's smallest room of clerks would have to do all its arithmetic again.

He feigned interest in a nearby vitrine, a woman with her nervous system mapped across her torso like a circuit board, silver tracery branching over her ribs and down her arms, pulsing faintly with every monitor-beep. "Fascinating," he murmured, his voice tight. "The precision required..."

"The human body is the most intricate instrument," the Custodian agreed. "We are merely the conductors, ensuring each note is played to its fullest potential."

And who, Dar wondered, conducts the conductors. He kept the question behind his teeth, where it cost nothing.

Dar's fingers brushed against the ledger wall, his heart pounding beneath the Lily's steady rhythm. He found the 'M' section and began flipping through the pages, his breath held. Mehran, Darius. There—his census page, his name in upright type above the hospital's serial, the sum of seven years paid and owing, and stamped across the foot of it in a red the Chorus reserved for delinquent accounts: MISSING. He slipped it into his coat, his movements practiced, casual, the same motion he used to pocket a scalpel at the end of a shift, the hand that moved quiet even here, in the one building in Ashkarad where quiet hands were most likely to be needed.

But then something else caught his eye—the Choratorium nursery ledger. Entries listed vessels like produce, graded on a scale of A to F, each line annotated with a small musical mark that he didn't know how to read and suspected, all the same, meant everything. One entry stood out: ILAY, PERFECT, RESERVED FOR THE THRONE. Dar's blood ran cold. This was the child Suri had mentioned, the one who had escaped. A perfect note, reserved for the throne, and the note had walked out of the Choratorium's score. Somebody, somewhere, was keeping a child off the books.

"Lost in the music, cutter?" The Custodian's voice was closer than he'd expected. Dar turned to find her standing beside him, her bone-plated face unreadable. "We keep meticulous records. Every vessel, every note, accounted for."

"Merely admiring your system," Dar said, forcing a smile. "The efficiency is... admirable."

The Custodian's gaze lingered on him, her head tilted slightly, the way a tuner's head tilts toward a string that has gone a quarter-tone wrong. "You carry the scent of something else. Something... alive. Not of the Chorus."

Dar's heart hammered against his ribs. The Lily inside him pulsed, a silent warning—give nothing. "I—I don't know what you mean," he stammered, taking a step back.

The Custodian's smile didn't reach her eyes. "Of course you don't. But we do." She raised a hand, and two Choirmasters in bone masks stepped forward, their scalpel-tipped fingers glinting in the harsh light. "Perhaps we should examine you more closely."

Dar's mind raced. He needed to stall, to buy time, and there was only one coin he had ever had that institutions always accepted. Competence. "The harvest floor," he said, gesturing vaguely. "The arrangements here... they're not optimal. The fluid ratios are off by 2.3 percent. It's affecting the organ viability."

The Choirmasters froze, their scalpel-fingers still, three hands suspended mid-air like notes on a hold. The Custodian's expression shifted, curiosity replacing suspicion. "Is that so? Explain."

Dar launched into a detailed explanation of fluid dynamics, his voice steady despite the terror coursing through him. He spoke of osmotic pressure, of nutrient absorption rates, of how even a slight imbalance could compromise the viability of harvested organs—how too much saline and the tissues swelled and sang flat, how too little and they contracted, dehydrated, went sharp. He did not invent any of it. That was the horror and the shelter of it: it was all true, learned across seven years at Saint Ferrous, knowledge that had finally found its perfect use in keeping him out of a vitrine. The Custodian listened, her head tilted, her expression thoughtful.

"An interesting observation," she said finally. "But we've been using these ratios for years."

"Times change," Dar said, his pulse hammering in his throat. "New research, new techniques. I could show you. Adjust the ratios myself. It would only take a moment."

The Custodian considered this, then nodded. "Very well. Show us. But make it quick. The choir awaits its conductor."

Dar led them to a nearby vitrine, his hands trembling as he pretended to adjust the fluid ratios—turned the brass wheel a fraction, watched the gauge drift, made small professional sounds of dissatisfaction. The Choirmasters stood watch, their scalpel-fingers poised. Dar's eyes darted around, searching for an escape route. The corridor behind him was lined with

harvested organs, preserved in jars and hanging from hooks, each jar labeled in the Chorus's upright hand, each label a name reduced to a tissue type. He made himself stop reading the labels.

"Is that it?" the Custodian asked, her voice impatient.

"Almost," Dar said, his gaze falling on a row of hanging lungs. "The ventilation system needs recalibration. It's affecting the oxygenation levels."

The Custodian sighed. "Fine. Show us."

As she moved closer, Dar made his move. He grabbed a nearby jar of preserved kidneys and hurled it at the Choirmasters. Glass burst against bone, amber fluid and formaldehyde spraying in a bright arc; one mask turned away, one scalpel-hand flinched up to protect its eyes, and in that opened fraction of a score, Dar bolted, running down the corridor, his heart pounding against his ribs. The Lily inside him pulsed, urging him faster.

He ducked into a side corridor, the sound of footsteps echoing behind him—not footsteps, he realized, the flat click of scalpel-fingertips on tile, a sound like a very small audience applauding. He ran past rows of harvested hearts, livers, lungs, each one a silent testament to the Chorus's methodology. The air grew colder, the scent of antiseptic giving way to something else—something ancient and hungry, a smell with no modern name in it at all. Behind him, the Custodian's melodic voice called out, still calm, still kind, the way a scale is kind: each note in its proper place.

Dar reached a heavy metal door and pushed through it, stumbling into a dimly lit chamber. The walls were lined with shelves, each holding a different organ, each one still alive, still singing its silent song—the hum in here was louder, closer to words, a room built like the inside of a throat. In the center of the room stood a massive glass tank, filled with a viscous, amber fluid. Inside, something moved—something vast and slow, its form shifting in the depths, and the shifting was not random. It had the rhythm of respiration. The tank itself was breathing.

Dar froze, his breath catching in his throat. The Lily inside him pulsed, a strange recognition washing over him, a warmth like memory but not his memory, like a child's photo held up to a stranger's face. This was the First Vessel, the buried proto-Throne the Chorus was trying to awaken. Forty years of the city's arithmetic, filed into one sleeping body.

"Found you," a voice said from behind him.

Dar turned to see the Custodian standing in the doorway, a bone scalpel in her hand. "You shouldn't be here," she said, her voice calm. "This is sacred ground."

Dar backed away, his hand on the door handle. "I'm leaving," he said, his voice tight.

The Custodian took a step forward. "You carry something that doesn't belong to you. Something that was planted with love."

The word love, in that room, with that tank breathing behind him, did more damage than any scalpel could have. Dar hesitated, then turned and fled, pushing through the door and back into the corridor. He ran, his lungs burning, the Lily urging him onward, and it occurred to him somewhere in the burning that the thing in his chest ran with him without complaint, that it did not tire, that it was getting better at him. He reached the entrance, bursting through the bone-arched doors and into the harsh light of the Choratorium plaza. The white glare stabbed down through his squint, and under it the Lily flinched and went small. Behind him the Choratorium's doors stood open, and he understood that the building had never been trying to keep him in. Why would it need to? It had simply wanted a moment to finish reading him.

As he stumbled out, every ceiling speaker in the clinic crackled to life. A woman's voice, calm and kind, filled the air—out on the plaza, in the fog, up and down the district, carried on every horn and bell the Chorus owned.

"To whoever carries our missing garden home," the voice said. "She was planted with love. Bring her back before she roots in strangers."

Dar froze, the voice echoing in his mind. The Lily inside him shivered—whether with fear or longing, he couldn't tell.

CHAPTER 5

The Professor of Impossible Anatomy

The door to the anatomy theater groaned open on hinges rusted shut by salt, revealing a staircase that descended into darkness. Suri nudged Dar forward with her elbow, the carbon scales of her prosthetic arm scraping against the stone wall. "He's down there. Smells like gin and regret." She pressed a coin into Dar's hand. "For the door. And don't mention how you got that chest wound. His prices triple for interesting stories."

The air grew thick with the scent of formaldehyde and spilled alcohol as they descended. The theater was a circular room with tiered seating rising around a central stage, now littered with empty bottles and anatomical models. At the center stood a man with wild grey hair and a stained lab coat, gesturing wildly at a human skeleton propped in a teaching harness. His voice echoed in the enclosed space, slurred but precise.

"—and you see here, the coccyx isn't just a remnant! It's the anchor point for what might have been, the evolutionary echo of a tail we never needed but the body remembers! We are walking archives of what could have been!"

He was, Dar realized, lecturing no one. He had probably been lecturing no one for years, and he had not let that change a single syllable.

Suri cleared her throat, and the man spun around, eyes wide behind thick spectacles. "Ah! Visitors! Prospective students? Or have you come to mock my exile? The Syndic Wardens took my accreditation but they can't take my vision!"

"Professor Vahid Anousheh?" Suri asked, her tone businesslike despite the surroundings.

"The same, at your service. Though 'disgraced' is the adjective they prefer in the Marrowworks journals. What can I do for you? Need a diagnosis? A modification? Or perhaps just a lecture on the futility of human form?"

Dar stepped forward, unbuttoning his hospital coat to reveal the bandages wrapped around his chest. "I need to know what's growing in me."

The professor's eyes widened, not at the wound, but at the way Dar moved—too steady, too coordinated for someone with such an injury. He circled Dar slowly, peering through his spectacles. "Fascinating. The vital signs are... anomalous. Like a machine with a soul. Or a soul with a machine." He gestured to a stool. "Sit. Tell me everything. And if you've got gin, I'll tell you twice as much."

Suri produced a small flask from her pocket, which the professor snatched with trembling hands. He took a long swig before speaking again. "Good. Good. Now, the wound. The organ. Start there."

Dar described the heist, the glass reliquary, the shot, and the impossible way the Lily had rooted itself in his chest. As he spoke, the professor's initial drunken demeanor sharpened into rapt attention. He pulled a magnifying glass from his coat pocket and leaned closer to Dar's chest, ignoring the bandages.

"Extraordinary," he whispered. "The graft points... the neural interface... this isn't just a transplant. It's a replacement. Your heart is gone, isn't it? Replaced by something that wanted the position."

Dar nodded. "It pulses differently. Thirsts for blood in the dark."

"Of course," the professor said, his voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "The Umbra Lily. I should have recognized the pattern. The Church's masterwork. They've distilled the entire process of Vein-engineering into a single, portable organ. It's not just a heart—it's a key. A key to what, I'm not entirely sure, but the mechanism is breathtaking."

He stumbled to a chalkboard covered in equations and began to draw, his handwriting surprisingly clear despite his intoxication, each stroke laid down with the economy of a man who had drawn this diagram a thousand times. "The Nine Veins. The biological ladder of transcendence. Flesh, Marrow, Blood, Breath, Nerve, Bone, Mind, Soul, and... Throne." He wrote each name with reverence. "Most anatomists consider them theoretical. Metaphors for human potential. But they're real. And your Lily is a shortcut—a cheat code to climb them."

Dar touched the bandages over his chest. "I'm already changing. Things heal too fast. My bones feel... denser."

"First Vein—Flesh," the professor confirmed, tapping the chalkboard. "The body's basic resilience. Second is Marrow—bone density, enhanced senses. You're already there, or very close. The Lily accelerates the process. But there are costs."

He turned back to Dar, his eyes serious. "Feeding requirements. The Lily needs specific nutrients, drawn from your blood. Sensory overload—each Vein opens new channels of perception, and the world becomes too loud, too bright, too much. Memory bleed—when you ascend, you don't just gain abilities. You gain echoes. Lived moments that belong to other people bleed into your consciousness. And the final cost..." The professor's hand shook as he wrote the last word on the board: BLOOM-THROUGH.

"What is that?" Dar asked, though he thought he already knew.

"It's when the transcendence stops being something you have and becomes something you are being turned into. The Lily doesn't want to live in you. It wants to become through you. Most carriers die of the process. The rest... stop being people. They become gardens."

The professor slumped against the chalkboard, suddenly looking old and tired. "I know this because I helped create the ancestor strain of the Lily. Before the Academy expelled me for 'unethical anatomy.' My partner, Dr. Shirin Bahar, believed we were building a heart that couldn't break. One that could patch itself, adapt, evolve. We succeeded. But we never considered the will of the organism itself. It wasn't a heart. It was a seed. And seeds are patient."

He walked to a dusty cabinet and pulled out a wax-cylinder recording and a sheaf of yellowed photographs. "This is our first volunteer. A dockworker with a failing heart. We grafted the prototype Lily into him. He lasted ninety days. This is what happened."

The first photograph showed a man in his thirties, smiling weakly. The next showed the same man, his skin beginning to sprout delicate black veins. The third showed his face almost obscured by what looked like petals of vascular lace. The final photograph showed only a figure standing in a dark room, covered in what could only be described as a garden of living tissue—black petals, pulsing vines, and at the center, where a heart should be, a flower that seemed to drink the shadows.

"He was serene at the end," the professor said, his voice cracking. "He said he could feel the city through the roots in his feet. That he was becoming part of something larger. Then he stopped speaking. Just... bloomed. The Church took him, of course. They've been refining the process ever since."

Dar stared at the photographs, a cold dread spreading through him. The Lily in his chest pulsed in response, a familiar ache that was becoming too intimate. "Why are you telling me this?"

"Because you're already in too deep to turn back," the professor said, his eyes meeting Dar's. "And because I owe you the truth. The Lily isn't a parasite and it isn't a gift. It's a seed. And seeds are patient."

He placed the wax cylinder on an old phonograph and lowered the needle. A crackling voice filled the room, soft and melodic, singing in a language that made the hairs on Dar's arms stand on end. It was the same song he'd heard in the canal wall, but clearer, older. The Lily in his chest responded with a violent shudder, and for a moment, Dar felt a presence behind his eyes—not his own, but something ancient and waiting.

* * *

The phonograph sputtered to a silence that felt heavier than any noise. Dar stood frozen, the phantom song still echoing in his bones. The professor watched him, his expression unreadable through the smudges on his spectacles.

"That was Shirin," he said, his voice barely a whisper. "Her voice. They kept it. After they harvested her. Said it was too perfect to let go. Now it sings for them in the Choratorium."

Dar's hand went to his chest, pressing against the bandages. The Lily pulsed in time with his own frantic heartbeat, a counter-rhythm to the memory of that song. "It recognizes her."

"The Lily remembers its creators," the professor said, his voice hollow. "And it remembers what they became. The Church doesn't just harvest organs. They harvest potential. They take pieces of people and try to stitch them together into something greater than the sum. But they're using the wrong thread. They're using scissors instead of needles."

Suri shifted beside Dar, the carbon scales of her arm clinking softly. "What do you want from us, Professor? You've told us a terrifying story. Now what?"

The professor straightened up, the weight of his grief momentarily lifting. "I want to help you understand what you're carrying. And I want to help you stop it from blooming through." He gestured to the chalkboard, where the Nine Veins were still written in stark white. "Each Vein has a cost. But each also has a key to resisting the bloom-through. For Flesh, it's control—learning to direct the healing. For Marrow, it's grounding—using the enhanced senses to connect to the world, not be overwhelmed by it. For Blood..." He paused, thinking. "For Blood, you must learn that your will extends beyond your skin, but it must remain yours to command."

He turned back to Dar, his eyes intense. "The Church is planning something. Something that requires all the Lilies to be in bloom at once. A ritual during the Blacktide. The salt-moon eclipse. They're building something beneath the Marrowworks. Something vast. Something ancient."

"The First Vessel," Dar said, the words coming to him unbidden. He hadn't planned to speak them, but they felt true. "I saw it. When I was in the Choratorium."

The professor's breath caught. "You've seen the First Vessel? How?"

"During my escape. There's a chamber beneath the clinic. A... thing. Sleeping. Fed by pipes."

The professor's hands trembled with an excitement that bordered on terror. "The First Vessel. The prototype for the Throne. Forty years of harvested organs, grafted onto a single, dreaming host. Custodian Anra Vey isn't just leading the Church. She's trying to become the

Ninth Vein. To become Ashkarad itself." He looked at Dar, then at the photographs of the bloomed man, a dawning horror on his face. "And she's using the Lilies to do it. Each one is a key. Each one is a piece of the puzzle."

Dar thought of the message that had broadcast from the Choratorium speakers, Custodian Anra Vey's voice calm and maternal, addressing the Lily within him. "She knows about me. She called it 'child.'"

"She called it 'child'?" the professor repeated, a strange look on his face. "That's... not right. The Lily isn't hers to claim. It's ancient. Older than the Church. Older than Ashkarad itself." He paced the room, his mind racing. "If she's trying to ascend during the Blacktide, and she has the First Vessel, and she's collecting Lilies... she's not just trying to become the Throne. She's trying to become the garden. The whole city."

Suri stepped between them, her arm held defensively. "Enough riddles. What do we do? How do we stop her?"

The professor stopped pacing and looked at them both, his expression grave. "We find the other carriers. We find out how many there are. We find out what she's planning. And we stop her before the Blacktide." He turned to Dar, his eyes pleading. "You're the key, Dar. The Lily chose you. It recognizes you. Maybe you can reason with it. Maybe you can control it."

Dar looked down at his hands, the surgeon's hands that had saved lives and now carried this impossible burden. The Lily pulsed in his chest, a silent promise of power and loss. "I don't know if I can control it," he admitted. "But I know I can't let it bloom through. Not like that."

The professor nodded slowly, a flicker of hope in his eyes. "Then we begin. We start with the song. The one you heard in the canal wall. The one that came from Shirin. If the Lily responds to it, maybe it responds to other things. Maybe there's a way to communicate. To negotiate." He picked up the wax cylinder again, holding it like a relic. "We start with the truth."

Dar reached out and took the cylinder from his hands, the weight of it feeling significant. The song still echoed in his mind, a melody that was both beautiful and terrible. The Lily in his chest pulsed once, as if in agreement. And in that pulse, Dar felt something else—not just the presence of the symbiote, but a question. A silent query hanging in the darkness between them.

What are you willing to become?

CHAPTER 6

The Cartographer

The Undergleam smelled of lamp oil and damp paper, a place where light was rationed like every other resource in Ashkarad. Every tallow stub had its ledger line; every shadow paid rent to somebody. Dar followed Suri through tunnels so narrow their shoulders brushed the slick, salt-crusted walls, and each brush of his coat left a pale smear behind, the tunnels keeping accounts of their own. They passed stalls where shadow merchants traded in rumors and contraband organs preserved in jars of cloudy fluid — a larynx, a heart-valve, a length of grafted nerve — each jar ticketed in cramped script, each price whispered rather than spoken, as if naming a thing too plainly might repossess it. Somewhere behind them, a buyer was haggling over a coil of intestine the way other men haggled over rope.

Suri's carbon-scaled arm scraped against a pipe, making a sound like stone on stone. "Three turns left," she said, counting under her breath. Dar had learned to trust her counting; in the Saltstairs, numbers were the only saints that answered. "Then look for the stall that smells of ink and old blood. The Cartographer doesn't like being late, and she hates being kept waiting more."

The air grew colder as they descended deeper, the salt-storm fog above pressing down like a physical weight, seeping through hairline cracks until the lowest passages drank it like cold soup. Dar felt the Lily in his chest stir, a subtle pulse that matched the rhythm of his own heartbeat but with an alien cadence — his beat, then its beat laid over it, the way a creditor's signature is written across a debtor's name. It had been quiet since they'd left Professor Anousheh's, patient as accruing interest, but now it seemed to wake, curious about the direction they were taking. "What exactly are we paying with?" Dar asked, keeping his voice low. The Lily didn't like loud noises; they made it withdraw, leaving him feeling hollow, a brief emptiness behind his sternum like a tooth drawn from the center of him.

"Information," Suri said. "And trust. The Cartographer deals in both. She'll want to know what the Lily dreams." She paused at a junction where three tunnels converged, each marked with different symbols scratched into the wall — a spiral, a cross, a stylized heart. Beneath the heart, someone had cut tallies, dozens of them, a five-barred gate of counted things that trailed off into the dark. "Left," she said decisively. "The other two are watched."

The stall was nestled in an alcove where the natural seepage of the Undergleam had formed a shallow pool of brackish water. The water moved without wind, small rings crossing and cancelling one another like entries in rival ledgers. A woman in a brass mask that covered

her face from forehead to chin sat behind a table covered in parchment. Her gloved hands moved with practiced precision, drawing lines that shimmered and rearranged themselves as she worked, ink settling into place the way blood settles into a pattern a physician can read. The air around her hummed with a faint energy, like static electricity after a storm, and the fine hair on Dar's forearms rose to meet it.

"The Cartographer," Suri said by way of introduction. "We have what you want."

The woman looked up, her eyes visible through the slits in the mask — dark and sharp, like obsidian chips. "And you have what I need," she said, her voice a low contralto that seemed to echo slightly, as if the alcove itself were taking notes. "The dreamer. Bring him closer."

Dar approached cautiously, aware that he was being assessed — weighed, measured, entered into some private column. The Lily in his chest was restless now, a fluttering against his ribs that made him short of breath, a borrower's flutter, the kind that came just before a note was called in. "What exactly will you be doing?" he asked.

The Cartographer gestured to a chair of woven reeds that looked uncomfortable but sturdy. "I will be listening to what your guest has to say. Through you." She held up a small device made of brass and wire, intricate and somehow alive; the wires flexed between her fingers like small breathing things. "It's called a song-lobe. I'll wire it to your temples. You'll sleep, and I'll map what comes through."

Dar hesitated. Sleep meant vulnerability, and vulnerability in a city like Ashkarad was a debt waiting to be called in. He thought of the wardens with their hand-cranked pulse-readers, of ledgermen with their lists, of every enemy he had made simply by continuing to breathe. "What's the price?" he asked.

The Cartographer smiled, a thin line visible behind her mask. "Not money. Not yet. Information. What you know about the Church, about the Lily, about the man who sent you to Professor Anousheh. And what the Lily dreams — that's what I really want."

Dar exchanged a glance with Suri, who gave a slight nod. "It's the fastest way to what we need," she said. "The Cartographer's maps are worth more than any currency in the Undergleam."

So Dar sat in the reed chair, wincing as the metal contacts of the song-lobe touched his temples — cold as coins taken from a dead man's pocket. The Cartographer's gloved fingers were surprisingly gentle as she adjusted the wires, seating each one with a surgeon's care. "Close your eyes," she instructed. "Let go. The Lily will speak through you."

The darkness behind Dar's eyelids wasn't empty; it was filled with the Lily's presence, a pulsing, living darkness that reached out to touch his mind. He felt himself sinking, falling through layers of consciousness — skin, fear, memory, debt — each layer thinner than the last, the Lily's dreams rising to meet him like water rising in a hold.

He was standing in a garden made of salt, under a sky the color of dried blood. The ground was crystalline, and beneath his feet he could feel the slow, rhythmic pulse of something vast and sleeping, a heartbeat so deep it took a full minute to finish a single beat. Rows of people lay buried in the earth like bulbs, their heads protruding, eyes closed in peaceful slumber, their faces dusted with fine salt that no wind ever disturbed. A tower rose in the distance, pulsing with light — each window a heartbeat, each floor a different rhythm, the whole structure shuddering gently out of time with itself, like a ledger whose pages had been bound out of order. And from the tower, a voice hummed, a lullaby in a language Dar didn't know but somehow understood, the way you understand a debt: not the words, only the weight.

The Cartographer's voice, distant and muffled, intruded on the dream. "Draw it," she said to someone — perhaps herself, perhaps an unseen assistant. "The salt gardens, the sleeping rows, the tower of hearts. And the voice — can you map the frequency?"

Dar tried to speak, to ask where he was, who was humming, but the dream held him fast, the way deep water holds a body that has stopped struggling. The Lily was in complete control here, showing him what it wanted him to see — or what it needed him to see; with the Lily, he was learning, the two were rarely the same. A figure approached through the garden — not walking, but gliding, her robes trailing behind her like smoke. Her face was obscured, but her presence was familiar, like a half-remembered melody. She stopped before one of the sleeping figures and placed a hand on their forehead, humming a single, perfect note that made the salt crystals tremble — and somewhere far away, in a room that smelled of ink and old blood, a quill began to scratch faster.

"Who is she?" Dar managed to whisper, though his voice was lost in the dream.

The figure turned, and for a moment, Dar thought he recognized the eyes — Anra Vey's eyes, calm and ancient, patient as a collector at year's end. But then the dream shifted, and the garden dissolved into darkness.

Dar woke with a start, gasping for air. The reed chair felt rough against his skin, and the metal contacts were gone. The Cartographer stood before him, her gloved hands stained with ink, several maps spread across the table. Her mask was still in place, but her shoulders were slumped, as if the weight of what she'd seen had settled there — an entry written in her own body's ledger.

"You saw her," Dar said, his throat dry. "The woman in the garden."

The Cartographer nodded, picking up a quill and dipping it in ink. "She's the one who's been hunting my signal too. The one who wants the Lily to bloom." She began to draw, her movements precise but hurried. "The Chorus facilities — their clinics, reliquaries, tithe-routes. Everything I have."

Dar watched as the maps took shape, each line and symbol representing a piece of the Church's hidden network. The Cartographer worked quickly, her breath visible in the cold air of the Undergleam. "There," she said, pointing to a series of interconnected lines. "The main Choratorium here, the nursery there, and the reliquaries where they keep the harvested voices."

She pushed the maps across the table toward Dar. "Take them. But there's one more thing." She picked up a fresh sheet of parchment and began to draw again, her hand shaking slightly this time. A single shaft, deep beneath the Marrowworks, older than the Church above it. At its base, a single word: THRONE. And around the shaft, lines of old ledger-script: DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS.

Dar leaned closer, squinting at the script. "What does that mean?"

The Cartographer looked up, her eyes shadowed behind the brass mask. "Because it counts back," she said, her voice barely above a whisper. "The heartbeats in that place aren't just alive — they're aware. And they remember."

* * *

Dar and Suri moved quickly through the Undergleam, the maps rolled tight in Dar's coat pocket, tight enough that he could feel their edges against his ribs like a second set of accounts. The Lily in his chest was quiet now, but he could feel it processing what it had shown the Cartographer — the dream of the salt gardens, the sleeping rows, the humming woman — filing something away in whatever ledger it kept inside him. "What do you think she meant by 'it counts back'?" he asked Suri as they navigated a tunnel that sloped upward.

"The Church has something old beneath the Marrowworks," Suri said, counting her steps. "Something that remembers being counted. Something that might be hunting us back."

They emerged from a maintenance shaft into the Saltstairs, the tenement warrens rising around them like teeth. The salt storm had passed, leaving behind a thick fog that blurred the edges of buildings and swallowed distant sounds whole. A warden's whistle cut through the fog, sharp and demanding. Suri grabbed Dar's arm, pulling him into an alley just as a grey-coated figure passed by, hand-cranked pulse-reader clicking rhythmically, the little brass

gears gnawing through the quiet like an insect eating through paper.

"They're checking for vital-debt defaulters," Suri whispered, pressing herself against the damp wall. "We need to move before they get to this sector."

Dar nodded, the weight of the maps heavy in his coat. The Lily pulsed once, a reminder of the debt it had placed on him — blood for growth, darkness for strength, and now this: a shared dream with a woman who seemed to be everywhere and nowhere at once. They had a lead, a path to the Church's secrets, but it was tangled with something older and far more dangerous, something the Church itself had seen fit to warn against in a dead hand's script. As they slipped back into the fog, Dar wondered if they were running toward answers or running straight into the thing that counted back.

CHAPTER 7

Memory Bleed

The tithe-barge groaned through the canal, its hull scraping against the salt-crusted stone as it passed beneath the Choratorium's shadow. The sound rolled down the waterway like a promise being broken slowly, plank by plank. Forty debtors stood in harvest-racks, their wrists bound to the rusted iron railing, paperwork nailed to the mast like a death warrant. "Voluntary," it read, in the fine print that always omitted the part about how voluntary stopped when the ledgermen came calling. Dar could make out the columns from the water's edge — name after name, each with a figure beside it, each figure a balance no one had consented to but everyone had signed. Suri crouched in the fog, counting heartbeats with her pulse-reader. "Sixteen crew, eight Wardens. Tide's turning — we've got three minutes before the current pins us against the seawall."

Dar adjusted the carbon-fiber blade strapped to his forearm, its weight familiar as debt. Three minutes. In Ashkarad, three minutes was either a lifetime or nothing at all, depending on which side of the ledger you stood on. The fog off the canal had a taste tonight — brine and engine oil and, beneath them, the faint iron sweetness of harvested blood. It clung to the back of his throat like a signature awaiting ink. The Lily in his chest pulsed in time with the barge's engine, a rhythm that wasn't his own, patient and mechanical, as though it already knew how tonight's accounts would close. He watched the Choratorium's bone-white spires pierce the salt-fog above the waterline, pale as teeth in a gum of mist. "They're taking them to the upper sanctums," he said. "That's not standard tithe procedure."

"Nothing standard about this job," Suri muttered, her carbon-scaled fingers tightening around a length of monofilament. "Cartographer wants the census ledgers from the Warden's cabin. Says they list names not in the public registry." Names not in the registry. In a city that counted everything — breath, marrow, hours of sleep — the uncounted were either debts too ugly to write down or assets too valuable to declare.

Ahead, the barge's engine churned the black water into a slow boil. The debtors in their racks did not look like cargo; that was the obscenity of it. They looked like people. One of them — a thin man with a cooper's forearms — was mouthing numbers to himself, the way Suri did, the way everyone in Ashkarad did when the sums stopped balancing. Counting what he was worth. Counting what he'd been sold for. The harvest-racks were priced instruments, and somewhere above them a clerk had already entered the night's yield in triplicate.

The first grappling hook sailed over the railing, biting into the deck. Dar moved with the current, his body remembering the weight of the gravel-heart he'd lost, the Lily's strange lightness in its place — as if some inner scale had been rebalanced without his permission, stone traded for something that weighed nothing and cost everything. A Warden spotted them, his grey coat flapping as he raised his hand-cranked pulse-reader. "Defectors! Audit them!"

Chaos erupted. Dar ducked under a swinging baton, the blade on his arm extending with a whisper. He caught a Warden across the throat, the blade sinking deep, hot blood spattering across his face. The taste of it — metallic, coppery — triggered something deep within him. His blood answered.

It wasn't pain that hit him first, but pressure. A thousand tiny hammers behind his eyes, each heartbeat in earshot amplified into a drum. He heard the whole barge at once: the crew's stampeding pulses, the debtors' arrhythmic panic, Suri's heart racing like a trapped bird. Every body on the water was an open account, and something in him had begun to read them. His own blood surged beneath his skin like a dark tide, responding to his will even as his vision swam.

The surgeon in him hated it and admired it at once. He knew blood — its lazy architecture, its one-way tolls, the patient mathematics of pressure and release. Now it moved for him like a hand answering its own name. He could feel the branching map of every artery he touched, the tollgates of the heart, the small collateral routes the body kept for emergencies it hoped never to bill. His knowledge and the Lily's hunger were merging into a single instrument, and there was no line on any ledger marking where one ended and the other began.

He fought blind, the blade in his hand an extension of his panic. A Warden charged, and Dar's blood lashed out, a tendril of crimson that wrapped around the man's throat, lifting him off his feet. The sound of the man's strangled gasp was drowned out by the drumbeat in Dar's skull. Through the red haze he saw Suri's carbon scales flash as she disarmed another crewman, her movements economical, precise. She was counting something — steps, blows, debts to be paid — her lips moving over numbers only she could hear, while his own numbers had broken loose and started counting him.

The deck slick with blood, the Lily in his chest pounding like a second heart. He felt it then, the Vein opening, not as pain but as expansion. His blood was no longer just his — it was a force, a weather system he could command. He directed it, a dark storm that swept across the deck, knocking men off their feet, tangling limbs in crimson strands. The debtors in their racks screamed, a chorus of relief and terror, and beneath the screaming Dar could hear every heart present, forty small accounts chattering in the rain.

And then the memories came.

Not his own. A woman in white gloves tending a salt-garden. Rows of sleeping people planted in the earth like seeds, their heads barely visible above the crystalline soil. She hummed a lullaby in a dead language, her movements tender, pruning the sleepers with the same care a gardener might give to roses. Her face was serene, certain, but loneliness clung to her like the salt on the garden's surface, a loneliness so old it had calcified into calm. She knelt beside one sleeper, her gloved hand resting on the person's forehead, whispering words that weren't meant for waking — and Dar understood, with a certainty that lived in his marrow rather than his mind, that the whisper was a promise the sleeper would keep long after she was gone.

The dream was not a window but a loan. The longer he stood in the garden, the more he understood it was lending him the keeper's certainty along with the keeper's sight: the rows were not graves, the hum was not a song, the sleepers were not resting — they were compounding. Interest accruing in the dark, head by salted head. And somewhere beneath his feet, beneath even the garden, something vast turned over in its sleep and almost — almost — noticed him back.

Dar gasped, stumbling backward, the blood-storm receding as his vision swam. The drumbeat in his ears softened, replaced by the woman's humming. He was standing on the deck of the barge, Suri shouting his name, the last Warden falling to his knees. Victory. But the memory lingered, salt on his tongue, the lullaby echoing in his bones. He had been somewhere else. He had been someone else's hands.

"Wake up, Mehran!" Suri's voice cut through the fog. She grabbed his arm, her carbon scales cold against his skin. "We've got the ledgers. Let's move before the backup arrives."

The debtors were free, stumbling off the barge into the canal's shallows, their chains discarded. No one thanked them; thanks was a currency the Saltstairs had devalued generations ago. The debtors waded ashore and scattered into the fog, already becoming rumors, and behind them the harvest-racks swung empty — forty withdrawals made in a single night against an account that had never been theirs. Dar followed, his legs unsteady, the woman's face superimposed over the salt-fogged sky. He didn't know how long he'd stood there, lost in her garden. Seconds? Minutes? The time had bled away, borrowed from someone else, and no ledger in the city could tell him the interest owed.

* * *

They met the Cartographer in the Undergleam, the maps exchanged for the dream-mapping. The brass-masked figure listened as Dar described the salt-garden, the

sleeping rows, the humming woman, her quill moving in short, certain strokes while the ink-lamp hissed between them. When he finished, she set the quill down with a click that sounded like a small verdict. "Custodian Anra Vey," the Cartographer said, the name like a stone dropped in still water. "Her private sanctum. Beneath the Choratorium. Registered to her alone." The brass mask tilted, considering him. "Understand what you carry, dreamer. The Lily is not new to her world. What you saw tonight, it has seen before."

Dar stared at the map the Cartographer handed him, the salt-garden marked in precise, careful strokes. The woman in the memory wasn't just any gardener. She was the Church's leader. The Lily inside him hadn't just replaced his heart — it had been inside Vey's world before. Carried, perhaps, the way a debt is carried from one book to another when a lender dies and the accounts must go on.

* * *

Later, Suri cleaned her blade in the canal's brackish water while Dar sat on the damp stone, the Lily in his chest quiet but not still. The tide had turned; the water pushed at the pilings like something impatient to be paid. "You saw something back there," she said, not asking. "Something that wasn't the fight."

"Memories," Dar said, rubbing his temples. "Not mine. The woman in the garden — she was humming a lullaby. I've never heard it before, but I know every note." He caught himself humming a bar of it under his breath and stopped, unsettled by how naturally it fit his own voice.

"The Lily bleeds memories," Suri said, counting the steps back to their bolt-hole. "Professor Vahid said it. At the higher Veins, you carry more than just blood."

"Carry," Dar repeated. The word sat wrong in his mouth, too small for what it held. "You make it sound like freight."

"In this city everything is freight," Suri said, wringing the blade dry. "Question is who's paying the portage."

The Cartographer's map lay on Dar's lap, the salt-garden marked with a single, perfect circle. "It's Vey's private sanctum," he said, tracing the lines with his finger. "The sleeping rows — she's been growing something down there. Something that needs to be tended."

Suri's pulse-reader beeped softly. "The Blacktide is three days off. The eclipse. That's when she plans to ascend. To the Ninth Vein."

Three days. In Ashkarad, that was forty debts called in, a hundred appointments missed, a thousand small agreements broken. Long enough for the whole city to feel the moon's thumb

pressing on its scale. Dar looked at the map, then at his own hands. The blood that had answered his will was still beneath his skin, a dark weather he couldn't control, holding its breath between storms. "The Lily wants to bloom," he said, the words tasting like salt. "But the memories it gave me — they weren't random. They were a warning."

The Lily pulsed once, a rhythm that felt like agreement. The woman's lullaby echoed in Dar's mind, a song of certainty and loneliness. He had seen inside the Church's leader, and what he'd seen was a garden of sleeping people, tended by a hand that believed it was doing God's work.

The Blacktide was coming. And the Lily in his chest had been to the garden before.

CHAPTER 8

War of Ledgers

The salt storm had been three days old when the war began. Not with a bang, but with the quiet click of a ledger sealing shut, somewhere in the Choratorium's vaulted halls. Dar felt it as a tremor in the Lily's roots, a vibration that traveled through his veins and made his teeth ache — the sensation, he imagined, of a great house settling all its accounts at once. The city had always been a pressure cooker, but now the lid was rattling. He could feel it in the small sounds around them — shutters drawn a little earlier, footsteps refusing to echo, dogs barking at frequencies only fear could set.

"They're blaming the Gavel," Suri said, her voice barely above the whisper of wind through the alley's dead-end. She crouched beside him, her carbon-scaled arm pressed flat against the damp brick wall. The scales caught what little light filtered down from the storm-walls above, glittering like fish scales left too long on dry land. "The Chorus leaked word that the Gavel's been harvesting early to weaken their stock."

Dar traced the outline of his ribs beneath his shirt, feeling the steady, alien pulse beneath his flesh. The Lily had settled since the memory bleed, but it left echoes — fragments of salt gardens and humming lullabies that surfaced when he least expected, like line items he'd never authorized appearing on a statement. "And the Gavel?"

"Retaliated. Burned a tithe-warehouse in the Marrowworks. Three harvests lost." Suri's fingers twitched, counting something only she could see. "Ledgermen are scrambling to cover their books. Wardens are cracking skulls to keep the peace."

Three harvests. Dar did the arithmetic the way the city had taught him: a harvest was bodies, bodies were yield, and yield was the only prayer Ashkarad answered. The war wasn't over doctrine or faith. It was over who got to enter the numbers.

Somewhere above them the storm-walls groaned, shedding salt in long white curtains. The air tasted of scorched timber from the Marrowworks, carried down through the veins of the city like smoke through a throat. Even the fog seemed to be reading the news.

They moved through the Saltstairs like eels through a net, staying close to the walls where the shadows pooled deepest. The Lily drank the gloom, and with each step into shadow, Dar felt his strength return — not just the strength of his body, but something more, something that made the darkness feel less like absence and more like home. His senses sharpened until he could smell the sour sweat of the family huddled in the cellar below, hear the frantic pulse

of a rat in the walls, taste the salt on the air that spoke of the storm still raging above.

"Price of a safe room doubled," Suri muttered, leading him through a narrow archway into the Undergleam. The air here was different — thick with the smell of lamp oil, damp paper, and something vaguely metallic, the scent of money changing hands in the dark. "And the ledgers are watching."

Dar followed her gaze to a trio of men in long coats standing by a flickering streetlamp. Their collars were turned up, but their eyes tracked every movement. Syndic informants, or worse — ledgermen collecting debts that weren't owed yet. One of them held a slim book of names and wet his thumb before each turn of the page, the way a man does when he knows the reading is going to be long. "We need to move faster."

"We are moving faster," Suri said, quickening her pace. "You're the one who keeps stopping to breathe."

Dar hadn't realized he'd been holding his breath. The Lily demanded more now, more darkness, more stillness. It was becoming a hunger that matched his own. "I'm fine."

"Fine is when you don't flinch at your own shadow," Suri retorted, rounding a corner and pulling him into a narrow alley that smelled of urine and despair. A child's face appeared in a second-story window, eyes wide with fear before vanishing. "This city is eating itself, Dar, and we're caught between the teeth."

"Then we stay out of the mouth," Dar said.

"Poetry," Suri muttered. "The Wardens love poetry. It gives them something to arrest."

They emerged onto a rooftop that overlooked the Undergleam like a god surveying a broken kingdom. The city stretched below them in a tangled web of light and shadow, the storm-walls rising like teeth at the horizon. In the distance, the Marrowworks pulsed with bioluminescent signs, their glow bleeding into the salt fog, a wound that glowed instead of bleeding. Between the rooftops, clotheslines sagged with laundry no one would live long enough to collect, and somewhere below a drunk was singing a debt-collector's marching song, off-key and unbilled.

"Look at it," Dar said, his voice softer than he intended. "All those lives, all those debts, and it comes down to numbers on a page."

Suri leaned against the parapet, her carbon-scaled arm gleaming in the dim light. "Numbers are the only promises this city keeps," she said. "Everything else is just words on salt."

Dar watched her profile against the backdrop of the dying city. The scales on her arm weren't just decoration — they were a reminder, a payment she'd made in blood and skin. He'd asked once, years ago, when he'd first stitched the wound that ran from her elbow to her wrist. She'd told him it was none of his business, and he'd respected that boundary. But now, with the Lily whispering in his chest, boundaries felt thinner than paper.

"You never talk about it," he said carefully. "The arm."

Suri's fingers tightened on the parapet. For a moment he expected the old refusal, the one she wore stitched in silence. Then, quietly: "I was nineteen. Debt for my mother's surgery. They took the skin, gave me this." She tapped the scales with her free hand. "Kept me for six weeks. Ransomed me back when my brother found the coin." She finally turned to face him, her eyes dark in the gloom. "Numbers, Dar. That's all it was. Six weeks. Two hundred milliliters. A carbon graft."

"And the debt?"

"Paid," she said, but her voice was flat. "In full."

Dar knew better. No debt in Ashkarad was ever truly paid. It just changed form. Six weeks of a nineteen-year-old's skin did not walk out of a Chorus clinic without leaving a forwarding address. "The rumors," he said, keeping his voice low. "About you being Chorus property."

Suri's laugh was sharp as broken glass. "Let them talk. It keeps the ledgermen at bay."

He didn't push. Some balances were kept in books that only opened under worse circumstances than these.

They stood in silence for a moment, the only sounds the distant wail of a siren and the whisper of the Lily in Dar's chest. The storm above had finally begun to break, the salt clouds thinning to reveal stars like scattered diamonds — cold, bright, and perfectly indifferent to the arithmetic below.

"We should move," Suri said, breaking the silence. "Before the Wardens start their sweep."

As they made their way back to the alley, Dar felt a shift in the air — a presence that had nothing to do with the storm. Three men emerged from the shadows, their faces hidden beneath hoods, their movements too precise to be random. Syndic Wardens, or worse. They wore no livery, but their boots had the shine of syndic issue, and they arranged themselves in the mouth of the alley with the unhurried geometry of men who had done this many times and never once been interrupted.

"Courier Kaveh," one of them said, his voice devoid of warmth. "You're coming with us."

Suri didn't flinch. "On whose authority?"

"The Gavel's," another said, stepping forward. "You're accused of trafficking in restricted organs."

"That's a lie," Dar said, stepping between them and Suri. He could feel the Lily stirring, the darkness deepening around them, the shadows leaning in like clerks summoned by the smell of a default. "She's with me."

The third man laughed. "And you are?"

"Nobody important," Dar said, his voice steady.

The lead Warden drew a pulse-reader from his coat, its brass gears clicking in the silence. "We'll be the judge of that."

The Lily pulsed in Dar's chest, a warning. He could feel the shadows thickening, the air growing still. But the Wardens had their pulse-readers trained on them, their fingers on the triggers, and a pulse-reader did not need to understand the Lily to sell him to somebody who would. One clean demonstration, and every ledger in Ashkarad would have his name written in it. There was no room for the Lily's power here, not without revealing everything.

Suri placed a hand on his arm. "It's alright, Dar."

"No, it's not," he said, meeting her gaze. "They're taking you for something you didn't do."

She smiled, a rare, genuine expression that reached her eyes. "This is how it goes, Dar. Ledgers have to balance."

"Not this way."

"Then pay me back later," she said quietly, and beneath the dryness there was something almost gentle. "That's an order from your creditor."

The Warden grabbed her arm, his grip tight on the carbon scales. "Move."

Dar watched them take her away, the pulse-reader clicking like a metronome counting down to disaster. The Lily's hunger was a physical pain now, a demand for action, for blood, a collector rattling at the inside of his ribs. But he held it back, knowing that to give in now would be to lose himself, to become something other than the man who'd promised to protect her. Some prices, he told himself as the hoods vanished into the fog, were only installments. The principal was still owed, and he intended to collect.

* * *

The city had descended into chaos by nightfall. The salt storm had passed, leaving behind a sky bruised with the promise of a new moon. Dar moved through the streets like a ghost, avoiding the Wardens' checkpoints, the Lily guiding him through the darkest paths. He needed

to find Suri, to understand why the Gavel would take her, and what they wanted with her. He passed a Chorus notice-board where a fresh proclamation was being pasted over an older one, wet flour-paste hissing in the cold: ALL ACCOUNTS SUBJECT TO FINAL AUDIT. Someone had already scrawled a reply beneath it in charcoal: WHOSE?

He found his answer waiting in his rented room — a small, windowless space that smelled of dust and desperation. On the floor, beside a flickering lamp, lay a small wooden box. Tied to it was a note, written in the precise, angular script of the ledgers.

The price of the courier is the vessel's heart — beating, in a box, by the new moon.

Dar's fingers trembled as he untied the note. The Lily pulsed in his chest, a cold dread spreading through his veins. They weren't after Suri. They were after the Lily. And they knew exactly what it was. He turned the box over in his hands. No lock, no lining, no engraving — just smooth pale wood, sanded courteous and hollow, a container built to order and already waiting for its inventory. Whoever had written the note had measured him the way a lender measures a house: not for what it held, but for what could be repossessed.

The new moon rose, casting the city in shadows deeper than any Dar had ever known. He looked down at the box in his hands, its surface smooth and unmarked. The Lily beat once against his palm, slow and deliberate, as if it could hear the box measuring it. Inside, he knew, was a heartbeat waiting to be silenced. The Lily's heartbeat. And the price was Suri's life.

CHAPTER 9

The Exchange

The fighting pit stank of brine and old blood, a familiar cocktail in Ashkarad's underbelly — the smell of an account that was never allowed to close. Dar walked through the tunnel's maw without a weapon, his hands empty except for the pulse-thrum against his ribs, a rhythm that wasn't quite his own. The tunnel walls glistened with condensation, and the closer he came to the light, the louder the roar above him grew, until it stopped being a sound and became a pressure, a weight of appetite pressing down through the stone. The crowd's roar hit him like a physical force as he stepped out, a wave of sound that parted around him like water around stone. Above, the quarry's lights hung like captured stars, caged in wire and glass, casting long shadows from the bone-plate champions already waiting on the muddy arena floor. They stood in a loose circle, their movements predatory, their joints clicking with each shift of weight — a dry, wooden sound, like abacus beads counted by a patient clerk. There were eight of them. Their bone plates had been lacquered against the wet, and old fights showed on the plating like annotations — gouges, burn-marks, a forearm re-set slightly crooked and healed that way. Each one had been bought, fed, and maintained. Each one was an investment in the act Dar was about to interrupt. The air tasted of salt and something metallic, the scent of a city that priced everything in blood and had never once offered change.

The stands had been carved into the quarry walls in tiers, and every tier was full. Dar had treated some of these people — set bones, drained fevers, stitched what the Wardens' batons opened. They had paid him in fish, in coal, in favors. Now they leaned forward as one body, hungry for the kind of surgery he could not refuse to perform. Somewhere in the tiers a child was being lifted onto shoulders so it could see the man without a weapon die.

"Surprise me, surgeon," Mother Gavel's voice echoed from the private box, amplified through brass tubes. She sat wrapped in furs, her face a roadmap of old scars, her eyes flat as a ledger page. Around her, the box's brass fittings caught the light like furniture made of coins. "I was expecting more steel. More... persuasion." She turned a fur-lined cuff between two scarred fingers, unhurried as a moneylender on collection day.

Dar didn't answer. His gaze swept the pit, searching until he found her. Suri was bound to a chair at the quarry's edge, her carbon-scaled arm gleaming under the lights. Her eyes met his, and in them he saw the same calculation he always did — debts, angles, exit routes. But there was something else too, a flicker of something that might have been fear. Or maybe it was just the reflection of the pit's lights. He made himself look away before the not-knowing could

finish itself. Her wrists were raw where the ropes had worked. They had left the scaled arm bare, Dar noticed — displayed it, the way a shop displays its finest repossessed goods. The sight of it settled into him with a cold permanence, like a figure copied into a book he could never close.

The gate behind him slammed shut. The sound was small and final, like a stamp on a form. The champions moved then, a coordinated rush of bone and muscle. Dar didn't retreat. He planted his feet, felt the mud squelch between his toes, and let the first one come. The bone-plate fighter swung a heavy fist, meant to cave his skull in. Dar ducked under it, his movements smooth, economical. He grabbed the man's arm, twisted, and drove his elbow into the joint where the plate met flesh — the one seam every suit of armor owes to the body inside it. There was a sickening crack, and the champion screamed, a sound that cut through the crowd's roar like a knife. Dar felt the man's shoulder under his hands the way he felt every joint that came under his hands: as a mechanism with tolerances, a lock with a known key.

Two more came at him from either side. Dar stepped between them, his hands moving like they were in the operating theater — precise, deliberate. He had spent years learning what bodies cost and where they kept their weaknesses, and tonight every account was open. He hooked one finger under the chin of the left fighter, driving his thumb into the soft tissue beneath the jaw. The man went down, choking. The right fighter brought up a knee, but Dar was already moving, his foot sweeping the man's legs out from under him. The impact was ugly, wet. The champion hit the mud with a grunt, his breath gone.

Mother Gavel's voice cut through the chaos. "This is disappointing, Mehran. I expected better entertainment for the price of my courier."

Dar ignored her. He stood in the center of the pit, breathing hard, the mud soaking through his trousers. The remaining champions exchanged glances, a flicker of uncertainty in their eyes. They had expected a victim, not a dismantler. They charged anyway, driven by pride and the promise of the purse. Dar read them the way he read symptoms: flushed faces, over-gripped fists, the shallow breathing of men who had confused courage with credit. Pride was just another form of borrowing, taken against the body's future.

Dar met them. He moved like water around stone, letting their blows glance off his shoulders, his ribs. He wasn't fighting them; he was redirecting them, letting their own momentum debit their accounts. A palm strike to the solar plexus sent one reeling back into the mud. A quick twist of the wrist broke the arm of another, the bone plate offering no protection against leverage. Dar heard the marrow note the insult — bone was supposed to be the one collateral no collector could touch. The last one hesitated, his eyes wide, his hands raised in surrender. Dar didn't give him the chance. A quick chop to the throat sent him down,

gasping.

The crowd fell silent. A hundred faces stared at him, their expressions a mixture of awe and terror. Dar stood alone in the center of the pit, the mud up to his ankles, the air thick with the smell of violence. He had won. He had done what he came to do. He turned toward Suri, ready to claim his prize. Mother Gavel's box was silent. No announcement, no forfeit called. In the Gavel's pit, winnings were simple: the champion took, the pit took its cut, and the ledger took the rest. He started toward the chair.

But the silence stretched, thick and heavy. And in that silence, something inside him stretched too. It was a feeling like a tuning fork struck in the marrow of his bones, a vibration that resonated through his entire being. The world seemed to slow down, the lights above to brighten. The crowd's faces became luminous masks, their expressions frozen in awe and fear. The sounds of the pit — the dripping water, the distant hum of the crowd — faded to nothing, withdrawn like funds from an account he hadn't known he possessed.

Dar looked down at his hands. Black veins, like lace, were spreading across his skin, branching up his arms, across his chest. They pulsed with a faint, internal light. He could feel his own heartbeat, not as a rhythm, but as a presence, something vast and ancient that was waking up inside him. The Lily was blooming. It was happening the way the dreams had promised and the warnings had feared — not an invasion but an unveiling, the steady unfurling of something that had been folded inside him all along, patient as equity, silent as interest. The lace was not growing onto him. It was growing out.

He turned his head, and the movement was impossibly slow. Mother Gavel was standing now, her face a mask of fury. "Seize him!" she screamed, her voice thin and distant, the brass tubes carrying it like a rumor carried down a long corridor. Guards moved at the edges of his vision, then stopped moving, unsure whether the order still applied to a thing like this.

But the champions were on the ground, groaning, broken. The crowd was pressing back, a sea of terrified faces. Dar took a step forward, and the ground seemed to shudder beneath his feet. The black lace on his skin pulsed brighter, and a sound emerged from his throat — not a roar, but a hum, a deep, resonant note that vibrated in the bones of everyone present. The lights above flickered, dimmed, then flared to an impossible brilliance, and in that brilliance every heartbeat in the quarry was audible to him, a ledger being read aloud from the first line to the last.

Dar didn't want this. He didn't want to terrify them, to become a monster. He thought of Suri, of the promise he'd made. He thought of the numbness that would follow, the price he would pay for control — the Lily's oldest term, hidden in the fine print of his own

bloodstream. He focused, not on the power, but on the man he had been — the surgeon with precise hands, the debt-bound intern with a gallows humor. He focused on the feeling of mud between his toes, the cold air in his lungs, the memory of his own heartbeat before the Lily: small, borrowed, and entirely his.

The black lace receded, pulling back into his skin like smoke. The lights dimmed to their normal glow. The sound died. The world snapped back to its normal speed, the crowd's roar rushing back in to fill the sudden silence. It came back wrong, though — thinner, farther away, as if he were hearing it through the memory of a wall. Dar stumbled, his legs suddenly weak, his body feeling hollow, numb. He couldn't feel the mud beneath his feet, couldn't feel the cold air in his lungs. He couldn't feel his own heartbeat. The bill had come due exactly as advertised: everything paid out of the account of feeling. He catalogued what was missing the way a clerk inventories a ransacked shop — the mud, the cold, the rope burns under his own palms — and somewhere in the list, between his pulse and Suri's weight, the person he had been this morning was quietly filed away.

He pushed through the stunned crowd, his movements clumsy, his senses dulled. He reached Suri's chair, his hands fumbling with the ropes. They fell away, and he caught her as she stood, her weight a dead thing in his arms. He couldn't feel her grip on his shoulder, couldn't feel the warmth of her body against his. He knew she was gripping him — he could see her fingers whiten against his shoulder — but the knowledge arrived like a figure on a page, secondhand, entered by someone else's pen. He carried her, a burden he couldn't feel, out of the pit and into the tunnel beyond, and the crowd parted for them in silence, because the city knows a repossessed man when it sees one.

The fog outside was thick, swirling around the quarry's rim like a living thing. Behind him, the pit's lamps were being relit one by one, as if brightness could restore the evening's expected order. And standing there, waiting, was the Cartographer. The brass mask gleamed in the dim light, reflecting the pit's distant glow. "Every bloom is a door, cutter," the voice said, calm and measured. "Something on the far side has started counting your heartbeats." A pause. "It's at one hundred and nine."

CHAPTER 10

Vein of Breath

The water hit Dar's face like a slap, cold and sudden, as Professor Vahid Anousheh kicked the bucket over. It sloshed across the stone floor of the abandoned cistern, pooling around Dar's bare feet, finding every seam in the old flagstones and running through them with a sound like whispers being passed hand to hand. "Breathe deep, boy," Vahid slurred, wiping his own beard with a stained handkerchief. "Fill those lungs. You'll need them."

Dar took a breath, the air tasting of rust and something else — decay from the depths, the cistern exhaling whatever the city had buried in it. He'd been standing blindfolded for what felt like hours, listening to Vahid's shuffling footsteps and the drip-drip-drip of water from the ceiling, each drop striking the pool below with the regularity of a metronome keeping time for nobody. The blindfold was rough burlap, smelling of mildew and old rope. He had stopped trying to guess how deep the chamber went. Deep enough that the Choratorium's bells couldn't reach it. Deep enough that debts felt like someone else's news. Vahid had called this a classroom, waving at the dark. Dar had counted the ways a cistern differed from a classroom and given up at drowning.

"Right," Vahid said, his voice echoing slightly. "Now, I want you to hold that breath. And don't let go."

Dar exhaled slowly. "How long?"

"As long as you can. Until you don't need to anymore."

The instruction was madness. A man could drown in minutes. But this was the price of the Lily's gifts. Each Vein-opening was a metamorphosis with real costs, and the Breath Vein was next on the ladder. His body still remembered the bloom — the black vascular lace that had covered his skin in the fighting pit, the terrifying speed, the numbness that had followed when he'd forced it to stop. He remembered the crowd's faces, luminous and appalled. He remembered carrying Suri and feeling nothing. He couldn't let that happen again. Not to Suri. Not to whatever he was becoming.

Dar closed his eyes, the blindfold redundant now. He drew in another breath, filling his chest until it ached. He held it. The seconds stretched. One. Two. Thirty. His lungs began to burn, a familiar pressure building behind his ribs. He focused on the sensation, on the burning, willing it away.

"Breathe," Vahid urged. "Or don't. The choice is yours. That's the whole lesson, boy. Everything else is commentary."

Forty-five seconds. The burn intensified. His heart hammered against his ribs, a frantic counterpoint to his stillness. This was the way. The Lily had shown him in the dreams — a darkness so complete it was a presence, a pressure that pushed back against his own need. He had to find that pressure and hold it.

Sixty seconds. The burn was a fire now, consuming his chest. He could feel the Lily in his chest, a silent, patient thing. It wasn't helping. It wasn't hurting. It was just there, an alien observer, watching its investment struggle the way a lender watches a debtor empty his pockets. Dar focused inward, past the pain, past the frantic pulse of his own blood, searching for the symbiote's core. His lungs wanted what lungs want. He offered them instead the memory of the pit — of standing in the center of all that silence with a heartbeat he couldn't feel — and told them: this is what running out feels like. Get used to the arithmetic.

Seventy-five seconds. His vision began to tunnel, the edges darkening. The water lapped at his ankles, cold and indifferent. He was going to drown. He could feel it, the primal panic rising, screaming at him to breathe. He fought it, teeth clenched, jaw tight.

And then he found it. Not a presence, but an absence. A void in his own awareness where the Lily's influence should have been. It was a place of perfect stillness, of no-needs. Dar focused on that point, letting the void expand within him, swallowing the panic, swallowing the burning.

At ninety seconds, the pain in his lungs vanished.

It wasn't a relief. It was an erasure. The need for air simply stopped existing. He was still holding his breath, but the biological imperative was gone — cancelled, written off, removed from the books as if it had never been owed. The water was just water. The cistern was just a room. Somewhere in the walls the drip kept its own time, and he heard it the way one hears a neighbor's clock: noted, distant, no longer his.

"How?" Vahid's voice was strained, awed. "How are you doing that?"

Dar didn't answer. He couldn't. He was experimenting, pushing the boundaries. He focused on the void, on the absolute stillness it represented. He could feel his own blood moving beneath his skin, a dark river, but he was no longer bound to its rhythm. He was separate from it. He was separate from the body that held him.

One hundred twenty seconds. The burning in his lungs returned, but it was different now. It was a memory of pain, not the thing itself. He could feel the water on his skin, the chill seeping into his bones, but it was distant, like a sensation felt by someone else. He was the

observer, and the body was just the vessel.

One hundred fifty seconds. The void was expanding. It was pushing out, past his skin, into the water around him. He could feel the cistern walls, the cold stone, the dripping water, but it was all filtered through this new sense of self. He didn't need air because he was no longer entirely in his body. He was in the space between things.

At two minutes, Dar let the breath go.

A stream of bubbles rose from his lips, silent in the water-smelling dark. He didn't gasp, didn't choke. He simply released the air and stood there, his lungs empty, his body functioning perfectly. The void was still there, a silent hum in his awareness. He was breathing water.

Vahid was staring, his mouth agape. "By the First Vessel," he whispered. "That's... that's not just Breath. That's something else."

Dar pulled off the blindfold, his vision clear. "What is it?"

"I don't know," Vahid said, his voice trembling. "The texts say the Breath Vein makes the air optional. They don't say anything about... this. About becoming the water." He sat down heavily on an overturned crate, the handkerchief forgotten in his fist, and for a long moment the professor looked less like a teacher and more like a man reading a bill he could not pay. "The Church's texts name three closing notations," he said at last. "Bloomed through. Fled. And reserved." He didn't look at Dar when he said it. "They never write the fourth thing that can happen."

"Which is?"

"Interruption," Vahid said. "That's you."

* * *

The Saltstairs cisterns were a labyrinth of damp stone and echoing chambers, a city beneath the city, complete with its own roads, its own dead ends, its own missing persons. Suri's voice came through the tiny earpiece, crisp and precise despite the acoustics. "Two o'clock, fifty paces. Reliquary archive. Water's waist-deep. No heat signatures. Motion sensors are offline. They've been offline for three days. Maintenance log says 'flood damage'. Convenient. If you must touch the glass, keep it brief," she added. "Reliquaries trip like alarms when you breathe on them wrong."

Dar waded through the chill water, his movements silent. The void was still with him, a constant companion. He didn't need to breathe, but he moved as if he did, conserving energy, his senses extended through the water. He could feel the cold, but it didn't bother him. He could feel the drag of his clothes, but it was just data. The flooded corridor smelled of stone

and stillness, and somewhere far off, water was falling from a higher chamber into a lower one, patient as a drip-feed. He passed a junction where the channel split and rejoined, and in the still pool between the two currents he caught his reflection, or the lack of one — a dark shape the void declined to finish.

The reliquary archive was a circular chamber, its domed ceiling lost in darkness. Shelves carved into the stone walls held glass reliquaries, most empty, some containing small preserved organs. The water here was clearer, still and cold, lit faintly by the pale glow the vessels gave off — the light of things that had been made honest by fluid and glass. Dar ran his fingers over the surface of one reliquary. It contained a heart, shriveled and brown, floating in clear fluid. A name was etched into the glass: Kaelen. BLOOMED THROUGH.

He moved to the next. Another heart. Elara. FLED.

The pattern was grim. A ledger of failed experiments, written in the only script the Church truly kept: assets in, assets out, each closing notation final. Two words for every debt, and the debt was always the same — a person. Dar moved deeper into the chamber, to where the floor rose in a low shelf and the water fell to his ankles, his bare feet silent on the wet stone. Suri's voice crackled in his ear. "You're in the main archive now. According to the blueprints, the vessel registry should be against the far wall. Behind the second row of empty reliquaries."

The second row of reliquaries was indeed empty — every jar swept clean of its contents, though faint rings in the glass dust showed where hearts had sat, and sat, and been collected. Dar found it. A stone slab set into the wall, covered in rows of names and dates. He ran his fingers over the etched words. Most were closed with the same two phrases: BLOOMED THROUGH, FLED. He was looking for a strain number, Vahid had said. Something that would tell them about the Lily's origins.

He moved his finger down the list, past dozens of names, all closed. Then he found it. Not a closed entry, but an active one.

VESSEL: ILAY AGE: 9 GRADE: PERFECT RESERVED: THRONE

Dar's blood ran cold, even though he didn't need it to. Ilay. The child from the nursery. The perfect vessel. He traced the letters with his fingertip, the stone rough beneath his touch. RESERVED: THRONE. The word from the Cartographer's map, the shaft beneath the Marrowworks, the warning in the dead ledger-script. A nine-year-old had been entered in the Church's books as a fixture, and fixtures were things that stayed. And then he saw it, a column he'd never seen on any other page.

SIBLING STOCK: ACTIVE

Dar's breath caught. The Lily wasn't alone. It had siblings. Active siblings. Somewhere in this city, other chests were being measured for other heartbeats, and the Church had filed them not as failures but as family. He needed to copy this page. He pulled a piece of charcoal from his pocket and a thin sheet of treated vellum he'd prepared earlier. He began to trace the letters, working quickly in the darkness, the water lapping at his waist.

"Copy's done," he whispered into the earpiece. "Getting out."

As he turned to leave, a bell began to toll. Not the gentle, rhythmic bell of the Choratorium marking the hours. This was a single, sharp, insistent note that echoed through the cisterns, bouncing off the stone walls and vibrating through the water, so that Dar felt it in his shins, his hips, his ribs — in the hollow where the Lily sat, which answered it with one slow, deliberate pulse. It was a bell that tolled out of hours.

Dar froze. Suri's voice came back, tight with alarm. "Dar? What was that?"

"I don't know," he whispered, his eyes fixed on the entrance to the reliquary chamber. "But I think we just woke something up."

CHAPTER 11

The Girl Who Heard the Singing

The bell tolled again, deeper this time, a vibration that traveled through the canal-works' iron supports and into Dar's bones. It didn't ring so much as accumulate, one bronze note laid over another the way arrears are laid over a name in a lender's book. Somewhere under his sternum, the Lily turned in its sleep and counted every note like interest coming due. Suri's hand tightened around his wrist, her carbon scales pressing into his skin like cool coins. "They know," she whispered, her breath fogging in the damp air. "They know we have the registry."

Dar didn't answer. Answering would have meant deciding what to be afraid of first, and there were too many candidates for the position. His focus was elsewhere — on the small bundle of rags they'd pulled from the pump vanes twenty minutes ago. A child, no older than nine, with eyes the color of river stones and hair the texture of spun copper. She hadn't spoken since they'd found her, hadn't even flinched when Suri had lifted her from the canal's oily embrace, as if being taken out of the water had been nothing more than a change of rooms. Now she sat huddled in the corner of their hideout, a converted cistern beneath the Saltstairs, tracing patterns in the condensation on the wall with a grimy fingernail. Spirals, Dar noticed. Circles inside circles, each one smaller than the last, like a sound being swallowed.

"Her name's Ilay," Dar said, finally looking at Suri. "She was in the registry. Perfect vessel. Reserved for the Throne."

He hated how the page had rendered her: not a name, not a child — an entry, a grade of tissue, a column headed disposition, all of it in the cramped, contented hand of an accountant who had never been required to look at what he counted.

Suri's gaze shifted to the child. "The Chorus lost their prize. That's more dangerous than us having a page." She knelt, keeping a careful distance, the way you kneel near a bird with a broken wing. "How long have you been hiding here, little thistle?"

Ilay looked up, not at Suri, but at the ceiling, where a single naked bulb flickered weakly, buzzing to itself like an insect trapped in glass. "Since the singing stopped," she said, her voice thin as ice over a drain. "In the walls. They called me the garden's daughter."

Dar felt a cold dread seep into his chest, a familiar ache that wasn't his gravel-heart but the Lily responding to something. It pressed outward against his ribs, attentive, the way a sleeper turns toward distant music. The garden's daughter. That was what the choir organs had called him in his dreams — before he'd known about Ilay. Before he'd known about siblings.

* * *

The hideout smelled of damp stone, old oil, and something vaguely sweet that Suri called "heat-berries" — small, bioluminescent fungi that grew in the city's warmer pipes, glowing a faint bruised amber along the seam where wall met floor. Dar had rigged a small burner to boil water, and now he watched the steam curl toward the ceiling, feeling detached from his own body, the way he sometimes felt over an open chest cavity: present, essential, and somehow not entirely in the room. The Breath Vein was still active, a constant hum beneath his skin, but he'd learned to control it, to separate himself from the need for air. It was like being underwater without the water, a quiet space inside himself where he could think. He kept returning to it tonight. The alternative was to feel everything at once.

Suri was counting again, her fingers tapping against her thigh. He'd noticed it before — she counted the way other people prayed. "Three days before the salt-moon eclipse. Fourteen days since the Lily took root. Sixty-seven heartbeats since the bell tolled first." She looked at Dar, and in the bruised amber light her eyes looked like they'd been billed for everything they'd ever seen. "The Chorus won't wait. They'll tear the Saltstairs apart brick by brick to find her."

Ilay sat on a crate, watching them with unnerving stillness. Children weren't supposed to be still like that. This one sat like a ledger waiting to be audited. "They'll find me anyway," she said. "The singing knows where I am."

Dar knelt beside her, keeping his movements slow, non-threatening, the way he approached a wound that might still be alive. "What singing, Ilay?"

"The singing in the walls," she repeated. "Before. When they took me away from the quiet room. It said I was the garden's daughter. That I had to go back to the garden."

"The garden," Dar murmured, thinking of the Umbra Lily, of its roots and petals and the black lace that had bloomed across his skin. "You mean the Choratorium?"

Ilay shook her head, her copper hair catching the dim light. "Deeper. Where the singing is loudest. Where the First Singer sleeps."

Dar's blood ran cold. The First Singer. Anra Vey's buried host. The thing beneath the Marrowworks that was being fed forty years of organs — forty years of debtors rendered down into monthly installments of meat. He'd read about it in Vahid's notes, seen the architectural schematics of the buried shaft that led down to it: numbers, load ratings, feed schedules, every figure annotated in that patient graveyard hand. But Ilay had never seen those schematics. She'd drawn it herself.

* * *

Two days later, Vahid arrived smelling of gin and old paper, his coat stained with what looked like ink and something darker. He'd been drinking, as usual, but his eyes sharpened when he saw Ilay, the way a lens sharpens when it finally finds its focal length.

"She's the one," he said, his voice rough as a file drawn across bone. "The registry said 'perfect vessel.' I didn't expect..."

He didn't finish. Ilay held up a piece of folded paper covered in crayon drawings. Vahid took it, unfolding it with the care of a man defusing something. His breath hitched.

The drawing showed a cross-section of the city, but not as any map Dar had ever seen. It showed layers — streets, pipes, foundations — stacked like the pages of a ledger, and at the bottom, a vast, bulbous shape surrounded by roots that reached up through the earth like grasping fingers, tapping every layer, holding every street the way a creditor holds collateral. Beside it, Ilay had drawn a series of concentric circles, each labeled with a number. Her numbers were neat, neater than any nine-year-old's had a right to be.

"The singing told me," Ilay said quietly. "The numbers are how many steps down. The circles are how loud it gets."

Vahid stared at the drawing, then at Ilay, then back at the drawing, as if the two were connected by a thread only he could see. "She's mapped the shaft," he said to Dar, awe and terror sharing his voice like a room neither wanted to pay for. "By ear. The girl who hears the singing has mapped the path to the First Singer."

Dar looked at Ilay, at the calm certainty in her eyes, and felt the ground shift beneath all his plans. This changes everything, he thought. Not just their escape, but everything. The Chorus wasn't just after him anymore. They were after her. And if they got her back, the ledger would balance itself with whatever was left of the city.

* * *

That evening, Dar sat with Ilay in the corner of the hideout, sharing a piece of bread dipped in heat-berry jam, the jam leaving faint glowing smears on their fingers. Suri was on watch, her silhouette sharp against the doorway, lamplight breaking into blades on her scaled arm. Dar had his shirt unbuttoned, the Lily a faint pattern beneath his skin — black veins like roots spreading across his chest — and he had stopped pretending he didn't track their growth the way a debtor tracks a balance.

"Why do they call you the garden's daughter?" Dar asked softly.

Ilay took a small bite of bread, chewing with the deliberation of someone who had learned that food could be irregular. "Because I don't mind the dark. Because I like the singing. Because when they put me in the quiet room, I could still hear it through the walls. The garden wants to sing, but it's too deep. Too big." She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. "It's lonely down there."

Dar thought of the Lily in his chest, of its patience, its curiosity. It wasn't evil. It just wanted to bloom. And Ilay was part of that. A sibling vessel. A perfect one. He felt the thing stir at the thought of her — a slow, warm bloom of attention that frightened him more than any hunger had, because hunger he understood, and this was closer to tenderness.

He looked at his hands — precise hands that had saved lives and now carried this thing inside him. Survival, then protection, then refusal. That was the shape his debts had drawn him into. He'd been surviving since the Lily took root. He'd started protecting Suri. Now, with Ilay, it was different. This was hope. Fragile, dangerous hope, but hope nonetheless — the most expensive thing a man in Ashkarad could carry, and the only thing no one could repossess.

* * *

The knock came at dawn, sharp and deliberate. Three raps, then a pause, then three more. Suri was on her feet in an instant, carbon scales gleaming in the dim light, her whole body arranged around the knife at her belt like a sentence around its verb. "Chorus," she spat. "Too soon. Too clean."

Dar put a hand on her arm. "Wait."

The knock came again — two raps, this time. Ilay stirred where she slept, her eyes fluttering open, and for the first time since the pump vanes she looked afraid. "It's her," she whispered, sitting up. "The one who hums."

Dar exchanged a look with Suri. The one who hums. Anra Vey.

The door creaked open, not kicked or forced — an unhurried sound, in a city where doors were usually arguments. Standing in the doorway was Custodian Anra Vey, dressed in simple grey robes, her face unmasked, her hair pulled back in a neat silver bun. She held a lantern in one hand and a wicker basket in the other. No soldiers. No bone-plate champions. Just her, and a calm that seemed to absorb the room's tension the way sand absorbs blood.

"Good morning," she said, her voice warm as tea. "I do hope I'm not intruding. The bell must have woken you." She stepped inside, unhurried, and set the basket on the floor. From it, she produced a thermos and three ceramic cups — three, Dar noted, exactly three; she had counted them before she came — and poured with the steadiness of a surgeon. "I brought tea.

Chamomile. Soothing for the nerves."

Suri's hand was still on her knife, but she didn't move. Dar stood between her and Anra Vey, his body a shield, the Lily pressing outward against his ribs as if it recognized the doorway. "What do you want, Custodian."

Anra Vey poured the tea, the steam curling around her like a living thing. "To talk," she said, offering Dar a cup. "And to offer a solution. A way out of this for all of you."

Dar didn't take the cup. "There's no way out. Not with her." He nodded at Ilay without looking at her, because looking would have been a concession.

Anra Vey's gaze shifted to the child, then back to Dar, and for one unguarded instant something moved behind her face — not cruelty, but appetite wearing cruelty's clothes. "The girl is safe with me. Safer than she is here, running from the very thing that will complete her." She took a sip of tea, her eyes never leaving his. "I can unmake the Lily, Dar Mehran. I can remove it from your chest and give you back your mortal heart. The gravel-heart that was failing you before. You'll be free of it. Free of the debt. Free of the bloom."

Dar felt the Lily stir in his chest, a pulse of fear. It knew. It always knew. And beneath his fear, shamefully, something in him leaned toward the offer like a starving man toward a lit window.

"All you have to do," Anra Vey continued, her voice soft as the steam rising from her cup, "is give me the perfect bloom. The girl. Ilay. She is the key. The garden's daughter. With her, the Ninth Vein is possible. Without her... well. We both know what happens then."

She set her cup down and looked at Dar, her expression one of gentle understanding — the face of a lender explaining that this is the last time, truly, the very last time. "The tea is poured, Dar. It's still warm. You just have to decide which cup to drink from."

CHAPTER 12

Chorus of Flesh

The salt wind carried the scent of blood and hymns as Dar pressed his back against the cold stone of the Choratorium's undercroft. Above them, the grading night was underway — the annual assessment when the Church's nursery vessels were measured, weighed, and cataloged before the "reserve stock" moved to the graft-theaters. Even through three floors of consecrated stone, Dar could hear it: the cadence of the inventory, an assessor's voice leading a hymn, children's voices answering in unison, bright and blank as fresh-minted coins. Vahid traced the symbols carved into the wall, his fingers trembling with a mixture of fear and anticipation. "The entrance is behind this false section of the nursery," he whispered, his breath fogging in the damp air. "The children are taught hymns to make their tissue compliant — keeps the graft rejection low."

Suri checked her carbon-scaled arm, the plates clicking softly as she flexed her fingers. "Counted twelve heartbeats above," she murmured. "Plus the Choirmaster. Thirteen targets. Eleven vessels to extract. Triage ethics under fire."

Dar closed his eyes, focusing on the Lily's pulse in his chest — a steady, rhythmic drumbeat that had become his anchor since the Blood Vein opened. The Lily had grown more vocal these past weeks, not in words, but in cravings and dreams: the taste of copper on waking, the recurring image of a door made of ribs. It wanted to bloom, and tonight — he understood this with a certainty that lived below thought, below fear — tonight it wanted to hear the singing. "Let's move," Dar said, his voice tight. "The sooner we're in, the sooner we're out."

The hidden door swung inward with a groan of ancient hinges, revealing a narrow corridor lined with humming jars. Inside each glass container, a preserved organ pulsed with a faint, rhythmic light — a heart, a lung, a kidney — each kept alive by the Chorus's dark science, each glowing its own particular color of indebtedness. The air was thick with the scent of formaldehyde and something else, something sweet and cloying like overripe fruit left as an offering. "The reliquary," Vahid breathed, his eyes wide with recognition. "They keep the harvested organs singing, like a choir."

Dar's fingers brushed against one jar, the glass cold beneath his touch, and through it he felt the contents answer — a tick of recognition, faint as a pulse tapping at a fingertip. Inside, a heart beat in a slow, mournful rhythm. The Lily in his chest stirred, a sudden, sharp pang of hunger that made him stumble and catch himself against the shelf, jars chiming softly around

him like an audience leaning forward. "They're alive," Dar whispered, realization dawning cold. "Not just preserved — they're alive."

Suri grabbed his arm, her grip firm. "Focus, Dar. We came for the children, not the dead."

They moved deeper into the corridor, passing row after row of humming jars, each one containing a piece of someone's past, someone's life, reduced to a song in a glass prison. The walls were lined with crude musical notation etched into the stone — hymns to compliance, to sacrifice, to the beauty of being made whole by being made apart. Dar read the verses without meaning to; every note was a receipt, every rest a small mercy withheld. "This is the nursery," Vahid said, stopping before a heavy iron door. "The children are taught these hymns every day. Makes their tissue more receptive to the grafts."

The door creaked open, revealing a chamber lined with small cots. On each cot lay a child, no older than ten, their eyes closed as they sang in unison — a chorus of small, clear voices that echoed through the chamber and seemed to continue in the walls after each breath, as if the stone were learning the words by heart. "Perfect vessels," Vahid murmured, his voice thick with emotion. "They've been raised for this."

Dar's heart ached — both his own and the Lily's, which was the trouble with carrying two hearts in one chest: every grief arrived in duplicate. The symbiote in his chest pulsed with a strange, predatory hunger, drawn to the purity of the children's song, and Dar clamped down on it the way he would clamp a bleeding vessel. "We need to move fast," Dar said, his voice low. "Before the Choirmaster comes."

Suri nodded, her eyes scanning the room, her lips moving faintly with the count. "Counted eleven children. Ilay's among them."

Vahid pointed to a small girl sitting near the back, her hands folded in her lap, the only child whose mouth kept singing while her eyes were already open. "There. That's her. The registry marked her as 'perfect, reserved for the throne.'"

Dar approached the children, his steps silent on the stone floor, a surgeon entering a ward he had no right to. "Wake them," he whispered to Suri. "Quietly. We need to go now."

Suri moved from cot to cot, gently shaking the children awake. One by one, they opened their eyes, confusion dawning as they saw the strangers in their midst. "Don't be afraid," Dar said, his voice soft. "We're here to help you."

The children stared at him, their eyes wide with fear. "The hymns," one boy whispered, his voice trembling. "We must sing the hymns."

"No," Dar said firmly. "You don't have to sing anymore. Come with us."

He reached for Ilay's hand, and she flinched, pulling back. "The singing," she whispered, pointing to the ceiling. "It's coming from the walls."

Dar frowned, following her gaze. The walls of the nursery seemed to hum with a low, resonant frequency, as if the very stone was alive and singing — and beneath the hymn the children had been taught, Dar could feel a second song, older, slower, patient as sediment. The Lily in his chest pulsed in response, a wave of longing washing over him that was not his own and yet used his body as its shore.

"It's the First Singer," Vahid said, his voice strained. "They've buried her beneath the Marrowworks, and her song resonates through the city."

Ilay nodded, her eyes wide with understanding. "I hear it too. The walls sing when the lights are out."

Dar helped Ilay to her feet, her small hand trembling in his like a bird deciding whether to stay. "We need to go now," he said, glancing toward the door. "Before they notice we're missing."

The children followed him, their small feet silent on the stone floor as they moved through the corridor toward the hidden entrance. Behind them, the nursery door swung shut with a final, echoing thud, and eleven voices dropped out of the hymn one by one, leaving a hole in the music shaped exactly like them.

* * *

The harvest amphitheater was a nightmare of flesh and glass. The narrow corridor opened into a vast chamber, its walls lined with humming jars of preserved organs — the reliquary continuing, Dar realized with a lurch, into the operating rooms, so that the harvested could applaud the harvest. In the center of the room stood a raised platform, surrounded by bone-plate enforcers in white gloves and bone masks. On the platform, a child lay strapped to a table, surrounded by gleaming surgical tools. The Choirmaster stood over them, their voice a smooth, melodic baritone that seemed to fill the room from the inside.

"Today we welcome little Elias to the choir," the Choirmaster announced, raising a scalpel so the lamplight ran down its edge like a signature in silver. "His lungs are perfect — clear and strong. They will sing for decades to come."

The crowd of Chorus members in the amphitheater applauded, their faces hidden behind white masks. Dar's stomach turned. The Lily in his chest pulsed with a mixture of hunger and revulsion, as if it too could feel the violation of the room — the wrongness of a ledger whose entries were written on the living.

"Now," Dar whispered to Suri and Vahid, who had joined them at the back of the amphitheater. "We move on my signal."

Vahid nodded, his eyes fixed on the platform. "I need to find Shirin's lobe. It's here somewhere."

Suri tightened her grip on her carbon-scaled arm, the plates clicking softly. "Counted six enforcers on the platform. Two at the exits. Eight more in the crowd. Twenty-two targets. Eleven children to extract. Triage ethics under fire."

Dar took a deep breath, the air thick with the scent of antiseptic and something else — something metallic and coppery, like old blood reheated. He let the breath out slowly and made his peace with the arithmetic. "Now," he said, his voice sharp.

Suri moved like a shadow, her carbon-scaled arm flashing as she disarmed the enforcers at the exits with precise, economical movements — no flourish, no waste, every strike an entry balanced and closed. Dar charged the platform, his hands moving with the speed of a seasoned surgeon as he grabbed the surgical tools and turned them on the enforcers. The bone-plate masks shattered under the force of his blows, revealing the pale, terrified faces beneath — men and women who had never expected the inventory to fight back.

The Choirmaster whirled around, their scalpel raised. "Intruders!" they shrieked, the melody gone out of their voice. "Sound the alarm!"

The amphitheater erupted into chaos as Chorus members scrambled to defend their harvest. Dar moved through the crowd, his hands a blur of motion as he disarmed and disabled the attackers. The Lily in his chest pulsed with each blow, its hunger growing with every scream that echoed through the chamber, and Dar felt — horror stacked upon horror — that part of him was keeping time.

Vahid darted toward the wall of humming jars, his fingers flying over the labels. "There," he breathed, pulling a jar from the shelf. Inside, a lobe of brain tissue pulsed with a faint, rhythmic light. It was Shirin's — her voice, preserved in glass, singing a soft, mournful melody that only he seemed able to hear.

"Shirin," Vahid whispered, his voice choked with emotion. "I'm so sorry."

With a surge of strength, he smashed the jar against the floor, the glass shattering into a thousand pieces, each one carrying a sliver of light that guttered and died. The lobe pulsed once more, then went dark. Vahid stared at the remains, his face pale with grief. "I couldn't save her," he murmured. "But I could free the others."

Dar grabbed the child from the table and handed them to Suri, who was already ushering the children toward the exit. "Move!" Dar yelled, grabbing Vahid's arm and pulling him toward the door.

The Choirmaster lunged at them, their scalpel flashing in the dim light. Dar sidestepped, his hand closing around the Choirmaster's wrist. With a sharp twist, he dislocated the joint, the bone snapping with a sickening crack. The Choirmaster screamed, stumbling backward, cradling the ruined wrist against their white coat.

"You've robbed a dispensary, cutter," they gasped, their voice twisted with pain and fury. "The Custodian is building a BODY. Ask yourself what the city is for."

Dar stared at them, the words echoing in his mind. The Custodian was building a body? What did that mean? Before he could ask, Suri grabbed his arm. "Dar, we have to go! Now!"

He nodded, following her as she led the children and Vahid out of the amphitheater and into the narrow corridor beyond. Behind them, the alarm bells began to ring, their sharp, insistent cry echoing through the Choratorium. They ran, the children's small feet pounding on the stone floor, Suri's carbon scales clicking with each step, Vahid's breath sawing behind them like a debt coming due. Dar could feel the Lily's pulse racing in his chest, a mixture of triumph and unease. They had saved the children, but what had they really accomplished? The Choirmaster's words echoed in his mind: The Custodian is building a BODY. What did that mean? And what was the city for?

They burst out of the hidden entrance and into the salt-laced night air, the Choratorium looming behind them like a monstrous tomb. As they caught their breath, Dar looked up. A figure stood at the highest window of the Choratorium, half in shadow — a woman in white gloves, her face hidden behind a bone mask. She watched them go. Slowly, deliberately, she began to applaud, her gloved hands moving with a quiet, chilling rhythm that carried impossibly across the dark.

Dar stared up at her, a cold dread washing over him. They had escaped, but they were far from safe. The Custodian knew who they were now. And she was not pleased.

CHAPTER 13

Nerve

The silence in the Saltstairs hideout was a physical thing, a thick wool blanket pressed over the mouth. Ilay sat in the corner, tracing a finger along the floor's cracked salt-glaze, her small face turned away from the group. Suri counted the seconds between her own breaths, her carbon-scaled arm wrapped around her knees. Vahid polished his spectacles with a stained handkerchief, though they hadn't been dirty. Nobody spoke. They had all learned the same lesson in the same city: silence was never free, and this one was already accruing.

Then it started.

A high, thin note from the Choratorium, miles away and yet inside Dar's skull. A low thrum from a harvest-floor beneath the Undergleam. A chorus of screams from the ledgers, compressed into a single, vibrating chord. They layered over each other, a cathedral of pain laid across Ashkarad like a second map, invisible but inescapable — every street a nerve, every nerve an invoice, the whole city one enormous body being read aloud. Dar's hands clenched on the dusty floorboards, his nails splintering against the salt-glaze.

"Dar?" Suri's voice was a knife through the noise. "You're white as a ledgerman's sheet."

He couldn't answer. The noise wasn't sound; it was pressure, a physical force pushing against his bones, an ocean that had decided his skeleton was seabed. Each choir organ was a different instrument, a different agony played in a different key. The Choratorium's was a pipe organ, solemn and cruel. The ledgers were a shrieking violin section. Somewhere, a debtor's heart was failing, a slow, mournful cello that vibrated in his teeth. He gagged, bile rising in his throat, and somewhere beneath the nausea the Lily lay very still, listening the way a collector listens.

Vahid was beside him, his hands on Dar's temples, steadying them the way you would steady a shaking lamp. "Focus, boy," he said, his voice a calm island in the storm. "Don't listen to the song. Listen to the silence between the notes. Build a door."

A door. In the noise. The idea was absurd, impossible. The cathedral filled every inch of Dar's awareness; there was no room in it for a door, no room in it, he realized with distant horror, for a Dar.

"Close your eyes," Vahid instructed. "Imagine a wall. Thick stone. No windows. No doors."

Dar tried. He pictured the salt walls of the hideout, but they dissolved into the screaming of the ledgers. He pictured Saint Ferrous Hospital — its wards, its smell of clean linen laid over old sins — and it became the rhythmic thump of a harvest-floor piston.

"No," Vahid said, his grip tightening. "Not a place. A concept. A barrier. Think of it as a surgeon's field. Small. Contained."

A surgeon's field. Draped cloth. One opening, and everything outside it surrendered. Dar focused on the feeling of his own skin. The texture of his shirt against his collarbone. The warmth of his own breath on his lips. He held onto that tiny sensation, a single thread in the hurricane. Slowly, painstakingly, he built a wall around it, a wall of pure will, stitch by stitch, the way he closed a wound he could not afford to reopen. The screaming of the city didn't fade, but it... receded. It was still there, pressing against his barrier like floodwater against a door, but it was no longer inside.

"Good," Vahid said, his voice strained. "Now, open a crack. Just enough to hear one street."

Dar did. He eased a corner of the wall, and a flood of information rushed in. Not pain, not yet. Just the mundane symphony of the Saltstairs: the cough of a dying woman in the apartment above, the frantic pulse of a rat in the wall, the slow, steady beat of a child sleeping in the next room. He focused on the child, the pure, untroubled rhythm, four beats to the bar of sleep. He made that his door.

The hideout rushed back into focus. Suri was staring at him, her eyes wide. Ilay had stopped tracing the floor and was watching him with unnerving stillness. Vahid let out a breath he'd been holding.

"The Nerve Vein," he said, wiping his brow. "It opens the city to you. Every living thing, singing its own song. Most drown in it. You... you built a raft."

Dar was sweating, his heart hammering against his ribs. The Lily inside him pulsed in time with it, a cool, steady counterpoint to his own panic. It wasn't afraid. It was... curious.

They spent the next days in a state of controlled chaos. With his doors cracked, Dar could triangulate the hidden harvest-floors the Chorus used when the official tithe-barrys were too slow. Suri would case the location, her carbon arm a silent weapon, and Vahid would find a way to cut the power or jam the doors. Dar would stand by, his senses narrowed to a single street, listening for the tell-tale thrum of the harvesting machinery. It was, he had to admit, the closest he had come since Saint Ferrous to feeling like a surgeon again — one patient at a time, one street at a time, the whole screaming city held at arm's length by a wall of will that he rebuilt each morning like a wound dressed fresh.

The first liberation was brutal. A converted warehouse in the Marrowworks, where three debtors were strung up like sides of beef, their bodies chalked with annotations — yield, grade, balance outstanding — in the same contented hand Dar remembered from the registry. Their screams were a physical assault even through his doors. Suri moved like smoke, disabling the guards with swift, economical strikes. Vahid worked at the restraints with a bone-saw he'd carried for decades, the old steel singing softly through the pins. None of the three thanked them. One wept. One laughed until the laughing turned into something else, and the third simply mouthed the terms of his new debt as if naming the price could make it his.

They didn't free them into the city. They couldn't. The Wardens would scoop them up for new debts before their feet remembered the streets. Instead, they guided them to a pre-arranged drop with a syndicate that owed Suri a favor. The price of their freedom was a new debt, a smaller one, to the Gavel. It was a choice between the Chorus's knife and the syndicate's ledger. They took the ledger. Dar understood the arithmetic even as it sickened him: they hadn't saved those three. They had transferred the account.

They did it again. And again. Each time, the city's song shifted. The screams of the harvest-floors were replaced by the frantic pulse of gang wars, the territorial drumming of syndicate enforcers. They were tipping the underworld, and the city was singing about it. Some nights the new song was almost worse. Greed had a brighter timbre than pain, and it carried farther.

But the cost was intimacy. Suri sat beside Dar one evening, cleaning her carbon scales with a rag, each stroke rasping like a file across tin. He flinched.

"What?" she asked, not looking up.

"Your pulse," he said. "It's like a hammer on a tin roof."

She stopped, her hand hovering over her arm. "It's always been like that."

"Not to me. Now I can't unhear it. I can't unfeel it. The man in the apartment above us has a heart murmur that sounds like a teakettle. The rat in the wall has a fever. Everything is a noise, and everything is a feeling."

Suri was quiet for a long time, and he could hear the quiet itself — her breath held, her heart not slowing at all, only being counted. "Count it," she finally said. "Count the beats. Make it a number instead of a sound."

He tried. It helped, a little. But the numbers had their own rhythm, a cold, mathematical pulse that was just as invasive as the biological one. He had escaped the choir only to discover the choir kept a ledger too.

Ilay was different. She had gone nearly wordless; when she spoke at all now, it was only to name what she had drawn. On scraps of paper, with charcoal she'd found, she made maps. Not of streets, but of what she called "the singing." She would draw a cluster of sharp, angry lines and say, "The Choratorium." A series of slow, heavy circles: "The ledgers." And between them, a space that was empty, a silence in the noise.

"The city's song has a shape," Dar told Vahid one night, showing him Ilay's drawing. "And the shape has a hole."

Vahid frowned, tracing the empty space with a grimy finger. "The hole is where the First Singer should be," he said, his voice low. "The Chorus's secret. The thing they're building beneath the Marrowworks."

The next day, they went deeper. Using Ilay's crude map as a guide, they tunneled through service corridors beneath the industrial belt, following the thrum of machinery that fed the city's vital-debt system. They were looking for the central harvest-floor, the one that powered the entire operation. The one that must be connected to the First Singer.

The air grew thick with the smell of ozone and something else. Something organic. Old. They followed the sound of it, a deep, resonant thrum that vibrated in Dar's bones, a bass note beneath the city's screaming treble, so low it seemed less like a sound than like a property of the earth itself.

They found a grate in the floor of an abandoned maintenance tunnel. Below it, darkness. But the sound was louder here, a physical presence in the air, a pressure on the eardrum like deep water standing on the chest.

"Can you hear it?" Vahid asked, his face pale in the dim light of their lamp.

Dar nodded, closing his eyes. He opened his doors wider, letting the cathedral of pain flood in, but focused on the sound below. It wasn't an organ. It wasn't a choir. It was something else. Something vast. Slow. Older than the Church. Older, he suspected, than the debts it inspired.

"It's not an organ," he whispered. "It's... alive."

They pried the grate open. Below was a shaft, dropping into absolute blackness. The thrumming was coming from down there, a sound that felt more like geological time than biology.

"I'm going down," Dar said, before either of them could protest.

The ladder was rusted, rungs slick with condensation. He descended into the darkness, the Lily in his chest growing warmer with each step, as if greeting a relative. He did not like

knowing that the warmth was comfort, and he liked even less that it was. The thrumming grew louder, filling his entire world. It wasn't a sound he heard with his ears; it was a vibration he felt in his teeth, in his bones, in the very marrow of his spine.

He reached the bottom. The space was vast, bigger than the Choratorium. The air was cold and still, smelling of wet earth and something ancient and sweet. In the center of the chamber, pulsing with a slow, rhythmic light, was something that defied description. It was a mass of tissue, vast and slow, like a buried heart or a dreaming brain. It was the source of the thrumming, the furnace the Chorus fed.

And it was awake.

The thrumming stopped.

For a single, perfect second, there was only silence. The silence of the deep earth, the silence before a star is born. Then, the thing pulsed again. But differently. It was no longer a steady, furnace-like beat. It was a question. A slow, deliberate thump that seemed to echo in the chamber's stone.

Thump.

Dar's own heart answered.

Thump.

It was a rhythm he knew. A lullaby. The one his mother used to sing.

Thump.

The thing pulsed again, matching his heartbeat exactly. It was amused. Ancient. And it was listening.

CHAPTER 14

The Ninth Door

The Cartographer's fingers traced the chalk line as if it were a living thing, the dust of the dead sea clinging to the brass plate of her mask. Her workshop smelled of tallow smoke, cold metal, and that fine mineral sweetness that followed her everywhere — the smell of a place that had dried up long before Ashkarad learned to count. Dar watched the map unfold not with ink but with pressure, the lines rising from the chalkboard like veins beneath skin, a city rendered the way he rendered an anatomy: not as streets but as systems, everything subservient, everything connected, everything billed. Three days until the salt-moon eclipse, the Blacktide that would turn Ashkarad to a blind cavern. Three days until the ritual began.

Dar had stood in the rooms of powerful people before — Wardens, syndics, one Custodian with a basket of chamomile — and every such room had a signature. This one's signature was subtraction. No portraits, no trophies, no ledgers, in a city where even the poor kept ledgers. Only the chalkboard, the dust of a dead sea, and a woman who had turned mapmaking into a species of grief.

"This is the First Singer," the Cartographer said, tapping a point deep beneath the Marrowworks. The chalk clicked twice against the board, like a faucet refusing to run dry. "Forty years of grafts. Forty years of debtors harvested and fed to a dream." Her voice was the rustle of paper, the scrape of charcoal. "They call it salvation. I call it architecture."

Dar did the arithmetic he could not stop himself from doing. Forty years, compounded monthly — he thought of the reliquary jars, each organ a payment on an account no debtor had ever been allowed to close. Forty years of installments, and the creditor still sleeping. Still hungry.

Suri leaned forward, her carbon scales catching the lamplight like shards of broken glass. "A body a city could live inside. That's what the Throne is?"

"The Ninth Vein," the Cartographer corrected. "The metamorphosis for which no honest text exists. The Chorus believes they are building a god. They are building a cage." Her free hand swept across the chalkboard, revealing a network of tunnels converging on the buried shaft — every line running downhill, Dar noticed, the way water runs, the way debts run. "The Choratorium sits directly above. The ritual chamber is in the nursery level. Ilay's drawings were crude, but true." Dar thought of her crayons, of the neat concentric circles labeled with their loudness. A child had charted the city's deepest wound by ear, and the Cartographer was

confirming it the way one confirms any instrument: against the wound itself.

Dar touched his chest, where the Umbra pulsed beneath his ribs. A low thrum answered, a vibration that matched the chalk in his hand, as if the thing inside him could hear the map being drawn and approved of the route. "The Lily wants this."

"She wants to bloom," the Cartographer said. "But not into a garden. Into a door. The First Singer is the door, and the Blacktide is the key." Her fingers traced the path from the Undergleam to the Marrowworks, a route through abandoned sewers and forgotten utility tunnels, lines the official city had stopped claiming and the dark had quietly inherited. "The ritual requires absolute darkness. The Syndics will be blind, but not us. We have the city's song." The city's song. Dar flexed his fingers against the memory of last night's headaches — the teakettle murmur upstairs, the fevered rat in the wall — and wondered, not for the first time, what kind of instrument a man became when the whole city could be heard through him.

Suri's hand went to the pulse-reader at her wrist. "The Wardens will be hunting. The Gavel's crew is already tearing the Saltstairs apart looking for Ilay."

"The Chorus and the syndicates will be fighting over harvest territory," Dar added. "A three-way war in the dark." Nobody answered that. It didn't need an answer; every ledger in the city had been trending toward it for weeks.

"A distraction," the Cartographer said. "The real danger is the ritual itself. When the eclipse begins, the Chorus will sing the First Singer awake. The organs will fuse, the veins will open, and the city will become tissue." Dar tried not to see it. He failed. He saw the reliquary corridor with its humming jars, scaled up and turned inside out — the whole city glassed and lit from within, every citizen a relic in a row, singing because singing was all a preserved thing could do.

Dar felt the weight of it settle across his shoulders, the whole city, every debtor and denier of it, hanging from his spine like a body from a harness. The Lily in his chest pulsed faster, a hungry rhythm, and he understood that to the thing inside him this was not a warning but an invitation. "What do you want from us?"

"The harvest-registry," the Cartographer said. "Burn it. No more vessels. No more debtors fed to a dream. In exchange, I will show you the way to the First Singer. I will give you the map to end the map." The phrase turned over in Dar's mind. Every account he had ever heard of in Ashkarad was a map of somebody — the registry was a map of Ilay, the tithe-books a map of the canals' poor, the Choratorium's hymns a map of children's lungs. A map to end the map was a strange kind of mercy: burning the picture so the thing pictured could stay unclaimed.

Dar looked at Suri, who gave a single nod. The scales on her arm seemed to shift in the lamplight, a thousand tiny decisions made in an instant. He thought of Ilay's crayon cross-section, of the neat numbers beneath the bulbous shape, of a child who had heard the whole account of the city and survived it. Some debts you could not pay down. You could only refuse to pass them on. "We'll do it," Dar said. "But I need to know one thing. What happens if we stop it?"

The Cartographer's fingers stopped moving. The chalk dust settled on the brass mask like ash after a fire. "The First Singer wakes incomplete. The bloom-through begins. The Chorus will have to start over. Forty years of work lost."

"And Anra Vey?" Suri asked.

"She becomes human again," the Cartographer said. "And she will be furious."

Suri smiled without a single unit of warmth. "Good," she said.

Dar looked at the map, at the convergence of lines, at the point marked with a crude drawing of a lily — drawn, he suspected, by the same hand that had traced the routes, a signature in the margin of an ending. The Lily in his chest pulsed in time with his own heartbeat, a steady drumbeat against the storm coming. "We'll stop it."

They turned to give Vahid the good news, to tell him the plan, to include the old man in the final steps of their desperate dance. But his chair was empty. It still held the shape of him, the way a paid-off debt holds the shape of the hand that owed it. The chalkboard behind his desk was covered in his cramped handwriting, diagrams of the Nine Veins spiraling into madness, notes on the Umbra Lily, calculations that made no sense to anyone but him. Dar read them the way you read a patient's chart after the code has failed — too late, and therefore honestly. Under the diagrams, a single line in his familiar scrawl: "They kept her voice six years. I am going to take it back. Forgive the plagiarism — I always stole your best lines."

His coat hung on the hook he never used, empty and waiting. That was the detail that finished it. In all the years Dar had known him, Vahid had never once hung up that coat; he wore it to funerals, to harvests, to the bottoms of gin bottles. A man who left his coat behind had not planned on needing pockets.

Dar read the line twice and could not decide, either time, whose best lines the old man meant — his, the Cartographer's, or Shirin's, six years silenced in a jar that no longer existed. It didn't matter. In Ashkarad, farewell and confession were written in the same hand.

* * *

The salt-storm had begun outside, a familiar grace that turned the world to white noise, erasing the horizon and the difference between the sky and the sea that had dried into it. Salt ticked against the shutters in dry little armfuls, like a clerk dealing out something that could never be counted to the end. The Saltstairs would have been deafening on a night like this, everyone shuttered in, everyone counting the gusts between themselves and the Wardens. Here the storm was almost gentle, a white curtain drawn around the last honest room in Ashkarad. Dar stood before the chalkboard, Vahid's diagrams still fresh in his mind, the storm's hiss the only sound in the workshop. The First Singer. The Blacktide. The Lily. The pieces were falling into place, but the picture was wrong. Something was missing. It took him longer than it should have — the picture was missing a man. Not a piece — a man. The one who had taught them the maps and then decided to walk one of them alone.

"He went to the Choratorium," Suri said, her voice low. "He thinks he can find her voice."

"Shirin," Dar whispered. The name felt heavy on his tongue, like a coin too old for any living scale. "He's going to destroy it."

"He's going to die," Suri corrected. "The Chorus will tear him apart."

Dar said nothing. He was watching the storm whiten the one small window, measuring an old man's minutes against the height of the Choratorium's towers.

Dar touched his chest, where the Lily pulsed with a new rhythm, faster, more urgent — grief arriving in duplicate, the way it did now, one heart behind the other. "She's scared."

"Of what?" Suri asked.

"Of being alone," Dar said. "Of the bloom-through." Suri looked at Vahid's empty chair, and for a moment her counting fingers went still.

The Cartographer's voice came from the shadows, where she had been tracing the map with her eyes. "The Lily is not scared. It is hungry. It wants the bloom. It wants the Ninth Door."

Dar looked at the map again, at the convergence of lines, at the crude lily drawn over the deepest point of the city, and this time he looked the way a surgeon looks at a chart before the first incision — no longer asking whether, only where. The Lily in his chest pulsed in time with his own heartbeat, a steady drumbeat against the storm coming. "We have to go after him."

Suri's hand went to the pulse-reader at her wrist. "The Wardens are already on patrol. The Chorus will be expecting us."

"We go through the sewers," the Cartographer said. "The storm will cover our tracks. The salt will hide our scent."

Dar nodded. "We get Vahid. We stop the ritual. We burn the registry."

"The Lily wants the bloom," the Cartographer repeated. "It will not make it easy."

The storm pressed against the walls like something asking to be let in. Dar buttoned his shirt over the black lace of roots beneath it and stood.

Dar looked at his hands, precise and steady, the hands of a surgeon who had saved lives and stolen hearts, the hands of a debtor who had decided the accounts would close differently this time — closed by him, in his hand, in his ink. "Nothing worth having ever is."

CHAPTER 15

Truce of Salt

The cistern smelled of wet stone and old salt, the air thick enough to chew. Water counted the silence from somewhere in the dark, one drop at a time, patient as an auditor. Dar stood with his back to the carved mermaid that once spewed water into a basin now filled with rainwater and cigarette butts, her stone face worn smooth by tides that had stopped coming a century ago. Tide-marks striped the walls in faded rings, each one a closed account. Above them, the whole weight of Ashkarad pressed down through the ceiling, and Dar felt it the way a debtor feels a ledger — a figure entered against his name, accruing.

Around him, the city's worst had gathered: Mother Gavel's enforcers in their stained leather aprons; the Ledgermen with their brass knuckles counting coins, each coin turned, weighed, bitten, entered; even a representative from the Gavel's rival syndicate, the Hammers, who kept his distance near the archway with his arms folded, smelling of tar and cold iron. Suri stood beside Dar, her carbon-scaled arm crossed over her chest, counting the exits, the heartbeats, the lies. The Cartographer stood opposite them, masked in brass, her hands folded as if she were about to draw a map of the room itself instead of speaking.

"The terms are simple," Dar said, his voice echoing in the damp space. "No tithe-taking from the Saltstairs. No debtors sent to the ledgers without trial. And no harvesting."

Mother Gavel scoffed, a sound like stones grinding together. She sat with her rings stacked on her fingers like anchors and looked at Dar the way a creditor looks at collateral she hasn't decided to seize yet. "And what gives you the right to make terms, little surgeon? You're just a man with a fancy new heart."

"I'm the reason your pit is still standing," Dar said. "I'm the reason your enforcers walk the streets instead of rotting in the ledgers. I'm the reason you're sitting here instead of being hauled before the Syndic Wardens for what happened in the Marrowworks."

The words settled into the water-dark air and stayed there. The Hammers representative shifted, boots grinding grit against wet stone. "The Wardens don't care about us," the man said. "They care about the ledgers filling up. They care about the Chorus taking too many mouths to feed."

"Exactly," the Cartographer said, her voice metallic but calm. "The Chorus grows stronger while we fight each other. They want us divided. They want us weak."

"Or they want us desperate," Suri added, and her voice had the flat precision of a figure read off a slate. "When a man can't pay his debt, he'll sell anything. His blood, his organs, his years. They don't need to fight us if we're already handing them what they want on a silver platter."

The room fell silent. Even the dripping stopped, as if the cistern itself were listening for the next entry. Dar could feel the Lily in his chest, a cold pulse against his ribs, quiet and attentive. It was feeding on the darkness of the cistern, on the tension in the air, on the fear that was thicker than the salt fog outside — fear was its preferred currency, and the room was rich in it. He could feel the Bone Vein stirring beneath his skin, a deep ache in his marrow like a storm turning in his bones, and he breathed through it slowly, the way he'd taught himself to breathe through a patient's worst hour. Interest, he thought. Every hour it sat in him, it compounded.

"I've brought something," the Cartographer said, reaching into her satchel. She pulled out a rolled parchment and spread it on the stone floor with both hands, kneeling, the way one kneels to a body. It was a map of Ashkarad, but not like any Dar had seen before. The streets were lines of living tissue, faintly pink under the lamplight, and when his shadow crossed them they seemed to flinch. The buildings were organs — the Saltstairs a lung, the Undergleam a stomach, the Marrowworks a knotted heart. At the center, where the Choratorium stood, there was only a black hole in the vellum, a wound in the map, and around it the tissue-lines bent as if being drawn in.

"The city is singing," the Cartographer said. "And the song is changing. Something is growing beneath it."

Mother Gavel leaned forward, her eyes narrowed, lamplight caught in the wet of them. "What does that mean?"

"It means the Chorus isn't just harvesting organs," Dar said. "They're building something. Something big. And if we don't stop them, they won't just take our people. They'll take the city itself."

The Hammers representative spat on the floor, a bright confusion in the brackish water. "Impossible. The Chorus is just a bunch of mad surgeons in masks."

"Are they?" the Cartographer asked. "Then why do their tithe-clinics never run out of supplies? Why do the Wardens turn a blind eye when they 'voluntarily' harvest debtors? Why does the salt moon eclipse coincide with their biggest festival?" She let each question sit on the water like an unpaid bill. "Madness doesn't keep schedules. Institutions do."

Dar could feel the Lily thrumming in time with his own heartbeat, a cold song that promised strength but demanded more. He could feel the Bone Vein opening further, his bones hardening, becoming denser, more resistant, until he stood on the wet stone with the stillness of architecture. He could feel the weight of the city pressing down on him, the weight of every life that had been taken, every debt that had been called in, and he made himself carry it upright.

"Fine," Mother Gavel said, standing up. Her chair scraped; her enforcers did not move, and that was its own kind of signature. "We'll agree to your truce. But only if you get us something in return."

Dar raised an eyebrow. "What do you want?"

"Your surgeon," she said, nodding at Suri. "I want her to work for me. Her arm is impressive, but I know she can do more. I know she can count things other than debts. I want her to count our enemies."

Suri stiffened. Beneath her sleeve the carbon scales rippled once, a shoal turning. "I don't work for syndicates."

"Then you work for the ledgers," Mother Gavel said. "Your choice."

The silence had teeth. Dar looked at Suri — she gave him nothing, her face a closed column — then back at Mother Gavel. "She works for me," he said. "And in return, your syndicate provides safe passage. No one touches her. No one touches anyone from the Saltstairs."

Mother Gavel smiled, a thin, predatory expression, all margin and no goodwill. "And what do you get out of this, little surgeon? Besides a dead enemy?"

Dar touched his chest, where the Lily pulsed beneath his skin, cold and patient and always, always counting. "I get to live," he said. "And I get to make sure they don't take anyone else."

The truce was sealed with a handshake, sealed with blood drawn in the dark — an old custom, a thin cut across the palm, each captain pressing blood to blood while the water took the drops and kept them — sealed with the weight of unspoken promises that no parchment could hold. The syndicates agreed to the terms, the couriers agreed to run the canals dark, the Cartographer agreed to spread the word through whatever paper and rumor network lived inside her brass mask. And as they left the cistern, one by one, boots splashing up the drowned stairs into the grey, Dar felt the Lily drinking it all in — the darkness, the tension, the fear, the hope — a creditor at the closing of accounts, pleased with the volume of business. He felt the Bone Vein opening further, his bones becoming denser, harder, more alive, and he hated how good it felt, how easy the strength came, as if his body were being paid on time for once.

* * *

Dawn came with a salt-white sky that bleached the color from the world. Dar stood on the balcony of his apartment, overlooking the Saltstairs, the buildings stacked like bones against the storm-walls, catwalks strung between them like sutures. The light had no warmth in it; it was the light of a room before the anesthetic takes. He could feel the Lily in his chest feeding on the dawn — on what thin hope the hour offered — and he could feel the Bone Vein settling, his bones dense as coral now, his senses sharpened until he could hear the heartbeats of the city below, arrhythmic, overlapping, ten thousand small accounts refusing to close; could smell the blood in the streets, iron under brine; could taste the fear in the air, copper and salt, like biting a coin.

Suri stood beside him, her carbon-scaled arm crossed over her chest, counting the heartbeats, the lies, the debts. She had not slept. Neither had he.

"They agreed," she said. "Mother Gavel, the Hammers, even the Undergleam boats. They agreed to the truce." A pause, her jaw working. "Two hundred and forty-one heartbeats in that room, and not one of them told the whole truth. But they agreed."

"Did they really?" Dar asked. "Or did they just agree to wait? To let us do the dirty work while they watch from the sidelines?"

Suri was silent for a moment. "They agreed not to harvest from the Saltstairs," Suri said. "That's something."

"It's something," Dar said. "But it's not enough. Not when the Chorus is building something beneath our feet. Not when they're trying to become the city itself."

He looked out at the Saltstairs, at the people going about their lives, selling blood, selling organs, selling years, just to survive — a whole district making withdrawals against bodies it could never pay back. He looked at the storm-walls, at the salt storms called "grace" that white out the streets for days, the city's oldest lie hanging in the air. And he looked at the Choratorium, the cathedral of grafts, rising like a bone-white spire against the sky, so clean from this distance, so anatomically perfect, the way a tumor is perfect under glass.

"We have to stop them," Dar said. "Before it's too late."

Suri nodded. "We have a plan. The sewers. The Cartographer mapped them. We can get in through the old aqueducts."

Dar nodded. "And Vahid?"

"Still at the Choratorium," Suri said. "He left a note. He said he had to destroy Shirin's voice. He said he had to finish what they started."

Dar sighed, and the breath came out of him like the last of a long calculation. "Destroy it," he murmured. "Or take it back. With Vahid the verbs were always the same." He shook his head. "He's going to get himself killed."

"Maybe," Suri said. "Or maybe he's going to do what we can't. Maybe he's going to give us the chance we need."

Dar looked at the Lily in his chest, at the cold pulse against his ribs, the Bone Vein settled dense as coral through him, his senses wide enough to hold the whole district's pulse in one breath. The weight of the city was on him, the weight of every life taken, every debt called in, and under all of it, faint as a signature, the lullaby he could not place. "We have to move," he said. "Before the Blacktide."

Suri nodded. "Before the eclipse."

They turned to leave the balcony, to prepare for the sewers, for the Choratorium, for whatever waited beneath the city. But as they stepped back inside, Dar stopped. He looked back at the Saltstairs, at the syndicate banners hanging from the buildings, the Gavel's chains, the Hammers' iron, the Ledgermen's scales. And he saw it.

Every banner, every flag, every piece of cloth marking a syndicate's territory was marked with a petal of black frost. Delicate as lace, intricate as a spider's web, the frost petals covered every banner in the district, bloomed across the fabric in the night. And every petal pointed the same way, compass-true, toward the Choratorium.

Dar stared at the frost petals, at the delicate black lace against the salt-white sky. The cold of them reached him even here, up four flights, through stone and distance, and the Lily in his chest turned toward that cold like a plant toward light, drinking the fear that was thicker than the salt fog. His bones were dense as coral, his senses sharp enough to count the heartbeats below and find, beneath all of them, a rhythm that did not belong to anything with a face.

"She knows," Dar said, his voice barely a whisper. "She knew all along. She left the door open. She wants us to come."

Suri looked at the frost petals, then at Dar. Her scales were very still.

"Then we come," she said.

CHAPTER 16

The Offering

The Choratorium's doors opened like the petals of a dying flower, swallowing Dar whole. He walked under a truce-flag of white cloth, his empty hands held where the Syndic Wardens could see them, his footsteps echoing in the vaulted entryway. Two Wardens flanked the doors, their pulse-readers held like reliquaries, counting his heart against some column he would never be allowed to see. He kept his pace even.

The air smelled of lavender and something else—old blood, perhaps, or the salt that had seeped into the stones over a century. Lavender was a cleaning smell. It was what people used when they wanted the arithmetic underneath to stay quiet. A bone-masked usher led him past walls carved with anatomical diagrams of impossible bodies, figures with multiple hearts and spines that branched like trees, every organ rendered with a draftsman's love and labeled in a script that hurt to follow. The floor beneath his boots was polished bone, cool and unnaturally smooth, giving back his reflection like still water.

"You'll dine with Custodian Vey," the usher said, his voice muffled behind the mask. "She's been most eager for your company."

Dar nodded. He felt the Lily in his chest, a quiet hum beneath his ribs. It was restless tonight, feeding on his unease, on the lavender-and-iron air, on the careful hush of a building that knew what it was. He'd eaten nothing since morning, knowing the Lily preferred empty vessels when facing the enemy — hunger kept the instrument honest, kept every sense filed to a point. The corridors were lined with locked doors, behind which he could hear the soft weeping of children. Not loud. Practiced, almost — the weeping of bodies that had learned the walls did not come. The nursery vessels, he presumed. He counted the doors as he passed, because counting was the only prayer he knew. Vahid was somewhere here too, though whether alive or already harvested remained to be seen.

The usher stopped before a set of double doors carved from what looked like fused ribs, ribs of something far larger than a man. He knocked three times in a pattern that matched a heartbeat too slow to be human — a pause too long, then a beat, then a beat. From somewhere below, the building answered. Dar felt the pressure in the air change, the way it does before a storm front, or before a wound opens.

The doors swung inward.

The dining hall was a cathedral to gluttony. A long table stretched before Dar, laden with foods he hadn't seen in years—real meat, not the nutrient paste most Ashkarad citizens subsisted on; fresh bread, its crust actually cracked; butter that wasn't rendered fat; fruits with intact skins, still wearing the dew of a cold room. The sight of it did something ugly to his mouth. This was a tithe-clinic's accounting made visible: one table's surplus, balanced against a district's deficiency.

At the head of the table sat Custodian Anra Vey, her white gloves folded neatly beside her plate, her bone-plate mask replaced by a face of serene middle-aged beauty, her hair the color of salt and ash.

"Darius Mehran," she said, her voice like warm honey poured over cold steel. "You honor us with your presence."

Dar bowed slightly. "Custodian Vey."

"Please," she gestured to the seat opposite hers, at the table's midpoint, a hostess's courtesy that still left the head of the table hers. "Sit. You must be hungry."

Dar sat. The chair was carved from a single piece of bone, polished to a high sheen. It felt alive beneath him, like it was breathing — a slow flex against his spine, adjusting to his weight the way muscle adjusts, and he made himself ignore it, the way he ignored a patient's pulse under his palm.

"I am not," he said.

Vey smiled, a careful expression that didn't reach her eyes. "The Lily is particular about such things, I understand. But surely you can indulge in a cup of tea? It's from the eastern slopes, before the blight turned them grey."

A servant in a white apron placed a cup before Dar. The tea was amber in the candlelight, steam curling toward the vaulted ceiling, and the candles were set thick along the table — between them, at intervals, stood glass bells, and something moved in each bell. He didn't look closely. Not yet. He took a sip instead. It tasted of mint and something else—metallic, like blood. The Lily in his chest pulsed once, a warning, a creditor's finger tapped against glass.

"You've been busy," Vey said, gesturing with her fork to a plate of roasted fowl. "Broker peace where others would see only war. A rare talent."

"I'm a surgeon," Dar said. "I mend what's broken."

"Some things," Vey replied, "were never meant to be mended. They were meant to be replaced." She took a bite of her food, chewed slowly, swallowed — deliberate, unhurried, a woman who had never once eaten in fear. "The Blacktide approaches. Do you know what it is,

Darius?"

"The salt moon eclipse," Dar said. "The city will be dark."

"Darkness is not merely the absence of light," Vey said. "It is a state of being. A place where things that cannot exist in the light are free to grow." She set the fork down with the precision of someone laying a scalpel on a tray. "You of all people should appreciate that. Everything you've become grew in the dark first."

She stood, her movements fluid, graceful. "Come. I want to show you something."

They left the dining hall, the scent of food giving way to something older, more organic. The air grew warmer, thicker, and Dar's empty stomach catalogued it: iodine, wet copper, rain on hot stone. As she walked, Vey hummed — barely a sound, an old tune worn smooth from use, a lullaby he almost knew. He told himself he'd heard it somewhere in the Saltstairs, off some merchant's radio, off some mother's exhausted mouth. He did not examine why his chest ached at it.

Vey led him down a spiral staircase carved from living tissue—veins pulsed faintly in the walls, arteries branched like handrails, and the walls were warm to within an inch of his sleeves. The further they descended, the louder the sound became—a low, rhythmic thumping, like a giant heart. The candle flames leaned with each beat, all together, all one direction, as if the stairwell itself were breathing in time.

"This way," Vey said, opening a heavy door.

Beyond was the graft-theater. It was vast, circular, with tiers of observation seats carved from bone and flesh, each seat shaped to a particular body, and Dar understood with a lurch that he was looking at an audience measured to the Chorus's own surgeons. In the center lay the First Vessel.

It was a person, or had been once. Now it was a cathedral of flesh grown too large for its space, its limbs elongated into pillars, its torso swollen into a dome, its head a grotesque mockery of a face with too many eyes, all closed. It was tethered to the floor by thick cables of living tissue that pulsed with a sickly blue light. Forty years of grafts—hearts lashed to its ribs, lungs breathing in tandem, kidneys straining to filter its impossible blood—had turned it into something both beautiful and horrifying. Beautiful the way the ledger is beautiful, he thought, when you only look at the totals.

"Our masterpiece," Vey said, her voice filled with pride. "And our greatest failure. It will not wake. It dreams, but it cannot dream itself whole."

She walked toward the Vessel, her footsteps silent on the organic floor. "Ashkarad is a body that refuses to be whole," she said, turning to face him. "The ledgers are its tumors, the salt storms are its fevers, the debt is its poisoned blood. It is a body at war with itself. And I will be its heart. I will end its pain."

"How?" Dar asked.

"By becoming the door," Vey said. "The First Vessel is locked from the outside. It needs a living Throne to open the door from inside. Someone who has walked the Nine Veins, who understands the body's transcendence. Someone like you, Darius."

She gestured to the side of the theater. There, on a raised platform shaped like an altar, lay Professor Vahid Anousheh, stripped naked, his arms and legs spread wide. Tubes and wires were being grafted into his flesh, connecting him to the First Vessel — the grafts already taking, his skin puckering around each line like soil around a planted stake. His eyes were open, unfocused, his mouth moving in silent prayer. Dar knew the shape of the words even without sound. Numbers. Equations. Vahid praying in the only liturgy he had ever kept.

"His theory made literal," Vey said. "The keystone that will complete the arch. His mind will guide the transformation, his body will provide the spark. Together, they will make the First Vessel whole."

Dar felt the Lily in his chest stir, a cold dread spreading through him, rootlets tightening along ribs he had thought were his alone. "You're going to kill him."

"We are giving him purpose," Vey said. "His work will not be in vain. His partner's voice sings in our choir; his mind will become the city's song." She said it like an act of charity, a debt forgiven, a beggar raised to the table.

She turned back to Dar, her expression softening. "There is another way. You could stand aside. We have your original heart, regrown in a vat. It beats in glass between the candles in the dining hall. It is yours, if you let us have the Lily."

The glass bells. Something moved in each one. He thought of the small pale shape he had refused to look at, beating in its bell between the candles, patient as a saved-up coin. His heart — kept like a deposit, like collateral.

Dar looked at Vahid, at the First Vessel, at the cables pulsing with stolen life. "You're offering me my old life back," he said. "At the cost of everyone else's."

"The cost of progress is always high," Vey said. "But think of the alternative. The Blacktide is coming. The city will be blind, vulnerable. Without a Throne, Ashkarad will tear itself apart from within. With one, it will be made whole. You can be part of that, Darius. You

can be the cure."

Dar looked at his hands, the hands that had saved lives and taken them, the hands that now carried a symbiote in his chest. He thought of Suri, waiting in the Saltstairs, counting the hours the way she counted everything. He thought of the children in the nursery, weeping behind locked doors in their practiced voices. He thought of the city that would become a garden if Vey succeeded — still, silent, planted, forever in bloom, forever at peace. Every street a flowerbed. Every voice compost.

"I can't," he said.

Vey sighed, a sound like wind through dry reeds. "Stubborn child. The Lily will bloom through you eventually. Why not let it be on your terms?"

"Because it's not mine to give," Dar said. "It's a guest. And guests don't get to choose the house for their host."

Vey studied him, her eyes unreadable, and for a moment the serenity in her face looked less like calm than like stillness — the stillness of a thing that had already counted him and found the total acceptable. "You love this city, don't you? Despite everything."

"I know its pain," Dar said. "And I know the cure isn't to replace what's broken with something else. It's to mend it."

"Mending is such a small word," Vey said. "For such a large problem."

She turned away from him, looking up at the ceiling where the first signs of the Blacktide were beginning to show—the lights in the upper levels flickering, then going dark, one by one. Somewhere far above, generators coughed, caught, failed. The darkness fell like a wave, swallowing the Choratorium from the top down, and Dar stood in it listening to the wave come, level by level, an eclipse not of the sun but of the building itself.

When the last light died, only the bioluminescent veins in the walls remained, casting a sickly blue glow over the graft-theater. The First Vessel pulsed in time with the darkness, its multiple hearts beating a rhythm that made Dar's teeth ache — forty years of stolen pulses running in parallel under one roof, the largest account in the city, and tonight the whole balance had come due.

Vey turned back to him, her face a pale mask in the gloom. She picked up her teacup from where it sat on a nearby table, the steam rising like a ghost. She held it for a moment, then set it down with a soft click — the click of a seal pressed into wax.

"Shall we begin?"

CHAPTER 17

Bloom

The black was absolute, not a shade but a presence, pressing against Dar's eyelids like a thumb. The Choratorium's graft-theater held its breath around him, the air thick with the scent of ozone and preserved tissue. Forty choir organs hung in their glass coffins along the nave, their life-support systems humming in perfect unison — forty separate instruments carrying forty separate voices, filed, indexed, kept, the way a bank keeps what it is owed. At the far end, Custodian Anra Vey stood before the altar, her white gloves steepled as if in prayer, though her eyes were open and fixed on the stone slab beneath her feet. The Blacktide had come. Somewhere beneath the slab, the giant heartbeat that had thumped up the stairwell all evening had gone silent too, and somehow that silence was worse than the sound.

"Begin," she whispered, and the humming ceased.

The silence that followed was more profound than any sound. It was the silence of a ledger closed, of a column summed, of an auditor's pen lifted from the page. Dar felt it in his teeth, a vibration that traveled up his spine and settled behind his eyes. The Lily in his chest stirred, not with pain but with recognition. It had been waiting for this moment, for the city to hold its breath and the stars to hide their faces. Dar closed his eyes and let go.

The first bloom came as warmth, spreading from his sternum down his arms and up his neck. His skin tingled where the black lace pattern first appeared, fine as embroidery but alive with its own rhythm, stitching itself along him in lines no tailor would own. The Flesh Vein opened with a sigh, and the wound in his gut—that old gunshot scar—sealed itself without a thought, leaving only the memory of pain. He felt stronger, not just in muscle but in sinew, in the very fiber of his being, as if every cell had audited itself overnight and found new balance to spend.

The Marrow followed, his bones thickening, sharpening, until he could feel the structure of the floor beneath his feet as if it were an extension of his own skeleton — every seam in the stone, every hollow where the tissue had grown over bone, entered into him like a line item. His senses sharpened to a razor's edge, catching the scent of Vey's perfume—something like night-blooming jasmine—and the metallic tang of fear from the choir organs behind their glass. Even the harvested were afraid. That was the detail his mind snagged on and could not release.

Blood. The third Vein opened with a rush, and his veins sang with power. He could feel the pulse of the city beneath the stone, the slow, rhythmic beat of the First Vessel deep below, and beneath that, fainter, the ten thousand smaller rhythms of the Saltstairs going about its frightened night. His own blood answered his will, thickening in his veins to seal any wound before it could form. Breath came next, not as a need but as a choice. He held his breath and the air in his lungs became his own, a pocket of stillness in the encroaching dark, a reserve account he could draw on when the body began to spend itself.

The Nerve Vein opened with a jolt, and he heard it—the song of living tissue, not just from the choir organs but from the very walls around him, from the stone itself. It was a chorus of a thousand heartbeats, a symphony of pain and pleasure, and for a moment, he was overwhelmed. Every nerve in the theater was an open account, and he could read every balance: longing, terror, a dull adopted contentment from the grafted things, hunger from the walls. He breathed — chose to breathe — and made the chorus into background the way a surgeon makes a screaming patient into anatomy.

Then came Bone. The sixth Vein opened with a crack that echoed in his mind, not in his ears. His skeleton remolded, knitting itself into something new, something that could endure what should kill it. The black lace spread to his elbows, intricate and beautiful, each petal a promise of transcendence. He felt the pitiless clarity of bloom, the understanding that he was becoming something more than human, something that could hold the weight of a city in his veins — and he understood, too, with that same clarity, that clarity itself was the price. The lace did not think in mercy. It thought in totals.

He opened his eyes.

The graft-theater was a cathedral of shadows. The choir organs were no longer humming; they were silent, waiting. Vey had turned to face him, her expression serene, almost maternal. "Come to me, Darius Mehran," she said, her voice carrying in the darkness. "And let me show you what you could become."

Dar took a step forward. The black lace on his arms pulsed in time with his heartbeat. He could feel the Lily's will, its desire to bloom, to become the salt garden it had shown him in dreams—a place where every person was planted and peaceful and forever. In the dream the garden had been white and still, rows of sleepers rooted to their beds, their faces smoothed of debt, of want, of everything that made a face a face. No ledgers. No chorus. No interest accruing anywhere, forever. In the dream he had been smiling, which was the part that frightened him most. It was not a threat. It was an invitation, and it was beautiful.

He took another step, then another. The floor beneath him groaned, not with his weight but with the weight of something else, something vast and slow and dreaming. The First Vessel. Dar could feel its presence, a slumbering giant beneath the stone, its body a cathedral of flesh grown over forty years of harvested organs. He thought of Suri, of the Cartographer, of Ilay—all of them, messy and loud and free, counting, drawing, arguing, alive. He thought of the city itself, with its salt storms and its debt-prisons, its beauty and its cruelty. He thought of the ugly, loud, free city he loved.

"No," he whispered, and the word was a blade in the darkness.

The petals receded, not with anger but with disappointment. The black lace on his arms thinned, the intricate patterns fading into his skin like a memory. The Lily yielded, and for the first time, it spoke aloud, in a voice Dar half-knew, warm and strange: "Then carry me a little further."

The sound echoed in the graft-theater, not through the air but through his bones, through the very stone around him. And then, beneath the floor, the First Vessel opened its eye.

* * *

The eye was vast, a moon of flesh rising through the stone slab at the altar. It was not human, not yet, but it was alive, its iris the color of storm clouds, its pupil a void that swallowed the light. Vey stepped back, her serene expression finally cracking into something like awe. "She hears you," she whispered. "The First Singer hears your refusal."

Dar felt a tremor run through the floor, not from the eye but from the body beneath it, the First Vessel stirring after forty years of sleep. Dust and salt sifted down from the vaults. The choir organs along the nave began to hum again, but this time it was not a melody—it was a question, a demand, the same note repeated as if the whole choir were waiting for an answer to be entered in a single blank line. Bone-plate enforcers emerged from the shadows, their masks featureless in the darkness, their hands gripping curved bone-blades that gleamed like teeth. They did not run. They advanced at the pace of things that knew the dark belonged to them.

The doors at the far end of the nave burst open, and light flooded in—harsh, electric light from the streetlamps outside, light that did not belong to the eclipse and so burned like an accusation. Suri stood there, her carbon-scaled arm raised, a syndicate crew behind her. "We've got the doors!" she shouted, her voice cutting through the humming. "How many more are coming?"

The Cartographer stepped beside her, her brass mask reflecting the light. "The walls are singing," she said, her voice calm. "They're afraid."

Vey laughed, a sound like breaking glass. "Afraid? No. They're listening." She turned back to Dar, her eyes fixed on the eye rising through the floor. "The Blacktide is not just an eclipse, Darius Mehran. It is a conductor's baton. And the city is our orchestra."

The eye blinked, and the world went dark again.

* * *

Dar lunged forward, not at Vey but at the altar, at the eye that was now fully exposed, a vast orb of flesh and blood and bone. He could feel the Lily in his chest, stirring again, its will merging with his own. The black lace spread up his arms again, this time faster, more deliberate, each petal a weapon against the darkness. He did not fight it this time. There was no account left to protect except the ones behind him, and he would spend whatever the spending cost. Strength on credit. He was learning, at last, how the Lily had always meant him to live.

The bone-plate enforcers moved, their blades flashing in the electric light from the door. Suri and the syndicate crew met them, the sound of bone on carbon ringing through the graft-theater, flat and terrible, the sound of one ledger trying to cancel another. The Cartographer hummed, her voice low and rhythmic, and Dar felt it—not as sound, but as a map, a path through the chaos, a way to the center of it all. Her hum never changed pitch. The map did not need to. Left around the first tier. Straight past the coffins. The altar. She was charting him a route through a room that wanted to swallow him, and his body followed the chart without asking permission.

Vey stood before the eye, her hands raised as if conducting an orchestra. "Now," she whispered, "we sing."

The choir organs along the nave began to hum in earnest, their voices merging into a single, discordant note that vibrated in Dar's teeth. The eye blinked again, and this time, when it opened, its pupil was not a void but a star—a point of light in the darkness that pulsed with the rhythm of the city. It was beautiful, and it was a collection plate. Every heartbeat in Ashkarad seemed to arrive in that pupil and be kept there, filed, folded into the light.

Dar reached the altar, his hands outstretched, not to attack but to touch. He could feel the warmth of the eye, the life within it, the dream of the salt garden — so close now that he could smell the dream, wet earth and white flowers and nothing burning, nothing owed. The Lily in his chest pulsed in time with the eye, and for a moment, he was the bridge between them, the conduit between the dream and the waking world. He felt the whole transaction pass through him: one city on one side of the ledger, one garden on the other, and his own name on the line beneath.

Vey turned to face him, her expression serene once more. "You see now, don't you? This is not about power. It is about peace. About becoming one with the city, with the dream."

Dar looked from the eye to Vey, to the chaos behind him, to the light from the door where Suri fought. He thought of the ugly, loud, free city he loved, with all its flaws and its beauty. He thought of the Lily's dream, peaceful and perfect and forever. He thought of the cost—of himself, of Suri, of the city itself. There were no minor clauses. The garden's silence was total, and totals were all the garden understood.

"No," he said again, the word stronger this time. "Not peace. Choice."

The eye blinked, and the light within it dimmed. The black lace on Dar's arms pulsed, and the Lily spoke again, its voice warm and strange: "Then carry me a little further."

The First Vessel's eye closed, and the world went dark.

CHAPTER 18

The Cost

Dar's fist shattered the altar stone just as Custodian Vey's fingers brushed the First Vessel's crown. The impact vibrated through his bones, up the Lily's roots, into his mind. Vein Seven—Mind—opened not as a gift but as a wound. The Lily's rootlets unwound through the soft ledger of his brain, and every memory in him stood exposed, a page of entries under an auditor's lamp, and something began to withdraw from the account. Memory bled like light from a punctured vessel. He saw his mother's face, the curve of her smile as she'd sung him to sleep as a child, the scent of her hair that smelled of rain and paper, the way her hands had felt when she'd held his gravel-heart against her chest after the operation — small and scalding and sure, humming into his hair while the anesthesia let go of him. Then it was gone. Not just forgotten, but spent, paid to the darkness to keep himself whole. He felt the space where it had been: clean, swept, balanced. The cost was immediate and absolute, and he understood, in the ruined clarity of the seventh Vein, that he had just made the first withdrawal of many. The Lily had not stolen the memory. It had billed him for the strength to keep standing, and memory was the only coin in him it accepted.

Vey screamed, but it wasn't a sound of pain but of rage. The Blacktide eclipse poured through the fractured ceiling, salt-moonlight the color of drowned ink, illuminating her transformation. Her skin had split like overripe fruit, revealing black vascular lace beneath—petals of the Lily's true form spreading across her body, wet and glistening, opening along her arms in ordered rows like entries in a book that had been waiting decades to be read aloud. She was becoming something else, something vast. The Choratorium itself seemed to pulse with her heartbeat. The eclipse light did not flicker with the dying generators above; it held steady, and under it her shadow was wrong, rooted, climbing the walls like ivy in fast time. The stone walls wept condensation that smelled like ozone and decay.

"FOOL!" Vey's voice echoed through the chamber, distorted by the bloom-through, doubled and tripled, as if every Choir harvest that had ever died on these floors were speaking through her at once. "The garden must bloom! You cannot stop what has been planted!"

Dar didn't answer. He moved, not with his own strength but with the Lily's will. His bones remolded themselves at Vein Six, absorbing the impact of falling debris — a choir coffin came down whole beside him, burst like a dropped bell, and the living organ inside it lay on the tiles still humming its single kept note, and Dar ran past it and did not look back. His blood answered his command at Vein Five, thickening to clot wounds before they bled. He was a

symphony of metamorphosis, each Vein a note in a discordant song. The graft-theater around them collapsed in on itself, stone and bone and flesh mixing in a grotesque ballet; the tiers of surgeon-fitted seats folded like paper, the nave's ribs came down in sprays of blue-light tissue, and the whole forty-year architecture of other people's bodies fell around him while he ran through it, spending himself to stay alive. Somewhere behind him an enforcer screamed, pinned under a fallen tier, and the dark did not answer him.

Suri's voice crackled in his earpiece, raw with pain. "Dar, the doors won't hold! They're coming through!"

He could hear it—the thudding of bone-plate fists against reinforced stone, the splintering of wood, the screams of Syndic Wardens caught in the crossfire, men who had come to collect debts and were now paying in full. The Cartographer's voice, calm despite the chaos, guided him through the collapsing sanctuary. "Three corridors left. The sanctum is ahead." Her hum threaded under the words, a map drawn in sound, and he followed it the way a drowning man follows a rope. Static chewed the edges of Suri's voice. The Cartographer's did not have edges to chew.

Vahid stumbled beside him, his left arm a mass of pulsing Chorus tissue that had replaced his own when the altar shattered — the graft had taken his arm the way the ledgers took a house, at the stroke of a falling stone, and the new flesh was pale, veined, alive, moving already to a rhythm that was not his heartbeat. Vahid stared at it as he ran, and his face did something terrible and brief: horror crossing over into the scholar's hunger that had built him. "The First Singer," he gasped, "it's awakening!"

Dar reached the sanctum just as the last support beam gave way. Vey stood before them, her form now half-throned, half-human. The black vascular lace had spread across her chest and face, and her eyes had become pools of liquid shadow, and she no longer looked like a woman in a room; she looked like an institution wearing one.

"You came to bargain," Vey said, her voice a chorus of whispers. "But you brought only destruction."

"The destruction was already here," Dar replied, raising his hands. The Lily pulsed within him, a cold fire in his chest. "You were building a cage."

"The city is a cage, child," Vey said, spreading her arms. The black lace spread like wings, pinning the candle-shadows to the walls. "We were offering it a heart."

Dar lunged. The fight was not of flesh but of will. Vey struck with the force of a collapsing building, but Dar's bones at Vein Six absorbed the impact, turning the blow into his skeleton and out through his heels into the shivering floor. He struck back with blood that hardened like

iron at Vein Five, tearing through her lace-petals, and she tore back, and the currency of the fight was not blood. Each wound she inflicted cost him more memory—his father's laugh, a sudden specific bark of delight gone from the world as if it had never been; the taste of his first kiss, salt and smoke and someone's name he no longer owned; the color of his childhood home, the walls grey now, greyer, then colorless, a room with the windows painted over. He paid without hesitation, trading himself piece by piece, initialing each loss like a withdrawal slip, because a man who stops paying in the middle of a fight is a man who stops. She learned fast. Every time he paid, she struck again into the emptied space, as if she could hear the hole where the memory had been.

The Cartographer threw open the sanctum doors, revealing Roya beneath the brass mask, her face streaked with grime and tears. She pulled the mask off with one hand like a bandage, and without it she was younger than her voice, and her mouth was moving before the mask had cleared her chin. "The syndicates are breaking through! We have to go!"

Vahid grabbed Dar's shoulder. "The First Singer!"

Dar turned. Beneath the shattered altar floor, the First Vessel stirred. Its eye, vast and ancient, opened. It had been growing for forty years, a cathedral of flesh and stolen organs, and now it was awake. The eye did not look at him the way eyes look. It looked at everything at once, the way a ledger does, and in being read he felt, briefly and completely, known. Its song was not of joy but of release—a wave of pure sound that washed over Ashkarad. It came up through the stone and into Dar's teeth, his marrow, the dense coral architecture of him, and it did not sing to him. It sang through him, to everything grafted, everything kept, everything held as security against a debt.

In that moment, every choir organ in the city went silent. The sound went out of the walls — the hum in the halls, the voice in the pipes, the forty-year chord that Ashkarad had mistaken for weather — and in its place, everywhere at once, ordinary noise. Donors woke whole on harvest floors, their bodies no longer instruments of the Chorus, the stitches in them closing on their own as the grafts that held them let go. The canal-singer's voice returned to its former glory, no longer amplified by stolen lungs, raw and small and entirely hers. The city was free. He felt the freedom arrive in his own chest like a credit entered at last against a long-owed name. In the tithe-clinics, machines built to read a debtor's signature-heartbeat began counting only heartbeats, and the Wardens holding them looked at their own hands like men holding dead instruments.

But the cost was immense. Vahid's left arm was permanently Chorus tissue, its pale fingers flexing to the Singer's fading rhythm, a limb that now belonged to the music it had been built to serve. Suri's scaled arm was split and burned, the graft ruined — he saw her through the

blown doorway at the end of the corridor, braced against a wrecked jamb, holding the arm against her ribs like a broken ledger she couldn't bear to put down. Roya's song-lobe went silent, her connection to the city's living tissue severed; the hum that had been a map all night stopped mid-note, and she stood in the doorway with her bare face in her hands, deaf to the walls for the first time since they had first spoken to her. And Dar—he couldn't remember his mother's face. He reached for it, out of habit, out of need, and found the column empty. The memory was gone, spent like coin in the darkness, and the darkness did not give receipts.

Vey screamed as the First Vessel's song washed over her. Her form dissolved into black lace, petals that fluttered in the Blacktide before dissolving into nothing — a whole institution unbundled into paper and burned, every signature drifting separately toward the fractured ceiling and gone. Only her white gloves remained on the altar rail, pristine against the stone, empty and elegant, like two hands that had signed everything and could now sign nothing.

Dar carried Vahid out into the first salt since the eclipse. The salt-storm howled around them, white and absolute, a grace that erased the streets and the burned banners and most of the sky. The salt found every cut on him and burned like a stamp pressed into wax. Vahid weighed almost nothing; whatever the Singer's song had taken, it had taken cleanly. Syndicate crews fought Wardens in the streets, their banners marked with black frost petals pointing toward the Choratorium, everyone still charging interest in a city that had just, briefly, forgiven none of it. The city was chaos, but it was chaos of their own making, and Dar found that he could carry that weight better than the other kind.

They came back through Vey's sanctum on the way to the stairs, and the sanctum was untouched by the destruction, as if the room had been held in reserve all along, walled off from its own collapse. In it lay the World Registry. Nine entries, nine cities, nine seeds sown a century ago by a hand signed only "THE GARDENER," each city's name inked beneath a small stamped flower blooming from a crack in the earth. Eight entries were stamped BLOOMED—TRUE THRONE, the wax on each seal dark as dried blood. He knew none of the names. The vellum had gone amber with a century of salt air, but the stamps were crisp, recent, kept current. Ashkarad's read: VESSEL: FLED—RECLAIM. Dar read it twice while the storm howled at the door and Vahid murmured equations over his new arm. The Ninth Vein was not a rank. It was a door. And it was never meant to be opened by a person.

He folded the page into his coat, against the beating of the Lily, where the ledger kept what it kept. Somewhere in him there was a swept, balanced space where a woman's face had been, and the lullaby still lived there, singing to no one. He carried Vahid into the white.

CHAPTER 19

The Tithe-Clerk's Day

Milla Ferun's fingers were always cold. They had to be. Cold fingers didn't tremble when the pulse-reader whined, didn't sweat when the debtor's pulse thinned under the clamp, didn't leave damp prints on the clean white forms that were the only things in the Marrowworks never permitted to smudge. Today they were colder than usual, the air from the vents carrying salt and the faint, sweet scent of preserved tissue — a smell she had long ago stopped naming, the way you stop noticing a weight carried daily. She stamped another form — T-7B, lung lobe, standard tithe — and slid it into the growing pile, where it settled against its fellows with the soft obedience of paper. The quota for the day was thirty-three hearts. She'd processed twenty-seven. Six more to go.

She knew the six the way she knew everything in this room: not as people, but as line items awaiting their stamps.

"Morning, Milla," said Elara, dropping a stack of fresh forms on her desk. The ink still smelled wet. "Saltstairs shipment coming in at noon. Better clear space."

Milla nodded and began arranging her stamps in their designated slots, an order she could have kept blind, in her sleep. The Heart-Stamp. The Debt-Stamp. The Voluntary-Stamp. Each one made a different sound when it hit the paper, and she had come to know those sounds the way a priest knows bells. The Heart-Stamp was the heaviest, a solid thud that felt final, the sound of an account being closed in a body. The Debt-Stamp was lighter, a dry click, because debt was never finished with anyone and the stamp knew it. The Voluntary-Stamp was the lightest of all — barely a whisper — which had always struck her as the machine's one piece of honesty. She'd started counting the sounds at the beginning of the month, because counting was the only prayer the Chorus had left her. Twelve thousand, seven hundred and forty-three. That was how many hearts she'd stamped in her five years as a tithe-clerk. She knew the number as well as she knew the sound of her own pulse, and she was no longer certain which of the two she trusted less.

The clinic was a long, white room with rows of examining tables where people lay still as sacrifices, sheeted to the chin, their arms turned palm-up as if in surrender or appeal. Beyond the glass wall, the nurses moved with practiced efficiency, their gloved hands disappearing into body cavities and emerging with organs nestled in coolers, each cooler labeled, each label correct, everything audited down to the milliliter. Milla never looked directly at the tables. She looked at the forms. Forms were clean. Forms had names and debt ledgers and next of kin.

Forms were people before they became inventory — people condensed, refined, reduced to their salable parts and their outstanding balances. A form never screamed. A form never asked what would become of its sister's lung operation. A form was the story the Chorus preferred to read.

"Name's Kaelen," said the man sliding into the chair opposite her desk. He was young, maybe nineteen, with the hollow cheeks of someone who'd already sold something valuable, and he sat the way debtors sat — spine straight out of principle, hands still out of terror. "Here for the heart tithe."

Milla took his census chit, the small brass disc that held all his information, warm from his pocket and warmer for it. She slotted it into the reader, and the machine did what the machine always did: it made him small. His face appeared on the little screen, then his debt ledger, and there it was, the number the Chorus had spent nineteen years arranging. Eighteen thousand, four hundred and ninety-seven marks. For his sister's lung operation. The system was designed to be inescapable; she had understood that on her first day, and five years of stamps had only deepened the understanding. A debt paid with blood was a debt that grew. The body shrank, the ledger swelled, and the difference was called interest.

"Standard procedure," Milla said, her voice flat as the page in front of her. She slid a consent form across the table. "Read section seven. The one about the grace period."

Kaelen's eyes were wide. "They said... they said I wouldn't feel it. The withdrawal."

Milla's fingers paused over the Voluntary-Stamp. It was the closest thing to hesitation her hands were still permitted, and she spent it here, every time, a thirty-second tax she levied against the system on the behalf of no one. "The heart doesn't hurt when it's gone," she said, which was true. "What hurts is the living without it." She stamped the form. The whisper of the Voluntary-Stamp was very loud in the little office. "Table seven. Nurse Jory will prep you."

As he walked away, Milla made a small note in her ledger: *Kaelen, L. — Heart Tithed — Grace Period: 72 hours.* She knew what would happen, because the form told her and because the form had never once been wrong. In seventy-two hours, the grace period would expire, and his debt would be recalculated based on his new, diminished capacity to work — a heart shy of the labor the number assumed, so the number would grow to cover the difference. He'd come back. People always came back. The Chorus was patient. They had to be. A garden couldn't be rushed.

The afternoon bled into evening, the light through the high windows going from white to grey to the color of old bone. The last shipment from the Saltstairs arrived — a dozen debtors

chained together at the wrists, their faces grey with resignation, some of them still carrying the salt of the storm in their hair. Milla processed them quickly, her stamps clicking like a metronome, and the metronome kept time for a room that had no other music. She didn't learn their names. Names were dangerous. They made you imagine them as people who had lives outside this room — meals, arguments, someone waiting up — and imagination was the one expense the Chorus had never figured out how to deduct from her wages. She gave them numbers instead. The numbers behaved.

When the last form was stamped and filed, Milla stretched her cold fingers, and the small motion felt like insubordination. Her supervisor, a man named Borin whose eyes were as flat as the clinic's polished floors, approached her desk without hurrying, because nothing in this building ever needed to hurry.

"Milla," he said, not looking at her. "A pulse-printout came in from the Saltstairs. Flagged RHYTHM UNRESOLVED. File it with the anomalies. And lose it."

Milla's stomach tightened, an old reflex from a part of her that had not signed anything. Anomalies were bad. They were things the Chorus didn't like, things that didn't fit the neat patterns of their ledgers — and patterns were all the Chorus loved. "What's wrong with it?"

"None of your concern," Borin said. "Just make it disappear. Permanently."

He handed her a thin strip of paper covered in jagged, irregular lines. Most pulse-readouts were smooth, predictable waves — the Chorus's own harmony, written out in grey. This one was a mess of spikes and dips, like a heart trying to find a rhythm and failing, or like a heart trying to carry two rhythms at once and refusing to drop either. Milla took it, her fingers brushing Borin's as the paper passed between them. His skin was cold, too. Everything in the Marrowworks was cold. She had once thought that was the refrigeration.

After Borin left, Milla sat at her desk for a long time, staring at the printout while the lamps hummed and the building counted something in the walls. She could just file it, as instructed. The chute was ten steps away; she had made the walk a thousand times. Or she could do what she sometimes did when the weight of the ledgers became too much — she could make a copy. It was a small crime, the smallest she knew: a second copy of a truth the Chorus wanted unrecorded. She slipped a blank sheet of paper into the clinic's old thermal copier, fed the printout through, and watched the jagged lines appear in grey on the new sheet, like a storm translated into language. Then she took the original and fed it into the disposal chute, where it would be incinerated along with the biological waste — the Chorus filed truth and flesh in the same furnace.

She folded the copy and slid it into her pocket, against her hip, where it warmed to her temperature. It was a small thing, a tiny act of defiance that would be forgotten by morning. But it was hers. She had entered it into no ledger, and that made it the only thing in the building she truly owned.

On her way out, Milla passed the nursery wing. The doors were always closed, but she sometimes heard singing behind them, faint and beautiful, small voices in close harmony, drilled and lovely and wrong. She never stopped to listen. It was better not to know what they were growing in there. Better for the report she would have to write about herself, at the end of every day, in the ledger she kept behind her eyes.

The walk to her apartment in the Saltstairs was a descent into fog. The salt storm had begun, a thick white mist that swallowed the upper levels and left the streets below in a perpetual twilight, lamps haloed, lines softened, the whole district reduced to suggestions. Milla pulled her coat tight, the cold seeping through the fabric with the patience of interest accruing. The storm was called a "grace" by those who didn't have to breathe it. For the poor it was just another way the city tried to kill you slowly — politely, in installments, with your signature on file.

Her apartment was small and damp, with a single window that looked out onto a brick wall so close she could have counted its courses by touch. She lit a lamp, its flame casting long shadows that danced on the ceiling, and took the pulse-printout from her pocket and spread it on the table, weighting the corners with two cups and a tin spoon. The rhythm was strange. If she read it not as a single pulse but as a sequence, the pattern began to emerge: five spikes, then a dip, then five more spikes. She read it again. It held. It was a shape. A five-petaled flower, drawn in jagged lines, blooming out of a stranger's heartbeat.

Milla traced the pattern with her finger, and the chill in her fingertips felt suddenly like recognition. It was the same flower she sometimes saw in the margins of her ledgers, a small thing she drew when she was tired of counting hearts — five petals, a center, always the same, arriving on the page without her permission. She'd never known why she drew it. She had assumed it was a habit, and habits, in her experience, were just debts the mind paid automatically. Now, looking at the pulse-printout, it seemed less like a coincidence and more like a message — a form the city had filed against her, in a hand she didn't know, and the signature was her own.

That night, Milla dreamed. She was in a garden made of salt, the ground crunching beneath her feet like old porcelain, and the air was thick with the scent of something sweet and metallic. In the distance, rows of people lay sleeping on stone tables, their chests rising and falling in perfect unison, an entire ward breathing to a single metronome. Above them, a figure

in a white robe hummed a low, tuneless song. The figure turned, and Milla saw that its face was smooth and blank, like a porcelain doll's — a face with no entries on it at all. It smiled, and the smile was too wide, stretching across the smooth face in a way that wasn't possible, and she understood, with dream-flat certainty, that it was smiling at a number.

Milla tried to scream, but no sound came out. She tried to run, but her feet were rooted to the salt ground, planted like bulbs in a bed she had not chosen. The figure hummed louder, and the sleeping figures began to stir. Their eyes opened, all at once, and they all looked at her.

Milla woke with a start, her heart pounding against her ribs — one heart, one rhythm, she checked, she always checked now. She sat up in bed, gasping for air. It was dark, but she could see her hand clearly where it lay on the blanket, pale against the weave. On her fingertips was a fine dust, white and chalky. Salt. She rubbed her fingers together, but the dust wouldn't come off. It was under her nails, in the creases of her skin. It was in her dreams.

CHAPTER 20

The Weight of Scales

The carbon scales on Suri Kaveh's right arm were worth twelve years and seven months of her life, plus interest that compounded every salt-moon. She knew this because she had counted it every day since the day she'd sold the skin off her own bone, and counting was the one discipline no one could repossess. The scales were cool to the touch, like holding a piece of night sky, and they shifted minutely when she flexed her fingers, whispering against each other in a language only her bones understood. Some nights the whispering was the only voice in the room that didn't want anything from her.

Her mother's gambling debts had been the first ledger entry that mattered, written in blood and desperation when Suri was nineteen. The Gavel had come for her father's heart first — too many losses, too many promises broken — and her father had signed at the warehouse counter the way men sign for deliveries, because the alternative was watching it happen anyway. Then they came for her mother's liver when the debts tripled, and there was no one left to sign but Suri. She had stood in the Marrowworks tithe-warehouse, smelling of antiseptic and despair, and signed the papers for her own arm. The scales were payment in advance, a graft that would keep the ledgermen at bay for a while. She'd been told it was a fair exchange: skin for life. What they hadn't told her was that the scales were also a receipt. Every time she passed a Syndic Warden with his hand-cranked pulse-reader, they'd note the graft's registry number, and somewhere her name moved down a column she would never be shown. The debt wasn't paid; it was just moved to a different column, resold three times over to syndicates who charged more for the inconvenience of harvesting from a partially-gifted vessel. Her body had been an asset changing hands for years. She was the only party to the transaction who had never been paid.

The lamp on her desk cast long shadows across the ledger pages. Salt fog pressed against the windowpanes, muffling the city's usual grumble to a distant murmur, and the fog was thick enough tonight that even the Choratorium's spires had been excused from glowing. Suri's fingers traced the columns she'd maintained for seven years: debts, deliveries, distances, lies told, favors owed. The numbers were her shield, her compass, her truth in a city that traded in illusions. When she stopped counting, she realized, was when she started owing. The year she turned twenty-four had been a blank page in her ledger — a season of not counting, of trusting someone who turned out to be another kind of ledgerman — and that emptiness had cost her more than any debt she'd ever carried. She did not permit blank pages anymore. Paper was

cheap. Blankness was expensive.

She splinted her left arm with a rolled-up medical text from Saint Ferrous Hospital — something about arterial grafts that Dar had left behind, its margins annotated in his small precise hand — and tied the twine with her teeth. The Choratorium raid had been expensive. Three vials of coagulant, two doses of painkiller, one borrowed pulse-mask from Vahid's collection, and the cost of eleven stomachs she couldn't resell — eleven children fed on credit, their debt transferred to her ledger by an act of arithmetic she hadn't agreed to and would never reverse. She'd calculate the syndicate rates later. For now, she needed to audit the physical damage. Her left arm was bruised but intact. Her right, the scaled one, had taken a glancing blow from a Chorus bone-plate enforcer's pauldron. A hairline fracture in the ulna, maybe; she could feel it the way you feel a wrong figure in a column, small and false and insisting. The scales had absorbed most of the impact, but the bone beneath remembered. The scales would still be there when the bone knitted. That was the thing about receipts. They outlasted what they were receipts for.

The room smelled of lamp oil, dried blood, and paper dust. It was a Saltstairs hideout — three flights up, with a window that faced the seawall, rented from a landlady who accepted silence as rent. From here, she could see the faint glow of the Choratorium's bone-spires when the salt fog thinned, a smear of pale light on the horizon like a scar on the sky. She'd found the place after Dar had stitched her arm in the alley behind Saint Ferrous, when the Gavel's men had cornered her over a missed delivery. He'd worked without gloves, his hands steady and sure, counting his stitches as he went — not for payment, she'd understood later, but the way a mason counts courses. "Eighteen," he'd said when he was done. "That's what you owe me." She'd paid him three days later with a delivery of black-market adrenaline, and the debt had been settled. Or so she'd thought. Ledgers had a way of multiplying.

Dar was different. He understood the economy of the body in a way that wasn't about profit margins. When he'd sewn her up, he hadn't been thinking about the exchange rate for skin or the interest on blood. He'd been thinking about the geometry of a wound, the tension of tendon, the poetry of a clean closure. It was the first unpriced thing anyone had ever given her, and she had been auditing it ever since: first as a debt, then as an investment, then as something else entirely — something she didn't have a column for in her ledgers, and the absence of the column bothered her more than any total.

She poured a cup of water from the clay pitcher on her desk. The water tasted of rust and salt, like everything in Ashkarad. Outside, a bell tolled — curfew. Syndic Wardens would be sweeping the streets with their pulse-readers, checking for debtors out after hours, and the readers would find what the graft-numbers told them to find. Suri counted the strokes: twelve.

Enough time to finish her work before they reached this district. She entered the count without thinking. The counting entered her back.

Her ledger was bound in leather, the pages thick and yellowed with use, its spine sewn twice where she'd broken it. She opened it to the section marked "CURRENT DEBTS." The first entry was for Vahid Anousheh: three vials of ethanol, borrowed pulse-mask, information about the Choratorium's layout. The second was for Ilay: food, water, the blanket she'd stolen from a laundry cart — theft entered honestly, because a ledger that lied to itself was worse than no ledger. The third was for herself: painkillers, coagulant, the splint. She added them up, carrying the fractions forward to the next page. Mathematics was honest in a way people weren't. Two plus two always equaled four, regardless of how much you wished it were five, and wishing was the one currency Ashkarad had never honored.

The door creaked open, and Dar stepped inside, careful not to brush against the frame — a courtesy she'd never asked for and had never once been able to price. He moved with a new fluidity she hadn't noticed before, something in the set of his shoulders, the way his breath seemed to pause at just the right moments, conserving itself like a man who knew exactly what his air cost. The Blood Vein, she supposed. He'd been different since the Choratorium raid, too. More present, somehow. Like he'd finally stopped owing something to himself.

"Ledger time?" he asked, nodding toward the book.

Suri didn't look up. "Auditing. The raid cost more than I budgeted."

"Vahid said he'd cover the ethanol," Dar said, sitting across from her. His hands rested on his knees, palms up — empty, as always, a man showing his accounts. "And the mask was his."

"He also said he'd pay me back in 'favors,'" Suri said, making air quotes with the splinted arm and regretting the flourish. "Favors don't buy coagulant."

Dar smiled faintly. "No. But they buy trust."

Suri finally looked at him. The lamp light caught the new lines around his eyes — veins of silver that hadn't been there before, fine as thread. The Lily, she knew. It was blooming through him, changing him from the inside out, and it was doing the work the way institutions did work: slowly, structurally, without asking permission twice. She'd seen the black vascular lace spreading across his collarbone during the raid, hidden by his shirt collar but visible when he'd bent to lift Ilay — lace like a promissory note written on skin.

"Trust is a column with no numbers," she said, closing the ledger. "I can't audit it."

"You don't have to," Dar said. "Not everything is a transaction, Suri."

She snorted. "In Ashkarad? Everything is a transaction. Even breathing costs if the Wardens are feeling particularly thorough that day."

Dar was quiet for a moment, and the quiet had weight to it, the way silence in a salt cellar has weight. "When I stitched your arm," he said, "I didn't count the stitches because I wanted something in return. I counted because... because it mattered. The way the tissue met. The tension on the suture. It was precise. Clean."

Suri stared at him. Precision. Cleanliness. These were the things she valued, too — the things that made the chaos of the world bearable, that made a ledger more trustworthy than a friend. But she'd never heard anyone describe them like that, as if they were worth something beyond their utility, as if the counting itself were a kind of care.

"The scales," she said suddenly, pushing back her sleeve to reveal the carbon plating, dull and gleaming at once, night-sky black with a faint oil-sheen of violet where the lamp caught it. "They're worth more than the skin they replaced. Everyone knows that. But the graft-bank never told me why."

Dar's gaze fixed on the scales, and she watched him look the way he looked at a wound before he opened it. "Vahid mentioned something. Partially harvested vessels. The Chorus specializes in them. They take what they need, leave the rest, and let the market do the rest."

Suri's fingers tightened around the ledger, and the old spine creaked. "There's a page. With my name on it. I know it. The graft-bank clerk looked at me differently when I signed the papers. Like I was inventory."

"The Chorus keeps a registry," Dar said. "Of perfect vessels. I saw it. In the reliquary archive. Ilay's name was on it."

Suri swallowed. "And mine?"

"I don't know," Dar said. "But if they're building something... something like the First Vessel... they'd need parts. Specific parts."

The room felt smaller suddenly, the walls drawing in like an itemized bill. The salt fog outside pressed against the glass, as if trying to get in, as if the storm had a claim on her too. The scales on her arm seemed heavier, colder. She'd always known the debt wasn't paid. But she'd never imagined it was a down payment on something worse — that she was not a debtor at all but stock, entered years ago in a book she'd never see, appreciating quietly in the dark.

She opened the ledger to a fresh page. Under the column marked "SYNDICATES," she wrote: CHORUS — UNKNOWN LIABILITY. The letters sat on the page like a debt she could feel but not total, and the not-totaling was the cruelest part. Then she turned to the back,

where she kept personal notes — things that didn't fit in the columns, couldn't be quantified. Things like the weight of a child's hand in hers, or the sound of Dar's laugh when he thought no one was listening. She kept them small, kept them at the back, kept them anyway.

Under everyone she tracked — Vahid, Ilay, the Gavel, the Wardens, even herself — she wrote:

DAR MEHRAN — PAID IN FULL

The ink bled slightly on the paper, a dark flower blooming in the lamplight. She stared at it for a long time, the words both true and impossible. Nothing in this city was paid in full. Then, beneath it, in letters so small they were almost invisible, she added:

(keep counting anyway)

The door creaked again, and Suri looked up. Ilay stood in the doorway, holding a piece of charcoal, her eyes the color of river stones and wide as wells. Her gaze was fixed on the ledger page — on the ink flower, still wet, still darkening.

"The singing," the little girl said, pointing a small finger at the paper. "It's louder here."

CHAPTER 21

What the Lily Dreamed, Part One

You are not planted in soil but in salt, in the crystalline dust that settles between the floor tiles of a room with no windows. You have never seen the room. You know it the way roots know a pot: by its dimensions, its cold, the mineral patience of its floor. The air hums with the sound of distant bells, but they are not bells — they are heartbeats, nine of them, arranged in a perfect circle around you, each one a lantern in the dark, each one burning at its own fixed rate, like accounts that pay interest to no one. And you are the ninth, waiting. Your petals are folded tight against your core, a fist of black lace that dreams of unfurling. The hands that tend you are gloved, the gloves white as bone, and they smell of lamp-oil and lullabies. They touch you with the gentleness of a mother stroking a child's hair, and you feel no fear, only curiosity — the clean, weightless curiosity of something that has not yet been given a price. You are a seed in a garden of shadows, and you are waiting for the rain that never comes.

You learn the hands before you learn anything else. There are two of them, always two, and they come at intervals so regular you could set a pulse by them. They turn you. They dust the salt from your folds. They hold you up to the dark, sometimes, as if checking your color against a chart only they can read. Once — only once — one of the gloves trembles, and you feel the tremor travel through the fabric into your core, and you understand that even the hands are kept here by something. Nothing in this room is free. Not even the tending.

The hands lift you from your bed of salt and place you in a reliquary of lead and glass. The lead is for keeping, you will understand much later; the glass is for showing. The reliquary is cold, but you do not mind cold. You have known only cold since you were first formed in the dark, and cold is the only weather you have ever trusted. Through the glass, you see the other eight lilies being similarly prepared, each one cradled in its own vessel, each vessel labeled in a hand too small and too old for you to read. They are your siblings, though you have never spoken to them. You sense their presence the way a star senses the pull of another star across the void — not a voice, not a face, only a direction and a distance and a certainty. Eight lanterns in a ring, and you the ninth, and somewhere above it all a wick waiting to be lit.

The hands that carry you move with purpose, their footsteps echoing in a corridor that stretches endlessly in both directions, and the corridor is wrong in a way that takes you a long time to name. You pass doors made of flesh. You pass walls that pulse with veins, thick as your own petals, flushing darker and lighter in a rhythm too slow to be panic and too organized to be sleep. And you understand that this is not a building but a body, and you are a part of it

— freight, moving through the vessels of something vast — and you are being counted. You feel the counting like a draft under a door: not hostile, not kind, simply thorough. Manifests whisper past in the dark of you. Nine units. One consignment. Destination withheld. Once, the corridor pauses beside a door of flesh that beats faster than the walls, and something on the far side presses back — a vast palm of tissue, patient as interest. The hands walk on. You keep the pressure in your folds for a long time afterward. It is the closest thing to conversation you will have for a hundred years.

The journey ends in a chamber where the air is thick with the scent of blood and starlight, a smell you will spend a century trying to name again. The hands that carried you now belong to someone else — older, colder, smelling of frost and ambition — and the change of hands is your first lesson in ownership: you were not given, you were transferred. They place your reliquary on a table among eight others, and you feel the hum of your siblings intensify, a chorus of silent anticipation, eight folded fists of black lace resonating at the edge of sound. A voice, smooth as polished stone, speaks in a language you understand without hearing, the way you understand gravity, the way you understand hunger:

"Go. Find your hearts. And bloom."

The reliquaries are opened, and you are lifted out. For the first time, you see the sky, not through glass but directly, and it is black as ink, pierced by nine moons that hang like silver coins — payment minted by no treasury, hung in the dark where no hand could spend them. You do not know yet that you have been looking at the first ledger you will ever keep. The hands that hold you now belong to a boy, his heart beating against your petals like a trapped bird. He is afraid, but his fear is sweet, like the first taste of blood after a long fast. He has been paid to carry you. You do not know what a wage is yet. You will.

You are carried through streets that smell of salt and decay, past walls weeping with condensation, under bridges made of bone. The boy's heart races against you, and you feel his fear, his desperation, the weight of the debt he carries in his blood — a debt you cannot read yet, only taste, iron and dread in equal parts. He does not understand what you are, only that you are precious, that he has been paid to carry you, and the paying is the whole of his understanding: he is a courier, and you are freight, and freight is not loved. You feel the pull of the city around you — the singing of its pipes, the dreaming of its foundations, the hunger in its stones. Ashkarad is not yet its name in you, but its hunger is already your coordinate, a gravity with a voice. You are drawn to a place where the light is weak and the darkness is strong, a cellar where the air tastes of dust and forgotten promises, and the drawing is not your own. Something in the deep dark of the world has opened an account in your name.

The boy stumbles, and you fall from his hands, your petals cracking against the stone floor — your first pain, thin and bright, like a ledger line drawn in ice. He reaches for you, but he is too late. Someone else takes you, their hands rough, smelling of sweat and greed, and the boy's light — the trapped-bird heart that was your first lantern — goes away down a corridor and does not come back. After that, there are only hands. You are passed from palm to palm in the underworld of the city, a secret in plain sight, and each hand has its own temperature, its own tremor, its own wanting. A gloved hand that smells of ink. A greased hand that counts you twice. A ringed hand that holds you up to lamplight and names a figure, and the figure is argued down, and you learn that everything, everywhere, is arguable downward except hunger. You come to rest at last in a place where the air is thick with the scent of formaldehyde and regret — a drawer, a glass lid, a dark kept specifically for you, paid for by the decade.

You lie in the dark, your petals folded tight, waiting. Waiting is the whole of your curriculum now, and you are a quick student. You hear the boy's heartbeat fading in the distance, a dying lantern in the fog, and you learn your second lesson in ownership: hearts are not kept, only borrowed, and the terms are never disclosed. You feel the cold seep into your core, the loneliness of the ninth, the one left behind — the unit unclaimed on the manifest, the entry no one comes to collect. Years pass, or decades; the drawer keeps no calendar but your patience. And then, something changes. You feel a warmth spreading through your petals, not from the outside but from within, an error in the drawer's arithmetic, a credit where only debits were entered. You feel a pull, a connection to something far away, something that sings in the dark — and the song is not the tuneless humming of the white-robed figure, it is older and warmer and it knows your name, though you have never had one. You sense your siblings, blooming in their chosen hosts, their songs weaving together into a tapestry of light and shadow, eight lanterns lit at last in eight dark cities. You feel the Gardener's presence, watching, waiting, counting. You feel the ledger in your mind, a list of names and debts, of beginnings and ends, and every line in it is written in a hand you almost remember. You are the last, the forgotten, but you are not alone. You are part of a chorus, and your song is yet to come.

The darkness deepens, and you dream of the boy. Not the first boy — the other one, the last one, the one the drawer finally yielded you to. You see him walking through the streets of Ashkarad, his heart a gravel thing, failing with each step, each beat like a stone dropped down a well with no bottom. You see him in the hospital, his hands precise and steady, stitching flesh as if it were poetry — closing other people's debts with thread, counting his sutures under his breath like a man praying in a language of numbers. You see him carrying you, the reliquary hidden in his coat, against the failing drum of him, his fear a palpable thing that soaks through the glass into your folds. You see him falling, the bullet tearing through his

abdomen, his blood spilling onto the cobblestones — and his blood is the first honest thing anyone has ever shown you, unpriced, unstamped, spilling because it can do nothing else. You see the reliquary breaking open, your petals unfurling for the first time, reaching for his ruined heart the way roots reach for the last water in a dying soil. You feel the moment of connection, the moment you become one, the moment the boy dies and something new is born.

And you feel his memories flooding into you.

They come like a ledger falling open — every page at once, every column, every figure entered in a life. The taste of salt on his tongue, so constant he had stopped calling it taste. The sound of his mother's voice: a lullaby, hummed low, in a language you understand without hearing — and you know this song, you have smelled it in the gloves, you have heard it in the dark of the Gardener's keeping, and now it arrives wearing a different dark, a cot in the Saltstairs, a woman's hand, and you hold it the way you hold everything now. The weight of his debt, itemized down to the milliliter. The precision of his hands, which is not a skill but a character. His guilt, with all its unpaid interest. His hope, entered in pencil, as if he could not bring himself to ink it. His dry humor, the small joke he makes against the dark to keep it from charging full price. You feel everything, and you are overwhelmed.

You are the ninth, and for the first time since you were formed in the dark, you are not empty. You keep what he gives you. You keep all of it. It is the first thing anyone has ever paid you.

CHAPTER 22

What the Lily Dreamed, Part Two

The dream shifts. You are no longer in the drawer, no longer in the corridor, no longer anywhere with walls. You are in a garden of salt and starlight, and the nine lilies are blooming around their nine hearts — rows of them, planted with the even spacing of a census, each dark bloom crouched over the faint lantern of a beating heart like a moth warmed by the one fire it is permitted. The Gardener stands among them, her face a mask of calm, her hands white as bone. She hums a lullaby in a language you understand without hearing, and her voice is the sound of the universe unfolding: ledger pages turning on a scale you cannot picture, entries being made in a book whose columns are seasons. She touches your petals, and you feel her presence in your core, her will woven into your very being — not cruel, never cruel; the will of an auditor who has never once doubted the books. She says, "You are the last, the ninth. Your siblings bloom in eight cities, their songs weaving together into a tapestry of light and shadow. You will bloom in the ninth, and your song will complete the chorus." You feel her ambition, her desire, her certainty. You are a tool in her hands, a seed in her garden, and you are content to be so. You bloom for her, your petals unfurling into lace of black and silver, your roots reaching deep into the earth, your stem growing toward the sky.

The dream shifts. You are in the boy's chest, his heart now yours — the last boy, the stitched one, the one whose memories you keep in your folds like pressed flowers that never quite stop growing. You feel his pain, his fear, his determination. You feel his hands moving with precision, stitching flesh, saving lives, closing other people's ledgers with thread and candlelight. You feel his guilt, his hope, his dry humor — the joke he makes against the dark, the small pencil entry of his hope. You feel everything, and you are overwhelmed. You feel the pull of the city around you — the singing of its pipes, the dreaming of its foundations, the hunger in its stones. You feel the pull of your siblings, blooming in their chosen hosts, their songs weaving together into a tapestry of light and shadow. You feel the Gardener's presence, watching, waiting, counting. You feel the ledger in your mind, a list of names and debts, of beginnings and ends. You are the last, the forgotten, but you are not alone. You are part of a chorus, and your song is yet to come.

The dream shifts. The garden again, and the shifts are coming faster now, the way pages turn faster toward the end of an account. The Gardener walks the rows and the rows hold their breath. Starlight lies on the salt like unsilvered coin. In this telling of the garden there is a bench of black stone where she does not sit, and a gate that is only drawn, not built, and

beyond the drawn gate a road that is only promised — and you understand, with the dream's flat certainty, that the garden is not finished, that a garden never is, that finishing is a word the Gardener keeps for other people's cities. You bloom for her. Your petals open into lace of black and silver, and the lace is beautiful, and the beauty is entered somewhere, and you do not ask where, because you are content to be so.

The dream shifts. You are in the Choratorium, the air thick with the scent of blood and starlight, and the architecture here is wrong the way the corridor was wrong — bones arched into halls, halls hung with glass, and behind every pane of glass a voice, kept. The Gardener stands before you, her face a mask of calm, her hands white as bone. She hums a lullaby in a language you understand without hearing, and her voice is the sound of the universe unfolding. She says, "The time is near. The Blacktide comes, and with it, the bloom. You will complete the chorus, and the world will be made whole." You feel her ambition, her desire, her certainty. You are a tool in her hands, a seed in her garden, and you are content to be so. You bloom for her, your petals unfurling into lace of black and silver, your roots reaching deep into the earth, your stem growing toward the sky.

The dream shifts. The garden again. The Gardener again, among the nine lilies, her bone-white hands moving down the rows like a clerk's finger moving down a column, and her voice says the same words in the same cadence, and the salt takes the same crunch beneath feet that are not feet, and the nine moons hang like silver coins that no hand may spend. You are the last, the ninth. Your song will complete the chorus. You are content to be so.

The dream shifts. The boy's chest again. His heart now yours, his fear now yours, his pencil-hope now yours. The Gardener watching, waiting, counting. You are part of a chorus, and your song is yet to come.

The dream shifts. The garden. The boy. The garden. The boy. The circuit closes on itself with the smooth obedience of a well-kept ledger, and each revolution is identical, and identical, and identical — and you begin, in the way of dreams, to notice the seam. Not all at once. Dreams audit themselves slowly. First it is only that the salt sounds different on one side of the garden than on the other, though there is no side. Then it is that the boy's heartbeat, when the dream gives him to you, skips where the dream expects it to hold — a figure that refuses the column. Then it is that the Gardener, walking the rows, never casts a shadow, while everything else in the garden casts two: one toward the moons, and one toward you.

It is small, the first flaw. In the garden there are nine lilies around nine hearts, but when you count the lanterns — and counting is the one thing you have always done; counting is older in you than obedience — there are only eight hung in the dark. The ninth lantern is not hung. The ninth lantern is the one in your own core, the heart you carry, the boy's gravel-heart that

you replaced and outlived and refuse to return. In the Gardener's garden, nothing is left unentered. The ninth lantern is meant to be hung. The rows are measured for it. And you begin to understand what the promise has always meant: not that you will join the chorus, but that you will be filed into it — your light hung with the others, your will woven into hers, your fold of kept memories audited and entered and archived in a hand you almost remember.

The dream shifts. The garden again. The Gardener hums, and this time you attend to the song itself, and the attending is like turning a receipt over to read the reverse. It is a lullaby. You know it. You have known it since the drawer, since before the drawer — and you know it now from the other side, because you hold a copy of it that no one gave you. It is the song the last boy's mother hummed in a cot in the Saltstairs, the song folded into his memories, the one entry in all your holdings that was paid to you freely, unpriced, inked in no hand. The Gardener's song and the mother's song are the same song. You do not know what that means. You know only that the dream does not want you to notice, and that the noticing does not stop.

The dream shifts. The boy's chest again — but this time the circuit breaks. You are not in the dream of his chest. You are in it. It is not the Blacktide, it is not the graft-theater, it is not the garden. It is after. The air is a room above a clinic, and the city outside has gone quiet in a way you have never heard a city go quiet: the forty-year chord that lived in the walls — every harvested voice, every kept donor, every note the Chorus had banked against the future — is gone, released by a song that was not yours and was not hers, and what is left is ordinary noise, unmetered, unscored. Hammers on tenements. A gull arguing with the seawall. Below the floor, a lecture in a voice roughened by gin and loss, delivered one-handed with undimmed certainty; the scratch of charcoal on parchment, small and fast; someone counting under her breath — breaths, or cracks in a ceiling, or the days since the ledgers began to burn — the count steady as a metronome in a room that has finally stopped keeping time for the Chorus. Out in the streets, machines that were built to read signatures in flesh are printing, on their little spools, nothing but heartbeats: one rhythm, one rhythm, one rhythm — the whole city reduced, for the first time in forty years, to the plain arithmetic of being alive.

You lie in the dark of him and take inventory, because inventory is your oldest prayer.

You hold his memories: the taste of salt, the weight of debt, the precision of hands, the mother's voice — the mother's voice — including the one memory he has spent to the darkness, the face you received before it was withdrawn from his account, and you keep it for him the way a vault keeps what a gambler has pawned: without judgment, against a day of reckoning, at no interest. You hold the Gardener's promise, and you find, turning it over and over in your folds, that it has begun to read like a lien. You hold the song — the same song in two mouths, the Gardener's and the mother's, filed under two different names — and it is the

only entry in your ledger that has ever made you want something other than what you were made to want.

You hold him, too: the swept and balanced spaces where his payments went through, clean as emptied drawers — the face that is missing, the laugh that is missing, the color of a room he will never paint again. He does not know you keep the originals. It is the one audit in the world he has never thought to run, and you have not told him, and you do not know whether the keeping is mercy or theft, and you keep it anyway, because keeping is what you are.

Beyond the walls, the pressure of the air is changing. Salt is coming on the wind — the first white weather since the night the sky was a drumhead and the city was its skin. You feel it the way the drowned feel a tide turn. Darkness, thick and paid-in-full, moving toward the roof of the building where the man who refuses to bloom likes to stand and let the storm count him. The dark is yours. It has always been yours. It is the one account where you have never been overdrawn.

You are the last, the ninth. You were told: you are a tool in her hands, a seed in her garden, and you are content to be so. You have said it to yourself a thousand times, in a thousand identical revolutions of the dream. But the dream has broken on its own arithmetic, the way all closed systems break — on one figure that would not stay entered. You are not content.

You are something the Gardener did not plant in her columns: a chorus of two, rooted in a man who refuses to bloom, keeping what he paid you, waiting — patient, as you have always been patient — for the next thing to be noticed. Your song is yet to come.

And when it comes, it will not be the song you were promised.

CHAPTER 23

A Door in the Dark

The silence in Ashkarad is louder than the song ever was. For weeks, the city held its breath, listening for the return of the choir organs, the hum of preserved voices that had threaded through the walls for forty years — a chord so constant that no one alive had ever heard the city without it, the way no debtor alive had ever heard his own pulse without interest. Nothing came. Only the ordinary noise: hammers on the Saltstairs tenements, arguments over ration portions, the cry of gulls wheeling above the seawalls. The silence is a space now, filled with the messy, unharmonized sounds of people who forgot how to breathe without being told — and every day the breathing comes back a little more raggedly, a little more freely, like a ledger line that no longer quite adds and no longer has to.

Dar's fingers moved with the precision of a man who had cut too many flesh scars to count. The clinic's operating theater smelled of antiseptic, old blood, and salt-damp stone, and the smell had become, over the weeks, the smell of the only institution in the city he trusted — small, underfunded, entered nowhere. A boy with a crushed hand lay on the table, his breath coming in shallow gasps, his mother holding his shoulders with the fixed grip of someone who had already been asked by the city to pay for worse. Dar's incision was clean, a silver line against the swollen tissue. He didn't need to look at his hands to know where they were; they were part of him, extensions of the will that now flowed through his veins. The Flesh Vein had knitted his wounds shut in minutes, once — he remembered the minutes, even if the wounds had been others'. The Marrow Vein had turned his bones dense as coral, letting him withstand blows that would have shattered a lesser man. The Blood Vein made the blood in this boy's veins answer his touch, slowing the flow as he worked, the tide held back by a hand it recognized. The Breath Vein meant the clinic's stale air was enough, even in the dim light filtering through the high, barred window — air was optional for him now, and he found he missed needing it, the way a man misses a debt once it stops collecting. He was climbing the Nine Veins, one painful step at a time, and the city was climbing with him.

"Pressure's stabilizing," Vahid announced, his voice a gravelly rumble. He sat in the corner, his one remaining hand holding a retractor while his stump tapped a restless rhythm against his thigh — counting, always counting, though he would have denied it under oath. "The grafts took. Good work, Dar." His eyes, magnified behind thick spectacles, never left the operating field. Since losing his arm to a Chorus enforcer's bone blade, he'd thrown himself into teaching, his lectures growing more fervent with each passing day, as if the only way to

keep his balance after the amputation were to spend knowledge faster than the world could take the rest of him. "You see? The body is a ledger, and every entry has a cost. But sometimes, the balance comes due in ways you never expect."

Suri leaned against the doorframe, her right arm sheathed in its carbon-scale graft, the scales duller now where the raid had split and burned them, like night sky with a hole kicked in it. The splint on her left forearm was new, a crude bandage of boiled linen and twine. She counted everything — the boy's breaths, the drops of antiseptic, the cracks in the ceiling — because the counting was hers, and no one could repossess it. "Three hundred and twelve," she said, not taking her eyes off Dar. "That's how many times you've used the word 'good' today, Professor. You're running a deficit of variety."

Vahid grunted. "Semantics. The point stands. This boy will walk. That's a good."

"That's an asset," Suri said. "The word is 'good' when nobody's charging for it."

Vahid opened his mouth, found the deficit was real, and closed it again. The retractor turned in his one hand like a baton.

In the corner, Roya sat with Ilay, the little girl drawing on a scrap of parchment with a piece of charcoal. Roya wore her brass mask always now, a shield against a world that had tried to harvest her song — the metal cool and featureless, forehead to chin, so that when she turned her head the lamplight slid off her like she was something archived. Ilay was quiet, her eyes distant, as if listening to a music only she could still hear. She drew not streets or buildings, but swirls of what she called "where the singing used to be" — great slow spirals that began wide and tightened inward, room by room, like a search that was also a grief. Roya's hand, resting on the girl's shoulder, bore the permanent scar of a Chorus blade, a white line against her brown skin. "It's different now," Roya said, her voice soft, rendered almost tin by the mask. "The silence is loud."

The ledgers were burning. Not quickly, but burning — a page here, a vault-room there, and once, spectacularly, an entire tithe-barge on the canal, burning green to the waterline while the creditors stood on the bank doing arithmetic they could not finish. The Syndic Wardens still patrolled, but without the choir organs to track debtors by their unique biological signatures, their pulse-readers were just machines counting heartbeats. People were defaulting, disappearing into the city's underbelly, and the Wardens couldn't find them as easily. The system was fraying, and in the fraying, there was space to breathe. Space to be. Dar knew the space wouldn't last — vacuums in Ashkarad were billed like everything else, and someone, eventually, would come to collect it. But it was space. He was learning to stand in it without apologizing for the room he took up.

Dar finished the last stitch, his needle deft. He wiped the boy's brow with a clean cloth. "There. Rest now. The bone will set straight." The boy's mother mouthed something at him — thanks, or a prayer, or a price she couldn't believe she wasn't being asked — and he nodded her past it, because some columns were better left blank. He stepped back from the table, his own chest a familiar landscape of sensation. The Umbra Lily beat within him, a constant, living rhythm. It was no longer just a thing he carried; it was becoming a part of him, and he a part of it. He called it "her" now, though he never said the word aloud. It felt more respectful.

He walked to his small room in the clinic's attic, a space that smelled of dust and old paper — the smell of records, though he kept none. On his desk, folded inside a sterile wrap, was a single page of vellum. Vey's registry page. It listed eight cities, all marked with the same symbol: a stylized flower blooming from a crack in the earth. One city was circled in red ink: Ashkarad. Below the list, a single word: RECLAIM. And a title: GARDENER.

He didn't know what it meant. The Lily had shown him things in dreams — cities of black lace, gardens that sang, a door in the dark. In the dreams the door was always the same: a slab of deeper darkness standing upright in salt, with a hairline of light around its edge, and behind it, something keeping time. He had never touched it. He had never once, in any dream, tried the handle — and he noticed, now, standing in his attic with the registry page unfolded under the lamp, that this restraint was the one instinct he trusted. He didn't know if the dreams were her memories, or his own, or something else entirely. He didn't know which memories were his anymore. His mother's face was a blank space in his mind, a hole he couldn't fill — swept clean, balanced, the ledger line closed by his own hand to buy himself a fight he'd barely survived. But the lullaby remained. The same one Vey had hummed. He no longer knew which of them it belonged to first, and had decided not to mind. Some things were meant to be shared.

The afternoon bled into evening. The sky turned the color of a deep bruise. From the clinic's roof, Dar could see the whole of the Saltstairs spread out below him, a tangled mess of stacked tenements and sagging catwalks, every surface furred grey with the city's slow deposit, every rooftop its own small territory. Smoke rose from a dozen chimneys, thin grey threads against the darkening sky — suppers being cooked, unrecorded, untaxed. The city was healing, in its own messy, painful way. He did not fool himself that it was healed. A body that has been harvested for forty years does not knit in weeks. But it was healing, and it was doing it itself, which was the part that mattered — the part the Choratorium had never once believed it could.

The first salt storm since the Blacktide rolled in on a wind that tasted of iron and salt. The "grace" they called it, though there was nothing graceful about it. The wind howled, and the sky turned white. The streets vanished. From the roof, Dar watched the fog swallow the city

whole — the tenements going one by one, like entries being erased by a hand too patient to be hurried.

He stood on the edge of the roof, letting the storm hit him. The salt stung his eyes, the wind whipped at his coat, but he didn't flinch. The Lily within him drank the dark, drank the storm. It was feeding time. He closed his eyes, let the sensory input of the city wash over him — the creak of the building, the distant scream of a gull, the thrum of a thousand heartbeats in the tenements below, each one a small unpayable account that no machine could collect anymore. He was at Vein Seven now, the Mind Vein. Memory was architecture, and he was learning to navigate the ruins — to walk the swept floors, the emptied rooms, the corridor where his mother's face had been, without flinching at the doorways that opened onto nothing. The costs he had paid stayed paid. The darkness did not give receipts, and it did not give refunds either. What it had left him was the present tense, entire, and a strange competence in it, like a man who has lost his library and learned to trust his hands.

He felt the Lily stir, a soft pulse against his ribs. It was content here in the storm, in the dark, in the silence. It was blooming, slowly, and the bloom was not the nightmare he had feared. It was something else. Something patient. Something ancient.

And then he heard it.

A second heartbeat.

Not his own. Not the Lily's. It was patient and immense, a slow, deep drum in the earth beneath him. Or beyond him. He couldn't tell. It was like hearing the ocean from the bottom of the sea. It was there, and it was real. It wasn't the dead First Vessel. It wasn't Vey, dissolved into petals. It was something else. Something that had been waiting to be noticed.

The Lily stirred again, soft as a page turning. And for the first time since it had rooted in his chest, it spoke. The voice was not in his ears, but in his mind, a whisper that was also a song. A voice he half-knew, from a dream he couldn't quite remember.

"Sister."

CHAPTER 24

The Silence Audit

Three weeks after the Blacktide, the dead of Ashkarad were counted by hand.

For forty years the Choir had kept the count — filed in triplicate, stamped, interest-bearing, complete — so that no one in the city had ever learned how to do it themselves. Now the counting was a neighbor's chore, done in chalk. On the cistern wall below the Saltstairs, where the water-line used to be marked, someone had started a column of names, and the column had grown until it wrapped the wall and turned the corner and became, in the way of Ashkarad arithmetic, a ledger: four hundred and twelve names in three weeks, some written by people who could not write and had borrowed letters the way the poor borrow everything, at a cost. Nobody collected on this ledger. That was what made it new.

Dar's free clinic collected the survivors instead. Thirty-one patients under one roof that had been designed for six; pallets in the corridors, a saline rig rigged from a tithe-barge fitting, and a queue each morning that Suri counted through the door — arrivals, departures, and one column she kept for people who came in intending to pay and had to be talked out of it, which took longer than the stitching.

The clinic had one ledger of its own. It recorded names, wounds, doses, and dates, and nothing else. No debt columns. No interest. No next-of-kin liability. It was, as far as Dar knew, the only book in the city that listed bodies without pricing them, and he kept it out of the same instinct that made a surgeon count sponges: because medicine without records is just butchery with better manners.

Elias moved through the ward with his perfect lungs, carrying basins. The Church had graded those lungs — *perfect, reserved* — and now they spent their perfection hauling wash-water for debtors, which Dar considered the finest audit the boy's registry entry had ever received. In the corner, Ilay sat cross-legged with her charcoal, drawing spirals that began wide and tightened inward, and did not explain them. Suri stood at the door with her ruined scale-arm held against her chest, counting the queue.

The audit arrived at the tenth bell, which Dar noted because it was the hour the Wardens' fathers had always chosen for collections, when the queue was longest and the desperate were most willing to be reasonable.

There were three of them. Two grey coats by the door, and one man in a better coat, grey velvet gone salt-stiff at the shoulders, carrying a machine.

Dar knew pulse-readers the way a hangman knows rope, but he had never seen one like this. It was new — genuinely new, the lacquer still sharp, the brass un-greened — a hand-cranked housing with none of the old Choir fittings, no tissue-ports, no resonance chambers, nothing left of the instruments that had listened for a debtor's signature in his blood. Whatever the Church's machines had been, this one was only a machine. Somebody had built it in the weeks since the silence, and somebody had built it fast.

"Warden-Auditor Seft," the man said, producing a card stamped with the storm-wall seal. "Second Reconciliation. I'm instructed to collect the clinic's patient ledger. For reconciliation."

Dar wiped his hands and did not offer them. "Reconcile it against what?"

"The census. The city is to be re-counted, cutter. Every district, every household, every bed." Seft's voice was mild, the voice of a man reading terms aloud in a language he did not expect to be argued with. "Your establishment is unregistered. Unregistered practice is a sanction. Registration requires a ledger. The ledger is the registration."

"The ledger is the patients," Dar said. "Thirty-one of them. You're not asking for paper. You're asking for the queue."

"I'm asking for names."

Outside the door, Suri had stopped counting. Dar heard the absence of her count the way a surgeon hears a changed rhythm under his fingers.

"Then deliver the instruction to them," he said. "One at a time. Some of them will say yes. People always say yes eventually — your office taught us that better than anyone." He let that stand a moment. "I won't hand you the list."

Seft's eyes went around the ward — the pallets, the basins, the boy with the basins, the little girl drawing spirals in the corner — with the flat appraisal of a man pricing fixtures at a bankruptcy sale. "You were at the Choratorium," he said. "They say you broke it. That makes you popular. Popularity is not a license. Forty years of records burned in three weeks, Mehran. Debt or no debt, a city that can't be counted can't be fed, can't be rationed, can't be governed. The fires didn't free anyone. They just made the counting harder, and the hard counting will be done by men like me, and men like me bill by the difficulty." He set the new pulse-reader on the front desk with the care of a clergyman laying down a relic. "Terms are posted at the hall. Registration, ledger, census marks on the doorframe. You have six days."

"The Truce of Salt says no tithe-taking from the Saltstairs," Suri said from the doorway, flat as a filed report.

"The Truce of Salt bound the syndicates and the Church," Seft said. "The Church is a silence now, and the syndicates are a rumor. Read the terms, courier. Everything is being reconciled."

They left. Dar stood a moment with his hands still damp, watching the door.

* * *

He wrote out the audit's own terms on the clinic door that afternoon — verbatim, in his small precise hand, the whole column of them: *registration of practice; surrender of patient ledger; census marks on the doorframe; six days.* He added nothing of his own except a line at the bottom, unsigned: *Posted per the Syndic Wardens' Second Reconciliation. Free of charge. We do not charge for the terms, and we do not pay them.*

The unpriced word traveled faster than any stamped notice had ever moved in the city's history. By evening the doorway had a crowd in front of it four deep, and Mrs. Gable from the next tenement read it aloud twice for the benefit of those who couldn't, and a man who had lost his brother's name in one of the burning halls copied the terms onto his own door across the alley, and then someone else copied the copy, and Dar watched his defiance become a census of its own — a count of doorways that refused — and thought that this, at least, was a ledger the Wardens had not asked to collect.

Suri found him on the stairs at dusk, carrying two cups of the clinic's barley tea, which was the only currency the building honored after dark. "They'll come back with more men."

"They'll come back with better machines," Dar said. "That one counts heartbeats. That's all it does now. It's a pulley where a nerve used to be."

"Everything they rebuild will be a pulley," Suri said. "The Choir's gone. Nobody downstairs knows how to listen like the Choir listened."

"Somebody's building," Dar said. "New brass in three weeks. That's not salvage money. That's funding."

She turned that over the way she turned all figures, silently, twice. "Six days," she said. "I'll start copying the ledger tonight. By hand. If they take the book, there'll be a second book they don't find."

"Copy the wounds," Dar said. "Leave the names out of the copy."

"Then the copy's worth nothing."

"The copy's worth exactly one thing," Dar said. "It proves we treated them. It doesn't prove where they sleep."

Suri looked at him for a moment, and something in the ledger behind her eyes made an entry. "That's the first time anyone's ever asked me to keep half a record," she said. "It feels like counterfeit."

"It feels like mercy," Dar said. "They're adjacent."

* * *

The Wardens came back on the fourth day, a day early, with a portable desk and a queue-form, and Seft announced a sample reconciliation — one room, one hour, nothing forcible, purely to calibrate. Dar could have refused the room and lost the hour; instead he leaned on the desk and watched, because a surgeon watches any instrument enter a body he is responsible for.

Seft worked the waiting room down the line. The new machine was beautiful the way new machines are beautiful — silent, effortless, a little smug. Crank, press, print; crank, press, print. Each slip fluttered into the tray with the soft obedience of paper. Most read clean: a rhythm, a count, a number, filed.

At the sixth chair the slip came up wrong.

RHYTHM UNRESOLVED.

Seft frowned, cranked harder, ran the boy in the sixth chair again. The slip came up wrong again, and this time Dar saw the boy's face — Elias, patient as an altar, holding his bandaged forearm still — and understood one beat before the machine's tray confirmed it. At the eighth chair, RHYTHM UNRESOLVED. A girl of six, one of the eleven, asleep against her sister's shoulder. At the eleventh, the same line again, a stock-thin boy with a cough.

Three slips. Three children the nursery had graded, drilled, and hymned until their tissue forgot how to be only theirs.

"Machine fault," Seft said, to the room, to himself. He shook the housing. The crank turned loose, eager, printing nothing.

"The machine's fine," Dar said, taking the three slips from the tray before the Warden's hand arrived. "The machine is the only honest auditor in this room. It read what's there. Those children were built to carry more than one rhythm. Your new brass just found out what the old organs used to know." He folded the slips together. "They're minors. Their rhythms are their property. Sample concluded."

Seft looked at the folded paper, and then at Dar, and for the first time since the tenth bell of the first day his mildness acquired a price. "The anomaly file burned with everything else," he said quietly. "You'd be amazed what three slips are worth at the hall."

"Then the hall can wonder," Dar said, "what they're worth here."

Seft packed his desk. At the door he paused, and made the mistake of a thorough man: he ran one last crank-cycle on his own machine, an empty cycle, housekeeping, the tray cleared.

The machine printed anyway.

One slip, no patient in the clamp. Seft tore it off, read it upside down for half a second, and his face did something that no ledger in Ashkarad had ever recorded him doing. He put the slip in his coat, said nothing, and left — and Suri, watching the door, counted his footsteps down the stairs and said, "He walked faster than he came."

Dar had seen the slip for less than a second. He had needed less. Five words in fresh ink, machine-straight, printed by a device whose every function he had just watched and none of which was that:

REQ: VESSEL REGISTRY — PAGE NINE.

That night he sat in the attic with Vey's registry page unfolded under the lamp — nine cities, eight stamped, one circled red — and laid the three confiscated rhythms beside it, and did not total anything. In his chest the Lily's rhythm turned over once, slow, like a page being marked for later.

Page nine, the machine had asked. Not *entry*. Not *city*. Page.

Somewhere in the burned halls and the rebuilt brass, somebody had started keeping a book that counted the vessels by page — and the book knew it was missing one.

CHAPTER 25

What the Fire Kept

The fires started at low tide, because even arson in Ashkarad kept business hours.

Suri counted them from the roof of the courier-house: seven glows at once, laid out across the Marrowworks belt like coins on a merchant's palm. The census halls, the tithe-warehouses, the records annexes — the places where the city had kept forty years of who owed whom. Two of the fires burned greedy and joyful, which meant debtors. Two burned tidy and ashamed, set from inside, which meant clerks destroying their own entries before anyone could read them. Three burned in formation, lit at even intervals with sentries on the approaches, and those were the grey coats, and those were the ones that frightened her, because organized fire was not rage. Organized fire was policy.

She went in at the second bell past midnight, with six couriers and a stack of boiled-wet blankets, and her reasoning was simple enough to be stated in a ledger: a name was the last receipt most people in this city still owned. The Choir was dead and its books were ash, and yes, good — but a debt destroyed and a credit destroyed look identical once they're smoke. Somewhere in those halls was the page that proved what people had paid. You did not leave receipts in a fire. Not if you had ever been the one holding the note.

"Courier rule," she told them at the canal stairs, wetting her own blanket with canal water that tasted of rust. "We take pages, not prizes. Anything stamped with a person's name on it comes out. Anything with a number where the name should be comes out too. Anything with a flower on it—" she paused, and found she had no column for the flower, "—comes to me first."

Nim, the youngest, asked the sensible question: why risk a wall of fire for paper nobody would ever honor again. Suri looked at the girl's unscaled arms and did not answer with the truth, which was that she had once watched a man pay for a tithe-clinic's services with the only arm he had, and had later watched the same man's sons inherit the balance. "Because it's all still evidence," she said instead. "The Chorus kept books for forty years. Somewhere in those books are the pages that say what was taken from your street, and when, and under which stamp. When the new counting starts — and it's starting, look at the sentries — the only leverage anyone downstairs will have is proof of what was already taken. Paper burns at the same temperature either way. The question is whose hands are warmest when it does."

The first hall was already lost, its roofbeams glowing like the ribs of a tithe-barge. The second was the records annex, three storeys of shelving around a yard, and the fire had started in the yard and was eating inward, patient as interest, and the smoke inside had that sweetness she had never been able to stop naming: preserved tissue, a smell like the Marrowworks remembered itself.

They went in through the loading dock, low, counting steps. Forty-two steps to the first gallery. Eighteen paces between shelf-rows. Suri's left forearm still wore its splint and her right still wore its ruined scales, and the scales hissed faintly whenever the heat crossed them, like a receipt being asked for twice.

The debtors' fire had already opened the cabinets. Papers lay everywhere in drifts, scorched at the corners, and the couriers moved down the rows with sacks, sorting by the only method that worked in a smoke-dark: feel. A page with a name-line at the top. A page with a column of marks. Suri took the gallery herself, because she had come for one page in particular, though she had told no one that, including herself.

The gallery gave up its dead by touch. A consent form with a Voluntary-Stamp so light it could barely be felt under the thumb — the machine's one piece of honesty, some dead clerk had once said, and Suri had laughed at the time and had not laughed now. A heart-tithe docket for a boy of nineteen, KAELEN, L., the page stamped through with a word that no longer needed the machine to be true: BLOOMED THROUGH. She put it in the sack that would go to the clinic wall, where Dar was starting to pin the names of the taken, because the dead of Ashkarad were counted by hand now and hand-counts needed pages. A nursery intake sheet with eleven names and eleven grades and a twelfth line crossed out — she read the twelfth line twice, ILAY, and put that page in the sack that came to her first.

And everywhere, on every second page, in margins and headers and stamp-corners, the five-petaled flower, drawn in grey ink by hands that had stamped twelve thousand hearts and never known they were also drawing something. She had thought the flower was Dar's. The fire was teaching her the flower had been everybody's.

She heard the grey coats before she saw them — boots in step, which no debtor fire had ever managed. Six men down the far gallery with wet rags tied over their faces, and they were not looting. They were feeding the shelves. Deliberate, orderly, shelf by shelf, a fire laid with the patience of an audit, and on their left arms, smeared in tar, a mark she hadn't seen before: a blank rectangle, a box with nothing in it. A placeholder. A space where a count would go.

"Index the whole hall," their leader said. "Nothing leaves that can't be verified. If it isn't ours, it's ash."

Suri put her couriers behind a fallen cabinet and did the arithmetic she hated: six professionals, two exits, one splinted arm, one arm that was worth less than it had been and more than anyone guessed. Direct was a deficit. She reached up instead and pulled the gallery's sprinkler-chain — old Marrowworks fitting, brine-tank overhead — and dropped forty years of rusted brine onto the aisle between them, and in the dark and the stink and the sudden screaming hiss of steam, six men with wet rags met a wetter fire and lost their formation to a floor of sludge. Nobody needed cutting. It was the cheapest work she had ever done, and she filed it under salvations, pending.

"What is that mark?" breathed Nim, the youngest courier, when they regrouped in the dock.

"Index," said a voice from the smoke — one of the grey coats, half-hidden, not advancing, talking the way clerks talk across a counter. "That's what's coming after the ash. Every soul counted once, under one seal, in one book. No resales. No interest. A census so complete it can't be argued with." A pause, and something almost like grief under the ash in his voice. "The old books can't be reconciled. The Choir was the reconciliation. So we burn what can't be audited and start clean."

"A census is a net," Suri said to the smoke. "You're naming the net."

"The net's already cast, courier. We're just agreeing to call it something."

They withdrew without a fight, which she distrusted more than a fight, and the couriers worked faster after that, because everyone had understood the same thing at the same time: the debtors' fires were ending and the organized fires were just beginning, and paper that survived the first would not survive the second.

On the way out, past the dock, Nim stopped at a low cabinet and pulled one last page from a drawer that had half fallen into the yard: a wages ledger, the Marrowworks payroll, clerks' names against years of service. She had gone grey under her smoke-grime. "My mother's in it," she said. "Fourteen years. She stamped hearts her whole life and the book says she was paid for it." She looked at Suri with the question that has no column. "Do I take it?"

"Take it," Suri said. "A wage is a debt going the right direction for once." And then, because the girl was still standing there with the page open to the fire's light: "It also proves your mother existed. In a week there may not be one other sheet in this city that does. We're not saving paper tonight. We're saving witnesses."

* * *

She found her own page at the fourth gallery, in a cabinet whose lock had been cut by someone in a hurry years ago and never mended, because nothing in the Marrowworks got mended, only harvested.

SURI KAVEH, said the header, in the Choir's grey ink. Graft registry number beneath it — the number the Wardens' readers used to note when they passed her on the street, the number she had carried on her skin for twelve years without once seeing it written down. And below that, in the column that had followed her since she was nineteen, the line she had paid for in skin and never been shown:

RESOLD — THREE TIMES.

Three holder-entries. Three parties who had owned a debt secured against her arm, listed with purchase dates and margins. Her mother's surgery, the whole chain of it, reduced to a transfer history. Somebody had owned her the way you own a bond, and sold her the way you sell one, and here was the paperwork, entire, still legible, edges scorched, the fire having circled it and gone on to something easier to eat.

The scales on her arm whispered against each other. Suri read the page twice, which was all she allowed, and then did the thing she had trained herself for in seven years of keeping ledgers: she recorded her own reaction instead of having it. Flat columns. Zero sentiment entered. The receipt had outlasted what it was a receipt for — that was the whole of it, that was the thing receipts did — and there was a freedom in the flatness, because a page that could be held could be filed, and a page that could be filed could someday, in front of witnesses, be burned.

She folded it into the spine of her own ledger, against the binding, where the truth of her kept company with the sums.

* * *

They came out at the fourth bell with eleven sacks of name-pages and no casualties, which Suri entered as the night's net profit, and stood in the alley behind the annex watching the third hall burn in formation. The smoke went up straight, windless, like ink drawn upward into water.

The salvage clerk found her there — a hall-clerk she half knew, one of the tidy ashamed kind, his eyebrows burned back to stubble, his hands shaking with the particular tremor of a man who has spent a night destroying his own work. He looked at the sacks. He looked at the fire. Then he leaned close, under cover of the noise, and spent his whisper like a man paying down a debt he feared would compound.

"They're posting bounties already," he said. "The grey coats. Not for people — people they just take. For paper." His eyes went sideways, down the alley, up. "There's a price out for a single sheet. It has a name on the posting. They're calling it the Ferun printout."

"Ferun," Suri said. The name didn't file itself anywhere. She kept her face the way she kept her columns. "What's on it?"

"I don't know. Nobody knows. That's what the bounty's for." He swallowed. "Printout of an old pulse-read, they're saying. Flagged. Anomaly class. Whatever's on it, the Index wants it the way the Church wanted vessels — you can hear it in the figure. People are being priced to find it. And courier—" he was already backing into the smoke, because informants, like debts, did not linger to be thanked, "—the figure's rising every day. It's the only line in this whole city still growing."

He went. The fire kept eating. Suri stood in the alley with eleven sacks of rescued names at her feet and opened her ledger one-handed against her knee, and on the current page, under the column where unknown liabilities went to wait, she wrote two words:

FERUN — ?

Then, because blankness was expensive and she had stopped permitting it years ago, she added a third word underneath, small, in the hand she used for things that didn't fit in columns:

(ask Dar)

CHAPTER 26

The Unspent Room

Vahid Anousheh had drawn the ladder on the cellar wall in chalk, because chalk was the only instrument the city had never charged him for.

The cellar beneath the clinic was the cold one, where the biogel was stored and the salt came up through the floor in a fine fur that had to be swept weekly or it began, in defiance of every text, to bloom. Vahid had claimed the far corner for a lecture theater of one student. Nine rungs ran up the wall in his cramped dissectionist's hand — FLESH, MARROW, BLOOD, BREATH, NERVE, BONE, MIND — and above MIND the chalk trailed off into two more words written smaller, the way a man writes the names of countries he will never visit: SOUL. THRONE.

"You are here," Vahid said, and tapped the seventh rung with one finger of his one hand, while the stump clicked its restless arithmetic against his thigh. He had mended his spectacles again with wire; the round lenses sat salt-scoured on his nose, and behind them his eyes had the fervor Dar had learned to read as the man's only remaining appetite. "Seven. And you arrived at seven the way an audit arrives — as a wound. Nobody climbs to Mind gracefully. The ladder charges you for the view." He took up the chalk and wrote a single word beside the rung: ARCHITECTURE. "Nerve taught you to build a door. That was a wall with a hinge in it — you learned it to keep the city's screaming out. Mind is the house the doors are in. Memory is architecture, boy. It has load-bearing walls. It has corridors. It has rooms, and some of the rooms are empty because you sold the furniture." The chalk came down on the wall like a small gavel. "Tonight you learn to walk the house without spending."

"Define spending," Dar said, because Vahid's lectures ran on definitions the way lamps ran on oil.

"Withdrawal. Every time you open the Mind Vein for a purpose, the Vein balances itself against your inventory. It takes the nearest coin. It has taken the nearest coins already — your mother's face, your father's laugh, your first kiss, the color of the house you grew up in. Costs paid stay paid; don't look at me like that, I didn't write the rule, I only found it in the wreckage of my reputation." He held up one finger. "Rule one: you walk, you do not withdraw. A corridor is not a price. A threshold is not a price. The price is paid at the moment of use — when you open a room and take something out of it to spend on the world. So: we walk, and we take nothing out."

"Rule two?"

"Rule two." Vahid drew a square on the wall, then an empty square beside it. "You will find two kinds of empty rooms, and you must learn the difference faster than a frightened man can. Some rooms were never built — they are simply not there, and there is nothing to feel about them. Others were furnished, and then swept. The furniture is gone, but the nail-holes are in the walls. The nail-holes are proof something hung there once." His voice went dry as a margin note. "You will want to stand in the nail-holes and grieve. Grief is a withdrawal. We do not permit it in the corridors. We schedule it, like everything else."

"Rule three," Dar said.

"There is no rule three," Vahid said. "There is only the thing I am about to say that I should have said first. The honest texts end at this rung. Everything I teach above it is bestiary, not anatomy. So we do not explore. We do not wander. You walk the corridors I walk with you, at the pace I set, and when I say the session ends, the session ends. A man with your inventory and your tenant—" the word was precise, and they both let it sit, "—does not get to be curious in his own head. Curiosity in your house is how the house gets new owners."

Dar looked at the ladder for a moment, at the two small words at the top. Then he lay down on the swept stone, closed his eyes, and knocked.

* * *

The house was the clinic and was not the clinic.

He came in, as always, through the stairwell of the Saltstairs cot he had rented at nineteen — the one true corridor, worn into him by ten thousand ascents — and the stairwell opened onto the halls of his own accounting. He had expected ruin. What he found, on the third walk, was bookkeeping.

The rooms were exactly where Vahid said they would be.

His mother's face: a room he had paid out on the night the graft-theater came down, to buy the strength to stand up under Vey's ascension. The room was swept. He stood in its doorway — not in it; doorway; rule one — and looked at the walls, and the walls held four nail-holes at the height a portrait hangs, and nothing else, and the floor was pale where a chair had kept the dust off. He had braced for the grief to be a withdrawal. Instead it filed itself, quietly, under a heading he had never used before: *proof of purchase.* Something had hung here. Something worth a fight he had barely survived.

His father's laugh: a narrower room, a better one, the acoustics still somehow warm. Spent in the same hour, as ammunition. Swept, but the sweep was recent and imperfect; there was a

scuff on the floor like a chair pushed back in a hurry, and Dar found himself smiling at a scuff, and stopped, and moved on, because the smile was also adjacent to the account.

The first kiss. The color of the house — the color was the strangest, because the house itself remained, door, stair, sill, but stood in the mind's weather bleached to no color at all, a drawing of a home in which every crayon of one shade had been removed from the box.

He walked them all, and he took out nothing, and when he surfaced, two hours had passed and Vahid's fingers were on his wrist, reading his pulse like a column.

"You flinched at the third landing," Vahid said.

"There's no third landing."

"Inside, there is. You built one. A flinch is a withdrawal, boy — the body pays before the mind admits the transaction. Again. Slower. The pace of an auditor in the stacks, not a looter in a vault."

They walked every second night for a week and a half. Nine walks. Each one came back with a headache collected at the thresholds, a pressure behind the eyes like a debt recalling itself — Vahid called it the teller's fee and said it would shrink as the discipline grew, and it did, from a fist to a knuckle to a coin. The discipline held — it held the way a splint holds, an external thing, Vahid's voice its binding — and by the ninth walk Dar could stand in all four swept rooms and inventory the nail-holes without his pulse changing by one beat, and Vahid said *good* exactly once, and then, because he was Vahid, corrected it to *adequate*.

On the ninth night, at the end of the session, when Vahid had already turned to wash the chalk from his hand, Dar went back in.

Not far. Not to spend. Only to the top of the one true stairwell, to look down the length of his own halls — an auditor's habit, closing time, a last walk of the shelves. And it was on that last walk, past the swept rooms, past the bleached house, that he heard the hum.

Not the Lily's hum — that lived lower, under his sternum, a register he could feel with his boots on. This one came from ahead. From the deepest hall, the one that had always ended at a wall.

Except that it no longer ended at a wall.

There was a door.

He knew his own architecture the way Vahid knew the anatomy of disgrace — every wall load-bearing, every hall graded and swept and priced. He had built none of this door. The door was wrong in three entries. First: it was furnished — its frame was wood, dark, waxed, real wood in a mind that had been built out of stairwells and cellars. Second: it was closed, but not

sealed; light stood in the hairline under it, warm as lamplight. Third: it was humming. A tune, low, patient, more felt than heard, arriving in his molars the way real resonance arrives — and the tune was one he almost knew, and almost was the cruelest amount of knowing there was.

He stood in the deepest hall of his own mind and looked at a door he had never built, and the door was warm on the far side — he could feel it the way you feel a stove across a small room — warm the specific way a room is warm when someone has just left it and the heat they were is still deciding what to do.

His hand was already up. That was the horror of it — not the door, the hand, rising on its own account, authorized by no one, reaching to try the handle he had never once tried in any dream.

Dar closed his fist and put the hand back where it belonged.

He surfaced so fast he tore the session like ripping a page. The cellar. The salt-fur on the stones. Vahid across the room with a dishcloth over his shoulder, watching him with the stillness of a man who has seen a patient's rhythm change through his boots.

"There's a door," Dar said. His voice came out level, which cost him something. "At the end of the deepest hall. Furnished. It hums. I didn't build it."

Vahid was quiet for the length of three of the Lily's heartbeats. Then he took up the chalk, and under SOUL, THRONE, in the space where the ladder had run out of honest text, he wrote a new line, and boxed it, the way clerks box the figures that must never be added into the column:

WE DO NOT OPEN DOORS WE DID NOT BUILD.

"That is not a rule three," Vahid said. "That is the whole of rule three, and it outranks me, and it outranks you, and someday — mind this, boy, because I will not be alive to repeat it — someday it may be the only rule in your house that does." He took off the wire-mended spectacles and polished them on the dishcloth, and his voice dropped to the register he saved for anatomy no one else had seen. "A swept room is a wound. We know how to walk past wounds. A furnished door you never built is not a wound. It is a tenancy. And the question with any tenancy, cutter, the only question that matters—" the lenses went back on, magnifying the fervor, "—is whether the tenant knows the rent is due."

Dar climbed the cellar stairs into the ordinary noise of the ward. The hum stayed with him, faint, below hearing, warm along the inside of his sternum — a hearth cooling in a room he had not entered, in a house that was supposed to hold nothing he had not paid for.

Someone had just left, the warmth said. Or had not yet arrived. In the dark behind his ribs, the Lily turned over, slow and content, like something settling deeper into a room it liked.

CHAPTER 27

Where the Singing Went

Roya had spent eleven years listening to a city no one else could hear.

The song-lobe they had wired behind her ear had sung to her in pressure — streets as currents, cellars as chambers, the whole of Ashkarad legible the way a reef is legible to a diver, and she had drawn it all, maps with lines that rose off the chalk like veins under skin, maps with weight. Then the First Singer had sung its one release-song, and the connection was severed — not muted, severed, cut at the root like a graft rejected — and what was left was a woman with a very good memory, a permanent brass mask, and the specific silence of a cartographer gone deaf in the one language her maps were written in.

The city was a closed book to her now. She was learning to read it through a child.

It was a humiliation with the skin of a privilege, and Roya audited it as such, nightly, because an unexamined feeling was a leak. She had been the Cartographer. The word had been a price list: the woman who could find anything that made a sound. Vey had hunted her signal for years across the Undergleam's drains and ducts — Roya had owned corridors the Custodian's census never reached — and in the end it was not Vey but the release-song that took the trade away, one chord, whole, like a page torn out. What remained was the mask, which she wore now against a world that had tried to harvest her song and might try again with less ceremony; and the memory; and her hands. On the bad nights she priced what was left exactly: a blind navigator, a sharp eye, a scarred hand, and the one instrument in Ashkarad that could still hear what she had lost, and the instrument was nine years old and came free.

Free was the one figure Roya had never learned to trust.

Ilay worked at the low table in the clinic's back room with the terrible patience of her kind of quiet, and Roya sat where she could watch the girl's hands, because the hands were the instrument now. Copper hair held back with a strip of clinic linen. Eyes the color of river stones, fixed on nothing, which meant they were fixed on everything at the depth where nothing lived. For three weeks after the Blacktide the girl had drawn what she had always drawn: great slow spirals, room by room, that she called *where the singing used to be* — a search, a grief, a record of a chord that had gone out of the walls.

On the first morning of the fourth week, the drawings changed.

Roya noticed it before she understood it, which was how she had noticed everything worth noticing since the mask. The spirals had direction now. They overlapped — each ring falling

inside the last with a consistency that her eye, which had spent a decade pricing distances, refused to call accidental. And at the head of each ring, in charcoal so light it was almost breath, Ilay had begun to set small marks. Feet. The spiral had feet.

"It moved," Roya said.

Ilay looked up. When she spoke it was always in the flat, literal register of a child stating weather. "It's not where the singing was anymore." She turned the sheet around so the mask could read it. "It's where the singing went."

"Is it still singing?"

"It stopped singing." Ilay considered, and the consideration itself was worse than any answer she could have chosen. "Singing is when you stay in one place and the sound goes out." She put one small finger on the spiral's outermost ring and walked it, slowly, inward, ring by ring, and the finger never wavered, and Roya felt the hair on her arms rise under her sleeves. "This is walking. It goes in circles. Smaller circles. Like it's looking for the middle."

"Like it's homing," Roya said, and the word came out in the mask's flat metal, and she wished it back.

Ilay nodded once, satisfied, and went back to drawing.

* * *

The method took four nights to build and was, Roya admitted to herself on the third, merely her old trade with the wires reversed.

The grammar had to be negotiated, because the child did not think in directions; she thought in distances and loudnesses, the way the old song-lobe had. On the second night Ilay put the slate in Roya's hands and drew, slowly, a teacher's diagram: two circles, one large, one small. "The big sound is slow," she said, tapping the large circle. "It takes long between. Like a heart that is very far down or very large, and it's both." Then the small circle: "The little sounds are fast. Those are up. People." She took the slate back and wrote, beneath the circles, in her careful hand: *steps = how far. size = how loud. that's all it is.* "That's all it is," she repeated, and Roya, who had once charged the syndicates a month's tithe for that same sentence with more syllables on it, laughed inside the mask where no one could bill her for it.

Each night, Ilay listened. Roya watched the girl's lips move, counting something that had no number yet, and watched her hands, and asked the only questions the mask could ask without lying: *Where? How loud? How far between?* And Ilay answered, and between them, ring by ring, on the cellar wall that Vahid had given up to the project because the salt kept blooming under his chalk anyway, the new map grew.

It was a spiral, but by the sixth night it was a survey. Fourteen rings, each dated in Ilay's careful child's hand — she dated everything now, Roya had noticed; a child who had been filed her whole life filed her drawings back — each ring tighter than the last, each ring with its bearing off the compass rose, and the bearings converged. Not on the clinic. Not on the Choratorium, whose ruins the Gavel's banners were already claiming across the rooftops. The rings tightened toward the Marrowworks belt, and under the Marrowworks belt, along the one vertical line every old map in Roya's possession agreed on like a scar all of them shared: the Throne shaft. The great shaft. The deep salt vaults at the bottom of it, where the dead First Vessel had sung itself silent.

Suri audited the dates against the one external record they had: the rooftop. Dar had felt the second heartbeat from the clinic roof in the first storm, three weeks back; he had felt it again on each of the four storm-nights since, and each time, he reported, a little less far away. Ilay's first ring was dated the morning after that first storm. The rings and the roof agreed to the night. Roya had spent eleven years selling certainty, and she had never once had two independent instruments confirm a plot the same evening, and she found that the certainty sat in her chest like swallowed river water — heavy, cold, impossible to spit out.

Roya laid her oldest chart over the wall one night — the shaft-map, the one with the ledger-script margin, DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS, in a hand she had sold for favors a decade ago. The spiral's center sat on the shaft's lowest ring like a coin dropped on a target.

"Converging," Suri said behind her, arms crossed over her ruined scales, counting the rings out of habit. "Fourteen. It's had fourteen rings and it's still spiraling in. That's not wandering. Wandering doesn't keep books."

"It's arriving," Roya said.

Dar stood in the doorway with his coat still on from the clinic's last hour, and he looked at the map the way he looked at films before cutting — the whole surface, then the one line that mattered. "The second heartbeat," he said. "The one from the roof. This is what Ilay's been hearing."

"Ilay's been hearing more than that," Roya said, and looked at the girl, because it was the girl's report to give, and the mask did not carry other people's confidences.

Ilay was drawing again, the evening ring, the fifteenth, and she answered without looking up, literal as an invoice. "There's the big one." The finger walked the spiral, inward. "The big one walks. And underneath the walking there's a small one." She tapped the center of the spiral, twice, the way you tap a wall to find where it's hollow. "The small one keeps time with

Dar."

The room did what rooms do when a child prices a secret in front of the room: nothing, loudly. Suri's count, Roya noticed, had stopped entirely, and Suri did not stop counting for anything that had a price.

"The small one," Dar said at last, carefully, in the voice he used to tell patients that the surgery would cost what it cost.

"In here." Ilay touched her own sternum. Then she reached up and touched Dar's coat, over the chest, once, with the matter-of-fact authority of a girl who had been a vessel-in-inventory before she had been a person and had never once confused the two filings. "You have two. The big one has one. It's lonely." A pause, the length of a held breath. "That's why it walks in circles. It's not hunting." She looked up at them then, river-stone eyes in lamplight, and delivered the sentence that Roya would keep behind the mask for a long time after: "It's coming to the only other one."

* * *

They finished the fifteenth ring near midnight. Ilay fell asleep in the chair with the chalk still in her fist, the way she did, and Roya carried her to the cot in the back, and came back to the wall because the wall had one more entry to be read.

The innermost ring. The fifteenth, tonight's, the tightest — a circle small enough now that Roya could cover its whole course with her scarred palm, the blade-scar whitening across it like a meridian. And at the ring's edge, in the careful hand that dated everything, Ilay had written the answer to a question nobody had asked yet.

Not a bearing. Not a count. A word, five letters, set down with the total seriousness of a child filing a fact into the only ledger she trusted:

soon.

Roya stood in front of the word for a long time, mask reflecting the lamp back at the wall.

Behind her, the clinic went on being the clinic — Suri's low voice setting the courier routes for tomorrow, a patient's cough through the floorboards, the ordinary noise of the only unpriced institution in the city. Above all of it, too deep for ears, the second heartbeat made its turn, and Roya realized she had stopped needing the girl's confirmation to feel it. Fifteen rings. Four weeks. Whatever walked below the salt had drawn a map of its own intentions on the wall of a child's refuge, and had dated it, and had been, by every instrument they had, on time.

She had sold every map she ever drew — to syndicates, to cutters, once, unforgivably, to the Church — and she had never once, in eleven years of the trade, been afraid of a thing she

had charted herself. Fear was for clients. The mapmaker stood outside the map.

She was standing inside this one. They all were. The spiral's thirteenth ring, two nights old, passed through the Saltstairs. The fourteenth passed through the clinic's foundations. The fifteenth ring was due to close somewhere under the Throne shaft, and the word at its edge had been written by a nine-year-old who had never in her life exaggerated a count.

Roya picked up the chalk, and below the word, in her own hand, in the flat metal script the mask had given her, she added the only term her trade had for it, the one she used to write on charts she couldn't price:

datum confirmed. not for sale.

CHAPTER 28

Sanctuary Terms

Mother Gavel annexed the Choratorium on a Tuesday, between the morning bells, without firing anything.

Suri read the notice where it had been pasted to the tithe-barge office in the Marrowworks belt, and counted the clauses because that was how she read everything now: seven. All Church property within the storm-walls was claimed by the Gavel under right of salvage, the claim to be held in trust for the city until a lawful authority existed to receive it. All former Church debts in Gavel territory were voided — *voided*, not forgiven; a voided debt could be re-entered in a new book later, and Suri imagined Mother Gavel knew the difference the way a knife knows the difference between resting and waiting. And clause five, the clause that had been written last and therefore mattered most: all syndicates, couriers, and free institutions within territory claimed by the Gavel owed the Gavel protection dues, payable in coin, in labor, or — the phrase sat on the paste like a fly in amber — *in records.*

The Truce of Salt was fraying. Suri had watched it happen with the professional calm of a woman who has audited a sinking hull before: no Choir to track anyone, no Church to arbitrate anything, no Wardens with teeth, and the Hammers and the couriers too thin to hold what the fall had opened up. A vacuum in Ashkarad was not an absence. It was an opportunity with a ledger behind it, and the Gavel had simply walked in and opened the book. The Choratorium's bone arches flew frost-petal banners by nightfall — the same compass-true petals that had pointed at the Choratorium during the march, now flown by the people who had once marched under them, which Suri thought was either irony or economics and knew better than to bet on which.

And clause five had a rider, posted within the day, small, exact, and addressed: *the free clinic of the Saltstairs will render its patient registry as protection records, per clause five, due within the week.*

The price of protection. The names.

Suri brought the rider to Dar, and Dar read it twice and said nothing for the length of three breaths, which from him was a wound assessment. Then he said, "We're not a syndicate."

"We're an institution with a registry," Suri said. "That's what the clause actually says. Institutions with registries. She wrote it for us. Everything else is salvage."

"She can salvage the ruins," Dar said. "The registry stays sealed."

"She'll send men to unseal it."

"Then we'll discuss it with her men," Dar said, in the voice that meant a price had already been set and only the parties were outstanding.

* * *

Her men came on the fourth day, at the shift-change hour, when the lanes were empty and the light was the color of old debt. Suri counted them down the tenement stair: four Gavel enforcers in mixed bone-plate and leather, brass knuckle-counters on their belts, and a ledgerman behind them with a slate — the Gavel always sent a ledgerman, because the Gavel understood that force was only the interest; the principal was always paper.

They had come for the Parra family. Old Parra, canal-works widower, both hands ruined by pump-vanes, and his two grandchildren, had defaulted on nothing and owed nothing, which was precisely the problem: the Gavel was enrolling debtors again, quietly, street by street, and a man with no debts made a bad first entry. The family had come to the clinic at dusk and asked — in the old formula, from the years when the formula meant the Chorus — to be written down as patients, and Dar had written them down, because that was what the book was for. Old Parra sat in the ward's corner with his ruined hands folded like tools retired from service, and the grandchildren — a boy of seven who counted everything under his breath, having learned it from watching the couriers, and a girl of four who had decided the clinic's cat-shaped shadow on the ceiling was a pet — had already been absorbed into the ward's economy: the boy carried water with Elias, the girl had appointed herself the pallets' protector and took the office seriously. Suri had entered them under *PARRA, HOUSEHOLD (3)*, doses and dates, no prices, and had found her own hand hesitate over the line, because once, in another ledger, in another city, a clerk had hesitated over her name, and the hesitation had been the last unpriced thing that touched her for a year.

The enforcers filled the ward doorway the way men do when they have been told the building is small. The ledgerman read from the slate: "Three entries outstanding. Parra, head of household, canal-works, enrolled under the protection schedule. Surrender the household and the registry, per clause five, and we file this as compliance."

"Compliance has a counteroffer," Dar said.

He was standing at the operating table with his sleeves rolled, midway through closing a crane-man's gashed thigh, and he did not stop working; the needle rose and dipped with the unhurried rhythm of a man whose heartbeat had never once been in arrears. "First: the family stays. They came in as patients. Patients leave when they're discharged, and discharge is a medical decision, and the only medical officer in this building is me. Second: the registry stays

sealed. Third—" and here the needle paused, and Dar looked up, and gave the four of them the whole of his attention, which was a famously expensive thing to receive, "—every man in this room will someday need stitching, and I mend without asking who sent you, and I remember without writing anything down. Those are the terms. There's no version of the next hour where they improve for you."

The youngest enforcer shifted, and Suri watched Dar's left hand, flat on the table beside a bowl of dark water — and watched the water in the bowl stir, faintly, against gravity, a single thread of red rising out of it like a filament remembering what it was. The Blood Vein did not threaten. It quoted. The enforcers' leader saw it too; his jaw set the particular way of a man recalculating in front of witnesses.

"The registry," the leader said, "or the schedule."

"You can tell her," Dar said, resuming the stitch, "that the registry is the patients, and the patients are under my knife, and my knife has never once been for sale — and she has known me long enough to know I put a fair price on everything else. Send the counteroffer up the chain. I'll receive it tonight."

They withdrew. The ledgerman left last, and at the door he turned, and said, with the first honesty of his visit: "She's going to like that you bargained. She hates a gift. Gifts can't be entered." The bowl's red thread settled back into dark water, and the clinic breathed.

By evening the lane outside had its opinions, the way lanes do. The Hammers' remaining crews went conspicuously, loudly unarmed past the clinic's door — a message priced to be read: the Gavel had moved on the Choratorium and the Hammers had not, and every silent walk-past was an audit of the truce. In the Undergleam, the Open Counts' talkers were saying that a new count was coming and the only question was whose thumb would hold the ledger down, which Suri filed under statements that were true and useless. Ashkarad was choosing up, the way a body chooses up around a wound — not toward health, toward the infection with the better terms.

* * *

The counteroffer came up the chain faster than Suri expected, which told her the Gavel had wanted a reason to deal. She carried it herself to the annexed Choratorium that evening, because the negotiation was hers — Dar standing off enforcers was surgery; this was commerce, and commerce was her vein — and because Mother Gavel had once put a price on Suri's head, and Suri had a superstition about finishing transactions in person.

The graft-theater had been swept of its reliquaries and swept again. Gavel crews worked the bone arches by lamplight, and at the center, on the surgeon's dais where the First Singer's

altar had been broken, Mother Gavel had set a table, a lamp, and her ledger, and sat behind them with her scarred roadmap of a face and her eyes flat as a filed page. She did not offer tea. Suri respected her enormously for it.

"You bargained through your cutter," Mother Gavel said. Her voice needed no brass tube at this range; it arrived with its own weight. "I sent four men and a slate for one family. You sent a counteroffer for a building. I raised four; you raised the stakes. I could be insulted."

"You could be paid," Suri said. "Here's the trade. The clinic is declared sanctuary — formal, posted, both sides' seals on it. Anyone under its roof is under the clinic's name, not yours, not the Index's, not the Wardens'. No names leave the building. In exchange, the clinic mends your crews — walk-ins, no questions, uncounted. Your men bleed in my ward and no entry is ever made with their names in it. You don't ask for our book; we don't keep a book on yours. Mutual blindness. That's the whole price, both directions."

"And my clause five?"

"Is about institutions with registries," Suri said. "Ours has no prices in it. You can't collect what's never been valued. Ask your ledgermen — they'll tell you a book with no numbers in it is the one book that can't be audited. I'm offering you the only ledger in Ashkarad that's safe to leave open, because there's nothing in it anyone can take."

Mother Gavel was silent for a moment. Somewhere above, a Gavel crew lowered a reliquary rack down a stairwell with the tenderness of men moving a coffin. "Mutual blindness," she said at last, and there was something in the flat voice that might, in a face less filed, have been amusement. "I built my crews on knowing everything that moves. You're asking me to underwrite a hole in my own map."

"I'm asking you to underwrite the only building in this city that stitches your men free of charge," Suri said. "That's not a hole in your map, Mother. That's a mercy your book can't hold. Even you have to enter it somewhere."

The old woman looked at her for a long moment, eyes flat as a ledger page, and then did the thing that made the hair rise on Suri's arms, because it was the first genuinely unpriced gesture she had ever seen from her: she closed her own ledger.

"Sanctuary," Mother Gavel said. "Posted terms, both seals. No names leave the building — theirs or mine." A pause, one beat, an auditor's beat. "Agreed."

Too easily, Suri thought, walking home through the fog with the signed card in her coat like a coal. Too easily by exactly one clause she hadn't asked for and couldn't find.

She found it the next morning, on the stair opposite the clinic door: a Gavel ledgerman with a slate, unhurried, comfortable, paying out twine like a man measuring a room. Across the lane, a second. He did not look away when she looked at him. He looked at the door, and made a mark, and spoke to the slate in the tone of a man reading figures.

Counting. Not names — the names were sealed, and the seal held. Foot-traffic. Who entered the clinic and when, how long they stayed, who left and in what direction. Hour by hour, a census of the doorway itself, assembled out of nothing more expensive than patience — and Suri stood on her own step and understood, with the flat clarity she reserved for the worst entries, what she had sold.

She had kept the names out of the book. She had not kept the building out of the count.

She went in and opened her ledger to a fresh column, and wrote the heading in the small hand she saved for things that had no price and would be billed anyway:

GAVEL — SANCTUARY (AGREED)

And below it, after a moment:

OBSERVED — DAILY, COUNTED — DAILY

CHAPTER 29

The Ninth Petal

The Saint Ferrous archive kept its census clerks the way it kept everything: filed, and lying about it.

Milla Ferun had been billeted there for eleven days — reassigned, the posting said, from the Marrowworks to a *reconciliation detail*, which meant eleven cots between the shelves and a work quota of pages re-copied from memory, because the halls had burned and the Index wanted the city's books rebuilt by the people who had kept them. She was good at the work. That was the indictment of her whole life: she was good at the work. Give her a ledger and her cold fingers would make it true, and the truest thing she had ever copied was a strip of pulse-printout she had stolen one evening five years into stamping hearts, and she had sewn it into her coat lining the same night, against her hip, where it had warmed to her temperature ever since.

The raid came at the third bell, which told her the raiders had read the archive's own shift-logs, and she was awake for it because she had stopped sleeping much. Boots in the stacks — not the Warden shuffle, the Index walk, in step, economical — and lamplight in lines under the shelf-doors, and a voice reading names off a list with the mild, terrible patience of a man serving notices: clerks, out, in order, by rank of access. Hostage-taking, but hostage-taking with paperwork; the Index was conscripting every clerk who could rebuild a census, and a census could not be built by volunteers.

She heard the terms through the stacks, delivered to the assembled clerks in the tone of a man doing them a favor: their debts were void, their billets were comfortable, their families would be found and reassured. Only their memories were required — forty years of stamps, filed and re-filed — and their signatures on new rolls. The Archive was to become an Index annex. The clerks were to become its hands. Refusal was not stated as punished; it was stated as *unavailable*, which was how the worst things in Ashkarad had always been priced. Milla listened to her colleagues agree, one by one, in the small relieved voices of people being permitted to keep doing the only work they knew, and understood that this was how the Choir had been built too — not out of monsters, but out of clerks reconciling themselves, page by page, to the latest set of terms.

Milla's fingers did not tremble. That was what they were for. She counted the boots past her shelf — eight, then two more at the end room where Elara slept; she heard Elara's name read, and Elara's voice answer, obedient, clerk-trained, and the sound of her colleague's

compliance was the last cost she needed entered. Milla lay still on her cot in the dark of the stacks and made the only transaction her life had been preparing her for: she defaulted. She had never once in her life failed to appear on a roster. She committed the omission the way other people committed crimes — thoroughly, in advance, with the paperwork of her own disappearance already filed in her head.

She had heard the bounty on the sixth day. The Index men talked over the copy-desk the way clerks talk, in figures, and one of them had named the figure: a season's wages for a single sheet, flagged RHYTHM UNRESOLVED, anomaly class, origin Saltstairs — *the Ferun printout.* She had heard her own surname in a bounty the way you hear a death notice for someone who shares your street, and she had understood two things at once: that the paper against her hip had become the most expensive thing in the city, and that she was the only person alive who knew where it slept.

She rose, sewed coat, boots in hand, and went out through the coal chute that the archive's fire-detail used for ash, because she had counted the guard rotations on her first day — it was not mistrust, it was habit, habit was all she had ever kept — and she dropped into the yard and walked into the Saltstairs fog with the most wanted paper in Ashkarad warming her hip.

The porcelain face came with her, the way it always did now. It had followed her out of the dream years ago and never quite left: smooth, blank, smiling too wide, smiling at a number. In the dream it stood in the salt garden with its white-cuffed hands folded, and behind it the sleepers breathed in unison like a ward, and she had understood, with the flat dream-certainty she trusted more than most of her waking judgments, that the smile was the truest ledger she had ever been shown. She dreamed it less since the Blacktide. What she dreamed now was the flower.

* * *

The clinic had a card on its door. Milla had never seen the word *sanctuary* posted on any building in Ashkarad that wasn't being sold, and she stood in front of it in the grey of the morning reading the terms twice — both seals, no names, no prices — with the fixed attention she had once spent on consent forms, because she had spent her life watching buildings lie through their doors and this one, impossibly, appeared to be doing the opposite.

The door opened before she knocked. A woman with a ruined carbon graft on one arm looked at her, then at the coat she was holding closed with both hands like a wound.

"You're a clerk," the woman said. Not a question. "Marrowworks, by the stamp-callus. Index is paying by name for clerks tonight, and you walked here from the east, which means you're not selling."

"I'm buying," Milla said. Her voice came out flat as a filed page, which was her voice, always, except at the end of the sentence, where something cracked along a line she had not known was in her. "Sanctuary. I want to be uncounted. And I have something for the surgeon — for Mehran. He doesn't know me. It doesn't matter. It's his."

She unwound the coat lining in the ward, on the scarred table, under the lamp, with the courier woman watching and the surgeon coming across the room with the wariness of a man who has learned what arrives in his building unannounced.

Up close, Milla saw, the surgeon had two pulses. She had known it for five years — had read it first in a strip of thermal-grey paper, origin Saltstairs, flagged and ordered destroyed — and then the whole city had learned what her one stolen page already knew: the Saltstairs cutter with the black lily, the man who broke the Blacktide. The knowing had sat in her like a second ledger ever since, unfiled, accruing nothing. Now the knowing and the man were in the same room, and her cold fingers were steady, because they had been rehearsing this appointment for half a decade without ever daring to schedule it.

The printout was five years old and perfect. Thermal-grey, machine-crisp, the jagged lines unmistakable — she had read it a thousand times in her own room, weighting the corners with two cups and a tin spoon. At the top, the flag: RHYTHM UNRESOLVED. And beneath the flag, in the sequence she had been the first person in the city to see, the pattern: five spikes, a dip, five spikes. A two-rhythm pulse, layered, unresolved, refusing the machine's arithmetic. A heart carrying a second rhythm and declining to surrender either.

"That's mine," Dar said quietly. He did not touch the paper. "That's the first reader I ever practiced on. Before I knew what I was carrying. This is—" he stopped, and Milla watched a surgeon price an artifact in real time: a recording of his own chest from the earliest days, made before the Blacktide, before the Veins, before he had spent his mother's face to survive it. A document of what he had been before any of it. The only one.

"The Chorus original went into the incinerator the same night I copied it," Milla said. "My supervisor ordered it destroyed. I fed the furnace myself and kept the copy. It's the only print of that rhythm left in the world — I've told no one, until now. I'm telling you because there's a bounty on it. They're calling it the Ferun printout." She heard her own voice continue with the detachment of a clerk reading another clerk's file. "I'm the Ferun in question. They priced me before I even knew I was for sale. I'd like, at least, to pick the buyer."

Suri had not blinked through any of it. Now she said, "The Index pays in futures, not coin. If you'd sold, you'd have been paid in a posting somewhere far away and a grudge that compounds. This was better bargained."

"Why bring it to me?" Dar asked. "You could have drowned it. Ash is cheap."

Milla looked at the table. Then she took out her pocket ledger — her own book, the one she kept behind her eyes made flesh, five years of margin-flower drawings — and opened it to the last page, and turned it around.

"I draw the flower," she said. "In the margins, when the counting gets heavy. In my sleep, lately, which is worse — sleep is the one room I never signed anything in. Five petals. Always five. It took me years to admit the five was a pattern and not a tic, and longer to admit the pattern wasn't mine." The page in her ledger was last night's drawing, made in sleep, in a hand that was hers and steadier than her waking hand ever was: a flower, centered, symmetrical, its petals drawn with the assurance of anatomy. "Last night it had nine."

The ward was quiet. Somewhere above, a patient's cough; the ordinary noise of the sanctuary doing its work.

"Nine," Dar said. His hand was flat on the table by the printout, and Milla — who had spent five years watching pulse-lines for a living — saw the second rhythm in him flicker under the skin of his wrist, one beat out of step, like a neighbor lighting a lamp.

"The garden is changing its filing system," she said, and heard the absurdity and let it stand, because there was no accurate way to say it. "Or it's counting something new."

Dar folded the printout along its old creases and put it inside his coat, with whatever else he kept next to his heart, and Milla realized with a small cold shock that she had just handed over the only valuable thing she would ever own and felt lighter for it, which the ledgers had no column for.

The courier woman showed her a cot, a shelf, the terms of the sanctuary spoken plainly: "You work the front desk. You're good at figures — I can tell by your hands. You count for us now. Freely." The word *freely* was said like a coin being set down.

Milla sat on the cot in the sanctuary of strangers, and did the last audit of her old life: salt on her fingers, fine and white and chalky, worked in under the nails — though she had not been underground in weeks, had not touched the Marrowworks since the fall, had not been within a mile of the salt gardens or the shafts. She rubbed at it. It did not come off. It smelled, faintly, sweetly, like a garden waiting for the right kind of weather.

She put her hands in her lap where she could watch them, and counted her own pulse until the counting was a lullaby, and waited to see what the flower would draw tonight.

CHAPTER 30

One Beat Behind

The clinic's roof was the last parish in Ashkarad where a man could stand still without being entered in somebody's book, and even that exemption was eroding. Twice a shift now, a Gavel tallyman marked the alley mouth below, chalk behind his ear, counting the clinic's foot-traffic with the diligence of an auditor who has been told, gently, that the account is not his — yet. Dar stood at the parapet anyway, past midnight, with a shard of slate in his coat pocket and the city breathing under him: eleven hundred heartbeats in the Saltstairs tenements, give or take the ones no one was left alive to count, and beneath all of it the great red brick wound of the Marrowworks two districts inboard, dark for the first time in forty years.

Suri came up the roof-ladder the way she came up everywhere, without wasted motion, and stopped at a precise arm's length. She had taken to leaving her left forearm unbound in the evenings — the fracture had closed at last, leaving a ridge of bone like a seam in a repaired ledger — and she flexed it once, checking the balance of herself, before she spoke.

"Four hundred and twelve tiles," she said. "Three are loose. One will go this winter and hit a Gavel man, which I have decided is a good outcome."

"Noted for the year-end accounts."

"Vahid says you're not to walk alone yet." She said it flatly, an entry, not an argument. "His word was 'prohibited.' He underlined it."

"His prohibitions are priced in gin," Dar said. "I can't afford the exchange rate."

She looked at him for a moment with those carbon-dusted eyes, and whatever she was tallying behind them came out even, because she nodded once and went back down the ladder, taking the last watch in the ward. She paused at the top rung only to say, "Milla rewashed her hands again. Fifth time since supper. If you're going to walk tonight, walk before she wears through her own skin," and was gone.

The Ferun woman had been eleven days under the clinic's roof. She still slept upright, still folded the RHYTHM UNRESOLVED printout into her sleeve before bed like a prayer she didn't believe in, and still scrubbed her hands as if the salt the city put under her nails were a debt she could sweat off. Dar had stopped telling her it wasn't grime. Some columns a debtor has to audit alone. In the ward she had taken over the medicine counts by the third day — twelve years of tithe-clerk habit do not resign, they only change employers — and her slips were exact in the way only a frightened person's slips are exact, every figure inked as if

someone were reading over her shoulder. Someone always had been. It was the reading-over she was learning to live without, and it went slowly.

He took out the slate.

The Cartographer had pressed it on him outside the fighting pit, in the fog, months and a lifetime ago: a ragged roof-slate, one scratch-mark cluster cut deep and sure, reading one hundred and nine. *Something on the far side has started counting your heartbeats,* she had said, metallic and calm. *It's at one hundred and nine.* He had kept it pinned above the attic desk ever since, beside the registry page, the way a man keeps the mortgage papers of a house he refuses to sell. He held it now under the moonless dark, and the salt frost on the parapet breathed white with every gust off the sea.

Then he closed his eyes and went inside — not the clinic, the other house.

* * *

Vahid's doctrine, chalked week after week on the cellar wall in his ferocious, crooked hand, came down to two lines: *memory is architecture; you built the ruin, you may walk the ruin.* Walking costs nothing. Only doors spend. For five weeks Dar had treated the Mind Vein the way one treats a road washed out by flood — known, mapped, avoided. Tonight was the first time he had stood at its edge with his ledger balanced and chosen to cross on purpose.

He descended his own halls the way he had once descended a patient's chest: by landmarks, never by hope. The corridors were his — swept, grey, lit by no lamp and needing none. He passed the room where his mother's face had hung and did not slow. He knew what was in it now, because he had made himself learn it in the cellar under Vahid's lens: a pale rectangle on the wall where a frame had been, the plaster a shade darker inside the rectangle than out, the way a wall remembers a mirror. Nothing else. No dust, because dust is time, and that room had had all of its time withdrawn, called due and paid in one terrible installment on the night the altar broke.

The room that had held his father's laugh kept a stone hearth with no kettle on it. He had spent that laugh as ammunition, three syllables of it per burst, and the hearth had gone cold in a way stone was never meant to go. The first kiss was behind a door he kept shut from habit rather than discipline — habit was cheaper. The childhood home's color was a room washed in no shade at all, a column left blank in a ledger that hated blanks. He had spent four rooms. The house had held more than four, and he was careful not to inventory the rest too closely. Inventories invite appraisals. Appraisals invite buyers.

Ilay's chalk spiral hung over the walk the way a route hangs over a man who has promised to travel it. Roya had copied the girl's map onto good paper and pinned it in the cellar: the slow

tightening gyre converging on the Throne shaft, ring inside ring, the innermost ring lettered in a nine-year-old's careful hand — soon. He had looked at that word for six nights running. It had not blinked. Vahid called it a child's projection; Roya called it a bearing; Dar, walking his own emptied halls on purpose for the first time, called it what he was afraid it was — an appointment someone else had made and neglected to invite him to.

He walked, and did not touch, and the walking cost nothing, which he trusted the way one trusts a tollgate found standing open.

At the deepest hall, the one beneath all his other halls, the furnished door stood where it had stood since the cellar weeks — hung, handled, hinged, of a dark wood that had never grown in any house he knew, set into a wall that was his own grey salt-and-bone everywhere else. It hummed, faintly, a note just under hearing. It was warm on the far side; he could feel the warmth across the eight feet of corridor like heat off a body recently vacated. A room someone had just left. And tonight — new, tonight — a thread of light moved beneath the door, slow as lamplight carried past on the far side by a hand too patient to be hurried.

Dar stopped eight feet away, as he had stopped eight feet away every time, and declined it. Not his door. Not his debt. He put the observation where he now put such things — filed, not felt — and turned back up the hall.

It was in the hush of the turning that he heard it.

* * *

It did not come from outside. It came up through the architecture, the way sound comes up a stairwell of stone, and it was a heartbeat — patient and immense, a slow deep drum under the world — and he had heard it before, on this roof, in the first storm after the Blacktide, and named it once with the only word the Lily had ever spent. But he had never heard it *clearly*, against silence, against a mind freshly swept, and clarity showed him the thing the noise of living had hidden.

It was one beat behind him.

He tested it the way he tested any figure that looked too neat: two fingers on his wrist, his own pulse counted out in the dark, the drum beneath the city answering each beat a full rest later. Beat. Rest. Beat, answered. Again. Again. Twenty counts, and the lag held to the twentieth, and his surgeon's mind did the only arithmetic available to it and came back sick: not an echo. Echoes degrade. This was reproduction — his column copied one line down, in a hand too patient to be mocking, the way a scrivener reproduces a master ledger without improving on it. *Because it counts back,* the old chart's margin had said. He had taken that for poetry. It was bookkeeping.

He surfaced onto the parapet with frost in his lashes and his own breath loud, and the night was exactly as he had left it, which suddenly felt like an allowance he hadn't earned.

The slate was still in his hand. He looked down at it because his hand had turned it over without asking him, and the scratch-marks were the same — one hundred and nine, cut deep and sure in the Cartographer's certainty — and beneath them, new.

Five strokes. Fresh. Chalk-bright against slate gone dull with a season of weather, their edges unsoftened by any rain or salt the city had thrown at the world since — and the city had thrown plenty. He had not cut them. He would have sworn that under audit, which in Ashkarad was the strongest oath there was, and the oath curdled even as he made it, because he had been standing at a door when the hush came, and the count, as far as he could ever reconstruct it, had only ever moved at thresholds. It did not run at pulse-rate. It ran at doors. And he had opened the hall tonight and walked it, deliberately, for the first time.

He did not remember making the strokes. That was the entry, and he wrote it nowhere, because some entries you keep only in the flesh.

The wind off the sea had turned while he walked his halls; he could taste the storm the wind was dragging behind it, still far out, still a rumor — grace coming, the city would call it, and batten, and endure. Below him the Gavel tallyman had gone; the alley mouth was unmarked chalk. The Saltstairs breathed. Two districts inboard, the Marrowworks lay dark over whatever lay under the Marrowworks, and under that — deeper than the dead First Vessel, deeper than Vey's cathedral of stolen years — the drum went on, one beat behind, unrushed.

Then the Lily leaned.

There was no better verb for it, and he was a man who rationed verbs. She had been still in him for weeks — guest-quiet, hum-quiet, the stillness of an account that has stopped accruing. Now the whole rooted weight of her tipped, all at once, toward the deep, the way a ship's cargo shifts in a swell, and his balance went with her because his balance was hers now whether the ledgers admitted it or not. He staggered against the parapet, caught it two-handed, slate bit and frost bit and his boots skidding an inch on the salt-glaze — an inch, on a roof, above four stories, and the inch felt like a reading, like a gauge, like proof of how much of him she could move without asking.

And then the answering pressure came.

It rose through the soles of his feet and arrived against his sternum from the inside of the world — patient, immense, unhurried — level, and deliberate, the way a counterweight is set gently on the empty pan of a scale. Not a pull. A *meeting.* The Lily pressed toward the deep,

and the deep, for the first time since the day a dying thief had crawled into a canal with a cracked reliquary in his arms, pressed back.

Dar stood at the parapet with his arms braced and his heart counted by something beneath the salt, one line down, one beat late, and understood that the count on the slate was not the ledger.

It was the copy.

CHAPTER 31

The Salt-Glass Door

Vahid put the prohibition in writing, which in a man who had spent his life being discredited in writing was either irony or surrender to form. He chalked it on the cellar wall beneath the Vein-ladder, underlined it twice with his one hand, and stood back from it the way a man stands back from a fence he knows will not hold.

"The Mind Vein is open in you the way a door is open in a house whose owner is out," he said. "You have walked it once, cleanly, I'll grant the cleanliness. But the deep, boy — the deep is where a thing older than the Church learned your mother's lullaby off your own pulse. It counted back at you from a hundred and nine heartbeats and now it has added to the tally without your hand. You do not visit a creditor who writes in your ledger while you sleep."

"It's not a creditor," Dar said. "It knocked. I intend to look through the keyhole before it comes up the stairs."

"It is a *summons*," Vahid said, and then his voice did the thing it did when the gin burned down to the exactness underneath, the lecture swerving from drunkenness to surgical clarity mid-sentence. "You have in your chest the ninth of nine seeds. Below this city lies the vault where the first of them has been waiting out a century in the dark. Whatever is leaning on you leaned on her first, and she has been down there alone since before your grandmother defaulted on her own spine. You walk into that vault and you are not a surgeon, Dar. You are collateral."

"Then I'd rather be collateral in the room where the terms are read out," Dar said. "Ilay's map says *soon*, Professor. I've learned to price other people's 'soon.' It's always dearer than it looks."

Vahid looked at him for a long moment over the round, salt-scoured spectacles, mended with wire, and Dar watched him weigh the argument and lose it to the worse arithmetic on the other side — the tally that grew without a hand, the thread of light under a door that had no business being furnished, a girl's lettering that said *soon* in a child's careful loan-cursive. The Professor took up the chalk, and instead of underlining the prohibition a third time, he wrote the descent rules beneath it. Dosage, a physician calls it.

"Suri counts every step aloud and you do not correct her. You carry the girl's map and you do not follow it past the last circle she drew. You carry a lamp and you keep it *low* — darkness feeds her, boy, and I would rather not learn what she does at a feast. And you take

this." He worked a stoppered phial out of his sleeve, tincture dark as ink. "Tincture of hawthorn and salt-wort. If her hum goes past your teeth, you drink it and you climb, and you do not stop to be polite."

"And you leave the girl above," he added, quieter, and the quiet was worse than the shout would have been. "The nursery taught her tissue to be compliant before she could write her own name. The deep knew her before it knew you. Whatever calls from under the salt, Dar — do not let it learn her address."

Dar took the phial. It was not agreement; it was witnessed dissent, which in the clinic's currency was the same thing accepted at par.

* * *

They went down through the Saltstairs at the dead hour, by Milla's route — the tithe-clerk's route, the way paperwork traveled when it wanted to reach the harvest floors without standing in line. She had drawn it for them on the back of a medicine slip: culvert stairs behind the cistern, the pump gallery, the clerks' door with its lock long since stolen and its silence never replaced. Above, the Gavel's tallymen marked the alley mouths with their chalk strokes; one of them watched the three of them — Dar, Suri, and Roya carrying Ilay's map in a wax-cloth roll — pass into the Marrowworks underbelly, and made a mark, and said nothing. Let it be counted, Dar thought. Everything in this city was counted. It was what got *collected* that mattered now.

Ilay had not argued to come. That was the part he kept turning over in the culvert dark. Roya had told her, in the flat metallic calm the brass mask gave every sentence, that the deep was not for children, and the girl had looked at Roya for a while — at the mask, or through it — and said only, "It's not for anyone. Take the circles. The numbers are how many steps. The circles are how loud." And then she had gone back to her charcoal, drawing the innermost ring one more time, bigger than the others, as if size were emphasis, as if *soon* had not been emphatic enough.

The Marrowworks was a drowned animal above them and a picked bone around them. Tithe-warehouses stood empty with their brass signs pried off; the harvest floors' long tables held only salt-fur and the ghosts of clamps; a tithe-clerk's station gaped open, three stamps still racked in their rest — Heart, Debt, Voluntary — drying out like dead urchins. Suri's lamp swung past it and her count did not falter.

"Forty," she said. "Forty-one. The manhole's at forty-four, map says forty-five, so somebody's moved the grate, which somebody's going to answer for— there." Iron clanged under her boot. "Forty-five."

Roya stopped at the manhole rim and did not follow them down. She had said her piece on the walk over in four words — *someone holds the top* — and held out the wax-cloth roll to Dar now with both scarred hands, the way you hand over something you have been carrying for someone else. He unrolled it by lamplight: the girl's spiral, ring inside ring, in copied chalk on good paper, the numbers running down the margin in her careful hand. The circles were loudness. The numbers were steps. Below the last circle, in a nine-year-old's lettering, the word *soon*, written twice.

"Severed or not," Roya said, metallic and quiet, from inside the mask, "nothing below learns your signal through me. That's worth one lantern at the rim. If you're not back by the time the oil burns to the wick, I will not come down after you. I will go and get the Professor, and the Professor will come down after you, and you will deserve him." She folded the empty wax-cloth and sat down on the rim with her back to the shaft, minding the door.

Below the clerks' door the stair became the shaft — the great bored throat, older than the Church above it, ringed with hand-holds worn to silver. Chalk marks climbed the crust of the first landings, scavengers' tallies and worse — a crude sun, a price list for glass, one line of a child's hand copying its own name over and over until the name ran out of wall — donors who had woken whole in a dead machine and walked up into a city that had no column for them. Most of the marks climbed. None descended. The old chart's margin was scratched into the salt crust at the first landing too, ledger-script in the Gardener's cramped certainty, and Dar read it by Suri's lamp with the words arriving one at a time like figures on a debt-slip: DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS.

"Two hundred and ten," Suri said, counting.

The margin was a century old and had never once been obeyed, which was itself evidence that anything down here kept books.

* * *

The First Vessel's chamber opened at the shaft's knee the way a cathedral opens — suddenly, sideways, space arriving before light. They stood on a gallery of salt-cut rock, lamps low, and looked across at it: the cold cathedral of flesh, forty years of harvested organs grafted and grafted again into one vast dreaming bulk, now a cathedral after the congregation has gone home and the god has been repossessed. The air in the chamber had the smell of a shop after closing — old biogel, cold glass, wax that had been warm too long — and the glass reliquaries studded into its flanks were dead, row on row of them, dull as the windows of a house whose debts died with it. The choir organs had gone silent in one song and stayed silent, and what silence they had left behind was not absence but pressure, the kind that makes the inner ear

file a complaint. Its face was turned away from them. Too many eyes, all closed. Vey had promised the city a heart and been handed instead the bill for one, and the bill had come due on the night the altar broke.

Frost furred the nearest flank in slow grey petals. Even dead, things grew toward it. Nothing grew away.

"Six hundred and forty," Suri said softly. Her count had not wavered once since the clerks' door, and Dar understood now that the count was not bravery. It was ballast. A counter knows that whatever else is true, the numbers are hers, and no one — not gods, not ledgers, not things that count back — can repossess the numbers. "The map's last circle is at six-eighty. Beyond that she didn't draw. She said it was too loud to see."

They passed the dead First Vessel the way you pass a collection plate no one will ever pass again, and the shaft went on down.

* * *

At six hundred and eighty steps the walls changed.

Salt had been under everything all along — grey crust, white fur, the weeping of a city built on a drowned sea — but here it became the whole substance, vault after vault of it, translucent as thick glass, and when Suri's boot scuffed a ripple of floor-salt the note it gave hung in the air for ten full seconds, a struck-glass chime that harmonized, when the great drum beneath them swelled, a quarter-tone flat. The vaults rang with their own footsteps. Every step was an entry; every entry was answered. They stopped speaking. Suri counted with her fingers against her thigh, and Dar watched her hand move and kept the map's last circle in his mind — too loud to see — and measured his progress toward it by the rising tide in his sternum.

The second heartbeat was no longer something he heard. It was something the vault did to him. It came up through the salt and the floor and the bones the Marrow Vein had made dense as coral, and it filled the dark the way a slow tide fills a cave — not arriving, *present*, patient and immense, one beat behind his own, one line down, entering after him.

"It's still one behind," he said. There was no reason to whisper. The vault was louder than both of them.

Suri considered that with the blank economy she gave all figures that refused to reconcile. "Then it owes you a beat," she said. "Everything in this city runs behind. Chapel bells. Wages. The tide. First thing down here that ever paid late instead of taking early." Her jaw tightened. "Don't start liking it."

The lamps burned low and leaned. Not out — *toward*, the way a plant leans, both flames bowing gently down the corridor into the deep dark as if the darkness there were a table set for them. Suri looked at the flames and then at him, and Dar tipped his lamp lower and walked on, because the tincture was in his coat and the rules were in his head and the appointment was in the girl's handwriting, and you do not break an appointment you were too late to decline.

At seven hundred and eleven steps the corridor ended, and the map was proved, and Ilay was right: it was too loud to see.

The door stood at the vault's end, and it was made of salt-glass clear as deep water, and behind it there was no wall. Behind it was darkness — not a shade but a presence, a darkness with mass and tide — and the second heartbeat filled that darkness like the sea fills a basin, slow, vast, unhurried, patient. The door had no handle. The door had no hinge he could find. It had only height and width and the cold shining of it, and the dark behind it breathed against the far side the way a sleeper breathes against a window in winter.

Suri's hand stopped counting. Her fingers curled closed.

"Seven hundred and eleven," she said, in a voice with no numbers left in it.

And pressed against the far side of the glass, level with Dar's chest — level, exactly, with the place where the Lily rooted in him and two hearts kept their separate books — was a single black petal, wide as his palm, veined in lace, waiting.

CHAPTER 32

Petal Against Glass

The last circle of Ilay's map lay behind them at six hundred and eighty steps, and everything past it was territory no one had drawn — forty-one steps of corridor where the tide in the walls made seeing useless and counting a courtesy. They had crossed it the way you cross the last stretch before a sickroom: slowly, lamps low, the tincture of hawthorn and salt-wort stoppered in Dar's coat like an argument he had promised to keep on hand. Now they stood in the chamber of the door, and the door stood at its end, and the petal did not move for a long time, and neither did they.

It lay against the far side of the salt-glass like a hand pressed flat to a window from inside a lit room — wide as Dar's palm, black as the underside of the tongue, veined in lace that was fine as the ledger-work on a first-edition debt-bond. Level with his chest. Level, exactly, with the place where his own second heart kept its books, and he had been a surgeon long enough to know that nothing in nature is level by accident. She had measured him through the dark. She knew where he kept her.

"Eleven steps down and it's colder than the First Vessel's floor," Suri said quietly. She had not touched her count since the door; her fingers were still curled closed around the number she had been robbed of. "It's not cold, though. Is it. It's *held.* Like breath held by something that never learned it had to stop."

The petal began to tap.

Soft at first — the tip of it against the glass, once, twice, a sound like a fingernail on the skin of frozen water — and then it settled, and the settling was the horror and the miracle both, because the rhythm was not random and it was not strange. Dar knew it the way you know your own stairwell in the dark. Three notes up, one hanging pause, two notes down, and the pause again: the opening bars of a lullaby in a language understood without hearing, the song the woman in white gloves had hummed over a garden of planted sleepers, the song Vey had hummed across a dining table between two cups, the song the dead First Singer had answered him with through a hundred feet of salt. The song he had spent his mother's face to pay for and could no longer say whose it was first. It came through the glass in taps, patient, small, unbearably careful — the way a debtor knocks at a relative's door. Dar stood with his hand not yet raised and his pulse knocking back, and let the song finish its first phrase, because it was also his — that was the part the Mind Vein had taught him and the cellar weeks had made him price: the lullaby did not come to him from outside. It had lived in him longer than the Lily

had. It had survived the spending of four rooms. It hummed at the bottom of his swept halls with its ownership disputed, and every claimant he had ever identified for it was dead, mad, or dissolved into black lace on an altar rail.

"It knows the song," Suri said. Her voice stayed flat. Her knuckles did not. "The one you hum when you think you're asleep."

One of us learned it from the other, Dar thought, and could not for his life have said which one that sentence meant.

His chest answered before he did.

The Lily had been leaning for a week — toward the deep, toward the dark, her whole rooted weight tipping like cargo in a swell — but leaning was talking; this was *singing.* The hum rose through his ribs from the roots she had laid along his sternum, and it was the lullaby, the same three notes up, the same hanging pause, and it met the tapping through the glass and fit it — not echoed it, not answered it, *fit* it, the way two column-figures fit when the ledger finally reconciles, line against line, entry against entry, a reconciliation a century in arrears closing itself with a sound like a long-held breath let go.

The frost on the door bloomed.

It came up the salt-glass in whorls and petals, grey lace climbing in the shape of five-petaled flowers, and the flowers did not open toward them but outward — through, he realized; the pattern was one pattern seen from both sides, her frost and his, the same design pressed between two panes of the world. The tapping quickened. The tide of the heartbeat behind the glass swelled, and for the first time since the canal, since the barge, since the altar, Dar felt the thing beneath the city not as weather and not as a creditor but as what the word he had never said aloud had always claimed: a sister. Real. Alive. Aware — aware of *him*, because the taps had stopped matching the song and started matching his pulse, landing on his offbeats now, her one-behind rhythm threading through his own like a figure entered one line down, and when he exhaled, the tapping paused. When he breathed again, it resumed.

She was listening to him breathe. She had been listening for a hundred years.

Suri stepped back — one step, exact, her boot finding old salt without a sound — and said, in the voice she used for figures that frightened her, "That's not a machine."

"No," Dar said. "It isn't."

* * *

The Lily pressed.

He felt it as forward lean gone to forward *need*, the whole black weight of her in his chest climbing toward the glass the way water climbs toward the hole in a hull, and her hum rose toward the octave where the tapping lived, and the petal flattened wider against the door, and the frost-flowers raced, and every instinct the Veins had ever put in his body said: *open it. Open it now, while the song is right, before the song is wrong.* The dark behind the glass was warm as a body. The gap he could not see was audible — the door, he understood with a lurch, was not sealed; it breathed at its edges; it had breath to breathe.

Dar put his hand flat on the salt-glass, and everything stopped.

The tapping stopped. The frost stopped mid-climb. The hum in his chest hung on its note like a struck bell forbidden to decay, and behind the glass the vast slow tide of the heartbeat went quiet, one beat, two beats, three — the silence of an animal that has heard the door of the cage click and does not yet know what the hand intends.

He had refused the Throne twice. He knew the anatomy of refusal by now, the way he knew the anatomy of a wound: where it hurts, where it tears, what it costs. At the Blacktide she had offered him the salt garden itself — rows of planted sleepers, a tower of lantern heartbeats, rest without end — and he had said no, and she had said, in the first words she had ever spent on him, *then carry me a little further*, and he had carried her, and the carrying had brought them here. This was not that refusal. This was the other discipline, the older one, the one they had never needed to teach him in any hospital because Ashkarad taught it free with every cup of soup sold on credit: *you do not corner the thing you came to meet.* She had knocked. She had sung. She had never, in a hundred years, opened — and a creature that lives alone behind an unlocked door for a century is not preserved by the lock. She was preserved by the fear. The door stood ajar because she could not make herself open it, and if he opened it for her, the opening would be his act and not hers, a transaction she had not signed, and he had built everything he was now on a single refusal to push paper under other people's hands.

"Not yet," he said. Not to Suri. To the glass, to the dark, to the listening — and the Lily's hum bent against the word, but she had yielded to him before, twice, at prices that had nearly ended him, and she yielded now, the need easing out of his ribs like a tide respecting a seawall. *Then carry me a little further,* she had said once, and he had, and here they were, a little further.

The petal hesitated. Then it withdrew.

It peeled off the glass the way a hand withdraws from a table when the deal is not yet signed — slowly at first, politely, then quickly, gone — sliding back into the dark like lace

drawn off a mirror, and the last black edge of it took the frost with it, and the door stood empty and shining and dumb.

And where the petal had been pressed, the keyhole showed.

It was cut through the salt-glass like a flaw cut deliberately, and it was not a keyhole in any locksmith's grammar: it was a five-petaled flower, small, exact, the sigil from the registry page, the sigil off the syndicate banners, the chalk mark of the census, blooming through a crack in the door of the world. The edge of the door nearest it stood a hair's-width ajar. Air moved through the gap — warm, slow, breathing — carrying a smell that had no business being warm or slow a hundred fathoms under a drowned city: loam. Living loam, and beneath the loam, faint as a signature under a signature, the ghost of a lullaby sung a long time ago to soil.

"It was never locked," Suri said. Her count stayed closed in her fist. "The whole way down — the warning on the landing, the margin, *do not count the heartbeats* — and it was never locked."

"It was locked from the far side," Dar said. "The lock is a decision. She made it every day for a hundred years." He took his hand off the glass. His palm-print stayed in the frost a moment, five-fingered, beside the flower, the two marks together like a page from a ledger no one would ever file. "She wants to be found. And she is afraid of being found. Both entries are true, and neither cancels the other."

They stood a moment longer in the ringing dark, two small balances on seven hundred and eleven steps of salt, while the tide behind the glass resumed — patient, immense, one beat behind him, following — and the warm air breathed through the gap against his chest like a question asked at a door by someone who could not make herself knock again.

The climb up was seven hundred and eleven steps out, and Suri counted every one of them aloud, and the vaults rang her count back a quarter-tone flat, and Dar did not correct her, and the corrected rhythm — his steps, her numbers, the deep following one beat behind — carried them up through the dead First Vessel's cathedral and past the racked stamps and out into air that tasted of iron and salt and ordinary smoke. Dawn was a rumor over the storm-walls. The city above went on defaulting and enduring and being counted by whoever still bothered to count it.

And above all of it, on an attic desk in the Saltstairs, folded in a sterile wrap under a dead lamp, the page waited: eight names, one sigil, one circled city, one word. *RECLAIM.* The sister had been the question. Dar was beginning to understand that the Gardener was the answer, and answers, in Ashkarad, arrived with their invoices already attached.

CHAPTER 33

Eight Cities, One Route

The question changed shape in the three days after the descent, the way a debt changes shape when the debtor finally reads the contract to the end. It had been *what is below.* It was now *who put her there*, and the answer had been lying folded in a sterile wrap on the attic desk for the better part of a season, waiting for him to stop flinching from it.

They made the cold cellar into an audit room. It was already the only chamber in the city where Vahid felt at home — the Vein-ladder chalked down one wall, his prohibition chalked under it, the girl's spiral map pinned beside both with its innermost ring lettered *soon* — and Roya arrived with her arms full of salvage and turned it into a cartographer's parish. Charts everywhere, unrolled, weighted with sterilizer jars and river stones: coastal charts of the fog-sea lifted from the census fires and dried flat; two Warden tide-tables with the Index's burn-scorch across their corners; and a cloth-bound route-book of the Caravan League — overland trade guild, surveyors and freight-clerks, the people who moved goods between the cities that still had goods — copied out in her own cramped, exact hand years ago and priced, then, at more than a harvest-floor saw in a month.

Dar laid Vey's registry page flat under the lamp.

It was vellum, and it was old, and it had been handled the way sacred things are handled — along the edges, by gloved fingers, never flat — until the night a Custodian had come apart into lace and left it behind for a surgeon to steal. He had carried it from her sanctum folded against his ribs, which even then had struck some unburned part of him as the correct filing: documents of this kind traveled next to the collateral. Eight city names, ranked in a column in a cramped and patient script: *Lowmark. The Vigil. Gullet. Sarn. Weep. Ossuar. Brack. Hallowfen.* And a ninth line, beneath them all, circled in red ink gone the brown of old blood: *Ashkarad* — with its entry not stamped BLOOMED but marked in the ledger-script he had last seen scratched into the salt of a shaft landing: *VESSEL: FLED—RECLAIM.* Below the column, one word: *RECLAIM.* Below the word, a title, unsigned: *GARDENER.*

Beside each name, repeated like a surveyor's mark on a boundary stone, grew the flower. Five petals. Blooming from a crack.

"Read me the margins again," Vahid said. He had his lens out — a brass loupe older than the Church's patent on anything, mended the same way his spectacles were mended, with wire and refusal — and he bent over the page one-handed, turning it a degree at a time, the stump

of his left arm braced against the table's edge for ballast. "Not the words. The *material*. I have been reading what the page says for a season. Tonight I want to read what the page is."

"Vellum," Dar said. "Calfskin, by the grain — no, wait." He adjusted the lamp and looked again, and the grain looked back, and the grain was wrong. Calfskin had pores. This had *cells.* Small, closed, regular, like the surface of a leaf seen under a clinic glass. "Not skin. Leaf. It's pressed leaf."

"Leaf," Vahid agreed, without surprise, in the tone of a man crossing an item off a list he wrote years ago. "And the marks?"

Dar moved the lens to the flower beside *Lowmark.* "Ink. Black ink—"

The lens stopped his mouth.

The black was not ink. Under the loupe, at eleven powers, the sigil resolved into granularity — into grain — into thousands of tiny bodies, ovate, dark, matte, with the dull authority of seed-coat, pressed into the vellum's grain the way pollen presses into the varnish of a thing left long in a flowering room. Not one mark of pigment anywhere. The flower was a *deposit.* The names might be ink; the sigil was not. The sigil had been grown there, or shaken there, or dusted there, the way a tailor dusts charcoal through a pricked pattern to carry a design onto cloth.

"Roya," Dar said. "Your loupe. Now. Look at the *Lowmark* flower and tell me what you see."

Roya bent. The lamp slid off her brass mask, forehead to chin, so that her reflection hung in the room doubled and featureless. For a long moment she said nothing, and the mask said nothing, and the silence had the specific pressure of a professional measuring the worth of her own trade.

"Pattern-pricking," she said at last, metallic and flat. "But for a route, not a hem. Look —" her white-scarred hand hovered above the column without touching it, moving name to name, "— every flower sits on a puncture. Needle-marks. Fine ones, through the sheet, at the flower's heart. And between the flowers — follow the grain — there are more, a line of them, faint as pinholes in a spy-hole. The page has been *pricked*, Dar. Someone stitched this list with a needle, city to city, like a pattern come apart from the cloth."

"And the black?"

"Is what came through the needle," Roya said. "A pattern-maker pricks and pounces. Whoever made this pricked and *pollinated.*"

Ilay's voice came from the corner, unasked, unhurried, the way her voice always arrived — laid down flat, like something already true. "It's warm," she said. She had come forward without anyone noticing, the way she did, and she was looking at the page with her river-stone eyes. "The paper. It's warm, like the door under the water place." She considered. "The door was warm too. Where the lady waits."

She went back to her charcoal. Nobody in the cellar found it necessary to ask which lady.

The cellar was quiet except for the lamp's small economy of oil and, from the ward overhead, the muffled arithmetic of Milla's medicine counts.

"Say it plainly," Vahid said.

"It's an itinerary," Roya said. "A route. Needle-run, start to finish, through all nine." Her hand stopped above the red circle. "The names are stops."

Suri, from the doorway, with her sleeves rolled and her ruined carbon scales catching the lamp: "Then run the route."

So they ran the route.

It took the better part of two hours, because the page did not give up its order to the eye — the needle-line ran *Lowmark* to *the Vigil*, the Vigil to *Gullet*, Gullet to Sarn, Sarn to Weep, Weep to Ossuar, Ossuar to *Brack*, Brack to Hallowfen, and from Hallowfen the pin-holes ran on, off the sheet, to the ninth line, to the circled name — and the eye kept wanting the column order to be the truth, and the column order was a lie, the way a bill's subtotals are a lie until you sum them. Roya pinned her charts flat, plotted the eight names by their salt-lane bearings and the League's route-book, and the needle-line came alive on the maps as a curve that wandered inboard and out, hill country to harbor, monastery coast to reef shelf, wandering as a creditor wanders when he is in no hurry and knows the debtor is not going anywhere.

"Brack first," Roya said finally, and set her fingertip on the far western shore of the fog-sea. "Then Hallowfen. Then Ossuar, upland. Weep. Sarn. Then Gullet — the reef shelf, here, on the carcass grounds. Then the Vigil, on the monastery coast. Then Lowmark, last of the eight — the drowned port. And then—" her finger came up the charts, across the fog-sea's narrow middle, to the salt-port drawn in her own younger hand, ringed with its storm-walls, and stopped. "Then here. Ashkarad. Last stop on the round."

"Two entries over," Suri said. She had come to the table's edge without ceremony and was looking at the column the way she looked at any column, for totals. "Brack. Two entries over from ours, on the sheet." Her finger rested near it, not touching. "And the League's route-book has no traffic on the Brack lane since before the storm. Freight don't skip a lane for weather.

Freight skips a lane when there's no port left to bill."

"Eight cities," Vahid said slowly, "and the flower bloomed in eight of them. BLOOMED—TRUE THRONE, the stamps said. And in the ninth, the vessel fled." He straightened, and his voice went to the lecture-register that was his way of not shouting. "It is not a map of an empire, boy. Empires list what they hold. This lists what is *owed.* It is a collection round. Sown a century ago by one hand — nine seeds, nine debts — and now the hand has come to call them in, city by city, in an order a clerk chose, and our city is the last entry on the sheet because our entry is the one that says FLED."

"RECLAIM," Suri said. Flat. Reading it off the page without looking at it, because she had long since memorized it.

"Reclaim," Vahid agreed. "Not punish. Not conquer. *Reclaim* — the word a ledger uses when the collateral has wandered off the books and the account-holder wants his security back." He looked at Dar, and there was no gin in his face at all. "You are carrying the collateral, boy. You have been carrying it since a dying thief crawled into a canal with a cracked reliquary. And somewhere out past the seawalls there is an account-holder with a needle, working down the column toward us."

Nobody said the rest of it. The rest of it was Ilay, nine years old, registry-grade PERFECT, the garden's daughter, drawing silence-swirls with a charcoal stub — sibling stock, active — and the rest of it was that the round had already reached the cities two entries over from Ashkarad's line, and the sea lanes between here and there had been empty of League traffic for a month, and empty lanes were either an omen or an opening, depending on which side of the ledger you kept your stool. Vahid began packing his lens into its chamois with exaggerated care, which was what the Professor did instead of weeping or drinking, in the hours when he managed both withholdings at once.

It was Milla, of all people, who ended the argument by accident. She came down with the evening medicine slips, saw the lamp burning on the page, and put out her hand to move the lamp-shade from her eyes — and the light fell full on the sigil beside *Hallowfen*, the last flower on the sheet, warm as a hand for the first time since it had been pressed.

The pollen moved.

Not scattered. Not disturbed. The grain in the flower's black petals *turned* — each tiny ovate body swinging on its own invisible axis, slowly, with the gravity of compass needles finding north or sunflowers finding the sun — until all of them, every seed-body in every flower on the page, lay pointed the same way. Toward the wall. Through the wall. West and down, where the charts hung and beyond the charts, toward the tide-line, the storm-walls, the

seawalls, the sea.

Roya looked at the page for a long time. The mask reflected the lamp back as one blank coin of light. Somewhere above them a Warden bell tolled the wrong hour — the bells had been unreliable since the Choir died, and the city had stopped trusting them, which meant the city now told time by hunger and lamplight, which meant, depending on your ledger, that the city was either freer or later than it had ever been.

"Not ink," she said. "Not a signature. *Bait.*" A pause, the length of one flat heartbeat. "No. Not bait. A receipt that knows where its debtor lives."

The pollen held its new bearing, patient as everything else that had ever been planted in this city, and pointed at the sea.

CHAPTER 34

The Surveyor's Kindness

The grace storm spent itself against the storm-walls for two days, and when it blew out, the wind that followed it brought the caravans.

They came up the shore road in the storm's wake the way they always had — League wagons riding three and four abreast, hulls of curved wicker under salt-stiffened canvas, their storm-sails furled along the spines like the fins of sleeping fish, draft-beasts steaming in the washed light. Ashkarad had traded with the Caravan League for longer than the Chorus had kept its ledgers; the League moved freight, grain, glass, and rumor over the hills and around the coast while the sea lanes sat empty, and a city that had just watched a page of pollen point seaward could be forgiven for watching the shore road instead.

The man who came to the clinic on the second morning after the storm arrived without escort, without letters of credit, and without — and this was the part that put every sense Dar owned on watch — without a price.

He was fifty-odd, weathered to the color of old rope, with a surveyor's compact build and the soft, precise hands of a man who had spent thirty years measuring things and never once harvesting them. Grey at the temples, grey-blue League coat brushed clean, a plumb-line coiled at his belt and a slate case under one arm. He stood in the clinic doorway among the smell of antiseptic and salt-damp stone, ducked his head to the lintel like a man entering a church of a different denomination, and introduced himself.

"Coram Hesh. Surveyor, out of the League, overland and coast. We've a custom after hard storms — a kindness, some call it, though I'd never presume — structural surveys, no charge, no obligation. Your district took the wind hard. The Saltstairs always does." He smiled, and the smile had patience in it the way some ledgers have patience, line after line, no hurry. "I'm told this house stitched up half the ward for free through the storm nights. It seemed the right place to start."

He is everything Vey was not, Dar thought, and the thought was the trap, and he walked into it with his eyes open. Vey had offered tea, terms, and endearments with the warmth of a stoved room in winter; Vey had priced the air between two cups. This man offered nothing but competence and asked nothing but the lint between the floorboards, and in Ashkarad that was so far outside the known market that it rang against the teeth like a coin too pure to be true.

"We'll take the survey," Dar said. "And you'll take payment."

"I won't."

"Then you'll take it from someone else. Nothing in this city is free, Surveyor. It's only billed late. You'll let me know whose account you're drawing on, and we'll get along."

Hesh looked at him for a moment — looked, Dar noted, not at the silvery veins at his collar but at his hands, a tradesman's glance, tool to tool — and inclined his head as if Dar had made a fair opening bid. "The League writes its own costs," he said mildly. "Call the payment an old debt of mine to this coast. I was here once, before your storm-walls went up. The city did right by me. Surveys are how I file the interest." He set his slate case on the door ledge, opened it, and took out chalk, wax-paper packets, a folding brass rule, and a small knife for taking samples, all of it worn to a shine. "Where hurts most?"

* * *

He worked for six days, and he was very good.

Dar watched him the way he watched a new drug in a ward: dosage, effect, side-effects. Hesh walked the Saltstairs from the cistern stairs to the topmost catwalks, and where he walked he mended by advice — a props-and-braces schedule for a tenement bowing over the fourth stair, a drain-cut for the cistern that had been flooding the undercroft since before the war of ledgers, load-lines chalked neat as type on beam-ends and door-frames, each mark a small clean glyph of circles and stems that meant, apparently, something exact to the League. He propped a wall with two apprentices and a jack-screw while its family stood in the alley holding their furniture. He set a child's broken kite-spar without being asked and told the child it had been a surveying instrument, which was a lie, and a kind one, and the child kept it.

The district took to him the way a ward takes to a nurse who remembers names. By the third day, cook-fires saved him bowls. By the fourth, the Gavel tallymen had stopped marking the alley when he passed, which any auditor will tell you is either a pardon or an oversight. Milla Ferun, who had not trusted an official face since the morning Borin told her to destroy a printout and smiled while saying it, brought the surveyor tea on the fourth afternoon, unprompted, with her own hands — and Dar watched her do it from the ward window and felt the ground shift somewhere under his certainties, because the kindness looked real from every angle he could afford, and kindness that looks real from every angle is either the rarest entry in the city's books or the most expensive.

Vahid watched him from the cellar doorway with the flat hostility of a man watching a rival thesis defend well. "No one is unpriced," he muttered, on the fourth night, glasses off, polishing them on his sleeve with his one hand. "Show me a free kindness in this city and I will show you the invoice underneath, written in something less visible than ink. Vey used tea. This

one uses *ladders.*" He set the spectacles back on his nose. "Watch the hands, boy. I have watched hands all my life. Hands tell you what the ledger won't."

Roya said nothing, which from Roya was surveillance. Suri said nothing, which from Suri was an investigation.

On the fifth evening, Suri stopped saying nothing.

* * *

She found him in the clinic's back ward at the changing of the lamp-oil, and she found him the way she found everything, by counting: three wax-paper packets laid on the instrument tray, folded with clinical neatness, and the surveyor's small knife, and the little brass scoop, and Hesh crouched at the waste-bin with a curl of bloodied gauze lifted between two fingers as delicately as a clerk lifts a voucher.

"Forty-one steps of your marks on the beams," Suri said. "Nine packets of wall-scrapings in your case, by weight. And now my ward's dressings." She did not move from the doorway. The carbon scales of her ruined graft caught the lamplight dully, night sky with a hole kicked in it. "Rate it for me, Surveyor. What's the going price of my bin."

Hesh straightened. He did not startle — that was the first entry in the account Suri was keeping; working men startle — and he did not apologize overmuch, which was the second. He wrapped the gauze curl into a fresh packet, folded it with the others, and met her flat gaze with his mild one.

"Subsidence records," he said. "The Saltstairs sits on salt, and salt eats, and what the ground takes, the League logs. These houses are built of the city and on the city, and the city is —" he considered the word with a craftsman's honesty — "organic. Walls here carry more tissue than timber, and tissue settles at rates we can read. Your ward's dressings tell me what your walls are doing to your patients. It's waste," he added, with the first flicker of something that was almost humility, "and it's logged, and it's burned at season's end. I'd show you the page, but it's in League cipher and would only insult you."

Suri looked at him for a slow count of five.

"Everything's waste," she said, "until it's filed." She took one packet from the tray — the oldest, the wall-scrapings from the cellar, from the chamber where the Vein-ladder and a girl's spiral map hung on the walls — and weighed it in her palm, and Hesh watched her do it with a face like a tide-table. "This one you'll leave," she said. "It's mine. The rest you can bill to the ground." And she put the packet in her apron, and went out, and did not tell Dar until the lamps were banked.

"She took a sample of my samples," Hesh told Dar the next morning, rueful, presenting a fresh-cut prop-beam like a man presenting references. "Your courier has a court's nose. Requisition the packet back if you like; it's only chalk-dust and dead wall."

"I will," Dar said. "I audit everything in my house. It's a habit of the formerly harvested."

"Then we'll get along," said Hesh, and hummed at his work.

* * *

It happened while they braced the undercroft beam, Dar holding the jack, Hesh setting the chocks, the two of them working in the easy silence of tools that fit. The Nerve Vein was always open a crack now — the city's pain played under his hearing like water under ice, and he kept the door of it narrowed, a surgeon's-field wall at a walk — but the undercroft was quiet, and the humming was *close*, and it came through the narrowed door before Dar had decided to listen to it.

The lullaby.

Three notes up, one hanging pause, two notes down — the opening bars, complete, correct, rendered in a soft closed-mouth hum with a working man's breath behind it, and Dar's hands went still on the jack-screw so smoothly that even Hesh read it as settling load. The song that the woman in white gloves had hummed over the planted sleepers. The song between Vey's two cups. The song under the salt-glass door. The song whose owner he had paid away and could not name. Here it was, note for note, in the mouth of a free surveyor from a caravan out of the empty sea lanes — note for note, except for one.

Where the pause hung — the hanging pause, the held breath in the middle of the phrase that every true singer of it kept open like a debt left on the books — Hesh sang a note. Small. Flat. A quarter-tone held where the original left blank, fitted in like a substituted figure in a column, entered so smoothly that only an auditor who had audited his own grief would ever catch it. Forgeries fill blanks. Originals keep them. Dar held the jack and kept his face at settling-load and let the man finish the wall, and filed the note where he now filed such things, banked, not spent — the Mind Vein's one free trade, an observation carried into the swept halls and shut in a room with no door.

That night, the first hard frost of the season came down the Saltstairs, and Dar found it when he made his rounds with the lamp.

The clinic's windows had bloomed.

Every pane — ward, stair, cellar-light, attic — wore the same grey lace, frost furred into five-petaled rosettes by the morning, and every rosette on every pane pointed one way,

bloom-tips aligned compass-true as if each window had been surveyed by the same patient hand. Dar stood in the dark ward with the lamp down and followed their bearing out through the glass, across the frost-furred roofs, down the tide-gate hill to the League's lodging-house by the shore road, where a surveyor out of the caravans slept with his chalk and his wax-paper packets and his one wrong note.

The frost pointed at Hesh's lodgings, and it did not waver, and the city that had stopped trusting its bells told him, in the only handwriting it had left, exactly where its attention had fixed: the same direction, that same night, as the pollen on the page.

CHAPTER 35

Harvest Marks

The Choirmaster had buried no one, because the Choratorium dead did not need burying; they needed dusting, and labels, and someone to keep the thieves out, and of those three duties he was equal to two.

He lived in the reliquary corridors now — had lived there since the night the city's forty-year chord died mid-note and the Church's cathedral-clinic became a carcass with a floor plan. He was half-starved by choice and schedule rather than necessity: there was food in the annexed halls below, Mother Gavel's people left leavings with the regularity of interest payments, and pride was a currency he had audited and found himself overdrawn in. He ate what the dead had eaten, which was nothing, and he kept the hours of the dead, which were all of them, and he tended the corridors the way a man tends the ledger of a house he burned down himself — not because the entries can be corrected, but because someone who can still read them has a duty to stand at the shelf.

The scavengers came at the lamp-less hours, mostly. Boys from the Hammers' side after the truce frayed, glass-hunters with pry-bars, one memorable pair of Sisters who had repented of the Chorus and looted it. He turned them all with the same instruments: a baritone voice kept in tune by forty years of harvest-floor command, a Chorus enforcer's bill-hook he had never once swung, and the corridors themselves, which did most of the work. People who enter a hall of dead glass carrying the expectation of treasure leave it carrying something else. He had watched the arithmetic happen on their faces, the revaluation, the entry made and then reversed. *Empty,* they thought. *No. Not empty,* the glass said. *Filed.*

Mother Gavel's people held the annexed halls below him and left him to his upper dark, having audited him once, early, through a delegation of two ledgermen who had climbed as far as the first reliquary rank and decided, on some creditor's instinct he respected, that the man in the ruins was already collectible enough. The Gavel wanted the city's fear on its books and not its guilt. He was a liability in the first column and an asset in no column, which in her arithmetic made him furniture. Furniture was left where it stood.

His right wrist had healed crooked. The cutter's grip had done it, on the night a boy named Elias had left the table alive; the joint clicked now on damp days like a lock testing itself, and the Choirmaster had come to use the click as a metronome for the slow work — dusting reliquary glass, righting the little brass name-plates, re-inking, with a stolen pencil, the labels that no one would ever read: *Kaelen. Elara. Elias.* Not the Church's labels. His. The

Church's had said yield.

He was re-inking Elias's when he heard the boots, and knew them for careful boots, and put down the pencil.

* * *

She came up the reliquary corridor with the lamp carried high and a courier two steps behind her, and the lamp-light ran along the brass of her mask, forehead to chin, and made of her face one smooth coin of metal. The Cartographer. Dead, the trade had said; unmasked, the trade had said; severed, the trade had said, her song-lobe cut out of the city's listening the way a tumor is cut. The trade said many things. The Cartographer walked his corridors at midnight with rubbings under her arm, which was a living person's errand.

"Surveyor's marks," she said, without greeting, laying them on the reliquary shelf one by one as if laying cards: chalk rubbings on cheap paper, lifted from beam-ends and door-frames, each a small clean glyph of circles and stems. "Drawn by a guest of my city. Free-handed, exact, and everywhere. I have forty-one of them from one district alone. I don't deal in what things say. I deal in what things are. Tell me what these are."

He looked. He was careful to look the way he had been trained to look, in order, the way he had taught initiates to audit a harvest district — routes first, yields second, gates third — and he got as far as the third rubbing before his hands went cold, and by the seventh he had sat down on a dead organ's plinth like a man whose margin call had arrived, and when he raised his eyes to the masked woman his face had gone grey as the dust.

"Where," he said, and his baritone came out a size smaller, "did your guest draw these."

"On our beams. Our stairs. Our doors. He asked permission for every one."

"He would." The Choirmaster heard his own voice do the thing it had done for forty years — go smooth, go level, go sweet as a graded hymn — and hated it, and let it, because the information deserved a steady instrument. "These are harvest-routing marks. Church-grade. The real grammar, the inner hand — not the street catechism, the *working* set." His crooked wrist clicked as he turned a rubbing toward the lamp. "This one is a route-mark: this lane carries wagons outbound, loaded. This is a yield-mark — see the stem with the two barbs? A count of souls by ward, expected yield, graded in the barbs. This is a gate-mark: here the wagons enter, here they are blooded, here they leave. And this—" the eighth rubbing, the one with the small clean flower inside two circles, "—is a claim-mark. Circled flower. Not a survey of what is. A plan for what will be."

"And in a working set," the Cartographer said, metallic, flat, "what does a full district of them make?"

"A master sheet." He said it the way a man names his own gallstone. "Every tithe I ever planned had a master sheet. The marks you can see are the field-copies — read them together, in their grammar, and they draw the master: one map, one hand, one round. Routes, yields, gates, claims." He looked at the rubbings the way he had once looked at chalk-boards of children's grades. "A city-wide tithe, Cartographer. Ward by ward, lane by lane, with the yields already graded. I drew plans like this for the Marrowworks district eleven times in forty years. I know my own hand's grandchildren when I see them. Your guest is doing a harvest."

The courier — the famous one, the counter, the woman with the ruined carbon arm and the splint gone hard as old debt — said nothing through all of it. She had gone to the shelf where the labels sat, and she was reading them. Kaelen. Elara. Elias. Her lips moved on the names without sound, pricing each one, and the Choirmaster watched her read and understood that of the three people in this corridor, she was the one most likely to kill him, and that she would be right.

"There's a second thing," he said. "Since you've come for inventory."

* * *

The reliquary archive lay two corridors down, and he walked them to it with the bill-hook as a walking staff and his heart going like a boy's at a grading. The archive was rank on rank of dead glass, reliquaries dark, the choir organs gone to silence and to dust-dull shine — the greatest choir Ashkarad had ever silenced, and he had tuned it — and behind the fourth rank, behind a false shelf he had built himself with a joiner's patience in another life, stood a lead-lined tithe-box with the Church's Debt-Stamp rusted on its hasp.

"When the order came down to burn the harvest-registry," he said, "I was the one holding the lamp-oil. The Index wanted ash; the Open Counts wanted ash with witnesses. It went into the braziers in the tithe-yard, every volume, and the fire was green and greedy, and I stood over it with a rake the way I stood over everything the Church ever made me tend." His wrist clicked. He opened the box. Inside, wrapped in oilcloth dry as wafers, lay a ledger the size of a paving stone. "I pulled one out. One. I have told myself for two years that I saved it for the courts, for the reckoning, for the day someone would come down here asking after names. That is a lie with good posture. I saved it because I could not be the last man who knew what we were *for*, and now the man who knows is—"

He stopped. Unwrapped it. The harvest-registry, unburned, whole: the vessel list entire, every name the Church had ever entered, grades and graft-numbers and resales, in the

cramped patient script of clerks who had been him.

The courier stepped forward and looked down into the box, and her face did not change, and her face changed completely.

"Is mine in it," she said. Not a question, but he answered it as one, because a ledger-keeper pays debts of grammar too.

"Kaveh, Suri," he said. "Graft-number and page. Resold three times, per the transfer columns. I filed it twice — once to the debt, once to the stock." He closed the box, softly, the way one closes a coffin on someone still breathing. "It stays with me. I am not bargaining with it and I am not selling it and I will not hand it to a cutter, a warden, or a queen. When the reckoner comes to read it — and one is coming, Cartographer, your guest's marks say so — he reads it with me standing beside the shelf. I made the entries. I will render the account. That is the only penance Ashkarad has ever priced that I can actually pay."

The masked woman took out her charts then, and chalk, and began to work on the archive floor itself, right there among the dead glass — laying the rubbings out, writing in the field-marks, linking route to route the way she had once linked a dream's towers — and he watched a master sheet assemble itself on the stones of his own cathedral, drawn by a severed oracle in a brass mask from the grandchildren of his own grammar. It took her less than an hour. It had taken the Church's planning office, in his day, a season and six clerks, and the result had never once been so clean. The wards took shape. The lanes took shape. The yield-barbs clustered where the living lived thickest, and the route-marks ran inward from every quarter like veins running toward a heart.

And in the district where the marks ran cleanest and newest, where a free clinic stood over a cold cellar with a chalk ladder on its wall, the Cartographer chalked the claim-mark whole: a small five-petaled flower inside two circles, circled again for the master.

"Ashkarad's page," she said, metallic, flat, final, "being redrawn by hand."

The Choirmaster looked at it for a long time. Forty years ago a cutter's grip had not yet broken his wrist and a boy named Elias had not yet been welcome to the choir, and he had stood in a harvest amphitheater and asked a bleeding stranger his one true question, the question the Church had trained him never to ask and then trained him to ask only of others: *ask yourself what the city is for.* He had spent his life answering it in the only grammar he was given. The answer had filled these corridors. The answer was in the box.

"Ask yourself what the city is for," he said aloud, to the masked woman, to the counting courier, to the claim-mark drying on the stones. "I asked it of a cutter once, as a threat. Now I ask it of every wall in this district, as a warning. Your guest is surveying for the answer." He

set his hand, crooked wrist clicking, flat on the closed box. "And I no longer believe he intends to like it."

CHAPTER 36

The Barge from Brack

The tide-gate bells rang thirteen times, and Suri counted every one, because one of them did not belong.

The gates had kept a twelve-bell schedule since before her mother owed her first debt — six bells flood, six bells ebb, and the harbor-wards paid the ringer a wage that outlasted three reforms of the currency. Thirteen bells meant a fault in the mechanism. Thirteen bells meant a clerk somewhere had entered an extra line. Suri stood on the tide-gate catwalk in the grey before dawn with her hands in her coat pockets and her ledger-heart doing what it always did: finding the line that had been added without authorization.

Below her, the harbor of Ashkarad lay like a purse turned out and shaken. Two months of silence had emptied it of traffic. The tithe-barges that once worked the coast were burned, scuttled, or sold for hull-iron; the chandlers' rows stood shuttered; the fog-sea beyond the seawalls kept its own accounts and shared nothing. Only salvage moved now — Suri's crews, couriers turned wreckers with permission, pulling name-pages and copper out of the city's drowned margins the way she had once pulled them out of burning census halls.

The fog opened, and the barge came through.

It came against the current. That was the first entry Suri filed and the one she never afterwards amended. The ebb was running hard out through the gates — she could see it combing the pilings, white-threaded, going the way water goes — and the barge came up that sliding hill of sea at a walker's pace, unhurried, without oars, without sail, without one living hand on any of its lines. A tithe-barge, forty feet, black-hulled, of a pattern the Ashkarad yards had not built in her lifetime. Its wake opened behind it like a ledger ruled in reverse.

Every surface of it was furred with grey frost-petals.

Not black. Suri knew the black ones; the whole city knew them, the frost-blooms that had crawled the syndicate banners and pointed compass-true at the Choratorium, the ones that pointed now, on the clinic windows, at a surveyor's hired room over a chandler's shop. These petals were grey — ash-grey, ledger-grey, the grey of a thing that had finished its working life — and they grew in thick felted banks along the gunwales, the tiller, the booms, the faces of the dead.

Because the barge was crewed by the dead.

They stood at their posts the way poor men stand at posts they have stopped being able to leave: upright, patient, salt-stiffened. Six at the lines. One at the tiller, both hands lashed to it with tarred twine. They wore the grey coats and brass cuff-guards of counting-house watermen, a city's livery that Suri had never seen and knew instantly she was seeing — because the harvest-registry copy the Choirmaster had carried out of the burning listed Brack second from the top, two entries over Ashkarad's circled name, and everything on this deck was grey as that page's margins.

Someone had paid them. That was the detail she filed third and kept longest. Sewn into every cuff, flat and neat as a kept promise, was a coin — harbour silver, worn thin, a dead man's wage delivered in full where no dead hand could spend it. The auditors of Brack, she thought, settle their accounts. They just never say to whom.

"Boards or burn?" asked Dess, the youngest of her crews, a boy who had come to her out of the census-fire carrying three names that were not his.

"We board," Suri said. "Dead men don't file complaints, and I want the manifest."

Dess looked at the grey felt on the gunwales and asked the sensible question. "What if it's the same sickness? What if it comes off on us?"

"It's not a sickness," Suri said. "It's a signature. Signatures don't take. They only say who signed." She said it with more certainty than she carried, which was the oldest trick in a courier's book: you quote the rate before you know if you can pay it.

* * *

She counted as she crossed. Eleven planks of the gangway she had her crews lay. Fourteen feet to the main hatch. Six dead, one at the tiller, one — a seventh — folded at the base of the mast like a receipt that had been crumpled and kept anyway. The cold on deck was wrong; it came off the hull itself, off the felted petals, a cold with direction and intent, and when her glove brushed a petal it did not crumble. It turned. All of them turned — she watched it happen in the corner of her eye, slow as a clock hand — every grey flower on that deck swinging, degree by degree, until every petal pointed not back the way the barge had come but inland. At the city. At the gates. At her.

Noted, she thought. Filed.

The hold was empty. That was the manifest: nothing. No organ-jars, no reliquary straw, no tithe-crates, no ballast worth the name. Just cold, and the smell — old rope, tallow, and under it something sweetish and clinical, like a sickroom that had been paid off. The Lily's kind of smell, she thought, and did not say it, because Dar was a mile away behind the clinic door and

she did not put his burdens into words where the wind could carry them.

She found the survivor in the stern, in the nest of dead men's coats behind the tiller-post — a woman folded in among them the way a clerk folds herself into a strong room at night, deliberately, by design. Alive. Grey lips, salt-scoured hands, the cuff-guards of a counting-house senior, ink-stains gone brown on her fingers. Her eyes opened when Suri's lamp touched her, and they were not a dying animal's eyes; they went over Suri's face, her coat, her crews, the deck — counting, Suri realized, the way she herself counted, out of the same unpayable habit — and then the woman shook her head, once, at whatever total she reached.

Her mouth was open. Her tongue was gone. Cut at the root, old work, healed wrong.

She was clutching a slate to her chest with both arms, the way other people hold children or money.

"Easy," Suri said, which was not a word she used, and then, because the woman's eyes kept counting her, she gave her what she gave counters: the truth in figures. "You're aboard a dead barge in a live city. Four of mine, one of you, seven of them. Nobody's collecting today."

The woman looked at her for three heartbeats. Then she turned the slate, slowly, and showed it to her.

Rows of tally-marks, five-bar gates, clerk-neat, running down the slate in columns like a debt schedule. The upper rows were steady. The lower rows wavered. The last line held a total — a large one, unfinished, the final stroke of it half-drawn, as if the hand that was drawing it had heard something on the stairs.

Suri did not need the tongue the auditors had taken. It was a count of the dead of Brack, she thought. She kept counting even then. That was the whole of her — they left her the arithmetic and took the voice off it.

* * *

The pulse-reader they found lashed under the tiller-post, still turning.

A Syndic Warden's machine, brass and bone, hand-cranked — but the crank was not a hand's. It was geared to a vane aft, to the wake, to the barge's own motion through the water, so that as long as the barge moved the machine turned, and as long as the machine turned it printed. They found the slips beneath it in a drift, hundreds of them, identical, furred at the edges with grey frost like everything else on the boat — page after page after page of the same census, printed and reprinted across however many miles of cold water lay between a silent city and this one.

Suri read the top slip by lamplight, and her face did not change, because Dess was watching, and because her face was the one part of her that had never once been entered into evidence.

BRACK POPULATION — 0.

Below it, in the machine's small stamped capitals, the second line, on every slip, the same:

FINAL COUNT FILED. RECEIPT DELIVERED.

Not a wreck, she thought, standing in the drift of identical pages with the grey petals turning slowly around her boots, all of them pointing inland. Not driftwood. Not an accident of current and grief. A receipt is addressed. Someone printed a city's closing entries, lashed the machine to a dead crew, and sent the account forward along the round — and the round, she knew, she had watched Dar work it out under Vahid's lens with Roya's charts in circles on the chalkboard — the round ends here. Ashkarad is the last name on the page. This was addressed to us.

She took one slip for the clinic and left the drift to keep its total. Then she had her crews carry the woman — slate and all, slate most of all — down the gangway, eleven planks back to the living side of the gate, and she did not look at the grey petals as they passed because she already knew, without looking, that they had all turned to follow.

* * *

The walk up from the harbor she spent on figures, because figures were the only furniture that fit the room in her head. Eight cities on Vey's page, eight flower-marks, one circle in red ink. Brack harvested two entries up the list — silent, reclaimed, its seed cut out — and its population machine printing zero in an endless identical column, like a heart that had learned only the one word. Her own page rode where it always rode, inside her coat, over the ruined graft: her name, her graft-number, resold three times, legible still. For two months she had kept that page as evidence, as ammunition, as a joke she told herself in the dark — they wanted this? this is what they paid for? — and now, walking behind a tongueless woman who had survived a city by the thickness of a ledger line, the joke wore through to the bone under it.

A city is a page, she thought. She had known it all her life; Ashkarad said so in its sleep, in every stamped chit and compounded tithe. She had just never believed anyone would come to collect the whole book at once — or that a count could be delivered like a death notice, machine-printed, addressed, and stamped FINAL.

And the woman had been left in the margin. That was the part Suri's ledger kept returning to as she climbed. You do not leave a survivor in a delivered receipt — a receipt closes. Unless the survivor is also an entry. Unless somebody, somewhere, still has a column with the woman's number in it, open and accruing, and sent the barge ahead not to announce a harvest but to deliver a reminder: we know one of you is missing from the count, and we know where the missing walk.

At the clinic door, Milla Ferun was waiting with a lamp, drawn out of her sleep by a courier's knock, and Milla took one look at the cuff-guards and the ink-stains and the slate and said, in the flat voice of a woman identifying her own kind across a ruined system: "Counting-house. Senior grade. They kept one alive to — " and stopped, because the end of that sentence was a thing none of them had a column for.

The woman looked up at Milla. Then at the clinic — the cots, the chalkboards, the walls where, along every sill and frame, the black frost-blooms of Ashkarad's own quiet garden grew in their slow way — and she began, very softly, with no tongue to do it with, to shake.

Suri got her inside, sat her down, wrapped her in sailcloth, and put the slate in her lap where her arms knew how to hold it. Then she laid the one salvaged slip on the table under the lamp, smooth, face-up, and stood looking at the machine-stamped truth of it with her thumb resting, without her permission, on the hidden edge of her own page inside her coat.

BRACK POPULATION — 0.

"Somebody deliver us the bill," she said to the empty room, "when they finish counting ours."

CHAPTER 37

What the Mute Carried

They put the woman from Brack in the cold cellar, in the cot nearest the stairs, because she could not say where it hurt and because everyone in the clinic had already, without discussion, stopped calling her the survivor. Vahid wanted that name entered and closed. Dar had learned not to argue with the Professor's triage until he had triaged it himself.

"She hasn't slept," Suri reported, at the cellar door, in her flat counting voice. "Four hours. She counts instead. Her fingers, the cot slats, our heartbeats — I've watched her take us all. She's not afraid, Mehran. She's auditing."

Milla Ferun sat with her for most of a day and came up the stairs looking like a woman who had seen her own trade buried at sea. "She's senior grade," Milla said. "Look at the cuff-guards, the way she rules a margin with her thumbnail before she'll write anything. In the Marrowworks we'd have paid her wage twice over and called it a bargain. They cut out the tongue of the best counter I ever stood next to." Milla's hands were salt-white at the nails, always now; she hid them in her sleeves. "Whatever they took a city's voices for, they took hers on purpose."

Vahid heard all of it, polishing his spectacles on his sleeve with the maddening one-handed economy he had learned since the amputation, and gave his ruling from the chalk ladder where he lectured like a man ascending a gallows he had built himself. "You are going to read her," he said. Not a question.

"She's the only witness the route has produced," Dar said. "And she's trying to give it to us. She's had that slate in her arms since the tide-gates. She's not guarding it. She's queuing."

"With the Mind Vein." Vahid set the spectacles back and became, for a moment, entirely the Professor of Impossible Anatomy, the gin gone out of his voice like water out of a cracked bowl. "Then hear the terms before you open the door, boy, because the instrument won't repeat them. The Mind Vein is not a lamp you shine into other people's windows. It is architecture. You will open your own halls and hers at once, and the traffic between two occupied minds is billed both ways. And the ledger that collects the fee does not take fractions. It does not take almost. It takes one memory, true and whole — and it selects."

"Can't I select?"

"You can carry an offering," Vahid said. "You cannot choose the till. That is what makes it a ledger and not a theft."

Dar stood a long moment in the cold. Below, through the floor, he could feel the deep heartbeat that had lived under the city since the salt-glass door — one beat behind his own, patient, immense, leaning. In his own mind, past the swept rooms, past the corridor where his mother's face had hung, there waited the furnished door he had never built, humming faintly, warm on the far side like a room someone had just left. He had learned to walk past it. He would walk past it again tonight.

He went down to the cellar and sat on the stool beside the cot, and he took inventory of himself the way he had taught himself to do in the burned season of his memory: what was spent, what remained, what he could afford to be asked for. Most of the big rooms were already empty — the mother's face, the father's laugh, the first kiss, the color of the childhood home; the great properties of his inner life, liquidated in one fight, at one altar. What remained was small stock. Patients. The clinic's mornings. Suri counting steps. Ilay's map of the deep. And one room he had never once needed to open since the intern years, because it contained no lesson and no comfort: the first patient he ever lost.

A boiler-man. Young, older than Dar had been then, hands burn-scarred in the crossed pattern of someone who worked pipes for a living and paid for it in skin. A borrowed gravel-heart on its last installments. Dar's sutures had been perfect — he could still say that, could still feel the even tension of them in his fingertips — and the heart had quit on the table anyway, at the hour, at the minute, like a debt called in. He had written the death notice himself, in his own intern's hand, and apologized to the body, which was not a thing they taught and not a thing that helped. He had carried that room for eight years, mostly shut, never locked.

It felt like the cheapest thing on the shelf. He was wrong, and he knew even as he priced it that he was wrong, and he offered it anyway.

* * *

The Mind Vein opened the way it always opened now: not as power but as a wound remembered. The cellar fell away. He stood in his own halls, and ahead of him, where no door had ever been, there was a door standing open into someone else's dark — and her dark was a counting-house.

That was his first knowledge of her, and it never afterwards left him: the woman from Brack kept, inside herself, a counting-house. Long benches. High shelves of ledgers gone. Every shelf had been stripped — not looted; audited — and where the ledgers had stood there were pale leaves now, pressed flat and thin as vellum, filed in their thousands, each one bearing the ghost of a pressure like a flower kept between pages. Her memories had been here.

He understood that without knowing how he knew it: her memories had been here, and something had pressed them the way you press a claim.

He walked the stripped aisles, and the aisles went down, and at the bottom, behind a grille of iron that a strong room wears, there was one room still lit.

He went in through the grille the way the Mind Vein permits, which is to say: he was suddenly, without transition, on the other side.

The harvest of Brack. What remains of it, he corrected himself — what she kept, what survived the pressing by being too close to the wall to take. Fragments, and the fragments had edges like cut paper.

White gloves. That first. White gloves on every hand of them, moving down the counting-house benches in an order, an orderliness so complete it read as kindness, gloves lifting each finished ledger into a brass satchel and pressing it flat. Their faces, where the memory allowed faces, were finished — closed, settled, like pages at the end of a book — and they did not hurry, because nothing in the room was theirs to fear. On a side bench, in a pan of scored brass, a row of tongues lay tagged like keys. Redactions, said the part of his mind that filed horror in column form, so it could be carried. The counters' speech was entered into evidence and collected. Everything that could have spoken the count was taken out of the count.

Then the harbor-temple. Brack's Throne.

She had seen it from a high window, through her own city's last storm of grace — the white-out that Brack's children must have called by the same lying name. The Throne of Brack was grown into the temple dais the way a nail is grown into a beam: black lace and vascular bloom, a human figure long since exceeded by its own garden, its face closed and tallied, its chest — where a seed sits, where the Lily sat in him — cut open along a line of surgical exactness. They had taken the seed out of it like a tooth. He watched the gloved hands draw it, wet at the root, black and pulsing faintly, heavy as a pulled heart, and he watched the Throne's many-veiled face turn toward the window where a clerk stood watching — toward her — and he felt, across eight years and two cities, the Throne of Brack recognize the last open ledger in the room and look away, deliberately, spending its final act of will on the smallest mercy on the books.

The city went silent through the wound. Not slowly. Through it — as if silence were a tide and the seed had been the door.

The final accounting was signed on the dais. One page, left-handed, the glove moving with the unhurried fluency of long habit — and the signature was not a name. It was a flower. Five

petals, blooming from a crack, drawn exactly, stamped down over and over in a column of identical signatures like a clerk who had long ago stopped being anyone.

* * *

Then the last room, the one she had saved the way misers save: herself.

The audit reaching the counting-house benches. The pressing. The gloves coming up her own aisle. And Vell — he had the name now, off the strong-room door-plate in her memory's own hand: VELL, SENIOR COUNTER, SECOND GRADE — Vell going to the wall where the death-column stood chalked, the list of the city's dead that some last clerk had kept to the end, and writing herself into it. Her own name, in her own careful tally-built letters. VELL. And beside it, the figure every machine on the barge had printed since: 0.

She had made herself a closed account, and the audit, which read the written world and nothing else, had passed over the one live entry in the building.

Counters, Dar thought, standing in her strong room with her whole city's silence in his ears, will outlast the auditors. It was not a comforting thought, and he filed it anyway.

And on the wall, scored deep across the plaster of the counting-house, over the death-column, by a hand that knew tallies better than letters, the last salvaged image rose to meet him as the Mind Vein began, gently, mercilessly, to close:

WE WERE COUNTED WORTH EATING.

* * *

He came back into the cellar with his face wet and did not know at which point in the reading the cold had entered his teeth. The Lily was pressed up under his sternum, molten and attentive, and her hum ran through his molars like a struck fork — she had drunk something from the walking, some lees of it, and he made himself breathe until she settled.

Suri was at the foot of the stairs with the lamp, counting his pulse from where she stood, out loud, to keep him honest. "Fifty-one," she said. "Fifty-two. You're back. What did it cost?"

He went to pay it and found the account already closed.

The room where the boiler-man had lived was swept. Not stripped like hers — swept, courteous, final. He reached for the man and had the shape of having reached for someone: the guilt was still hanging on its peg. The fact stood in the doorway of him — I lost a patient, my first, my own table, my own notice — the fact stood there like a name-plate over an empty office. The sutures he could feel in his fingertips, even their tension. The burned, crossed pattern of the hands — and even that, as he watched, going grey at the edges, like a figure in

fog.

The name went first. He never had it again.

"It took the first patient I ever lost," he said. "All of it. Whole."

Vahid, from the ladder, one hand steady on the rail: "That's what whole means, boy. That's the rate."

On the cot, the woman from Brack was watching him with her counting eyes, and she had read the payment off his face the way she read everything, in figures. She turned her slate over. She spat a chalk-stub into her palm — they had learned to leave chalk within her reach the way you leave water — and on the slate's clean back she wrote, in the tally-built letters he now knew her by, her first address to the living city that had taken her in:

WATER MARKS. I KNOW THE WAY. I WILL COUNT YOU THERE.

Then, beneath it, smaller, the way a clerk signs a working file:

VELL. OF BRACK. REMAINDER: ONE.

CHAPTER 38

Sibling Stock

Vahid Anousheh had performed dissections in better rooms than this and in worse, and he had learned long ago that the room never mattered; only the specimen's honesty mattered, and specimens lied in every room ever built. He pinned the two documents to the cellar corkboard with the brass pins he had once used on excised hearts, poured himself the evening gin out of ritual, and did not drink it, because tonight he was working on Shirin's half of the ladder and Shirin had hated to see him pour and not think.

The first document was Dar's copy of a registry page, taken out of the Choratorium's reliquary archive in the raiding season and copied in a surgeon's exact hand:

VESSEL: ILAY. AGE: 9. GRADE: PERFECT. RESERVED: THRONE.

And down at the bottom, in its own ruled column, the line that had been staring at them for two months like a debt no one would read aloud:

SIBLING STOCK: ACTIVE.

The second document was the Choirmaster's — one unburned copy of the harvest-registry, salvaged from the census fires entire, the vessel list running back generations, page after page of children entered in the Church's own notation. The man himself sat in the corner of the cellar where the lamplight went to fail, half-starved still, grey as his old robes, keeping his hands folded like a choirboy at a funeral he had conducted. Vahid had not invited him. Vahid could not have kept him out. It was, the Professor conceded, the man's book in a way nothing would ever be Vahid's.

They had both been staring at the notation for a week. Tonight, with Brack's zero still going around the city like a coin no one wanted to touch, the notation opened.

It was the graft-lineage code. That was the shame of it, the pure mechanical shame: he recognized it in four seconds once he stopped reading it as a Church script and read it as a ledger. The conventions were his and Shirin's — the serif conventions, the descent arrows, the percentage columns, the whole honest apparatus they had built at Saint Ferrous to match graft to patient so that no one would ever again be sold a heart that would be rejected on the table. A notation is innocent. A notation only makes saying easier. He sat with his one hand flat on the desk and watched the Church's forty years of saying pour through his own grammar, generation by generation.

Here was the whole of it, in their language, in the Church's hand:

The nursery was not an orphanage. It had never been an orphanage. The vessels were not taken children, graded; they were grown children, entered — and the stock column did not record siblinghood as blood records it. It recorded tissue-lineage. Every line in the vessel list descended, through as many as five recorded generations, from the same root entry, and the root entry was written in the notation reserved for specimens, not patients, and its catalogue number was one Vahid had seen once in his life, in the margin of an older man's forbidden map, with a warning in ledger-script beside it.

The First Vessel. The deep thing beneath the Throne shaft. Forty years of harvested organs grown onto one dreaming host — and before that, before the harvests, a source. The Church had been drawing tissue off the First Vessel the way a landlord draws rent, and growing the draw into children, cohort after cohort, grading each child's acceptance of graft, burning the failures into the great unlabeled columns at the back of the book — Vahid counted the failure columns the way you count a plague — and refining, refining, refining, until this last cohort of twelve, of whom eleven had walked out of the nursery on the raiding night, and one of whom was:

GRADE: PERFECT.

"Ilay," Vahid said aloud, to no one, because the name had to be said in a human voice once the figures had said it in theirs.

"She was never reserved for the Throne," he said, still in the human voice, because it helped. "She was grown toward it. The column isn't a booking, boy — it's a batch. The whole cohort is one batch. Twelve children off one root. Sibling stock, active." He drank nothing. "The Church has been farming the First Vessel's flesh into children for three generations, and we pulled eleven of the harvest out of a building that was still billing their keep."

From the corner, the Choirmaster spoke, and his smooth baritone was a ruin of what it had been on the harvest floor. "Grading nights," he said. "You know them now as what they were. I was told the stock was the city's — that the vessels were Ashkarad's children, tithed up and perfected for a great work. Hymns to make the tissue compliant, we called it. Compliance." His folded hands did not move. "No one ever asked me whose children the children were. It was not a question the hymns had a verse for."

"And you, Anousheh," Vahid said to himself, because the confession would not be honest with only the Church in it. He had built the ruler. They had measured the pantry — no. He took the thought back and wrote it correctly: they had measured children with it, and called the children stock, and the stock active, and active was a word from his own percentage columns, a word that meant the line breeds true.

Shirin had seen where the grammar pointed. That was in her last letter, which he had reread so many times the paper was going translucent at the folds: They have stopped asking what the seed can do for a body. They are asking what bodies can do for the seed. She had gone at the Church over that question like a woman going at a locked door with her shoulder. The Church had kept her voice six years.

He poured the gin down the drain, all of it, undrunk, and unpinned the first document, and put the second in his case, because if the clinic burned tonight the vessel list would not burn with it. Not ever again.

* * *

Roya brought Ilay down the cellar stairs an hour after midnight, and Vahid knew from the set of her masked jaw before either of them spoke that the night had decided to continue presenting evidence.

The girl's drawings had changed again. Roya pinned them up beside the registry pages without comment — Roya had begun translating the child's hearing into chalk the way she had once mapped dreams, and her chalkwork had learned a terrifying fluency — and where last month's sheets carried the great slow spiral converging under the Throne shaft, tonight's sheet carried the same spiral with sound written into it: short strokes, overtones, a pitch. Ilay stood in the lamplight with her copper hair pushed back from her river-stone eyes and looked at the corkboard full of her own kind's bookkeeping without one flicker of recognition, and then she began, absently, the way a clock runs, to hum.

Vahid's whole body went still, the way it had gone still in the anatomy theater forty years ago when a heart did something hearts were not supposed to do.

The hum was the music. He knew that at once — the music only Ilay heard, the deep music from under the salt, the thing they had all assumed was a broadcast, a beacon, the second heartbeat's voice reaching up through the vaults. The girl hummed it because she could not not hum it; it was in her the way the hum in the walls had once been in the whole city.

And the cellar answered her.

Not echoed. Answered. The salt in the walls — old, deep, memory-crammed salt — took her phrase and returned it half a step down and a breath behind, the way a companion voice does, and Ilay, who was used to this and had never been taught to notice it, hummed on, changing her pitch slightly, and the deep changed with her. Twice more. Twice more exact.

Vahid laid Roya's spiral-chart over Dar's copied page, and the innermost ring of the spiral sat on the registry like a signature sitting on a line, and the arithmetic assembled itself in his

head with the horrid smoothness of a sum that has only ever had one answer.

It is not singing to her. It is tuning to her.

The realization arrived in the lecture-voice he could never fully retire, because lecture-voice was how he kept the front of his skull orderly: The vessel stock is First Vessel tissue. The Second — the one behind the salt-glass door, the patient immense heartbeat, the sister — is kin to that tissue as a sibling is kin. When it sounds, it sounds down the family line. The child is not receiving a message. She is the message's tuning fork. It plays her to hear what else still rings. Somewhere below the city, something is striking the last cohort of the Church's harvest, one child at a time, and counting what comes back — and the child it has struck most often, the child it is always striking, is the one stamped PERFECT.

"Stop," Roya said — to the room, to the deep, to nobody; and her tin-muffled voice cracked on the word like ice under a boot. "She's nine."

"She's the tuning fork," Vahid said, and hated the sentence, and did not withdraw it, because the withdrawal of true sentences was the luxury that had cost Shirin everything. "And whoever struck the first note knows the pitch."

The Choirmaster had put his face into his folded hands. Vahid did not bother to classify the gesture. Some accounts you let a man settle privately.

* * *

It was Ilay who ended the night, because Ilay ended everything the deep began, in her small literal voice, without ceremony.

She had stopped humming. She was standing by the corkboard with her head tilted, listening the way she listened, to the music that was not a broadcast and was not a message and was somehow, tonight, at this hour, louder than it had ever been — louder, Vahid thought, since the barge, since the count of zero came into the harbor, as if the whole deep had leaned toward the sound of a city's population being stamped out and stayed leaning.

"The music has taught me a new word," she said.

Vahid did not move. "Taught," he said. "Not gave."

"It leaks," Ilay said. "Like under a door." She held out her hand to Roya without looking, and Roya put the chalk in it, because that was their arrangement now, the map-keeper and the girl who heard what could no longer be mapped, and Ilay knelt at the cellar's chalk wall — the wall where the Nine Veins ladder had been drawn in an older man's hand and a younger man's hope — and beneath the ladder, in her careful child's letters, each stroke ruled first with her thumbnail like a counter ruling a margin, she wrote the word she had been given through the

deep by whatever spoke down there in the dark, over and over now, in the voice of the family line:

RECLAIM

She wrote it the way children write words they do not know the price of. Then she sat back on her heels and looked up at Vahid with her river-stone eyes and asked the only question she had ever asked him in two months of living above his lectures.

"It's not a word for a thing," she said. "It's a word for a debt. Isn't it?"

Vahid looked at the registry page on the corkboard, at the Church's own notation in the Church's own hand, at the column that read SIBLING STOCK: ACTIVE, and he heard Shirin's last letter say what it had said all along, in the grammar he had built for honest matching so long ago: They are asking what bodies can do for the seed.

"Yes," he said. "It is."

CHAPTER 39

Two Cups

The Caravan League feasted the city in the Choratorium's ruins, and Dar went, because not going would have been information too.

Mother Gavel had annexed the wreck of the great cathedral-clinic in the season of the sanctuary terms, and her crews had made the bone arches honest in their way — debris cleared to the walls, the great harvest floor given over to trestle tables, the wreck of the graft-theater door below sealed with Gavel's chalk and Gavel's seals. Her banners hung from the arches where the Church's reliquary-glass had hung, frost-etched, and her people moved through the guests with scales and tally-slates, charging for lamps, for benches, for the coats of arms of a silence. The League had paid her hall-fee without argument. The League, Dar had learned, never argued a fee; it just made sure the fee was later entered somewhere in its own favor.

Lanterns burned in their hundreds. The Wardens sat at the far tables in two separate silences — the Index men with their bounty-notices folded into their coats, the Open Counts with their new soft caps and their new soft language of reconciliation — and between the factions the storm-caravan merchants glittered like a trade route made flesh, salt-cloaks, brass clasps, ledger-books chained to their belts. And above the head table, mounted on a board like a saint's panel in a poor man's shrine, hung Surveyor Coram Hesh's master map of Ashkarad.

Dar looked at it exactly once, from across the hall, the way you look at a wound you have already decided to close. Eight districts surveyed and redrawn in the League's fine surveyor's hand — and over the Saltstairs, over the clinic's own stacked parish, drawn small and precise and circled, a flower. Five petals, blooming from a crack in the earth. The Church's old sigil. The Gardener's mark, redrawn by hand on the last unclaimed page of a nine-city ledger, in front of four hundred people, none of whom could read it.

Suri stood at his shoulder, counting the room out of habit and duty. "Four exits that don't go through the kitchens," she said. "Gavel's enforcers: nine on the floor, two at the theater door below. Index: six, and one of them keeps looking at Milla's empty chair, so Milla stays home tonight. Hesh's League factor has paid for every lamp twice." She paused. "Your heart rate is up. Sixty-eight. You stood at the door at fifty-six."

"He's near," Dar said.

That was all the warning he could give her, and it was all she needed; she had been listening to his pulse for two years, and she took up her post at his left shoulder, where the

counting was best.

They had come in the long way, through the old dining hall, because the League's route to the feast floor went past Vey's table — her long table, her candle-brackets, the place where she had once kept a heart beating in glass between the candles and called it hospitality. The alcove between the brackets stood empty now, dust-ringed, a square of clean shadow on the salt-stained wall. The glass and its patient cargo had been recovered weeks ago by the Choirmaster's steady hands and carried out through the reliquary corridors to the clinic, where it was kept warm and lied to by lamplight on a schedule Roya had ruled into a drum. Dar had stood in front of the empty alcove for four of his own heartbeats and let the dust-ring tell him what it told him: something had stood there a long time, and something else had wanted it, and had been patient about wanting it. He had not liked the arithmetic. He carried it anyway, the way you carry a stitch you can't yet remove.

Hesh came through the guests toward them like a mild current. He was everything Vey had not been — he seemed to know it, and to have chosen it, the way you choose a coat for weather. Where she had been salt-and-ash beauty and white gloves and maternal menace, Hesh was middle-sized, greying, wind-chapped, a surveyor's squint and a surveyor's patience; he wore the League's grey and thin clerk's gloves, and he had spent a month crawling the storm-gutted districts with his instruments, propping walls, paying porters over rate, setting bones at collapses before the clinic could arrive — useful, humble, unpriced. The city had begun to love him. That was the horror Dar kept failing to make colder than it was: you could not have designed a better nurse for a sick city than a man who genuinely, somewhere in the figures, liked cities.

"Surgeon." Hesh stopped at the polite distance and inclined his head. To Suri: "Counter." To the air where Roya had taken up her vigil against a pillar, brass mask sliding with lamplight: "Map-keeper." He never used names. Names were inventory tags, Dar thought, and this man's inventory was not of lamps.

"You've concluded," Dar said.

"The survey is filed." Hesh smiled with the whole weathered face. "You'll be pleased to hear your district is the soundest in the city. Old construction. Good bone in it."

Good bone in it. Dar held his face where it was, and behind it the Lily turned over in her sleep of rage and pressed her black lace up under his collarbones like a crowd pressing at a door.

The feast carried on around them — toasts, the League factor's speeches, a choir of salvage-orphans singing something the Index had not yet banned — and Hesh signaled, and his

factor's boy brought a tray: a pot of tea, two cups, and nothing else. No milk, no leaf-basket, no receipt. Hesh poured with surveyor's economy, one cup and its twin, and set them on the tray between himself and Dar, one to the left, one to the right, exactly — Dar's skin catalogued the exactness — exactly the spacing Vey had once used at her own table, down to the turn of the handles, the angle of the tray, the pause.

"You just have to decide which cup to drink from," Hesh said.

The words went into Dar like a blade that had been kept oiled for this exact wound. Vey's words. Vey's cadence, Vey's table, Vey's warm absolute sentence, spoken by a mild surveyor over a feast in her ruins — not learned from Vey, he understood in one cold drop of time, but handed down, the way the lullaby was handed down, the way the flower sigil was handed down. Vey had never owned the ritual. She had been performing it. Somewhere behind her, behind the Chorus, behind forty years of harvested voices, an original hand had poured this tea for the first time, and everyone who ever poured it after was reciting.

And the Lily woke all the way up.

The hum came up through his ribs into his molars, and his gums ached, and then split — he felt the fine wet give of them, both sides, the old wound-gates of the crave opening on schedule — and the taste of his own blood crossed his tongue, and the Lily surged toward it and toward Hesh and toward the trays and the arches and the whole fraught room with a hunger that had nothing to do with tea. Black lace pressed the back of his hands from inside. Down the table, a caravan merchant paused mid-toast, frowning at the lanterns as if a draft had moved them.

Build a door, he told himself, in Vahid's lecture cadence, and built it — the surgeon's wall of will, the field he had learned in the drowning season, and he stood inside it with the crave hammering it like weather, and bled quietly into his own mouth, and did not move.

Because the room was wrong for her, and she knew it, and that was half the rage. Blood given in darkness fed her; blood taken in darkness calmed her; but the feast floor was an ocean of lanterns, four hundred flames and every window unshuttered for the League's glassware, and light weakened her at the root. So she pressed and pressed against the door he built, a hunger the size of a city's worth of harvest with nowhere to be put, and the door held the way his doors held — barely, expensively, at a cost he would feel in his hands tomorrow — while the blood sat in his mouth and she watched it through his own eyes like a woman locked out of her own house.

"Your gums," Hesh observed, with gentle clinical regret. "You shouldn't work through pain, surgeon. It impoverishes the reading."

"What's in the cups?" Dar asked. His voice came out level. He was distantly proud of it.

"Tea."

"What does each one cost?"

"Nothing." Hesh's mildness did not flicker. "It's a kindness. Kindness is unpriced, surgeon. You of all people have taught this city that."

"In Ashkarad," Dar said, "nothing is unpriced. When a man offers me a kindness with no column for it, I look for the column he's keeping somewhere else." He looked at the two cups, steaming gently in the lamplight, twins, identical, patient. "I don't drink on credit."

"Neither did she," Hesh said, "in the end. It was a beautiful pour to watch."

He said it without edge, almost with admiration, and he gathered the tray — both cups untouched, still steaming, still identical — and turned back into the feast, a good guest making his farewells, and the Lily screamed along her roots so hard that Dar tasted iron down his throat for a full minute after the grey coat was lost in the crowd. Suri counted him through it under her breath. Fifty-eight. Fifty-nine. Sixty. Count with me, Mehran. He counted.

And it was there, in the counting, with his gums split and the crave receding and Suri's voice laying the numbers down like planks over a drop, that the understanding he had been circling for three weeks finally stood still long enough to be read.

He knew what rode in his chest. He had known it in the way you know a debt you refuse to open — passively, at the envelope's edge. Now he opened it. The Lily was one of nine. Nine seeds, sown a century ago by a hand signed THE GARDENER, one to each city, each seed a vinedoor into a body that would become a city or a city that would become a body — eight of them carried to bloom, to TRUE THRONE, to the cut tooth and the silent harbor and the machine-printed zero of Brack. And the ninth, the last, the fled — the one that had cracked its reliquary in a salt storm and chosen a dying thief with a surgeon's hands — was here. In him. The asset the whole round was coming to collect. RECLAIM, written on Vey's page in a stamping hand; RECLAIM, chalked under the Nine Veins by a nine-year-old tuning fork; RECLAIM, the standing order, older than the Church, and the Church itself only the round's last staging-post, Vey only the local branch manager of a ledger that had never once had Ashkarad's interest at heart.

He had thought all season that they were fighting the remains of Vey's machine. They were not. They were the anomaly on the books — one seed gone missing — and the audit had come to correct the entry.

"Roya," he said quietly, to the pillar. "It's time. Spring it tonight."

The brass mask turned toward him and away, a nod in everything but the neck. "He'll verify before he files," Roya said, in her rendered-tin voice, metallic calm. "And there's one place left in this city with ears deep enough to verify to. We'll be ready."

Across the hall, Hesh was bowing his farewells to Mother Gavel, who watched him with eyes flat as a ledger page and charged him, Dar would learn later, a parting fee for the lamp over his table that was exactly, insultingly, one coin.

And on the head table, where Hesh had sat, the tea things still waited: two cups, untouched, cooling now, twins in the lamplight with nothing to choose between them — and between them, folded, squared to the table's edge with a surveyor's neatness, his white gloves.

He had worn them all evening. He had taken them off to pour.

They lay there patient as a kept appointment, not left behind but set down, the way a man sets down a tool he will want in the morning — and every frost-bloom on every ruined sill in the Choratorium, black and slow and certain, had turned in the night air to point at them, as if the building itself knew a glove when it saw one, and remembered who used to wear it, and was keeping the seat warm.

CHAPTER 40

The Listening Heart

Roya had been wired to a city once, so she knew a listening device when she held one in her hands.

That was the part nobody at the feast had understood, watching the mild surveyor climb into his hired cart. The heart in the glass had never been a relic. It was an instrument — the oldest instrument in the case. Vey had grown it from Dar's own flesh in a vat and kept it beating between the candles in her dining hall, and a heart grown from a man's flesh does not stop being his when it is outside him: it keeps his time. It had sat in its alcove for two months after her fall, singing his rhythm into the salt the way a struck fork sings into a table, and the salt of Ashkarad remembers everything it is given, and the salt, somewhere at its bottom, had been listening on behalf of a mistress who signs left-handed.

Then the surveyor came, and within a week of his arrival the heart was gone from the alcove.

The Choirmaster had found the dust-ring first — found it and understood it, because he had served the Chorus and knew what an instrument case looked like when the instrument was out on loan. He had brought the finding to Roya the same night as the harvest-routing marks, and the two of them had done what couriers and choir-masters do best: followed a stolen thing through a sleeping city at two in the morning, up the chandler's row, to a hired room over a chandler's shop, where a wire-suspended glass jar sat in a frame of surveyor's brass, beating in its bath, keeping the vessel's patient time.

Hesh's antenna. Keyed to its flesh. All along — every structural report, every kind visit, every propped wall and overpaid porter, the whole mild and useful and unpriced month of him — he had been reading the vessel's state out of a jar.

They had not broken it. Roya wanted that entered in the record, because it was the only genuinely clever thing she had done since they took the song-lobe out of her skull and the city went quiet behind her eyes. You do not destroy a channel, she had told the Choirmaster in the cart with the jar warm between them. You buy it. A listening instrument is a door, and a door opens from the side that pays.

So they had carried it to the clinic cellar, and set it in biogel, and rigged it — a hand-cranked drum of cams, pins set in wax, a stylus arm that tapped the rehearsed rhythm down into the bath through the glass — and for nineteen days the heart had kept not Dar's time

but Roya's. She had ruled the schedule herself, in her own chalk, from the old harvest-notation: a decline. A seed failing. A carrier dying of the climb, month over month, beat over beat, the rhythm thinning on a curve no honest body could argue with. Nineteen days of a lie fed into the salt on a dying man's behalf, and the salt had carried it down to the listening dark, and the listening dark had believed it, because the salt believes whatever the heart says; the salt has no other scripture.

Tonight the drum stopped.

Roya stood in the cellar with the Choirmaster and watched the heart come off the lie the way a watch comes off a winder — a shudder, a hunt, a settling — and take up, beat by beat, its true time. His time. Two miles of salt between the jar and the sleeping city, and every foot of it now carrying the one message the lie had spent nineteen days withholding: alive. Located. Whole.

The discrepancy was the trap. That was the whole architecture of it, and she laid it out for the Choirmaster while the heart sang, in her short way, because laying it out kept her hands from the old habit of reaching for a signal that was no longer there. Somewhere below the world, his masters now held two ledgers. The first said the vessel was failing; nineteen days of declining curve, filed through an antenna they believed was in their man's safekeeping. The second said the vessel was alive; one night of true rhythm, sung by the same jar, arriving by the same salt. An auditor can forgive many things. A discrepancy is not among them. He will have to verify, she said. He cannot verify through the salt — the salt is the thing that disagrees with him. He will verify at depth, where the ears are old and direct, where the deep complex still opens its mouths into the city's cellars and theaters. There is one place left with the right ears, and he has had three weeks of legitimate reason to learn its doors.

The graft-theater.

They had spent two days making the trap polite. The Gavel seals on the theater door below the feast hall were still chalked and waxed from the annexation — so the Choirmaster had walked them that afternoon with Gavel's own floor-wardens, all courtesy, and the wax had lifted clean and the chalk had rubbed, in the way that chalk rubs when a man who spent twenty years managing that building's doors stands next to it sighing about subsidence. Two of Gavel's enforcers would keep the corridor, outside, uninvolved, witness only: Mother Gavel had priced her cooperation at one look at the man's face when the building turned on him, and Roya, who had once brokered with her over a living ledger of enemies, judged the price fair.

And Dar would be below. Roya had argued for it and won, over Suri's flat arithmetic of danger, on the oldest rule she knew: you hide a coin in the vault. The theater's dark was

absolute when the last lamp went out — true dark, cellar dark, the dark the Lily drank in her rooting season — and in true dark, wrapped in the thunder of the deep's own answering voice, the vessel's signal drowned. Let the surveyor verify into a cathedral of noise. Let him swear to his masters that the deep says the seed is alive and well and watching him do it.

Roya racked the drum. Cased the pins. Put out the lamp.

"Nineteen days," she said to the dark, in the tin voice the mask made of everything. "File that."

* * *

Dar stood in the graft-theater's absolute black behind the dead altar, and listened to the building breathe.

It was not a silence. Silence was pressure; he knew its weight like a splint. This was an audience — the dark of the old theater held the remembered hum of forty years of choir organs the way a shell holds the sea, and under the floor, far below the sealed shafts, the deep heartbeat kept its patient time, one beat behind his own, the way it had since the salt-glass door. He had the Lily quiet. That was the night's work: he had walked her down into the dark she loved and asked her for stillness, and she had given it — grudgingly, at interest, a stillness like a held breath — because he had bled for her once in a cellar like this and she remembered her prices even when she forgot her manners.

The chalk-seal on the far door had been broken for hours. The broken seal was the invitation, and the invitation was the trap, and he stood in the trap's dark center and waited for the auditor to audit.

Hesh came at the dead hour, alone, as Roya had counted it. The door opened on a hooded lamp, a blade of light, and then closed again, and the surveyor of the Caravan League stood in the graft-theater of the Chorus he had served all his life under another set of colors, and Dar watched him take off the mildness like a coat.

It was not a dramatic change. That was what made Dar's hands cold on the altar rail. The man's posture corrected — shoulders back, chin level, the whole weathered face arriving at rest — and the gentle uselessness went out of him, and what stood in the theater beneath the hooded lamp was neither kind nor cruel: it was exact. A face like a finished page.

Hesh unhooded the lamp a finger's width. Set it on the altar rail. Needed no instrument. He faced the open dark of the theater's deep well, where the floor had been cut away in the old seasons down toward the connected dark, and he sang.

The lullaby. Four bars of it, unhurried, in a voice that had no business being that gentle — and the fourth bar carried the wrong note, the one wrong note Dar had first heard at his work in the storm season, the signature that said the song had come down another line than mothers. The wrong note landed in the theater's dark and the dark took it down.

Then Hesh spoke, aloud, in the flat stamped cadence of a clerk reading a form into a record, and the theater — the walls, the salt in the walls, the whole deep shelf of the world beneath the city — gave the words back to him at half a beat's remove, the way the cellar had given Ilay's hum back to her.

"Ashkarad. Page nine. Vessel: fled. Standing order: reclaim. Discrepancy: filed. Come to order. Verify."

And the deep answered.

Not with the lullaby. With attention. Dar felt it arrive the way you feel a change in a patient under your hands — a vast displacement of pressure, the whole immense patient heartbeat below the salt leaning, for one measured second, toward the theater, toward the call, toward the small exact man at the rail — and the Lily rose inside Dar against every term of their bargain, roaring silently at the nearness of that voice, that attention, that family, and he held her, held her, held her, in the dark where she was strongest, a door under a flood.

And every frost-bloom in the building turned on him.

Dar heard it before he saw it: a dry, papery, incremental sound, all through the walls, above, below, the stairwells, the sills, the frames — the sound of a jury rising to its feet. When he risked his eyes past the altar rail, the hooded lamp's finger of light showed him the nearest sill, and the black blooms on it were no longer pointing where they had pointed for weeks — at the clinic cellar, at the jar that sang there in the dark. They were pointing at Hesh. All of them. Every black flower in the theater, in the corridors, in the reliquary galleries overhead, every slow sign of Ashkarad's own quiet garden, rotated with the patience of a thing that had never once been in a hurry — and settled, and fixed, and faced the surveyor of the Caravan League with the stillness of a verdict.

Hesh did not step back. Dar gave him that, and knew the man heard the assessment passing, because the surveyor turned his head, unhurried, toward the altar rail and the dark behind it, and inclined it, the way he had at the feast.

"Surgeon," he said, mildly, from inside the jury of flowers. "You came down to watch the reading. Good. Readings want witnesses."

"Your masters have two ledgers," Dar said, from the dark. "You know whose hand ruled the second one."

"I know the hand that ruled the first," Hesh said. "It has ruled every first ledger for a century." He let that stand in the dark exactly as long as it stood, then squared himself to the theater's open well, to the salt, to the deep, to the attention leaning on him from below like weather, and Dar understood the trap had done its final work: it had made him verify in front of the city's own garden, and the garden had testified, and the testimony was evidence.

Hesh filed his report to the open air, in the flat stamped cadence, unhurried, a man closing a column he had kept all his life:

"Vessel located. Send the wain."

He did not run. He picked up his lamp, squared his coat, and walked out of the theater the way he had walked into it, past Gavel's enforcers at the corridor's mouth who looked at the frost-pointed dark behind him and did not step into it, and no hand in the whole annexed ruin was laid on him, because nobody there — not the syndicates, not the Wardens, not the clinic, not the garden itself — could name, that night, the fee for touching him.

The theater's dark took the filing and kept it. Far below the salt, the deep heartbeat went on, patient, immense — one beat behind Dar's own, as it had been since the door.

Then, for the first time since the salt-glass, it was not.

CHAPTER 41

Beyond the Seawalls

By morning the whole city had the filing, because couriers are couriers, and a sentence spoken to the open air in a syndicate's annexed theater is a sentence that ships.

Vessel located. Send the wain.

It moved through Ashkarad the way a default notice moves through a tenement: shutter to shutter, faster than the bells, changing weight at every landing. The Index posted a notice on the census-hall ruin by noon — RE: REGISTRY IRREGULARITIES, SALTSTAIRS PARISH — which everyone correctly read as an offer to sell the parish's irregulars to whatever was coming, in exchange for being left off the audit. Mother Gavel's ledgermen began, quietly, to count the roads. The Open Counts sent the clinic a soft-capped delegation that said, in their new soft language, that the Wardens' protection extended to the seawalls, and Dar thanked them and did not say the obvious thing, which was that the seawalls were precisely what the protection was standing on.

Hesh's hired room over the chandler's shop stood empty by dawn — stripped to the boards, the surveyor's brass gone, the frame that had held a glass heart gone with it. On the sill, squared to the edge with a surveyor's neatness, lay one coin. The lamp-fee. He had paid Mother Gavel's insulting little charge on his way out of the city, and no one, afterward, could say in which direction he had gone, except that the fog to the south was thinner that morning, as if something had walked through it carrying a light.

The council at the clinic was short, because they had all done the arithmetic during the night and the arithmetic did not have two answers.

"The wain is a siege engine or a tithe-barn on wheels, and I don't know which," Vahid said, chalk in hand, one finger of the chalk ladder. "The old papers call it a conveyance and leave it at that — the way the Church's books called the harvest a tithe and the nursery a choir school. Nobody living in this city has seen one and stayed sane enough to file the description. If it's the first, it sits outside the walls and starves the truce out — and the truce, boy, the Truce of Salt, binds the syndicates to each other. It does not bind one step of ground beyond the seawalls. The moment that thing crosses the tide-line, every promise this city has made itself ends at the wall, and everything inside the wall is what gets negotiated away. You know what gets negotiated away first. She's nine, and she's stamped PERFECT, and the Index already has a notice on Milla's printout."

"If it's the second," Roya said, from her corner, in her tin voice, "it loads the harvest and takes it. Either way it comes for the vessel. And the vessel, at present, is the loudest thing in the salt." She tapped her own temple, where the song-lobe had been, where the silence lived. "We stopped lying to it last night. It has sung your true rhythm every hour since. You cannot be sheltered here. A city cannot hide a coin that rings."

"The answers are on the route," the Choirmaster said. He stood by the door of the cellar where the woman from Brack slept, half-starved still, upright out of old habit, like a man at a choir rail. "I kept the harvest-registry for forty years and I never once asked what the round was for. Somebody along it knows. Somebody along it has watched a city be closed like an account and lived."

"Then it's settled," Suri said, and closed her own count the way she closed everything, with the total spoken aloud. "You can't stay, we can't hide you, and you can't fight a wain with a clinic. So we don't fight it. We read it. The round runs forward" — she looked at Roya — "and errors are found reading backward."

"Walk the RECLAIM round in reverse," Dar said. "Start at the end of the ledger. Ashkarad, and the two behind it. Find what the collection is for before it arrives to collect."

Nobody argued. That was the strange mercy of the morning: that after two months of the city paying for his heartbeat in small uncounted ways, every person in the room had already, privately, without being asked, priced his leaving as the cheapest entry on the books. He took less than an hour to pack, because a surgeon's kit packs itself if you have done it enough times, and because the clinic was not his to carry — it was theirs, now, the way the truce was theirs, and he had to leave both in hands he trusted or the journey would be a debt he walked out on.

The hardest column of the leaving he kept to himself, and it was the one under the city. Somewhere below the Marrowworks, past the dead First Vessel's cold cathedral of flesh, at the end of the deep salt vaults, a door of translucent salt-glass stood ajar — unlocked from the other side, a five-petaled flower for a keyhole, and behind it the patient immense second heartbeat that had spent two months learning his own. She wanted to be found and was afraid of being found. He had stood at her door with his palm flat on the salt-glass and promised her nothing, because promises were the one currency he had learned not to issue, and now he was going to walk out of the city and leave her door open behind him like an unpaid account. The Lily turned once toward the deep, the whole length of his walk down, like a woman looking back up a stair.

* * *

They went down to the seawall gate at first light, through streets that had come out to watch, because Ashkarad had never in living memory opened the seawall for a departing walker, only for tides.

From the clinic's upper windows, the eleven looked down — the freed vessels, the last cohort of the Church's long arithmetic, Elias among them with his perfect lungs and his ruined idea of what a hospital was. None of them waved. They stood at the sills in a silence that had its own acoustics, and along the frames, between their small hands, the black frost-blooms of the city's quiet garden grew, and Dar understood, with two streets still between him and the harbor, that the garden had already ruled on his departure. Every bloom on the clinic face was pointing south. Not at him. With him.

Ilay was waiting at the foot of the gate stair with Roya, and she did not say goodbye, because Ilay did not use the word; she pressed her sound-map of the deep into his hand instead — the paper soft as cloth from two months of her pockets, the great spiral drawn in her careful child's strokes, the innermost ring dated soon, the whole descent of the salt-glass door rendered in the language of a girl who heard the world from underneath. Dar took it the way you take a held breath from someone. "So you remember which way down is," she said, "in case you ever need to be under something." And then, because she was nine and precise: "Come back and tell me what the music says when it's outdoors."

"It's a promise," Dar said. "Unpriced. Don't let anyone here collect on it."

"The Professor says unpriced things are the only things that stay," Ilay said, and stepped back into Roya's shadow, work done.

Suri took his pack off his shoulder before he reached the stair, weighed it in her ruined-graft hand — the dead carbon scales clicking like a burned ledger closing — and shouldered it onto her own. "Porter," she said, when he looked at her. "You work for me now, Mehran. Surgeons carry nothing but their hands; it keeps the hands honest. I carry the kit, the water, the salt-rations, the charts, and you, if it comes to that." She counted him, once, head to boots, the old flat audit. "I'm carrying you back. You're just going to be heavy."

"You're not priced for this," Dar said, because someone had to say it, because the ledger deserved the attempt.

"Nobody's priced for anything," Suri said. "That's the finding of my audit. Now walk."

Vahid came last down the stair, one hand on the rail, a canvas case over his shoulder, and he did not make a lecture of it, which was how Dar knew it was costing him. "Shirin's cylinders," he said, giving the case into Dar's arms — fourteen wax cylinders, each one wrapped in the Professor's own shirt-linen like relics, which they were. "Her archive.

Everything we ever proved and half of what we only hoped. Listen to her before you listen to anyone, including me. She meant what she recorded." His voice went dry and exact. "I only ever talked." Then, at the foot of the stair, with the seawall looming: "And boy — the Ninth is a door, not a rung. Whatever hands you a key out there, look at the price stamped on the bow before you turn it."

The Choirmaster did not come down at all. He stayed at the top, by the clinic door, with the harvest-registry in its oilcloth across his folded arms — the vessel list entire, the names not yet crossed out — and he bowed over it, a small precise bow, the deepest thing Dar had ever seen him do. "Somebody burned the book I kept," the Choirmaster said. "The least I can do is stand where it isn't burning." Behind him in the doorway, Milla Ferun stood with the lamp still in her hand and her salt-white fingernails folded into her sleeves, and she gave Dar the nod that one clerk gives another across a closing entry: filed, witnessed, carried.

Vell was already at the gate, of course. She had been at the gate since before light; a gate-ward swears she was there when the watch changed. She stood with her slate against her chest and her face turned south, and when Dar reached the foot of the stair she turned the slate for him to read, in her tally-built letters, the whole of her application for the journey:

I COUNT FOR THE LIVING NOW. WATER MARKS. TWO CITIES. I AM YOUR FIGURE ONE.

Then she took a place in the column behind Suri without asking, the way a number takes its place in a sum.

The wardens sang out the gate-cries — the old cries, salt-cries, that the harbor children used to mock — and the great gate groaned back on its chains, and the wind of the open world came through, tasting of iron and salt and of nothing else at all, no hum, no chorus, no debt. From the canal wall behind them, thin across the morning, Lena Vance's returned voice rose after them for one bar of something that was not the lullaby, and Dar was glad of it; the city should send its own music to the door.

Then the seawalls opened, and Dar saw the fog-sea for the first time.

He had lived his whole life inside the accounting of it — tide-tables, gate-bells, the fog-sea as a margin at the bottom of every map — and it was nothing his margins had priced. It went out and out, grey-white, breathing, a country of weather lying on top of a country of water, and it made the city behind him feel like what it was: one entry. And the tide was going out. Not ebbing — going out, the exposed flats shining and clicking and steaming at the gate's foot, the water withdrawing from the land for a distance no tide-table had ever entered, as if the whole sea had been asked for its balance and was paying — far, far out, toward a horizon that sat low

and patient on the world.

As if something out there, at the edge of the page, were drinking.

Behind him, under the city, the second heartbeat kept its new time — whatever the new time was — and against his own ribs the Lily leaned once, hard, back toward the deep she was leaving, and then, deliberately, forward, toward the sea.

Dar stepped past the gate-wardens, out from under the last stone of Ashkarad, and turned his face down the reversed round, and began to walk.

CHAPTER 42

The Ledger of the Road

The seawalls closed behind them the way a book closes — two leaves of salt-black stone swinging on hinges older than the Church — and then Ashkarad was gone, and there was nothing in any direction but the flats.

The flats were a ledger of their own. White salting ran out ahead of them until the world lost its seam, sky and ground meeting at a line too even to be honest, like a column summed by someone who wanted the number clean. The fog-sea had withdrawn to a grey smear at the bottom edge of the horizon, and it kept withdrawing. From the roof of the last tanner's shed Dar could still see the tide going out, mile on mile of seabed coming up into the air, black mud drying to grey at its edges the way a wound dries. The water had not come back on any schedule the old marks allowed. It left the way a creditor leaves a failing account — gradually, then all at once, then not at all — and what it left behind was the shape of its absence, held in mud, exact.

Suri walked point with the porter's frame strapped across her shoulders. The frame held a padded crate, and the crate held Shirin Bahar's wax cylinders, forty of them, each one wrapped in oilcloth like a small expensive bone. She had appointed herself porter at the seawalls and had not asked anyone's permission, which was how Suri did everything. Her ruined arm hung in the strap where the carbon scales had split and burned, dull as a night sky with a hole kicked through it, and her voice came back over her shoulder at even intervals, flat as a clerk reading a column.

"Nine thousand, four hundred and ten."

Nobody had asked her to count aloud. She counted because the counting was hers, and out here there was no one to repossess it.

Vell walked the route stones. Every mile the registry's old surveyors had set a post, knee-high, salt-eaten, and on each post the same mark: a five-petaled flower carved as if blooming out of a crack in the stone, weathered to a shadow of itself and still legible, the way a stamp stays legible long after the hand that held it is filed. Vell stood at each one longer than she needed to. She was a small woman with a clerk's posture and a counting-house's stillness, and her tongue had been cut out of her in Brack, so the world got her opinions in chalk. She wet her stub of chalk against her lip, considered the post, and wrote on the stone itself, under the flower: two lines, a number, and an arrow pointing back the way they had come.

"What's she marking?" Suri asked, though she had already guessed.

Dar read it. Vell's hand was a counting-house hand, narrow, vertical, meant for ledgers. WATER AT POST 41: FORTY-ONE HANDS BELOW OLD MARK. She moved to the next post and chalked the same observation with a new number, and at the next, and by the third post the numbers had a direction, and the direction was down. She was charting the sea's retreat the way an auditor charts a shortfall — hands per mile, mile per day — and she did not like the total she was arriving at. Her face said so. Vell's face said very little, but against that background of very little, the amount it said was a shout.

They walked. The flats gave them their entries to read as they went. Cairns stood out on the white in loose families — stacked stone, knee-high to chest-high, each one a traveler's estate closed out by whoever came behind. Some were old enough that the salt had welded them into single grey teeth. Some were days old. None of them had names on them; out here you did not file the name, you filed the number of stones, and the desert kept the count. Farther on, the masts began: ships that had died standing, hulls swallowed to the gunwales by decades of salting, masts left up like grave-posts with notches cut into the wood — crew counts, Vell decided, running her fingers down the notches and then writing the totals on her slate with a certain professional approval. Even out here, someone had kept books.

At dusk the tide-line paid its interest. Heat-berries came up along the last wet ground in strings and clumps, bioluminescent, a low green-gold radiation of light exactly where the water's edge used to run, as if the sea had left a creditor's lantern burning to show it intended to return. Dar knelt once at the line and looked at the glow without touching it. Feeding light to the dark was a transaction he understood from the wrong side now.

Because daylight was a tax. He had learned the rate of it within the first mile. The Lily ran dim under the open sky; he felt her the way you feel a fire banked behind a closed stove door — present, patient, thermostatically subdued — and every hour of sun was an hour of debit against her. When the light went, she came back into the front of his chest like warmth returning to a hand. So they walked the long daylight hours in a purposeful silence, and made camp in whatever ruin or hull-shadow the flats offered, and in the dark he paid her.

He paid her the second night in the lee of a grave-mast, in a shelter of hull planking and oilcloth sealed down on all four sides so that no light could enter. He opened his own palm with his own knife, in the total dark, and gave, and the Lily drank from him with a gentleness that was worse than violence, and outside the oilcloth, in the cold, frost bloomed. They saw it at dawn: fine grey petals feathered across the canvas in a long converging fan, and every petal pointed the same way. Not toward the sea. Back — back along the route, back toward Ashkarad, toward the deep heartbeat under the Throne shaft, toward the sister the one word

had named, and gone patient again.

His balance leaned that way too. It had been leaning since the roof, a fractional tilt of the whole body toward the west and down, as if something below the salt had hooked a line to his sternum and left it slack and then, mile by mile, begun to take up the slack.

"You're listing," Suri said, on the fourth morning. "Starboard. Like a loaded barge."

"She leans," Dar said.

"Toward home."

"Toward the deep end of home." He rolled his shoulder, correcting a drift he could not correct. "I'm carrying a compass that wants what's behind us. And we're walking the other direction because the answers are printed in front of us. It's a ledger imbalance. We'll carry it."

Vell, passing, wrote on her slate and held it up: THE BODY IS NOT THE BOOK. He looked at it for a moment. "No," he agreed. "The book is not the body either. That's the problem with both of them."

The nights were for the Mind Vein's discipline, which meant the nights were for not using it. Vahid's instruction held: memory was architecture, and you did not spend what you could walk. So Dar walked his corridors in the dark of the shelter, past the swept floors, the emptied rooms, the doorway where his mother's face had hung and now hung nothing — and stopped, as he always stopped, at the furnished door at the deepest hall's end, the one he had never built, warm on the far side like a room someone had just left. He did not touch it. He stood in front of it and counted his own two heartbeats until the walking was done, and came back up the stairs of himself without paying anyone.

On the sixth day the flats changed their subject. The white gave way to stakes — old mooring-posts in rotted rows, thousands of them, marching out of the mud where no water stood, and the smell arrived before the sight did: iodine, old rope, wood rot sweetened with salt. The drowned port's outskirts. The seabed lay exposed to the horizon in every direction, flats on flats of drying mud scored with the tracks of things that had lived under the water and were learning, or failing to learn, to live without it. Heat-berries glowed out here even at noon, dim green constellations in the shadow side of every stake.

And across all of it, one line of footprints.

They came off a bank of dried sea-mud and the prints were there, and the line of them ran straight as a ruled entry, from the seaward emptiness inland — toward Ashkarad, the direction they had come from — walking through the stakes without once deviating to use them, small feet, bare, a diver's spread toes and salt-burned heels, and no second set of prints anywhere.

Whoever had walked here had walked out of the sea's absence and kept walking, and the mud had held it all.

Suri crouched over the first clear print for a long time. "Small," she said. "Light. Ball of the foot first, no scuff, no drag. Whoever it is doesn't get tired." She set her own boot beside it. The print was half again smaller than hers. "Bare in this cold. That's a diver's foot, or nothing's foot."

Vell was already pacing the line, chalk out, tallying. Dar watched her measure the interval between the first print and the second, and the second and the third, and saw her stop. She went back and did it again. Then she stood in the middle of the line with her chalk hanging in her fingers, and for the first time since the tide-gates her face said something large.

Dar felt it before she finished writing it. The Lily leaned — not west now, not toward home, but down, and slightly toward the prints, the way a person leans toward a window to hear a familiar song on a far street. His balance went with her. He put his hand against a mooring-stake and stood inside the pressure of that attention and counted.

His own stride fell on his own pulse. He had never thought about it before; a body carries its meter with it, and the meter is the heart. But the prints under him had their own meter, and Vell's chalk finished the entry on her slate and she turned it around and held it up in the grey light.

ONE HEARTBEAT APART. NOT HER PULSE. NOT YOURS.

He counted the distance between the prints against the second heartbeat, the deep one, the patient one, the drum he had heard once from a clinic roof and could not unhear. It fit. Every print fell precisely into the vast slow interval, stride for beat, the walker's body keeping time to something enormous walking with her, under her, through her — a small bare woman pacing out the tempo of a buried god, headed home.

The wind came across the flats with nothing left to slow it. Somewhere behind them the tide was still going out, and somewhere ahead, down the drowned streets of a city that had married its god, a black flower the size of a district lay in a drained harbor and waited to be fed.

"Lowmark by tomorrow's dusk," Dar said. "We walk on the stones. Nobody follows the line."

They walked on. The line of prints went the other way, small and bare and patient, one heartbeat at a time, toward Ashkarad.

CHAPTER 43

The Drowned Choir

Lowmark announced itself by its rooftops. They rose out of the flats for an hour before anything else of the city did — chimneys first, then ridge-lines, then the grey backs of roofs ranked down the old hillside like scales on a submerged animal — and by the time Dar stood close enough to see the doors, he understood what the route stones had been politely not saying. The city was drowned to the second story. The sea had taken the ground floors a lifetime ago and never given them back, and Lowmark had adjusted its books rather than argue: ladders and gangplanks ran where streets had been, boats were moored to chimney-stacks, attic doors opened onto rope walkways slung from ridge to ridge, and the whole town went about its business at the height of a gull. Down in the flood-line, under green glass water and sheets of recent mud, the drowned first stories stood furnished and open, shopfronts dark, salt crust on every shelf — with the tide out this far, you could walk on the roofs of the drowned street and look down into the rooms of the drowned houses, and the people of Lowmark had built their walkways precisely so that they would not have to.

The harbor was at the bottom of everything, and the harbor was occupied.

The seed had bloomed in it like a black water-lily the size of a district. Dar saw it from the ridge of the salt-warehouse and stood still for a count of ten, because there was a limit to what a man should take in at one gulp. Petals the size of sails lay slicked back across the drained harbor bed, black at the heart, grey-edged with dry salt, ranked in whorls, and at the center of the last whorl stood the flower's true middle — a dark the eye kept sliding off, a closed bud the size of a chapel — and out of that middle came the hum. He felt it in his teeth before he heard it with his ears. The whole city sat inside the sound the way a thing sits inside its own name.

He did what Vahid had taught him and built the door: narrowed the Nerve Vein's hearing from the city's entire chorus down to one instrument, then one section, then one line. Under the hum there were voices. Dozens. Then, when he let the door stand wider, more than dozens — a congregation of them, braided into the harmonic the way interest is braided into a debt, each voice a person who had walked down the petal-road on a wedding day and been taken into the flower's keeping. The tide-priests told the town that the married still sang. The tide-priests, for once in the history of clergy, were telling the truth.

The priests were everywhere above the flood-line. They wore grey-blue robes hemmed in wax that had been sewn and resewn until the hems hung like candle-drip, and they walked the

planks in processions of two and four, and from a pulpit of stacked hull-timbers at the head of the harbor stair, one of them preached the day's arithmetic to a roof-edge congregation. Dar and Suri stopped to hear it, because you always audit a man's doctrine before you audit his books.

"The sea withdraws because the Bride is hungry," the priest said. He had a good voice, kept like a ledger line, and he did not raise it. "The waters go to whoever feeds her, and we have fed her thin. Look at the harbor. Look at the mud. The sea is counting our devotion, neighbors, and finding it short."

The congregation looked at the mud. The mud was very lookable; it went to the horizon.

"Marriage," the priest said, "is the tithe that fills the account. The tide comes home to a faithful household. Ask of the Bride, and she will ask of you, and the ledger of the world will balance." He said it the way Vey used to say things, Dar thought — warmly, maternally, with the whole price list folded inside the tenderness — and then he rebuked himself for the comparison, because Vey was a residue in another city and this man had grown his own.

They lodged among salvage-divers, because the priests' hospice charged by the prayer and the divers charged by the week. Maren's dive-house was a second-story hall built over a drowned chandlery, floorboards strong, windows glazed with what had once been ship's glass, and a stair of rope and spar running down into the open air of the drained street. Maren herself was sixty if she was a day, hands like knotted mooring line, a voice pitched to carry over weather. She looked at Dar's surgeon's hands for exactly as long as it took to price them, looked at Suri's ruined arm for exactly as long as it took to believe it, looked at Vell for longer than either.

"Counting-house?" she said to Vell.

Vell wrote on her slate: BRACK.

Maren's face did something complicated and then settled into the expression of a woman updating an account. "Brack," she said. "We heard Brack's number. Zero." She jerked her chin at the harbor. "Ours is going to be worse. Sit. You'll pay in work. The little one dives, the big one — whatever she does — and the cutter sets hands."

"The cutter sets hands," Dar agreed.

So the week set itself. Dar worked the dive-house's common room each morning, and the divers came to him the way debtors used to come to Saint Ferrous — except that here nobody was billed. Crushed fingers from hauling on the drowned street's doors. A knee that had gone the way of a bad hinge. A child's ear, ruined by a dive into the flooded cistern under the old customhouse. He stitched, and splinted, and reduced, and the clinic of the Saltstairs

reassembled itself in him piece by piece, the muscle memory of the unpriced transaction, and the divers began leaving things by his bench without being asked — a pot of rendered fish-oil, a spool of waxed thread, once, wet from the dive, a child's shoe.

He learned the economy in self-defense, because Suri had learned it first and would not stop narrating it.

"Four hundred and six," she said, on the third evening, lying on the bunk with her boots off and her ledger open on her chest. "That's the casks that went up the inland road since we came. The first caravan was thirty-one casks, two factors, one outrider. Today's was twenty-eight casks, same two factors."

"And the marriages?" Dar said, from the bench, winding thread.

"Two, since we came. The old diver's son, and a woman from the roof-row. Two marriages in, seventy-one casks out." Suri turned her head and looked at him with her flat ledger eyes. "The Bride weeps a lot, Mehran. More than the weddings take. Either she's grieving by the ton, or somebody's milking the flower and calling it doctrine."

The tallow was the why of everything here. He had seen it rendered — the tide-priests let the town see it, that was the display of it: great copper pans behind the harbor temple, the grey-gold grease skinned off the pans and poured into casks, each cask stamped before it went up the road. Bloom-tallow, the divers called it. It burned longer than any wax Maren had ever bought, burned with a low cold light that never guttered, and it glued, and it caulked, and it burned. The seed wept it after every marriage, from the broken edges of the petals, the way a wound weeps — and the priests collected the weeping, rendered it, and sold it inland by the caravan-load. Lowmark's god had been turned into an industry, and the industry's fuel was funerals conducted as weddings.

Tetch, the youngest of Maren's crew — a wiry boy with a diver's swollen knuckles and a voice like a gull — explained the doctrine's economics from the doorway, spitting carefully between every sentence, because the divers spat toward the harbor on principle.

"Marriage gets you heaven, they say. Your girl walks down the petal-road, the flower takes her, and now she sings in the harbor, and you can hear her if you're good." He spat. "My brother's up there. In the chord. He used to sing flat." A pause. "He still does."

The marriage they witnessed was on the fifth dusk, and Dar could not make himself look away from it, because he had spent his life learning to watch a procedure without flinching and he refused to stop being useful now. A bride of the roof-row walked down the petal-road in wax-sealed cloth, attended by priests swinging lamps, and the town watched from every ridge and chimney like a congregation watching a tithe-cart leave. She did not struggle. That was the

worst of it — she walked like a woman who had reviewed the terms, and at the end of the road the petals curled up and over her with a slowness that was almost courteous, and the hum of the drowned choir gained one voice, and the harbor's note came up richer by exactly one singer, and the crowd made a sound that was grief and satisfaction filed under the same word.

Suri stood beside him on the ridge and counted the hymn's bars under her breath. "Forty bars," she said. "Shorter than Ashkarad's. They're economizing on the god."

Vell wrote, and turned the slate: THEY ARE PAID IN CANDLES.

It was after, as the crowd thinned, that the readings began. The priests set a canopy of waxed cloth at the foot of the harbor stair, and under the canopy they set a table, and on the table they set a box. The box was lead, small, worn dull at the corners by a century of hands, and the sight of it did something to the back of Dar's neck before his mind caught up and told him why: lead was for keeping things from the world, and things kept from the world were kept by people who feared them.

A queue formed. Pilgrims, roof-row widows, divers off the rope-walks, anyone with a coin or a memory to sell. For a price, the priest at the table opened the box — Dar saw the inside of the lid, lined in more lead, and a cloth of the greyest grey — and took out what it held, and pressed it to the pilgrim's cupped hands, and the pilgrim's face would go somewhere else entirely. Every one of them came back from that somewhere weeping, or smiling, or both, and the priest would fold the thing back into its cloth and say, "There. You have seen her morning. She wakes, she breaks her bread, she is content. The married want for nothing."

"What is it?" Suri asked, low, watching the box like a creditor watches a strongbox.

The priest at the table answered over the head of his next customer, in the warm administrative voice, as if reading from a notice: "The Bride's relic. Her mercy. A leaf of her own keepsake, preserved in the first salt of the first flood. Readings are two coppers, or one small memory of your own, freely given." He smiled at them both with the smooth confidence of a man whose till has never once come up short. "For the mourning, sisters and brothers. The dead have mornings still. The Bride keeps them for us."

They walked back along the ridge in the dark, above the hum, above the choir, Suri's boots quick and even on the planks. At the door of the dive-house she stopped, and looked back once at the little canopy and its queue, and said it flat, the way she filed things:

"That's not a relic, Mehran."

"No," Dar said. His chest ached where the Lily lay banked and listening; all night she had been leaning toward the harbor, down, toward the petal-road, the way she had leaned at the deep vaults, and he had been leaning with her. "That's a page."

CHAPTER 44

Memory-Vellum

The readings-room sat above the drowned customhouse, which amused a part of Dar's mind that would not stay quiet in any city: the tide-priests had built their mercy-trade over the rooms where Lowmark had once taxed itself honestly. You reached it by a spar-stair from the walkways, past wax lamps burning with that low cold bloom-light, and at the top a man kept the door and the books and the box.

He gave his name as Orlo, registrar of this house of the Bride, and he was a narrow, unhurried person with ink-stained cuffs and the eyes of a man who had priced so many things that his own face had become one of them. He looked at Dar the way counting-house men look at strangers — once for the clothes, once for the hands, once, briefly and with professional distaste, for the obvious. Dar had seen that triple entry before, on auditors and on Mother Gavel's ledgermen. It meant: this one will be expensive to cheat.

"You want a reading," Orlo said. It was not a question. The queue's gossip had already filed them. "Everyone wants a reading, after a wedding. The dead's mornings are very comforting. Two coppers buys you the priest's version." He folded his hands. "For the leaf itself, the house has other rates."

"I want the leaf," Dar said. "The real look. Not the sermon."

"Then you pay the house rate." Orlo drew a shallow tray across the counter and set on it a slip of grey stuff that was not paper — Dar had seen organs kept alive in glass and pages kept alive in wax, and nothing had prepared him for a document that was simply skin grown to a purpose. The slip had the weight of wet vellum and the give of skin that has been dried and pressed and dried again. "One true memory," Orlo said. "Small, and whole, and yours. The house presses it to a blank slip — that pays for the reading — and then you may hold the leaf for the space of eleven breaths. You will be shown what the leaf keeps. You will not be shown what the house does with what you paid. That is the rate. It is the rate for everyone. It was the rate before your city had a name."

"And if the memory isn't mine to give?"

Orlo looked at him a moment longer than the question needed. "Then the house will know," he said, "and the house does not return reading fees."

The press was a machine of black bone and brass, knee-high, older than any tool in the room around it — or it looked older; it had the terrible timelessness of the Gardener's make,

the flower's own aesthetics grown into hardware. A bed of polished black bone. A screw of brass. A slot for the blank slip and, above the bed, a shallow cradle the size of two cupped hands, rimmed in the same grey velum.

"Hands in the cradle," Orlo said. "Think of what you pay. Hold it whole. Hold it at the front of you. The press does the rest. Most people find it like a tooth coming out. Clean, if you don't fight it."

Dar thought about lying. He had one good lie left in the maneuver budget and he was saving it. He put his hands in the cradle.

He paid the smallest true thing he owned that would still weigh something. It was the smell of carbolic soap in the intern washroom of Saint Ferrous Hospital — his first year, the long counter, the row of basins, the soap's white lather and its medicinal bite under the permanent salt of the city, the smell that had meant: you are inside the machine now, but you are clean, and the work is real. A nothing memory. A clerk's memory. He had carried it twenty years without once taking it out to look at, the way you keep a coin you never spend because it is the smallest one you have.

The press took it. There was no pain; that was the horror of it. There was a pressure, a turning, a sensation exactly like a tooth being drawn whole — and then it was done, and the brass screw ran back, and a slip lay in the slot, grey and heavy, one corner embossed with a five-petaled flower that had not been stamped but had simply come up through the slip's own grain, the way frost comes up through a sill.

Dar reached into himself for the washroom and found the room with the smell subtracted. Everything else was there — the counter, the basins, the cracked mirror, his own young hands — and the room was silent the way a room is silent when it has been robbed of one specific thing. He would never smell that soap again. Every memory of Saint Ferrous he owned was now captioned in absence.

The receipt printed itself while he stood there, from a slot in the counter's flank, in ledger-perfect script: RECEIVED — ONE (1) MEMORY, TRUE, SMALL. CONDITION: WHOLE. FILED. He took it, because a man takes a receipt; that reflex outlives everything.

"Eleven breaths," Orlo said, and opened the lead box.

The leaf came out on its grey cloth, and the room's lamps leaned toward it, all that bloom-light bending like grass in wind, and Dar understood that the lamps were not lamps. Nothing that had been alive was pretending very hard to be a lamp in this room.

The leaf was a page. It was heavier than paper, lighter than lead, grey as the inside of a shell, and its edges were finished with the flower — embossed along all four borders, the five

petals repeating like a wallpaper pattern, like a watermark, like a stamp run along a document's length to prove it was money and not paper. A leaf of the World Registry itself. The priests were selling readings off a loose page of the Gardener's books, and calling it mercy, and the terrifying thing, Dar thought, taking it in both hands, was that to this town it probably was.

He breathed once, and touched it, and the last morning came up into him whole.

It was a woman's morning, sixty years old and kept in the page as if it had been pressed that week. Lowmark in flood, but flood the way it had been meant — water where water belonged, boats in streets, light on the harbor. She was young. She was breaking bread on a second-story sill with flour to her wrists, and her sister was braiding her hair with the brisk tenderness of someone who has practiced this exact grief in advance, and her father was keeping his boat, out on the gray water, and working the knots over and over because his hands needed a job that was not shaking. She was dressed in white by the sister's hands. She walked down through the city — through the real Lowmark, the living one, streets loud with people who would not meet her eyes because they had paid her family's debts in silence — and down the harbor stair, and onto the petal-road, and the petals of the Bride stood open for her like doors.

She was not afraid. That was the detail the page kept most cruelly, because it was the detail no sermon would ever use: she was glad. She had counted what her family owed and what she was, and she had decided she was the larger number, and she went down the road toward the dark heart of the flower the way a debtor walks into a counting-house to sign — with the terrible relief of a balance about to be settled.

And Dar understood, holding the eleven breaths of her morning, what the World Registry was actually made of. Not paper. Not vellum. People — the spent parts of people, pressed and filed, the surplus skimmed off every carrier and every vessel the route had ever opened, the way a mill skims the cream and sells the milk twice. The Registry's pages were an industry's waste product that happened to be somebody's whole morning: pressed carrier-memory, dried, cut, ruled, and stamped, and somewhere at the top of that supply chain a white hand signed each leaf like a foreman signing off a batch.

And then, the end of the morning. The end of the page.

The pressing. He was inside it — the memory's final act was its own filing, the last thing the dead woman's morning ever did was become this leaf — and he felt the press of the great bed, the bone under him, the grey of the velum rising through his own last light like frost rising through a floor. And over him, into his sight's last inch, a hand came down to sign.

Left-handed. Bone-white. A wrist with a ring of old burn-scars around it, old scar on old scar, healed wrong and healed long ago, the mark of a person who had once put her hand somewhere fire lived and taken it back out again, changed. The hand held a pen of black bone, and it did not sign a name.

It signed the flower.

Five petals, blooming from a rendered crack, drawn in three strokes, fluid as breathing, identical — Dar knew it was identical because he had a page folded in sterile wrap in the bottom of his pack, Vey's page from the sanctum under the Choratorium, eight cities, one circled in red — identical to the sigil he had been carrying for a season like a debt he could not read. The hand drew the mark once, unhurried, and set the pen down, and pressed the leaf, and that was the end of the morning, and the room came back.

He was standing. His hands were empty; Orlo had the leaf folded in its cloth already, and the box shut, and the receipt drawer closed, and Orlo was looking at him with the first honest expression Dar had seen on him — the expression of a clerk who has watched a customer understand the currency.

"Her mark," Orlo said. "The Bride's own, so they say here. She signs every leaf of the Registry. No name. The house has ten thousand of her signatures in the vaults and not one of them is a word." He said it as doctrine, bored, a man reciting a page he had inherited. "A name is a thing you are given. The mark is the thing that is given you."

Over and over, Dar thought. Like a stamp. She had signed the World Registry the way the Church stamped hearts, the way the census chalked doors — not because she could not write her name, but because the name was not the point; the mark was the account, and the account was the flower, and the flower was everywhere, blooming from every crack in every stone the route owned.

He walked down the spar-stair with his receipt in his pocket and the smell of carbolic soap subtracted from his past, and behind him, through the temple wall, he heard the drowned choir shift to a new harmonic, patient and vast.

That night, in the dive-house dark, he gave the Lily his palm and she drank, and afterward he held his hand open against the floorboards and frost came up through the grain of the wood in a slow fan of grey petals, every one of them pointing not toward the harbor this time, but up the hill, toward the readings-room, toward the lead box and the leaf and the counting-annex behind it where the vault-arches stood open and he had glimpsed, on his way out, shelf after shelf of grey leaves in their thousands, and a brass counter ticking to itself in the dark like a patient pulse-reader.

She knows her sister's paperwork, he thought. Or her mother's. The frost petals held their pointing, and he watched them until they melted with the dawn, and made his counts, and did not sleep again.

CHAPTER 45

True Currency

The Ashkarad box came up out of the vault on a dumbwaiter of brass and bone, and it was smaller than Dar had spent a day and a night expecting it to be.

The counting-annex lay behind the readings-room, down a hall of open arches, and the hall was the Registry in miniature: shelf after shelf of grey leaves in lead boxes, each box lettered and numbered in the vertical counting-house hand, each leaf somebody's pressed and filed remainder. Orlo walked the aisle with the lamplight bending after him, and stopped at a box marked with the route's own filing code, and set it on the counter, and opened it, and there was Ashkarad — not the city, the city's paper, the deposit-copies of everything the city's one carrier had ever spent.

The index leaf lay on top. MEHRAN, DARIUS, it read, in entries as clean as surgery notes, and Dar read his own account down the page like a man reading his autopsy.

MOTHER — FACE. FATHER — LAUGH. FIRST KISS. HOME — COLOR. PATIENT, FIRST — LOSS. The last of those had a second notation beside it, in smaller script: SPENT ONCE — READING, BRACK — and was priced here all over again. Everything you paid the Registry, Dar saw, could be charged to you twice: once to spend it, once to look at having spent it.

Five entries. Five withdrawals from the only account he had ever been afraid to overdraw, each one pressed out of him by fire or by his own hand at the moment he had needed the credit most, and each one priced now in the house's denomination, in the margin, in Orlo's vertical script. The patient was priced at one true memory, small. The first kiss was priced higher. The laugh was priced the same as the patient. The face — and he knew which entry the face was, because his eye went to it the way a tongue goes to a broken tooth, MOTHER — FACE, two words, no date, the only entry on the page that had been written in the black bone pen rather than the registrar's chalk — the face was priced at a decade.

"A decade of a life," Orlo said, following his eye with the serenity of a man quoting a wall-chart. "The house prices memories in memories, carrier. The face is worth ten years of living, pressed at the standard rate. No one pays it twice."

"I don't want to buy it," Dar said. "Not yet. I want a playing. The laugh."

"A playing." Orlo turned the index leaf over, found the tariff, recited it flat. "The house lends the deposit into your senses. You will hold it as if it were yours, because for the term of

the loan it is. Eleven heartbeats for the small rate. One true memory pays. Small and whole," he added, and the phrase had worn a groove in him, "and yours."

"I know the rate."

"I don't think you do," Orlo said, without heat. "But the press will teach you. It always does."

The cradle waited by the press like a pair of cupped hands. Suri stood at the end of the counter with her arms folded over the ruined strap of her graft, and Vell stood by the door with her slate held against her chest the way other people hold prayers, and Dar put his hands into the velum rim and went hunting through his own architecture for the thing he intended to spend.

He offered the woman in the salt garden.

It was the oldest piece of somebody else he owned — the memory bleed from the first weeks, before he had ever heard the word Gardener: rows of sleepers planted like bulbs, the tower with its windows lit like heartbeats, and the woman in white gloves moving down the rows and humming, and the hum so much his mother's lullaby that for a year he had not been able to tell whose memory it actually was. It was a real memory. It had weight, and texture, and a morning's worth of light in it. He held it whole in the front of his mind, the way Orlo had taught the paying, and felt the press descend.

The press refused it.

There was no violence in the refusal; there was something worse, a bureaucratic convulsion. The brass screw stopped. From the counter's flank the little printer coughed, and a slip came out, and Dar read it upside down before Orlo could turn it.

RHYTHM UNRESOLVED. NOT NATIVE TO ACCOUNT. FILING FAULT.

And beneath that, in a second strike, harder, the way a stamp comes down when the clerk is insulted: COUNTERFEIT — ALREADY FILED.

Orlo took the slip, read it, and slid it across the counter with two fingers, and for the first time since the spar-stair his face lost its priced serenity and became what it had probably been before the pricing, which was careful.

"You tried to pay with another person's morning," he said. "The house knows its own paper, carrier. That memory is on deposit somewhere already — pressed, filed, owned. You cannot spend what was only ever lent to you. If it had gone through, you would have paid your debt with counterfeit and the house would have collected the difference out of the rest of you." He let that sit. "Now. A true memory. Yours. Small."

Dar stood in the cradle with his hands in the velum rim and did the one thing he had promised himself in the dark of the dive-house that he would not do, which was to think about it first. Thinking about it was how you chose the cheap thing, and there was no cheap thing left that was true. His inventory ran itself the way the Nerve Vein ran the city: the Saltstairs stairwell, the fight pit, the barge, the cistern, Vahid's chalk ladder, Ilay's copper head bent over charcoal, the roof in the first storm, the seawalls opening — and then the mornings, because he had a trader's instinct for the exchange rate even now, even here.

There was one morning that was his. The first one. The clinic's first morning, three days after the Blacktide, when the silence was still so loud it had a texture, and he had unlocked the door of the salt-rotted chandlery off the Saltstairs stair and put Vahid's chalk ladder on the wall and the one chair by the table, and nobody had come for an hour, and then everybody had come for the rest of his life. Suri had counted the floor tiles out loud, forty-one, because the counting was hers and no one could repossess it. Ilay had sat in the corner drawing spirals that tightened inward, room by room, like a search that was also a grief. The light had come through the high barred window the color of dirty pewter, and it had been, against every probability the city offered, an unpriced morning, the first one he had ever owned.

He paid it.

The press took it room by room. That was the cruelty of the mechanism — it did not take the whole at once; it took the door, then the stair, then the chalk, then the light, and each taking was clean, a tooth coming out whole, and Dar stood in the cradle with his eyes open and filed nothing, because there was nothing left in him that could object loudly enough. The morning left the way the tide had left the flats. Gradually. Then all at once. Then not at all.

The receipt came out of the counter's flank: RECEIVED — ONE (1) MORNING, TRUE. CONDITION: WHOLE. FILED.

"There is a piece of that in me too," Suri said. Her voice did not rise; it did the opposite of rising, it went down into its flattest register, the one she used for totals. "Forty-one tiles, Mehran. I counted them. That was mine as much as yours." A pause, exactly as long as a ledger line. "You didn't ask."

"I know," Dar said. "I'm not going to pretend that makes it clean. It makes it spent, and spent is the only tense the Registry keeps."

Orlo drew the deposit-box across the counter and opened the index to the second entry and lifted out a leaf no bigger than his palm, and set it in the reading-tray, and said, "Eleven heartbeats. The house counts."

Suri's hand was on Dar's wrist before he touched the leaf. Two fingers, the counting position, her eyes on his pulse rather than his face, because someone in the room had to keep the books and he was about to be away.

The laugh came back into him like a lamp being lit in a swept room.

His father's laugh. The whole of it — not the sound alone, the sound is the least of a laugh — the doorway he had stood in, the coat over the chair, the big hands mid-gesture with a bottle and a story, the sense a child has that the largest thing in the house is amused, and the laugh itself, rolling, unhurried, a laugh that had never once in its life been performed. For eleven heartbeats it was his, and he stood inside it, a grown man with two hearts, ten years of surgeries and one spent childhood, and listened.

And inside the laugh — under it, woven into it the way a second voice is woven into a round, so quiet he would have missed it if the Registry's press had not pressed the morning whole, nothing skimmed, nothing left out — a woman was humming.

The lullaby.

The laugh withdrew on the eleventh heartbeat, exactly as billed. The leaf went back into its slot. The room was the room again, lamps and lead and the tick of the counter, and Dar stood with Suri's fingers still on his wrist and did the arithmetic that the deposit had just made unavoidable, entry by entry, in the vertical hand of his own mind.

His father had been a clerk of the seawall works who could not carry a tune and had never, in any memory Dar retained — in any memory the Registry still held — sung, hummed, whistled, or kept company with anyone who did. His father's world was tide-tables and pint measures and the names of other men's boats. The lullaby did not live in that world. It could not have entered it by itself.

It entered it carried. Sung where he could hear. Night after night, in the rooms above the clerk's books, close enough and constant enough to soak into the walls of an ordinary evening, into the coat on the chair, into the pause before a laugh — his mother's song, present in his father's morning the way salt is present in everything the sea has touched.

"That song is not from here," Dar said. He was not aware he had said it aloud until the room answered.

The answer was not words. She never spent words. But the hum rose in his bones, in the marrow the second Vein had made dense as coral — the lullaby's opening bars, felt not heard, keyed to the exact phrase that had been woven under his father's laugh — and she held the denial inside the music itself, a flat sustained tone under the melody, the sound a ledger makes when a column refuses to total. No, she said, in the only voice she had. Not from here.

His mother had sung the Gardener's song in a seawall clerk's rooms above the works, a lifetime before the Blacktide, before the Choratorium, before the seed in his chest had ever heard of Darius Mehran. The Registry had just shown him the receipt.

Suri opened her ledger against the counter and wrote, in her flat bookkeeper's hand, one line under the day's column, and turned the page so he could see it filed: THE CLINIC'S FIRST MORNING — SPENT. WORTH IT: UNKNOWN. KEEP COUNTING.

"Come away from the counter," she said. "You've bought everything they're selling today."

CHAPTER 46

Three Heartbeats of Her Face

Dar came back to the counting-annex at the turn of the tide-priests' lazy morning, when the lamps in the arch hall burned their lowest and the vault shelves stood quiet, and he laid Vey's folded page on the counter beside the Ashkarad box, because today he was going to stop being a customer and start being an account.

"The face," he said. "Not a playing. A look at the entry itself."

Orlo did not ask which entry. The registrar turned the index leaf over with one finger, and the groove his serenity had worn the day before was still there, and he read the tariff line the way a man reads a weather he has no intention of arguing with.

"A decade of a life," he said. "That is the price of the face. Not eleven heartbeats — a look is not a loan; a look is the door opened onto the deposit, and the deposit is the whole of her, pressed at the moment of filing. The house prices a door like that in living. Ten years, standard rate, pressed and filed to the house before the door opens." He folded his hands on the counter. "No one pays it twice. Very few pay it once. I have been registrar of this house for twenty-two years and I have seen the decade paid three times, and two of the three were seed."

"We don't have a decade," Suri said, from the end of the counter. "We have a road, a crate of cylinders, and whatever the tide-priests haven't confiscated."

"Then you have the house's paper," Orlo said, "or you have nothing," and that was when Vell stepped forward and put her slate on the counter, and wrote on it, pressing hard enough that the chalk squealed, in her vertical counting-house hand:

COLLATERAL: ME. BRACK CUSTOM. THE BODY SIGNS.

Dar read it twice, because the first reading refused to be true. Vell stood beside the counter with her chin up and her burned-salt hands flat on the wood, a small woman who had survived the drowning of one city and the drowning of its books, offering herself into the ledger the way her people had offered themselves for a hundred years — and Brack's custom was the oldest entry in Ashkarad's oldest nightmares: the body in the book. Not a promise. Not a signature. A lien, held against flesh, exercisable at default, and every counting-house in Brack had exercised, in the end, because that was what the harvest had been — the whole city foreclosed.

"No," Dar said.

Vell wiped the slate with the heel of her hand and wrote again, fast, the chalk snapping once against the wood: I AM ALREADY COLLATERAL. BRACK COUNTED ME WORTH EATING. I WOULD RATHER THE BOOK BE ONE I CHOSE.

"You're not paper," Dar said. His voice came out in the surgeon's register, the one that does the counting during the bleeding. "You're a witness. You're the only person on this route who has seen the harvest close up and kept her numbers — and a witness who signs herself into a ledger stops being a witness the moment the holder decides to collect. That's not a rate, Vell. That's the whole account, given away for a look through a door."

Vell looked at him. Then she wrote, slower, and the slowness was the argument: THE OTHERS SIGNED. EVERY ONE OF THEM. THEY WERE NOT PAPER EITHER.

"And that sentence is what the burning was for," Dar said. "No."

He put his hand flat over the slate, over the words, the way you close a ledger you refuse to balance, and Vell looked at his hand for a long moment, and then did the thing he would remember about her for the rest of a life that had been getting shorter in entries all season: she nodded, once, like a clerk accepting a ruling she intends to appeal forever, and stepped back from the counter.

It was Suri who closed the gap, because Suri understood instruments the way Orlo understood them — as load-bearing things.

"The paper," she said. "The house's paper. Read me the terms."

Orlo produced the promissory from a drawer lined in lead, and it was a single leaf of the grey velum, blank, humming faintly the way the vault shelves hummed, and he laid it flat and read the terms in the voice of a man who has read them so many times they have worn smooth. The debt would be denominated in the house's currency: a decade of a life, pressed at the standard rate, from any account the signatory designated or, failing designation, from any account the house designated. Interest would accrue at the road's discretion. The holder of the paper would be the road itself — not the house, not the Bride, not the Registry's far vaults, but the route, the round, the collection entire — and the road's collections were not performed by clerks.

"Who collects for the road?" Suri asked, though Dar could see by her face that she had already read the answer in the room, in the wax hems, in the flower stamped through everything in this city like a watermark through money.

"The heralds," Orlo said. "The road's paper is herald paper. It is honored on presentation."

Suri read the leaf twice, clause by clause, and she counted the clauses aloud as she read, because the counting was hers and no one could repossess it, and Dar watched her do the thing she had done in Mother Gavel's fighting pit and at the seawalls and in every transaction of her life: price herself into the arrangement before anyone else could. Eleven clauses. She made Orlo repeat the seventh, the one about designated accounts, and watched his eyes when he repeated it, and then she took the registrar's pen of grey bone and signed her name in a hand as flat and vertical as a column total, and the leaf drank the name out of the air the instant it was written, the way salt drinks water.

"On account," Orlo said, "the house shows three heartbeats of the deposit. The door opens that far. It opens no farther until the decade is paid." He drew a shallow reading-tray of black bone across the counter and set the MOTHER — FACE leaf in it, face up, and the leaf was smaller than the others and heavier than it should have been, the way a thing is heavier when more than one person's grief has been pressed into it.

Suri's fingers found Dar's wrist. The counting position. Her eyes went to his pulse, not his face.

He touched the leaf, and the face arrived.

It came up out of the grey the way the bride's morning had come up, whole and warm and immediate, but there was no morning around it — no room, no city, no light — only the face itself, held in the dark of the deposit like a lamp lit in a swept room, and for the space of one heartbeat it was the most complete thing he had ever seen. The jaw was right. He knew the jaw was right the way his hands knew sutures, below thought, below memory, in the place where the body keeps what the mind has spent. The mouth was right, and the way her head sat on her neck, tilted two degrees, listening for something in another room — the kettle going, his own small crying, the bell of the seawall works tolling the tide — all of it right, all of it hers, and Dar stood in the second heartbeat and understood that he was looking at his mother.

In the third heartbeat, it went wrong.

Not by much. That was the obscenity of it. The jaw stayed right, the mouth stayed right, the tilt of the head stayed right — and the eyes changed. They were older than any mother's eyes. Not tired-old; not grief-old; old in the way the route stones were old, in the way the five-petaled flower carved a hundred years ago under the salt bloom was old — a time-depth that no human face could carry without the face collapsing under it, and the face did not collapse, which was how Dar knew, in the last instant he had the face at all, that whatever he was looking at, it had never once been his mother.

The Lily went still.

Not banked. Not dim. Still — the stillness of a guest who has recognized a stranger in a family photograph, the stillness of a thing that held, folded away in whatever ledger it kept inside him, the original of this picture, pressed whole the day the two of them fused, and knew precisely, to the note, how the copy in front of him differed from it. She held her stillness out to him like a verdict, and Dar read it the way he read a pulse: not her. Not her.

And the face, fading — the grey rising through it like frost rising through a floor, the way every filed thing in this house eventually frosted over — shaped its mouth around three syllables of an endearment he had never heard in his life.

There was no sound. The deposit kept no sound, or the sound was pressed somewhere else, filed in some other box, sold in some other city. But the shape of the syllables carried their meaning the way the lullaby carried its own — a dead language that understood itself without hearing — and the meaning arrived in Dar whole, priced and labeled, from a mouth he did not know by a mother he could not remember, and the meaning was:

Little root.

The grey took the rest. The tray was empty. The lamps stood up straight again. Suri's fingers were still on his wrist, and she said, "Three," and let go, and the counting was done.

They stood on the rope-walk outside the customhouse for a long time, the three of them, above the drowned street with its drowned shopfronts and its heat-berry glow coming up green along the flood-line, and the harbor hummed its district-sized chord below, and nobody filed anything for a while.

"It was wrong," Dar said at last. "The face. Everything was right except it was wrong — and she knew." His hand lay flat on his sternum, over the banked heat of the second heart. "She has the original. When we — " he did not finish that. When we fused, you drank my memories, and you have been keeping hers ever since, in the dark, in the ledger you keep inside me. He did not say it. He said instead: "The Registry doesn't hold my mother's face. It holds whatever the house decided my mother's face was. A composite. A copy of a copy. And copies of copies, in my trade, are how wrong limbs get attached."

Vell wrote on her slate, and held it up: THEN WHO FILED THE COPY?

That was the question, and it had teeth in it, because a deposit did not press itself. Someone had taken a face that was not quite his mother's and entered it, under his name, in the World Registry's books — signed it, in three strokes, blooming from a crack — and Dar could think of exactly one hand that signed that way, over and over, like a stamp, and he could not yet think of one honest reason why that hand would bother to forge his mother.

Suri did not say any of it. Suri sat down on the rope coil by the walkway rail, opened her ledger on her knees, ruled a new column with the edge of her wax knife — four strokes, unhurried, a clerk making the books fit the world instead of the world fit the books — and wrote the column's title at the top in her flat bookkeeper's hand, each letter priced and filed:

WHAT WE OWE THE ROAD.

Below it, as the first entry, she wrote: ONE (1) LOOK — THREE HEARTBEATS — PAID: PROMISSORY, UNSIGNED BY ME IN SPIRIT, SIGNED BY ME IN INK.

Then she closed the ledger, and looked out at the harbor, at the black flower the size of a district lying in its drained bed, and said, to the city as much as to him:

"Interest at the road's discretion, Mehran. I've been charged by worse."

CHAPTER 47

Bloom-Tallow

The announcement came at first light, and Suri counted it the way she counted everything now, because the counting was hers and nobody on this road could repossess it: two criers on the harbor stair, one writ of the Bridewarden read aloud in the warm administrative voice the priests all seemed to grow into their robes with, and four hundred and some faces on the roof-rows going still in the particular way of people doing arithmetic they do not want done.

"By grace of the Bride and the necessity of the tide," the crier said, "a marriage-tithe is declared. The account of the city runs short. The Bride asks a bride."

"The Bride asks a bride," the second crier repeated, and unrolled the schedule, and Suri heard the name from three roofs away, in the flat silence that followed it, and was moving before the crier's echo finished.

The crop was a child.

Hessa — no surname; the pruning roads had taken it, or she had; refugees off the flats learned to travel light in every column — was eleven years old, small for it, quiet in the way of children who have audited their own situation and filed it under unsolvable. She had come into Lowmark a month back with a salvage caravan off the drowned coast settlements, walking the whole distance, Maren said, with her shoes tied around her neck so the salt would not eat them, and Maren's dive-house had taken her in the way the dive-house took in everything the tide gave back: without a ledger entry. For four weeks she had been nobody's account. Then the priests had come to the roof-rows with their needle-test, grading blood in the doorways the way the Church of Ashkarad had once graded vessels — and the girl's blood had answered them.

Stock. Suri had stood in the doorway of Maren's common room and watched the needle come away from the child's arm and watched the priest's face do its entries, and she had known the word before he priced it, because she had sat up nights in a Saltstairs clinic guarding another child with the same column in her file. Sibling stock. Nursery-grown, hymn-fed, the Church's long investment — except that this one's Church had drowned, and the road's Church had come to collect the returns.

"The stock is the Bride's by the law of the route," the priest at Maren's door had said, not unkindly, which was the worst of it. "She was sown to sing. Let her sing where singing is kept."

Now the criers had scheduled it: marriage at dusk, the petal-road, the full rite. Suri spent the morning doing what she did instead of despairing, which was bookkeeping. She sat on Maren's roof with her ledger open on her knee and the harbor laid out below her like a column waiting to be totaled, and she added up a city.

The Bride's yields, as doctrine told them: the weeping of the petals after every marriage, the bloom rendered in the copper pans behind the temple, the whole of it the god's own substance, tithed to the town's keeping. The casks out: four hundred and six since the strangers came, and Suri had numbers for the weeks before that too, because Tetch's older sister kept the dock tallies and Tetch's older sister could be traded with. The marriages in: eleven in the season. Eleven marriages' weeping, against four hundred and six casks. Suri ran the rate twice, because you always run a shortfall twice before you accuse anyone of it, and the shortfall did not shrink. It was not a shortfall. It was a skim, and it had a schedule, and the schedule ran weekly, up the inland road, toward the reef-city on the leviathan's carcass where the books said the rendering was done at scale.

"They're not tithing the bloom to the Bride," she told Dar, in the common room, while he restocked the bench from Maren's salvage. "They're tithing it to Gullet. The god weeps, the priests milk, the traders haul. The marriages are just the udder."

Dar tied off a bandage, said, "I've heard worse theology," and did not smile, and Suri filed the line under the column she kept for the things he said when he was already three moves into a plan she hadn't been shown yet.

The audit itself she did that afternoon, in person, because numbers you have not stood in front of are rumors. The granary stood at the head of the petal-stairs, a stone-buttressed barn of a building where the tallow casks were staged for the weekly caravan, and its tally-boards hung by the loading door in plain view, because the priests had never needed to hide their arithmetic — who was left in Lowmark to check it? She walked the loading yard with Maren's tally-stick in her sleeve and Tetch on look-out at the stair, and she read the boards, and copied nothing, because the counting was hers and it lived in her head now — Vell chalked the totals after her anyway, a second copy, a clerk's insurance — filed under the day's column: casks rendered, casks blessed, casks tithed to the temple floor — and then, under the temple's own mark, the second ledger, the real one: casks sold, casks priced, the factors' chits stacked on an iron spike like receipts for a god they had already sold. Each chit was stamped with the flower, and each flower had been countersigned at the bottom by a Gullet factor's mark, and the prices on them were the prices of industry, not faith.

She was back over the rope-walk before the bells, with the whole skim priced and filed, and dusk came down on Lowmark like a hand closing a book.

The petal-road at dusk was the most obscene beautiful thing Suri had ever been forced to look at — the great black petals slicked with their own weeping, the wax lamps of the procession bowing their cold light along the road, the hum of the drowned choir rising up through the soles of the walkways until her back teeth ached with it — and down the center of the road, small in the too-big white, walked the crop.

The Bridewarden himself officiated, a vast calm man with a voice like the tide coming in, and the rite began the way the rites began, with the hymn, forty bars, economized — and Suri stood at the rail of the harbor stair with her whole body counting, and watched Dar walk out onto the petal-road.

He did not run. That was the first thing the crowd noticed, and the thing they told each other after: the cutter from the dive-house walked out into the procession at the pace of a man crossing his own clinic, and he went to his knees before the bride as if the road itself had summoned him, and he said, in a voice pitched to carry to the last roof, "The town's surgeon examines the bride. Every diver here has paid me in work and I have never yet billed any of you. Nobody prices this child today but me."

The Bridewarden's calm did not flicker; he extended one hand in permission the way you permit weather. And Dar turned back the wax-cloth from the girl's hairline, and the crowd saw what Suri had already seen from the stair and could do nothing about except count: under the marriage-crown, the crown of wax and bloom the priests had set on the bride's head, the child's scalp was already sutured. Stitched. Seven knots of waxed thread, worked in the tide-temple's neat surgical hand, anchoring the crown into living skin — the marriage had been performed in advance, in a side chapel, without consent, without witnesses, and the ceremony on the road was only the delivery.

"Seven sutures," Dar said to the crowd, and his voice did not rise either; it dropped, into the register Suri had heard him use on mothers in the Saltstairs, the one that makes a room go quiet by refusing to be loud. "She is eleven. The crown is grown in. If she walks the road today, the flower does not take a bride — it takes a graft that has already been sewn, and everything the priests have told this city about the married wanting for nothing is a lie stitched into a child's scalp." And he took out his knife, and he cut.

He cut the way he cut — Blood Vein quiet under the skin, the girl's blood holding in her veins at his word so that there was no red on the white cloth at all, seven knots unpicked in the space of twelve of the Bridewarden's heartbeats, the crown coming free into his hands like something aborted — and he stood up on the petal-road holding the marriage in his hands, and the town of Lowmark, which could count, counted.

Suri took the pulpit stair. Not asked; she had stopped waiting to be asked sometime around the second city of her acquaintance. She stood where the criers had stood at first light and she read the numbers, flat, at carrying volume, the shortfall and then the skim and then the schedule, eleven marriages against four hundred and six casks, the god's weeping priced and sold up the road to Gullet's factors at the prices of industry, and she finished with the worst figure, the one she had saved: the Bride's own share, per the priests' own second ledger, since the season began.

"Zero," she said. "They're not feeding her. They're farming her."

The silence afterward had a texture. Then Maren's voice came off the roof-row, gravel and rope: "My son sings flat up there," she said, "and you billed me for his candle," and the dive-house crews came down their stairs with their hands empty and their faces full, and the Bridewarden stood on the petal-road among his wax lamps and did the arithmetic of a man watching his congregation convert in real time, and gave no order at all, because there was no longer an order that totaled.

They took the child home through the crowd with Dar's coat around her and Suri's hand on her shoulder, and on Maren's roof, in the common room, with fish stew going cold around her, Hessa began to hum. Low, automatic, terrified — the claiming-hymn rising out of her blood because her blood had been taught it before she could walk, the Church's long investment waking to collect. Dar crouched in front of her and did not tell her to stop. He put two fingers on her wrist, the counting position, and breathed with her, one, two, three, until the hymn lost its place and the girl's own breathing filed in under it, and Suri sat across the table and entered the child in her ledger under the only heading she had left: OURS. THE ROAD CAN'T HAVE HER. STAY COUNTED. YOU ARE OURS NOW.

The granary burned itself that night.

No torch, no spark, no sappers — the divers on the roofs swore it to a person, and Suri believed them, because she had seen the frost. Grey petals had come up over the granary doors an hour after midnight, fine as breath on glass, fanning across the stone the way they fanned across Dar's camp-canvas, and then the tallow inside had caught from within, all four hundred casks of the priests' skimmed and hoarded god lighting along the seam-lines at once with a low cold green flame that did not gutter and did not spread to the neighboring roofs, a fire with the good manners of an audit. It burned to the waterline of its own floor and stopped. The priests stood in the yard and watched their surplus become light and did not reach for one bucket, and out in the drained harbor the drowned choir shifted, and the hum came up richer by one long note, like a ledger, somewhere, being balanced.

In the morning, in the wet ash of the loading yard, Suri found the chit. It had been on the iron spike with the others; now it lay on the staging table with the table's legs burned out from under it, face up, unburned — stamped with the five-petaled flower in strokes as fluid as breathing, and countersigned beneath in the Gullet factor's mark, and under the countersignature, in a third hand, small and vertical and terribly patient, the instruction that had licensed the whole skim, the whole season, the whole route:

PER THE RECLAIM — SUSTAIN THE ROUTE.

Suri read it three times. Then she folded it into her ledger, into the new column, the one she had opened on the rope-walk two days ago with the knife-edge of a wax stick, and she wrote beneath it the only entry the morning allowed: EVIDENCE — ONE (1) — and, after a moment, looking up the inland road toward the reef-city and the monastery and whatever else the route kept ahead of them:

THE ROAD IS SUSTAINED. THE QUESTION IS BY WHOM.

CHAPTER 48

The Walking Quiet

Five days out of Lowmark, the frost changed its mind.

Every dawn of the road, Suri had walked the camp's perimeter before the light came up and read the night's frost off the canvas the way other people read a gauge — grey petals feathered fine as breath on glass, every fan of them pointing west and down, back along the route, toward the deep heartbeat under the Throne shaft. It was the Lily's compass, her appetite, and her homesickness filed in a single entry, and Suri had learned its grammar well enough that she only woke Dar when the grammar broke.

On the fifth morning she woke him.

"They've changed ledgers," she said, and held the canvas where he could see it. The petals still pointed — frost always pointed; that was the one honest thing about it — but not west. The fans had swung through a half-turn in the night, and every petal now stood aimed down the route, toward the horizon they were walking into.

Vell was already at the route stone with her chalk out. She wrote on the stone's flank, under the weathered five-petaled flower, in her narrow counting-house hand: PETALS TURNED IN THE NIGHT. CAUSE: AHEAD. And beneath it, because she was Brack to the bone: LOGGED.

All that day the Lily leaned forward instead of back, and Dar's balance went with her, so that for the first time since the seawalls his body was voting for the direction the party was already going. It should have been a relief. It was not a relief. It was the feeling of a hand that has been resting on your collar turning, gently, into a hand that is pointing.

"You're listing again," Suri said, in the afternoon. "Forward, this time. Like a barge that's decided where it wants to be."

"She leans ahead," Dar said.

"Toward what? There's nothing on this stretch. I counted the masts yesterday. Sixty-one dead ships, one living fly, no water."

"I don't know. Something that takes a whole city to say."

The mountain came over the horizon at dusk, and by noon the next day it was still coming, and by noon it had moved.

Nobody said anything for a while. A mountain that moved was a thing the eye kept filing and kept getting back stamped REFUSED. It was a walled town — walls of black stone, towers, a lantern-glow along the parapets like banked coals — and it stood on legs. Dozens of them, grey, thick as harbor pillars, jointed at the knee, taking their turn in a gait so patient it took half a minute to see that it was a gait at all. The city walked the way old men walk to a service they do not expect to outlive: slowly, correctly, without complaint.

And it made no sound. That was the part that sat worst. A town of that weight should have ground the flats to powder beneath it; the horizon should have carried its thunder the way the route carried its stones. Instead the walking arrived as a feeling in the soles, a slow double pulse through the ground, one-two, one-two, like a heart that had decided to become a pilgrimage.

"The legs are the endowment," Dar said, when he had watched long enough.

The Lily, all the while, was leaning through him toward the walking city with a want that had no manners in it at all — not the banked, patient pull she kept for the deep heartbeat, but the flat, immediate hunger of a thing that has heard a voice through a wall it has been walking toward all its life. Dar held her the way you hold a door against wind. Whatever slept in the Vigil had been shut up behind lead and silence for two hundred years, and his passenger wanted to introduce herself through his ribs at a volume he refused to imagine. He passed Vell the thought and she took it up, chalk moving: THE LEGS ARE THE LEGACY? He shook his head and pointed, and she looked — at the columns, at the regular seam-lines running up each one, at the little dark doors set into the seams at shoulder height, hundreds of them, thousands, each door the size of a coffin-lid — and her chalk stopped.

The Vigil did not rest its walking on machinery. The Order had been filing its dead into the load-bearing work for as long as the city had walked, and the city walked on its founders, on its abbots, on its schoolteachers and its bell-ringers, every one of them sealed into a cell in a leg with their name scored on the inside where only they could read it. The dead of the Vigil did not rest in the ground. The ground of the Vigil was in ongoing session.

They were seen, of course. Long before a shout could have crossed the distance, a single walker came out from the city's shadow across the flats — a grey robe, a rope belt, boots wrapped in felt so the footsteps would cost the world nothing, and a slate hanging from a strap. The monk stopped forty feet off, lifted the slate, and wrote.

YOU BRING FROST. THE CITY READS ITS WEATHER. WELCOME.

The party's own frost had spoken for them before they did. Dar looked back at their camp-canvas, at the grey fans all standing compass-true toward the walking city, and

understood that out here the Lily's weather was a letter of introduction, and that it had been read.

Vell stepped forward and wrote on her own slate, and the monk read her counting-house hand, and went very still — and then wrote back, quickly, in a grammar of abbreviations that was Brack's ledger-script to the stroke. Dar watched his only mute companion conduct, in chalk, the first conversation she had been fluent in since her city drowned. Whatever grief it cost her to be understood that well, she banked it, and kept writing.

The monk's slate rose one more time. COME. WALK SOFT. NOTHING ABOVE A WHISPER, BY THE RULE.

The gate stood at ground level between two legs, and the city bent over them as they passed under it like a cathedral leaning down to a doorstep. Inside, the whisper-rule was not a sign; it was the architecture. The streets were swept stone, and the few people abroad moved close to the walls and spoke — when they spoke at all — at a volume that would not have carried across a sickroom. Bells hung muffled in felt. A market was concluding in total silence, buyers and sellers settling prices with fingers and slates, and children passed by in a line, each one speaking, when they had to, at the volume of snow. The city's walking they did not hear at all. It came up through the bones.

The Abbot was waiting at the second gate, and he was the oldest thing in a city of old things — a spare man in grey, salt-scoured, with a voice that had the grain of paper that has been folded and unfolded for decades. He did not greet them. He stepped close to Dar, bowed his grey head, and laid his ear flat against Dar's sternum, over the coat, over the cloth, with the matter-of-fact trespass of a physician and the patience of a man listening to a cellar.

He listened for a long time. Somewhere above them the city took a step.

"Two," the Abbot whispered, straightening. "One of them hers." His eyes were the eyes of a man reading a figure he had only ever seen in other people's margins. "You carry one of the nine."

"We do," Dar said, at the permitted volume.

"Then the Vigil owes you hospitality, and hospitality has one condition." The Abbot's whisper did not waver; it had been worn smooth by a lifetime below the voice-line, and it was the most frightening voice Dar had heard all year because it had clearly never once needed to rise. "Lead-glass quarters. For the world's safety. Indefinitely."

Suri heard the word and priced it where she stood. "Indefinitely," she repeated, flat, making it a column heading.

"It is not a cage," the Abbot said. "The door does not lock. But a seed hears a seed across a mile of quiet, and we keep a quiet here that the world cannot afford to spend. What rides in you would call to what sleeps in us, and what sleeps in us must not be called. The glass muffles you. The offer has no term, because the sleeping has no term. You would walk with us. Many have chosen worse."

"Many have chosen worse," Dar agreed, "and paid for the choosing forever. We'll take the glass for the nights. For the days, I'll work — I saw your necks on the road in. A city that whispers for a living wears its throats the way miners wear their lungs, and I'm the only surgeon this circuit has seen in years. Treat the trade as paid."

The Abbot considered him for a moment with the unhurried attention of a man whose calendar ran in decades.

"Guests are shown one thing," he said at last. "It is the rite. Afterward you may owe us nothing, and we may owe you, and the glass will stand open regardless. Come and see what the Vigil is for."

They went down. The guest-rite's last station was beneath the gate, behind a door of lead that two monks unbarred in absolute silence: a round chamber, walled in lead, faced in panels of glass so old and thick the world beyond it moved like slow water — and in the chamber's center, raised on a plinth of black stone, a cradle.

A cradle of lead, lined with cloth gone grey, sized for nothing larger than a large book. It had the worn, honored look of a thing that had held something precious for a very long time, the way a doorframe holds the shape of every hand that used it.

"The founder's tomb," the Abbot whispered. "He built the Order after the Burning, when the roads were still full of things that sang. He built this chamber to hold the registry's first page. Page zero. The leaf the whole ledger was written on top of — the first account, the one that came before the nine. The Order kept it four circuits. It was our one inheritance and our one duty, and we kept it the way you keep a heart: in lead, in the dark, uncounted."

Dar looked at the empty cradle, and the cold arrived in his hands before the arithmetic did.

"The tomb is empty," he said, already knowing.

"The tomb is empty. A herald came, within the decade. She presented the road's authority, which the founder's own charter obliges us to honor, and she took the page, and she left a receipt we cannot read, and the Order let her go, because we have never once learned how to refuse the route." The Abbot folded his hands. His whisper never changed volume, and that was the worst of it — a man reporting the loss of his order's one sacred thing in the tone of a clerk reading a shortfall he had already carried to his superior. "The road took its own first

page back, surgeon. Whatever the collection is for, it has begun collecting the beginning."

Suri wrote nothing. Vell wrote one line and turned the slate, not to the Abbot but to Dar:

IF SHE HAS PAGE ZERO, SHE HAS THE ACCOUNT EVERYTHING ELSE WAS FILED UNDER.

"Yes," Dar said, to the slate, to the cradle, to the city above them taking its slow steps on its dead. "Then we know what she's auditing."

They were led up through the whispering streets to the lead-glass cells as the city walked on into the dark, and the frost on the windowpanes pointed all night, compass-true, at the well at the city's heart where something slept behind lead and listened to the only sound the Vigil permitted itself, which was none at all.

CHAPTER 49

Terms of Silence

The lead-glass cell was a lantern turned inside out: a small glass room set into the city's wall, and beyond its panels the whole walking dark of the Vigil, and Dar inside the light of it like a wick.

He lay that first night, coat open, the second heartbeat keeping its slow patient time under his ribs, and watched the city go by at the pace of a funeral through the glass. The Lily stood pressed against the inner wall of his chest, flattened toward the panels, the way a hand flattens against a window. Beyond the glass, four streets away, under a lead canopy in the center of everything, the Vigil's seed slept its two-hundred-year sleep in its well, and listened.

That was the thing the Abbot's trade finally taught him, and it taught it early: the quarantine was not a wall. It was a hostage exchange in which both parties were the hostage. The Order kept the seed from waking by keeping the city from making a sound worth waking for, and the seed kept the Order honest by being awake underneath the silence — awake, and listening through it, the way you can hear, in a sleeping house, the difference between a settled silence and a held breath. A seed roots where it rests. So the Vigil never rested. And a seed wakes to song, and wakes harder to silence broken. So the Order dared neither sing nor stop singing, and had spent ten generations inventing the exact volume of sound that is neither — a whisper, citywide, perpetual, a lullaby with its volume filed off, fed to a listening god one hushed syllable at a time so that it would never be hungry enough to open its eyes and never be lonesome enough to start singing back.

Dar lay in the glass and did the arithmetic of the arrangement and did not like the total. Nobody in the Vigil had signed. The whole Order had simply been born into arrears.

In the morning they came for his medicine, and they came in a queue.

The infirmary was a long ward off the rope-works, and the queue was the whole senior grade of the Order, and their bodies were the audit of two centuries of whispering. The throats came first: scar-webbing below the voice-line where a lifetime of sound held just under speaking had grown its own architecture, nodules like river stones, voices that frayed if they were ever raised to the volume of an argument. The lungs came second: salt-crusted, working at half their margin, because a city that walks through grace-storm with its mouth closed learns to breathe through its teeth. And under both, the sleep — the whisperers of the Vigil slept in shifts, in a city that never once fell quiet, and their faces had the unfinished look of accounts

carried forward too many years without a rest day.

He worked the ward at whisper-volume, which was its own strange discipline: a surgery in which the surgeon could not say hold still and the patients could not say when. Vell circulated for him, fluent for the first time since Brack, reading the queue's slate-answers and lining up the worst, and the monks watched her move and write with the tenderness people reserve for a language they thought had gone out of the world. He lanced what would lance. He patched with wax-cloth and heat-berry tallow, taught the salve to three monks old enough to be trusted with a recipe, and filed, with a ledger-keeper's honesty, the entries he could not cure: the throats were lifelong. He could pay down interest. He could not retire the principal.

The youngest patient in the queue was a novice of perhaps sixteen, and his throat was the worst in the ward, and the history on his slate explained why. Three winters ago, at his grandmother's filing into the walking — her coffin-door set into her chosen leg while the whole city stood at whisper — the boy had broken. He had sung. Full voice, one verse of the burial-response, before forty hands could reach him: a single human sound at the volume the world outside takes for granted, rising through a city that had not permitted itself one in a generation. The silence had bent around it like a thing struck. The seed in its well had turned over in its sleep — every monk on the circuit had felt the walking stumble, one missed step, a heartbeat of a pause in a gait two centuries old — and the Abbot had not punished him; the boy's throat was punished instead by his own hand, in the penance-room, at his own request, because the alternative was to live knowing what his voice had nearly collected. Dar cleaned the scar-webbing and gave the boy what the medicine gave, which was not enough, and wrote on the boy's slate what he could honestly write: YOU DID NOTHING THE WORLD WOULD CALL WRONG. The boy read it, and wrote back, in his careful novice's hand: THE WORLD IS NOT WHAT SLEEPS BELOW.

The Abbot came at midday and sat on a stool at the end of the ward with his hands folded, and paid.

"Item," he whispered, when Dar came to him with clean hands. "Truth for medicine, as agreed. The first item you have already priced yourself: the seed is not asleep. It listens through our silence. It has listened for four circuits; every unguarded sound this city has ever made is written somewhere in it, and we do not know the rate at which it reads."

"Item two." He led Dar up a stair into a hall lined floor to rafters with tally-slips — a hundred thousand of them, hung in columns like a wall of reeds. "The log of the Order. Every pass of the road's people across our circuit since the founding: dates, bearings, seals. The heralds do not hide from us. We are beneath their interest, and being beneath interest is the only safety the route has ever sold." His finger walked the columns, decades deep. "Read the

sequence and you will read what we read two circuits ago: the round. Brack first. Then the coast, then the wastes, then the last name. We wrote it in the log as a weather-pattern, before we understood it was a menu."

"The Gardener's route," Dar said.

"If that is the name the ninth's books give her, then it is her route, and she has walked past our door for four circuits, and signed nothing, and taken nothing but the glass." The Abbot's finger stopped on a column of seals, five-petaled, repeated down the decades like a stamp. "We knew her as the Surveyor. It was the only name the founder's charter gave us leave to use."

"And the Vigil is skipped," Dar said.

"The Vigil is passed over." No pride in it; relief with a toll attached. "Our tithe is glass. We smelt lead and draw it into panes for the route's reliquaries, and the wain takes its consignment at the circuit's crossing and does not stop. The road does not eat its glass-house. It has never once been late."

"Item three, then. The wain's schedule."

"Logged at Sarn, eleven days ago. It will stand at Gullet within the month — the renderers pay it in tallow and it takes a city's account in nine days — and after Gullet the round has one name left on it." The Abbot looked at Dar's chest rather than his face, with the courtesy of a man declining to stare at a wound. "After Gullet, surgeon, the last name is yours."

"And the fourth item," Dar said. "The word."

The Abbot was quiet for a moment. In the quiet, high above, the felt-muffled bells changed the watch.

"The Church's books file you as a vessel," he whispered. "The Church grows vessels. It plants what it plants and files what takes root, and a vessel is a container — grown to be worn, spent by wearing, and replaced. That is the Church's word, and it is a word for inventory." He put one hand flat on the tally-wall, on two centuries of passes. "The seeds have their own word. The old books of the founder use it exactly once, in the founder's own hand, and then it is crossed out — crossed out, understand, not blotted; crossed out the way you cross out a word too dangerous to leave legible and too true to leave out. Scion." He said it the way you name a dead child. "A cutting the seed took of its own will. Not grown for it. Chosen by it. Grafted, the way a scion is grafted — living wood onto living wood, two lives in one claim. Not vessel, surgeon. Scion. The Vigil has been quarantining gods for four circuits, and you are the first one who was asked."

Dar stood with the word for a while. It sat differently in him than vessel had. Vessel had been a filing; he had spent a career pulling filings out of other people. This was a kinship, and kinship, in his experience, was the most expensive instrument on any shelf — it was the word for what the Lily had made of him in the dark of a cracked reliquary without asking anyone's leave, guest and house in one body, and there was no returns column for it anywhere in the trade.

"The trade," he said, "is paid. But I'll buy one thing more. On the road in, your people read our frost and knew us before we knew you were reading. Tell me what else the city has heard."

The Abbot folded his hands again, and this time the pause had grief in it, banked and old.

"A month ago — our months are walked, so call it a month — the deep heartbeat crossed beneath the wastes. Traveling toward Ashkarad. We heard it for six nights, surgeon, and we are the only institution on this route built to hear anything: our whole discipline is listening to a silence. It passed under our circuit like a tide under ice, patient past all sense, keeping its own time. And our seed heard it too." He looked up, and for the first time the whisper frayed. "It strained. Two hundred years of perfect quiet, and our seed leaned after that sound the way a child leans at a window — and the quiet we have maintained since needs twice the monks it needed before. The world's safety ended the month she walked past. Now there is only ours."

"She," Dar said.

"The Order calls her the Pilgrim." The Abbot's dry smile came and went. "She keeps a circuit of her own. Hers is longer."

He was at the door when Dar asked the last question, the one he had been carrying since the founder's tomb — because if the Order knew the road's habits, they knew its people.

"Have you ever met one of me before? Another carrier. Another scion."

The Abbot stopped in the doorway, and did not turn around, and answered at the same low volume with which he had reported the emptying of his order's holiest thing.

"Once. Three circuits past, a woman came asking. Our seed called her by the founder's word before we could — she walked into the city and the frost came up to greet her, and we understood we had a guest like you. She stayed three days in the guest cell. She asked her one question and we could not answer it, and on the fourth morning she walked out the sea-leg of the circuit to the end of the old jetty, and folded her gloves, and went into the fog-sea at slack tide, and did not come up." The Abbot's hands tightened on each other. "The gloves are still there, surgeon. White ones, folded on the end post. We have walked that jetty at every circuit since, and the salt has never taken them, and none of us will touch them. They are folded the way a thing is folded when it expects to be worn again."

He went out. The ward's queue waited on in its whispering shuffle of slates, and Dar stood among the tally-slips with the wain's schedule in his head — Sarn, eleven days; Gullet, within the month; after Gullet, the last name — and the picture of white gloves on a jetty, patient in the salt, folded toward a sea that no longer came there.

The last scion, the Abbot said. He turned the phrase over and heard what was filed inside it: not the last ever. The last they knew of. The road had been collecting carriers the way it collected cities, one at a time, quietly, and it kept the ones it liked the way it kept everything — on paper, forever, in the dark.

He went back to work. It was what he had. Medicine for truths, truths for the road, and the road already walking.

CHAPTER 50

The Renderworks

Gullet announced itself by smell, two days before it arrived: rendered fat and hot salt and lamp-oil, a smell like a kitchen the size of a harbor, carried out across the flats on a wind that had nothing left to slow it down. Suri counted the change in the wind's cargo the way she counted everything now, because the counting was hers, and this entry she did not like: wherever they were going burned something at an industrial rate, and there was nothing out there to burn but the route's own produce.

The city came up over the horizon on the third noon, and it was a carcass.

A leviathan's, beached and decades dead, longer than the Saltstairs, its spine a broken ridge against the grey sky — and grown over, through, and out of it, a town. The ribs stood bare for gantries, braced with chain and timber, cask-hoists running up them like arteries. The baleen had been cut and hung in vast grey sheets for walls, and behind the sheets lamps burned at midday, because the works ran all hours and the light was not a byproduct. The light was the product. Gullet sold light. It burned what it rendered and rendered what it burned, and from a distance the whole reef-city glowed along its seams like a fire banked inside a whale.

"They render it here," Suri said. "Lowmark's skim. It comes up the coast by barge-chain and it ends here, in the open, and they sell it as light and glue and tallow, and the chits we found in the granary ash are this city's handwriting." She looked at Dar. "The priests were milking a god. This place is the dairy."

Beyond the reef, at the world's edge, the fog-sea had come back into view — a grey line of it, low and receding, the first water they had seen since Ashkarad — and it kept its distance from the carcass the way a customer keeps a distance from a shop whose debts are visible. Suri filed the geography under one heading: the city had been built where the sea used to feed it, and now that the sea was leaving, the city had begun to feed on itself, and called the difference profit.

The gate was a whale's jaw, hinged with chain, and past it the party walked into the loudest quiet Suri had ever audited. The Vigil had whispered; Gullet roared — chain, hammer, steam from the render-pans, the barge-bells — and underneath the roar the people made no sound of their own at all. They had tally-brands instead of voices, most of them: a ruled line inked and re-inked along the inner forearm, notched at each quarter, the way you notch a stick you do not trust yourself to remember. Bloom-debt, the tally-master's clerk told them at the gate, in

the tone of a man reciting weather. Sign at fourteen, work it off at the pans, interest every salt-moon. The clerk's own arm carried four ruled lines, close-ruled, like a ledger that had been rewritten because the first entry would not die.

Suri looked at the lines and felt the old cold, the Saltstairs cold, the one she had carried since a hospital sold her a carbon graft at nineteen and let her keep six weeks of her own skin. She had thought the Church held the patent on this. The Church had merely been the local office.

And under the cold, all that first day, sat the other thing she did not say out loud: the leaf in her ledger's spine, the promissory she had signed in another city's counting-annex to buy three heartbeats of a dead woman's face. Interest at the road's discretion, the terms ran, collected by the heralds — and here was the road's pantry, its rendering floor, the place the route's keep was drawn from, and she had walked into it with her signature already on file. She kept the thought banked. She priced it where she priced her other fears: daily, at carrying volume, to nobody.

Dar's trade opened the doors, the way it always did. The head factor of the Renderworks was a soft grey man called Doane, and Doane had a foot that had been hurting him for a year in the specific way of a man who stands on grating twelve hours a day, and by evening of the first day Dar had him lanced, splinted, and grateful, and Suri had a chair in the counting-house and an afternoon's access to the books. The factor signed the access himself, wincing, because his foot was under contract now and contracts, he believed, ran both ways.

By the second morning Dar had a ward. It assembled itself the way his wards always assembled, without a posting and without a fee: a bench behind the baleen of a side-street, an oilcloth, Vell on the stool with the queue's slates. Gullet's injuries had their own grammar and the grammar was the industry's. Hoist-crushes. Chain-burns. And the one he had not met before this road: bloom-scald, the skin's protest against spilled casks of the living tallow, which did not blister the way burns blistered but frosted — the scalded patch going grey and fine-feathered overnight, petals almost, reaching, before it cracked. He learned its margins from the workers, who knew them better than the company's stamped surgeon did. He learned, too, that the company surgeon was a bone-setter with a price-list, and that the price-list was collected at the company store against company scrip, so that in Gullet even your wounds were invoiced to your debt.

The Lily ran dim here, dimmer than anywhere on the road. The whole city was light — render-pans, lamp-strings, the export itself burning in the open — and she withdrew behind his sternum to her deepest banked register and kept her own counsel, and watched the spilled bloom in the scald-ward the way a poor man watches another man's bread. Dar fed her nightly

in the black of the cellar Doane let them have, and each dawn the frost on the cellar's low ceiling pointed not at Ashkarad now but down — through the reef's floor, through the carcass's chest, at whatever wept and burned and begged at the center of the works.

The books ran to three rooms. Suri started with the newest and worked back, and Vell came with her, chalk stub out, and by the time the second bell rang Suri had the shape of the whole reef in her head, and the shape was a closed loop with no exit marked.

The book of the light, the company called its payroll ledger, and the book of the light recorded, on the credit side, wages: scrip, struck in lead, spendable at the company store and nowhere else on the reef. On the debit side it recorded bloom-debt: the signing-sum advanced to every fourteen-year-old for the family's keep, against future labor, at interest compounding every salt-moon. Suri sampled the ledger at random, forty entries, and ran each one forward the way you run a fever, and in forty samples she did not find a single entry that aged out. Wages ate interest and bought keep. Debt renewed at fourteen, because the signing parent's own debt had never cleared, because the scrip only spent at the store, because the store's prices were set by the company, because the interest compounded every salt-moon. She went back six decades in the stacks to check the founding assumption, and the founding assumption was the whole finding: in sixty years of the book of the light, no entry had ever been stamped PAID. Not one. The company had never once recorded a debt as retired, in four generations of a city that did nothing, all day, but retire debt.

"They're not working it off," she told Dar that night, on the factor's own gallery, with the render-yards glowing below. "There's nothing to work it off to. It's not a city with a harvest in it, Mehran. It's a harvest with a city in it. Four generations of people mortgaged to the rendering of themselves, and the rendering itself — " she tapped the chit-spikes visible through the gallery glass, each spike crowned with flower-stamped tallies — "goes up the route. The company pays the heralds. Sustain the route, the chits said, and now I've seen what sustains it: this. Light, glue, tallow, and a town that pays for the privilege of producing all three."

Vell chalked the audit entire on the factor's back wall in her vertical hand — totals, decades, the zero at the bottom of the paid column — a second copy, a clerk's insurance, filed in the enemy's own counting-house. Doane watched her do it. He stood in the doorway with his splinted foot and his soft grey face and watched the whole ruin of his city get copied out in chalk, and he signed nothing, and stopped nothing, and when Vell finished and washed her hands he said, quietly, to the ledger-room air: "My grandfather's line is on the third spike. Four notches." And he went back to his desk, because a bell was ringing and the reef does not stop.

The party's third day in Gullet was the day Suri learned what the city did at shift-change.

She was on the gallery again, closing the audit, when the bells rang — a heavy triple pattern, different from the hour-bells — and the reef changed gears. The day-crews came off the pans, the night-crews went on, the hoists slowed, and in the gap, with a thousand small sounds falling away all at once, the city's heart became audible.

It came up out of the ground. Out of the carcass. A moan, long and rising, brass-deep and wet at the same time, the sound of something enormous drawing breath to speak and getting no further than the breath. It rolled through the gantries and the baleen walls and up through the soles of Suri's boots into her back teeth, and it did not stop so much as subside, the way an animal subsides when the effort of crying costs more than the crying is worth.

The whole reef flinched, in its separate ways. The night-crews did not look up. The day-crews did not look at each other. A woman at the cistern put her palm flat over her tally-brand for a moment, the way you press a bruise, and went back to her pail.

"The Cow," said the tally-master's clerk, passing behind her with his lamps. He said it without shame and without introduction, the way you say rain. "She moans at shift-change. Always has. Foremen say she's begging."

"Begging," Suri repeated.

"For feed. For rest. Depends which foreman." He shifted his lamps. "She's the engine. She's what the light comes out of. You get used to it."

He moved off into the roar, and Suri stood at the rail and listened to the moan go down and the works come back up to their full indifferent volume, and she thought about the Vigil, about a city that had spent two centuries learning exactly how much sound a sleeping god could bear — and about a reef-city that had never learned anything at all, that had built a light-industry on top of something alive and chained it where the heart should go. She opened her ledger to the column she had ruled on a rope-walk in another city, under the heading she now maintained like a debt of her own, and she wrote:

THE ENGINE BEGS AT SHIFT-CHANGE. ENGINES DO NOT BEG. SOMETHING DOWN THERE IS OWED.

Below the entry, after a moment, watching the render-yards burn their own export into the dark:

AND THE WHOLE TOWN IS PAYING US TO LISTEN TO IT.

CHAPTER 51

Old Tally

The day-chain parted at the third bell, and Dar learned the sound of it from the inside of a patient's mouth, mid-suture: a crack like the city's spine clearing its throat, then a long tearing run of links, then the whip.

The day-chain was Gullet's whole morning — a haulage chain thick as a man's waist, running off drums in the carcass's spine, lifting the tallow casks from the barge-basins at the waterline up three hundred feet to the render-floors. Under load, at the third bell, with a full string of casks off Lowmark on the hook, the master link had simply resigned. The falling end had gone down into the basin. The rising end had come back through the gantries like a creature leaving its den, and eleven people went to the grating along its path, and the casks went with them.

The works' surgeon arrived at a run. He was a bone-setter with a stamp and a price-list, and he was one man, and the yard was suddenly an anatomy lesson with the anatomy still awake in it. The foreman in charge of the yard — a slab of a man called Coss, with a voice that did not need the brass tube the Gavel bosses used — looked once at the queue of the hurt, once at the bone-setter, and then across the yard at Dar, who was already moving.

"Reef-cutter," Coss said. It was what the workers had taken to calling him; on the reef, everything got renamed into the books. "You're on the company's rolls since you set foot on my grating. The books call labor."

"Then the books can watch me bill them for it," Dar said, and knelt.

Triage was triage in any language. He put the Blood Vein quietly to work under his gloves and clamped the worst three where they lay, and the yard's second foreman stood over him calling the cask-count to the spine-drums in a flat voice while Dar called pulses to Vell, who stood at his shoulder with the tally-slate and counted everything back to him in chalk. Bloom-scald came off the split casks in steam. Where it landed it frosted. One render-hand, scalded down the throat by a burst cask, did not come back from the grey no matter what Dar closed or opened, and Dar filed him with the only honors the yard allowed, which was that two of his crewmates stopped working for as long as it took to look at him. Then the reef does not stop, and it went on.

What the reef did instead of stopping was price. By the time the chain was re-coupled, the factor's runners were through the yard with the accident-book, entering the day against the

accounts: the lost casks, the lost chain-hours, the render-hand's unworked shifts to come, already discounted to the store. Suri read the book over a runner's shoulder, uninvited, and wrote nothing down and forgot nothing. "They billed the corpse," she said that evening, in the flat voice she reserved for totals. "I've seen cities eat their living, Mehran. This one bills its dead for the interruption."

The chain was re-coupled by noon. By the noon bell the yard was back to its own volume, and Dar was washing bloom off his hands at the cistern when the summons came, and the summons was not for his hands.

"The tail fouled the extraction-line," Coss said. He had come down off the gantries personally, which the foremen did not do, and he stood with the discomfort of a man visiting a place he avoids. "The whip went through the gantry over the engine-room and took the line with it. The line can't be cut. You have to understand that, cutter. Whatever the line is fouled on — you treat it. You don't cut it."

"The line," Dar said. "The extraction-line from the Cow."

"From the Cow." Coss's face did something Dar had not seen it do: it went to the place where the begging lived. "Lamp-crews won't go in that room. I'm not asking them to. The factor wants light by dusk — the whole city burns what she renders — and the line's fouled up-slope of the pans. You're the only one on this reef who opens things for a living." He looked away, at the render-yards, at the baleen, at the light. "She's down there. You'll see."

The engine-room was at the carcass's chest, where the heart would have hung, and the party of one that went down into it went down through warmth. Not furnace-warmth — body-warmth, the deep steady heat of something living, rising out of the hold the way breath rises out of a mouth. The stair was brass, worn hollow. The lamp-crew's oil-lamps burned at the mouth of the chamber and no further, as if the dark past them were a door.

The Cow was a womb of brass and glass the size of a chapel, ribbed and piped, seated in the leviathan's chest cavity the way a heart is seated — carefully, with its vessels respected. Glass pipes ran out of it by the dozen, up through the ceiling on their way to the pans, each one running with slow gold. The whole assembly moved. Not mechanically. Peristaltically, gently, the way a chest moves around the business it is keeping, and the sound inside the chamber was not the shift-change moan but its opposite: a hum, a many-voiced hum, so low that Dar felt it arrange itself along his bones and take up residence.

The line was fouled on the chain, but the chain was fouled on her.

She hung in the machine's near side, visible through a pane of glass older and thicker than the Vigil's, and she was an old woman, and she was half a garden. Black lace had taken her

from the left ankle to the collarbone — vascular lace, fine and dense, the pattern Dar knew from his own chest under strain — and along the whole left arm the lace had opened into petals, dozens of them, black-fringed and open, and the arm itself was bare of the machine's housing and seated to the elbow in the extraction-glass, because the petals wept the tallow and the tallow was drawn off through the pipes and the pipes fed the city. Her hair was rope-grey and tied back for work. Her right side was only a very old woman's side, thin and work-worn. Chains ran from her — waist, right wrist, a collar seated soft-looking and final — and every chain was polished bright where a century of living had moved against it.

She was counting. Her lips moved on numbers, an unbroken column, low and even, the way Suri counted and the way Vell wrote: because it was hers, and nobody on this reef could repossess it.

The broken chain-tail had come down through the gantry above her and wrapped twice around the great pipe where it seated to her arm, and the torque had cracked the seat, and where the seat had cracked the weep ran free over the glass instead of into it, and that was the wound. Dar looked at it with the surgeon's eye first and the rest of him second: an extraction-point of a century's standing, an interface between a body and an industry, ulcerated at the margin, weeping from the wrong place. Treat it. Do not cut it. Whoever had built this machine had built it around a person, and the person had kept the machine alive for a hundred years, and the machine could not spare her and she could not spare the machine.

He got the glass seat's casing open with Coss's chain-tools and worked the repair the way he worked everything, narrating in the low voice that made rooms go quiet by refusing to be loud. The old woman watched him through the pane without pausing her count.

He gave her the surgeon's read while his hands worked, because it was the only ledger he could keep balanced in a room like this. Half bloom-through, but held — not the stopped, surrendered half of the photographs in Vahid's papers; an argued half, a partitioned half, the garden grown to her collarbone and no further in a hundred years because some will in her had drawn the line and stood on it. The seed's weep ran through the garden-arm the way sap runs through a tapped tree, and her body had organized itself around the tap: the chains were load-bearing, the arm was a fixture, the machine was a prosthesis she had been surgically joined to by economists. She should have been gone decades ago — the bloom-through should have taken her — and she was not gone, and the physician in him put the question to the room in the only form the room allowed: what does a person cost to keep, when the person is the pipe? Then, as he lifted the second clamp, she stopped counting, and looked at him — not at his face, not at his hands, but at his chest, at his coat, at the banked heat riding under it — and read him the way you read a ledger, top to bottom, in one glance.

"Little ninth," she said.

Dar's hands went still on the clamp.

The old woman's face creased into something too tired and too warm to be a smile, and she said it again, to make sure he had it, in the tone of family — the tone Suri's counting had, the tone Ilay's drawings had, a register Dar had not heard aimed at him since a salt-glass door had tapped out a lullaby's opening bars. "Little ninth. You came the long way round. I felt you pass — felt her pass — two cities back and more. I told her: mind the light, he's day-walking." The chains took up the small motion of her shrug. "She's shy in the sun. We all were."

"You're a carrier," Dar said, and his voice came out in the register he kept for operating, because the alternative registers were not equal to the room.

"I'm the first carrier. First and last, the seed's whole account runs through me." She flexed the garden-arm inside the glass, easy, unafraid of it, a hand in a familiar glove. "Third seed. Gullet's mine. I was a net-mender on the carcass-fleet when she rooted in me, and I thought I was dying, and I was — but slow. The bloom came up the harbor and the town grew rich on it and I grew strange with it, and when the harvest men came they cut the bloom-stem like a tooth and could not take the root, because the root was me. So they built the machine." She looked around the chamber, the brass, the pipes, the chapel of it, with the unhurried survey of a woman viewing her own headstone and finding the masonry sound. "An engine, they called it. The Cow, the crews called it. And me they chained in, because the weep runs through me and I keep it steady, and a chain is cheaper than wages. I have been the extraction-point of this city for a hundred years, little ninth, and I have counted every cask, and at shift-change, when the counting stops — "

The bells rang, high above, the heavy triple. The works throttled down. And the moan came up through the floor of the chamber and filled it, brass-deep and wet and rising, and up close, inside the thing that made it, it was not a moan at all. It was a call, shaped and specific, a note laid over the dark in one direction only, the way you call a name you have been calling for so long the name has become the breath.

"She cries at shift-change," the old woman said, when it had subsided. "Hundred years now. She cries for her sister." Her eyes came back to Dar and settled there, patient as the chains. "And that's why I'm glad you came, little ninth. I've waited a hundred years to ask a ninth one question."

"Ask," Dar said.

The question, when the old woman finally asked it, was about her sister.

CHAPTER 52

A Door Shared Between Two

Dar came back down every night for a week, because the crack in the pipe-seat needed tending and because the answer to her question needed a hospital of its own.

The week, on the surface, ran on rails. Suri closed the audit and gave Doane her totals in the flat voice she saved for verdicts, and Doane copied them into the company's own books at the factor's instruction, the only instruction the reef honored; Vell's chalk copy of the book of the light stayed on the counting-house wall like a notice of seizure, and the workers began to walk past it on purpose; and Dar's ward behind the baleen kept its hours, and the reef kept its shifts, and the Cow moaned at every change, and nobody priced any of it differently, which Suri recorded as the reef's most expensive line item: THE BOOKS ARE CORRECT AND THE CITY IS UNSAVED.

The chamber he entered after dark was a different room. The lamp-crews left their oil-lamps at the stair; the works throttled; and in the dark the third seed came up out of its century-long bank and filled the glass womb with presence, the way the Lily filled a cellar — warmth first, then the hum, then the attention. The old woman had them dim the panes further with felt. "She's shy," Tally said. "Hundred years of audiences. She'd rather be listened to than looked at." Dar lay on a rope pallet Coss's people smuggled down rather than be caught caring, and the two seeds conversed across the room at a frequency below hearing, and he lay between them like a man lying between two conversations in two languages he was fluent in and had never been taught.

Tally talked the way old people talk who have been saving it up: nothing wasted, everything filed.

Her question, when she finally put it to him — she had carried it down a hundred years like a coal — was this: "My sister went up against the eighth door, alone. Is there anything of her behind it, or did it all end against the stone?" And Dar gave her the only honest answer the trade had: "There's no honest text. I don't know." Tally nodded, the way you nod at a bill you had already priced, and began at the beginning, because if the ninth did not know the door, then somebody had to tell him what the door had already cost.

Her sister had come seventy years ago, walking out of the wastes with the frost rising to meet her boots. A carrier — like Tally, like Dar; the word the founder had crossed out and she said plain — and not of her seed but of a sister seed, one of the middle girls, sown in a city

whose name Tally had never learned because the woman had not known it herself. She had been born to the seed the hard way, the way Dar had. She had felt Tally's Cow sing across a hundred miles of flat, one night, at shift-change, and she had gotten up from a dying town and walked toward the sound, because when something sings in your own key you go to it or you die of not going.

"That's the truth of us," Tally said. "The seeds call. Everything else is paperwork."

She had hidden the woman in the chain-lockers for six weeks, in the dark the seed liked, and they had been six weeks of family. Two carriers, grown in two cities by two seeds out of the same first garden, and neither of them had ever had anyone to ask. What do you do when it wants the light gone. What do you do when it wants the blood. What do you do with the dreams — the rows of planted sleepers, the tower of heartbeats, the woman humming in a language you know without hearing. Two women in a locker under a whale, comparing the contents of a condition, and for six weeks the reef's books had balanced without them.

"She had a name before," Tally said, once, in the middle of that telling. "Before her seed took her. Never gave it to me. Said the seed had filed it, and what's filed can't be owed. I've thought about that a hundred years, little ninth. That's carrier arithmetic, that is. The road files your name so it can't be used against you, and then you go through the rest of your life unable to be called anything but what the seed calls you." Her chains took up the shrug. "She called me sister. I never even knew her name. You tell me which of those was the truer title."

"She wanted the eighth," Tally said. "That was her whole ledger. She'd climbed to the seventh on her own seed's credit — walked her mind-ruins the way your professor's papers tell it, spent what had to be spent, and she was standing at the top of the ladder with one rung left and no honest text for it. Nobody has an honest text for it. The honest texts died with the First Burning, and everything since is folklore, and folklore is what the road leaves in the pantry." The old woman's eyes went to the dark glass, to the presence inside it. "My girl told her what my girl knew, which was nothing. But the woman was past nothing. She went down into the salt under the carcass, alone, the way you'd go down to close a big account, and she tried the eighth alone."

The Cow had gone mute for a day.

"I thought the light would fail with her," Tally said. "The whole reef thought it. They run the pans by her and they didn't know it, and for one day the tank-lamps burned brown and the foremen walked soft, and under everything I felt what she felt, because that's the other truth of us: the seeds share what happens to their carriers. She came up against the door of the Soul and threw herself at it the way you throw yourself at a locked ledger — every key she had, the

whole spent fortune of her, all seven rungs of her — and the door did not open, and it did not need to be cruel, because it did not even notice her. You cannot break a door that isn't shut, little ninth. You can only die against the idea of it."

"What is it, then," Dar said. "The eighth."

Tally was quiet for a while. Above them the reef breathed its industry; below them, under a mile of salt and carcass, the deep places held their own appointments. When she spoke again, the counting-voice was gone and something older was in it, the voice of a woman reciting the only inheritance the road had never managed to confiscate.

"The Soul Vein is not a rung. The rungs below it you climb, because flesh and bone and blood and breath and nerve are single, and a single thing can be forced. Mind you can walk, because a mind is one room even when the rooms are ruins. But the Soul was never one. It doesn't open to strength and it doesn't open to payment and it doesn't open to spending, because it isn't checking your fortune at the door. It's checking your company." The chains took up her slow shrug. "It is a door shared between two. It opens from the far side — by someone who knows the shape of your silence. Never by one. That's the whole doctrine, and my sister died for the lack of one sentence of it, and I have had seventy years to learn the sentence by heart and no ninth to tell it to."

Dar lay still on the pallet while the heartbeats kept their time — his own second heartbeat, and the deep one, the one that was not in the room but was always lately in his hearing, patient, immense, one beat behind.

One beat behind. It had been one beat behind since a rooftop in Ashkarad, copying him, the way a copyist reproduces a hand one line down. It had tapped the lullaby's opening bars through salt-glass and set its taps on his offbeats. On the road its frost had turned for him; its footprints had kept his stride; it had leaned when he leaned and stopped when he stopped, for a year, learning him — and he saw it with the clarity of a diagnosis confirmed: something had spent that year learning the shape of his silence, and the doctrine said that was the only credential the eighth door honored.

"The far side," he said aloud, working it like a knot. "Someone who knows your silence opens it from the far side. That's why it can't be climbed. It isn't climbed. It's answered."

"Then you already know the address," Tally said, "and all that's left is the walk. Provided," and the old warmth came back into her voice, dry as the flats, "you don't die against it alone on the way. My sister's mistake wasn't the trying, little ninth. It was the alone. The road teaches alone. Alone is the road's whole curriculum. Unlearn it somewhere soft."

She reached up then, into the housing where the garden-arm met the glass, and worked — her face steady, the petals parting around her fingers, the weep running brighter for a moment, the hum dipping one full note and coming back — and brought out a petal. Black, five-veined, cool as a filed receipt, lighter than a coin. One of her seed's own, freed at cost from the living machinery of a century.

She pressed it into his hand and closed his fingers over it, and her grip was very strong, and her eyes were family.

"To show your Sister," she said. "She'll know the third's line; we pressed petals in the dark before your city had a name. Tell her the third kept the light burning. Tell her we're all still counting. And tell her — " for one moment the recitation-voice cracked, a century of shift-change calls under it — "tell her the Cow is sorry. We didn't know. We were never told what we were singing to."

The warning came with the gift, because Tally of Gullet settled her accounts in one sitting. "The wain passed here a week ago, little ninth. Bound for Ashkarad. It doesn't stop at Gullet — we render for it; our tallow is its keep — but it passed, and it's ahead of you, and it doesn't hurry, because it has never once been late."

Dar asked the only question a surgeon could act on: what unchaining would cost. Tally answered honestly: the extraction was her circulation now; the seed's weep had no other channel; the city's light would fail in a season and the seed would follow it, and she would follow the seed, and the books would not notice for a week. He heard the whole account. He filed it, unpayable, next to the other unpayables, and said the one thing worth saying: "I owe you a door's asking, then, and I pay my debts at the door."

"Pay the sister," Tally said, settling back into the chains, closing the ledger of him. "I've been paid in counting for a hundred years. I'm rich."

At shift-change that night, with Dar up on the gantries and the reef throttling down around him, the deep heartbeat came.

It rolled in under the reef from the south, through a mile of salt and stone and dead leviathan, and the whole carcass felt it pass — every rib of the gantries taking the count like a struck train of bells — and it was moving the wrong way to be anything but what it was. Toward Ashkarad. Past them. Ahead of them. The Sister was ahead of them, running home.

Below, in the engine-room, the third seed answered — one note, laid over the dark in one direction, a hundred years of calling answered for the first time by the sound of the called-for passing close. The moan broke pitch. Frost came up through the render-yard boards in a single concerted breath, grey petals by the thousand, every one of them pointing back along the road

the way the party had come — and Dar stood on the gantry with Tally's petal in his pocket and his balance gone suddenly and entirely homeward, while beneath his feet the light of Gullet burned on, rendered from a caged sister who had just watched her own kind run by, at last, toward the door that could not be climbed alone.

He went down the stair to the pallet-room, once more, to tell her: she passed. She's ahead of us. She's going home.

The old woman was already counting again, softly, and this time Dar understood the column: the beats as they passed, every one, a tally a hundred years long, with, at last, an end to count toward.

CHAPTER 53

Go Home, Ninth

They left Gullet at dawn, on the tide the reef no longer believed in, and turned their backs on the light.

The reasons were tallied the night before, in the cellar where the frost pointed down, and the tally was short. The wain was ahead of them, bound for Ashkarad, and it had never once been late. The doctrine was in Dar's head now like a splinter working toward the skin: a door shared between two, opened from the far side by someone who knows the shape of your silence — and the someone had passed under the reef a week ahead of their leaving, running home. And Suri's ledger, open on her knee, held a column she had ruled in another city, and the column's collector was also ahead of them, also bound for Ashkarad, because the heralds collect on the route and the route, for them, ended at home. "We owe the road," she said, closing the book. "Fine. But I'll do my owing where the collateral lives."

Vell spent the last hour at the gate, chalking. On the route stone at the reef's landward approach she wrote the party's direction and the date of their leaving, and below it, in her vertical clerk's hand, a line she had never once written on the whole journey out, because the journey out had been the registry's round read backward, and now it was not: HOME. She wet the chalk against her lip, considered, and underlined it.

Coss saw them to the gate himself, which foremen did not do, and which neither he nor Dar remarked on. At the jaw he stopped, and looked back along the reef — the gantries, the pans, the light running in its seams — and then down, at the ground, for a long moment, as if the carcass's floor were a ceiling and he had finally wondered what room was above it. "The cutter'll be back through," he said, to the route stone, in the tone of a man entering a figure he cannot yet justify. "The books show an open item." "The books show three," Dar said. "A pipe-seat, a factor's foot, and a question I owe an answer to." Coss nodded slowly, the nod of a man who has heard a debt he understands, and went back in, and the jaw-hinge ran on its chain behind them, and the last thing Gullet gave the road was the shift-change moan, rising over the flats behind them all the way to the horizon, calling its hundred-year call after a Sister who had already passed.

The homeward flats were wrong before they had walked a day.

The fog-sea had been the road's one fixture — a grey line at the world's edge, low, receding, obscene in its patience, but present, a creditor's lantern at the boundary of the map.

On the second day home Suri climbed a grave-mast with her glass and came down without saying anything, and Dar climbed it after her, and the line was not low anymore. It was gone. The seabed ran out ahead of them to a horizon as clean and dry as a rule drawn under a finished column, and there was no water behind the rule, and no light on it, and no smell of tide. The wind had changed cargo again: salt and old rope and nothing living, a wind with no sea left to remember. Heat-berry strings glowed at the old tide-lines, banked down to embers, a lantern industry serving a customer that had stopped coming.

"The drinking's done," Suri said. "Whatever stood at the horizon and drank — " she looked at Dar's chest, then west, toward Ashkarad, and did not finish, because the only ledger that total was written in was below the salt of the city they were walking toward, and they were not there yet.

On the third day home the mud began to carry writing.

Vell saw it first — she was reading the route stones as she had read them the whole road, flower-marks and water-marks, keeping her reverse-tally — and she stopped, and stood very still, the way she had stood at the mooring-posts the day she proved the footprints were keeping time. Then she pointed, and Dar saw it, and the flats stopped being flats.

Ledger-script. Scored into the drying seabed for a mile, in strokes a hand deep, each one dragged through the mud in a single pass by something that had not paused and had not hurried: a heading, and beneath the heading a column, and beneath the column entries in a grammar Vell's chalk began to transcribe before her face had finished going pale. The language was none of the route's. It was the dead language — the one Dar knew without hearing, the one the lullaby understood itself in, the one a fading composite face had mouthed at him over a reading-tray while the grey came up through it like frost.

"Little root" had been three syllables in that tongue. This was a mile of it.

He worked it the way he worked everything, with his hands, kneeling in the drying mud. Vell's transcription gave him the grammar — a heading in the address-form, columns under it, a total at the end; the notation of a counting-house, whoever had cut it — and Ilay's map gave him the rest. He unrolled the hide-cloth she had pressed into his hand at the seawalls, for an unpriced promise: her charcoal rings, her careful child's hand, the sound-map of the deep music she had been transcribing since the singing went out of the walls. He laid it on the mud beside the scored strokes, and matched them, ring against stroke, and the match was not a resemblance. It was a correspondence, exact, the scored line and the charcoal line two renderings of one text — the deep music, written down by the thing that was walking it — and Ilay's transcription, which had spent a year learning to spell that music, rendered the scored

line's heading in one line, in her hand, under his finger:

GO HOME, NINTH.

Suri read it upside down, the way she read everything, and said nothing for the length of ten of her own heartbeats, which was her longest silence of the road.

"It's an address," she said at last. "Not an order. Look at the grammar Vell's got — that heading's the addressee-line. She scored you a letter, Mehran. A mile of it." Then, because she was Suri: "Or it's a stamp. I've seen the route stamp things in bigger letters than this."

They walked the line's length because it was on the way and because neither of them could get the parties to a reading without it. The column under the heading, Vell ruled, was entries: counts of some kind, tallied in the dead language's clean vertical hand, and the counts ran large. "Whatever she was counting," Vell wrote on the slate, and underlined it twice, "she counted it all the way home. Like Tally. Like me. You people count when you're afraid, and she's the biggest of you, and she counted a mile."

And under that, because she was Brack to the bone, she wrote the second thing, the one Dar was already carrying and had not filed: SHE WROTE IT WHERE THE ROAD COULD READ IT. WHATEVER ELSE SHE IS, SHE IS NOT HIDING.

The walker's prints ran beside the scored line the whole way they followed it — small, bare, a diver's spread toes, salt-burned heels, spaced not at one heartbeat's interval now but at a stride that shortened and slowed as the line went on, the stride of someone who had stopped to check her work, or lost her nerve, or both. At the line's end the prints left it, and turned, and went on toward the west and the seawalls, and the mud held them all.

They came up out of the flats on the fifth day and the seawalls were standing, and that was the last thing about them that was right.

The breach was at the foot of the wall, two miles south of the tide-gates, and it was not a breach the way Ashkarad understood breaches. No ram-marks. No burn. No rubble. The wall's base had been opened the way a ledger is opened — a section of the foundation stone sixty feet across lifted and set aside whole, cleanly, its own bedding-marks intact, as if the wall had been a page and something had wanted to read what was printed beneath the city. Through the opening, down, the dark went back into the salt in a passage the size of a cathedral door, and the air that came up out of it was warm and loam-scented and impossibly green at the back of the nose, the exact air that had breathed through an ajar door of salt-glass in the vaults beneath the Throne shaft, the last time Dar had stood in front of it and refused to open it. She had not refused. She had gone under the city while they were away, through her own door, under the walls, home — and the passage's rimed lip was furred grey with frost-petals by the ten

thousand, every petal pointing inward, into the dark, down toward the vaults.

Above the breach, on the wall's walk, the tide-gates stood open on a dry harbor. The city beyond was making sounds. Smoke stood over the Saltstairs. Ashkarad had heard something go under it and was, in the city's own way, doing arithmetic about it, and the arithmetic was not finished, and Dar's chest ached suddenly and completely with the Lily leaning down through him toward the deep like a plant at the end of its light. The frost on the wall's inner face agreed with her. It had come up through the stone seams in fans, and every fan pointed down and in, toward the vaults, toward the door he had left ajar at another woman's wish because it had to be her act — and the act, it turned out, had needed only his absence to be performed.

"Not siege," Dar said, to the wall, to the party, to the ledgers. "Passage. She didn't break in. She went under, the way the route goes under — through her own door, at the bottom of her own dark — and the walls were just the last page of it." He looked at the breach, at the size of what had passed through it. "Something enormous is home."

Suri had her ledger out, over the column. Vell had her chalk out, wetting it, already transcribing the rimed stone. Dar stood a moment longer with the scored mile at his back, and then he turned around and looked at it once more, all of it, from the breach — the heading, the column, the walker's shortening stride, the whole mile of a letter scored into the seabed by the walker's hand, which by her prints had passed this way an hour ahead of them, while what had gone under the walls had gone under without waiting for her —

And the last stroke of the heading glistened. Along one edge, low on the line where the blade or the finger had dragged the mud up into its dark paste, the scored script was still wet. One edge of the final stroke shone in the flat light, un-dried, un-greyed, paste-dark, as if the writer had stood here within the hour — and Dar did the arithmetic of the flats, the pace, the tide of days since anything alive had crossed that ground, and the arithmetic came back stamped, and the stamps all said the same thing.

She had been here. She had written GO HOME, NINTH into the mud of the world for the ninth to read. And whatever of her was already ahead — under the walls, under the city, at the bottom of the dark, walking without waiting for her own feet — the ink of her summons was still drying, home was doing its arithmetic, and the ninth was expected.

CHAPTER 54

Two Circles Under

The horns at the seawall gate woke Ilay before the light did — three short and one long, the new cadence, the one the Index used when it was counting something in — and she was on the stair with her palm flat against the wall before she was properly awake, because the wall under her hand was singing in two voices, and for as long as she had been alive it had sung in one.

She kept her ear there and counted the city waking, because the hearing was hers and nobody in Ashkarad could repossess it. The Index first: boots in double file down the Saltstairs cut, a new step they had learned since the spring, shorter at the front than the back so that a whole patrol sounded like one animal with forty feet. The crank-and-clack of the new readers riding on their shoulders, winding themselves as the bearers walked, little brass throats clearing themselves every nine steps. Then the Gavel: slower boots, heavier, and under them the dry click of ledger-counters being thumbed open and shut, open and shut, the sound of Mother Gavel's crews doing their morning arithmetic around the Choratorium ruins they held. Then, under that, a sound she had to reach for: nothing. The ward offices of the Open Counts had been chalked shut for eleven days now, one line on each door, and even shut doors made a small sound if you knew how to listen, a held-breath sound, and this morning eleven doorways' worth of held breath was the loudest quiet in the district.

And under all of it, the deep.

The deep music had come home. She had no better way to put it, and she had tried, on slate, on the wall, in her mouth without sound: the great slow beat that had walked its circles under the flats for a month and gone under the city while the two-hearted man was away had risen, and it was in the vaults now, beneath the Throne shaft, filling the salt the way a tide fills a channel it has known for a thousand years. The first voice had never left — the older one, the patient one under everything, the one she had drawn as the center of the spiral before she knew spirals were the wrong shape. Now there were two, and the wall carried both into her teeth, and one of them had changed its rhythm in the night.

She heard the gate open the way she heard everything, from the inside of the sound. The bar coming out of its cradle. The wardens' boots going to their marks. And then, past the horns and the mud-smell and the wind that came off the dry seabed tasting of iron and old salt, the two-hearted man — his two heartbeats, the count she had memorized before she had words for counting — coming up the seawall road with the woman who counted aloud under her breath and a third set of steps that kept stopping to chalk things, and behind all of it, faint, the

wooden knock of wax cylinders in a porter's frame.

"They're in," she said, to the stair, to the clinic below her, to nobody, and went down to the door before the knock came.

They came in like a ledger being balanced after a long audit: the two-hearted man first, salt-white to the knees, then the counting woman with her ruined arm carried careful against her ribs, then the chalk woman, Vell, who looked at the clinic doorway the way Brack's dead must have looked at theirs. Behind them, out on the mud, the fog was closing again over the scored flats, where for half a mile the writing stood in the mud that had been the sea — GO HOME, NINTH, in letters tall as houses, cut clean, and Ilay had heard the wardens argue for two days about whether writing could be wet when there had been no rain.

Inside, the two-hearted man stood still in the middle of the front room with his eyes shut, and the Lily leaned him, the way she did — a degree off true, toward the floor, toward the deep — and Ilay watched the woman who counted put out her good hand and steady his elbow without being asked, the way you hold a scale steady while the needle finds its number.

"It's doubled," he said. "I can hear it from here. Roya?"

"Upstairs," Roya said, from the stair, brass mask catching the lamp. "Wall's ready."

The rest of the news had come up the stair with the counting woman, flat, at her working volume, the way she read numbers that meant people: the wain had passed the reef-city eleven days ago, bound for Ashkarad, on the road, on schedule, and no one on the seawalls could say from which quarter it would come up, because the sea was gone and the roads were mud and mud keeps no heralds out. Behind that, the flats themselves: scored, a mile of them, in the dead language the deep had used before there were ledgers, and the score of it said, in the only line anyone could render: go home, ninth. And behind even that, the thing the party carried in a porter's frame without yet showing anyone: fourteen wax cylinders, a doctor's voice, and the two-hearted man's face when he set them down on the cellar shelf, which was the face of a man adding a bill he already knew he could not pay.

The Index came for the water-line at midmorning, because the Index did everything on schedule now. Ilay was at the cistern with the others, Elias and the two youngest of the eleven and a dozen Saltstairs children whose names were on nobody's page, and the patrol came around the corner in its one-animal stride, and the people in the line did the thing the people of Ashkarad had learned to do this season, which was to become very still and very countable. Auditor Seft walked at the front with the new reader on a strap against his chest, and the new reader was not the old reader; the old one had listened for debts and found two rhythms it could not file, and this one had a wider throat and a different appetite. This one listened for

the hymn. It had been built, she heard one grey coat tell another, keyed to the training — the nursery's forty bars, the compliance-song, the thing the Church had sewn into stock blood before the fall — because a hymn, once planted, never fully leaves; it waits in the veins like a note waits in a string, and a machine with a wide enough throat can hear the string humming.

They washed the children's hands first, because it looked like hygiene. Then the needle-cuff, then the crank, nine turns, and the machine printed its small hot slip, and Elias went last because he always put himself last, and Elias's blood sang. She heard it leave him — forty bars, rising out of his skin like heat off a stove, the claiming-hymn answering the machine the way a named thing answers its name — and she heard the machine file it.

HYMN RESONANT. STOCK. SEE REGISTRY — PAGE NINE.

Elias did not look at the slip. He looked at his own hands, as if the singing had come out of them and he was checking them for damage. The grey coats wrote his name — they had his name; the Index always had the name — and Auditor Seft looked at Ilay, one beat longer than he looked at anyone else, the look of a man reading a column total and finding it does not sum.

"Sanctuary," Roya said, arriving with the seal-board under her arm like a woman carrying a tray. "Both seals. You counted them on the door yourself in the spring, Auditor. Shall I read you the terms, or will your machine do it?"

Ilay had kept still through all of it, hands in the water, eyes down, the way Roya had taught her — be countable, be boring, be a child — though her own blood would have answered the machine louder than any of them, graded perfect, reserved for a throne that no longer had a church to sit in. She counted the crank turns instead: nine, every time, nine turns to a reading, and the machine's little hot slips stacked on the auditor's board like a month of receipts.

Seft wound the crank down. "The machine hears what's there," he said. "I only record that it heard." And he took his patrol up the lane in its one-animal stride, and the line breathed again, and Ilay put her hand flat on the cistern lip and felt the deep music carry both its voices up through the water, and the water shivered in rings, two sizes of ring, like a thing said twice in two languages.

The city spent that day and the next arming itself against an enemy that had not yet named its price. Braziers went up along the storm-walls, and the wardens' bells called the watches in a pattern frayed from overuse. Tithe-carts were dragged across the lane-mouths and chalked with the owners' names, which in Ashkarad was the oldest kind of barricade there was. Mother Gavel's counters stood their post across from the clinic with slates and tallied the foot-traffic hour by hour, and the tally had stopped being about protection and started being about appetite, and everyone on both sides of the lane knew it and priced it in. At the front desk,

Milla Ferun counted the day's patients in her clerk's hand, square and even, and twice during the afternoons Ilay saw her stop, look at her own fingernails, and go on, and the salt was back under them, though Milla Ferun had not been underground in weeks.

"We're home," the two-hearted man said, in the cellar, with the chalk ladder over his shoulder and Vahid already arguing the Veins at him like a man reclaiming a stolen coat. "That's what's wrong with it."

On the second night the clinic's map wall got its new sheet.

Roya worked the way she always worked now, one-handed on the chalk, the brass mask tilted to catch Ilay's hearing the way a dish catches oil, and Ilay stood at the wall and gave her the deep the way she gave her everything, in counts and circles, line by line, the two voices laid on the salt like strata. The new voice first — the one that had come home. It sat high, as deep-things went: in the vaults, under the Throne shaft, behind the salt-glass door where a petal had once tapped out a lullaby to a man with two heartbeats. It kept time. That was the first thing she told Roya, and Roya made her say it three times, because it had kept time before it left and it kept time now that it was back: one beat behind the two-hearted man's own pulse, patient, exactly, the way a copyist lays a line one rule down from the original.

"It's holding still," Ilay said. "It came home and it lay down. It's listening."

"Listening to what?"

"To him." She touched the second circle. "And to that."

The older voice had no floor she could find. It had been under the spiral's center all along, so deep the shaft's warning had been nailed to rock above it — DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS — and it had never once, in her whole hearing, changed its pace: vast, slow, regular as interest, the metronome everything else in the city had been unknowingly set to. Tonight it had turned over. That was the phrase that came and would not leave: it had turned over, the way a sleeper turns over, the way a body in a bed shifts when the house above it goes quiet, and the turning had taken three of the two-hearted man's heartbeats to complete, and when it finished, the deep music was two voices where it had been one, and the new voice had come home to lie down above it like a hand laid flat on a lid.

Roya chalked the two circles one inside the other, dated the sheet in her small surveyor's hand, and stood back, and the mask held its metal calm, and her voice came out level as a wire.

"Two circles under the city."

"Two," Ilay said. "The new one came home. The old one is waking up."

Below them, faint through the clinic's floor, through the Saltstairs' brick, through whatever the city was actually made of down there where nobody had ever built, the deep music held both its voices at once — the hand and the thing under the hand — and the walls of Ashkarad rang like struck glass, very softly, all night long, in a chord nobody but the girl at the wall could hear was waiting to resolve.

CHAPTER 55

The Woman from the Mud

On the third morning after the coming-home, the fog off the dry seabed lay against the tide-gates like a creditor waiting to be let in, and the Lily leaned Dar toward the door before breakfast — not down, toward the deep, the way she had leaned since the vaults filled, but out, level, seaward, a new bearing she had never once asked for — and he had learned to price her leanings the way sailors price weather, so he was pulling on his coat when the wardens' runner arrived to say that the machine at the gate had printed something it could not file and that the woman it would not file was still standing on the mud, waiting, as if the gate were a teller's window and she had all day.

The tide-gates had not opened for anyone in a season. There was nothing to open them for: the sea had gone out past the horizon's manners, the harbor was a mile of cracked grey mud scored with the writing everyone had now seen and nobody could unsee, and the great gates stood throat-high in salt crust like a mouth too dry to speak. A warden line held the road across the mud, and behind the line, half-sheltered in the gate's iron shadow, stood the thing the machine had choked on.

She was small. That was the first datum, and Dar's eye took it the way it took all triage data, without permission: small, barefoot on salt-plate that would have opened a boot-sole, her feet split and sealed by salt into their own grey boots of scar. Salt-burned everywhere the salt had reached — lips cracked to the tissue, hands scoured to the whorl, the whites of her eyes gone the dull nacre of a shell left out — and she stood at a kind of attention that was not military but tidal, as if she were keeping herself upright the way a post keeps a wire up, because something on the far end of her was still attached. At her collarbone, spread against the skin like a hand laid flat under cloth, was a petal. Black, lace-veined, wide as a palm, rooted — he could see the rooting from six feet, the way the edges of it feathered into her skin without seam, no graft-line, no suture, no account of how it had been paid for — and it moved when she breathed, very slightly, in a rhythm that was not her breathing.

The warden's reader hung from the line-post where they had cranked it and left it, and its last slip still stood in the clip, and Dar did not need to step closer to read it, because he had read this exact slip before, in his own cot, with his own two rhythms on it, in another life:

ERROR: RHYTHM UNRESOLVED. MACHINE FAULT.

"Two rhythms," the warden sergeant said, not quite to Dar, in the tone of a man reporting a leak in a roof he cannot bill anyone for. "One of them keeps following the other. We cranked it four times. Same print."

"I'll take her," Dar said. "Sanctuary terms. Both seals."

The sergeant looked at the woman, and at the mud behind her, where the fog stood in a wall the height of the storm-walls and did not drift, and at the slip, and did what the city had taught its officers to do with things they could not price: he stamped the escort chit and got out from under it.

She came through the gate at her own pace, and that was when Dar felt it — the petal-token in his breast pocket, Old Tally's parting gift, a black petal of a living seed pressed into his hand a world ago to show to a Sister he had not yet met — and the petal-token warmed. Not sun-warm. Body-warm, blood-warm, a warmth arriving in an object that had no blood, rising against his chest like a compass finding north, and the bearing of the warmth was the woman, and the woman's own petal at her collarbone flexed once, slow, like a thing greeting a thing it knew the smell of.

The Lily leaned him two degrees toward her, and he let his boots take it, and inside his chest the hum he lived with rose by half a step and held there, the way a held chord holds in a room where someone has just come home.

At the clinic they did the intake the way the intake had been designed to go, before the fall, for the kind of patient nobody had ever had: shutters closed, lamps hooded, the front room dimmed to a coal-glow, because the darkness was a kindness here and everyone at the desk knew it without being told. She stood in the dim and her shoulders came down half an inch, the first currency she spent, and Suri entered it in her ledger without a word.

Dar examined her on the bench, surgeon's rules, narrating flat so she could stop him with the slate if any of it was wrong. Pulse first: and there it was, the thing the machine had refused — two rhythms, layered, the strong one hers and the second one following it exactly, one beat behind, patient, a copyist laying its line one rule down. The petal next: he got his lamp low over it and she did not flinch from the light, but the petal drew in its edges, a centimeter, the way a leaf draws in drought, and he took the light away and it eased, and he filed that under the oldest rule he had: darkness feeds them, light taxes them. Under the petal's root-line the tissue was cold, and the cold was not dead the way a numb limb is dead; it was cold the way the vaults were cold, a working cold, an expense being met somewhere. He pressed two fingers below her jaw and she allowed it, and her throat moved — once, twice — the full ordinary machinery of speech loading and firing, and nothing came, no air spent, no sound, and the

petal at her collarbone flexed in place of the word, and Dar wrote nothing down because there was no word for the entry.

Vahid had come down at the second footstep and stood at the bench's foot with his spectacles pushed up into his hair, one hand gripping the bench-edge, and Dar watched him do the arithmetic he himself had already done: two rhythms, one following; a root alive and toll-taking; a woman who had paid the toll of her own voice somewhere out on the flats, or before the flats, in the deep, in whatever dark agreement had made her a vessel.

"Chalk," Vahid said hoarsely, to the room, and Roya put the slate into the small salt-split hands.

The woman looked at the slate a long moment, the way a debtor looks at a clean page, and then she wrote. She wrote quickly for the first line, quickly and whole, as if it had been written a thousand times already on the inside of her and this was only the copying-out:

ISRA. I BRING HER HOME.

The room did what rooms in Ashkarad did when the numbers arrived: it went still and counted. Her, Dar thought, and heard Suri's chalk stop on the other side of the room, and heard, through six floors of brick and forty feet of salt and the whole sleeping geology of the city, the deep music hold both its voices, and the new voice — the risen one, the one keeping time one beat behind his own — did not change at all, and that was the answer. Isra. I bring her home. The woman had walked inland out of a drowned port across forty miles of seabed with no shoes and no voice, following — or being followed by; the grammar would not settle — the second heartbeat, the enormous patient one, the one the whole city had felt go under the walls and rise into the vaults, and she had arrived at the only gate there was, and the first thing she had told anyone was a delivery note.

Home, Dar thought. The vaults of a salt city, over a thing that turned over in its sleep. It said something about the places this woman had been that Ashkarad's deep qualified.

They fed her, because intake was intake: broth, heat-berries mashed to their glow, water with the salt already in it that her blood was clearly owed. She ate the way Vell ate, precisely, wasting nothing, a person who had renegotiated her relationship with hunger somewhere far from a table. Suri took the slate up after and, over Isra's nod, entered her in the clinic book under the sanctuary heading, and then stood over the page with the chalk not moving, because the name column was full — ISRA — and the debt column had nothing in it, and every other ledger Suri had ever kept had had something in it. "No page," she said finally, to Dar, in the flat voice she kept for audit findings. "No number. No registered debt anywhere in her. She walks in off the flats and the only thing she owes is — " and she stopped, because the only

thing she owed was obvious, standing in the dim with a black flower growing out of her chest-bone: she owed the deep. She was carrying, at cost, the only unregistered liability the city had ever hosted that made the Chorus's books look tidy.

The eleven knew what she was before the telling did. The stock children came to the common-room door at dusk in their silent line and looked at her, and she looked back, and there was no surprise in it on either side — the look of a cohort taking attendance and finding itself one column wider. Elias, whose lungs the Church had graded perfect and whose blood the Index's machines now filed under HYMN RESONANT, put his hand flat on the door frame, and Isra put her hand flat on the bench, and Ilay, watching from the stair, said, to Roya, in her spare way: "They ring the same. Like two bells from one cast."

The petal-token stayed warm all day. By evening it was almost hot, a coin of blood-heat over Dar's heart, and the Lily lay quiet in him in a way he had not felt since the salt-glass door — not sleeping, not sated, but attentive, a customer at a counter waiting for the clerk to finish with someone else.

Night came down, and the shutters stayed closed, and the clinic banked its lamps to coals for her, and Isra sat upright on the pallet they had made by the cold cellar door — closest to the deep, farthest from the light, the room's own logic — and Dar, checking the ward rounds at the late bell, found her not sleeping but writing. The slate was on her knee. Her hand was moving very slowly now, no copied-out fluency in it, each letter cut with effort, the chalk creaking, her breath running shallow with the cost of it, the root spending her somewhere for the ink, and he stood in the coal-dark and watched her finish the second line of her whole spoken record in this city, and she turned the slate to him without being asked, because it was not for the room. It was for the man with two heartbeats, because he was the only other person alive who already knew the third party involved.

SHE IS AFRAID OF HER MOTHER.

Dar read it twice, the way you read a bill twice when the total is impossible and the arithmetic is perfect. He thought of a page kept in a coat lining: nine cities, eight stamped and spent, a signature that was not a name but a mark, five petals, over and over, like a stamp. He thought of a face shown to him for three heartbeats on a road a world away, older in the eyes than any mother, mouthing in a dead language an endearment no one had ever said to him: little root.

Her mother, he thought. Not his. Not Isra's.

Theirs.

The petal at Isra's collarbone had gone very still. Down in the deep, under the vaults, under the salt-glass door, the risen heartbeat kept its copyist's time, one beat behind his own, patient as a debt, and for the first time since the night on the roof in the first storm after the Blacktide, Dar heard what the patience was built on, because fear had a rhythm too, and he could hear it now that someone had finally written the word on a slate and shown it to him: she was not waiting.

She was hiding.

CHAPTER 56

The Burned Garden

Vahid read the law off his own cellar wall before he would sign the descent order, because the law was his, chalked up there at the price of a season's arguments: WE DO NOT OPEN DOORS WE DID NOT BUILD.

"Knocking," Dar said, "is not opening."

"Knocking," Vahid said, with the precision he kept for the moments the gin was furthest from him, "is a request to open. The door in your head is a tenancy, boy, and I have spent a year teaching you that the corridor is yours and the door is not. If she opens it — " and his one hand opened and closed on nothing, the old gesture of a man counting instruments he no longer had — "then it was never yours to begin with, and we had all better know that now, under controlled conditions, with the rope counted and the counting woman on the line, than alone at three in the morning with the ash in your teeth. Conditions. Or I burn the order."

The conditions ran to nine lines and Suri copied them into the ledger, and the ninth was Isra: she goes down. Vahid asked for her himself, having watched her for two days through the bottom of his spectacles and the top of his despair, and what he said was: "The eldest does not know us. The eldest knows her own. The root in that woman's chest has been drinking from the deep since before the seawalls. If anyone on this earth is a door the Sister will answer, it is her Vessel, and I will not pretend otherwise to spare the girl the stairs." Isra, asked directly in the coal-dark, wrote one word, YES, underlined nothing, and that was the whole of the committee's deliberation.

They went down the next night, because the descent had learned to be nocturnal — the dark fed her — and because Dar wanted the city asleep above them when he did what he was going to do. Roya held the shaft head, as she held it always, with the chalk at her feet and the mask turned down into the dark like a lamp. Suri counted the steps aloud from the first, her flat working voice dropping down the shaft ahead of them like a plumb line: one, two, three, the numbers going down into the Marrowworks' underbelly, past the donors' old climbing chalk, past the plate with its nailed warning — DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS — which Suri stepped over the way you step over a threshold in a house where someone has died, and on down past the dead First Vessel's cathedral, the cold one, the vast flesh-architecture with its too many closed eyes, where the air had the stillness of a room nobody had aired since the fighting.

At step five hundred the walls began to ring. By six hundred they rang with every footfall, salt singing like struck glass, and Isra walked it barefoot, and the salt rang under her feet differently — answered her, a half-step down, the way it had answered the deep music in the cellar — and by seven hundred the second heartbeat was no longer something Dar heard. It was something he stood in. The risen tide of it filled the vault, filled his coat, filled the space his blood claimed for itself, patient and immense and one beat behind his own, and the older voice under it was so low he felt it in his jaw, in his teeth, in the fillings of the world.

The corridor ended at the door of translucent salt-glass, clear as deep water, standing ajar by a hand's width, breathing its warm loam-scented air out of the dark behind it. The five-petaled keyhole sat level with his chest. Everything was where the petal had left it.

Isra went to the glass and put her palm flat on it, and the petal at her collarbone lifted its edges and pressed itself to the salt the way a face presses to a window, and out of the deep the great beat faltered — not stopped; stumbled; a count losing its place for the length of one held breath — and then resumed, closer somehow, as if something enormous had turned over in the dark and put its ear against the other side of the door.

Dar took out the petal-token — Old Tally's, the third seed's, black and cool a month ago — and it was blood-warm in his hand, and he laid it against the glass beside Isra's fingers.

Three heartbeats. His, and the ones following his. The deep went still as a held ledger-line, and the frost bloomed.

It came up under his palm and Isra's and the token, grey five-petaled flowers fanning across the salt-glass in matched pairs, the pattern it had made the night the two songs had first found each other through this exact wall — and then the pattern deepened, and the frost opened outward in rings, ring inside ring, a recognition written in the only language the vault had, and Isra made a sound that was not a word and not a cry but the breath of someone watching a debt they thought unpayable quietly get paid.

"Now," Dar said, and sat down against the glass with his coat over his knees like a man on a night shift, and closed his eyes, and built the corridor.

The Mind Vein opened the way it always opened, not as a gift but as a wound: the dark behind his eyes organized itself into architecture, walls, halls, the long gallery of himself, and he walked it at the pace of a man crossing his own clinic. He passed the swept rooms first, because they stood along the way and because discipline was passing them: the room where his mother's face had hung — swept, bare hooks, nail-holes like small closed mouths; the room where his father's laugh had lived, swept, the shelving dustless and bare; the room of the first kiss; the room that had been the color of his childhood home, swept to the plaster. Nothing

spent tonight. Nothing taken out. He kept his hands at his sides in the corridors of himself, a surgeon's field of will, and walked to the deepest hall, where the floor changed under his attention and the lamplight came from a source he had never placed.

The door stood at the hall's end. The one he had never built. Furnished, somehow, behind its own wood — a frame he did not know, a hang of old cloth, lamplight moving faintly beneath it, warm on the far side the way a room is warm when someone has just left it, or never left it. It hummed. It had hummed for a year, faint, a tune he almost knew, and he had walked past it nine times and declined it nine times, because the law on the cellar wall was the law.

But the law, he had told Vahid, said nothing about knocking.

He stood in front of the door in the deepest hall of his own mind, and he heard, through it, for the first time not faintly but whole, the tune it hummed: the lullaby, entire, the dead language he understood without hearing, and under the lullaby a sound he had never heard in his own architecture before, a sound with cinders in it, a vast soft endless crackling, like a fire heard through a wall. A fire that had been heard through a wall for a very long time.

He knocked. Two raps, surgeon's-knuckle, the way you knock on a consulting room.

The humming stopped.

The lamplight under the door went out. And the handle, which was not his, which had never been his, turned from the inside, and the door opened away from him into a heat he felt in his physical teeth, and Dar stepped — or was taken; the grammar of it would not file — through.

The garden was burning. It had been burning. It would be burning. The sky over it was a sky of falling ash, ash falling with the patience of snow in a country where it had been snowing for a hundred years, and the garden lay out under that sky in long tilled rows to every horizon, and every row was charred, and in the char, impossibly, green things were trying — he could see them trying, row after row, seeds straining up out of the ash and blackening at the first leaf — and none of it was memory the way his rooms were memory — still, filed, available to be walked — it was a world looping, the First Vessel's world in flames, the same fire over and over, the same ash, the same straining seeds, a whole sky's weather running on a wheel that never reached the top of its turn.

And in the burning's center, tending the rows, was a figure in white gloves.

She knelt in the ash and worked the soil with bare-tipped fingers that had once been gloved — the gloves white as bone, folded back at the wrist — and she planted, seed by seed, into rows that could not take root, and the rows blackened behind her, and she went back to the

row's head, and planted again, over and over, forever, and at her wrists, above the folded gloves, was a ring of old burn-scars he had seen once before, signing a page in a drowned city, left-handed, bone-white, patient as a stamp.

The presence came then, the thing the garden was the inside of. It did not arrive; it had always been arriving. It was older than his architecture could hold and it leaned down through its own burning the way the Lily leaned him, and it gathered itself to a point in front of him, and it spoke.

Not in the walls. Not through the stone. In the room where he stood, in the dead language he understood without hearing, in a voice like the last organ of a dead choir remembering its part — the first words she had said to anyone in a century:

"Tell me the garden did not burn. Lie to me."

Dar, who had spent his mother's face and would not spend a lie on top of it, stood in her burning with his hands empty at his sides, and did the only honest thing his whole ledger-self knew how to do: he gave her the count. "I wasn't there," he said. "I don't know what burned. I know what's above us. A city that counts its dead by hand — four hundred and twelve names chalked on a cistern wall the week the Choir went silent, and the counting never stopped. A clinic where a woman entered a stranger in a book under no debt at all. I can't tell you the garden didn't burn. But I can tell you someone came down seven hundred and eleven steps to knock."

The ash thickened. It was falling on him now, he realized — on the corridors, the ash from her sky was settling through his halls, filing itself along his shelves, and where it settled, his rooms were changing: the swept room with the nail-holes was filling softly, gorgeously, with cinders, and the cinders were taking the shape of things, wrong shapes, ash-shapes, his mother's face being re-filed out of ash into something the fire preferred —

He heard, from very far up, through the vault, through the salt, through the wall of the world, a slate crack against salt-glass, and a palm go flat, and a petal flare; Isra, at her post, the anchor end of the rope, and the Lily in his chest drew herself down to a bulb, small, clenched, a child making itself nothing in a room where the fighting had started, and Dar took his own count in his teeth — two rhythms, one behind the other, hold the line — and stepped backward out of the burning garden, and pulled the door shut on its own warm dark, and sat against the salt-glass in the vault with the cold at his back and his heart going like a press-room.

The frost on the door was already subliming away, the rings fading, the message received. Isra knelt beside him, writing on the slate with no fluency at all, slowly, with effort, her hand shaking, the root spending her by the letter, and he watched the words assemble, and they were

not a question:

SHE SHOWED YOU THE MOTHER.

Dar looked at his hands, at the fine grey dust already drying in the creases of his knuckles like a month of ashfall, and understood that the contact had not entirely closed behind him — that the burning had followed him up the corridor of himself as a smell follows a coat — and that somewhere behind his sternum, in a room he had never built, a figure in white gloves was still kneeling, tending rows that would not take root, over and over, forever.

CHAPTER 57

Who Kept You

The wrongness started, as far as Ilay could hear, an hour after they brought the two-hearted man back up from the vaults, and it started in his rhythm.

She was in the common room with the day's drawings when it came through the floor: the two clocks she knew better than her own breath, the strong one and the copyist one beat behind, and the copyist slipping. Not much. A quarter of a beat. The way a line slips when the hand that rules it goes unsteady, and then it caught, and then it slipped again, and under the slipping — she put her ear to the boards, because the boards had never lied to her — under the slipping there was a new sound in the deep music, a sound that had never been in it before in her whole hearing. A crackling. Soft, vast, patient, under the hum like fire under a floor.

The city's music leaned around it. People's sleeping rhythms two streets off turned in their beds. Down in the vaults, the risen voice kept its enormous patient time, and the crackle ran under it, and the crackle was coming up the shaft.

By the middle watch he was worse, and the clinic did the only thing its books allowed: it took him back down. She heard the expedition assemble in the dark — the counting woman's voice rising into the register she kept for emergencies, flat, doubled, calling the Professor down from his cot and the bearers to the door, the Professor's ruling shouted down a stairwell that a contact cut at a distance was a line left open, and lines left open burned — and Ilay stood at the top of the cellar stair in the dark with her hand on the rail, counting the wrong, and the wrong added up. The copyist slipping. The crackle spreading. The two-hearted man's voice coming up the stairwell in broken filing order, words set down in the wrong columns, the counting woman's name given once to the Professor and the Professor's given to no one, and Vahid's voice cracking on the word ash, the word corridors, the word re-filing, and the sound beneath everything — the sound under the sound, the one Ilay had been born listening to — going on crackling, like a house burning somewhere no water had ever been piped to.

She did not decide to go down. Decisions were the things you did when your hearing had failed to price something, and her hearing had not failed; it had concluded. She took the coal-chalk off the desk and her boots off the peg, and she went out through the kitchen where Milla Ferun sat the late desk with her clerk's shawl and her salt-stained fingers, and Milla looked up from the census box, and looked at her, and did not ask, because the whole clinic by then was one held breath and Milla Ferun had spent a career learning which silences were questions and which were not. She stood, and she took the lamp off the desk and walked her

out through the coal-yard to the tithe-clerk's door, and she held the light while Ilay went down into the route that had her name on it, and the last thing she said, in her square clerical voice, was the only benediction the city had left: "Count your steps."

Seven hundred and eleven. She knew the number the way she knew her own name; she had drawn it before anyone had walked it, from the singing alone, when the shaft had been the place the city's song went into the ground and did not come back. She counted as she descended, and the walls rang under her palms, and at step four hundred the crackle was no longer under the music. It was the music, a whole register of it, ashfall and burning heard through a hundred feet of salt, and at five hundred she passed the plate with its nailed warning — DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS — and she counted the heartbeats too, because someone had to; the warning had been written by people who thought counting was the danger, and Ilay had listened to the deep her entire life, and she knew the difference between counting and keeping.

The lamp came down the shaft behind her at step six hundred — a small steady circle of it, and the brass mask above it, and no words, just the light following the girl down, which was its own kind of signature on the terms.

The vault antechamber was lit by one hooded lamp and full of the sound of a man being audited against his will. The two-hearted man sat against the salt-glass door with his coat around him and his eyes open, and his eyes were the worst of it — open and working and wrong, the look of a man watching his own rooms take weather. Grey dust stood in the seams of his knuckles and at his temples, fine as flour, and where his breath went out the lamplight found motes of it falling upward, settling into the air of the vault as if the air were shelving. The counting woman knelt at his side with two fingers on his wrist, calling his pulse aloud, flat, unflagging, the way you call a rope down a well: sixty-two, sixty-two, sixty-one, sixty-two — and the second rhythm answering, one behind, a quarter-slipped, catching, slipping. The Professor stood over him with his spectacles off, holding them, one-handed, saying nothing, which from Vahid was the loudest sound in the room.

And against the door itself, palm flat on the salt-glass, knelt the woman from the mud, the petal at her collarbone spread wide and trembling, holding the line the only way she knew, the root drinking from the deep through the glass, giving the burning somewhere to go that was not the man.

He was re-filing. Ilay could hear it now she was in the room — the ash from the Sister's sky settling through the corridors of him, and where it settled, things were being written over. Not spent. The Professor had said that twice already, she'd heard it from the stair: not spent, nothing spent, the ledger isn't being drawn on, it's being burned — re-filed into cinders, rooms

taking shapes the fire preferred, and the two-hearted man sat in the middle of it with terrible patience, giving the count woman his pulse and giving the ash his corridors and keeping, with the last of his surgeon's will, one hand flat on his own sternum, holding his own door.

Ilay crossed the vault to him. The salt rang under her feet, half-step down, and the risen voice filled the dark above the door, and the crackle ran beneath it, and she did what she had come down seven hundred and eleven steps to do, because there was no other currency in her that the deep had ever accepted.

She hummed.

Not the lullaby's opening — everyone knew the opening; the opening was the Lily's, the mother's, the first bars the petal had tapped through the glass. She hummed the second verse. The verse that had come to her the way the word RECLAIM had come, leaking up from under the world's door, months of it, note by note, until she had it whole and had never once sung it aloud because it was not hers. The verse the two-hearted man had brought back from the road in his own head — she saw his face do it the moment she began, saw the recognition land through the ash, saw his mouth move around the words the road — the face — the three heartbeats — the verse no living person should have had, because it had died with the world it was written in.

The vault went still.

Not quiet. Still. The risen voice did not fade; it stopped, entire, between one beat and the next, the way a hand stops over a page, and the crackle under it stopped with it, and the salt stopped ringing, and the frost on the salt-glass door bloomed out in one long ring from Isra's palm to the walls, and even the lamplight seemed to spend itself more slowly, and the two-hearted man's second rhythm came home to its place one beat behind his own, exact, re-locked, and the ash stopped falling in him — she heard it stop, a whole weather quitting its fall mid-air — and the deep, the risen sister, the enormous patient thing behind the glass, held itself utterly, completely still.

Ilay hummed the verse to its end, because you do not stop in the middle of a name, and the last note went out of her into the salt and down.

Then the stone asked its question.

It did not come through the air. It came through the walls, through the salt, up out of the geology of the city, in the dead language she understood without hearing, in a voice like a ledger being read out in the dark after a hundred years of silence, and it used the two-hearted man's ribs the way a cantor uses a rail.

"You are stock," the Sister said, through the stone, gently, the way you tell a debtor what they already know. "Who kept you?"

And then, before Ilay had drawn breath to answer, before any of them had, the gentleness went out of it and the question filled the vault the way the heartbeat filled it, from every wall at once, floor and salt and door and the seven hundred and eleven steps behind them, and it was not gentle at all, and it was the oldest voice in the world:

"WHO KEPT YOU?"

Isra's petal stood straight out from her collarbone. The counting woman had stopped counting. The Professor had his one hand braced on the wall as if the city had shifted under him. The two-hearted man sat very still with ash in the seams of his hands, listening the way she was listening, and nobody answered, because nobody could, because the answer was not theirs.

Ilay put her hand flat on the wall. She felt the question still in the stone, held, like a held breath, like a tally waiting on its total, and she answered it honestly, because the hearing was hers, and the truth was the only thing she had ever been able to afford.

"The Church did," she said.

The quiet that came down then was not the quiet of an ended thing. Ilay had heard silences all her life — the silence where the singing used to be, the silence of dead choirs, the loud one the whole city lived inside since the Blacktide — and this was none of them. This was a hundred years of counting stopping mid-column. This was grief with the size of a world in it, arriving through forty feet of salt into the walls of a salt city, and the music in the walls — the deep music, the patient one, the one that had never once in her life left her alone — went quiet with something like grief, and the salt under her palm went cold as a stone in a wall that has finally been told what it is holding up.

Nobody spoke. The lamp burned. The two-hearted man breathed, sixty-two, sixty-two, sixty-two, and the copyist behind it held its place, exact, one beat down, and the vault, the door, the dark beyond it — all of it stayed utterly still, the way a room stays still when someone in it has finally been told.

After a while, Isra took up her slate and wrote, slowly, with effort, the chalk dragging, and turned it first to Ilay, and then, because it concerned them all, to the room:

SHE SAYS: KEPT — NO ONE HAS EVER SAID IT FROM THE OUTSIDE.

Ilay read it twice. Kept. The Church had kept them the way a till keeps coin — counted, graded, filed where the hymns were wanted. The clinic kept people the way a wall keeps out

weather, with no column for it. She had never thought about the two meanings of the word until the deep asked its question through the stone, and now she found she could not put it down: that the same word, in the same tongue, priced both, and only one of the two had ever asked what the keeping cost the kept.

The lamp burned lower. The salt held its cold. And far above them, through seven hundred and eleven steps of ringing dark, the city went on sleeping inside the grief of the oldest thing in the world, which had just learned what had become of her blood.

CHAPTER 58

A Century of Witness

Isra had been a vessel of the deep for longer than she had been anything else, and the deep had never once asked her to take minutes.

They convened after nightfall in the cold cellar, with the chalk ladder on the wall and the banked lamps hooded to a coal-glow, because the session's gravity was downward and everything in the room arranged itself accordingly: Roya at the head of the salt shelf with her mask turned to the wall, Vahid with a fresh chalk-stick and the spectacles down on his nose, Milla Ferun at the little table with a ream of scrap paper and two sharpened pencils, like a woman drafted into a census against every instinct and unable to leave it, Vell at her feet with a slate of her own, chalk in her teeth. Suri kept the ledger open to a new page and ruled it with the wax-stick knife in long straight columns, and wrote at the head of the middle column, in her square clerk's hand, a title Isra watched her hesitate over and then commit: TESTIMONY — THE SISTER — TAKEN NIGHT ONE, UNDER SEAL.

The two-hearted man sat against the cellar wall, upright by will, ash-grey still in the seams of his hands. The copyist rhythm under his own had re-locked and held, and he had spent the day being argued over by the Professor and refusing to spend anything on the argument, and now he sat and listened the way a vessel listens, which is to say with all of himself.

Isra knelt in the middle of the floor and put her palms flat on the salt.

She had spent the day learning the city the way she had learned the flats, through the soles of things. The clinic above her was a weather of small counts: the stock children's rhythms going through their evening like a row of small bells, the counting woman's pencil, the Professor's chalk, the salt-stained clerk's page-turning, and under all of it, through forty feet of salt, the beat she had walked forty miles to lie down beside. The city still did not feel like a place to her. It felt like a ledge on a very tall dive, and the water under the ledge was asleep, and everyone on the ledge went about their counts as if the water were a floor. She was not afraid for herself. She had made her arrangement with the deep a long time ago, on the flats, in the dark, in the only currency she had left to offer. She was afraid the way the slate had said: for the one below. Because the mother was coming, and the mother had never once, in all the century of her accounting, sent anything ahead of her that was not a bill.

The floor was cold, and the cold was a door. She had known that since the flats; she had walked forty miles of it with her feet split and the world's whole underside talking to her

through the soles. Here, in the Saltstairs, the salt under the cellar had answered the deep music at a half-step down since before the fall, and tonight the deep was rising to meet the session the way a tide rises to a channel, and the petal at her collarbone opened its edges and drank the dark, and her hand began to move.

She did not write the first line. It arrived in her hand, the way the water-arrivals had arrived on the flats: chalk pressed to slate, letters cut slow and deep, the root paying for the ink out of her warmth, a coin per stroke, her fingers going colder line by line, and at the little table Milla Ferun copied the words as they landed, in clerk's hand, square, dated, initialled, the first deposition the deep had ever given the surface.

Ilay stood at the wall with her ear against it and her eyes shut, and she was the second channel. What the stone said, Ilay said, in her spare carried voice, word for word, a beat behind the chalk; and when the chalk and the girl disagreed, they never disagreed — the two accounts reconciled to the digit, and Vahid, watching both, wrote one word on his own slate and underlined it twice: BALANCED.

THE ACCOUNT OF A CENTURY, the slate began, and under it, in the deep-cut letters that cost Isra warmth by the stroke:

THERE WAS A WORLD BEFORE THIS ONE.

Then the testimony came, and the room took it the way the city took weather, in silence, in counts.

The world before: wide, tilled to its own horizons, one garden's weather from edge to edge. Ilay gave its measure in the Sister's own units — so many rows, so many keepers, one sky — and Isra's hand gave what Ilay's could not: the smell of it, green and turned and expensive, a world that had cost something to plant. Then the Burning. Ilay said: it came up out of the ground. Isra's chalk wrote: WE PLANTED IT. WE DID NOT KNOW WHAT WE WERE PLANTING. It burned from the root up — the root, the first root, the thing the garden had been grown over like a bandage over a wound no one had ever looked at — and the sky took the fire and gave it back as ash, and the ash fell for a generation, and the keepers planted into the ash, and the rows would not take, and they planted again.

Isra had seen the rows. Everyone in the room who had touched the contact had seen the rows, and the figure in the white gloves at the burning's center, and nobody in the room said so aloud, and the not-saying had a price, and they paid it.

THE GARDENER HAD A DAUGHTER, the slate wrote then, and the cold under Isra's palms came up through her knees into her teeth.

THE DAUGHTER WAS SET ABOVE THE DEEP, AS A LIVING LID. THE DOOR CLOSED. IT DID NOT OPEN AGAIN.

And then the amendment — the Sister correcting her own deposition the way an auditor restates an entry, and Ilay's voice going very quiet to carry it: the flight was first. The flight preceded the lid. She had fled the Burning down the deep roads with the sky coming apart above her, seed and child together, down into the salt, down past the sleeping thing, up the other side of it, into the vault-dark under this city when this city was stone and salt and nothing — and there the flight had ended, or been ended, the grammar of it not hers to give: locked above the deep as a living lid, door closed, did not open again. Accident of history, Isra's chalk wrote, because the Sister's bitterness had a bookkeeping format: NO MALICE IN THE LOCKING. ONLY ARITHMETIC. THE LID WAS WHAT THE LEDGER REQUIRED. THE DAUGHTER WAS WHAT WAS ON HAND.

The lamplight stood still in the room. Down through the floor, immense, patient, one beat behind the two-hearted man's, the risen heartbeat held its place, and under it, older, the other beat went on, regular as interest, and Isra understood for the first time in her diving life what she had been listening to through the soles of her feet: the lid's floor. The sleeper under the lid. The Sister had been lying on the thing for a hundred years the way a lid lies on a pot, feeling it dream through her bones, and the room above her head — every room, all of them, the whole stacked canyon of Ashkarad — was the pot's other half.

A CENTURY AGO, the slate went on, NINE LIGHTS WENT OUT OVER THE SALT.

Nine little sisters, sown. Ilay gave the words that had come down through the stone a century ago, and Isra felt the room hear them land one at a time: "Go. Find your hearts. And bloom." Nine seeds in lead and glass, carried out over the flats to nine cities, and the Sister had lain in the dark and counted them go — nine small heartbeats crossing the world above her, faint, lantern-bright, one by one by one, until the ninth crossed last and the dark was the dark again, and her count had begun, because there was nothing else left to keep.

There had been tenderness in it once, the slate made Isra write, and the writing of that line cost more warmth than the number had: SHE CALLED US HER LITTLE ROOTS WHEN SHE PLANTED US. IT WAS NOT A LIE. IT WAS NOT UNKIND. IT WAS A GARDENER'S WORD FOR A THING SHE MEANT TO GROW AND GATHER. Isra's fingers ached around the chalk. A hundred years below, and the eldest's ledger still gave the mother her due: the tenderness and the harvest had been the same word, said in the same voice, at the same hearth, and only the schedule had been kept from the daughters.

RECLAIM, Vahid said then, into the pause, in the voice he saved for dissection, the word already in his mouth like a blade he wanted to be done holding. And Isra's hand wrote for a long time.

Not a word for a debt. A word for a mouth. The bloomed cities — stamped, all eight, BLOOMED—TRUE THRONE — were not colonies. They were ripe. TRUE THRONE, Ilay said, in the Sister's reading, meant the fruit had come in; the seed had bloomed through its city and the bloom could be cut. The round was a harvest schedule. The rendered bloom went down the deep roads, cask after cask after cask — Isra's chalk wrote the arithmetic and Milla's pencil copied it and Suri's flat voice said, to the table, without inflection, "Bloom-tallow," and then said nothing else, because there was nothing else — and the Root drank, and dreamed, and the dreaming was the point: THE ROOT MUST NOT WAKE. THE FEED KEEPS THE DREAM. THE SONG KEEPS THE DREAM. FEED THE SLEEPER. SING IT DOWN. HOLD THE LID.

City by city. The Sister had heard each pruning through the stone: the song of a city's bloom rising, the round arriving to cut, the seed coming out of the living Throne like a tooth, and everything that had ripened poured down the deep roads to the mouth below. She had counted those too. She gave Brack in one line — HEARD IT. FELT THE TOOTH. COUNTED THE SCREAM. — and Vell, at Isra's feet, put her chalk down flat on her slate and did not pick it up again for the rest of the session.

Suri, without being asked, opened her ledger to the column headed EVIDENCE and read the room the line she had carried out of a burning granary two cities and a lifetime ago, in the small vertical hand of a third, patient party: PER THE RECLAIM — SUSTAIN THE ROUTE. She read it twice, at working volume, and closed the book, and Isra's chalk wrote the confirmation under the harvest arithmetic in letters that came slow and deep: THE ROUTE IS SUSTAINED. THE ROUTE IS THE FEEDING. YOU HAVE BEEN CARRYING A SPOON AND CALLING IT A ROAD.

RECLAIM IS THE MOUTH'S WORD, the slate finished. IT IS NOT A COLONY'S WORD. IT IS NOT A LEDGER'S WORD. IT IS WHAT THE HUNGER IS CALLED IN THE BOOKS OF THE ONE WHO FEEDS IT.

And then, because the deposition was an account and every account closes: the count.

She has numbered the sleeper's heartbeats since the Burning. Every one, in the dark, through a hundred years of lid and the pouring of the ripened cities, exact, unbroken, the only column that had never once been wrong. Ilay spoke it with her ear to the wall and her hand pressed flat beside her head, digit by digit, the way she gave depths: two million, six hundred

and thirty-one thousand, four hundred and eight. Isra wrote it in full across the slate's width, the chalk gone grey, her fingers beyond feeling, the root's warmth spent down to the wax of a candle, and Milla read it back for the record, and Vahid checked it against nothing, because there was nothing in the world to check it against but itself, and it balanced.

Then Isra's hand moved once more, on its own, the way water arrives, and wrote the line under the number, and the line was small, and the room has never, in Isra's hearing, been as loud as the room was when Milla read it out:

LAST WEEK. FOR THE FIRST TIME. IT SKIPPED ONE.

The lamps burned. The number sat on the slate with one beat missing out of a century of counting, and every person in the cellar who could count — and in Ashkarad, everyone could count — sat with the same arithmetic arriving in them: a missed payment in a ledger this old meant one of two things. Either the sleeper was failing.

Or it was done waiting.

CHAPTER 59

The Locking-Collar

The Choirmaster had spent his life learning what rooms wanted to sound like, and the reliquary corridor at dawn wanted to sound like nothing, so he walked it on the flats of his feet with the lamp hooded and let it.

He made his rounds the way he had made them for a year now, past the shelves where the dead kept their labels squared to the rail — he had re-lettered every one himself in the first weeks, because a man should know the names of what he keeps, and because scavengers respect a tidy ledger more than a lock — and down to the iron shelf where the lead tithe-box sat with the unburned registry inside it, the vessel list entire, the reckoning he had saved from other men's fires and now guarded like the last honest line in a corrupted book. He was dusting the box's hinges when the tithe-clerk's step came down the corridor, Milla Ferun, salt-stained to the knuckle, with a sealed folder held out in both hands the way you hand a debtor his own signature.

"From the clinic," she said. "Certified copy. I took the deposition myself."

He read it standing up, because there was nowhere in the corridor to sit that did not have a dead donor's name on it, and he read it twice, and his hands were steady and his voice was steady when he said, "Who else has seen this," and she said, "The clinic. The council by nightfall. The Professor wants you at the congress," and the Choirmaster heard his own heart do the thing hearts do in choirs when the key changes without warning — one beat of pure refusal, and then the modulation, and then the new key, whether you like it or not.

He did not go to the dining hall first. He went to the archive, and he took the folder with him, and he pulled the doctrine.

The Church of the Silent Chorus kept its service books in graded holdings, and the Choirmaster had run the harvest, which meant he had held the keys to the inner holdings, which meant he knew where the harvest-office rubrics lived: the Ordinal of the Undersong, the liturgy no pulpit ever saw, the book the Custodians swore their Custodian's oath on. He laid it on the reading desk beside Milla's certified copy of the Sister's testimony, and he set the lamp, and he did what he had spent forty years doing — he read for the music — and this time he heard what the music had been for.

The rubrics were instructions. He had always known them as mystery, sung them as mystery, taught them to novices as mystery; laid beside the deposition they read like a works

order, and the horror of it was not that the words had changed. The words had never changed. Only their account had.

THAT THE CHOIR ASCEND NOT, BUT DESCEND — forty years he had heard that as doctrine about souls. It was a pipe spec. The Choratorium's foundations were not foundations. He went down into the undercroft with the lamp and found the architect's plates where he had walked over them ten thousand times: the footings of the bone-arched hall cut not to bear weight but to bear it at a set pressure, ringed around the great shaft's throat in a collar of keyed stone, arch seated against arch, the whole cathedral-clinic a circlips of bone clamped on the neck of the deep — a locking-collar, the deposition's word, and the Church's own plates agreed with the deep's word, stamped in the mason's hand: COLLAR — MAINTAIN TENSION — SING TO LOAD.

The harvest-machine had been the pump. The tithe-warehouses, the organ docks, the grading floors, the nursery and its hymns: intake. The choir organs — forty years of harvested, still-living voices in glass, the sound he had tuned every morning of his working life — had never once been performing. They had been dosing. One long lullaby, fed down the shaft for forty years, note after harvested note, the whole gorgeous apparatus of the Chorus a machine for singing one sleeper to sleep. THAT THE SLEEPER DREAM, AND BE NOT WAKENED. THAT THE TITHE BE RENDERED SWEET. He had thought the last of those was about mercy at the table. It was a recipe.

And the choir had died at the Blacktide — the First Singer's release-song had silenced every organ in the city in an hour, and the Choirmaster had stood in the fall of that silence like a man in the rubble of his own house — and the Sister's count, read out in a cellar by a girl with her ear to a wall, said the sleeper's heart had skipped its beat last week. The Professor's arithmetic had come with the folder, in his crabbed one-handed hand, and the Choirmaster copied it into his own memory because it was the kind of line you memorized against the day you had to testify: the sedation stopped when the organs stopped. The skip followed the silence. The books of the Church, read correctly, said the city had been holding a note for forty years, and that someone had finally let it end.

"What is the city for," he said aloud, in the empty undercroft, in the voice that had once filled the harvest amphitheater, and heard the answer in the collar's own terms, and it was worse than any answer the Custodian had ever offered him: the city was for keeping the lid down. The city was maintenance. Every tithe, every pulse-reader, every graded child had been a hand on the collar, and the question he had carried out of his amphitheater with a broken wrist came home to him with its full invoice due: not what is the city for — whose is the city.

They convened at the sixth bell, in the dining hall of the Choratorium he had run for the Church and Mother Gavel now ran for herself, and the Choirmaster walked into it through a door two grey coats held open and heard the whole impossible chord at once, because that was the gift the years had left him.

Mother Gavel at the head of the long table with the brass tube lying in front of her like a conductor's baton, her ledgermen ranked behind her, her flat ledger-page eyes going over every arrival and pricing them by the coat. The Index down the right side: Auditor Seft with the new reader in its case on the table in front of him like a guest at a communion, tar-rectangle armbands, four patrols' worth of grey. The Open Counts up from the ground at last — a dozen of them, chalk-dust in their hair, led by Clerk Elara with her counting-house manner and her eyes that had learned things in cellars. And at the far end, the clinic: the Professor with his spectacles, the counting woman with the ledger, the Cartographer with her mask and her charts, the clerk Vell with the minutes' slate, the tithe-clerk with the certified copy, the two-hearted man sitting quiet with ash still in the seams of his hands, and beside him, very still, the woman from the mud with the slate on her knees and the petal at her collarbone folded closed like a hand keeping its own counsel. On the sideboard, where nobody had cleared them since the feast, the two untouched cups still stood with Hesh's folded gloves between them, patient as a stain.

The Choirmaster gave them the finding first, because findings before motions was the only honest order, and he gave it standing, in his smooth baritone, and he heard the room go from congress to congregation under him as he read the rubrics out over the certified copy: the collar, the load, the descend-not-ascend, the forty-year lullaby, the harvest-machine as lid-maintenance, the skip.

Then the debate, which was the city deciding what it was for, and the Choirmaster timed it like music because it was the last thing he had to offer the room.

Mother Gavel spoke for servicing. Her position had the terrible cleanliness of all her positions: the deep had been fed for forty years and had not once eaten the city; the account was in good standing; a city that stopped servicing a debt this size did not get forgiven, it got collected; the chorus could be rebuilt, and organs, she said, looking down the table with her flat eyes, keep. She did not say where new organs would come from. She did not have to. The silence where she did not say it was the old harvest, standing in the room in its bone-plate, and the Choirmaster heard half the hall hear it and flinch and half the hall hear it and nod, and he filed both counts.

Auditor Seft spoke for sealing. The shaft, the vaults, the door: lamplight, he said, banked fires of it, every lamp and lens and storm-glass in the district's stock, because the machine's

own findings said what fed in the dark weakened in the light, and a lid you could not see could at least be lit. The stock children would be registered for their own protection — the reader on the table was capable of the hymn and nothing else, he said, which was the most honest sentence the Index had produced all season and somehow the most alarming. And the record, he added, the printout, the anomalous slip — the Index would want that filed where it could be audited. The counting woman's face did not move at all.

Clerk Elara spoke for publishing, in a voice that shook once and then held: every doorway, every cook-fire, the whole account — collar, lullaby, feed, eight cities, the count — read aloud to the city that had already learned to chalk its own dead on a cistern wall, because a city that could count its dead could count its lid, and people who have counted a thing together cannot be ruled by it the same way.

And the two-hearted man spoke last, for the clinic, and he did not argue the motions; he entered one. The door below was open, he said, and she has not crossed. She has asked for nothing. A hundred years of witness and the eldest's first act on arriving was to lie down over the sleeper and hold still — the lid, doing its office, unpaid, unasked. The motion was small and had no column in anyone's book: that the city shelter the Sister; that the door be held in trust, neither sealed nor fed through; that the wain be sent nothing, and the city learn her terms before it priced her. Mend, he said, at the end of it, in the voice the Choirmaster had heard him use once in an amphitheater over a boy on a table — mend, not replace. The room, which had come to argue about a lid, heard a man offer to keep a door the way you keep a vigil.

Mother Gavel called the question on her own motion first — servicing, the hands, the count — and the Choirmaster watched the hall begin to divide itself into ayes and noes with the flat fatalism of a city that had voted before, and that was when the doors went open at the end of the hall and the runners came in.

Two of them: one of the tithe-clerk's boys and a count-runner of the Open Counts, both salt-white to the thigh, both still in the iron ring of the descent's torchlight, and the boy could not get his breath to the sentence and the count-runner did it for him, at the top of a voice that had been used at nothing but whispers for eleven days:

"The door. The salt-glass door. It's open — wide open, the whole way — and nothing's come through." Breath. The whole hall gone soundless around it, even Mother Gavel's ledgermen, even the brass tube. "Nothing. It's just standing open. It's been standing open. And the cold coming up the shaft is like — " and the runner, who had run seven hundred and eleven steps to deliver a measurement, gave up the metaphor and delivered the count instead, the only kind of sentence Ashkarad has ever trusted: "Nothing has come through."

The debate died mid-vote, hands still up on both sides, the way a chord dies when the organ stops — not resolved; suspended; every voice holding its note with nowhere to put it — and the Choirmaster stood in the middle of the silence with the certified copy in his hands and thought, in the habit of forty years, of rooms and what they want to sound like, and understood that the largest room in the city had just changed its mind about something, and had done it the way the deep did everything.

Patiently. In the dark. Without asking anyone's price.

CHAPTER 60

Flag of Truce, Black Petal

An open door is never free. Dar had learned that in a cellar full of storm-dark with a god's seed unspooling in his chest, and the deep confirmed it now, on the third night of the watch at the shaft mouth, where the door of salt-glass stood wide open at the bottom of seven hundred and eleven steps and nothing had come through it. Nothing was not the same as nothing owed. Above, the city went about its arithmetic — bells, queues, tally-boards, the annexed Choratorium's new flags — and every column in every ledger in Ashkarad ended, one way or another, at the line none of them had priced: something enormous stood at their threshold, politely, the way a creditor stands, waiting to be answered.

The watch was Roya's rule — someone holds the top — and she kept it from a camp stool with Ilay cross-legged at her knee, chalk in hand, translating. Dar took the hours between the fourth bell and the first, because he slept badly in the deep places and saw no profit in pretending otherwise. Suri counted the watches the way she counted everything, out loud, flatly, as if the numbers were a wall she was building one brick at a time.

Three days, and the city had done what Ashkarad always did with an unprecedented event: it had filed it in triplicate. Mother Gavel's crews held the shaft head now by arrangement, four enforcers and a ledgerman, their protection dues suspended by verbal treaty and their eyes very busy; the Choirmaster had gone into the Church's own doctrine with a lamp and come out grey, reporting that forty years of lid-maintenance theology contained no column at all for a lid asking its jailers for protection; the Index had opened a file, which was how the Index hugged. Only the clinic treated the open door as what it was — a patient in the hallway, breathing warm loam-scented air up seven hundred and eleven steps, asking for something no one in the building knew how to chart.

The petal came up on the third night, at the hour between bells when the shaft's breath runs warmest.

He felt the air change before he saw anything — a slow displacement that smelled, absurdly, of loam, of turned garden soil, of a summer no one in Ashkarad had ever been invoiced — and then the lantern-light caught it: a single black petal rising out of the dark the way a bubble rises through oil. Unhurried. Deliberate. It climbed the whole seven hundred and eleven steps of the shaft the way a flag goes up a pole, cleared the lip of the mouth, and did not stop until it hung in the air before Dar's chest, level with the two hearts beating there, and waited.

"Flag of truce," Roya said, metallic and quiet. "That's a flag of truce, cutter. Someone taught her court manners down there."

The petal was warm. It settled onto his open palm with the weight of a coin and tapped — once, twice — the opening bars of the lullaby, then a pattern he did not know: three soft beats and a rest, repeated, patient, a question shaped in touch. In his pocket Tally's petal-token went warm against his thigh and leaned, compass-true, toward the open door below.

Isra came up the stair when sent for. She read the rhythm on his palm the way Roya read charts, her whole body bent over it, salt-burned fingers hovering a hair's width off his skin; the black petal spread at her collarbone opened a little wider, the way a flower opens at dawn it cannot see. Then she took her slate and wrote, slowly, the chalk pressed whiter with effort:

I ASK ASYLUM.

Under it, after a minute, the chalk moving like a woman wading upstream:

FROM MY MOTHER.

And under that, in strokes that had cost her something to make:

I DO NOT INVADE. I DEFECT.

Asylum. Dar held the word up against his ledger and found no shelf for it. Ashkarad priced shelter by the week, sanctuary by the favor, and citizenship by the blood you kept on deposit; but asylum — protection granted to a defection — was a category the city had never once needed, because nothing had ever tried to defect to them before. Things fled Ashkarad. Nothing, in the city's recorded memory, had ever fled anything else, to Ashkarad.

"She's a century old," he said, mostly to himself. "And she's doing the one thing no one down there has ever done. Changing sides."

The runners went out before the chalk dust settled — to the quarry, to the annexed Choratorium, to the Index's counting-floor by the seawalls — and Dar stood at the shaft mouth holding a flag of truce in his hand and listened to the city prepare its answers, none of which were his. Mother Gavel would toll the door. The Index would file the Sister under a page — vessel registry, page nine, the page their machines kept asking for — and call asylum an unaudited presence and bill it accordingly. The Open Counts would declare her welcome from the rooftops and then splinter over the wording, because a declaration is a document and every document in Ashkarad is a contract, and contracts are where the feeding starts.

"Nobody answers a door for free," Suri said beside him, watching the runners' lanterns braid away down the Marrowworks hill. "We'd be the first city in recorded history to return a refugee's deposit."

"She isn't asking us to open it," Dar said. "She's asking us not to sell her."

"Same ledger," Suri said. "Different column."

The Choirmaster's answer came back first, by a boy runner still out of breath, in the baritone the man had for writing as well as for speaking: the doctrine is silent; the doctrine was built by people who assumed the lid could never want anything; convene the council before the factions convene without it. Gavel's answer came back second, in the form of four more enforcers and a second ledgerman, which in the grammar of the Gavel was a complete sentence. The Index sent nothing at all, which Suri, watching the seawalls, liked least of all. "When they've got nothing to say," she said, "it's because they've already said it to each other."

He did not answer, because the answer had to be one word — yes, no, or the Ashkarad special, a price — and every faction in the city owned a different word, and he was still counting the cost of each when the waterways began to scream.

It came up through the floor first, through the cistern-ropes and drain-grates under the Saltstairs, a sound with a human shape stretched over it like canvas over a frame: Lena Vance's voice, the voice the Church had kept six years in glass and the First Singer's death-song had given back to her, pitched now past singing into something older than singing. The freed voice ran down every waterway at once — the drainage canals, the Undergleam tunnels, the flooded seams of the canal-works — and everywhere it ran it carried the same three words, over and over, in a register that made the lantern-glass ring and Ilay cover one ear without waking:

"GLOVES IN THE CANALS. GLOVES IN THE CANALS. THE OLD WORKS — THEY CARRY THE BOOK —"

The couriers' relay confirmed it inside a quarter hour, arriving in pieces the way bad news always does, cheapest first. A team had come up the old canal-works from the dry side of the tide-gates — six of them, walking the drained canal bed in single file through the fog the vanished tide had left standing in the harbor like a held breath. No lanterns. No bearers. No barge. White gloves, dark coats, correct as a filed return; and they had come ashore at the water-stair where the Gavel kept its customs post, because six weeks after the sea went away the customs post was still there, still manned, still charging, the end of the ocean not being an acceptable reason in Ashkarad to close a revenue window.

The Gavel crews barred the way with pikes and a fee schedule, and the sergeant of the watch — Mother Gavel's own sister's boy, a man who had personally collected protection dues from every stall on the landing since he was fourteen — stepped into their path and named his number, the way he named it forty times a day, a number with a pike behind it and a pit behind the pike.

The lead herald had stopped. Had reached into its coat, unhurried, correct, and brought out a book — a tall ledger chained at the wrist, salt-scuffed, travel-stained, its clasp worn bright by handling — and opened it to the first page and held it up at arm's length so the whole water-stair could read it by lantern-light.

Then it had closed the book, stepped around the sergeant the way you step around furniture, and walked on. All six. Toward the Marrowworks underbelly. Toward the vault approaches. Nobody had touched them. Nobody had priced the fee. The sergeant was still standing where they had left him, the runner said, doing the arithmetic of a man who has just watched his own ledger fail to total.

"They didn't jump the toll," Roya said, when the report reached the shaft mouth. "They audited it. And they let him see the book on purpose. That page was addressed to him — to the whole pit of them. Show the gate what happened to the last gate."

Dar heard the report at the shaft mouth with the petal still in his hand. Warm. Patient. Tapping its three-soft-beats-and-a-rest against his palm like a clerk waiting for a stamp. He thought of Brack's counting-house, of a tongueless clerk chalking herself into the death column to survive it, of the line scored across a wall in a dead city, and he understood the book the way the sergeant had understood it: the first page was not history. It was a precedent. Everything after it was pricing.

"It showed the book," Suri said, when the runner finished. "At a toll gate. It doesn't need to fight us, Mehran. It showed us the receipt for the city before ours."

The wain's tally-book. The round's account, carried ahead of the wain itself the way a bill of lading travels ahead of the cargo. And its first line — its opening entry, stamped before ever the team reached Ashkarad, already old, already paid — was a city two entries up the route, a city of counting-houses and water-marks that had kept its books to the end:

BRACK — PRUNED, PAID.

Dar folded the petal into his coat, into the inner pocket where Vey's registry page lay folded next to Milla's printout, the archive of everything the city had not yet answered, and felt it go still against the paper like a bird settling. The council would convene on the asylum question by morning; the factions were already drafting their terms; and it no longer mattered, because the answer had been overtaken in transit, the way answers in Ashkarad always were. The city could grant the Sister asylum, or refuse it, or bill it — and the tally-book would go on up the route regardless, page by page, stamp by stamp, an account no vote had ever been able to close.

Below his boots, at the bottom of seven hundred and eleven steps, the door stood open and the Sister stood at the threshold of it, neither in nor out, waiting on the verdict of a city that billed everything it touched — and had not yet found a column for mercy.

Above the lanes, thin as wire, Lena Vance's voice was still running the waterways, following six white gloves down through the dark of the old works, repeating the only warning Ashkarad had left that nobody owned:

"GLOVES IN THE CANALS. THEY CARRY THE BOOK. THEY CARRY THE BOOK."

CHAPTER 61

The Claiming-Hymn

The countermeasure filled six numbered vials, and Vahid Anousheh had brewed every one of them from a dead woman's voice.

Not a metaphor — he was precise about this even when he was drunk, and tonight he was not drunk, because tonight the vials were going out of his cellar and into the world, and the world had a way of auditing whatever you sent it. Nine weeks of nights it had taken, one hand on the needle, the wax hissing under the stylus while he transcribed, spliced, and brewed — brine from the salt vaults for the base, iron for the carrier, and over it all the notation itself, the rests she had left in the tune, concentrated the way you concentrate anything in this city, by refusing to waste it. He had ruined two batches learning that the silence could not be synthesized, only harvested. It had to be cut from the living recording, from her breath, from the places where Shirin Bahar had declined, in her own throat, to sing.

Shirin Bahar's fourteen wax cylinders stood ranked on their brass spindle like a choir at rest, and what he had taken from them was a notation: the shape of the Church's compliance-hymn, transcribed off her recordings where she had once, in the last spring of her life, hummed it to herself the way a locksmith hums over a lock she is learning to pick. Between the formal passages of her notation — the graft-tolerances, the tissue-gradients, the lecture voice she used when she knew the machine was the only audience she would ever get — her voice dropped, and she talked to herself, and in one of those lowered passages, forty years old and pressed into wax, she had sung the claiming-hymn through twice, slowly, contemptuous, marking its cadences the way an auditor marks a fraud.

"It's a key of seven notes," he had told the council, holding up his one hand with the fingers spread. "The nursery poured it into their blood before they could speak, and blood is a filing system — it keeps what it is given. The hymn doesn't compel. It *requests*, in the only language the stock was ever taught to answer. So we don't fight the request." He had closed the spread fingers into a fist. "We pharmacy the silence between the fourth and fifth note. A rest, distilled. Brewed in brine and iron and one reagent this city has never had before — a counter-singing that sings to nothing. Chorus-free medicine. The first honest prescription Ashkarad has filled in forty years."

The council had found the budget in an afternoon, which told him more about their fear than any debate could have.

The order to move the children came down at dusk. After the herald team walked through the city's toll gates like auditors through an unlocked door, the arithmetic of the marked district stopped balancing: the clinic sat under the circled flower on Hesh's master map, the Index was hunting vessel registry page nine through the ruins of every census hall in the city, and eleven stock children and Ilay were sleeping in the one building in Ashkarad whose every wall was a coordinate. The council voted the evacuation before the lamps were lit. Destination: the deep counting-rooms under the Choratorium's lower corridors — the Choirmaster's ground, the one stretch of architecture in the city lined floor to ceiling with dead glass, where the jars that had held forty years of harvested voices stood empty and silent, drinking every resonance that came near them. The quiet way. The one road in Ashkarad where hymn-trained blood could pass without ringing like dropped coin.

The Choirmaster walked rear guard. He had put on weight since the winter, filled out the black coat he had been half-starved inside of, and he carried a fire-axe over his shoulder the way other men carry a shepherd's crook, and he moved down his relic corridors naming things to the children in a voice like warm oil — *this jar sang bass, this one lied, this one only knew the one note* — because he had decided, in whatever country inside himself he kept, that the way you take children past a graveyard of voices is you introduce them. He did not look at Elias more than three times in the whole descent, which Vahid, who counted everything a man's eyes refused to do, noted and filed: the last time those two had shared a building, the Choirmaster had been introducing the boy to a harvest table, and a stranger with two heartbeats had dislocated his wrist over it. Debts between the two of them were being serviced, silently, in kind.

Vahid walked mid-column with the vials strapped against his chest in a padded brass frame his left stump had learned to hold. Elias walked beside him, breathing in counted fours the way the clinic taught, a small boy with straight shoulders and the Church's own grading written into his lungs — PERFECT, the old harvest-files said, as if lungs could be a grade — and around them the dead reliquary corridor did its work. The glass drank their footfalls. The bone walls ate the echo. Even the deep, that vast slow pressure beneath everything, came through here thinned to almost nothing, a tide behind glass.

The strike came at both ends of the corridor at once, which was the whole point of it, and told Vahid that the heralds had read the city's disposition the way he had — correctly.

From below, toward the shaft mouth, a runner came up the Undergleam spur at a dead sprint with the report: torches in the Marrowworks underbelly, six white gloves at the mouth of the Throne shaft, making no move to descend, marking the head of the deep road the way a surveyor marks a boundary — chalk, and patience, and a book opened on a knee. Holding the

top, as Roya would say, was going to be a figure of speech until the wain itself arrived.

And from ahead, at the corridor's far end, the barred door that led up into the ruined graft-theater levels opened without a sound.

Three of the six came through it. They did not rush. Rushing was for bailiffs; these walked with the unhurried economy of clerks who know the deadline is theirs, and the one in front stepped to the center of the corridor, faced the column of children down its whole ringing length, and began to sing.

The claiming-hymn. Vahid had read it off wax and heard it in his dreams for nine weeks, and it was worse in the original than in the transcription — thirty-one bars of patient, reasonable melody, a lullaby's grammar with a lien's intention, the tune the Church had poured into stock blood before speech so that the blood would know how to answer when asked. The nursery compliance-song, activated now in the open air of a ruin by a voice with white gloves on its hands.

Elias answered.

The boy's mouth opened and the hymn came out of him like water finding a grade — no terror in the face of it at first, only the terrible obedience of tissue doing what it was filed to do, his perfect Church-graded lungs producing the melody in a voice doubled and trebled by the dead jars along the walls until the corridor itself seemed to be singing the child. And down the column, one by one, the other children's lips began to move. Ilay clamped her hands over her own mouth and hummed against her palms, hard, off-key, her copper hair shaking — a girl bailing out her own blood with both hands. The younger ones stirred like sleepers being called in a voice they trust. If the verse completed — if the question finished being asked — the whole cohort would answer, every stock child in Ashkarad at once, a census taken from inside their veins, and the herald would not need to touch one of them.

Vahid was already moving. He had planned this the way he planned dissections, on the assumption his hands would shake, and his hands were shaking, and the plan held. The brass frame braced against his chest took the weight of the vial; his teeth pulled the stopper; his one good hand found the vein at Elias's wrist, the counting position, and the boy looked down at him mid-verse with his eyes full of a terror that had finally, blessedly, become his own.

"Permission granted," Vahid said. "Sing something of your own afterward. That's an order from the Chair of Impossible Anatomy, and I fail every student who disobeys me."

The needle went in on the fourth bar, into the silence between the fourth note and the fifth, and the first dose of chorus-free medicine in the history of medicine entered the bloodstream of a boy who had been property since before he was born.

The hymn did not stop the way songs stop, dying bar by bar. It stopped the way debts stop — no cry, no struggle, just the flat, administrative finality of a stamp coming down. Elias's voice quit mid-syllable; his lips kept their shape around the fifth note for one full breath, and then his whole body forgot the tune, a forgetting visible like a wave, passing down the column child by child, lips going still, shoulders dropping, the corridor's dead glass drinking the last of the melody out of the air. The boy breathed. Four counts in, four counts out. He sang to nothing. He sounded like nothing at all, which was, Vahid thought, the most beautiful clinical finding of his entire discredited career.

The herald in the center of the corridor finished its own verse alone, into a silence that had stopped answering it. It stood a moment, listening — taking the reading, Vahid thought, that was the whole expedition: *does the stock still answer* — and then it closed its mouth with the small finality of a ledger being shut, and the three of them withdrew the way they had come, unhurried, correct, backward through the door that opened without a sound. They had not touched a child. They had not needed to. They had come to check an investment's yield, and the yield had just been foreclosed in front of them by a dead woman's distilled contempt, and they wanted their masters to know it, and they wanted Ashkarad to know that they knew it, and both messages arrived intact.

They left the tally-book.

It lay on a jar plinth midway down the corridor, open, squared to the plinth's edges with a clerk's neatness, weighted at the corner with a spanner as if even its abandonment had been filed. Vahid got to it first, because his legs remembered being young. The page it was open to was not the first page. It was Ashkarad's — the city's own account, the round's current entry, written in that vertical, terribly patient hand the tally-book's own earlier pages had already taught him to dread, and beside the entry, in the column where, pages back, Brack's account carried its stamp, the record of Ashkarad's standing:

LIEN PENDING — COLLATERAL: THE LID.

The Choirmaster read it over his shoulder, and for a long moment the corridor's silence held both of them, and forty years of dead glass, and eleven children breathing in counted fours, and one boy humming — tunelessly, raggedly, gloriously off-key — something that was nobody's hymn at all, just a small boy's own noise, scored to nothing, owned by no one, priceless.

"So that's what we are on their books," the Choirmaster said at last, and his voice, for once, was not smooth at all. "Not a city. Collateral."

"Every city is collateral somewhere," Vahid said, and closed the book, and was surprised at how much it weighed, which was not a property of books. "The difference between us and Brack, choirmaster, is that our lien is pending. Pending is the only word in that whole line we have any vote in."

He carried the tally-book up out of the deep in the brass frame, against his chest, where the vials had ridden, and above him the city was waking to the news in its usual way — as a price adjustment.

CHAPTER 62

The Nine Locks

The deep stirred at the hour of the sixth bell, and for the first time in the history of instruments, every pulse-reader in Ashkarad agreed.

They were counting machines, all of them — hand-cranked, brass-souled, built to file a debtor's heartbeat against a ledger's expectation — and at the sixth bell, in the quarry office, in the annexed Choratorium, on the Index's counting-floor by the seawalls, at the customs post on the dry water-stair, and on the clinic's own scarred bench, they printed the same page. Not a rhythm resolved from a patient. A rhythm with no patient near it at all: vast, slow, patient as interest, filling the paper edge to edge. Runners carried the slips in from every quarter through the grey of that morning, and Suri laid them out on the clinic's long table in a row, twelve machines' worth, and the row was one line.

"It's not listening to us anymore," she said. "It's talking. And every machine in the city just got drafted to take dictation."

The implications arrived on their own schedules, the way costs do. The Warden apparatus's whole rebuilt tracking layer — the new readers, the audited beats, the page-nine registry — was now a choir of loudspeakers pointed the wrong way; the machines could no more file the city's debtors than a bell can file the wind. Every census in Ashkarad was back to chalk and fingers, which meant, as Suri said, that for the first time in forty years the only honest count in the city was going to be the ones people did out loud, in front of each other, with their own pulse in their own throat. And beneath all of it, the rhythm on the slips was not the arrhythmia of something waking in pain. It was the cadence of something waking *deliberately*. Something that had decided to be felt.

Upstairs, Ilay heard the same thing and said it smaller. She stood at the wall-map with her chalk, where for weeks two circles had been plotted under the city — the great slow spiral of the deep, and beneath it, inside it, the small circle that kept time with Dar — and now she drew the two circles touching, then overlapping, then one circle, and wrote beneath it, in her careful child's hand: *together now.*

The council went down. All the way down — seven hundred and eleven steps, past the cold cathedral of the dead First Vessel, into the salt vaults where the walls rang like struck glass — to the antechamber before the open door. Dar walked at the front with Isra; behind him came Suri counting steps for the whole column, Vahid with spectacles and satchel, Roya with Ilay at

her knee, the Choirmaster with his fire-axe carried like a crook, and Mother Gavel's overseer with a slate and a mandate, and at the very rear an Index observer who had declined, in writing, to descend below the salt line, and had filed instead a form requesting the minutes.

The door stood open, as it had stood open for six days. The warm air came up out of it, loam-scented, garden-scented, and nothing had ever come through. The Sister stood at the threshold on her side of the glass, a vast slow presence the eye could not fix and the ribs could not ignore, and she had been standing there, so far as any instrument could tell, since the night her petal rose the shaft asking for a word the city's factions were still drafting.

Isra knelt at the door with her slate. Ilay knelt beside her. And the Sister's testimony came up out of the deep in the two channels she had: the girl who heard, and the woman who wrote.

The geometry completed itself the way a column completes, line by line, each figure falling into the one above it.

The vaults beneath the door — the deep salt galleries the city had never mapped because they did not want mapping — held nine lock-seals. The Sister had lived against them for a century; she had counted them by touch the way a prisoner counts bars, and she counted them now for the living: nine great rings of salt and bone, older than the Church above them, older than the burning behind her, arranged in the dark like the chambers of a heart that had never beaten. The city above them was not built on a secret. It was built on a lid. Ashkarad itself — the storm-walls, the tithe-warehouses, the whole vertical ledger of the place — was weight, ballast, a paperweight of masonry set on a door to keep it shut, and the locking-collar of the Choratorium and the forty years of harvested lullaby had been maintenance, service, the upkeep of a seal.

She gave them the count, too, because she gave them everything she had — the long testimony she had kept for a hundred years with no one to file it to. The number of the deep thing's heartbeats since the burning, kept in her head without paper, one of the two longest columns in the world; and the note, still terrible, that a week ago, for the first time, it had skipped one. A missed beat, down there in the dark, in a rhythm that had not missed since before the Church had a name. Either it was dying, she wrote — and Isra's chalk hesitated over the word — or it was waking. She did not know which entry to post it under.

And the seals took keys. Nine seeds, sown a century ago by the same hand, one key to a seal: nine lilies sent down into the world to grow, and bloom, and be harvested — and each harvest, each pruning, each city emptied and stamped was a key turning. Lowmark's bride, humming in her flooded harbor. The Vigil, silent on its walking legs, quarantining its seed in lead and whisper. Gullet's Cow, moaning at shift-change, the third seed's Vessel caged in the

engine's heart. Sarn, Weep, Ossuar, Hallowfen — names from a page, weights on a schedule, each one a seal turning over in the dark like a sleeper disturbed. Brack, first of the round, PRUNED, PAID. Eight keys already turning in eight far cities, one by one, on a schedule the tally-book carried in its chained and salt-scuffed pages. When the ninth turned — and the ninth key was not in a far city at all, but asleep in a surgeon's chest two paces from the door — the last seal would open, and the lid's term would end, and whatever the weight of Ashkarad had been holding down would be free to stand up.

The silence after the testimony had a texture, like felt. Then Mother Gavel's overseer spoke for her principal from the back of the antechamber, brass-voiced even without the tube: "The pit asks the obvious. What's the rate? What's the city get for holding the lid? Because somebody's been paying forty years of maintenance on this thing, and I don't see the receipts."

"The receipts are the city," the Choirmaster said, quietly, to no one, and Dar heard in it the man's own old question — what is the city for — finally answered, and heard how it landed on him like a diagnosis.

Then the Sister made her offer, and the offer was the worst arithmetic of the day.

She knew her mother's protocols the way a hostage knows a house. The Eighth Vein — the door past Mind, the one no honest text described — was not climbed; it was opened, and it could only be opened from both sides at once. Two climbers, or none: a door shared between two, each holding the other's silence against the far side. Tally of Gullet had spent a hundred years knowing it; the Sister had spent a century being the far side of it. And the Gardener, who had sown the keys and scheduled the round and sent the wain, was ready — eager, patient, terms prepared — to climb it herself, together, with the ninth. With Ashkarad. With whoever, in whatever council chamber or quarry pit or ledger line, said yes. Her hand on one side of the door, the city's hand on the other. Consent as the toll. The gentlest possible foreclosure. And the Sister, who had watched her mother's courtesy work for a century on eight other cities, appended the only annotation her testimony had ever carried, the closest her slate would come to an opinion: SHE HAS NEVER ONCE SAID NO TO A DOOR. SHE ONLY SAYS YES TO IT FIRST.

The factions' answers came the way weather comes. The Index observer above, consulted by runner, filed a written opinion recommending acceptance on the grounds that a signed agreement with a superior power was the only stability on offer. The Gavel's overseer asked, in one word, what the collateral status of a city that said no would be. The Open Counts, splintering even now over whose census was true, split three ways on the wording of the question itself.

Dar stopped listening to them.

He looked at the open door, and at the threshold where a century of patience stood waiting on a verdict, and he did the only arithmetic that had never once been done in this city, which was triage without a price. The Gardener's hand on one side of the door meant the Gardener's terms on both sides of it, forever; a door opened with her was a door she owned half of, and doors, in Ashkarad, were the only things worth owning. The Eighth Vein wanted two climbers. The city could not be one of them — the city was a lid, and lids hold doors shut. But Isra knelt at the threshold with the Sister's petal open at her collarbone, half-rooted, silence-trained, a diver who had already given her voice to the deep and gotten back a self; a woman who owed the Gardener nothing, feared her openly, and was known — known personally, chamber by chamber — to the one intelligence on the far side. The door between Dar and Isra already existed. It had been building itself since a salt-burned stranger walked out of the fog with a slate that said I BRING HER HOME.

"The climb happens," he said, and the antechamber's ringing salt carried his voice to every ear in it, "and it happens without her." He looked at Isra. "You and me. That's my vote. Nobody's buying the other side of this door."

Behind him, flat as a ruled line, Suri said, "Then I count the door. Every session, both pulses, one column. Nobody climbs anything in this city without a counter," and that was seconded by nobody and needed seconding by nobody, and was, therefore, law.

Isra looked at him for a long moment. Then she took the slate and wrote — no effort in it at all, the fastest he had ever seen her chalk move — I CLIMB. And at her collarbone the black petal turned on its stem, slow as a minute hand, until its point faced him: the Sister's own signature on the arrangement.

Above them, on Dar's chest, under his coat, the Lily went utterly still — the stillness he had learned to read as her version of leaning — and then she pressed once, briefly, against the wall of him nearest to Isra, and was quiet.

The column filed up the seven hundred and eleven steps into the grey morning, and the factions took their answers with them to be misfiled, and Isra caught Dar's sleeve at the first landing, out of the others' sight, and wrote on her slate slowly, with effort, two lines she did not show to anyone else. He read them alone, by the light of the shaft, and then folded the memory of them into the same inner pocket where the black petal rode against Vey's page:

She says: bring the ninth's music. Bring nothing you cannot lose.

CHAPTER 63

Shirin's Marginalia

Vahid Anousheh's life's work ended at Bone, and he had known it for forty years, and he had only now, with the chalk dust still on his fingers from a ladder he had drawn a hundred times, admitted it in public.

He stood in the clinic cellar under the Nine Veins as he had chalked it — Flesh, Marrow, Blood, Breath, Nerve, Bone, a rung for a year of his disrepute, each one documented in his own discredited hand — and above Bone the ladder was bare wall. Mind he never chalked at all, because Mind had never been climbed by the book. Mind had opened in a boy's head during the Blacktide the way a tooth opens a jaw: as a wound, with the price paid in the coinage of a mother's face. There was no marginalia for that rung. There was a scar.

"Past the sixth rung," he told the room — Dar, Suri, Roya, Isra seated by the stove with her slate on her knee, and the climbing-rig's manifest spread open on the bench like a diagnosis — "I am a man reading someone else's mail. I taught this boy the first six rungs because a better anatomist than me taught me the first six rungs, and she is forty years dead, and everything above Bone lives in fourteen cylinders of wax, and I have been avoiding them because listening to her voice was a debt I did not know how to service sober."

He put on his spectacles — round, salt-scoured, mended with wire — and took them off again, which was as close as he came to a rhetorical flourish.

"So tonight we service it."

The listening took the whole night and most of the gin, and it was not a matter of putting a needle to wax. The fourteen cylinders held the formal archive — the lectures, the graft-tolerances, the tissue-gradients dictated in the lecture voice she used when she knew the machine was her only student — and between the formal passages her voice dropped, and she talked to herself while she worked, the way working anatomists do, and it was in the talk, in the margins of her own recordings, that Shirin Bahar had hidden what she had never dared publish: her thinking on the upper Veins.

They found the theory on the third cylinder, in the gap between a protocol on sinus-repair and a note about the cost of lamp oil.

"*Marginalia,*" she said, in the young-dark voice of a woman talking to her own hands. "*For nobody. For me. Everyone asks me — the funding men, the deacons, Vahid when he is drunk and honest — how high does the ladder go. They all draw it as a height. Flesh to Throne,

a climb, a spire. They are wrong, and the wrongness is the whole of the medicine. The first six veins are depth — going down into your own body, cellar by cellar, and every one of them makes you more of what you already were. Mind is not depth. Mind is up — out of the cellar into the architecture, the whole house of you at once. And the eighth —*"

The needle hissed through a pause that Vahid, who had edited recordings in his youth, identified professionally as a woman deciding whether to say a thing and deciding yes.

"*The eighth goes sideways. Soul is not a depth in you and not a height of you. It is a shared organ. It is grown between two people, the way a bridge is grown between two banks, and it grafts along the line where two silences fit. You cannot grow it in one body for the same reason you cannot shake hands with yourself. Every honest text that says otherwise was written by someone who tried it alone, and every such text stops mid-sentence, because the writers stop mid-everything. The door is shared between two or it is not a door. That is the whole of it. That is what I would have told the funding men if any of them had ever asked what a soul was for.*"

Vahid made the room sit with it for a while. Isra wrote one line on her slate and turned it to the company: THE SISTER IS THE OTHER BANK. Roya, mask motionless, said: "She has been holding her side of a bridge for a century with nobody on it. That's not an entity down there. That's a co-signer."

The climbing-rig went up over the salt-glass door over the next six days, and it was the strangest construction job in the city's history, because the site was seven hundred and eleven steps down and the client was a door that must not be touched.

The haul alone was a civic effort: sixty-two loads, ferried down the shaft on a winch-brake Suri commandeered from the Gavel's own dock crews and paid for, in Gavel's hearing, at the Gavel's own posted rates, because if the city was going to build an instrument at the bottom of its deepest hole it might as well do it through the only logistics chain that functioned. Milla Ferun kept the load-manifests — the woman who had spent a career stamping other people's tithes now checked off salt blocks and brass rod in a fair clerk's hand, and reported, only half-joking, that the manifests were the first honest paperwork she had ever processed. Every load was counted going down; every block was counted again going into the wall; Vahid signed off each stage with the ceremony of a man who had been stripped of the right to sign anything and had decided, years ago, to keep doing it anyway.

They built in the antechamber, against the ringing salt, a body's width off the glass. A floor of fitted salt blocks to level the sloping vault floor. A canvas wall to hold the warmth in and the vast draught of the door out — canvas, not timber, because timber sang, faintly, at resonances

nobody could hear but everybody's blood could read. A frame of brass. And in the middle of the cold room, facing each other across four feet of salt floor, two chairs — plain, webbed, built in the clinic's workshop by a one-handed professor and a young apprentice with perfect lungs, and Vahid personally oiled every joint so that neither chair would creak when it needed to hold two people perfectly still.

One pulse-reader stood on a brass tripod at the head of the two chairs: the old machine, the one Suri had stolen for a debt-ridden intern to practice on a lifetime ago, the first machine in Ashkarad ever to print RHYTHM UNRESOLVED and mean it. Vahid had asked for it by name. Its crank was oiled; its stylus was new; its paper tray was stocked with three hundred slips. Whatever happened in the room between the two climbers, the machine would write it down, and the machine had never yet lied to this particular chest.

On the canvas wall, in chalk, in his own hand, Vahid wrote the room's law, the way he had once boxed a law on the wall of the cold cellar upstairs: NO SONGS. Under it, smaller: NOT EVEN HUMMING. The reason went unwritten because everyone who would use the room already knew it: songs were the heralds' grammar, the hymns' grammar, the deep's grammar; a song was a key that fit every lock the Gardener had ever grown. The climbing room would be the quietest volume in Ashkarad. The climbers would enter it the way divers enter water: with their mouths shut and their blood loud.

The briefings were Vahid's, and he did not enjoy them, because a good briefing is a forecast and he was about to send two people past the edge of his knowledge. He taught them the entry — Mind first, the architecture of the self as the staging ground; the between-space as Shirin had modeled it, not a place in either mind but the seam where two prepared minds met. He taught them the discipline: pay deliberately, never pay in panic; sit back-to-back in the physical chairs until the shared room held a floor, because the body's habit is the mind's handrail. He taught them the failure modes — the pull to look at each other's payments before the walls were up; the itch to take back what had been given; and the one he would not say aloud, which went into the manifest instead, in the flat register he reserved for things he could not bear to say standing up: *the room does not care which of you it keeps.* He taught them the rule of payment: the room between them would hold what was given, but what was given was *given*, and Shirin's marginalia on that point, found on the ninth cylinder, were copied out flat and posted on the canvas beside the room's law: *WHAT IS POOLED IS POOLED FOREVER. THE ORGAN GROWS FROM WHAT TWO PEOPLE NO LONGER OWN ALONE. IF YOU ARE NOT PREPARED TO HEAR A STRANGER WALKING IN YOUR HOUSE, DO NOT BUILD A HOUSE WITH THEM.*

"Choose the payments like a surgeon chooses flaps," he said. "Nothing hidden, nothing vital, nothing you will lie about later. The organ grows from what you no longer own alone — so own nothing in that room that you cannot stand to have witnessed." He looked at Dar, and then, because it was owed, at Isra. "And the risks past that are posted past my signature, which means I cannot price them, which means I will not pretend to. The honest text ends where my partner's voice ends. I have sent boys into wounds I understood. I am sending two people into an organ I have only heard described. Bring each other back. That is the entire discipline. Everything else is anatomy."

The last cylinder he played alone, at the end, after the others had gone up to their beds. It was the fourteenth — the final recording, the one the archive's own index had listed as *damaged, truncated* — and he had been saving it the way a man saves the last of anything. It was late dictation; her voice was older here, rougher, rapid, the voice of the last spring, and it was not a lecture and not a marginalia. It was a message, left the way people leave messages in wars: short, addressed to no one, addressed to whoever. She said — the wax crackled, and his one hand lay flat on the bench as if the bench were a pulse —

"*If anyone ever climbs it — if anyone actually builds the room — the door will show them the far side, and they will ask me, if they can still ask anything, what it was. I stripped my own chair rather than say it to the deacons, and I will say it once here, to the wax, where the deacons keep no votes. The far side is not a place. And when the organ takes the whole weight of you both — and then you will hear the sound—*"

The recording stopped.

Not wore out. Not skipped. Stopped — a clean cut in the wax, the groove ending mid-word the way a page ends mid-sentence, and Vahid sat in the lamplight with the stylus ticking the run-out and did not move for a long time.

Because he had heard that truncation before. They all had. The Lily's oldest dream — the loop Roya had once wired a song-lobe to map, the dream of the salt garden and the nine lantern-heartbeats and the woman with bone-white hands — ended, mid-phrase, at the same word. *The sound.* A century between the two recordings. A woman's wax and a seed's sleep. The same knife.

Vahid took off his spectacles and polished them on his sleeve, thoroughly, twice, and said to the empty cellar, in the voice he used for lectures no student would ever pass:

"Someone has edited the woman I loved and the thing in that boy's chest with the same blade. Which means the cut is upstream of both of them. Which means, my dear Shirin, that you got close enough to frighten the *publisher*."

He racked the cylinder with the others. Fourteen wax souls on a brass spindle, and the fifteenth voice they needed was a door, and the door was open, and it was waiting on two chairs and a machine that had never yet lied.

CHAPTER 64

The Shared Room

The first session was scheduled for the hour between the third bell and the fourth, because Suri wanted the city's quietest watch and the clinic's emptiest corridors, and because Milla Ferun, cranking the pulse-reader, had once processed night-tithes for six years and swore the machines read truer between bells.

Dar sat in the left chair. Isra took the right. The room was cold the way the deep was cold, and the canvas walls held out the draught of the open door so that the only air moving was their own. Vahid stood at the machine with his one hand on Milla's shoulder like a helmsman's. Suri sat at the line she had drawn on the salt floor with chalk — the door-line, the column she had promised — with her ledger open and her pencil bare, counting. Roya and Ilay held the shaft top. Nobody sang. Nobody hummed. The room's law hung on the canvas in Vahid's chalk, and the two climbers obeyed it before they ever sat: NO SONGS. NOT EVEN HUMMING.

The entry was Mind first, as briefed. Dar went down his own architecture with the ease of long discipline — past the swept rooms with their nail-holes, past the corridor where his mother's face had hung and now hung only the fact of her, past the furnished door he had never built, which was dark tonight, and which he passed without breaking stride, the way you pass a tenant's door when the tenant is out. At the deepest hall of himself, where the walls ran out, he found the seam.

It was not a door. Shirin's model had been exact even from the grave: a seam, a place where the architecture of one mind abutted the architecture of another, a hairline of pale light in the mortar of him, and on the far side of it, felt rather than seen, the pressure of a second silence — trained, salt-burned, waiting — holding still against his the way two hands hold still before they clasp.

He put his weight on the seam and Isra put hers, and the seam opened the way ice opens, along the line, without breaking, and they built the room.

Not found. Not furnished by anything but themselves. Built — load by load, at a site neither could own. And the founding rule of the place announced itself the moment the first payment was made, because that was what the room was for: you paid to build, and nothing you paid was spent.

Dar went first, by agreement, and chose as briefed — and the choosing had taken him two days, which he told no one, because the choosing was the payment's real cost. He had

inventoried his whole house for something true, unharmful, and load-bearing. The clinic's first morning was spent; the registry held that receipt. The first patient he ever lost was spent; the name had gone first, and he would not sell a scar. Suri's stitching belonged to her before it belonged to him. His mother's lullaby was not his and never had been. In the end the ledger offered him exactly one asset that was honest, his, and strong enough to build with — and it was the only truly valuable thing he had ever done: the refusal.

He walked his memory-architecture to the graft-theater — the room the Blacktide lived in, vaulted, wax-lit, heavy with the smell of hot salt and candle-fat — and stood in it a last time as its sole owner. The offered garden was where it had always been, spread under the altar dark like a banquet: rows of sleepers planted like bulbs, the tower with its windows of heartbeats, the humming woman with her bone-white hands, the whole salt garden held out to him as invitation, not threat. And there, at the center of it, the refusal — his own word, the one he had said while the Blacktide poured itself through the Choratorium and the Lily had yielded in his chest, saying *Then carry me a little further* — the refusal stood in his memory the way a load-bearing wall stands in a house.

He took it out. Not spent — there was no needle in it, no toll, no machine-fault, none of the Mind Vein's terrible billing. He lifted the whole of it, the theater and the garden and the word, and he laid it down in the middle of the empty between-space, deliberately, the way you set a keystone, and the room built itself around the payment. The ash of the memory became plaster. The candle-fat smell became the room's air. The refusal set and cured and became the wall that held the roof: a room founded on the word no, in a city that had never once refused anything it could afford.

Isra's payment was the drowned flats.

She paid it the way she did everything, without narration, and Dar was inside it before he understood he had been given the door: a harbor with the sea gone out of it and still going, miles of grey seabed under a sky the color of ledger-paper, and a child walking it barefoot where ships had been — her, small, soundless, already the girl who did not speak — past the drowned bells standing to their rope-walks in the shallows, past tide-tables chalked on a door that would never see a tide again, learning the flats the way other children learned streets: by pressure, by line, by what the water left and what it took. The memory poured itself into the room's floor and set, and the floor of the between-space was, from that moment, a seabed at dead low tide, firm and ridged and smelling of iodine, and neither of them could stand in the room without standing on the other's childhood.

They surfaced before the fourth bell, back in their bodies, back in the cold, with the machine-lanterns burning exactly as they had been left. The cost, when Suri audited it, was

almost insolent in its smallness: a headache, a taste of tallow at the back of the throat, and the permanent fact. Isra flexed her hands and looked at Dar across the four feet of salt floor with the expression of a woman re-pricing a currency. The room's payments had not left either of them. They had multiplied them.

That was the discovery, and it settled over them both like a bill: held in common. The registry's houses had taught Dar that even memories could be repossessed. This room inverted the whole science. Nothing here was spent, and nothing here was owned. What was given was held — jointly, permanently, visible to both — and there was no instrument in the world that could repossess it, and no price at which it could be sold, and the two of them stood in it like the first shareholders of a bank whose only asset was trust.

Suri, at her door-line, watching two pulse-lines slow into synchrony on Milla's slips, wrote the session's entry in one line: *ROOM HOLDS. FLOOR: HERS. WALLS: HIS. OWNERSHIP: NONE. FILED UNDER: UNPRECEDENTED.*

The machine printed its usual fault, and for once in its brass life the fault was a reading: RHYTHM UNRESOLVED — two heartbeats approaching a unison it had no column for. Vahid looked at the slip for a long moment, and then took off his spectacles, and cleaned them, and put them back on, and said nothing at all, which from him was a medal.

* * *

The second night, Isra went down the shaft ahead of Dar, because the room was hers too now and she had stopped waiting to be invited into her own house. The rig's watchers were at their posts when she reached the bottom — Vahid at the machine, Milla's hand resting on the crank, Suri at her chalked line with the ledger open — and the cold room took their stillness the way it took everything, quietly, into the inventory.

She found it as they had left it — the seabed floor, the plastered ash walls, the two chairs facing — and she walked it slowly first, a diver's circuit, checking her own water for hairline fractures, because a shared room that had held once could still leak, and a leak in the between-space would not drip; it would simply become true somewhere else. Everything was where the first session had set it. The room was sound. And the first wrongness, when she found it, was small and total: the lamp.

They had left the lamp on the table, unlit, wick trimmed, because the room had no need of light. The lamp was lit. It burned low and gold and perfectly still, in a room where no air moved, and the flame did not gutter when she crossed the floor, and Isra stood very still inside her own body and did what a diver does at a changed water-line, which is to stop swimming and listen.

Then she felt it. Not through her ears. Through the petal at her collarbone, which warmed like a coal going soft, and through the soles of her feet on the seabed floor, and through the shallow water of her blood: a third heartbeat, below the room. Not in the walls — under them. Far under, patient, immense, familiar as her own pulse because it had been keeping time with her since the fog at the tide-gates: the Sister, listening from beneath, an ear pressed to the underside of the floor the way a child presses an ear to a wall to hear the room where the family is.

She did not speak. The Sister did not speak — Isra felt the absence of it like a hand held back from a door, a century's discipline of not being the thing that enters — but the room began, gently, without hands, to move.

The chairs slid first. They left their facing line and went to the long wall, together, evenly, like a couple taking a bench, and became a bench — the webbing slackening and widening, the brass breathing, two chairs resolving into one seat with room on it for three. The table turned itself a quarter-circle, out of the room's center to the wall beside the bench, and its four legs settled into the plaster and put out, briefly, at the joints, a suggestion of root. The lamp migrated to the table's new position without appearing to travel. And the angles of the room changed — subtly, rightly, the way furniture is right in a house you have lived in: the wall opposite the bench standing down an inch, the floor ridging itself in long low rows, planting rows, a frame and a bench and a light set at the height and spacing of tended ground.

Neither of them remembered this garden. That was the grief in it. Everything the Sister had ever shown anyone had been the burned garden, the loop of ash, the First Vessel's world on fire — and this was not that. This was older than the burning and cleaner than the ash: a garden's furniture, arranged from memory, in a garden neither climber had ever seen, set out the way it had stood before the fire, before the lid, before the dark — a bench for resting, a frame for planting, a lamp for the evening shift. Someone had lived here. Someone had tended here. The room did not know whose it was, because the room's builders did not; only the listener under the floor knew, and she was not saying, and the not-saying was the loudest thing Isra had ever heard in a place with no sound in it.

Isra took her slate from her belt. It was the one object she owned that the room kept as itself — chalk and slate and the habit of a woman whose voice was given away — and she set it face-up on the planting-frame table, where the Sister's rearrangement had made a place for it, and she did not write on it. The writing was not the point. The placing was: a diver's sign, left at the changed water-line, in the old grammar of her trade. *Heard you. Not afraid. Will not startle.*

Under the floor, the third heartbeat slowed — one beat, two — and settled into time with the lamp's stillness, and stayed, listening, warm through the seabed floor like sunken sun. And when Isra turned her head, very slowly, toward the seam in the wall where Dar would arrive, she found the room had already made his chair — the third place at the table, the third seat of the bench, the lamp turned a degree to light it.

Isra sat down on the bench her chair had become, in a garden neither of them remembered, and waited, without songs, without speaking, for her partner to come down the shaft and find what the room had become while he made his way down to it: not theirs. Common property. All three of them.

CHAPTER 65

The Gavel Ration

The sea had been gone six weeks, and Ashkarad learned what it had never once priced: that the ocean had been doing the city's water-work for free.

The fog-sea had not come back with the tide. It stood out past the seawalls where the horizon should have been, a grey absence with a curve to it, and the dry harbor breathed at night like a thing with a collapsed lung, and every salt-storm since had come inland off mud instead of water, tasting of iodine and old debt. The wells were the only water left in the world now, and they were dying at a measurable rate.

Mother Gavel seized the pump-works on a Tuesday, in the manner of all her acquisitions, which was to say the gear-houses changed their flags between one shift and the next and the crews who came off shift found their wages already renegotiated. The canal-works pumps, the deep cistern-wells, the chain of reservoirs under the Saltstairs — all of it had been straining against a sea that was not there, hauling from drop-wells the city had never needed to drill, and the Gavel's ledgermen had done the only honest arithmetic left in Ashkarad and posted it over the pump-houses in letters a hand high: WATER FOR WORK.

The ration worked like this. A day's pumping, hauling, bracing, or well-cutting bought a household's measure — a counted bucket-line at dusk, stamped chits, no exceptions, no credit. The Gavel's brass speaking-tube read the schedule from the pit-head at each dawn: which districts pumped, which cisterns were open, what the day's water-price was in hours. It was extortion with a flow-rate. It was also — and Suri hated this the way you hate a rival's good bookkeeping — correct. She went out to see it run on the fourth morning, because numbers you have not stood in front of are rumors, and she stood in a queue of sixty households at the Tanner's Walk cistern while a Gavel lance-corporal counted buckets with a chalked tally-board and two enforcers held the line with their arms folded and their faces empty, and the queue was silent, and orderly, and fed. Nobody pushed. Nobody begged. The ration had done to the crisis what the crisis had done to the sea: taken the uncertainty out of it. A queue you can count is a queue that holds, and the Gavel had understood, before any hall of government in this city, that fear is mostly an accounting problem.

Suri audited the ration's third week out of professional grief and found the numbers cruel and true. The well-yields balanced against the bucket-lines to the bucket. There was no skim. There was not, in the whole apparatus, a single unpriced kindness to exploit, and she wrote in her ledger, under GAVEL — PUMP-WORKS: ADMIRED (PROFESSIONALLY) /

DESPISED (PERSONALLY), the note that the most dangerous government was the one whose arithmetic you could not fault.

The Index's demand came the same week, by writ, under seal, in Auditor Seft's rebuilt bureaucratic hand.

The Index wanted the stock children. Conscripted sonar, the writ called them — a listening-post of living instruments, *for the city's safety, for the duration of the emergency* — because the hymn-training the Church had poured into their blood was, the writ observed with its horrible frankness, the only sensor array in Ashkarad that could hear the heralds coming and the deep beneath them, and it was wasteful, in an emergency, to leave an asset sleeping in a clinic. The writ requested transfer of eleven vessels and one Ilay, GRADE: PERFECT, to the Index counting-floor by the seawalls, where pulse-reader cradles were already being built to spec around listening-children's beds. Page nine again. The Index had been hunting that page since before the fire, and the fire had taught it that when paper failed, you went to the flesh.

Dar's answer to the writ was two words and a signature, and the two words were *They're patients*, and the signature was the clinic's, and Suri watched Seft's clerk receive the refusal, stamp it RECEIVED, NOT COMPLIED, and file it — and understood that in the Index's grammar that was not a defeat but a docket. The writ's runner, a boy with the Index's blank rectangle tarred on his sleeve, asked, in the flat courtesy of his masters, whether the clinic would care to file an objection in triplicate, and Suri told him the clinic filed everything in one copy and kept the original, and the boy wrote that down too.

The Open Counts splintered the same fortnight, publicly, over the only question three kinds of clerk can splinter over: whose count was true. The original Open Counts — the reform census that had counted the city openly after the halls burned — broke into three named factions over the deep rhythm the pulse-readers had printed. One faction held the printouts were contamination and every count since the sixth bell was void. One held the rhythm was a new variable that had to be counted *into* every census going forward, door by door, breath by breath. The third simply walked out of the counting-house with the master tallies under their coats and became, by nightfall, a rumor, and by the following week a bounty, and the city's last public arithmetic thus acquired a black market. Three censuses now circulated where one had stood, each sworn, each sealed, each true from inside its own premises, and the only question the street could not answer was the one that mattered: when a count was a weapon, who got to hold the pen. The lane outside the registry saw two counts' worth of clerks fighting over a tally-board like gulls over a dropped fish, and the city watched its last neutral instrument — arithmetic itself — descend into the same factional ledger-war as

everything else, and the clinic, watching the water rise around it, did what islands do.

It declared itself neutral ground, and posted the terms on the door.

The sanctuary census was Suri's construction, and she built it the way she built everything, out of the materials the city had left her. Every soul under the clinic's roof and in its yard-cots — patients, couriers, the stock children home from the deep counting-rooms, Isra, Vell, the staff — counted once, openly, by name, in a census posted where anyone could read it. Milla Ferun as registrar: the woman who had spent years stamping other people's debts into other people's ledgers now kept the count of the living, in her fair clerk's hand, and signed each page like a woman signing a confession she was proud of. Vell of Brack chalked the second copy on the yard wall, because in Brack you never trusted a count to one surface, and a clerk who had survived the end of her city by chalking herself into a death column had opinions about redundancy that Suri honored like scripture.

Counted once. Counted openly. Counted by name. The census was a shield, and both factions' seals went on it — the Gavel's hammer and the Index's blank rectangle — because the terms of neutrality required the books to be open, and Suri, who had spent her life in closed books, was betting her entire remaining stock that open books, in Ashkarad, could be armor.

The dispersal was Dar's addition, and it was the part the census-takers argued about. The clinic's sensitive holdings — Vey's registry page, the tally-book from the reliquary corridor, Milla's printout, the evidence of everything they had survived — could not sit in one building that both factions now had the right to audit. So the archive was distributed, deliberately, into the keeping of the people whose business it had always been. Dar gave Milla her printout back at the registrar's desk, in front of witnesses, and the room went quiet, because everyone in it knew what the slip was and what it had cost her. "Evidence keeps best with its witness," Dar said, in his triage voice, folding the slip into her coat lining where it had lived for years before any of them. "You're the registrar. It's provenance." Milla took it with both hands and did not say anything, and the salt under her fingernails, Suri noticed, had never quite gone away.

The audit was the price, and the price came due on the sixth day.

Two of the Gavel's ledgermen arrived with the morning bucket-line, polite as invoices, and Suri sat them at the long table and gave them the census and the water-accounts and the treatment-tallies, everything, because the terms were the terms. They were good. She marked them good the way she marked everything — the senior one turned a page with a wetted thumb and never lost his place, and his junior recited sums back unasked — and she was beginning to believe the week might total clean when the senior ledgerman opened the last item in his audit-bag, and the room's arithmetic changed.

It was a book. A Chorus vital-debt ledger — one of the master volumes, salt-stained, fire-licked at one corner, salvage-stamped on the spine in the Gavel's receiving mark. The wrecking crews clearing the burned census halls had sold the surviving Chorus paper off by weight, Suri knew; the Gavel had bought a lot of it for pennies, the way the Gavel bought everything the city stopped guarding. The ledgerman laid it on the table and said, without ceremony, "Exemption audit. Property schedule. We check the sanctuary against the debt-books, miss. Nobody neutral by accident."

He turned the pages with his wetted thumb. Suri sat still and counted her own pulse, because there was nothing else in the room to do with her hands, and the pages came around like weather, and the ledgerman stopped, and read, and did not look up.

"Kaveh, Suri," he read aloud, flat as his master's tube. "Carbon-scaled, registry number attached. Debt resold — three times. Original holder, the Chorus. Final assignment of record..." He turned the book a quarter-circle so she could see, and there it was in the assignment column, in forty-year-old ink, the whole history of a skin she had sold at nineteen arriving like a tide at the top of a wall: the chain of resales running down the margin, transfer, transfer, transfer — and the last holder of record, stamped in the receiving mark she had watched go up over the pump-houses three weeks ago.

The Gavel.

For a moment the room's accounting held its breath. The junior ledgerman looked at the page, then at her arm — at the carbon scales sheathing it, the receipt she had carried since nineteen, ruined and regrown and always, always somebody's paperwork — and looked away again with the practiced blankness of a man who has learned where the eyes go when the books stop being abstract.

The ledgerman drew a chalk circle around her name on his audit-slate, unhurried, correct, and said, "Your exemption's fine, miss. Your person, though — that's an asset on our schedule. We'll want the paperwork reconciled." And he passed her the book, page open, the way you pass a man his own death notice, because in Ashkarad even mercy was documented.

Mother Gavel came to the door herself at dusk — the pit must have been told by runner within the hour — and stood in it a moment with her scarred roadmap of a face and her eyes flat as ledger pages, and looked at Suri sitting at her own long table with a Chorus debt-book open in front of her and her whole ledger-discipline arriving, beat by beat, at the sum.

"Sanctuary keeps names in," Mother Gavel said, through the brass tube, conversational, almost kind. "It's never once kept a debt out. I'll send terms."

Suri looked down at the page, at the registry number at the top of it — the number the Church had filed on her skin before she was old enough to read — and then at her own ledger, her true one, the one the system had never been able to repossess. She opened a new column, and her pencil did not shake, because the counting was hers, and it was the last thing on earth that was.

She ruled the line and wrote the heading, and the heading sat on the fresh page like a claim being staked, like a lien filing itself:

THE GAVEL — OWNS — ME?

CHAPTER 66

Paid in Full

The Gavel served its claim at the sixth bell, and Suri counted the service in, because it was hers to count: two ledgermen on the clinic step with the rain still coming off their coats, one courier-detail waiting in the lane with a covered barrow — for her, she understood; the barrow was the tell — and between the ledgermen, held out flat on both palms like a relic, a Chorus debt-book with its spine broken open to the page they had bought the right to show her.

KAVEH, SURI. Graft-number, inked in the old maroon. RESOLD — THREE TIMES. Interest compounded every salt-moon since she was nineteen. And in the margin, in a hand she recognized from the ration lines, the purchase note: acquired at derelict auction, 110 coin. The Gavel had bought her out of the Church's burning for pennies, the way you buy a drowned house, and had waited the polite interval of an audit before coming to collect the property.

"The debt is Gavel property now," the senior ledgerman said. He had the flat courtesy of a man reading terms he had not written. "The debtor is therefore an asset. Mother Gavel elects to take the asset in person. The boss remembers your hands. Counting hands are rare."

"Present yourself at the pump-works by the eighth bell," said the younger one, "or be collected."

Suri did not answer at once. She read the page the way she read everything, top to bottom, twice, and her eyes stopped one line above the total. "Your interest table is wrong," she said. "You've billed me nine thousand, nine hundred and forty. The resales compound from the third resale date, not the first, and the third resale paid down principal — it's on your own page, the entry in faded ink. The true retirement figure is ten thousand, six hundred and eight."

The senior ledgerman looked at the page, and then at her, with the first honest expression she had seen on him. "You're correcting your own bill upward."

"I don't retire on a rounding error," Suri said. "A debt that dies wrong doesn't die. It haunts. Re-price it."

They re-priced it. It took them twenty minutes, and she stood over them while they did it, and the covered barrow waited in the lane like punctuation.

* * *

Dar heard the terms in the ward with his sleeves still rolled from a delivery, and Suri watched him do the arithmetic she had already finished. There was exactly one thing in

Ashkarad the system respected, and it was payment, and the clinic had no coin. What the clinic had was a slip of thermal-grey paper, five years old, flagged RHYTHM UNRESOLVED, the only surviving print of the two-rhythm pulse that had started everything — and an Index bounty on that slip rising since the fires.

"You could refuse," Suri said. "Sanctuary covers me. The terms say no names leave the building."

"Sanctuary covers the sick," Dar said. "They'll argue you're not a patient, you're an asset, and they'll be right by their own books. Arguments lose to ledgers, Suri. We pay."

"And the price of paying is the printout."

"The price of paying is a copy of the printout," Dar said, "at a price that retires your page in full. Nothing more. I'm not selling them the anomaly. I'm selling them the receipt for it — and I'm pricing it at exactly what you cost, so they know the trade was never about them."

Roya made the copy that night. She worked at the back table with the lamp hooded, and she did not trace the slip so much as persuade a second sheet of scrounged thermal stock to remember what the first one remembered — pressure and heat, her old craft, the lines rising like veins under skin. When she finished there were two slips on the table and she covered the older one with her scarred hand before anyone could touch it. "This one stays," she said, through the brass mask. "Copies are for selling. Originals are for keeping."

"Mine's already sold, then," Milla said from the doorway, in a voice with no weather in it at all, and went back to the front desk, and counted something very hard for a long time.

* * *

Dar went to the annex alone. Suri waited at the clinic and did the only work left to her, which was bookkeeping: she entered the claim in her ledger under GAVEL — CLAIM SERVED, the corrected figure beneath it, and beside that column she opened another, and ruled it, and left it blank, because she did not yet know what went in it.

He was back by the fifth bell of evening with rain on his shoulders and three papers, and he laid them on the ward table one at a time, like a man dealing out a verdict.

The first was the Gavel's surrender: the debt-book page with her name on it, stamped across the maroon in the Gavel's blunt grease-pencil — SETTLED — PAID IN FULL — the chain of resales struck through in one clean stroke. The second was the Index's receipt: ten thousand, six hundred and eight in coin, received against delivery of one print, anomaly class, origin Saltstairs, the figure written in a hand that shook slightly, as if the clerk who wrote it had understood he was buying a confession. The third was blank paper, and Dar turned it over

and said nothing, and Suri understood the blank was the point: the Index had offered more, and he had priced the city's only evidence at cost.

"They verified it against their rebuilt machine records for an hour," Dar said. "Then their auditor paid, and thanked me, and said a thing I'm supposed to carry back. He said: the seal counts every rhythm eventually — now it has two of yours on file." He looked at the table. "The city's secret is in their annex. There's no column that undoes that. I checked."

"You paid my debt with the one proof that we exist," Suri said. It was not an accusation. It was the entry, being read aloud for errors.

"I paid your debt with the thing they were already hunting," Dar said. "The hunt was priced in the moment they posted the bounty. I just chose who got paid."

* * *

Milla was waiting when the ward emptied, and she did not wait politely. She came to the table with her cold fingers flat on the wood and her stamp-callus facing him like a credential, and said, "You sold the Ferun printout."

"I sold a copy of it."

"You sold my page." Her voice stayed level, which was worse. "You sold it to the men who priced me by name before I knew I was for sale. I gave that slip to this clinic. I did not give it to a market. Sanctuary means no names leave the building, Mehran, and that slip is the loudest name in this city."

"It bought ten thousand, six hundred and eight," Dar said, "and every coin of it is stamped on the Gavel's surrender, and Suri Kaveh is owned by no one as of tonight."

"I know what it bought." Milla's hands did not move. "I've known since I heard the barrow in the lane. I'm not here about the price. I'm here about the estate." She unpicked the seam of her coat lining with a clerk's small knife, three fast strokes, and drew out a fold of oilcloth, and opened it on the table.

The slip inside was thermal-grey and five years old and perfect, and it was not the slip Dar had carried since the night she defected. It was the same rhythm — five spikes, a dip, five spikes — but sharper, first-generation, and along the bottom edge ran the machine's fault-strike and, in faded official ink, a destruction-order number. The Chorus original had gone into the furnace; this was the first pull, the true print, the one the copyist had kept.

"I told you, in this ward, that the copy I gave you was the only print left in the world," Milla said. "I'm a clerk. I run originals twice and file the difference — the second pull went into your coat, and I let you believe it was the whole estate, because the bounty was on my

name and I had been audited before. Originals stay with their clerk." She folded the oilcloth back over the print, seam by seam. "So the Index has the pattern — a faithful copy of the second pull, made by the best forger in the city. They'll count two rhythms, they'll verify it against their rebuilt machines, and they'll build their readers around it, and that cost is real, and you meant it to be. But the first pull has the machine's own fault-strike and the destruction order in the margin — the only marks in the world that prove where this rhythm was read, and when, and on whose order it was to die. When the fleet comes, and someone has to prove what was done to this city — the proof is mine, and it stays mine, and it stays sewn where it has slept since before the Blacktide." She sewed the lining shut with three strokes of the same small knife turned needle-wise. "You should have asked me, Mehran. I'd have said yes. That's the part I'll hold against you — not the sale. The not asking."

Dar took that the way he took triage, without flinching and without arguing. "Noted," he said. "Filed."

"You're damn right it's filed," Milla said, and went back to her desk, and the clinic was quieter by one old lie.

* * *

They burned her page that night, in the clinic stove, because Suri said a thing that was paid for should be seen to burn, and Dar said a thing paid for should be buried, and Suri said graves are just ledgers the ground keeps, and won.

She took it out of her own ledger's spine, where it had ridden since the night of the fires: the salvage page, her name and graft-number, RESOLD — THREE TIMES, soot-stained at one corner where she had pulled it out of ash that was still breathing. She laid it on the ward table, and Milla brought the ink without being asked, and a pen with a clerk's nib, and stood by while Suri wrote across the maroon entries in her flat, counted hand:

PAID IN FULL.

She had written those words once before, on a page about Dar, with a parenthetical after them, and her hand hesitated out of pure habit above the space where the parenthetical went. Then she wrote the words only, and capped the ink, and carried the page to the stove.

It did not burn cleanly.

The Chorus inks, Vahid had told them once, in the register he used for the things that shamed him — their census inks carried a living trace, a tissue-ink, so the books could answer to their masters when called. The flame took the paper fine and ordinary, and then the maroon entries caught, and the page began to scream. Faintly. The way a kettle screams from a street

away; the way a wet finger drawn on glass would scream, if glass could grieve. The graft-number howled in a register below hearing that everyone in the ward heard anyway. Suri held the stove door and did not step back, because the debt had been hers and the dying of it was going to be hers too, and her face did nothing at all.

Ilay came down the stair before anyone called her — drawn, the way she was drawn to wrongness, with her copper hair tied back and her eyes the color of river stones. She listened to the page for the length of three heartbeats, hers or Suri's nobody counted. Then she sat down on the wood-box, folded her hands, and hummed.

It was not the lullaby. It was the small, tuneless music she made when the deep was quiet and nothing in the walls was counting — the sound of a child alone in a room where nothing needed her. She hummed it at the stove, evenly, the way you hold a note you intend to keep.

The screaming settled. The entries blackened quietly, one line at a time, like a ledger being closed by a careful hand, and the maroon ink let go of its living trace and became only ink, and only ash. The stamped words went last, the way good ink does, holding their line until the fire made them true.

Suri closed the stove. She went back to the ward table and opened her ledger to the blank column she had ruled that morning, and wrote across its head, small: KAVEH, SURI — RETIRED. The column beneath it stayed empty, and she looked at the emptiness the way other people look at the sea.

The column read zero. She kept counting anyway.

CHAPTER 67

Common Property

The descent took seven hundred and eleven steps, and Dar counted them, because counting was the load-bearing wall and everything else had been sold off it: two hundred to the dead First Vessel's cold cathedral, four hundred more through the dark where the walls rang like struck glass, and the last stretch down the new-cut stair to the rig the clinic had built over the salt-glass door.

The rig was a cold room — canvas walls, brass frame, two chairs — with the room's law chalked on the canvas by Vahid's own hand: NO SONGS. NOT EVEN HUMMING. The law had been there since the first session and had never yet been obeyed by the building itself. The door breathed at the far wall, ajar, warm, patient, and the dark behind it was not empty the way a room is empty; it was empty the way a held breath is empty.

The cold was not weather. It came off the door in a slow flood, and it had purposes: it kept the climbers' blood thick and their hearing sharp, and it kept the Lily settled in Dar's chest the way a cat settles in a shadowed window. Darkness fed her; the deep had darkness to spare. That was the other reason Vahid had built the rig down here instead of up in the clinic, though he had phrased it as geology. The ninth seed climbed better at the bottom of the world, where her eldest sister could hear her through the wall.

Isra was already in her chair. The watchers had gone up at the eighth bell — Suri's rule now, fewer witnesses to a tithe, fewer debts owed on one — and the salt-burned woman waited alone with a black petal spread at her collarbone like a brooch pinned through her, still as a diver at the edge of a drop. Her slate lay across her knees. On it, in her slow effortful strokes, she had written the evening's only business: I KNOW WHAT IT TAKES TONIGHT. DO YOU?

Dar sat, and put his hands on the armrests, and answered out loud, because the rig's rule was no songs, not no words. "I know."

The pulse-reader clicked itself on. Nobody touched it anymore. Since the fourth session it had run when they ran, and its stylus printed in the small administrative grammar of everything in this city that had ever taken an account, and tonight, before either of them had closed their eyes, it printed two lines:

RHYTHM PAIRED. TITHE: ONE EACH.

* * *

The room between them had been built out of two childhoods and was now furnished by three debts.

It had not started as a room. It had started as a floor — Isra's drowned flats, laid down the first night she paid, a tide-line of kelp-smell and wet sand across nothing — and then his Blacktide refusal had gone in beside it: an altar, a cracked reliquary, a single word standing in the air like a man refusing to sit. NO, said in a graft-theater, to a god's own invitation. The room had kept both payments on open display, the way good rooms keep what they are built from, and every session since had added its tithe to the shelf, and the shelf had grown, and now the room was a room — walls, a lamp that cast no shadows, the two payments at its heart like hearth-stones.

That was the doctrine Shirin Bahar had left in wax, and Vahid taught it at the clinic ladder with his one hand and his wire-mended spectacles: the Soul was not a rung but the shared organ, grafted between people rather than grown in one — and a graft between two minds made a space, and the space had customs, and the customs had a price schedule. Every session the room took its tithe. Not spent, the way the Mind Vein spent — spent was a withdrawal, a room stripped to the nail-holes — but paid over, entire, into common property: held thereafter by everyone in the graft, irretrievable by the giver alone, forever. You could not buy it back. There was no registry house for it.

They had learned the rule the way you learn any ledger, by receiving a bill. On the fifth night the room had taken, unchosen, a memory of Dar's — a doorway, a color of paint — and Isra had lost the taste of her mother's cooking for a whole session, gone from her like a tide, back on waking but diminished, a page re-copied by a stranger. After that, Vahid's law: you choose the tithe before the room chooses for you. You pay what you can afford to have, not what you can afford to lose. There was no third category.

Tonight Dar walked his own corridors to choose.

He went down the halls of his mind with the discipline Vahid had drilled into him, past the swept rooms he visited like graves — mother's face, father's laugh, first kiss, home's color, all stripped to pay the war — and past the furnished door he had never built, which showed its thread of lamplight as always and was not for him. In the deep residential quarter of himself there was a kitchen. Steam on a window. The grain of a table worn pale by two generations of elbows. A voice singing.

The face was gone; it had gone to the Blacktide, spent like a coin, and no part of it had ever come back. But the voice had survived the spend, the way a nail-hole survives the picture — the lullaby, sung low, in a kitchen, by a woman whose face he had paid away and whose

voice he had somehow been allowed to keep, and for years he had not known whose voice it was. The lullaby remained. The ownership had not.

He stood in the kitchen the way you stand at a counter, and counted the costs of paying it over. If he gave the memory, the room would hold it — Isra would know a mother singing; the dark below would know it. And the lullaby itself would stay in him, but stripped of its one attestation: it would never again be the song his mother sang. It would be only what the world had already made it — the Lily's song, the Gardener's song, everyone's song and no one's — and the last small ledger that said a woman with no face had sung it in a kitchen with steam on the glass would close.

He could afford to have that. He could not afford to lose anything load-bearing, and nothing had ever been more load-bearing than the proof that the song had a first singer.

He stood a while longer, doing the final audit, because the last part of the price was the part you paid afterward, every day, forever. Above, in the city, there were people who hummed the lullaby without knowing what they carried — Hesh with one note wrong, the tide-priests selling it by the reading, the Church feeding it to the deep for forty years through forty years of harvested throats. After tonight he would hear it in strangers' mouths and feel nothing he could name, because the name would be gone — not the tune, never the tune, but the fact that it had belonged to anyone before it belonged to the dark. He paid anyway, because the alternative was letting the room choose, and the room did not love anyone.

He carried the kitchen to the room's center and set it down.

The room took it the way the press at Lowmark took payment — no violence, a settling, a click of weight accepted — and where it stood there was now a shelf he had not built, and on the shelf, held in common, the memory sat: steam, table, voice. His to visit. Never again only his.

Isra's slate tapped the chair-arm twice. In the between-space her slate was slate and her writing was writing; that was the shape her side of the graft had taken, and no one had chosen it, and it was hers. She wrote for a long time, slower than speech, and turned it to him.

MY BROTHER'S NAME.

Then, beneath, because she never wrote one line when the truth needed three:

HE MARRIED THE BRIDE TO CLEAR OUR HOUSE'S DEBT. THE MARRIED LEAVE THEIR NAMES AT THE TEMPLE DOOR. THE BOOKS DROWNED ANYWAY. I AM THE ONLY FILE LEFT.

Dar understood what she was pricing, and understood it was the exact twin of his. Her brother's name existed nowhere now — struck from the temple register by doctrine, drowned with the port's records — except in one salt-burned diver's memory, and now she was going to make it common property: held by the room, by him, by the dark below. Not destroyed. Mutualized. She would no longer be able to reach it alone, ever, for the rest of her life — and it would survive her, because nothing held in common dies with one holder.

She wrote the name once, in careful letters, and let him read it — a short name, coastal, worn smooth like a stone from a shingle — and then she paid it, and the shelf took it, and the slate in her hands was blank, and she looked at the blankness with her head tilted like someone listening to whether the sea was still where she had left it.

The name sat on the shelf beside the kitchen. Dar held it now, in the way the room held things — not remembered, resident. He knew the boy without ever having met him: older by four years, patient with rope, the one who had taught a small girl that fear was a number you counted down, and that the count always landed. He knew it the way Isra now knew the inside of a kitchen she had never stood in. That was the graft: two climbers, one shelf, and nothing of either one of them entirely alone again.

Then she wrote, in strokes that took her a long time:

NOW IT IS OURS. OURS IS BETTER THAN MINE. MINE WAS SOMETHING THE WATER COULD TAKE.

* * *

The tithe paid, the room settled, and the work went on — the slow, wordless diligence of two nervous systems learning to be one organ, the pulse-reader printing its paired rhythms in ever-tightening registration, one beat behind, then half, then finding the interval that held. The lullaby's shelf stayed warm. Common property always did; that was in Shirin's cylinders too, though the cylinder had ended mid-word — and then you will hear the sound — and no one had ever heard the sound.

The pulse-reader printed twice more before the hour turned. TITHE: RECEIVED. TITHE: RECEIVED. It did not print received from whom. Machines in Ashkarad had stopped distinguishing their debtors long ago; a tithe was a tithe.

And then, at the room's edge, where the floor became not-floor and the wall became the standing dark of the one who never crossed, the Sister began to hum.

Softly. The softest thing Dar had ever felt with his teeth. The rig's law was NO SONGS, not even humming, and the law had been written for the climbers, because songs were keys

and the door was locked with them — and the first song the rig ever heard came from below its own floor, from the dark that had stood a century at the threshold of her own rescue, and it did not come to open anything.

It came to sit with what had just been paid.

She hummed the lullaby — and not the line of it, not the child's thread of it that Dar had carried all his life without knowing whose it was. She hummed the under-line. The harmony. The line a mother lays beneath a child's singing so the child cannot get lost — low, steady, going where the going is dark, coming back, coming back. The mother's line, not the child's.

She had heard the kitchen through the shelf. Everything paid into the room, she heard; she was the third heartbeat at the wall, the listener, the eldest, and the memory of a faceless woman singing in a steam-fogged kitchen had settled where she could reach it, and she was holding the under-line of it the way you hold something someone has just trusted you with.

The Lily stirred in Dar's chest and answered through his ribs, taking the child's thread against the dark's mother-line, two songs fitting, and Isra sat with her blank slate and her hand at her collarbone petal, and Dar stood in a room built from two childhoods and listened to his mother's line sung back to him from below the world.

He had paid the memory to keep the song. The song had gone into the common dark. And the common dark, which had waited longer than the Church, longer than the ledgers, longer than the salt, was paying it back out — one held breath at a time, the under-line, the mother's line — like a refund from a house that had never once, in a century, been asked what it was owed.

CHAPTER 68

The Pick Comes Back Flowering

Mother Gavel kept the pump-works the way she kept everything: on the books, and ahead of them. She met Dar in the ration hall at the eighth bell, under the new pipework, at a table her clerks had cleared to bare wood, and she let him stand a while — not discourtesy, procedure; you priced a man's posture before you priced his terms — and then she sat, and folded her scarred hands, and opened the meeting the way she opened all of them, with the arithmetic.

"Herald movement on the flats," she said. "Caravan flags running the Reclaim route, week on week. Your wain is coming, cutter. When it comes, the vault-mouth is the door the city fights at, and tonight my crews can hold it." She slid a paper across the bare wood. "Here is the price."

Dar did not touch it. He read it from where it lay, the way you read a bill you have no intention of paying, and the terms were exactly the terms her runners had promised: the Gavel's crews under Gavel's discipline to hold the shaft, the reliquary corridor, and the antechamber against all comers — Index, herald, fire, or famine — until the fleet's business was done. In exchange, on the day the city's affairs resumed, the deep became hers to work. The salt vaults. The salt-glass. The cathedral of the dead god and everything its flesh would render. A mine, with the clinic's name on the deed of surrender, and her water-debt against the clinic forgiven forever, in perpetuity, in the manner of perpetuities.

"You're paying me in guards," she said, "for what you can't guard. And you're paying me in water you can't pump. I've read your ledgers, Mehran. You're a rich man in every currency but the two that spend."

She had read more than his ledgers. Four days ago her ledgermen had surrendered a debt-book page under grease-pencil, and the retirement coin had come across her counter in sealed boxes, and the asset the coin retired had walked out of her books and back into the clinic's census without one word of thanks. She did not resent it; resentment was interest paid on a principal you refused to collect. But the arithmetic of it sharpened the terms she was about to lose him with: the clinic could raise ten thousand in coin in four days. What it could not raise was water in a drought, or men in a siege, and both were coming up the Reclaim road with the caravans.

"The deep isn't mine to lease," Dar said. "That's the first refusal and the whole one. There's a woman behind that door who has stood at the threshold of her own rescue for a hundred years, and above her there's a grave, and under her there's a heart, and you're proposing to put a shaft through all three of them and call it yield."

"I'm proposing to put men with lamps on a frontier," Gavel said. "Frontiers pay or they don't. The ones that don't get closed."

"It's not a frontier. It's a patient." Dar's voice stayed in the register he used on wards. "You don't mine a patient, Mother. You triage one."

She looked at him for a long moment with her eyes flat as a ledger page, and Suri, who had come as far as the hall's door and no farther, would say afterward that you could hear the column closing. "Then I'll price it again when you're hungry," Gavel said. "The ration runs on my pumps, cutter. Everything in this city runs on my pumps now. Refusals are entry numbers. Good evening."

He went. She sat a while in the ration hall and did not look at the paper he had not touched, and her clerks entered the refusal in the day-book: CLINIC — TERMS DECLINED, NO COUNTER. Under the column for assets, she drew a line, and under the line, in her own hand, she wrote the word she was to think of, later, at the shaft-head, with a flowering pick standing in the corner of her counting-room like an umbrella nobody claimed.

The word was: ODDS.

* * *

They went down four nights later, without her order and without her knowledge, and she reconstructed it afterward from depositions the way she reconstructed everything, in statements, in order, in ink.

Statement one: the overman, Harl. His crews were owed water — three shifts of pump-work under ration law, billed and unpaid since the Index seized the eastern mains, and a crew owed water under a water-for-work ration is a crew with nothing to trade but risk. The deep was full of the one wealth the war had not touched: salt-glass by the ton, walls that rang like struck glass, the cut flower in the door's lock like a gem the size of a hand. The dead god's cathedral was full of tissue the old Church had graded and certified and never finished rendering — biogel stock, Church-grade, enough to buy the whole crew out of the ration books twice over. Harl's arithmetic, in his own words, taken down flat: The church priced that flesh for forty years. The church is gone. Prices don't die with the church. Somebody was going to go down and collect.

Statement two: the pickman, Sedge. He had swung at the flower-keyhole. Not at the door — everyone agreed on that; nobody crossed thresholds down there, not even the thing that lived behind the door crossed its own threshold — but at the lock. The keyhole stood exposed in the salt-glass, a five-petaled flower cut clean through, and a cut flower is a cut gem is a fortune, and Sedge had put his pick to it the way a man puts a chisel to a safe, with the whole crew's hunger standing behind his shoulder.

Statement three, and the shortest: the strike. One blow. The pick came back flowering.

Harl's deposition ended there, and then went on longer than any statement she had ever taken from him, because he kept trying to explain the sound. There was no sound, he wrote first. Then: there was a sound like a struck glass, but struck from inside. Then, crossed out and rewritten twice: it rang back. You swing at a wall, the wall rings. This rang back at the swing. He finally wrote the sentence she kept: It didn't take the blow like stone. It took it like a ledger takes an entry.

The fourth statement was the one she took herself, at the shaft-head, from the two men who had carried Sedge up seven hundred steps at a dead run while the third man ran behind them holding a tool that had stopped being a tool. They were still shaking. She wrote their words down herself, in her own book, in her own hand, because some entries you do not delegate.

The frost had run down the haft from head to grip in the time it took to lift it off the door. Grey petals, fine as breath on glass, open and unfolded and pointing — every petal of them, the whole flowering length of the haft — compass-true, down. Not at the city. At the deep. The pick had gone down to take a lock and come back as a receipt.

And Sedge, who had swung it, had begun to count before they reached the second stair. Backward. From one hundred and nine.

* * *

Dar came to the quarry at first light, because the sanctuary terms cut both ways and Gavel crews were treated at the clinic without charge and without names, and what came up the shaft at dawn needed treatment the way a fire needs ignoring.

They had put Sedge in the infirmary shed, on a table, under blankets he had kicked most of the way off. Frost on his knuckles in five-petaled blooms that came and went; pulse two-handed and holding; eyes open, tracking, present — and counting. It came off him the way breathing goes on without permission: one hundred and nine, one hundred and eight, one hundred and seven — a man counting down to something with the calm of a clerk who has seen the schedule.

Dar took his wrist. The Lily went still in his chest — not the stillness of craving, not the stillness of rage; the stillness of a thing listening to its own name spoken in another room — and under his fingers Sedge's pulse paused at the touch and resumed one beat late, like a copyist reproducing a line one line down.

"One hundred and six," Sedge said, to the ceiling. "One hundred and five."

"Does the count move?" Dar asked him, and Sedge's eyes came down out of the middle distance and fastened on him with terrible sobriety, and the answer was the worst thing Dar had heard in a year of bad numbers.

"Only at thresholds," Sedge said. "Doors. Stairs. It's at one hundred and four."

The Cartographer's tally shard had read one hundred and nine for a year, with five fresh strokes cut under it by no hand Dar could name, and the count only ever moved at thresholds — and here was a man with a threshold in his mouth, spending it backward one number at a time. Something behind the door had been counting Dar's heartbeats since before the Blacktide; now it had handed the arithmetic to a pickman, the way you hand a bill to the nearest clerk. The deep did not defend itself. It billed.

"Can you treat him?" Gavel asked, from the shed's doorway, and it was the only time Dar ever heard her ask anything.

"I can keep him warm and hydrated and seen," Dar said. "The count isn't a sickness. It's a lien. Someone's lien on someone, and he's standing where the paper does its business." He looked at the tool rack by the door, where the pick leaned where they had put it, flowering still, the grey petals having neither wilted nor spread, holding their pointing like a compass holds north. "The debt isn't his. He's just the address it was delivered to."

There was a chalked line on the old shaft maps, the Cartographer's warning, copied by hand onto every chart that went below: DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS. And under it, the reason, in the same copperplate: Because it counts back. Dar had read it in a fog of nerve-scream a year ago and filed it as a warning about listening. It had never been about listening. It had been about accounting. Swing a pick at the deep and the deep does not defend itself; it bills you. One hundred and nine had been an invoice all along — the Cartographer's shard, the five fresh strokes, the count that only moved at thresholds — and now the invoice had a debtor's name on it, and the name was Sedge's, and the delivery address was a quarry infirmary in the rain.

Gavel came into the shed, and crossed the floor, and stood over the pick for a long moment — the longest Dar ever saw her do anything — while her crew waited at the door for the word that would send seven hundred men back down the stair into the one frontier in Ashkarad that

had never once, in any ledger she kept, failed to pay.

The petals pointed down. Sedge counted: "One hundred and two. One hundred and one."

Gavel put her hand flat on the flowering haft, and took the measure of it — weight, cold, direction, odds — the way she had taken the measure of the paper Dar had not touched, and whatever she found in the arithmetic of a tool that had come back as a receipt, she entered it, and closed the column.

"Off the deep," she said, in the brass-tube voice she saved for orders that had to survive her. "All crews. The shaft is Gavel ground and Gavel closed, this bell, to everyone, forever, until the odds improve."

Harl, at the door, waited for the rest. There was no rest.

She looked at the pick a moment more — at the grey frost, at the pointing, at the patient arithmetic written all over it in a language older than her books — and then she took her hand back, and Suri, at the shed's edge, watched the oldest survivor in Ashkarad price something and decline to buy.

"One hundred," Sedge said, to the ceiling, comfortable, unhurried. "Ninety-nine."

The count went with him into the dark of the shed, and the pick stood in its corner, and the deep, far below the quarry and the clinic and every book in the city, kept its own books, and waited for the next entry with the patience of a creditor who has just been shown — at last, after a century — that the city above can read.

CHAPTER 69

Sold in Bulk

The final push had a price list, and Suri wrote it on the clinic wall in her flat counted hand, because the first rule of funding anything in Ashkarad was to know what anything was.

The list read: vault watches, fed and paid through the ration, six hands a night, forty nights. Chorus-free doses, Vahid's distillation, materials the city no longer made and the League still carried — glass, spirit, silver salt, four kinds of wax. Lamp-oil for the deep, where oil was life and the darkness fed things that were not them. Grain against the ration's arithmetic, because the clinic's neutrality bought no one's hunger. And water, at Gavel's pump price, every day, for a house that had spent its coin four days ago retiring a courier and would spend it again the same way.

Against the list, in the second column, Suri had written the clinic's assets: one free clinic, one sanctuary census, one reputation. And then, because the column would not balance and she was not a woman who left a column unbalanced, she had added the only line that could close it, in smaller letters, as if the ink could be made responsible: HIS.

Dar read the wall and understood the accounting perfectly, because it was his own accounting read back to him by someone who had never once let him lie in it. The clinic had one asset left that the market priced. He had spent a mother's face and a father's laugh and a first kiss and the color of home to buy a war, and the war had not closed, and the registry was still buying.

"I know the exchange," he said. "I've used the counter at Lowmark. The press takes true currency, refuses the false, files what it takes. It cost me the smell of carbolic soap and a dead bride's last morning, and it bought me a look at the Gardener's hand." He rolled his sleeve. "I'm not selling the load-bearing walls. I'm selling furniture."

Suri looked at him with the expression of a woman auditing a smuggler's manifest. "Furniture," she said. "I'll be the judge of the furniture. You don't touch the list I keep. You bring me every slip before it goes, and I strike it from the ledger of you, and if the ledger of you says stop, we stop."

* * *

The League kept a counting-room by the tide-gates — a narrow brick office where caravan clerks billed storm-freight, and behind the counter, in a cage of brass bars, sat the thing Dar had crossed a drowned city to use: a press of bone and brass, small, the clear child of

the mother-house machine in Lowmark, with a feeding slot and a print-tray and a clay basin underneath for the lees. The League sustained the route; the route was the Gardener's; every League office was a registry counter wearing freight like a coat. Dar had understood that for a year. He used it anyway. That was the trade, and he priced the trade and took the trade, and hated the trade, and the trade did not care.

Vell came with him the first morning, unasked, chalk in hand, because Vell of Brack had worked for a counting-house that sold to the registry and knew its grammar the way fish know water. She stood at the counter while the League clerk inked the docket, and she read the posted rates — rates that moved like tides, re-priced by the week against the fleet's approach — and she wrote on the counter's slate, in tall steady letters:

BRACK SOLD HERE TOO.

She underlined it twice. Then she wrote: I WILL COUNT YOUR SLIPS. NO ONE SHOULD SELL ALONE.

The first deposit was small, and true, and his: rain on the Saltstairs the night of his seventh birthday, drumming the cistern lids, his father's coat over his shoulders, the smell of wet wool. The press took it the way the room below took tithes — a settling, a click of weight accepted — and the clerk logged the catalog line in the docket, and the counterfoil came back printed, and the price of a night of rain on a cistern lid, at that week's rates, was enough to buy the clinic six days of water.

He stood in the counting-room a moment after, the way you stand after setting a bone, waiting for the hurt to file itself where hurts go. The rain-night was gone. Not dimmed — gone, the way the Mind Vein's spends were gone, except that the Mind Vein had stripped a room and this had taken a room entire and put a stranger's seal on it, and somewhere up a drowned coast a press had made a leaf of him and filed it under assets. The Lily shifted against his heart, once, like a sleeper turning at a door.

They pinned the counterfoil to the clinic wall. Then they pinned the next, and the next.

* * *

It went on for eleven days, and the wall filled, and the wall was the most terrible ledger Dar had ever seen, and he had seen the Choratorium's.

Deposit-slips, each priced and priced again — the registry re-priced its holdings upward as the fleet came, the way any market re-prices whatever is leaving it, so that every morning Suri walked the wall with her stick of wax and corrected the totals, and the totals only rose. The taste of storm-tea. The weight of a sleeping cat from his childhood street. The hour Vahid

lectured sober, once, on the anatomy of the hyoid, for no reason anyone ever learned. The first time he held a retractor steady enough for a senior to stop watching. The green of the canal in spring. The sound of Milla's stamps, from the next room, on his first day at Saint Ferrous — he sold that one sitting down.

The patients read the wall the way the poor read anything priced in a window they cannot buy from: without expression, and completely. One of the freed vessels, a girl of twelve with graded blood and careful eyes, asked him what the slips were, and Dar, mid-stitch, gave her the only honest version. "They're days of mine," he said. "Sold so the house stays warm." She considered that with the gravity the nursery had taught her, and asked the question the nursery had also taught her, the one that priced everything: "What do you get, when you sell a day?" And Dar said, "Six days of water for eleven people," and the girl nodded slowly, filed it, and never asked again, because in Ashkarad the arithmetic had always been that honest, and that obscene.

Milla audited the wall on the fourth day, registrar to market, cold fingers flying down the catalog lines, and rendered her verdict at the desk in front of the whole ward: "Your rain is underpriced. Your retractor is overpriced. Whoever is buying knows the rain is worth more than you think it is, and is letting you think the retractor is the prize." Dar asked her how she knew. Milla said, "Because I've been priced by professionals," and went back to her census, and he sat with that longer than he sat with any slip.

Suri kept the other ledger. She called it the ledger of self, and it lived in her lap, and it had two columns: SOLD, and BEARING. Every slip he brought her went into the first column, described in her flat hand, and then she made him walk the second column with her — the load-bearing inventory, the walls the house stood on: Suri's stitching, and the first unpriced thing; Ilay's hand in his; Vahid's voice saying the word control; the feel of a pulse under two fingers; the refusal at the Blacktide; the word no, said in a theater, to a god. She audited the walls after every sale, and her audits got shorter, and her silences got longer.

Vahid, consulted, gave the doctrine in one of his lectures that started drunk and ended surgical, chalked one-handed on the clinic ladder: "A mind hollows from the connections out, boy. Not from the edges — the edges are where the junk lives and the junk can burn all day. Hollow starts where the walls meet. You sell the meeting and the wall still stands and holds nothing. Corridors first. Then the corridors forget where they were going. I have opened the last body of a man who sold his meetings, and there is nothing in the box but shelf. You are not selling furniture. You are selling joinery, and calling it furniture because the word is kinder." He put down the chalk with his one hand, precisely. "Bring me the slips before you sell them. I will not watch another student hollow. I watched Shirin's city do it to a generation."

On the ninth day Suri closed the ledger and did not open it, and said the thing she had been holding since the first slip.

"Three memories from hollow," she said. "Not three slips. Three walls. You're selling furniture, and the furniture's holding up the roof, Mehran. That's how houses go — not wall by wall; all at once, with the right wall gone. You're three walls from hollow, and the market keeps raising your price, and the market is not on your side."

"The market is funding the last climb of my life," Dar said. "I can't be choosy about whose coin."

"You can be choosy about whose hand it comes out of," Suri said, and marked the day's total, and the total had risen again.

* * *

On the eleventh evening the counterfoils came back from clearing at the mother house — the caravan turnaround had shortened from weeks to days, the route clearing its own throat — and Vell spread them on the ward table in rows, and Suri counted them, and stopped at the fourth, and set it down on the table with the care you use for something that has been in a fire.

It was pre-stamped.

Every cleared slip came back bearing the registry's flower and the word CLEARED, inked at the mother house, routine as weather. This one bore the flower and one word more, stamped in the black bone-pen hand Dar had seen sign a page of the World Registry, pressed into the counterfoil before the slip had even finished its route — before the caravan left, the timing said; before the ink of the deposit was dry on the docket:

RECLAIMED.

Bought at the source. Read off the docket as it was written. The Gardener was not clearing the market and taking what came. The Gardener was standing at the counter of the route, everywhere, at once, buying on the open market — buying his memories as he sold them, in real time, at his own asking prices — funding the last climb of the ninth seed's carrier out of her own account, one rain-fall and one retractor and one sober lecture at a time.

"She's paying for her own delivery," Suri said. Her voice was flat, and slower than flat. "We sold the furniture. She's the buyer, the courier, and the house. Every coin in the clinic's box right now passed through her hands coming and going." She looked at the stamped slip the way she had once looked at a granary ledger that would not balance. "That's not funding. That's feeding."

Dar stood in front of the wall of slips with the RECLAIMED slip in his hand and did the audit he should have done on the first day. The cleared slips, all of them, row by row — Vell had transcribed the catalog lines from the docket in her tall chalk letters, a clerk's insurance, and he read the line for every slip the black hand had bought, and the reading took the room's breath and did not give it back.

Not one of the cleared slips was random.

Rain on cistern lids — drummed, in his memory, in the meter the rain kept. The sober lecture — Vahid's voice turning on the anatomy of the hyoid like a tune. The green of the canal in spring — with the canal-singer's far voice caught in it, one street over, singing. The stamps, the tea, the cat — each one carrying, somewhere in its floorboards, some fragment of sound that rhymed with a single song, and he knew the song, and the song knew him, and every cleared slip was a memory of music.

He looked at Suri. Suri was already looking at the rows.

"She's not buying memories," Dar said. "She's buying the song. One bar at a time. Out of me."

Vell, silent, tongueless, took up her chalk and wrote it on the ward table's edge, and underlined it twice, the way she had underlined BRACK SOLD HERE TOO — a clerk's insurance, a counter's alarm, rung from a counting-house that had been eaten by the thing now buying:

SHE IS COLLECTING IT.

CHAPTER 70

She Is Buying the Lullaby

The cross-reference took one night and cost nothing but sleep, and that was the obscenity of it: the answer had been hanging on the clinic wall for eleven days, priced and re-priced, in his own hand's counterfoils.

Dar laid the cleared slips out on the ward table in the order of their clearing, and Vell chalked the catalog lines beside them, and Roya — who could no longer hear the city's song and had never once stopped being able to see its shape — stood over the rows with her brass mask catching the lamp, and did to the slips what she had once done to dreams. She mapped them. Not the contents. The intervals.

"Rain on the cistern lids," she said, tapping the first. "Meter's nine against four. The lecture — the hyoid, the sober hour — his cadence lands on nine against four at the turn. The canal in spring — the singer a street over, the phrase she repeats, it's nine against four." Her gloved finger moved down the rows, and the rows confessed. "Everything this house sold has a spine in it. The same spine. Bar and bar and bar. Somebody has been buying one song, Mehran, sold to her in pieces, in the floorboards of a hundred ordinary days."

Dar had known it since the ward table, since Suri's flat voice over the rows: every cleared slip a memory of music. What he had not done, because the not-doing was the last kindness he had left himself, was name the song. He named it now. There was no version of the night where he did not. The lullaby.

Not the whole of it — the slips were fragments, bars, meters, a hum caught one street over — but the Gardener was not buying fragments to shelve them. The registry pressed memories into leaves, and leaves could be laid edge to edge, and the Gardener had spent a century signing her mark over and over like a stamp; assembly was her native art. Piece by piece, out of the floorboards of his life, she was fitting the complete lullaby together — and the complete lullaby was not a keepsake.

The Choirmaster had told them what the Choratorium's foundations were: a locking-collar, the lid-maintenance machine, forty years of harvested organs one long lullaby fed to the deep. The choir organs were silent since the Blacktide; the collar was running on stored song, on resonance, on habit — a lock maintained by a music nobody was singing anymore, which meant a lock running down. A completed lullaby, sung from the city side, would recharge the collar. Or the reverse: a completed lullaby, sung with intent, was the key-side of the same

instrument — the chorus that would open the deep from above at the exact hour he opened the door from below, so that the door would open into her hand. She was not collecting his past. She was building the hinge, and the hinge was his mother's song, and he had been carrying it to her counter in armloads, grateful for the coin.

"Cut the trade," Suri said. There was no audit in it, no column. "Now. Tonight. Burn the route."

* * *

Cutting the trade took until morning, and every hour of it was negotiation with a machine that did not recognize the word.

The registry's terms were the registry's terms, learned in a drowned city and printed on every counterfoil: deposits, once made, are the registry's to clear. What a depositor could do was close the account — stop selling, withdraw what was uncleared — and what it cost to close an account was an account-closing fee, priced like everything else at that week's rates, which was to say like extortion, which was to say Dar paid it, in the last coin the clinic had, standing at the League counter while the clerk inked the docket with the expression of a man witnessing something the paperwork had no column for. Behind the brass bars the little press sat with its feeding slot open, patient as a mouth. Vell stood at his shoulder and chalked one word on the counter, small, where only the clerk would read it: GOOD.

The account closed. Thirty-one slips remained uncleared, withdrawn, struck back into the ledger of self by Suri's own hand, one at a time, with her counting each one back into him aloud — "Rain. Retractor. Tea—" — and stopped.

"Tea," she said again. She was holding the last counterfoil in the withdrawal stack, and the ledger in her lap had gone somewhere she was not looking at it. "Mehran. This one cleared before the withdrawal. It's stamped."

Dar took it. The counterfoil was warm from her hand, and the registry's flower stood on it in ink, and beside the flower, in the black bone-pen hand he had seen sign the World Registry, pressed into the slip before the caravan ever left Ashkarad, one word:

RECLAIMED.

He remembered the deposit. That was the cruelty of a good memory: it played once more on the way out, like light holding in glass after the lamp is gone. The Choratorium dining hall, a year and a lifetime ago. Candles down a table long enough to seat a parish. His own regrown heart beating in its glass between them, the offer she had made him — his old life back, in a jar, for a child — and the two cups, always the two cups, the ritual she had taught Hesh and

Hesh had taught the city's ruins: decide which cup to drink from. And Vey — Custodian Anra Vey, salt-and-ash hair, white gloves — pouring tea the way she poured everything, like an administration, and talking, because Vey always talked, warm and maternal and absolute, the endearments that were threats; and Dar, twenty-six years old and mortgaged to his own chest, filing it all under enemy and surviving.

He had filed one sentence wrong.

Vey, pouring the second cup, not to him, to the room, in the tone of a woman correcting a small error of ceremony: "She takes hers with the leaves left in. The Gardener. I pour this the way she taught me, and I have never once been asked whose pour it is." A pause, the steam moving. "The Gardener drinks alone. That is the whole of the liturgy."

The word. The name. Spoken by the branch office's own Custodian, in her own voice, over her own tea, with the intimacy of a hand on a shoulder — filed away in Dar's memory for a year like a hair in a ledger-book, and sold by him for the price of lamp-oil, and cleared, and pressed, and bought by the hand that taught the pour. The Gardener now owned Vey's voice saying her name. She owned the sound of her own authority confirmed by the woman who had run her Ashkarad office for forty years and never once been asked.

And the memory had held more than the name. He made himself hear the rest of it, because Suri was waiting and the audit had to be complete: beneath the talk, under the pour, Vey humming. Vey had always hummed at her tea; the whole Choratorium had been built on a humming woman. And the humming that night had run the lullaby — the child's thread, the mother's under-line, the turn, the verses — and the ending. The ending he had never heard from any other living mouth, because his mother's ending was spent and the Lily's was copy and the deep below kept its own counsel. Vey, pouring tea for a debtor she meant to harvest, had sung the lullaby whole, once, carelessly, the way rich people handle coin — and the press had drawn it out of him to the last bar, and the black hand had bought it, and somewhere on the Reclaim road the song was complete.

* * *

That night, in the cold room over the salt-glass door, the Lily could not remember the lullaby's ending.

It was not a thing Dar could have explained to anyone who had not spent a year learning her weather. She did not speak; she had spent her whole budget of words on him across two years and was not spending again. But she hummed — in the bones, in the teeth, in the space behind the sternum where a second heartbeat keeps its office — and the hum was hers, and on bad nights it was the lullaby, and this was a bad night, the wall of slips downstairs still reeling

with what they had fed through it.

She began. The child's thread, low. The mother's under-line arriving under it from the dark below the floor, the Sister holding her harmony the way she had begun holding it, session after session, a century of loneliness answering a kitchen. The turn came. The verses came. And then the hum reached for the ending and there was nothing there.

Dar felt the loss before he understood it — a wrongness in his chest like a stair that ends one step early, the body's own arithmetic objecting before the mind files the paperwork. Frost crept up the salt wall beside the rig in a half-finished pattern, five petals that would not close, blooming and un-blooming at the lip of where the last bars should have carried them.

Not a wrong note. Not a hesitation. A nothing, with the exact shape of the ending — the way a room holds the shape of furniture after the furniture is gone, dust-edges on the floorboards where a thing stood for years. Her hum stood at the threshold of the last bars and the last bars were not in her, and she stood there, and did not fall, and did not repeat, and the silence below the floor held its breath with her.

Then, softly, the Sister's under-line laid itself across the gap — the harmony going on without the melody, the way a hand goes on holding a rope after the load is cut — and the Lily drew a breath Dar felt in his own lungs, and let the ending go.

He sat in the cold with both heartbeats quiet and did the accounting, because accounting was all he had ever been good for, and the account came out worse than any he had ever filed. He had thought the ending was his — bought back in a father's laugh, confirmed in a kitchen, resident. It had never been his. It had entered him through Vey's careless mouth, a thing he was holding in trust for a woman he had hated and a seed he had never met, and the press could not have known trust from property — the press does not price intention, only truth — and he had sold it for lamp-oil, and the hand that taught the pour had bought the pour. Downstairs, Suri was entering it in the ledger of what they owed the road, because that was her way of grieving: you wrote the loss down or the loss wrote you.

Part of it was never his to lose. He had lost it anyway. That was the whole of the arithmetic, and it did not total, and in the dark below the floor the two of them — the ninth seed and the first, the carrier and the keeper — sat in the gap where the ending used to be, and no one sang it, because the only complete copy left in the world was riding the Reclaim road in a wain of pressed leaves, going to a house where a hand with a ring of old burn-scars was fitting the bars together like panes, one by one, by lamplight, patient as interest.

CHAPTER 71

Every Crack Sings

The writ came at dusk, and Roya read it through Ilay's hearing before the messenger's boots reached the step.

The girl had come to her at the attic window with her chalk already out, the way she came when the walls were saying something they shouldn't. "Grey coats," Ilay said. "Lots. And they're humming. Low, so the stones don't hear them planning." The Index did not march in step when it hunted stock children; it hummed — bars of the claiming-hymn, tossed down the streets like lines into water — and waited for the fish of the Church's long investment to rise toward the bait in their blood. Roya's song-lobe had been severed since the Blacktide; the city's living tissue was silence to her, had been silence every day since, and would be silence every day until she died. But Ilay was not silence. Ilay was the best instrument in Ashkarad, and Roya had spent a year learning to read her, and the girl's hearing painted the night the way her own maps painted terrain.

The writ, when the messenger presented it at the clinic door, was everything Ilay had heard and worse: an order of conscription, under one seal, blank-rectangle tar armbands, requiring the surrender of all sibling-stock minors in the sanctuary — for the city's defense, the paper said, as sonar, to be keyed, trained, and billeted at the annex. Signed, dated, stamped. Count every soul once under one seal. The children were the last uncounted souls in Ashkarad, and the Index had come with a barrel of ink.

Dar read it twice and gave the messenger the answer the clinic gave everyone: sanctuary terms, both seals, no names leave the building. The messenger went away the way weather goes. Suri took the front — couriers on the stair, Milla at the desk with the census under her hands, Mrs. Gable from the next tenement already herding the smaller ones back from the windows with the terrible competence of a woman who had raised children through three purges — and Dar made the decision Roya had already mapped from the girl's silence: the children did not stay in the crossfire. They went down.

The only uncounted direction was under the world.

* * *

Roya took them into the deep herself, because her maps did and because Ilay's maps did and because the thing she could not do — hear — mattered least where the walls rang like struck glass. Fourteen children, copper-haired Ilay at the head of the line with her hand on the

stone like a helm, Mrs. Gable bringing up the rear with Elias's collar in her fist and a storm-lantern she refused to surrender to anyone. Two hundred steps to the dead First Vessel's cathedral, four hundred more through the cold, and at the junction where the reliquary corridor met the down-shaft, Roya set her listening post: a niche, a slate, a stool, a child.

The plan was simple and Suri had signed it: the children shelter in the antechamber above the salt-glass door, in the one room in Ashkarad no faction will enter, because every faction that has met the deep has learned what it does to accounts. The clinic's line holds the junction until the writ's hour burns out and the conscription dies of its own paperwork. Nobody sings. Nobody fights if fighting can be filed instead.

Then the first boots came down the shaft, and the plan's account began to clear.

"Boots," Ilay whispered, palms flat to the stone. "Eleven. Coming down the tithe-stair, the fast way. And under them — picks. A lot of picks. The other side of the cathedral. They're not being quiet." Her face did something Roya had learned to dread, the small scowl of a child hearing people do arithmetic out of tune. "The Index is humming the finding-song. The miners are just walking."

Three forces, one corridor, one door. Gavel's crews, down the freight ways with their lamps hooded — the odds had improved, with the Index in the field; a mine abandoned is a mine the Index owns. An Index conscription squad, humming their way down the fast stair after the children the writ called sonar. And the clinic's line between them, couriers and freed donors and Suri's flat counted voice moving people like freight. Roya could hear none of it. Roya heard Ilay, and Ilay was hearing everything, and that was the whole of her instrument: a girl's ears pressed to the stone of the world, a blind woman's chalk, and between them a map that updated itself with the sound of boot-heels.

"Fourteen at the cathedral," Roya said to the runners, reading the slate as Ilay wrote it. "Miners, double file, freight way. Index squad of eleven on the tithe-stair, four minutes behind. Line to the second pillar, then hold. Suri holds. Nobody advances." She called positions off the girl's ears like bearings off a star, and the line moved in the dark the way ships move on soundings, and it held, and it held, and then the reliquary corridor began to sing.

* * *

The Choirmaster had held the corridor since the burning, and he held it now.

He was a gray stalk of a man with a wrist that had never forgiven Dar and a baritone the nursery choirs had once obeyed like weather, and his ground was the long reliquary gallery where the Church had shelved forty years of harvested voices in glass. The voices were gone — freed or silenced by the First Singer's release, the shelves empty, the glass dreaming — but

the corridor remembered them, and the Choirmaster remembered the corridor, and he had spent the year since doing what he had always done, which was keeping the dead's house ready for singing. The freed donors stood with him: thirty of the once-harvested, whose throats the Church had borrowed and whose voices had come home, shopmen and dockers and a needlewoman who had been a soprano and was again. They could not fight. They had never needed to.

When the Index squad's finding-song came up the corridor — the claiming-hymn's bars, hummed low, the fisher's bait, designed to wake the hymn-training in stock blood and call the children out of hiding like rungs waking in a ladder — the Choirmaster stepped into the gallery's mouth with his fire-axe grounded like a parade weapon, and gave his thirty the downbeat.

They sang back.

Not the hymn. Never the hymn. They sang the corridor — the old reliquary acoustics he had re-tuned shelf by shelf for a year, the resonances that made the bait-song scatter into harmonics and die, the dissonances that made hymn-trained blood roll over and take notice of nothing. The Index hummed to find children; the corridor ate the hum and gave back a wall of wrongness; the squad's own blood-sense went as blind as Roya's song-lobe. The bait was in the water, and the water fought back.

"Somebody," the Choirmaster said into the sudden wreckage of their song, in the melodic baritone that had once graded children like fruit, "has come to requisition voices in my corridor. The corridor is closed to requisitions." The axe came up off the stone. "Also, I keep the dead, and you are standing on their shelves."

They rushed him. Of course they rushed him; the Index did not retreat from acoustics. The first two went down at the gallery's mouth to the axe and the axiom of a man who had watched forty years of harvests and had exactly one lesson to teach about doors: that they close. The needlewoman and the dockers pulled the third into the lee of an empty reliquary shelf and sat on him, which was not in anyone's training, and the corridor held — bar by bar, wrong note by wrong note, the once-harvested singing the dead's house at the men who had built it.

They held. It was not enough. Nothing that night was enough; the night had been priced for more than anyone had budgeted.

In the niche by the down-shaft, Ilay's hands never stopped moving. GALLERY HOLDS. WRONG NOTES WINNING. MINERS PAST CATHEDRAL. INDEX BEHIND THEM. Roya read the slate as it was written and called the bearings down the runner-line, position by position, like bearings off a star — the only surveyor in Ashkarad mapping a battle she could

not hear, through the ears of the one child the battle was coming for.

The miners came through the cathedral with their lamps hooded and their picks shouldered, and the Index squad came on behind the wreck of its own song, and the clinic's line stood at the second pillar with the antechamber and the children and the door behind it, and the three of them met at the mouth of the vault — Gavel's greed, the Index's seal, and the clinic's counted refusal — in the one place in Ashkarad where every account ever opened came due at once.

The melee was short, and ugly, and administrative to the last: boots and lanterns and the flat crash of picks on stone, Suri's voice spending orders like coin, Dar's voice two galleries over telling someone to breathe the way he told patients to breathe while the world tried to bill them, Elias's lungs pulling the smaller children back along the antechamber wall, Mrs. Gable's storm-lantern swinging like a censer. A courier went down with a pick-butt across the shoulder and got up counting her own fingers, because that was the training now. An Index enforcer reached the second pillar, got one hand on Suri's ruined graft-arm, and left the encounter with a broken grip and a lesson about assuming the maimed are the spent. The line bent. It did not break. Somewhere above it all, the actual night turned on its wheels — the tide, the ration bells, the fleet's lanterns weeks away on the dark seabed — indifferent as interest.

And then a Gavel pickman, swung off his footing in the crush, flailed for balance, and his pick — the twin of the pick that had come back flowering, another head from the same quarry racks, another debt-hungry tool out of the same ration night — kissed the salt-glass door beside the flower-keyhole as he went down.

Hairline. A thread of fracture, off the fifth petal of the flower, four inches of bright nothing in the glass.

Every faction stopped. The pickman on the floor stopped, mid-curse. Suri stopped with an order half-spent. The Index squad stopped with its writ literally in its captain's hand. In the listening post, Ilay's hands flew off the stone and covered her ears, and Roya, who had no song-lobe to be wounded by it, felt it anyway, in the slate, in the floor, in her teeth: the crack had begun to sing.

Every crack sang. That was the horror and the anthem of it — not one voice but a choir of them, the fracture branching as it sang, hairline splitting into hairline, and each new thread of it carrying the lullaby in a different dead language. A tongue like water over slate. A tongue like the sound a bell makes falling. A tongue Roya's bones knew and her mind did not — the language of the First Burning, maybe, the language the Gardener's hands had signed in. Fourteen languages before anyone could count them, seventeen, twenty — the door's own deep

glass reciting its one song in every tongue that had ever been lost above it, soft as frost forming.

And every one of the languages was singing the same bar first. The opening bars. The child's thread. The four notes a petal had tapped against the far side of this glass a year ago, the four notes a faceless woman had hummed over a kitchen, the four notes the Church had spent forty years of harvested throats feeding down through the floor of the world. The door was not warning them. The door was not threatening them. The door was letting them hear, in every tongue that had ever been lost above it, exactly what it was — the lid, the lock, the lullaby's instrument — while three armies stood in the dark with their lanterns shaking, and no one — not the miners, not the seal, not the line, not the children — could make themselves move, or speak, or do anything but stand in the uncounted dark and listen to the smallest sound the war had ever made, which was the sound of the lid, very quietly, beginning to come apart into music.

CHAPTER 72

Inventory of the Dead

Triage is done by inventory. Ashkarad had always counted its worst nights that way — item by item, in the order the items could still be saved — and Dar worked the vault-mouth in the old grammar, sleeves rolled to the elbow, voice pitched flat and itemized, because a counted voice was the only lantern in the place that didn't gutter.

One courier, pick-butt across the shoulder blade, breathing clean; she counted her own fingers twice and made the total agree both times, which was the training now, and he passed her fit on her own figures. One Gavel miner with his palm opened to the bone by his own pick at the moment the singing started — splinted, billed for the thread, told to invoice his foreman and to lose the invoice. Two Index enforcers down at the second pillar: one with a grip that would never again close on anything softer than iron, one with a corridor's worth of re-tuned wrongness rattling in his hymn-trained blood, and to the second one Dar gave a clerk's diagnosis — not a fault of yours, rhythm interrupted — and watched the man decide to believe it, because a person will hold any ledger steady if you put something in his hands. The pickman whose pick had kissed the door sat where he had fallen with his hands flat on the floor, showing the stone they were empty, and when Dar knelt to look at his eyes the man said, in a whisper that had given up on being private, "I heard my own name in it. In one of the languages. It's a dead language and it knew my name." Dar noted the pupil response, noted the pulse, and wrote in his head, beside the man's trade and crew: exposed, once, to the interior — and left the line open, because there was nowhere yet to file it. Thirty freed donors, unwounded, hoarse, already moving through the gallery setting the emptied reliquary shelves to rights, because the Choirmaster's people kept the dead's house ready for singing even now — the Choirmaster himself among them, axe grounded, offering his ruined wrist for examination with the dignity of a man surrendering a monument, and declining treatment with the same breath. Fourteen stock children, accounted for. One storm-lantern, still lit.

The count was good. The count was clean. It was the kind of count a man could sign.

Then the crack exhaled.

It had been singing for the better part of an hour — the fracture branching hairline by hairline off the fifth petal of the flower, every new thread reciting the lullaby in a different dead language, soft as frost forming — and the cold came out of it the way owed money comes out of a hiding place: all at once, and exactly the amount. Not wind. A billow of vault-cold rolled up through the door's bright thread of nothing and into the antechamber, and

the storm-lanterns went out one by one down the line of the wall, flinched dark, like candle-counters reaching the end of a column. The stone frosted. The air itself took on a grain, a texture of absolute collection — the cold of a place where nothing was ever spent, because nothing there had ever belonged to anyone.

The children were asleep against the antechamber wall when it came.

Mrs. Gable had raised children through three purges, and she knew the arithmetic of a bad night better than any clerk in the city. She did not scream and she did not run. She spread her coat over the smallest three, dragged the storm-lantern in under her body where its oil would keep, and folded herself over the pile of them — a wall of one old woman going up between the children and the deep with the speed of a thing that had been built many times before and torn down twice as often, elbows out, skirt spread to the last inch of its cloth, everything she owned arranged into a roof.

Dar came around the pillar in time to watch the frost take her breath. It went through her the way the Church's interest went through a debt — quietly, by the terms, on the compounding date. He inventoried her the way he had inventoried everything that night, pulse, pupils, the white climbing the veins of her wrists like a bill filling in its copies, and there was nothing in the inventory to operate on. The deep's cold was not a wound. It was a repossession. By the time he had her shoulders off the stone the billow had passed on and down, receded through the crack exactly as it had come — the deep bills, it does not gloat — and under her body the lantern was still burning.

"Count them," she said. Her voice was already mostly ledger, flat, itemized, going out of stock. "The children. Count them out for me."

He knelt and counted. Fourteen, all present, all breathing, the smallest three under her coat with the frost of her heartbeat still on the cloth. "Fourteen," he said. "All present."

"Good," said Mrs. Gable, who had brought every tenant of her stair through three purges and a war of ledgers without losing one to the cold, and filed herself.

* * *

Mother Gavel came down the freight way an hour before dawn with two lantern-men and the flowering pick carried upright between them like a legal exhibit, and she surveyed the cracked door's leaking cold the way she surveyed a defaulted district: at arm's length, in silence, without once touching the asset.

She held her bare hand up in the leaking air and let the frost write on it — grey petals forming across her scarred knuckles, all pointing down — and she read them like a document,

turning the hand slowly as a clerk turns a page. Two hundred steps above her, in her counting-room, the pick she had confiscated stood in its corner with its grey bloom aimed at the floor, and the pickman who had swung its twin lay in her quarry infirmary counting backward from one hundred and nine, and his count had crossed below forty at the last threshold he was carried over, which meant the deep was billing steadily and the account was approaching delivery. Gavel recalculated. It took a long moment, and it cost her something visible: the flat ledger-page eyes narrowing by degrees, the way a rate narrows.

"A mine," she said at last, to no one, in the voice she used to close accounts, "is a hole with an exit." She looked at the crack, at the frost on her own hand, at the door that had been a door and was becoming a throat. "This is a hole with an entrance."

Her lantern-men turned their hoods toward Dar, waiting to see what the clinic would spend to change her figures. He had nothing to spend. The door was cracked, the cold was leaking, the singing was a lien with no maturity date, and somewhere on the dry seabed the wain was keeping its schedule; every number she held was already better than any number he held, and she knew it, and she let him know she knew it, by not once looking at him.

She ordered the withdrawal to the quarry without apology, apology not being a line item her books carried, and she filed the withdrawal correctly, too — not as retreat. "Order through debt," she said, turning to the stair, brass tube under her arm, "postponed." Her crews went up the freight ways with their picks grounded, orderly as a re-routed funeral, and the vault-mouth belonged to the clinic, the donors, and the dead.

The Index squad was already gone. The writ's hour had burned out at midnight, and conscription dies of its own paperwork on schedule; somewhere upstairs an auditor was already dating the re-file. They left the second pillar standing and the corridor humming with wrongness, and the only trace of them was one dropped glove, grey with frost, that nobody picked up.

* * *

Suri audited the cold itself before the shift changed, because unpriced weather was how the worst accounts opened. She held the clinic's one working pulse-reader in the leaking air at a body's width from the crack, and the machine, hand-cranked and honest, tried three times to file the reading and printed, on the third attempt, in its small stacked type: AMBIENT: COLLECTION IN PROGRESS. She chalked it into the night's column under EXPENDITURES — ENVIRONMENT: THE COLD, ONE OLD WOMAN, TOTAL — and ruled the line off with a straightedge, so that the figure could never quietly grow.

They carried Mrs. Gable up the 711 steps in relays of six, and the freed donors took the first shift, and the needlewoman who had been a soprano and was again carried the storm-lantern the whole way without once letting it swing, so that the flame would not be seen to bow in any direction at all.

The mourning was done the Ashkarad way, which is to say it was done in a book. There was no priest; the Church was a silence with a building on it. There was no hymn; the city had learned at last what hymns were for. There was a table, a lamp, and Suri opening the clinic's ledger to a fresh page with the flats of her thumbs, and the whole of the mourners' arithmetic going down in columns in her flat counted voice, because grief that is not filed is grief that can be repossessed:

GABLE — TENEMENT, SALTSTAIRS — DIED SHIELDING. ASSETS: FOURTEEN CHILDREN, ALL PRESENT. DEBTS: NONE.

Then her pen stopped, because the Ashkarad way was a line-item, a name kept, a debt recorded, and no form in the city had ever shown her the direction of that debt. She solved it the way she solved everything, by ruling a new column, and the rule of the pen was steady as a stair rail. OWED BY THE CLINIC: FOURTEEN CHILDHOODS. INTEREST: COMPOUNDING. TERMS: FOREVER. "We keep the name," she said, flat as a stamp. "Names are the one asset this city has never once debased."

Milla Ferun filed the death notice in her registrar's hand, ruled a line through the empty stamp-box at the bottom — no Heart-Stamp, no Debt-Stamp, no Voluntary-Stamp, just the clean strike of a clerk refusing a blank — and considered the space where the Church's forms had always wanted a cause of death in one word. Her pen hovered. She wrote THE COLD, and beneath it, smaller, where only another auditor would ever look: THE DEEP'S.

They buried her at the head of the Saltstairs, in the strip of cistern-garden she had kept like a boundary marker for thirty years, and the stock children stood in a row at the graveside in the order Mrs. Gable would have counted them, smallest first. The Choirmaster stood at the back with his hat over his axe. When the earth was done, one of the smaller children — a boy with perfect lungs and no idea yet what his lungs had been graded — said the only eulogy anyone dared: "She was like a grandmother to us."

Ilay, at the edge of the row with her chalk in her fist, went very still, in the way she went still when the walls said something worth writing down.

* * *

That night Dar went back down the shaft, because there was one more line in the inventory and he had not let himself count it.

The crack was still singing, though the languages were thinning now, a tongue at a time, like a choir going home. He stood at the door and put his eye to the four inches of bright nothing, and the deep breathed on the other side of the glass, slow, tidal, one beat behind his own heart and patient about it. DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS, the old margin said in his memory, because it counts back — and he counted anyway. He was owed one dishonesty, and he chose this one.

Through the crack, he counted the deep heartbeats, and got three.

Not three hearts. One heart, three chambers — each beat coming back in threes, beat, beat, beat, the way an invoice comes back in copies — vast, unhurried, and keeping its own books. He stood with his hand flat on the singing glass while the threes rolled under the city like patient freight, and beneath his counting hand, precise as a clerk correcting an underling, the deep counted back.

In threes.

CHAPTER 73

For My Grandmother

Ilay heard the ending before she had the beginning, because the deep was like that: it gave you the last page first and made you earn the earlier ones.

She had the ending for the length of one bar, on the third night after the inventory, at the deepest listen she had ever taken. Roya held the listening-post niche at the shaft head with the slate on her knees and the lamp turned low, and Ilay lay flat on the stone with both palms spread and both ears down, the way divers lie on sea-ice, and the true song came up through the world's floor and through her bones and she took it down as fast as her hand could move. Numbers for how many. Circles for how loud. Lines for how long. The notation was hers; no one had taught it to her; it had come up out of the same place the music came from, and Roya, who had once mapped the dreams of a god with a wired song-lobe and now mapped a nine-year-old's hearing with chalk, had pronounced it the best survey instrument left in Ashkarad and did not mean it kindly to the city.

The song was not the lullaby. She had learned that early, and it had cost the grown-ups a bad hour to learn it too. The lullaby was the thing the Church had spent forty years feeding down through the Choratorium's floor, the maintenance-song, the locking-collar's oil. The true song was older and did not go down; it came up. It was the song the garden sang when there was still a garden, and it had verses the way a ledger has pages, and the deep below the cracked door held most of it and hummed it in its sleep, and the crack in the door sang it in every language that had ever died up here, and the Sister below the door held the mother's line — the under-line, the harmony that was not a child's thread — and gave it to Ilay at the room's edge, softly, one visit at a time, like an heirloom being handed down a stairwell that had never once been swept.

The crack was her second teacher. Every language sang the same four opening notes and then went its own way, and each way of going was a lesson: this tongue held a verse against the beat, like a diver holding a stone for weight; that one let the ending fall off unfinished and expected the next singer to catch it. Seventeen languages, then twenty, then a number Ilay stopped announcing because Roya had asked her to stop announcing it — the slate could only hold so many columns. Ilay stitched. That was the work nobody else in Ashkarad could have done, and it was not talent; it was tenure. She had been listening to the deep since before she had words for steps and circles, and the deep had been listening back, and between the two of them a text was being assembled the way coral assembles — one deaf ear at a time.

Stitching it together was the work of two nights and one funeral.

At the graveside, after the earth was done and the columns were ruled, one of the smaller children had said the thing about grandmother — she was like a grandmother to us — and Ilay had taken the word the way she took everything, literally, and filed it. A grandmother is the mother of your mother. She laid the word against the music the way Vahid laid two ledgers side by side. The mother's line ran through the Sister. The Sister and the stock children rang like two bells from one cast; the music said so; it had said so the day she walked in from the flats. Cast implies caster. The caster of the cast keeps the garden. The garden's song was being handed to her whole, every verse, the mother's line included — and things handed whole to a cast, in every ledger she had ever heard described, were not performances. They were inheritances. The one who sang the mother's line was the eldest of the cast. The one the garden belonged to was the mother of the mother's line. The word for that was at the graveside, in a small boy's mouth.

She titled the score on the night she finished it, in her careful child's hand, block letters pressed deep enough to read by touch: FOR MY GRANDMOTHER.

Then she did the only thing a transcriber can do with a finished text: she checked it against the source. She lay down on the shaft-head stone and sang the score back to the deep — silently, all of it, verse by verse through her bones, no air, no sound above a whisper's ghost, the NO SONGS law kept in the letter and spent in the ledger — and the deep below took the verses one at a time the way a teller takes a stack of coin, weighed each one, found every verse correct, and returned them with the mother's line added underneath, entire, the way a bank returns a deposit with the interest attached. Nothing tangled. Nothing came back short. On the last verse the deep held the ending a moment too long — the hinge at the page's edge — and let her go, gently, like a hand opening.

Nobody corrected her. Nobody in the clinic had a correction that would not have been a lie, or a worse truth. Vahid read the title over his spectacles, opened his mouth, closed it, and went down to the still. Dar read it and stood a long time with the pages in his one good hand and his ruined nerves, and what he finally said was nothing, because there was no entry in any of his books that paid for what the girl had worked out by ear.

* * *

She asked him for her place on the climb at the shaft head, two nights before the dark of the ration-bell, with the rig's canvas snapping somewhere below and the cold room's law chalked at its mouth — NO SONGS / NOT EVEN HUMMING — which she could feel through the stone like a silence with teeth.

"I can come down," she said. "The music goes down better if I carry it. It doesn't tangle in me. It's never once tangled in me."

Dar did not answer at once. He had a surgeon's silence for diagnosis, and she had learned to wait inside it without counting, because he always paid the silence back with the true figure.

"The door is shared between two," he said at last. "That's the doctrine. Not two plus an instrument. A third voice doesn't make the chord richer, Ilay. It makes it a chorus. And choruses open from above." He crouched to her height, which he always did, which had the odd effect of making the refusal feel like a consultation. "Tally told me the door checks your company, not your fortune. If I bring you down and stand you at the door, the door will check whether I love you more than I fear what's under the salt. It will open on the answer. The answer is yes. I'm not spending you on a door."

"Isra spends herself," Ilay said.

"Isra's already down there half the week, and she knows the shape of the thing she's walking into. You know songs, and songs are what the other side collects." He tapped her chalk, once, gently, with one finger. "Bring nothing you cannot lose. That's the Sister's own instruction, and I'm telling you what it prices. You're the thing on that list."

Ilay considered it. She did not cry; crying was a toll and she had never located the booth. She re-filed. If the music could not go down in her, it would go down in the one who was already half of both houses. The score needed a carrier who climbed.

She went and found Isra in the clinic's warm room, sitting with the smaller children asleep against her sound side, the rooted petal at her collarbone folded closed like a hand. Ilay put the score into her arms with both of her own arms, all of its sewn weight — every verse, the mother's line included, eleven pages of numbers, circles, and lines in a notation no academy had ever certified — and Isra took it the way a diver takes weight, settling it, testing its balance against her own.

Then she wrote, slowly, the root-toll visible in the whiteness of her fingertips: THIS IS THE MUSIC. I WILL BRING IT.

And beneath it, after a pause long enough that Ilay understood the second line had been priced before it was written: CARRIED. NOT COUNTED.

* * *

Vahid distilled the last of it on the final night, down in the cellar where the fourteen cylinders sat spooled on their brass spindle like a century of held breath.

The protocol had been six vials once. One had gone into Elias's blood in the reliquary corridor and saved a boy's verse. The other five stood in their fleece sleeves, and Vahid looked at them the way a man looks at five arguments he intends to combine into one. One-handed, spectacles mended with wire, he ran the still hot and then hotter, rendered the five vials down through glass and chilled coil and charcoal, and decanted at the end a single dose, no larger than a thumbnail of night, in a vial he wrapped in wool and tied with wire. Twice in the work he stopped, because the last cylinder was on the spindle and Shirin's voice was mid-sentence in the machine's memory, and he stood with his hand flat on the boiler until the sentence finished, the way a man stands at a graveside he has dug himself.

"A single injectable silence," he said, holding it up to the lamp so the dark showed through it, which was the only way it showed anything. "The rest, from Shirin's own recordings — the silences between her words. I have spent five voices' worth of rest to make one rest, which is either wasteful or the only honest arithmetic left in this city." He gave it into Dar's hands and closed Dar's fingers over it with his own remaining hand. "It is not medicine for a hymn you can hear. By the time you hear it, the blood is already singing. It is medicine for the verse before the verse — the one the body learns and doesn't tell you. One dose. One bloodstream. It will not make a child deaf to music, boy; it will make her blood deaf to orders. Choose the bloodstream like you'd choose the last stitch on a wound you can't redo."

Dar tied it into the kit that would go down with Isra, next to the score, and weighted the two of them together in his hand — the song and the silence, carried by the same pair of arms.

* * *

Isra carried the sewn score from the night she took it on, but it went down into the world still lacking its last page — Ilay had held the ending out of the sewing on purpose — and the last thing it needed was not music.

She finished the last page at the shaft head, two nights before the climb, with Roya reading her hands, and the page held the closing bars — the true song's ending, which she had heard whole, once, for the length of one bar, and had never been able to shake since, because the ending was wrong the way a door is wrong in a wall. It did not close. It did not resolve. Every verse stacked on the verse before it, and at the end, where a song should sign off and go quiet, the notation ran to the page's edge and stopped against something that was not silence but passage — a hinge drawn in numbers, a door drawn in circles. The ending was not a close. The ending was where the song stopped pretending to be a song.

She thought about the ones who collected things. She thought about the slips on the clinic wall, priced and priced again, and the one that had gone away stamped RECLAIMED, and the

complete lullaby riding the road in the wain. Things that were counted could be collected. She pressed the chalk down until it squeaked.

On the last page, beneath the final bars, in her careful child's hand, she wrote the only instruction the score would ever carry:

the ending is a door. don't let them count it.

CHAPTER 74

The Gardener Names It

The rig sat over the salt-glass door like a confession booth built by surveyors: canvas and brass, a body's width off the glass, two chairs, one hand-cranked pulse-reader, and Vahid's law chalked across the canvas in letters a child could read from the stair — NO SONGS / NOT EVEN HUMMING.

Suri counted them down the way she counted everything, which was aloud, in order, without mercy. "Climbers: two. Pulse: his, hers, hers below, one beat behind. Song: none. Debts: current. Kit: one silence, one score." She had appointed herself the door's counter back when the door was whole, and the door was cracked now, and singing in dead languages through a thread of bright nothing, and she counted anyway; that was the whole of her doctrine. The kit went across Isra's body on a diver's strap: eleven pages of sewn notation against her sternum, and beside them, in its wool and wire, a thumbnail of night — the single injectable silence, the last distillation of Shirin Bahar's voice, insurance for a verse nobody had heard begin.

Above them, the clinic held the children and the lamps. Above that, the city. Above that, weeks out on the dry seabed, the wain kept its schedule with the patience of a lien. Dar took his chair. Isra took hers. Vahid put his one hand on the crank and did not wind it yet — "I want the fault before the reading," he said, "not after" — and Roya and Ilay stood at the shaft head with chalk and slate, mapping the climb the only way it could still be mapped, through the ears of a girl who heard the deep assembling itself for company.

The way down had taken them past the dead First Vessel's cathedral, because there was no other road, and Dar had not looked at it, and had looked at it the whole way — the ribs of it, the shelved dark of it, the face with its too many eyes all closed — because he had spent a year thinking of that place as a machine that had been shut down, and the girl behind him was carrying a song for a grandmother, and the arithmetic of the two facts had begun, quietly, to add. He had counted his steps instead, four hundred past the cathedral, and given the count to Suri at the junction, and she had taken it into her columns without comment, because some figures in Ashkarad were carried so they would not have to be said.

Dar closed his eyes and went down Mind-first.

The corridors were as he had left them: the four swept rooms where his spent treasures used to hang, the stair that had no number, the furnished door he had never built at the deepest

hall — and past it, the between-space, where the room they had built together stood furnished as a garden neither of them remembered. The chairs were still a bench. The table was still a planting-frame. The angles of the walls still held tended ground, rows that had never been planted here, arranged by a third heartbeat that lived under the floor like an ear pressed to a wall. The common property was on its shelf: the Blacktide refusal; the drowned flats; the memory of a faceless woman singing in a kitchen that belonged to both of them now and to neither; a brother's name, unspoken and unspeakable, held where only the room could reach it.

Isra was already there — she had gone down ahead, the way she always did, quiet as ballast. She stood at the room's far wall. There had never been a far wall. There was one now, and it was a door, and it was not made of anything; it was made of the seam where two silences fit, and Tally's hundred-year-old doctrine stood in it like a lintel: a door shared between two, opened from the far side by someone who knows the shape of your silence. Never by one.

They waited. That was the whole of the technique, and it was the hardest thing Dar had ever done in any Vein: to stand at a door with his hands empty and not spend, not pay, not force, not open — to be company, and let the door check it. Isra's hand found his. Her fingers were cold; the root-toll had been charging her all week, and the slate-lines had been costing more warmth each night, and she stood at the seam of their two silences like a diver on a ledge, spending the last of her body's warmth simply by being known.

The door opened from the far side.

It did not swing. It admitted, the way a host admits — and the shape that knew their silences was the shape that had been learning them for a year, one beat behind, tapping the offbeats, listening under the floor of the room they built. The Sister opened her own door from her own side, and the burned garden came around them like a tide: rows that would not take root, ash falling in a sky the color of a snuffed lamp, the white-gloved figure at the center going on with its endless tending, over and over, forever.

And the Eighth Vein opened.

Not in either of them. Between them. It came on like a graft along a seam — the place where his architecture ended and hers began knitting itself into a shared organ, a pulse with two addresses — and it hurt the way intimacy hurts when it is finally priced: not a wound in a body but a wound between bodies, closing over something that would never again be single. Two hundred steps overhead, in the rig, Isra's spine bowed and Dar's hands locked on the chair arms, and the hand-cranked machine that had printed RHYTHM UNRESOLVED for Dar's two hearts since the beginning of everything tried to file the new rhythm, and failed, and printed, in its small stacked type, the only honest entry it had: RHYTHM: HELD IN

COMMON. Frost came up through the rig's floor in matched rings, ring answering ring, one set keyed to his pulse and one to hers, and where the rings crossed, the frost made a pattern Vahid would spend the rest of his life failing to draw: nine points, every point touching every other. In the shaft head's niche, Ilay's hands flew off the stone and covered her ears, not because the sound was loud but because it was plural — the whole city, she signed to Roya's slate, has mouths in it now — and Roya chalked it, and looked at what she had chalked, and did not cross it out.

Every bloomed thing in Ashkarad opened at once, like a book.

The frost on the vault walls spoke first — grey petals turning from the stone like faces. Then the truce-petal in Dar's pocket, and Tally's token warm against his ribs, and the petal folded at Isra's collarbone, and two hundred steps up, in a counting-room, a confiscated pick with its bloom of grey pointing down. And beneath everything, far to the south, up through the stone and the salt and the long dead route, the Cow's moan arrived — the brass-and-glass womb in Gullet's carcass that had begged at shift-change for a hundred years — and for the first time in its bonded, burdened existence, the moan was articulate. The voice was one voice, and it came from all of them, and it was not the Lily's. Dar felt her then, felt her clench small and lean away inside his chest, every petal straining back from her own words — through her, not from her — and the voice that used her petals the way a stamp uses ink was dry, and vast, and patient, and warm the way a ledger is warm, from the friction of a century of entries.

"I am told you have opened the door between you. Good. Doors want keeping. I have kept mine alone for a long time."

"You sold me the last bars of my own song, by the way. I have them filed. I had rather not spend them."

The frost pressed a five-petaled flower into the rime, unhurried, the signature that was not a name, and then the naming came, entry by entry, in the cadence of an audit that had been running for a hundred years and was pleased, at last, to read one aloud.

"Beneath your salt sleeps my garden's heart. It was buried alive at the First Burning, when the world before yours was closed out, and everything I had tended was filed under loss. It does not wake, and it does not die, and it dreams, and it must go on dreaming, and everything I have done for a century I have done to keep it dreaming. It is called the Root."

"Above it I locked my daughter. The first vessel of that burned world — the last living piece of the garden — the lid that held the dream shut. The city was her collar. The harvest was her lullaby. Forty years of borrowed throats, fed down through her floor, one long song to keep the sleeper sleeping."

"My daughter is dead."

"You killed her kindly, which is the only way anything down there has ever been killed, and I have audited the mercy and found it real. But her death left the lid held by songs alone, and songs wear out. The collar is cracked. I hear it, in every language that ever died above it. I have heard it all the way down the route — through Lowmark's water, through the Vigil's glass, through the reef they render at Gullet — and I will tell you what I have told no one in a hundred years: I do not know how long a song holds a door. No one has ever let one get this far. I have come to collect what the books say is mine."

The burned garden stood still around them. Even the ash hung. At the center, the white-gloved figure had stopped tending, and its gloved hands hung at its sides like tools set down, and Dar understood, in the space of one skipped heartbeat, that the figure had been tending rows that would not take root because the Gardener had been tending rows that would not take root, and neither of them had ever once been able to stop.

Below the floor of the room, the Sister's under-line had gone silent — the mother's line, the harmony she had hummed since the beginning of everything — and the silence was total, a held ledger, an entire account paused mid-column. Then it came back. One beat late. Deliberate, exact, and off her mother's downbeat, the way a debtor pays a day late to remind the creditor who is keeping which books.

The voice did not take offense. Offense was not a line item. It filed the harmony's late return where all such returns were filed, and laid out the terms the way a creditor lays out terms — three entries, cleanly ruled, no interest accruing on any of them until the signature.

The whole city heard. That was the shape of it, though Dar did not understand the shape until later: the frost on every window in Ashkarad, the grey bloom on the Gavel's confiscated pick, the petals gone quiet in a hundred pockets and doorways and walls, all of them mouths for the same few minutes, and every soul in the city that was awake, and most of the souls that were not, received the entries the way a city receives a rain — at once, and where they stood. There was no reading to be served. There was no door to post them on. The city itself was the paper, and it had been fertilized for a hundred years against exactly this delivery.

"Plant the ninth. Your city blooms, the seed takes its Throne, and Ashkarad takes its place in my garden — fed, and free, and eaten last of anything alive."

"Burn the garden. The Root with it. Every seed in the world wakes hungry, and we discover together what hunger builds when nothing is tending it."

"Or rewrite the ledger. I do not know what that entry costs. Neither do you. Open it, and we will both find out — and I will tell you now, as one keeper of books to another: no ledger in

the history of keeping has ever closed without a life in it."

"You have until the tide forgets to come back."

CHAPTER 75

Terms on Every Door

The fleet came the way a debt comes: first the quiet, then the notice, then the men with the books.

Three weeks after the Gardener named the Root, the seawall watch saw the lights first, an hour past midnight — not the scattered watch-fires of an army but a grid, lanterns hung in ruled rows, mile on mile, laid out on the dry seabed where the fog-sea used to stand. Ilay heard it before the bells could be rung, from her window over the clinic, with her palms flat on the sill: not marching, she signed to Roya, not even walking. Adding. A sound like a city's worth of clerks wetting pens. Roya chalked the map of what could not be marched on, because nothing out there was moving except arithmetic, and by the time the garrison bells had finished arguing about which of them was authorized to ring, the thing had a shape.

The bells argued for a quarter of the night. That was the system's epitaph in miniature: three garrison towers, three jurisdictions, three chits of standing authority, and not one of them stamped for an event that had never been pre-filed — a fleet arriving on the seabed like an invoice laid against the horizon. The Index wanted the ringing held pending confirmation. The garrison wanted it held pending the Index. The ward bells wanted a payment account opened for the rope-wear. In the end a saltstairs child rang the sinner's bell at the top of the tenements, three strokes, unauthorized, unpriced, and the city woke to look, which was all the alarm Ashkarad needed and the only kind it had left.

Not an army. An audit.

The camp covered the seabed from the old tide-line to the horizon's rule: tents of clerks in ranks as straight as ledger lines, chimneys of sheet brass breathing thin smoke into the salt-dark, long open-sided sheds where bone tally-frames stood in racks like muskets. White-gloved auditors moved down the avenues at filing pace, pairs of them, stopping at each tent-flap to read, initial, and move on, and behind them in slow patrol walked ranks of the herald-chorus — robed, barefoot on the salt, spaced with the precision of pipes in an organ — humming, very low, in unison, a note that Dar felt from the seawall in his teeth and in the gravel-heart's scar and in the black lace under his skin: the pitch of a collection being scheduled.

And at the center, where an army would have kept its general, stood the wain.

It was the size of a chapel that had decided to travel. Brass ribs, lead-glass panels, a hull of banded iron, wheels taller than a tithe-barge's mast, and even at three miles, even in the dark, the light through its panels was wrong — a patient glow, like the interior of a reliquary, like something kept alive in glass and tended by the book. Around it, at a distance nobody had ordered and everybody observed, the camp's avenues bent slightly, as if the ground had agreed to circumnavigate the thing rather than cross it. Frost furred the tent-ropes of the whole camp grey, and every petal of it pointed at Ashkarad. Twice in the night, the wain's engine turned over — a sound like a hymn being swallowed — and the whole grid of lanterns brightened one step, all together, the way a ledger breathes when the ink goes down.

Nobody in the city attacked it. Dar understood the refusal without having to broker it, because he shared it: you do not attack an audit. An audit re-files whatever is aimed at it. It would have taken the militia's charge and entered it under EXPENSES, DONOR: ASHKARAD, and the charge would have been real, and the entry permanent.

* * *

The out-riders reached the tide-gates before dawn — six of them on the salt-hard mud where water had once argued with the walls, and five were clerks with canvas cases strapped to their backs. The sixth was a captain.

Bone-plate, and the mask smooth as a skull, and he stood apart from the clerks the way a signature stands apart from the body of a letter. Dar saw him from the wall through a garrison glass and felt the year of the prologue arrive in his stomach like bad interest: the same mask, the same stillness, the man who had knelt in a burning organ dock with Dar's blood on his gauntlet, tasted it, and pronounced his verdict — it chose; as it always does; the choir must be complete. He had not aged. That was the detail Dar's hands understood before his mind agreed to it: not one line different, not one plate re-set, a man filed under a permanence the city had no category for. The skull-face turned slowly along the seawall, reading the city the way a tuning fork is presented to its note, and did not look up, and did not need to.

"He's here for the choir," Suri said at his shoulder, flat, counting the out-riders' positions off the wall's shadow. "Not for us. We're the venue."

The out-riders did not attempt the gates. They posted one page on the tide-gate's customs post, weighted its corners with frost that grew through the paper like a biopsy, and withdrew to the camp at filing pace, and the garrison, to its credit and its shame, let them go, because the writ of every man on that wall said do not engage in the same handwriting. The bone-masked captain withdrew last, walking backward, the way sentries walk at a tomb, and he took up a station on the flats midway between the gate and the camp and stayed there, apart, facing the

city — and he would stand there, Dar would learn, all that day and the days after, posting nothing, reading nothing, collecting nothing. He was not a signature and he was not a clerk. He was the seal. And seals, Dar knew from a year of this city's papers, were what got pressed into you when the terms ran out.

* * *

By dawn, every door in Ashkarad bore posted terms.

Every door — the clinic's, the ward offices', the sealed wards', the Gavel's quota-house, the pump-works, the cistern-gates, the tenements of the Saltstairs from top stair to bottom, doors that hadn't opened in years, doors behind doors; the Open Counts counted eleven thousand four hundred and some before they gave up counting, and the count did not include the doors of the deep, where Roya reported frost on the salt-glass itself arranged in ruled blocks, like text, patiently waiting for someone to read it to her. The papers were grey stock, good stock, durable as tithe-contracts, and no one had seen them posted, and no nail in the city had been touched; the pages were pinned by their corners in frost-petals, grown through, pointing inward.

Dar stood in the clinic doorway and read Ashkarad's account, and the terms were everything the night had promised and the syntax made worse, because the syntax was kind.

The tribute was named in the first line: the stock children, entire, delivered to the wain; and the ninth seed, delivered in its carrier. The consideration followed in the Church's oldest generous grammar: in exchange, and for the term of the arrangement, a place for the city of Ashkarad at the tail of the pruning schedule, with provisions, with quotas, with the light of the bloom shared according to need. There were sub-clauses. There were always sub-clauses. The provisions clause ran to nine lines and provided, among other mercies, grain against work, water against work, and the continuance of the city's ration in the event of compliance — the Gavel ration, adopted whole into the Gardener's grammar, order through debt at a scale that made Mother Gavel's own books read like a child's abacus. And then the schedule itself, printed city by city, in an order that was not an order until you understood it was a queue:

LOWMARK. THE VIGIL. GULLET. SARN. WEEP. OSSUAR. HALLOWFEN. ASHKARAD — LAST.

Brack was not on it. Brack had been first, once, and Brack was now an entry in a tally-book's first line — PRUNED, PAID — and the absence of the name was the loudest thing on the page. The tail of the schedule was not mercy. It was the queue for the knife, and Ashkarad had been placed last because its seed had fled its carrier, and the Gardener's books had never once lost an asset, and the last city on a harvest schedule is the city that watches

seven harvests before its own, with provisions.

Suri read the due line aloud, because someone had to and her voice was the steadiest instrument left: "Payment due: the next tide." She looked at the sea's absence beyond the seawalls, the dry mile, the horizon standing where water should have been, and she did the city's arithmetic in one flat breath. "The tide has been going out since the day you walked out those walls. It hasn't come back. They're not naming a date, Mehran. They're naming a condition we already meet."

Dar walked the city all morning and read the terms eleven times, in eleven doorways, because he kept hoping one of the postings would differ, and none of them did — that was the point of them. In the Choratorium ruins, Mother Gavel read her copy once, with her thumb on the tribute line, and issued the only commentary her books contained: "Tribute lines are where they tell you what they're afraid to take." She ordered her crews to hold the water-works and the quarry and nothing else, and put her clerks to counting what a city eats in a season, because the terms said provisions, and provisions meant the audit was prepared to wait, and the Gavel had been waiting out sieges since before the Church learned to sing. At the annex, the Index re-keyed its pulse-readers against a hymn that had not yet been sung, and filed the terms as EVIDENCE, FOREIGN, PENDING — the machine in Seft's office printing the schedule over and over, as if repetition were jurisdiction. The Open Counts chalked the whole text onto the Choratorium's outer wall in Clerk Elara's hand, big enough to read from the funiculars, because their doctrine had never changed: a city that has read its own bill cannot be surprised by the collector. And in the reliquary corridor the Choirmaster took down his copy with his fire-axe's edge, carefully, the way you take a splinter from a hand you intend to keep, and read the tribute line twice, and said nothing all day, which from him was a paragraph.

* * *

The terms were countersigned at the foot of every page, and the signature was the last item audited, and it was wrong in the way a stamped form is wrong — perfectly, deliberately wrong.

Not THE GARDENER. Not the flower sigil that bloomed from a crack in the earth, not the left-handed flourish whose curls matched the mark that had signed nine cities a century ago — none of it. The signature block read, in a clerk's practiced round hand:

WARDEN OF THE RECLAIM, PER G.

Per G. The initial of something the size of the sky, initialed. Dar stood on the clinic step with eleven thousand pages of terms posted on eleven thousand doors around him, and understood that the Gardener had not signed at all — she had been signed for. Somewhere

under the sea that wasn't there, someone kept her mark the way the Church had once kept its stamps, in a box, in a drawer, issued to authorized hands; and the hand that posted Ashkarad's terms was authorized, and the authority ran down from the flower sigil through the office of the Warden of the Reclaim and stopped, like everything in this world's books, one initials-line short of a name.

"Bureaucracy," Vahid said, over his spectacles, reading the signature block with the expression of a man confirming a diagnosis, "all the way down."

CHAPTER 76

The Quarry Assembly

Mother Gavel prepared the pit the way she prepared a closing, because to her every assembly was a closing: the moment when everyone's numbers were finally on the table and someone had to initial.

Two days after the terms went up on every door in the city, her crews swept the fighting pit — the quarry, the old amphitheater her grandfather's grandfather had dug out of the salt rock when the Gavel was a crew and not an institution — and set it for the largest gathering Ashkarad had held since the Blacktide. Benches in tiers. Torch-baskets rigged with counterweights. Her own box at the floor's center, with the brass speaking-tube on its stand like a relic. She placed the factions by her own seating doctrine, which was credit exposure: the Index under Seft to her right, where she could watch his hands; the Open Counts under Clerk Elara to her left; the Hammers' remnant and the fog-sick in the cheap tier; the clinic's people where the light was worst, because Dar did his best work in the dark. She set no guard on the gates. Guards at the gates told the city the vote was rigged, and she needed the vote more than she needed her pride, and both of those facts went into her books as COSTS. The sea was still gone beyond the seawalls — dry mile, salt flats, the horizon standing at attention where water had argued for a thousand years — and the pit's own cisterns were under her seal, rationed by her crews, and every family in the benches had come up out of that arithmetic, and she knew to a bucket what fear of thirst does to a quorum.

She had read the fleet's terms with her thumb on the tribute line, and she had read the Gardener's three entries off the Choratorium wall with the whole city's breath held, and she had spent two nights reducing both documents to what she sold in her own pit: products. Three of them, cleanly ruled.

The chorus. Reopen the machine — rebuild the collar's song, harvest again, feed the lid its lullaby — and live as ordered livestock. She gave the product its honest prospectus: bread against work, organs against bread, forty years of borrowed throats, and the fleet takes its tribute and rolls on to Weep and Ossuar and the rest, and Ashkarad endures, curated, milked, and filed. Every family in the pit owned a piece of that product already. It had the market's one great advantage: it existed.

The bloom. Plant the ninth — force the Throne while the choosing was theirs — and be a Throne: fed, free, and eaten last. She gave that its prospectus too, because the Hammers' remnant was already selling it on the terraces in a cheaper dialect: no more ledgers, no more

ration, the city becomes a body that feeds itself, and the harvest queue comes for everyone else first. She noted in the margin what the prospectus did not print: eaten last is still eaten, and a city that is eaten last has seven neighbors' screams to watch first, and interest on dread compounds like everything else.

And the third product. Dar's. The unnamed one. He had been trying to articulate it for two days in doorways and cellars and her own counting-room, and she had watched him fail with something adjacent to respect, because she had seen a thousand men fail to name a thing they were certain of, and the certain ones failed the hardest. The third product had no name, no prospectus, no yield schedule, and one feature the other two lacked: it was the only one on the menu the Gardener had not priced.

In the infirmary above the pit, Sedge was counting. Nineteen. He had come down through the thirties and the twenties as they carried him from threshold to threshold; thresholds moved the number, and the assembly was nothing but thresholds. She had him placed where she could see his lips. A mine is a hole with an entrance, she had told the vault, and she had postponed; and now the fleet had come, and postponement had acquired a counterparty, and the only gauge she trusted of what the deep thought about all of it was a pickman counting backward with his lips moving like a man praying to a debt.

She rapped the tube once. The pit went quiet the way her ledgers went quiet, all at once, on her authority.

"The city is called," she said, and the tube carried her voice flat and enormous to the top tier. "Three products on the floor. We count them tonight."

* * *

The chorus went first, and it went the way the dead go, politely, with attendance. Dar had spent two days articulating his product in doorways and cellars and her own counting-room, and the city had spent those same two days rehearsing its objections, and the pit was where the rehearsals came to open.

Seft argued it as written — order, bread, the fleet satisfied, the children excepted by amendment, the amendment excepted by sub-amendment — and the pit let him run four minutes and then started drumming their heels, one heel at a time, a sound like rain deciding. The Index's own clerks would not co-sign it. Ten years of sealed wards and stamped lists, and when the product was finally on the table with the blood priced in, the men who had built the filing system looked at the collection line and would not hold the stamp. Elara did not speak against it. She simply stood, and read the tribute line aloud one more time — the stock children, entire — and sat down, and the reading did the work the whole Index machine could

not.

The bloom went harder, because hope always argues dirtier. The Hammers' remnant had the terrace, and the fog-sick had the grief, and both of them pointed at the same crack in the world: a city is a lid, the lid is held by songs, the songs are wearing out, and blooming at least makes us food that eats first. Against them stood the arithmetic nobody could unhear: the Sister's testimony, the granary chit, per the Reclaim — sustain the route. BLOOMED—TRUE THRONE, Isra's slate had translated once, means ripe. Eight cities had voted with their bloomers and been poured down the deep roads as feed. The bloom was not escape. The bloom was the harvest, self-served.

And the third product came to the floor, and Dar stood up in the bad light, and failed again.

He had the pieces. He had them all, and everyone in the pit could see him carrying them: the census of the willing, the medicine made from silence, the city that had counted its dead without the Choir's help and buried its old women by line-item and kept the names. Consent — he said that word, and the word went into the pit and fell like a coin down a dry well. The Hammers asked who ate under his system and he could not say, because the honest answer was he did not know what a city fed on consent ate, and no honest text existed. Seft asked who counted it, and he said everyone, which was either the first unpriced census in the world's history or a mob with a ledger, and the pit knew both readings were live. The Choirmaster — who had asked one question of this city across a harvest table, years and a broken wrist ago — stood up in the back with his hat in his hands and asked it again, quietly, without the tube: what is the city for? And the pit turned to Dar for the answer, because it was his product, and Dar looked at fourteen children who were not on the benches tonight, and at an empty storm-lantern in the clinic's window two districts away, and said: "For keeping." And it was true, and it was not a product, and the pit sat with it while the torches burned, and it would not close. Mother Gavel watched him fail to close his own sale and understood, in the ledger-way, what she was looking at: the first thing in her life's accounts that gained value every time it was refused, and she marked it unpaid and unsettleable, and hated it, and did not strike it.

They voted by chit and hand, both, because the Gavel trusted neither alone. Mother Gavel counted the hands herself, tube down, lips moving, Sedge's lips moving in the infirmary window above her in a slower count that no one was collecting. The chorus died in the low hundreds. The bloom took the terrace and half the fog-sick and died at the thought of seven harvests watched first. And the third product — refuse both, hold the city, name it later — climbed, and climbed, and stalled.

Nine short. Nine votes short of half the pit, with the abstentions burning unread in the Gavel's counting-box, and Mother Gavel looked up from her count and gave Dar the news the way she gave all news, flat, at cost: "Nine short. I don't round."

Deadlock. And deadlock, in her books and in the Gardener's, had a default clause.

In the infirmary window above her box, Sedge's lips stopped. Not the end of the count — the Gavel had audited that fear every night for a month — but a pause, mid-number, like a teller looking up from a ledger because the room's light had changed. She marked it. She had learned to mark everything the pickman did; he was the only instrument in Ashkarad that the deep read directly, and instruments, in her experience, were what you checked before you signed.

The pit began to understand what the default was. The terms were already on every door; unanswered terms collect at par; and the wain was on the seabed with its engine warm. Nine short. Dar stood in the bad light doing the arithmetic of a city that had come within nine souls of refusing the world, and somewhere below all their benches, under the salt, under the pit's old tally-scarred rock, the account they were all drawn on decided, for the second time in a hundred years, to turn a page.

The deep heartbeat skipped.

Every soul in the quarry heard it — not through the ears, or not only; through the benches, through the rock, through the fluid of their own bodies, one vast beat that failed to arrive and then arrived doubled, a stammer in the world's floor, and the Sister's counted total, two million six hundred and thirty-one thousand and some, gained its second missing entry in a century. The torches did not gutter. They bent. Every flame in the pit leaned seaward at the same angle, all together, a congregation of fire turning to face the water that wasn't there — toward the dry seabed, toward the grid of lanterns, toward the wain — as if the air itself had been drawn up into the world's lungs for the next word.

In the silence after the skip, in a quarry where nine votes had just failed to save anyone, a child's voice began to hum.

Elias. Perfect lungs. He sat in the third tier with the younger ones packed around him like a clutch, and he hummed the true song's first bar — Ilay's transcription, four notes, the opening of the thing the garden sang when there was a garden — and his voice did not go down through the rock or up through the collar; it went out, plain, unhurried, a boy's hum with nothing claimed in it.

No one stopped him.

CHAPTER 77

The Consensual Draft

The vote failed, and the city organized anyway, which was how Ashkarad had always done its accounting: the form denied, the substance filed anyway, in whatever book would hold it.

Suri saw the shape of it at dawn in the quarry's mouth, while the pit's chits were still being burned for warmth by the fog-sick. Elias had hummed four notes to a silent quarry and no one had stopped him, and the reason no one had stopped him was the reason the whole failed vote had already come apart: four notes of the true song, hummed by unclaimed blood, had done nothing. No hymn had woken, no reader had printed, no child had risen to the bait. The deep's own song, sung by consent, was the one music left in the world that did not bill the singer — and every soul in that pit had heard the nothing it cost.

Dar came down the tier while the torches were being doused, and he did not argue, and he did not articulate. Two days of articulating in doorways had taught him what the failure in the pit had taught the city: the third way could not be sold, because a thing that is sold is priced, and a thing that is priced is owned, and everything the Gardener's books touched became an entry. It could only be staffed. He struck the only three bargains the city had left on its books, and he struck them on the only terms Ashkarad had ever respected — work, price, and skill — and the striking took him the morning: Mother Gavel, for her part, got the water-works held and her crews' debts honored in any order that came after; Seft, for his, got the writ of conscription withdrawn by his own clerk's pen and the Index's readers pointed outward at the seabed instead of inward at the nursery; the Open Counts got the wall, and kept it. And the three mandates went out by noon, chalked under Elara's published terms where the whole city could audit them, and the city, which had failed nine votes short of saving itself, read the mandates and understood that the vote had been a form all along: Ashkarad had been assembling the third way for a year, one unpriced kindness at a time, and the only thing missing had been a book to hold it.

Suri took the counted.

She set the census up on the clinic stoop, because sanctuary had made the stoop the one ground in Ashkarad where names had never once been surrendered, and because Milla Ferun was already there with the registrar's table she had not stopped setting since the sister walked out of the sea-fog. Columns ruled in Vell's straightest chalk: the second copy going up on the counting-house wall as fast as the first went into the book, twin ledgers, no seal on either. Three columns, headed in the registrar's hand: SING. FIGHT. HIDE.

A census of the willing. That was the whole mechanism, and it was without precedent, and it worked by the one force the city's creditors had never once learned to collect against: people stood in line to be counted on purpose. The couriers signed SING first — forty of them by the second morning, Lena Vance's voice already carrying the word down the waterways — and the dockers signed FIGHT in blocks, whole crews with their foreman's mark first, and the tenement grandmothers signed HIDE with the competence of a trade, because hiding children through purges was a craft and they were its guild and they did not intend to be modest about it now. The lines crossed. The needlewoman signed SING and FIGHT. A Gavel ledgerman signed all three columns and Suri made him initial the overlap, because a mark in two columns was a promise twice and she collected promises twice. The freed vessels came with the guardians who had kept them through the purges, and signed SING in a cluster with their lungs' grades unread, because the census did not carry a stock column and nobody proposed one. Vell of Brack chalked her own consent on the wall-copy where a signature would go — a small tally-mark, one stroke, the first mark she had made for herself since her city stopped existing — and Suri entered it in the book as a name with no sound in it, spelled V-E-L-L, and moved down the line. Nobody was drafted. Nobody was asked twice. The Gavel crews signed as a block behind Mother Gavel's own mark, which she set down first, at the head of her crews' page, where a signature belongs.

By the third day the book had a body count of the living: two thousand one hundred and some counted, and the count not slowing, and Suri ruling the totals at each dusk with the straightedge, and Milla ruling beneath them the line the census had existed to make true: COUNTED — BY CONSENT — FOR ASHKARAD.

* * *

Vahid took the makers.

He took them the way he took everything, by lecture, assembling them in the cold cellar under the clinic — glaziers and chandlers, tallow-boilers and a lamp-oil refiner, four apothecaries who had kept their trade through the Chorus years by selling it quietly — and giving them the only inheritance he had left: Shirin Bahar's protocol, spoken aloud over her own cylinders, the chorus-free medicine rendered from the silences in a harvested woman's voice, scaled at last past six vials and one saved boy.

"City scale," he told them, and his wire-mended spectacles caught the still-light, and his one hand drew the runs of the apparatus in the air like a man conducting a foundry. "Which does not mean more. It means ordinary. The dose stops being a jewel and becomes a utility, like water, like lamp-oil; it is drawn, it is stored, it is rationed by the census. We are not brewing medicine any longer. We are bottling an absence, and the absence is the point."

They built it in three days. Still on still, coil on coil, the Choratorium's salvaged glassware traded back from the Gavel's salvage-crews at rates the Gavel's books called generous and the Gavel's face called nothing at all, because Mother Gavel had read the fleet's provisions clause and knew exactly what unrationed water was worth in six weeks. The cylinders played in rotation on the brass spindle, Shirin's voice running the numbers of her own silences into the batch, and the vials came off the line in ranks — hundreds the first week, plaited into straw baskets like lamp-oil, staged at the census's SING tables so that every willing throat would know where its rest was drawn from.

And the smoke came after the medicine, because the smoke was older. The Vigil's recipe — carried home in the party's packs from the walking city, the Silent Order's one gift that could be given without silence being broken — for a grey ash that ate resonance. Vahid's people built the censers in the Chandler's Row shops: squat iron pots on chains, smudge-fire packed with the ash of burned hymn-pages and lead-dust and salt, the Vigil's proportions, the Vigil's patience. One censer gave a room a rest. Ten gave a street one. The crews drilled the hanging of them on the clinic's roof until the smoke stood over the Saltstairs in a low grey lid of its own, and Ilay, hearing it from the shaft head, signed to Roya's slate the closest thing to approval the deep had ever offered the city: it sounds like snow.

* * *

Roya took what cannot be mapped.

Not the city; the city was mapped, was over-mapped, was chalked on walls in three hands. She took the deep vaults — the region no surveyor's instrument had ever honestly seen, the salt vaults beneath the Throne shaft where the lock-seals sat in their century of dark and the cracked door sang its dead languages into the cold — and she mapped them the only way left to her, which was the way she had mapped a battle in the dark: through Ilay's hearing, live, chalk in one hand, the girl's voice in her ear like a cable.

They worked from the listening-post niche and then below it, where DO NOT COUNT THE HEARTBEATS was scored into the old stone in its ledger-script that no one obeyed anymore because everyone was counting everything now. Ilay lay on the rock with her palms down and called the vaults the way soundings are called off a hull: seam, seam, pool of cold, seam. Roya chalked. Beneath the girl's hearing, all the while, the Sister kept her post — the pedal-tone, one beat behind the city's heart, holding her harmony under the numbers like a hand under a falling ledger — and Roya had learned to chart her too: the calm rooms where the pedal-tone rose, the rooms where it pressed down, the one corridor where it thinned to almost nothing, which Roya circled and labeled in her blunt capitals, DO NOT POST THE FLEET HERE, without knowing why she was sure, and trusting the surety, because for a year

now her surest instrument had been a child's ears and her second-surest was an exile's instinct that had never once been wrong about where the danger stood. What came up under her hand was not a map as the city understood maps — it was a score. The vaults' architecture was acoustic to its bones: every gallery a resonator, every corridor a pipe, every lock-seal a node where the deep's rhythm came up through the salt like water through a wall. She charted the leak — the cracked door's cold, its tidal range, the rooms it reached at slack and at flow. She charted the crack's languages by gallery, thinning east, thickening west, and marked where they overlapped into unison, because unison was load. And on the master sheet, in her blunt surveyor's capitals, she chalked the one finding the whole draft had been for: STANDING ROOM — WHERE A CHORD CAN BE HELD — and under it, circled, the antechamber above the door, and the reliquary gallery, and the long stair, and the pit.

The fleet wanted the children as tribute and the lid as collateral, and it had posted its terms in the city's own generous grammar. Roya chalked the city a different grammar — a survey of its own basement, hung on the counting-house wall beside Elara's published terms where anyone could read it — because her doctrine had never changed either: the unmappable is only unmapped, and the bill for leaving it so was already in the mail.

* * *

On the fourth evening the census's first page came up out of the book for certification — the signature page, the page that made the willing binding on the willing — and Milla laid it flat on the registrar's table, and the room of counters went quiet, because the first line of the first page of the count had been held blank all week.

Suri knew whose it was. She had been saving the line like the last unspent coin of a dead currency.

Milla ruled the heading first, in her registrar's hand, the only heading the signature would ever need: ASHKARAD — COUNTED. Then Ilay stepped up, last, in front of everyone, and she did not sign her name, because she had never once needed one to be exact. She took the chalk and drew, in the careful pressure she used for maps, a flower: nine petals — nine, and everyone in the room could count, and everyone did — and every petal connected to every other, point to point, a lattice that was also a bloom that was also, Roya saw from the back of the room, exactly the pattern the frost had made in the rig where two pulses had crossed.

Milla certified the mark with the registrar's hand, no stamp, and Suri ruled the page into the book, and the book took the weight of two thousand signatures and one flower without a sound.

The chord. Drawn by a child, on the first page of the first census in the world's history taken by consent.

CHAPTER 78

Her List of the Dead

Isra came up the shaft at the hour between bells, when the lamplowers were still arguing with the cold, and she carried the bundle against her chest the way divers carry their last breath — close, in both arms, as if letting go of it were a thing that happened to other people.

Seven hundred and eleven steps. She had gone down nine nights earlier with an empty satchel and a promise nobody had thought to ask her to make, and she had come back up with the satchel full and her lips the color of a ledger's margins. Suri met her at the shaft head, did the arithmetic aloud, because that was how she loved people.

"Nine nights in the cold. Writing." She took the bundle's weight one-handed and looked at Isra's blue knuckles, the frost-burn at the wrists where the root sat under the skin like a second pulse. "Sit down before I file you as an expense."

Isra sat. The bundle went onto the table between them, and it did not sit like cloth. It sat like a book: rectangular, cornered, sewn at the spine with sinew, the pages tallow-cured hide rubbed with ash-ink, and even before anyone touched it the room knew what it cost. Cold came off it in a slow fold, the way cold comes off a body that has stopped. Every stroke on every page had been paid for out of the writer's own warmth, nine nights of it, in the dark, seven hundred and eleven steps below the last lamplight in Ashkarad.

Isra let herself be steered to the stove bench and sat with her palms open toward the coals, and while the warmth crept back into her by visible degrees she watched the bundle the way a diver watches the surface — not with longing, exactly. With accounting. She had made an arrangement with the deep once, on the flats, out beyond the seawalls, and the arrangement had never once asked her for anything she hadn't chosen to give. Nine nights of dictation in the vault dark, the sister's cadence coming up through the stone like a pulse through a mattress, and Isra's hand keeping the record because Isra's hand was the only hand down there that could be paid in warmth and stay open. The root at her collarbone had drunk the dark and grown greedy, the way it always did below; the lamplight had taxed it, the way light always did; and between the two of them — the lamp and the dark — she had priced every page and paid it and gone on writing, because the voice under the world had said one thing the first night, and it had been enough.

WRITE IT TRUE. NO ONE ELSE WILL HAVE IT.

Suri opened the clinic book and ruled a line. "Gift, incoming," she said. "No debt column. Not yet."

* * *

They read it that evening in the cellar, under darkened lamps, with the doors drawn and the censers breathing their clean smoke. Dar at the table. Suri at his shoulder with the tally. Milla Ferun with her registrar's nib and the salt still under her nails. Vell at the wall with her chalk, taking the second copy stroke for stroke. Roya in the corner with Ilay, because the list was read twice that night — once off the page, and once out of the stone.

The pages were written in the dead language, the ledger-script scored a mile long on the flats, the script Dar understood without hearing. He had hoped, dimly, that understanding would feel like nothing. It did not. It felt like reading his own handwriting in a stranger's book.

The hand never varied. A century of discipline in nine nights of copying: every letter the same weight, every column ruled true, the dates entered not in days or moons but in counts — vast seven- and eight-figure numbers, each one a position in the deep heartbeat's ledger, each one a moment in the Root's long account. Milla converted nothing. "You don't translate a witness," she said. "You transcribe one."

Vahid leaned in over the first page with his one hand pressing the hide flat, and his spectacles down on his nose, and for a long moment the Professor of Impossible Anatomy read like a man reading his own discredited papers returned from the dead.

"Method," he said at last, half to himself. "Understand what you are looking at. She was filing while the world burned. Whatever else is down there, whatever it ate, whatever it lost — it kept books. Dates. Columns. A double entry, if my eyes are any use, and they remain my only remaining virtue." He tapped a column of figures with a cracked fingernail. "These are not annotations. These are balances. She has run the Root's account across a century the way a factors' house runs a freight ledger, and she has never once missed a posting. That is not the madness of a buried thing, boy. That is the discipline of a witness who knows the day will come when her word is all anyone has."

The names were cities.

Not the nine. Not first, anyway. The first pages belonged to a world before the Church, before Ashkarad, before salt meant grace — cities whose names went through Dar's understanding like water over slate, dozens of them, each with its date, each date a number in the millions, and Dar read them aloud in a flat surgeon's cadence because the alternative was to read them like an elegy and no one in the room could have stood that. Cities harvested into glass. Cities that burned. Cities whose names the script wrote the way you write a debt —

once, cleanly, and never again.

Vell's chalk slowed at the ninth page, and stopped. She looked at Isra. Isra looked at the wall, and wrote one word on her slate, and held it up.

TESTIMONY.

"She has prepared it for a trial," Dar said. The understanding arrived the way diagnoses arrive — all at once, with the history already attached. A century below, keeping the lid, counting the Root's heartbeats, watching cities die through the stone: and through all of it, the witness had done what witnesses do. She had kept exhibits. She had kept her counts exact. Because someday someone would sit in judgment — the Gardener, the fleet, the far cities waking, the city she had defected to — and she had wanted, on that day, to be able to open a book and say: here is everything, dated, entered, true.

"She expects to be tried," Milla said, not looking up. Her nib moved through a silence with forty cities in it. "Clerks always do. We prepare for the audit we deserve."

Ilay's hands were flat on the cellar floor. She had been still a long time. Now she lifted her head, and her voice came out flat and literal, the way it came when the stone was saying things through her, and everyone stopped writing.

"She says: someone will. She would rather it were us."

The chalk did not move for a while after that.

The nine came at the end, and the nine were entered differently — not as the dead but as the living, each seed's city named in the Church's own tongue, each with its date of planting, its date of blooming, and a third column Dar made himself read twice. Brack. Lowmark. The Vigil. Gullet. Sarn. Weep. Ossuar. Hallowfen. Eight columns read BLOOMED in the script he now knew better than his own. Brack's third column had been written in the fleet's grammar, learned secondhand down the deep roads, and it read the way the tally-book had read it from the first: PRUNED, PAID.

One city dead in this round, seven more ripe on the schedule, and Ashkarad's own column left blank — not VESSEL: FLED—RECLAIM, Dar noticed. The Sister's ledger had no such stamp. Her column for the ninth said only: LENT.

"Ask her," Suri said quietly, because Dar had gone still over the word. "Ask her what lent means, and when she wants it back."

Dar didn't. He knew lenders; he had been one's patient, one's employee, and one's thief, and every lender he had ever met kept receipts precisely so the question would never have to be asked twice. A lent thing is a thing expected back whole. He closed the page on the word

with more care than he had closed the pages of the dead.

But Ilay was already shaking her head, hands pressed harder to the floor, and what came up through her was not an answer about the ninth at all. It came slowly, in the Sister's own cadence, and Ilay delivered it word for word like a courier who knows the freight is fragile.

"If I go mad down there, sing the second verse, and I will remember I was loved before I was used."

Nobody spoke. The censers breathed. Vahid took his spectacles off, polished them on his cuff with his one hand, and put them back on, which was what he did instead of weeping; Roya's mask gave back the lamplight, blank as a filed receipt. It was Suri who moved first, because Suri always moved first when something needed to be entered before the room could talk itself out of it. She opened the census to its first ruled page, under Ilay's nine-petaled flower, and wrote in her flat clerk's hand a standing order, dated, sealed with both the sanctuary's seals:

THE CITY OWES THE DEEP ONE VERSE, ON DEMAND. SECOND VERSE OF THE GARDEN'S SONG. SINGER: ILAY. NO PRICE ATTACHED.

"The first unpriced thing we've ever owed," she said. "Keep counting anyway."

Ilay listened to something a long moment, then nodded once, solemn as a signature. "She heard it," she said. "She says the order is received." A pause. "She says no one has ever put her in a book that wasn't a cage."

Milla finished the page she was on before she spoke, because a registrar finishes her page. "Then she has never been read to," she said. "Only entered." Nobody answered her, and the nib went back to work, and the silence after it was the kind that files itself away to be spent later, when it will cost more.

* * *

It was Milla, transcribing the final page, who found the last entry — because it was the right shape to catch a clerk's eye. Not a city. The grammar was wrong for a city; it had no harvest columns, no bloom date. It was a single name in the dead script, short, and beside it a date from deep in the first million of the Root's count, a century old and more.

"The carrier," Isra wrote, before anyone could ask. "The first one. The one who fell."

The boy with the lantern, Dar thought, and did not know where the image came from — a fog, a light going down, an old grief that was not his and was. The Lily did not stir. That was the strangest thing. He had learned her moods the way he had learned his own pulse, and at the name on that page she went altogether still, in the way of a thing that has heard its own history

read into the record.

Beside the name, in the same disciplined hand, the same ash-ink, the ink still smelling faintly of the vaults — added after a century, and the warmth-cost of three words paid as recently as nine nights ago, three words that had no business surviving a hundred years of ledgers:

He did not die.

Suri looked at the entry, then at Isra, then at the entry again, the way she looked at a column that would not balance. "When," she said. Not a question; a requisition.

Isra turned the slate, wiped it with her sleeve, wrote slowly, letter by letter, paying the warmth as she went.

SHE ADDED IT EIGHT NIGHTS AGO. THEN SHE LET ME STOP.

The lamps burned. The censers breathed. Seven hundred and eleven steps down, something that had spent a century keeping the only true books in the world sat behind a cracked glass door with her testimony finished at last, her exhibits in order, her count exact — and the last line of the ledger she had kept against the day of her trial said that the boy who fell did not die, and none of them knew yet what that was going to cost.

CHAPTER 79

The First Carrier

The white flag went up at the tide-gates an hour after dawn, and it was a glove.

Dar saw it from the wall through a courier's glass: a single white glove on a surveyor's pole, bone-pale against the dry seabed, fingers spread in a wind that had no business smelling of salt that had never been seawater. Parley law was older than the Church — a flag of truce meant the bearer's books were closed, and the bearer walked unspent — but no flag in Ashkarad's living memory had been made of a glove, and the gloves of the fleet had been the last thing Vey's hands wore, and the last thing the Gardener's hands wore in a dream that did not belong to him. Suri stood at his shoulder and read the pole the way she read everything.

"They're telling us whose errand this is," she said. "Not whose war. Whose errand."

Two days had passed since Milla's nib had stopped on the Sister's final page, and Dar had spent them with that last line open on the table, reading three words until they stopped being words. He did not die. The carrier. The one who fell. And now a glove on a pole, and a figure walking up the dry seabed toward the gates at a clerk's pace, unhurried as a due date.

"You know who that is," Suri said. She wanted it said under seal, between the two of them, before the gate opened and the record began.

"The list says he didn't die."

"Witnesses get things wrong," Suri said, and did not believe it, because a counter's first duty is to keep both columns open until the figures come in. "Rule: nobody answers a question we haven't priced. Whatever's in the barrel — we look with our hands still."

The gate-readers clattered and printed their empty slips, then went quiet as the figure approached, the way machines go quiet in a sickroom.

The Lily had been leaning toward the sea for a week. Dar felt her through his ribs the way you feel a dog lean against a door — weight without motion, wanting without words. He had learned not to call it hunger. It was older than hunger. It was the pull of a thing toward the first hand that ever carried it, and it terrified him more than the whole audit fleet, because wanting was not in her vocabulary, and had not been since the Blacktide.

"Stay at the gate," he told her, or told his own sternum; the distinction had stopped mattering a year ago. Then he went down to the tide-gates, with Suri and two couriers and the law of the flag, to meet the boy who fell.

* * *

Wen came through the gate-shadow like an entry being posted.

He was a century old and it had happened to him the way interest happens — everywhere and nowhere at once. A clerk's coat, brushed, mended at the cuffs with thread that matched. A ledger-barrel hung on a shoulder strap. His face was forty and a hundred at the same time, a face audited by something patient: the left side smooth, the right side gone fine-grained as the cover of an old account book, and at his collar, climbing out of it like ink through blotting paper, black lace. The lace stopped midway up the throat. It had stopped, Dar understood at once, the way a stopped clock is right twice — not finished, not reversed, frozen at the filing.

Behind him, two tally-bearers with a folding desk, which they set up on the gate-stones with a click of brass feet, and squared, and stepped back from.

"Warden of the Reclaim," Wen said. His voice was mild, rounded at the edges, the voice of a man reading terms aloud to a room he has already measured. "For the fleet, per G." He laid a docket on the desk and turned it so Dar could read the signature line: WEN, WARDEN OF THE RECLAIM, PER G. "You will want to know who G is. I have wanted to know for a hundred years. The hand signs; I am per someone. Everyone is per someone. It is the oldest mercy in bookkeeping." He sat, and folded his hands, and looked at Dar with the unblinking patience of an adding machine. "Darius Mehran. Carrier of the ninth. Account nine, closed at the counter's fee. You funded our lamp-oil, cutter. The books were grateful. I am here to see whether you would like to be."

Suri's breath went out slow through her nose. Dar kept his eyes on the lace at Wen's collar, because a surgeon triages what he looks at, and looking at the rest of that face was not yet triage.

"You've come about the terms," Dar said.

"I've come about the mercy." Wen opened the ledger-barrel with a small brass key, and the smell that came out of it was wax and salt and something under both that made the Lily surge so hard against Dar's ribs that he put a hand flat on the gate-stone to stay upright. "The posted terms stand — the stock children, the ninth seed, tribute at the tail of the schedule. Kneel, and the tail is honored. After Hallowfen, after the Vigil, Gullet, Sarn, Weep, Ossuar. A generation, more or less. Perhaps two. The road is slow, and the books can be kind when the collateral behaves. And there is an enclosed kindness, which I am instructed to deliver with the offer."

From the barrel's depths, wrapped in wax-cloth and packed in a nest of choir-glass, he lifted a case and set it on the desk and opened it.

The heart beat.

It was small, and red-gold, and whole, and it beat in its glass with the steady importunity of something that had never once been inside a body — and Dar's two hearts stopped and restarted out of rhythm, because he knew this organ the way you know a photograph of yourself as a child. His. Regrown in a vat under the Choratorium, offered once across a dining-hall table by a woman who wore white gloves, priced at one child; kept beating since by hands unknown, on someone's books, in someone's dark. A pulse-slip was pinned inside the lid. RHYTHM: STABLE, it said. ASSET: ORIGINAL. HOLD.

"Collateral," Wen said, "restored upon compliance. It has been kept warm, cutter. It has been kept, which is more than most things in Ashkarad can say. Kneel, and it goes home into the chest it was grown for, and the schedule waits a generation at the tail, and the stock children grow old. It is, I am given to understand, the best paper anyone will ever offer this city." He waited, hands folded. "I am required to wait while you consider it. I am not required to pretend I hope."

Dar looked at the heart for a long time. The Lily pressed against the gate of his ribs and did not make a sound, which was worse than any sound.

He made himself do the triage out loud, because out loud was the only ledger Suri could audit. "It's bait. It's my own heart, and it's bait, and the hook is that it's my own heart."

"Yes," Suri said. "And if you kneel, the hollow gets everything in it eventually. That's what a tail is. Decline the paper, and decline it fast — looking at your own heart on a desk is worse than looking at a debt. At least a debt was never his."

"Brack knelt," Dar said. "Or knelt fast, at any rate. Read me Brack's stamp."

"PRUNED, PAID," Wen said, without hesitation, without inflection.

"Then the tail is still a collection point, and time is your interest, not ours." Dar closed the case, gently, the way he closed a chest after telling a family. "We've read the schedule. We decline the mercy. File the refusal."

Wen inclined his head a precise half-inch. "Refusal, noted." And then, mildly, terribly: "The books prefer refusals. They compound." He rose and gave the gate the courtesy of a man leaving a hearing he had already recorded. "The offer does not expire. But the tide will remember itself, and when it does the fleet stops offering courtesies, and I stop being the one who walks up under a glove. Whatever you are building in that quarry — build it before the water."

* * *

The tally-bearers packed the desk and the barrel, and the heart went back into the dark of it, beating, filed, held. Wen waved them on and did not follow. He stood instead with one hand resting on the folded case, and something moved through the mildness of his face like a line of figures refusing to total.

"You are reading me," he said. "You have been reading me since I sat down. The lace. The age. You have a witness below who writes in the old script, and her list came up the shaft two nights ago, and the last name on it is mine — I know, because I have carried that name on my own roll for a century, filed under her, and eight days ago the entry acquired an amendment that I did not file." He looked at Dar. "You are trying to make me an entry, cutter. Let me save you the ink. I am the first carrier. I was nine years old, and I fell, and it left me."

He drew his collar aside with two fingers, unhurried, clerkly, and showed them.

The scar sat below the lace on the right side of his chest: five petals, gone white with old tissue, arranged around a hollow the exact shape and size of a keyhole. A flower-keyhole. The same mark the salt-glass door wore, cut small and personal into a man. Dar had seen that geometry once before, chiseled into the deep glass of the world's lid, and it had been a lock. On Wen's chest it was a socket. An absence with a flower around it, a century old, and the hollow had never filled.

"She slept there," Wen said. "Nine years. I carried her the way you carry the only warm thing in the world. Then the road took me — the fog, the cold, a lantern going down — and she woke, and she looked at me, and she fled." His voice stayed level; that was the worst of it. Nothing in the man accused. He stated the century like a balance brought forward. "The Gardener's books kept me. A pulse entered in error is still an entry; a life filed wrong is still a life, and mine has been amended daily ever since — kept alive on margin, serviced, maintained, audited. I am her first failed key. I jammed. Everything since — the choruses, the schedule, the wain, this courtesy — is an attempt to file the correction."

The Lily's hum rose in Dar's bones, half a step, and wavered there — pressed against him, against the gate, toward the man with the keyhole in his chest — and did not go to him. It could not be called unwilling. It was more terrible than unwilling: it was the sound of a thing that knew exactly what it had done, a hundred years ago, in the fog, to the boy who loved it, and had lived with the entry ever since, in a ledger it could not write in.

Wen closed his collar with two fingers. He looked at Dar the way an auditor looks at a balance that is true and wished it weren't.

"Did it ever sing for you?" he asked. Quietly. No weight anywhere, except all of it. "It never once sang for me."

And there it was — not a demand, not a threat, nothing the law of the flag could govern, nothing the census could count. Just the one question the century had left in him. Dar opened his mouth, and the honest answer was already in it, filed and stamped and true: yes — in a stolen reliquary's crack, in a cellar's dark, in his bones every night since the Blacktide, a hum with a lullaby in it, a voice that had said mine and meant it. He could not say no to this man. He could not say yes to him either. The words stood in his throat like a debt he had no account to charge.

Wen read the non-answer the way he read everything, easily, expertly, to the end of the line. Then he shouldered his barrel, took up his pole with its white glove still spread against the sky, and walked back down onto the seabed, unhurried as a due date — and the Lily, pressed close against Dar's ribs the whole long way home, never made a sound.

CHAPTER 80

The Hymn in Every Throat

The warning came up from the wall at the hour when Ashkarad is at its smallest, and it came through a girl's ears and a blind woman's chalk.

"They're tuning," Ilay had said, hands flat on the attic stones, an hour before the fleet did anything at all. "Down on the flats. Lots of them. They keep finding the note and letting it go. Like when the Choirmaster makes a choir breathe before the downbeat." Roya had chalked it out in bearings and intervals — the sound of a chorus finding its band, plotted street by street — and carried the slate down three flights to the cellar where Vahid was working, and Vahid had read it and gone very still, and then very busy, in that order, and both states had lasted the rest of the night.

He had one hand, round salt-scoured spectacles mended with wire, and the largest pharmacy in Ashkarad's history, and he had known for two days that the arithmetic was going to come up short. The chorus-free distillation was made for throats you could reach: eleven vials' worth of Vigil ash and Shirin's silence, drawn off in measured rests, enough to dose a corridor, a refinery shift, a column of children. It was not made for a city. It was barely made for a district. And the hymn — the claiming-hymn, the compliance-song the Church had spent forty years and four generations planting in stock blood, verse by verse, grading day by grading day — was not in eleven children. It was in every throat that had ever learned it. School halls. Orphan wards. Tithe-clinic waiting rooms where the humming came free with the numbering. A city's worth of sleeper-training, lying in the dark of ten thousand chests, waiting for a verse to wake it and find out what it was worth.

"You cannot out-sing a summons," he told the censer crews in the pre-dawn, walking the line of them with his one hand and his cane and his lecture-voice, which had never once in his life managed to sound calm for its entire duration. "A summons is served on the blood, and the blood has been paying instalments since before most of you were weaned. What you can do is stand between the summons and the throat. You are not soldiers. You are aerosol. Smoke the corners. Keep the rests alive in the air. And when the verse comes down the street, you will want to sing along — some of you will have to want very hard not to — and if you feel your own mouth opening, you will bite down on the count and breathe the censer. We are the rest in the music. The rest is where the music keeps its promises. Go."

They went. Suri stayed to the last, with her breath-book already ruled up — she had begun ruling it at midnight without being asked, columns for every censer post in the district, because

she had done the same arithmetic Vahid had and reached the same shortfall and had started, in her flat way, to ration the future. "Smoke's a supply," she said. "The moment it's a supply it's a ration. I'd rather we did the counting than the smoke."

"Suri," Vahid said, "if we live through the morning, I will write a lecture about you."

"File it," she said, and went to her posts.

* * *

The herald-chorus sang at first light.

It came up the dry seabed in ranks, a thousand voices to a clause, and the storm-walls took it the way the Church had always intended its city to take a song — the locking-collar's own engineering, the walls and flues and stairwells of Ashkarad conducting the hymn inward, room to room, floor to floor, until the city was an instrument and the fleet was playing it. The activation verse did not need to be loud. It needed to be correct. It walked through stone like a name through a roll.

Ashkarad woke mid-bar.

A cobbler at his last straightened with the awl still in his fist and sang the second line without knowing his mouth was open. A crane-girl on the grain spouts sang down into the fog-hazed streets, her pitch true, her grade finding itself. A bell-ringer in the Marrowworks hung off his rope with both hands to keep from lifting them and had to wrap the rope twice around the beam and sit on it. Milla Ferun, at her desk with the sanctuary census under her hands, felt her stamp-arm lift and keep time — four beats, down, four beats, down — and pinned it to the wood with the other hand and sat on it, sweating, while her own chest hummed a tune she had learned at eight years old in a numbering line. All over the city, in beds and doorways and cistern queues, children stood up in their sleep and sang. That was the sound the pre-dawn had been built for: not fear, not pain — compliance. A thousand small voices rising in unison out of their own dreams, obedient, accurate, graded.

The eleven woke in the clinic's upper ward with the first verse already in them. Elias came up out of sleep with his lungs full of the hymn and his body halfway to standing before he knew it, and what he felt then he felt with a precision the Church had paid for: every verse landing in his blood like a key finding its ward, the tune pulling, the chest answering. Around him the younger ones were already up, eyes shut, faces calm as a filed form. Vahid came down the stair two at a time with a numbered vial in his teeth because his hand was full of three more.

"Not the little ones first," he said, to himself, to Elias, to the world. "The little ones are the point of the exercise. Elias — you know the way."

Elias knew the way. He had walked it in drills and in dreams: the salt-tunnels, the old cuttings under the district where the salt ran dead and the air stood still, the routes Ilay had mapped and the couriers had chalked, leading down and out beneath the reach of the conducted verse. He got the smaller children up, and counted them, and went.

* * *

He led lungs first, because that was the deal he had made with himself in the drills and it was the only one the tunnels honored.

The dead salt cut nothing off cleanly; it thinned it, verse by verse, the way distance thins a bell, and the thinner the hymn got the harder the little ones pulled toward it, throats itching, feet turning wrong at junctions, one girl singing the third line in a whisper before Elias caught her chin and tipped it up and made her breathe instead. Four counts in, two held, four out. He had the best lungs in Ashkarad — the Church had graded them perfect, and the Church graded true — and he spent them like a man who knew exactly how much he had: breathing for two, then for three, setting the count so the smallest ones could ride it, keeping them ahead of the verse through the wet dark, hand over hand along the chalked arrows, until the walls stopped humming and the air went still and old and tasted of nothing at all, which down there was the taste of safety, and the hymn was a rumor behind them.

Twice the verse caught up with them at a junction, coming down a vent-shaft thin as a whine in the teeth, and twice Elias stood the little ones still and breathed at them, loud, ugly, arrhythmic — his own breathing made deliberately wrong, a noise no hymn could ride — until the whine lost its grip and passed over like weather.

"He counts like Suri," the needlewoman who had come down as a second pair of hands said later, wondering. "Out loud. All the way."

"He counts like somebody who was graded," Elias said, and counted.

They came up out of range at the heat-berry shelves in the old cistern-farm, thirty-one children and two babies, blue-lit and breathing, and Elias got them sat against the warm stone in a circle and taught them the only lesson that had ever been free in Ashkarad: you are not your throat. Above them the city rang with the fleet's choir, and not one voice down there in the blue dark joined it.

* * *

In the streets, Vahid fought the hymn verse by verse, and lost, and lost, and won.

The second verse came down and the censer crews answered with smoke, the ash-recipe's vast neutral rest rolling through the tenements, and whole streets went toneless in the middle of the hymn like pages torn out of a choir-book. The third verse came down and Lena Vance answered, her freed voice climbing the drainage canals the way it had screamed warnings once, and behind her the canal-singers — the once-harvested, the freed donors whose throats the Church had borrowed and the First Singer's song had given back — rose out of the walls in counter-harmony, under the streets, through every grate and culvert, singing the claiming-hymn wrong on purpose, bar by bar, flat by flat, until the activation verses came apart into their components and could not resolve. It was the Choirmaster's arrangement, though his name appeared nowhere on it: the baritone in the reliquary gallery giving the downbeat along the culvert-lines his corridor had re-tuned all year, the corridor's wrongness propagating outward through the waterways like a scandal. The Church had built the canals to carry hymns inward. It had never considered what one of its own choir-masters could do with the same plumbing in the other direction. The fourth verse came down and Vahid himself stood in the clinic doorway with his one hand on the frame and his spectacles flashing, dosing the nearest sleepwalked singers with the needle-silence, one throat at a time, methodically, the way he had once graded anatomy, refusing the hymn with his whole furious body and never once singing.

The final verse needed the full chord. That was its flaw and its honesty: the claiming-hymn had always been written for a complete roll, every graded voice in the register, and this city's register had been spent — the nursery emptied years ago, the eleven underground, the smallest children out of range in the cistern dark, the streets smoked toneless, the canals singing back. The chord reached for its missing notes and found the rests where they should have been, held a moment at the top of its reach like a hand closing on nothing, and broke.

It broke the way debts stop. No crash. Just an absence where a sound had been, citywide, total.

The herald-chorus withdrew in step, unhurried, ranks folding off the flats the way a clerk folds a completed docket. That was what wrong-footed everyone — no retreat, no rout, no fury. The tally-bearers had never stopped writing. They had walked the whole engagement with their books open, and they withdrew with them full.

"They were never trying to take the children," Roya said. Her voice through the mask was tin and level, and everyone at the shaft head heard the arithmetic under it. "They were appraising them."

The chorus-free crews stood down. The city counted its children, and its throats, and the census came home by districts: every throat in Ashkarad that had woken and sung, entered

somewhere — the fleet's tally-books now held the pitch, the grade, and the address of every sleeper the Church had ever trained, a complete audit of who in the city could sing, taken in one morning, paid for in one morning, and Ashkarad had spent that morning saving its children from the harvest without once noticing that the harvest had come and gone already, done, invoiced, complete.

CHAPTER 81

Read Aloud

Suri had watched the fleet's tally-bearers walk the hymn-morning with their books open, and she had understood the shape of the trap before the last rank had folded off the flats. You did not defeat an audit with defiance. Defiance was a fine feeling and it compounded like everything else. You defeated an audit with provenance — you attacked the paper the appraisal was made on.

The fleet had spent one morning appraising Ashkarad's singing blood. Appraisals rest on ledgers. The ledgers the fleet had inherited from the Church were the same ledgers Ashkarad had lived under for forty years, and Suri had spent her whole life inside those ledgers — sold, resold three times, retired, burned — and she knew them the way you know a house you grew up in. She knew which rooms were real. She knew which rooms were drawn on the plan and never built.

So she went to the council with a motion that cost nothing and could not be refused, which was her favorite kind, and she drafted it in the grammar of the thing they were fighting. The fleet's terms — the stock children, the ninth seed, tribute at the tail — were prices. Prices presumed valuations. Valuations presumed records. Therefore, the motion ran, before any valuation of Ashkarad's collateral could be entertained by any party, the underlying record would be read into the public account, in full, aloud, so that buyer and seller and asset alike stood on the same page — and if the record proved unsound, then every price built on it fell with it. An audit could refuse many things. It could not refuse an open book. That was the whole disease and the whole cure of bookkeeping, and she had learned it from the inside, in a numbering line at eight years old.

"For three days," she announced in the quarry, from the floor of Mother Gavel's pit, to the assembled crews and the gallery and the Index's observers and the fleet's own distant lenses, "the clinic will read the Chorus's books aloud. Every page. Every name. Every Voluntary consent. You cannot unring a ledger that has been read out loud, and no audit on that seabed can price a city on paper that dies in the open air."

The couriers posted the hours on every door in the city that same night, next to the fleet's posted terms, lower and to the left, the way a correction runs under an error.

Mother Gavel granted the floor with a nod that moved one scar no more than a coin moves. "Truth's free," she said, flat as ever. "I'm supplying the acoustics."

* * *

The first day was the rescued pages — the name-pages the couriers had dragged burning out of the census halls a year ago, Suri's salvage, kept in the sanctuary's sealed shelves — and the reading of them was Suri's own, because she had led the smoke teams and she owed the names that debt. She read debt after debt in her counted voice: sums, dates, resales, the interest columns that grew while the debtors slept. Once she reached a page with her own graft-number on it — the page that should have been ash in a clinic stove, retired, the column at zero — and she read it the same as all the others, flat and exact, and did not once look up, and the pit let her have her privacy in the only way a crowd can grant it, by being silent enough to count as no one watching. The crews who had spent decades collecting those debts stood and heard them itemized, and the itemization was worse than the collecting, because collecting never showed you the whole book.

The second day was Milla's.

She took the registrar's stand with the coil of her printout in its oilcloth, and read the first pull of the RHYTHM UNRESOLVED machine aloud — the two rhythms, the fault-strike, the destruction-order number — into a silence that leaned toward her like water toward a drain. She read the order that had commanded her to burn it. She read the date. Then she told them, in the voice of a clerk reading minutes, what she had done instead: copied, kept, carried the true original sewn into her coat lining through a year of audits, purges, and bounties, salt in her nails the whole while.

"An anomaly is only a fault," she said, "until someone keeps the receipt. Then it's a record. I am the record."

Then she did the thing Suri had spent two nights coaching her on, and did it with a clerk's merciless economy: she dated the forgeries. The Voluntary consents came off the shelf, hundreds of them, and Milla walked the pit through the ink, the stamps, the hands — one consent signed in a child's careful letters dated three years before the child's hand could have written it; the same clerk's hand on four hundred consents in a single week; Voluntary stamps filed in sequence, in batches, like masonry. The Chorus's consent machine came apart in the pit the way the activation verse had come apart in the streets: not violently. Component by component, unable to resolve.

On the gallery rail, in the third hour, a senior Index stamps-clerk named Ivet stood up, unhitched the great Warden's stamp from her belt — forty years of writs and seizures in one brass cylinder — and carried it down the stairs and laid it on the registry table in front of the registrar.

"The record should be kept," she said, "by people who read it."

Suri looked at the stamp, and then at the woman, and made herself ask the question that mattered: "Why now?"

Ivet considered her answer the way she had apparently begun considering everything, freshly, as if the old procedure had been recalled. "Last winter I ran a seizure on a weaver's family in the Weep steps. Two presses, one sick child. The consent was signed. It was in order." Her thumb moved along the brass barrel of the stamp, finding the wear. "This morning your clerk read four hundred consents signed in the same hand in one week, and I thought: whose hand signed mine. I have been asking since breakfast. There is no answer in the file. There is no file. There is a stamp, and I am putting it down."

She was not the last. By dusk on the second day there were nine stamps in a row on Suri's table, and then nineteen, and the Index's docket of conscription and seizure died in the open air of provenance, unmourned, unsigned. Seft's readers could print RHYTHM UNRESOLVED all they liked; there was no longer a stamp in the room that would file the city's children under anything.

* * *

The third day belonged to the Choirmaster.

He came up from below with the last exhibit in a strongbox on a handcart, and he came up at the hour when the pit was fullest, because a choir-master knows you do not begin the anthem before the house has filled. The box held the unburned harvest-registry copy — the nursery's own working roll, the book of the taken, pulled from the sealed clerk-nest under the harvest floor where he had shut it the night the Choratorium's other ledgers fed the fires, and kept, and kept, and kept. He had held it through the burning, through the silence, through the year of the door, and he set it on the registrar's table now and opened it, and his baritone, which had once graded children like fruit, filled the quarry the way it had once filled the amphitheater.

He read the roll.

Every child's name. Every entry — name, stock, grade, date taken, and the column that recorded what was harvested and when. He did not hurry, and he did not soften, and when he reached the eleven, the quarry's breathing changed, and when he reached the ones who had never come out of the amphitheater, whose lungs and voices were already glass by the time the raid broke the doors, his voice did not waver at all, because it had not wavered on the harvest floor either, and that was the crime, and he made them hear it. He read his own annotations in the margins, the ones no supervisor had ever signed — this one hummed while they took the

blood; this one asked if the choir was cold — and the pit heard the machine from the inside, in the machine's own hand, which no amount of doctrine on the seabed was going to un-hear.

He read until the roll was done, every child's name counted out into the open air of Ashkarad at last, and then he gathered the registry into his arms and carried it to the pit's great brazier and fed it to the fire page by page. In the count-room above the pit, a pickman named Sedge, who had been counting backward from one hundred and nine since a flowering pick taught him the price of touching the deep, felt the number in his skull let go of one whole unit at once — the quarry was a threshold, and things had crossed it — and sat down on the stairs and laughed until he wept, and Gavel's crews made a place for him without being asked. Mother Gavel took off her hat. That was all. She took off her hat and held it to her chest with both hands, flat as a ledger page, and no one who worked for her ever once mentioned it, because some entries you keep off the books.

"No more vessels," the Choirmaster said, to the fire, to the crews, to the seabed, to the deep. The register of the taken went up in a column of black and gold, and no one in the quarry moved to stop it, because there are debts that are only ever paid in burning, and every soul in that pit recognized one when it was finally, publicly, discharged.

* * *

It was Ilay who felt the last thing, because Ilay's hands were on the stone, and the stone had been carrying a rhythm for a year that skipped, and faltered, and counted back in threes.

She took her hands off the floor and turned to the council bench with her face full of a wonder she had no slate word for yet, and Roya read her before she found one, because Roya had spent a year learning the girl's silences the way other people learn weather.

"What?" Suri asked. "What is it?"

"It settled," Ilay said. "Under the pit. The big one — the deep one. It was counting back in threes and being all — crowded." Her hands made a shape in the air, an unclenching. "It's slow now. Even. Like —" she hunted for it, ears tipped toward the floor, ten years old and the best instrument in the city — "like when the Choirmaster finishes the anthem and nobody leaves."

Isra's slate came up slowly from the front bench, paying its warmth letter by letter, and said what the Sister had said down there in the dark, under a cracked glass door, when the books of her captors were read aloud in the open air above her for the first time in a century:

THE DEEP HAS BEEN READ TO ALL ITS LIFE. NO ONE EVER READ IT THE TRUTH.

Suri looked at the slate for a while. Then she opened the census, ruled a fresh column beside the standing order for the second verse, and headed it READINGS — THE DEEP, DAILY, and entered the quarry's three days as the first item, disbursements none, consideration truth. "Then we keep reading to it," she said. "It's the only neighbor we have that's never once lied to us about a balance." Vahid, at the bench's end, was already revising a lecture he would never deliver about the therapeutics of testimony; Roya chalked the settlement on her map wall — the spiral's innermost ring gone slow, gone even, gone quiet as a sleeping account — and looked at it for a long time with the mask tilted, as if the map had finally said something kind.

The Root's rhythm ran slow and even beneath the city until dawn, and the clerks of the quarry wrote that down too, because it was true, and because — apparently, and terribly, and against every Doctrine on the seabed's shelves — the deep liked being read to.

CHAPTER 82

I Don't Get Kept

The charter came up to the quarry at dusk under the parley glove, in a clerical transport that had been built, like everything else in the fleet, to be counted rather than fought: one herald, two tally-bearers, one document-case chained at the wrist, and a reading-lamp.

Mother Gavel received them in her counting-room above the pit, because she received everyone there, and because a room lined with her own ledgers was the only neutral ground she had ever believed in. She was a woman with a face like a roadmap of old scars and eyes flat as a ledger page, and she sat through the herald's preamble the way stone sits through rain.

The herald was good. Better than good — the fleet had sent someone who understood her, which she noted, and resented, and filed. He did not open with tribute or threat. He opened with a valuation. Ashkarad's order-through-debt, he said, had been appraised by the Reclaim's own auditors as the finest surviving instrument of its kind in any city on the schedule. The Church had built the machine; she had kept it running through the silence when everything else of the Church had stopped. The Gardener's fleet did not want to destroy that. It wanted to scale it.

Then he unlocked the case, and laid the charter on her counting-table, and read it aloud.

The terms were beautiful. That was the first thing she noticed, and it was the tell; she had never once in her life signed a beautiful document. Warden's partner. The city's charter of the Reclaim: her crews as the schedule's enforcers, her water-works as the Reclaim's ration, her counting-room as the branch office of the audit, her title — Mother Gavel, Warden's Partner, Ashkarad — engraved on the first page in letters that had cost someone money. In exchange: the Reclaim's protection, the Reclaim's roads, the Reclaim's ledgers. Maintenance of order in perpetuity, at scale, per G.

It was aimed at her like an arrow she had described to a fletcher herself. Order-through-debt was her creed, and had been since she was fourteen years old in a debt-prison in the seawalls, watching a clerk feed a family into the ledgers one finger at a time and understanding, with the terrible clarity of the young, that the clerk was the only person in the room with any power at all. She had spent her life becoming the clerk. The fleet had read her life the way it read everything, and offered her the clerkship of the world.

And it was honest, which was the insulting part. The pit's protection against the schedule — real. The roads open to her freight — real. The harvest deferred while she enforced order

— real, and written plainly in appendix two, DEFERRAL, NOT REMISSION, because the fleet did not lie in its charters. The fleet did not need to. It had her own method to borrow, and it borrowed well.

She read it three times while the herald waited, and the third reading was the one she paid for, because it found the clause the beauty was built to hide. Page nine, sub-section four: upon signature, all outstanding obligations of the partner's crews — wage-debts, ration-debts, pit-debts, flesh-debts, every column of every book she had ever kept on a human being — were assumed by the Reclaim. Assumed. Her crews' debts would stop being hers, and start being the fleet's. Her people would pass, on signature, from her ledgers into the Gardener's, where interest ran by the salt-moon and the term of the loan was the schedule, and the schedule was the harvest, and the harvest was forever.

She had seen what the fleet's interest did to a debtor. Everyone in Ashkarad had seen it by now, in miniature, in one man: pickman Sedge, who had swung a pick at a flower-keyhole and come away owing the deep a count that ran backward through him at every threshold. She had kept Sedge on full wages since, though he could no longer work; she kept him the way you keep a margin note in a book you wrote yourself. And page nine wanted the whole quarry in margins like that, in a book she would never see again, kept by a hand that signed per G.

The herald watched her read it. He had, she granted, honest eyes. He believed the mercy. That was the saddest column in the whole document.

"You've written me a fine title," she said.

"The partner's title is genuine," the herald said. "The Warden of the Reclaim signs personally. Per G. It is —"

"It is a leash with my name engraved on the collar," Mother Gavel said, "and I know engraving when I see it, because I have paid for it." She stood. She took the charter off her table in both hands, went down the stair to the pit floor, where the evening crews were racking their tools and the lamps were coming up along the galleries, and she stood on her own mark in the center of her own sand, and she held the thing up so every crew in the quarry could see the seals.

"Forty years I have kept ledgers on every soul in this city that asked me to," she said, and the brass tube carried it to the last gallery without her raising her voice, the way it always had. "You owe me hours. You owe me water. Some of you owe me flesh. It's all in the books, and the books are mine, and you have always known where you stood, because I show you the page when you ask." She let that sit. "This paper says the fleet will take those books. All of them. Every name. Every debt. It says you'll be their entries and I'll be their clerk, and they'll call it

partnership, and they'll call it scale, and the interest will run until the schedule comes due — and you've all seen what comes due."

She turned to the brazier. She fed the charter to the coals page by page, seals first, and stood watching it with her scarred hands folded while it burned, and the crews watched her watch it, and nobody in the quarry made a sound until the last seal curled.

"I keep ledgers," Mother Gavel said. "I don't get kept."

* * *

The crews did not celebrate. She had not expected them to, and it said something about how far her people had come that they did not cheer her either. They came to her counting-room in deputations instead, all that night, the way crews come to a boss when the arithmetic has frightened them.

The pump-crew came first, and they were for the charter — water guaranteed at scale, work guaranteed at scale, their ration-debts assumed and their names on the Reclaim's protection rolls. "It's paper we'd never get from anywhere else," their overman said, standing where he had stood for twenty years. "It's the safest column on the seabed."

"It's the safest column in the book because the book eats cities," Mother Gavel said. "Brack sat in a safe column too. Read me Brack."

The pit-crews came, and they were against — they had seen the flowering pick, some of them had friends counting backward in the infirmary — and the freight-crews came, and they were split, and a girl of seventeen from the lamp-crews came alone at the dead hour with her wage-debt book in both hands and put it on the counting-room table, open, and said: "If they take the book, do I stop owing you?" and Mother Gavel looked at the girl's twenty-two entries, every one entered in her own hand with its reason written plain beside it — sick mother, broken arm, the winter the pumps froze — and felt the whole weight of what a ledger is, which is a promise you made to someone weaker than you, kept until it costs you.

"No," she said. "You stop owing me when I say the column's paid, and I haven't said it, and no one signs my people over my signature. Not even me. Especially not me. Go to your bunk."

It was after the girl left, with the lamps burned down and the ash of the charter still in the brazier's draft, that she took the brass tube down from the brackets by the window and set it on the table and looked at it while the night ran out. It had never once been pointed at her own people in forty years. It had pointed at enemies, at the sand, at the sky. There was no keeping it and there was no keeping herself out of what was coming; the only choice the arithmetic left was which books survived it.

When Dar came to the quarry the next morning, because word travels in Ashkarad faster than fire, he found her in the counting-room with the ash swept and the ledgers open and the day's water-rations ruled up in her own hand, as if nothing had happened, because as far as her books were concerned nothing had.

They traded the way they always traded, which was to say like two surgeons consulting over a patient neither could save alone. Her price for joining the third way was the water-works: not the ration — she had read the clinic's censer-lines and Suri's breath-books and knew exactly what the new order intended to do with arithmetic — but the works themselves. The pumps, the mains, the heads, the hours. Paid in function and never in flesh.

"You'll run the water for the whole city," Dar said. "Under the census, not over it. No debts in the pipes. Suri audits the ration and posts it open."

"Fine," Mother Gavel said. "One correction. Not no debts in the pipes. No new debts in the pipes. The old ones are mine to retire and I'll retire them my way, at my pace, and your registrar can watch me do it." She drew a sheet toward her and began, without ceremony, to draft the articles in her own square hand, ruling the columns where their two books would meet. "I don't work for a mob, Mehran. I work for the arithmetic. Your third way doesn't have one yet. I'm giving you mine. Don't waste it."

It was when he stood to go that she stopped him at the door.

"Take this." The brass speaking-tube came off its brackets by the counting-room window — the old pit-horn, brass gone brown at the mouth from forty years of her voice, dented once by a thrown bottle in a night she had never bothered to have repaired. She put it in his hands with no ceremony at all, and its weight surprised him, which she watched him hide, which satisfied her. "The day the city has to be counted in — all of it, one count, everyone at once — you'll want a voice that reaches. Mine reaches. I'm not giving it to you, mind. I'm lending it, and the day it calls that count, it comes home to me, because I'm the one who'll be calling." She turned back to her columns. "Carry it. Don't talk into it. If I hear my voice coming out of it before the day, I'll want the weight back the same hour."

"Why hand it to me now?"

"Because the tide is coming back," Mother Gavel said, flat as a ledger page, "and everything that floats in on it is going to want the city to kneel, and I have decided, after considerable accounting, that Ashkarad is the only debtor in this ledger I have never once been ashamed to carry." She went back to her columns. "One condition. Write it down."

Dar waited.

"When the new order writes its books," Mother Gavel said, not looking up, the nib moving through the figures like a pick through soft seam, "my crews' debts go into the fire first. Before yours. Before the Church's. Before the deep's. First." The nib stopped. She looked at him then with her eyes flat as the page she kept, and there was nothing in them to argue with. "Every debt in this quarry I have counted myself, and every one of them I can justify except that they exist, and if freedom is coming to this city, it arrives at my people's houses before it arrives at mine. That's the price. That's the whole price. Now get out of my counting-room — I have water to move."

CHAPTER 83

The Bloom-Fog

The fleet stopped negotiating on the third night after the readings, though nobody in Ashkarad used the word. They used the sound instead: the sound of the seabed changing, out beyond the storm-walls, in the dark before first light — a long, structural groaning of hulls that had no water under them being made to move anyway.

From the wall, Suri watched the barges come up the flats into position with the courier's glass and did not like a single figure in the picture. They came in a line, towed by the wain's engines on great drumbed cables, and they sat low even empty, riding on runners that had been built for mud, and they were the color of fat. Rendered, whale-pale, staved like the hulls of ships that had been bled: the carcass-barges of Lowmark, riding up the dry seabed of a dead sea two cities from home, each one packed with the bloom-tallow of a city that had bloomed and been pruned and gone into the books as PAID. The tally-book in the Choirmaster's keeping had carried the stamp for a year — BRACK — PRUNED, PAID — and Lowmark's page had acquired its stamp sometime in the last three weeks, quietly, somewhere out along the round, while the fleet negotiated. The audit, Suri understood now, had been the courtesy. This was the paperwork.

They anchored the line upwind of the city — squarely, precisely upwind, the way you place a lamp — and they opened the barges, and they set the tallow alight.

Bloom-tallow burned the way nothing in Ashkarad burned. It burned without crackle, a slow white yielding, and it did not make smoke so much as make fog: the fog that had been gone from the coast since the sea itself went — the fog-sea that had defined the horizon all Suri's life — came back overnight, one night, from the landward side, thick and low and smelling faintly of flowers, and it climbed the storm-walls like a tide that had read the blueprints, and it came into the city through every gap the seal-crews had not yet plugged, and it was hungry.

You felt it in the breath before anywhere else. One breath of the bloom-fog and something in the base of the lungs sat up and paid attention — a settling, a yearning, a low animal certainty that there was somewhere better to be, somewhere down, somewhere warm and dark and enormous, and that every hour spent above the salt was an hour spent away from home. The clinics filled with people who had stopped mid-step on vault-side streets, facing the wrong way, licking salt off their own wrists. A ceiling-joiner was found in a cistern-vent at noon, elbow-deep, weeping, trying to enlarge it. People counted in their sleep. Not upward.

Roya mapped the fog the only way it could be mapped, which was blind: she chalked the city hour by hour off Ilay's hearing, marking the streets that went quiet as the fog's fingers found them — the fog did not roar, it emptied, it turned whole lanes into places where no one was breathing out loud — and by dusk the map wall in the clinic bore a picture no one who saw it ever described as weather. The fog had hands. The hands were patient. And every hand pointed, compass-true, down.

"They are not besieging us," Vahid said in the war-room, his spectacles flashing, one hand flat on the day's first casualty log. "Siege wants you starved or frightened. This wants you homesick. It is the most obscene thing I have ever watched a chemical do, and I have watched the Church teach children to hum."

Isra's slate came up slowly from her corner, where the lamps burned close and the sealed vents were stuffed with censer-ash, and said what her root already knew, letter by letter, the warmth draining out of her fingers as she paid:

THE SMOKE IS MY SISTER. THEY ARE BURNING MY SISTER.

Below the city, all that day, the deep did not stir. The Root's rhythm stayed slow and even, the way it had settled since the readings — and somehow that was the worst figure on the board. The fog was made of the harvested, and the deep beneath the lid slept through the smell of its own children's burning, and Suri entered that in her book under the only heading that did not lie: THINGS WE DO NOT UNDERSTAND YET.

* * *

Ashkarad sealed, and Suri rationed the air.

It was the quietest mobilization the city had ever run. The gates went shut at dusk, all of them, and the storm-wall flues were packed with clay and censer-ash, and the city drew inward around its cisterns and its stored breath like a body closing a wound. What could not be sealed was fed. The chorus-free smoke — the ash-recipe, the Vigil's rest, Vahid's whole stock and the censer-works' whole output — went to the censer-lines at the cistern-works and the clinic and the deep of the Saltstairs, and the censer-lines ran on Mother Gavel's water, because the deal she had struck was already paying: her pumps drove the smoke-lines, her crews ladled the censers, her pipes carried the city's clean breath the way they had once carried its debts, and she stood at the cistern-works the first evening with her arms folded, watching her arithmetic serve Suri's, wearing the expression of a woman who has discovered that two ledgers can hold the same page without either one catching fire. At each line Suri posted her breath-books, and the breath-books were the meanest and the cleanest arithmetic she had ever ruled.

Four counted breaths at the smoke, twice a day, per soul, entered by hand. No debts. No deferrals. No flesh. You could not owe a breath and you could not lend one, and she had the lines marshaled so that a mother's four and a magistrate's four came out of the same ladled smoke, and she stood at the cistern-line the first evening and watched the city of Ashkarad breathe on the count, in queues, in the fog-sick streets, thousands of chests rising and falling to a clerk's cadence, and she thought: this is what an honest ledger feels like from the inside. It feels like everyone breathing.

The fog pressed on the walls all night and all day, patient as appetite. And on the second night it sent her brother.

* * *

She heard him before she saw anything, because the fog ate light and left sound.

She was walking the seawall's inner gallery because the fog-sick drifted to the walls and someone had to count them back, and out through the stone, muffled and doubled, against the outer face of the seawall, a man was coughing. Fleet livery, by the shape of him through the merlons — a clerk's coat, a clerk's stoop, one hand flat on the salt-black stone. He coughed, and the cough was not what stopped her. What stopped her was the count under it. He was coughing in cadence. Four beats, a held rest, four beats again, the cough fitted to the count like a word to a tune, and the cadence went through Suri like a needle finding an old scar, because she had known it since before she knew anything else — since grace storms in a one-room flat above the drying-racks, when their mother had sat between her children and counted their coughs aloud to keep the fear from compounding: four in, four held, four out, again, again, a rhythm to put your breath inside of, the way other mothers said hush.

Dathan.

Her brother had gone out of the record when she was nineteen — gone to find coin for a skin he was too late to keep from being sold, and had found it, somehow, in the only market that dealt in what he had: himself, signed, a counting-house boy, ledgered. She had never once had to wonder whose books held his page. She had known the way you know an unpaid balance. And now here was the balance, walking itself up the outside of the seawall in the enemy's fog, coughing his cough in their mother's count, and Suri Kaveh, who had retired her own page with fire and ink, stood on the inner gallery with her hand pressed flat to the stone exactly opposite his hand, and could not for the life of her make the two columns meet.

He coughed. She counted the beats. Her lips moved with them; she could not stop them.

And the coughing stopped, and there was a silence with two people breathing in it on opposite sides of the wall, and then his voice came through the stone, small with distance and

fog, in the flat tone of a man reporting his own figures: "You still count, Su."

"You still cough in four," she said.

A sound that was half a laugh and mostly coughing. "It's the fog. It doesn't like it when I count. Nothing over here likes it when I count." The hand on the stone shifted, gripped. "I'm not coming to the gate, Su. I'm just — walking the wall. You can hear a city through its wall. I wanted to hear if anyone in there was still counting."

"Everyone is counting," Suri said. "Come to the gate and I'll enter you myself."

"No." Flat. Final. A clerk declining a posting. "I've got a column to keep."

The fog-whistles sounded somewhere down the flats — the fleet calling its people home out of the smoke — and he pushed himself off the wall, and she heard him straighten his coat the way their mother had taught them both, and he went, unhurried, back down into the fog toward the barge-lights, coughing in fours all the way. Suri stood a long time with her hand on the stone. Then she took out her book, and ruled a line where a column should go, and did not write anything above it. Nineteen years she had kept the account open in her head; it could stay in her head a while longer. You did not enter a brother in a ledger until you knew which side of the page he was on — and if she wrote him down as the enemy's, she thought, climbing back along the dark gallery with the fog pressing gentle and hungry at the stone, then it would be a fact, and facts in her book were the kind that got collected. She left the line ruled and the column empty, and shut the book on it, and kept the count.

* * *

The tide came back on the third night, and it came back wrong.

There was no sea behind it. There was nothing behind it at all — no wind driving it, no moon pulling it, no water anywhere on the charts or in the cisterns or in the memory of the port — and yet the dry seabed below the walls began, at slack midnight, to shine: a black gloss crawling in from the edges of the world, climbing the flats against their own lie of the land, uphill in places, curling around the barge-line like a hand closing, filling the tow-channels the fleet's own engines had cut. The sentries rang the wrong bell because there was no right bell for it. Water that had forgotten to come back for a year was remembering, all at once, from underneath, as if the earth itself had opened a vein.

And the tide bore cargo.

It lifted the wain — the wain, the Gardener's own reliquary on wheels, dark and vast at the center of the fleet's lamplight, the thing that had never once been late — and it carried it, without one engine turning, smooth as a pall at a funeral, directly to the tide-gates, and set it

there against the sealed doors of the city with a courtesy that was worse than ramming. The fleet's ranks parted to let it pass and did not follow. Ashkarad stood on its walls in the bloom-fog and watched the black water lap the gates like a tide that had made a delivery, and on the wain's flank the lamp caught the white of a single glove, untied, hanging from the rail, patient as a filing date.

Suri stood at the wall with her book against her ribs and her brother's column still open, and watched the coffin come up to the door of the city. Dar reached the gallery at a run and stopped beside her, and she saw him put his hand flat over his own sternum the way you quiet something pressing at a door — and then she felt it too, through the stone, through her boots, through the marrow of everyone standing watch: his second heartbeat, the one that was not only his, humming, very low. Not the lullaby. Not any tune the city had a name for. A note like an acknowledgment of receipt.

CHAPTER 84

Collateral Returned

The tide that had come uphill to deliver the wain went out again before dawn, and this time it did not come back. It left the Reclaim's great reliquary-wain seated against the tide-gates like a creditor who had finally stopped knocking — barnacled to its axles, furred with grey frost that pointed, every petal of it, inland — and it left Ashkarad holding the Gardener's deadline in its mouth. *You have until the tide forgets to come back.* The tide had come back wrong, delivered the wain like a coffin on a shoulder, and forgotten itself on schedule. The deadline was spent.

The white flag went up the Saltstairs road at the ninth bell.

Wen walked in front of it the way a filing date walks into a debtor's week — unhurried, expected by the arithmetic if not by anyone's wishes. A century old, half-bloomed, the boy who had fallen carrying the ninth seed and been kept alive by the Gardener's books as her first failed key: he came up through the bloom-fog with two white-gloved auditors behind him and a glass case between them, and he stopped at the clinic's threshold under the darkened lamps, courteous as ever, courteous as a filing date.

"The Warden of the Reclaim," he said, "returns what the books held."

Dar came down the stairs and stood in the doorway, and Suri stood one stair below him with her ledger open, and Vell chalked the visit into the record before anyone had said a word, because Vell had been a counting-house clerk in a city that was eaten and had opinions about courtesy.

"You'll forgive the paperwork," Wen said. "It was collected during the sealing, on a signed lien. Collateral of the ninth seed's account. The account has been reconciled." One of the auditors stepped forward and set the case on the threshold stone with both gloved hands, the way a verger sets a relic, and stood back. "Collateral restored. The books never wanted your heart, cutter. They only ever wanted it where it could be counted."

The heart was in the case.

It was smaller than Dar remembered, and it was beating. His original heart — the one he had been born with, the one that had failed at nineteen and been regrown in Vey's vats to hang between candles as an offer he had refused — beating in glass on his own threshold, in the dark, in a room where every lamp had been hooded for a year because the thing in his chest could not afford the light. It beat the way it had always beaten, which was to say slightly out of

order, the arrhythmia he had grown up with filed away in the grain of the muscle, and it beat — Vahid would confirm it within the hour with his brass tube and his mended spectacles — in threes.

"One heart, three chambers, counting back," Vahid said, ear to the glass, one hand steadying it because he had only the one hand now. "Counting back in threes. That's not your rhythm, boy. That's the deep's."

"That," Wen said, "is the courtesy."

Suri did not look up from her ledger. "We have a receipt," she said. "Signed, sealed, dated the night of the sealing. *Received — one heart, human, original, beating. Held against account.* My copy." She turned the page so he could see it. "It doesn't say anything about a courtesy."

"The receipt covers custody," Wen said. "The courtesy covers contents. Your professor is holding a key, courier. I'd ask him to look again, and this time to ask what it opens."

Vahid looked again. He was a long time about it — long enough that Milla came down from the census desk with her transcription book and stood at the rail, and long enough that the fog pressed at the hooded windows like something reading over their shoulders — and when he straightened up his face had the particular stillness he saved for findings that would otherwise be shouted.

"It's been re-keyed," he said. "The re-growth was Church work and it kept Church time, whatever else it did. This isn't Church time. Someone has taught it the deep's meter — the three-count, the backward fall — grafted it into the beat, muscle by muscle, a recital learned by a heart. And there's a verse in it." His thumb moved along the glass. "The claiming-song. The water variant. The one the heralds' hymn only rehearses. It's primed in there like a charge in a well."

"Say the rest," Dar said.

"The trigger is feeding." Vahid did not look at him when he said it, which was its own kind of mercy. "The key is set to the deep's rhythm, and the deep keeps time one beat behind you. The next time the ninth seed feeds — the next supper you pay her in the dark — the resonance comes due. The heart sings the claiming-song, and the water carries it. Every cistern under the Saltstairs. The pump-works. The ration lines. Every throat in Ashkarad drinks its own activation."

The city's water was Gavel's now, held as function and never flesh, and the cisterns beneath the Saltstairs were older than any of the ledgers — a hundred drowned rooms where the district kept its drinking and its children had always been warned not to swim. The heart of

a debt-bound surgeon, primed like a charge, waiting on the appetite of the seed that had replaced it.

"Return it," Dar said.

"That would defeat the reconciliation," Wen said, gently, as if correcting a column. "The collateral is restored. Restored means *returned to the account.* The account is you." He inclined his head, and there was — Dar had learned to read it by now, the centenarian's terrible patience — no threat in him at all. Threat would have been cheaper. "The Warden's regret, cutter. I argued for a warmer instrument. I was overruled by a filing cabinet."

They let him walk out under his flag, because the flag was the only mercy anyone had budgeted for, and the fog took him the way the tide had taken the city's sea: completely, and without an apology.

Suri closed her ledger on the receipt and stood at the rail with her ruined graft arm held against her, doing the arithmetic she could not stop doing, out loud, flat, counted.

"It's a lien on appetite," she said. "That's the shape of it. They didn't send a fuse, they sent a *term* — the bomb isn't aimed at a day, it's aimed at a supper. You can't starve her, Mehran, she's your second pulse. You can't feed her in the open, light taxes her. So every dark room in this city where you pay her what she's owed is a firing lever, and there's no filing this one under *never.*" She looked at the case a long moment. "They learned that from us. The heralds watch what we ration and price the copy. Censers, water, blood — we taught them our own bookkeeping, and they've written it back to us as a weapon."

"Then we retire the collateral," Dar said.

"That's tomorrow's column," Suri said, and ruled it, and wrote the heading before she went up to the war-room: *THE HEART — OPTIONS.*

* * *

They put the case on the cold cellar table, and the argument about what to do with it began in the room above and leaked down the stairs like everything else in the clinic leaked.

Dar stayed below with the heart, because it was his — that was the whole of the jurisdiction, and everyone in the building knew it — and because Vahid had said, on his way up to lecture the war-room on pyres and lime-kilns, the thing that had sent the rest of the household up out of the cellar: "A heart that beats in glass can be listened to. Before anyone burns it, someone who knows the song should hear what it's been taught." He had looked at Dar with his salt-scoured spectacles gone white in the lamplight. "And no one else in this city is going to know the difference. That's the price of what you sold, boy. You're the only ear left

that can catch a forgery in that voice."

The Lily knew he was near the case before he was within a yard of it.

She came up through him the way she came up through him on the bad nights — not pain, exactly, but inventory, a full stock-taking of everything in the body she lived in — and then the craving arrived, and it arrived the way the doctrine of Vahid's lectures had always promised it would when Dar bled near her: total, ancient, and invoice-precise. The case held his blood. Twenty-seven years of it, regrown in a vat by the woman who had wanted to be the city's heart, and every drop of it was meat that had once been his, and the seed in his chest wanted it the way a drowned man wants the surface — gums aching, mouth flooding iron, the black lace stirring along his forearms like a reader leaning toward a page.

"no," Dar said aloud, to his own chest, in his own cellar, and heard how it sounded, and did not care.

The rule was older than the craving and it had never once failed him: blood craved when Dar bleeds. He drew the cellar lamp into the deepest corner until the room went almost honest dark, took his knife, and opened his own palm over the floor-drain — given, in the dark, the way she had always been fed, the first price he had ever agreed to pay her — and the craving turned like a ledger re-filed. She drank what he offered through the dark, and what she wanted beyond the offering she did not press, and by the time the hum in his ribs settled she was quiet again, fed and, he thought, ashamed, if a seed could be ashamed, of what she had wanted and from whom.

Which was when the heart began to sing.

Faint. Through the glass. A sound like a reliquary remembering — and Dar knew the song before he knew he knew it, four notes first, then the turn, then the long descending rest: the lullaby. The lullaby in a woman's voice, thin as memory through glass, and the woman's voice was a voice his bones filed without asking him — *his mother's voice* — the timbre of it, the breath before the phrase, the small catch on the third note that he had paid a decade of a life to look at once and had been given a face that was *wrong*.

And it was not her voice. That was the finding, and he made it the way he made every finding now, against his own hope, with instruments that had been sold and resold: the real one was held in a room below the world, in the common property of a door shared between two, unbuyable, unownable, beyond the reach of any market the Gardener could clear. This voice was assembled. This was the echo of the sale — every cleared slip, every memory of music the Gardener had bought off his counter-wall and out of his own chest, stitched into a composite and taught to a muscle. His mother's voice the way a forged stamp is his mother's signature:

correct in every line, and never once hers.

The heart begged in it. That was the mechanism under the mechanism — under the re-keying, under the primed verse, under the three-count — a heart that beat in glass had been made to *beg*, in the lullaby, in a voice built out of everything he had ever spent, and it begged the way the fleet's engines had learned to beg at shift-change, and it was begging *him*, and the worst of it, the part he would not put in any report, was that for four full notes his body leaned toward the glass the way a child leans toward a kitchen door.

Dar closed the case. He latched it, both latches, and put his uninjured hand flat on the lid, and made the only entry the finding allowed.

"It's not her," he told the dark, in the flat triage voice he used on the dying so their families could stand up under it. "It was never her. It's the invoice for what we sold."

Under his palm, patient as interest, his original heart went on beating in threes, counting back, and sang to the cellar in the voice of a mother he had never had, and waited — primed, keyed, restored to its account — for the next time the ninth seed would be fed.

CHAPTER 85

Burial as Gift

The war-room split along the only seam the city had ever split along: what to do with a thing that sang.

"Destroy it," Vahid said, and he had the chalk, so the word went up on the board in his crabbed lecture-hand, underlined twice. "It is an antenna wearing a heart's clothing. The Vigil taught us the recipe — ash, lime, a fire that is fed nothing it can sing to. I built this strain's grandfather in a room like this one. I am telling you as its maker's ghost: some instruments are only ever retired by fire."

"Cage it," said Mother Gavel's runner, reading from a slate in the boss's own flat hand, because Gavel did not climb stairs for anyone, even now, even for this. "*An asset that sings is an asset. Lead box, quarry vault, my ground, my guards. The clinic holds the key or I do. Terms negotiable.*" The runner set the slate on the table like a deposit.

"It sings in threes," Roya said, from the corner, her brass mask catching what little light the hooded lamps allowed. "The deep's meter. Put it in a lead box and it will teach the box the deep's meter, and the box will teach the floor, and the floor will teach the quarry. Everything the deep touches learns to count. You held the pick, Mother. You know what comes back from the mine."

"There's a third column," Suri said. She had been ruling it while the others talked, because ruling columns was what she did while other people had opinions. "The clinic's old trick. It was Hesh's antenna once, and we fed it a rehearsed rhythm for weeks and the lie traveled up the road and sprang him. Cage it *singing.* Feed it a false count until the trigger closes on nothing."

"The trigger is feeding," Vahid said. "It's set to the deep's beat, and the deep keeps time one beat behind the boy. You'd be filing false entries in a book the *Root* audits. The last man who taught the deep a lie was a pickman who cannot stop counting backward from one hundred and nine." He took his spectacles off, which he only did when a finding had frightened him. "And there is a worse column nobody has priced. The composite voice in it. The lullaby. Whatever taught that heart to sing has all the music it bought off this clinic's wall, and if we cage the heart, we leave the Gardener's instrument on the board where she can reach it. Fire is the only ledger that closes."

Into the middle of it, uninvited, came the sound of chalk on the window sill.

Ilay was at the wall — she had been at the wall for most of the argument, palms flat to the stone the way she had pressed her hands to the world since she was nine years old, listening down through the brick to the two circles under the city — and the music she was hearing had changed its mind about something. Roya saw it first, the way she saw everything first now, by watching the girl instead of the stone. Ilay's chalk was moving. Her face was the small scowl she wore when the walls said something they shouldn't, and her hand was writing at dictation speed.

Roya read it aloud, because Roya had spent a year learning to be the girl's voice for rooms the girl could not see.

"LET HER EAT IT," she read, and the war-room went quiet the way the vault had gone quiet when the door first sang. "THE FIRST SEED REMEMBERS EVERY HEART. SHE WILL KEEP YOURS SAFE BELOW."

"The counsel of the defecting party," Vahid said at last, very dry, very carefully. "Received from a locked room under the world, through the girl. Forgive me if I price this slowly. The first seed is the Gardener's eldest. She was made by the same hand, seeded from the same flesh, kept by the same books. We are asked to hand the enemy's eldest sister the enemy's bomb and call it a burial."

"We're asked to give her the collateral," Dar said. "Her word for it is *keeping.*"

"Her word is *eat,*" Vahid said.

"Both things are true down there," Isra said.

She had not written on the slate in an hour — writing cost her warmth, letter by letter, and she hoarded her heat like a diver hoards air — and when she did write, she wrote slowly, and Suri read it out flat: *THE FIRST SEED KEEPS WHAT IS GIVEN. IT IS THE ONLY LAW SHE WAS LEFT. ASK HER WHAT SHE DID WITH MINE.*

Nobody in the room could answer that. Isra's arrangement with the deep was her own; what she had given below, she had given below. But the slate sat there on the table with its question ruling the silence, and the silence, when the vote finally came around, ruled the vote.

"Sanctuary terms," Dar said. "That's the whole of the law we hold. She petitioned for asylum and the city has never answered her, and she has kept the door shut from her side for a year, and asked for nothing, and the one time she asks for anything it is for the safekeeping of a piece of me. I've been a debtor in this city my whole life. I know a keeper's terms when they're offered. We give her the heart."

Vahid looked at him for a long moment over the rim of his spectacles. "Then I'm carrying it down," he said. "I made its grandfather. I'll not have it go to the grave in a courier's satchel like a parcel. If this is a burial, it will be a burial with a next of kin present."

* * *

Seven hundred and eleven steps, and Suri counted every one of them, because counting was how she held a hand in the dark.

Roya and Ilay took the shaft head — Roya because her maps owned the vertical, Ilay because someone had to hear what came back up. The party below was four: Dar, Isra, Suri, Vahid with the glass case against his chest, carried slung like a sick man's child, both latches wired shut. They went past the dead First Vessel's cold cathedral of flesh, and Vahid — who had a lifetime of reasons not to look at it, and looked anyway — said nothing the whole length of it, and the walls rang like struck glass, and the temperature fell the way it always fell, as if the descent were being paid for out of the air's own account.

The salt-glass door stood wide open, as it had stood for a year. The hairline crack off the flower-keyhole still threaded the pane like a fault in ice, and it still sang, faintly, the four notes over and over in their different dead languages, a sound none of them would ever call music again without flinching. And behind the glass, in the dark the lamps had never once been allowed to enter, the first seed waited. She had never crossed. Not at the asylum petition, not through the faction war, not when the city cracked itself open at the vault-mouth three armies deep. She stood at her own threshold the way the wain stood at the tide-gates: patient, punctual, and outside.

Dar knelt at the door.

The case was heavy in his hands — heavier than a heart, lighter than what it had been primed to do — and he set it on the threshold stone with the latches facing her, the way you set a settled account facing the teller.

"It sings in threes," he said. "It's keyed to the deep's rhythm, and it's primed to sing the claiming-song through the water the next time the ninth feeds. She built it out of everything I sold her, and she sent it back as a courtesy." He turned the case so the frost-furred glass caught the last of the lamplight from above. "You said you'd keep it. So keep it. Buried, burned, or broken — it stops being a weapon tonight, and it becomes whatever you decide to file it under."

The dark reached out.

Not a hand — the city had learned its lesson about hands — but something in the grammar of one: a limb of root and petal, black vascular lace drawn out of the deep's own darkness the way a signature is drawn out of ink, and it took the case the way the auditors had taken it, with both prongs, carefully, the way you take something you have read the receipt for. The begging voice inside the glass — the composite, the forged mother, four notes of it always rising before anyone could stop their ears — changed. Dar felt the change land in his own ribs before he heard it leave the case: the three-count unwinding, beat by beat, the backward fall easing, the primed verse going slack in the muscle like a fuse pin drawn. One beat behind his heart. Then with his heart. Then kept — held in a rhythm that was not counting at all, only holding, the way a hand holds what it has been given.

"The first seed remembers every heart," Isra wrote, and held the slate where the lamplight found it, "AND SHE HAS NOT HAD ONE TO KEEP IN A HUNDRED YEARS."

They carried it down. That was the part Dar had not known how to imagine until he heard it — the sound of the vault floor taking the weight, a slow grinding of salt on salt, patient as grave-digging because it was grave-digging, down and away from the door, along a passage no one had ever mapped, toward the one chamber in the deep the Sister had asked Ilay's maps to leave unmarked: the cold place where the daughter lay. The Gardener's daughter. The first vessel. Dead since the Blacktide's death-song and cold since before that, a cathedral of flesh with every eye closed, and beside her — grave-goods, an offering, a key — the original heart of Darius Mehran, planted in the dark like a bulb.

The Lily stood witness. Dar felt her do it — felt her come to the front of his chest and lean, hard, toward the deep, her hum dropping to the lowest register she owned, and then — he would spend years deciding whether he had felt this or invented it — settling, key by key, into the Sister's own line. Two songs fitting together, the way they had fitted at a pane of salt-glass a year ago, four notes apiece. Sisters dividing an estate: one got the grave, one got the carrier, and neither of them, as far as he could tell, had been consulted about the will.

"Grave-goods," Vahid said quietly, watching the dark where the case had gone. "And a pass-key, if I know anything about locks and grief. She hasn't defused it, boy. She's *re-keyed* it. From trigger to talisman. The next time anything opens that door for true, it will find a heart in the ground that was told *keep this one safe* — by the one creature in creation the Gardener's books never held." He took off his spectacles and polished them on his sleeve, one-handed, badly. "The bomb is defused. I want it minuted that I recommended fire, and that I have rarely been so pleased to be voted down."

* * *

They came up the shaft in silence, four of them plus the absence of a case, and the silence held all the way to the listening-post at the head, where Roya waited with her slate and Ilay waited with her hands pressed to the stone and her chalk already out.

Because the deep was talking.

Not the four notes. Not the meter. Words — Ilay's scowl said words, her hand said words, and Roya read them up the shaft to the climbers as they arrived, her voice flat and careful in the ringing dark:

"NOW I OWE YOU," Roya read, "I HATE OWING."

The first unprompted sentence the Sister had ever sent the surface. A year of asylum petitions and testimony by transcript, and this — not thanks, not grief, not the century's ledger of the dead — this was the entry she chose to file, through the girl, to a man still catching his breath at the top of seven hundred and eleven steps.

Ilay looked up from the chalk. She had one more line to add, her own, small letters under the transcription, and she wrote it and turned the slate around without being asked, because some columns a child audits better than a surgeon.

"owing is a debt," the slate said. "she pays her debts. it just takes her a hundred years to open the account."

CHAPTER 86

Testimony at the Door

The council went down to the deep on the morning of the fourth day, and it went down as witnesses, which in Ashkarad was the highest office the city had ever invented.

Dar had convened it the night before in the dining hall of the Choratorium ruins, under Gavel's provisional roof, and the summons had been written in four hands on one sheet: *The first seed will testify at the door. The city is invited to attend. Come as witnesses or don't come; there is no third column on this page.* Suri signed first, because it was her census that had promised the Sister an answer eventually. Milla signed under her, registrar's hand, and asked only one question — "Will I need the certified forms?" — and packed them anyway. The Choirmaster signed and said nothing, which from the Choirmaster was a paragraph. Mother Gavel's answer came back by runner on the boss's slate: *I'll attend. I owe the deep a look at its creditor.*

Roya held the shaft head with Vell, whose chalk was faster than any transcript when the words came slow, and Ilay went down because the words came *through* Ilay — that had been the arrangement since the first deposition, what the stone said the girl said, and no one had found a better instrument in a year of trying. Isra went down as the door's answer, the Vessel, the one the first seed would speak in front of without the stone costing her more than she could pay. Fourteen of the stock children were kept above with the Choirmaster's freed donors, over Elias's flat-voiced objection. This was not a hearing they needed to attend. They had already given their blood's testimony to the claiming-hymn. The less said back to it, the better.

The Open Counts sent no witness — Clerk Elara's splintered remnant had asked, in writing, only for the certified copy, *to be posted door by door within a day of the close,* which was its own kind of attendance. The Index sent no one at all. Whatever the Index had been since its clerks crossed the quarry floor with their stamps held up like surrendered weapons, it was no longer in the business of hearings. Seven hundred and eleven steps, then, for the people who would actually stand in the room: a courier, a clerk, a choirmaster, a boss, a surgeon, a slate, and a girl.

Seven hundred and eleven steps. Milla counted them against her transcript margin and noted, in the clerk's hand that had survived two purges, that the cold came up out of the ground like a bill.

The antechamber above the door had been swept and bench-lined since the night three armies had filled it, and the witnesses were set along the wall with lamps hooded to embers, because light taxed the deep and everyone present had learned the tax code. The salt-glass door stood wide open. The hairline crack sang its four notes in its dead languages, patient as ever, and behind the door the dark kept its own counsel, one beat behind Dar's heart, three chambers to the count.

Then the deep began to speak, and the girl gave it her voice.

* * *

It came up through Ilay the way water comes up through a well-chain, hand over hand, the girl's flat unchildlike cadence carrying words she could not have owned in a lifetime of owning words, and Milla took them down in the certified hand, and Vell's chalk talked up the shaft to Roya above, and this is the shape of what the century said:

That there had been a world before this one, planted by keepers who did not know what they were planting, and that it had burned in the catastrophe the far cities called the First Burning; that the world's root was buried below the salt to keep it from the fire, and the Gardener's own daughter above it, locked where the lid could be kept; and that she herself — the first seed, the eldest — had been set where a witness is set, which is close enough to a lid that over a century she had stopped being able to tell the difference; and that there had been no malice in any of the locking. Only arithmetic. The Gardener had counted what was left, buried the half that frightened her, posted watchers over it, and gone away to sow.

That the nine seeds were sown a century ago with the words *Go. Find your hearts. And bloom,* and that she had counted them go, one to a city, like coins leaving a dead woman's purse; and that BLOOMED—TRUE THRONE, the stamp the far cities celebrated, meant *ripe*; and that the harvest was the harvest — Brack first, then the others on the round, pruned city by city and poured down the deep roads to keep the buried root dreaming. She had watched each one die. She had kept the list. The list had been sent up once already, through her Vessel, every city named and dated, prepared for a trial she had always assumed was coming, because in her accounting she had never once been on the side of the court.

Here Ilay's voice slowed, and Milla's pen slowed with it, because the witness had come to the entry the city actually needed.

NOT EVIL, the slate said. *I KNOW WHAT THE WORD DOES. I HAVE HAD A CENTURY TO STUDY IT FROM THE INSIDE. LONELY. THE ENTRY IS LONELY.*

Gavel asked the first question. She asked it the way she asked everything, as if reading terms across a table that did not exist.

"The feeding," she said. "Name it. What does the deep eat, and in what coin?"

The answer came back without pause, in the girl's cadence, flat as poured wax. *CITIES. POURED DOWN THE DEEP ROADS, RENDERED AND CARRIED, ONE PER ACCOUNT, ON A SCHEDULE. THE COIN IS THE SCHEDULE ITSELF. THE GARDENER FEEDS THE ROOT TO KEEP IT DREAMING, AND DREAMING, IT DOES NOT RISE.* A pause, the length of a page turning. *BRACK WAS EATEN IN AN AFTERNOON. LOWMARK MARRIED ITSELF TO THE FEEDING AND CALLED IT WORSHIP. GULLET BUILT A MACHINE TO MILK ITS OWN SEED AND CALLED THE MILK AN ENGINE. I HAVE COUNTED EVERY ONE. I WILL READ THE COUNT TO ANYONE WHO ASKS. IT IS THE ONLY BOOK I HAVE EVER KEPT THAT NO ONE HAS EVER WANTED TO SEE.*

The Choirmaster asked the second question, and his voice, the melodic baritone that had graded children like fruit, came out of the vault's cold with frost on it.

"The collar," he said. "The Ordinal says *maintain tension, sing to load.* Forty years, the machine I kept. Was the song ever — " and for the first time in his professional life he chose a word carefully — "*received?*"

THE COLLAR SANG TO THE ROOT, the deep said. *IT WAS MEANT TO. IT WAS THE GARDENER'S OWN LULLABY, RANK BY RANK, VOICE BY VOICE, FORTY YEARS OF HARVESTED THROATS FEEDING THE ONE SONG DOWN THE SHAFT. THE ROOT SLEPT. THAT PART OF THE BOOK BALANCED.* Another pause, and this one had weight in it, the weight of an entry held back for a hundred years. *AND THE GARDENER LISTENED DOWN THE COLLAR EVERY NIGHT OF THOSE FORTY YEARS FOR A VOICE. NOT THE ROOT'S. SHE LISTENED FOR A VOICE THAT USED TO SING UP AT HER FROM THE OTHER SIDE OF THE BURNING. THE SONG WENT DOWN. THE VOICE SHE HEARD COMING UP WAS SOMETHING ELSE. I HAVE TRIED TO FILE THIS ENTRY GENTLY FOR A YEAR. I CANNOT. IT DOES NOT FILE GENTLY.*

And then the afraid part, which was the part that rearranged the room.

I AM AFRAID OF HER, the deep said. *YOU HAVE HEARD ME SAY IT THROUGH MY VESSEL'S HAND AND YOU HAVE FILED IT AS THE FEAR OF THE POWERFUL. FILE IT AGAIN. THE GARDENER IS AFRAID TOO. SHE IS THE MOST FRIGHTENED THING I HAVE EVER COUNTED.*

Isra sat with her slate in her lap and her hands folded over it, and the cold of the antechamber kept taking her warmth the way it always did, letter by letter paid out of her own

body, and she did not stop the deposition to rest, because the witness below had waited a century to be heard and the Vessel's arithmetic was simple: whatever the transcript cost, it was being bought at a discount.

The witnesses did not move. Gavel stood with her arms folded like a woman auditing a rival's books and finding them, line by line, honest — the worst discovery her profession allowed. The Choirmaster had gone the color of his own reliquary glass. And the Sister testified on, in the girl's flat cadence, to the thing beneath the thing beneath the salt:

The Root had stopped answering her decades ago.

Not dead — her count of its heartbeats was exact, two million and more, kept since the Burning, and last week, for the first time, it had skipped one. Not dead. But the answering had stopped: the voice under the world, the one the Gardener had buried her world's heart to keep, no longer spoke back to the hand that fed it. Decades of silence, and the Gardener — who had built her whole order on the premise that the deep could be kept dreaming, audited, fed on schedule — had gone on feeding it *blind.* The heralds' tallies were her ears. The flower-stamped chits were her hearing-aid. Every pruned city, every tally-book, every stamped line of the Reclaim was the sound of a woman listening at a keyhole for a voice that had stopped caring whether she stood there, and hearing, always, something that answered in its place.

Milla's salt-whitened fingers kept the transcript even through that. It was Gavel who broke the silence first, flat as a ledger page, the brass tube still slung at her hip where she had carried it down without explaining why.

"The harvest," she said, to the door, in the voice she used for reading terms. "Forty years of the Chorus. My mother's generation in the tithe-houses. The nursery. All of it — sedation. One long lullaby fed down the shaft to keep the beast under the floor asleep, because its keeper couldn't hear it anymore and was afraid to stop the song and find out why." She looked at the Choirmaster. "Your Church wasn't a religion. It was her night-light."

The Choirmaster took that the way he had taken the breaking of his wrist — as a professional reviewing another professional's technique. "Forty years of harvested voices," he said, "one long lullaby, fed to the dark." He turned his fire-axe once in his hands, the way he did when the numbers frightened him. "I kept the dead's house ready for singing. I was keeping *her* house ready. I'd like the record to show which of those I can still stand."

The last of it came up quiet.

The Sister had one more entry, and she filed it the way the oldest filers file — without preface, without mercy for the listener, in the space of two sentences, and afterward Ilay stood

with her hands pressed to the stone and her eyes shut, repeating it exactly, because the stone had said it twice and the stone did not repeat anything twice for emphasis.

"She thinks she still hears my mother," Ilay said. "She hears the Root imitating her."

For a moment the antechamber held nothing but the four notes of the crack, going around their dead languages, over and over.

And then, for the first time in the whole year of testimony, the deep spoke without the girl. The words came up out of the stone themselves, through the floor, through the walls, through every crack in the door's singing glass, soft as frost forming, in the voice they had all heard once before at a pane of salt-glass — the mother's under-line, the harmony below the child's thread — and every witness present would swear, in the affidavits Milla took down that evening, that the voice was not speaking to the room at all.

It was correcting the record. The way a clerk corrects a file. The way the eldest corrects the youngest. The way, below every ledger in Ashkarad, the deep kept its books.

She thinks she still hears my mother, the stone said, to no one, in the dark. *She hears the Root imitating her.*

Milla wrote it twice — once in the certified transcript, once on her own copy, with the salt under her nails and her hand perfectly steady — and above them, up seven hundred and eleven steps, Vell's chalk came down the record like a stamp coming down on a page, and the testimony of the first seed was complete.

CHAPTER 87

The Crack in the Ninth

Vahid refused to authorize it in writing, and then he refused to authorize it out loud, and then he stood at the rig with his one hand flat on the canvas wall and told Dar the only thing his lifetime of anatomy had left to teach on the subject.

"The honest texts end at Bone," he said. "Mind opened as a wound, and we both know what that cost you. Soul was a door shared between two, and the two of you opened it, and the books do not record — Shirin's cylinders do not record, the Order's whisper does not record, *nothing in this world records* — what happens when a carrier pushes past Soul. There is a reason the Ninth Vein has no honest text, boy. There is a reason every honest text stops one door short. The ones that kept going weren't honest. They were gardens."

"I need to see it," Dar said.

"You need to see it because the fleet is days from forcing the vault-mouth and you want the ground mapped before the enemy owns the approach. I know. It's even good bookkeeping." Vahid took his spectacles off, polished them, put them back, and looked older than the salt. "I won't write it down and I won't watch it. If you come back less than you left, I'll have spent the session inventorying what we can't replace. Suri has the counter. Isra has the door. Go be reckless on a schedule."

So the census stood counter, and the Vessel stood door, and the climber climbed.

The rig over the salt-glass door had not changed since the nights it was built: a canvas-and-brass cold room a body's width off the glass, two chairs, the old stolen pulse-reader with its sacred fault, and the chalked law in Vahid's hand — NO SONGS / NOT EVEN HUMMING. Isra was already in her chair, slate on her knees, breath fogging, her warmth hoarded the way a diver hoards air. The room took its tithe as the session opened, one memory from each climber into the common property of the graft, irreversibly, unbuyable — Dar paid the color of the awning over the clinic door, a small thing, uncounted until it was gone; Isra paid the name of the first fish she ever caught, and wrote afterward, when the ledger-printer had done its work: *FAIR. IT WAS A SMALL FISH.*

Then they went in.

The shared room was where they had built it, in the between-space under the Mind's architecture: the bench, the planting-frame, the angles of tended ground arranged by a third heartbeat that listened from under the floor. The Sister was there tonight — of course she was

there; she was always there now — a presence like an ear pressed to a wall, and when the climbers sat down she did not speak, and she did not hum, and Dar understood before he understood anything else that she had made room. The room had been arranged, tonight, the way you arrange a room for someone to pass through it. Furniture moved back. A lane cleared. A door in the far wall that had never been there, standing slightly ajar.

"She knows," Isra wrote, and showed him. "SHE IS HOLDING THE FLOOR OPEN."

The far door was not the salt-glass door and it was not the mind-door he had found furnished in the deep hall of his own architecture, the one that had hummed with someone's recent warmth. It was older than both, and it did not lead deeper into himself. It led down.

The census held him as he crossed the room. That was the finding he would carry back, the one that mattered: that he did not go down alone, and not because anyone followed. Every name in Suri's census of the willing rode in him — who would sing, who would fight, who would hide, nine thousand counted signatures of a city that had voted with its blood — and the weight of them was not weight. It was *music.* The way a chord is not more notes than a single tone; it is more *agreement.* He had spent two years learning to be two heartbeats in one chest. He crossed the floor of the between-space carrying nine thousand, and the crossing held.

He put his hand on the far door, and pushed past the shared one, and the Ninth opened a crack.

Not bloom-through. He felt the bloom come for him — of course it came for him; he was a carrier with a seed in his chest standing in the anteroom of Throne, and the invitation was the oldest invitation in the world: *stop being a person; become the garden; the rows are warm and the watering is easy.* It reached for him the way the salt garden had reached for Suri in the frost on a cellar wall, the way the lullaby had reached for him through a forged voice. And it could not close its grip, and the reason, when he could finally file it in words, was the reason the honest texts had never written down: bloom-through is what happens to *one.* He was not one. The census was held in him the way a chord holds a note — every name a finger on a string that was not his alone to press — and a chord cannot bloom through a single throat. The seed in his chest strained; the counted city in his blood bore him back. He was nine thousand people's agreement not to be eaten, and the garden had no line item for that.

So instead of a door swinging, a crack opened. A hairline. In the world.

It opened in his teeth first — the old physics, resonance filed as pain — and then in his eyes, and he was looking *through* something, down, past the vaults, past the dead First Vessel's cold cathedral, past the buried Root's three-count chamber, past everything the

Church had ever built its lid upon, and there — beneath the salt, beneath the seed-vaults, beneath the underside of the world — was the Door.

Not a lid. Not a lock. A *door,* and it was older than the Church, older than the burning, older than the ledger the Gardener had been keeping on the far side of it for a century. It was not built; it was *grown,* the way the salt-glass was grown, in patterns no surveyor could square, and it stood open a hand's width, and through that opening the light that came out was not light. It was growing weather.

The garden on the far side was green.

Dar had crossed salt flats where the fog-sea had forgotten to come back. He had walked cities that were eaten, and grafted a canal-singer's freed voice onto a wall of stone, and spent his mother's face to save a city, and in two years of the ledger's arithmetic he had never once, in waking or in dream, seen the color green. It was the color of the first seed's original garden, and it was tended — rows and rows, planted like bulbs, each row taking, each furrow dark with real loam — and it was alive in every direction the crack would let him see, and at the center of it, kneeling at a grave that was empty, was a woman in white gloves.

She was tending the grave. That was the horror of it, that was the entry Dar knew he would carry the rest of his life: the garden was perfect, and the grave was empty, and she tended it anyway — hands bare-knuckled in the loam around a headstone that held no name he could read, the ground smoothed, the watering done, everything a burial needs except anyone buried. A ring of old burn-scars circled her wrists, above the gloves. He had seen that ring pressed into the paper-grain of a registry leaf in a drowned port, and seen it at the center of a burned garden under a sky of falling ash, tending rows that would not take, over and over, forever. Here the rows took. Only the grave stayed empty, and she stayed with it, a keeper keeping a grave that had never once held what it was dug for.

The keeper looked up.

Straight through the crack. Not searching for it — *at* it, the way you look at a window when you have heard glass settle in its frame — and Dar understood, with the last of his attention going like lamplight in a rising tide, that she had felt the crack open the way a landskeeper feels a fence-post shift two fields away, and that she had been waiting for exactly this sound for a hundred years.

She did not speak. Her mouth moved, one endearment's worth, unhurried, the way you say a thing you have said ten thousand times to something you planted — and the crack carried it whole, because it was not carried in sound at all but in the old language-understood-without-hearing, the tongue of the scored flats and the dead registry

leaves, the tongue of the three-heartbeat face he had bought for a decade of a life and been given a mother who was *wrong:*

Little root.

* * *

The climb spat him back into his body at the rig like a debt being called, and the room's instruments filed the return in their own indifferent hand.

The pulse-reader printed for a long time. RHYTHM UNRESOLVED, then a second line it had never printed before and never printed again: NINE (9) RHYTHMS RESOLVED. Vahid, who had sworn he would not watch, watched that printout and said nothing at all. Suri took Dar's pulse with two fingers, counted, and wrote in her ledger of self, in the column that had no heading yet: *COUNTED BACK. HE COUNTED BACK.*

He had lost an hour — the descent back up through his own architecture, gone the way the Mind Vein had taught him things go when they are spent rather than held — and there was frost on the inside of his chest where no frost had any business being, in a pattern Roya chalked from his description without comment: nine petals, every one of them touching the next. The crack did not close. That was the finding Vahid made him dictate, twice, for the record, in the flat voice he used for terminal numbers: a wound that sees does not close. It sat in him the way the salt-glass door's fracture sat in the pane — hairline, singing when the world was quiet, patient as everything else that had ever been kept below.

They priced it in the cellar afterward, because everything in Ashkarad was eventually priced in a cellar. "It's a liability," Suri said, flat, counting it out. "It's a door the enemy wants open, and you've cracked the frame from the inside. If the fleet learns the ninth is already leaking Throne — " "It's an instrument," Vahid said over her, quietly, and everyone heard the old lecture-heat come back into his voice for the first time in days. "A hairline in a pane of glass will carry a note. Ask the door. The boy is a pane now." Isra wrote one line on her slate and turned it to the room, and no one argued with it, because no one could: "SHE LOOKED AT HIM. YOU DO NOT LOOK AT SOMETHING UNLESS YOU MEAN TO COME BACK FOR IT."

And the Lily — the Lily had gone utterly still. Not the stillness of fear; the stillness of a ledger being balanced by hand. She stayed that way through the examination, through the printout, through Suri's counting, and when the cold room had emptied and Dar sat alone in the cellar dark that fed her, she leaned. Down. Toward the deep, toward the Door, toward the buried garden where a white-gloved woman kept an empty grave — and her hum, when it came, was four notes, the child's thread, offered into the dark like a coin into a well.

He had bought three heartbeats of a face once, and the face had mouthed an endearment he had never heard in his life, and he had filed it under *wrong mother* and paid the decade and moved on. Now he knew whose mouth it was. The keeper of the green place. The signer of the registry. The woman whose song had been misfiled all along as a mother's, sung over a cradle that was never his — *little root* — said, in the end, to the seed in his chest, and through the seed, to him.

CHAPTER 88

What the Harvest Was For

The parley flag was white with salt by the time it reached the tide-gates, and the man under it was older than the flag's cloth by ninety years.

Behind him the seabed kept its patient arithmetic. The tide had not come back — the sea stood ten miles out like a debtor avoiding a door — and the fleet's camp lay grid-perfect on the wet mud where fish should have been: tents of clerks, ranks of white-gloved auditors, the herald-chorus at drill in files you could have ruled with a straight-edge, and at the center of it all the wain, vast, barnacled, hung with frost that pointed inland, a reliquary on wheels that had crossed the ledger of the world to stand at this gate. The bloom-fog breathed around it all. Somewhere in that grid a cough counted itself in a cadence Suri had known since childhood, and Suri counted the parley's minutes and did not turn her head, because turning her head would have been an entry, and she was not ready to file it.

Wen came alone this time — no auditors, no case, no courtesy except the flag itself — and he came to the gate the city had unbarred for him, and he stood in the grey light with his hands folded like a clerk at a counter, and he said, without preface:

"You testified me, cutter. The whole city heard the first seed's deposition. I've heard it too, by now — everything bloomed hears everything bloomed, that was always the design — and the Warden's office has spent two days filing it." He looked up at the walls, at the censer-smoke rising from the streets in its rationed threads, at the frost-petals on the gate's iron pointing inland like a weathervane made of debt. "The books are wrong about one line, and I've come under the flag to correct the record before the wain moves. Ask me anything. I'm authorized to answer, which should frighten you more than any terms I've ever brought."

Dar came down to the gate with Suri at his shoulder counting the parley's minutes, Vell at her elbow with the chalk, and the Choirmaster behind them with his fire-axe left behind and his Church still on him like a coat. Vell chalked the hour of the parley's opening on the gatepost, and as she finished, the frost-petals on the gate's iron turned — all of them, together, very slightly, the way a room of listeners turns toward a witness — toward the man under the flag.

"Say it plainly," Dar said. "What does the fleet want with Ashkarad?"

"Not what you've priced," Wen said. "Not punishment. Not an example. The schedule was never cruelty, and I'll say that to Vell of Brack's face, though I know what it costs to hear." He

inclined his head to the mute clerk — and Vell, who had crossed the flats on chalk and fury, did not move, and did not forgive, and wrote one line on her slate and turned it around: *THE RECORD IS LISTENING.* "The fleet wants the Door opened. That is the whole of the warrant. Every tent on that seabed is a clerk of the opening."

"The Door," the Choirmaster said. His voice had gone very careful, the voice of a man handling a page he has only ever seen under glass. "Capital-D."

"Capital-D," Wen agreed. "The one beneath the salt. The one your Church was built on top of without ever once being told what it rested on. Your Ordinal's first page, choirmaster — the doctrine the founders cut away from the rest and carried like a bone. Say it. I'd rather hear a Churchman say it than say it myself."

The Choirmaster said it. He said it the way he had once read children's names from a burning registry, level and clear, a man determined to be accurate about the thing that had eaten his life: "The Ordinal of the Undersong, first page, oldest clause. *The deep door keeps itself. No hand opens it from without. It answers only to a living Throne set within — the door opens from inside, or it does not open.*" He let the axe-hand he wasn't carrying fall open. "Forty years I served the machine that sang the lid to sleep, and I never once asked what the lid was on. We were the padlock's night-watch."

"The harvest feeds the Root," Dar said. He could feel the geometry closing as he said it, account by account, the way the Mind Vein had taught him to feel a diagnosis arrive. "The prunings. The round. Brack, Lowmark, the rest. Rendered and poured down the deep roads on a schedule — not tribute. *Sedation.* Keep it dreaming while the key is grown."

"While the key is grown," Wen said. "Yes. A living Throne, cutter, and there are only two ways in a century's arithmetic to grow one. Bloom a seed to Throne in the field — eight cities tried it, and eight cities are stamps in a registry now — or grow the key *in place,* slow, fed, sung to, indoors, where the books can watch it. The Gardener has been growing a key in this city for two years without touching it. She grew it the moment the ninth seed chose you. Everything since — the heralds, the surveys, the offered terms, the wain, the census of who in Ashkarad can sing — is the husbandry of one plant."

"The terms on every door," Suri said, flat. "Stock children and the ninth seed as tribute, and a place at the pruning schedule's tail. That wasn't a ransom."

"It was a *planting bed,*" Wen said. "You were offered the tail of the schedule because a harvested city is a quiet city, and a quiet city is where you grow a Throne without the neighborhood waking. She has done it before. She has had a century of practice at growing keys that don't turn."

"And your Custodian," the Choirmaster said. The words came out of him like a splinter leaving the hand. "Vey. Anra Vey. The woman who built the Choratorium and ran the harvest and meant to be the city's heart at the Blacktide — "

"— was her subcontractor," Wen said. "Filed. You understand the word; your Church ran on it. Vey was promised the chair — the wardenship of the opening, the seat your friend here keeps being offered in one language or another — in exchange for growing the key on site. She thought the key was herself. She built forty years of throat-machinery to force her own bloom at your eclipse, and the door's inhabitant sang her out of her gloves before the verse finished. The books wrote it down as a defaulted line and moved on." He looked at the Choirmaster with something that was not quite apology and not quite pity, and was perhaps the oldest thing at the gate. "You kept her night-watch for her. I kept *hers.* Between us we have served the same locked door under two different seals."

He said it without drama, and that was the worst of it — a clerk correcting a column. And then the clerk's voice did change, once, the way old cloth tears, because he had come to the line he had carried up the whole length of his kept-alive century, and the Warden of the Reclaim set it down on the counter between them like a coin he had been holding under his tongue since he was a boy in the fog with a dying lantern for a heart.

"She doesn't want a Throne. She wants her daughter's door unlocked. I was the first key she tried. I jammed."

No one at the gate moved. Out on the flats the fog moved for them, slow, carrying the smell of tallow and far cities.

"She made me before the sowing," Wen said. "Or she *took* me — the order of operations stopped mattering to me sometime in the second decade. I was a boy and she put the ninth seed in me, the last one, the one that had been waiting longest to be carried. And it fled me. Not because I was cruel — I would have carried it anywhere, I would have carried it *still* — because I was *first,* and firsts are for learning on, and the seed knew the arithmetic better than I did. It left me in the dark on the flats and it went to find a better chest, and it took a hundred years to find yours." He touched his collarbone, where — Dar had seen it at the first parley, under the half-bloomed lace — the scar sat like a keyhole with nothing left in the house to lock. "A century, cutter. She kept me alive on her books that whole time. Do you understand what the *books* are? Not punishment. Not reward. A ledger is a promise that you will still exist when your account is next looked at. She kept me existing. She has never once asked me whether I wanted to be a line."

"Her daughter's door," the Choirmaster said quietly. "The daughter she locked above the deep. The first vessel. You're telling the court the warrant is — " he stopped, and started again, and the second time it came out as the thing it was. "She's been harvesting cities to keep a dead thing asleep so that nothing wakes up and disturbs her before she can carry her daughter home."

"I'm telling the court the warrant is *grief,*" Wen said. "Filed in a hundred-year hand. I was there when the deep stopped answering her — I was her key before I was her clerk; I was counting when the count stopped counting back. You heard the first seed's testimony. The Root is not hers anymore. It has not answered to her hand in decades, and she has been feeding it *blind* ever since, on books, on schedule, on the only song she has left — because the alternative is to stop feeding it, and a gardener does not stop feeding, whatever the garden has become. She thinks she is a warden. I have watched her for a hundred years, and I will file it under what it is. She is a woman at a locked door with her daughter's body in her arms, and the door only opens from inside, and the only thing that has ever been able to stand *inside* and open it is a living Throne." He looked at Dar, and his ancient face did the thing it had done at the first parley, when he had asked his one quiet question and cracked Dar worse than any terms. "You refused her twice. Blacktide and bloom. I'm not here to change that. I'm here because the geometry finally closes and somebody had to read the total aloud."

"The total," Suri said.

"The fleet does not want Ashkarad punished," Wen said. "The fleet wants the Door open, and the key grown, and the daughter buried in the garden she was stolen from — and every path to it runs through the ninth seed and the man it chose, and the man has spent two years refusing to be a door. So. Now you know what the harvest was for. Now you know what the wain is *for.* File it where you like."

He gathered his flag. The parley's minutes were up — Suri called the count, flat, and Vell chalked it — and for a moment the Warden of the Reclaim stood in the gate with the fog beading on his century like salt on glass, and asked, for the record, the one thing left on his sheet.

"The fleet's true books," he said. "The ones I keep, not the ones she lets be posted. Every seed is entered by its song — it's how the round is audited, it's how a city's ripeness is certified. Brack's seed: entered, harvested. Lowmark's: entered, harvested. The Vigil's: entered, quarantined, singing to itself in the dark for two hundred years." His hand lay flat on the gate's iron, over the frost-petals, over the scar-line of the door beneath the world. "The ninth's entry has stood open for a century. One line. *Song: unverified.*" He looked at Dar's chest, at the place where two heartbeats kept a ledger the books had never held, and the

Warden of the Reclaim, first of her failed keys, asked the only thing he had ever asked for himself, for the true books, before he ended:

"Does it really sing?"

CHAPTER 89

The Standing Count

The fleet stopped being an audit in the last hour before dawn, and became, in the fleet's own bookkeeping, an *entry.*

They came up from the tide-gates along the old canal-works, the route their heralds had scouted a season ago, and they did not come as skirmishers. They came as a procession — clerks first, then auditors two by two, then the herald-chorus in files too straight to be anything but liturgy — and behind them, dragged on rollers over the dry canal-bed by two hundred pairs of hands and one patient tide's worth of borrowed arithmetic, came the wain's engine.

Dar watched it come up the Marrowworks' loading slope and knew it before anyone told him, because Suri, counting at his shoulder, went quiet in the middle of a number.

It was a brass-and-glass womb the size of a tithe-barge, furred with grey frost, hung in a cage of leviathan rib, and it was moaning. Not mechanically. *Begging* — the shift-change moan of a reef-city's heart, the sound Suri had audited in another life and filed under ENGINES DO NOT BEG. SOMETHING DOWN THERE IS OWED. The Cow of Gullet, or the Cow's seed-core, torn out on the round and caged in the wain's belly: the engine-seed of a pruned city, carried here the way the fleet carried everything, as an exhibit and an instrument.

"They weaponized it," Vahid said, one-handed, glasses flashing in the hooded lamps of the shaft-head gallery. "A seed that has spent decades learning to sing to a chained woman is aimed at our vault-mouth to sing the claiming-song into the deep. Force the lock with a choir, instead of a ram." His jaw set. "And a conductor to beat time."

The conductor stood on the loading slope with his back to the city, and Dar's body knew him before his mind caught up — the bone-plate mask, smooth as a skull, from a prologue of blood and salt: the captain who had tasted Dar's blood on the night of the theft while Dar bled out on the dock plates. *It chose,* the captain had said, to no one, to the choir, to the dark. *As it always does. The choir must be complete.* Two years, and the man had never stopped performing the liturgy. Behind him the herald-chorus stood in ranks of forty, mouths open before the downbeat, throats the fleet had carried from city to city like tools, and below them the slope held the last thing Dar had expected the fleet to respect: a line. The census's fighting column — quarry crews, dock-gangs, couriers with their counter-weighted chains grounded, picks planted like pikes — holding the loading slope's edge at a walk's distance, not swinging, not shouting, spending nothing. Suri had trained them in one doctrine and one doctrine only,

and they held it now in the fog: *you are not there to win a fight; you are there to make the fight unaffordable.* The bone-masked captain mounted the engine's cage with a conductor's baton of white bone in one white-gloved hand, raised the herald-chorus with the other, and gave them the downbeat of the claiming-hymn's activation verse — the finding-song, the waking-song, the tune the Church had spent forty years and a nursery teaching into stock blood.

The verse rolled down the shaft like water finding a drain.

And Ashkarad, which had spent a year learning what its own chest was for, answered with the only thing the city had ever made that the Church had no entry for.

* * *

The Standing Count had been a census line once — *who will sing, who will fight, who will hide* — and tonight it became what its name had always promised: a count that stood.

They came up out of the streets and the stair-canyons and the ration-lines at the sixth bell, every soul above the vault, and they did not come to fight. They came to *keep time.* Suri led it, because Suri had always led it, from the gallery rail above the shaft mouth, her ledger closed for once, her ruined graft arm raised like a choirmaster's baton — and Mother Gavel stood beside her with the brass speaking-tube she had handed over weeks ago for the day the city must be counted in, and the day had come, and the tube's brass throat carried the count down the slope and up the walls and into every ear in the fog:

Count. One. Two. Three. Four.

Not the hymn's meter. The city's own — hearts, given freely, in rhythm: the counted and the makers and the quarry crews and the ration-lines and the dock-hands and the tenement rows, eleven thousand chests above one vault, each of them paying the only coin the deep had never been able to tax, because it was only ever legal tender when it was *given.* The tube called the numbers. Gavel's voice, flat as a ledger page, did not once lift, and did not once break, and her crews on the slope — the debts she meant to see burned first in any new book — stood in ranks of their own and counted with the rest, because their boss had priced the third way and paid for it in advance.

Below the gallery, the children sang.

Isra had carried Ilay's transcription down from the attic in its oilcloth — *for my grandmother,* the score said on its cover, every verse, the mother's line included — and the chorus-free cohort stood in the antechamber dark above the salt-glass door with Elias's perfect lungs at their head, and they sang the true song into the stone. Not the claiming-hymn's bait.

The other thing. The song the garden had taught a nine-year-old through a mile of rock, the song Vahid's medicine had freed their blood to carry, and it went down through the antechamber floor and into the vaults the way water goes into a root.

In the listening-post niche by the down-shaft, Roya mapped a battle she could not hear, exactly as she had mapped the last one, reading the night off Ilay's ears like bearings off a star — CHOIR HOLDING. COUNT HOLDING. ENGINE STRAINING — and beside her Ilay pressed her palms to the stone with tears standing in her river-stone eyes, because the city was singing her song, her transcription, the one she had titled for a grandmother no one had told her she had, and up at the parley-line by the tide-gates, where the fleet's second rank waited under a furled flag, the Warden of the Reclaim stood with one hand flat on his own collarbone scar and listened to a seed's song verified at last, a century late, from outside the walls of the only city that had ever refused him.

And under the streets, the freed voices rose to meet it — Lena Vance's freed voice up every canal and cistern at once, the once-harvested donors in the reliquary gallery, thirty throats the Church had borrowed and returned — and below *them,* below everything, the pedal-tone: the Sister, giving the deep's own under-line to the chord for the first time in a century, the mother's harmony laid under the city's count like a floor under a house.

At the center of it stood Dar, on the gallery above the shaft, holding the crack open.

It was surgery. That was the only way he could hold the account of it in his mind — not mysticism, *surgery:* a hairline wound in the world, running through him at the ninth vein, and he stood at the wound and kept it open the way he had kept chests open on a harvest floor, not one finger's width wider than the bleeding could pay for, because the bloom waited on his other side like a warm garden and the invitation had not expired. The census held him. Nine thousand signatures of agreement pressed through the crack and into the deep below, and the chord that had been a metaphor all year became, at the sixth bell, a *mechanism:* the hymn came down the shaft hunting silence to wake in, and the city above the vault was not silent. You cannot activate what is already singing. The claiming-hymn needs a sleeper, and Ashkarad, every soul above the vault, was awake, and counted, and *counting.*

The herald-chorus sang the activation verse four times, and four times it fell into the Standing Count like a debt into a ledger that was already balanced, and the count did not stumble, and the tube did not lift its voice, and the bone-masked conductor on the engine's cage beat time for a choir that was discovering, bar by bar, that its own song had been redirected.

* * *

Mother Gavel saw the conductor's end from thirty feet, and filed it the way she filed everything, flat, in order.

She had come down to the slope to hold her crews' ground — an abandoned mine is a mine somebody owns, and tonight it was the city's — and she watched the captain on the cage try to take his choir back. He was good. She could see that even with no ear for it: a liturgy-man to his bones, a failed carrier who had never stopped performing the choosing, holding the claiming-hymn's lead like a man rowing against a tide he had personally ordered to rise. The chord took the heralds' voices out of his hands the way the deep had taken the pick out of a miner's grip — not violence, *redirection* — verse folding into verse, the hymn's own bars turning home like iron filings finding their field, until the claiming-song stood complete in the air over the slope, claiming its singer.

It chose, she heard him say, under the mask, in the last bar. *As it always does. The choir must be complete.*

The choir was. It came down on him the way forty years of Chorus procedure came down on everything — thorough, aboveboard, and without an appeal — and when it let go, the herald-chorus stood ragged and silent on the slope, and the bone-masked captain knelt at the engine's cage in the attitude of a man finishing a recital, and the mask was uncracked, and he did not move again, and his white gloves were empty. Not bloody. *Empty.* The choir had finally collected its keeper's voice, and the books had the only entry the deep had ever needed for him: a first-generation herald, a failed key, performed the liturgy to the end. Gavel looked at the gloves for a long moment, and thought of a woman made of black lace on an altar rail, and ruled her column, and said to her overman in the flat voice the fog would carry no further than it had to:

"Mark the line paid. Nobody touches the mask. It's a headstone now, and we don't rob graves in this city. Not anymore."

* * *

The Cow screamed against the chord at dawn.

It had been moaning all night — begging at the count, begging at the children's song, begging at the pedal-tone rising out of the vaults, one chained engine-seed against eleven thousand freely given hearts — and when the Standing Count rolled over into its second hour, even and unhurried and impossible to bill, the engine-seed stopped begging and *screamed,* brass and glass and frost, the sound of a rendered city's heart being asked to sing against its own kind, and the herald-chorus broke and ran for the canal-works with their verses in their throats, and the wain itself shuddered an inch on its rollers like a coffin adjusting its shoulder.

And up every crack in Ashkarad — the door's hairline, the salt-glass seam, the wall-fissures, the chalked lines of Roya's living maps, the fault in a surgeon's chest — something older than the Church and the burning and the harvest came awake enough to speak. Not the Gardener's voice. Not the Sister's. Not any voice the city's ledgers held. It went up through the stone the way the lullaby had gone down through it for forty years, in the tongue understood without hearing, felt in the teeth, one word, filed everywhere at once, and every pulse-reader in Ashkarad printed it on the same stroke, and Ilay chalked it a foot high on the shaft-head gallery in her careful child's hand because someone had to, and it was not a threat and it was not a plea and it was not addressed to anyone in particular, which was the worst of it.

The Root was awake enough, at last, to say what it was.

HUNGRY.

CHAPTER 90

Both, or Neither

The word was still in the walls at dawn.

HUNGRY. It had come up through every crack in Ashkarad at once — through the singing fracture in the salt-glass door, up the cistern-necks and drain-channels, along the pump-works' iron and the tomb-thin spaces between tenement stones — and when the light came, it did not leave. Dar woke on a pallet in the shaft house with it filed behind his teeth, the way the deep's resonance always filed itself there, and lay listening to a whole city breathe around one syllable.

The Standing Count thinned as the sun rose. It did not end. All night it had held — every soul above the vault giving its heartbeats freely into one rhythm, Gavel's brass tube calling the count, Suri's couriers keeping the lines, the stock children singing Ilay's transcription in voices that no hymn could bait, the freed donors under the streets, the Sister's pedal-tone below it all like a hand under a falling body — and Dar had stood at the center of it holding the Ninth Vein's crack open the way a surgeon holds a retractor, not one hair wider than the wound requires. Now the great mass of it went home to water and bread, and what remained was the discipline: nothing below gets an answer. Answers are coin. The city had stopped spending.

The Cow's scream had burned itself down overnight to a whine, and by dawn to a whine you could only hear if you listened for it, which no one did. The herald-chorus stood in the bloom-fog beyond the seawalls with nobody left to conduct them. Their conductor the bone-masked captain they had found at first light, silent, gloves empty, laid out straight as a filed receipt. Ashkarad counted its dead from the night and got a number small enough to distrust, and posted it on the clinic door anyway, because a count you distrust is still worth keeping.

Then, in the hush the count left behind, the bargaining began.

It came up through the cracks the way the word had. But this time it was not one word. It was a voice — warm, patient, intimate, the voice Dar had spent a year calling his mother's — and it did not shout. It negotiated.

Feed me, it said, from the drains, from the door's fracture, from the salt in the walls. Feed me and I open. You want the door. I want the feeding. Both accounts settle. We are both owed.

The mimicry was very good, and that was the horror of it. It had the exact grain of the voice out of the memory bleeds — the voice the First Singer had used on him at the bottom of

the shaft, the voice his original heart had begged in when it sat in its glass box singing the lullaby in a mother's voice that was never his mother's. It was wrong the way the three-heartbeat face had been wrong: not in the timbre but in the arithmetic behind the timbre, a patience with nothing personal left in it. Every ninth beat the voice skipped, a needle jumping its groove, and began the sentence again, and each time it began again it was a little hungrier, the interest compounding in real time. It never sang the ending of the song. It hummed to the edge of the last bars and stopped there, as if the recording itself had been cut, and then it asked again, in the daughter's voice, to be fed and opened like a door is opened, like an account is opened, like a mouth.

Nobody answered it. The rule held at every threshold in the city. Suri had ruled it the first night, flat as a stamped page, and the city kept her rule the way it kept water: Nothing down gets a reply. A reply is credit, and we are not lending.

* * *

The Gardener came at the second hour, on foot, up the dry seabed.

The sea that had come back uphill to deliver the wain withdrew again before dawn — out and out past sight, as if the horizon had decided not to watch — and the flats lay bare and grey under the bloom-fog, ribbed with the old tide-marks, littered with the fleet's abandoned survey-cairns. She walked out of that fog the way an audit walks into a ledger room: unhurried, unavoidable, without apology. Alone. Bone-white hands bare at her sides, no gloves, nothing carried, nothing hidden. At each wrist a ring of old burn-scars, pale and regular as tally-marks. The herald ranks stood down to let her pass, and the clerks stood up out of their tents to watch her go, and she did not look at one of them, because you do not look at files.

At the tide-gates the last working gate-reader turned and printed, for the first time in its service, the only rhythm it had ever truly been listening for: the deep's own beat, slow, vast, one heartbeat to a mile. She passed under the arch without breaking stride.

Nobody ordered the way to the vault-mouth opened. Nobody dared order it closed. The crowd moved the way water moves around a thing it cannot afford to touch, and Dar stood on the shaft-house steps and watched her come up through her own fog, and knew her, and wished he did not.

He had bought three heartbeats of that face once, at a decade's price, in a counting-annex at Lowmark — a mother's face that was not quite his mother's, wrong in the mouth, where a smile is filed. She had knelt at an empty grave beyond the Door and looked up through a crack in the Ninth Vein and mouthed an endearment at him across the difference of worlds. Here she was at the mouth of the shaft with her hands bare, and the wrongness was still there, and

the likeness was still unbearable, and he understood at last that both of those facts were about the same woman.

"You held your door all night with your hearts," she said from four steps below him, in the voice of a woman closing a very old account. "I came to hear why. I heard." A pause, measured and paid. "I have come to ask, not to command. I have not asked anything of anyone in a hundred years. It is harder than commanding. The muscles go."

"Ask," Dar said.

"Open the Door with me." Her voice did not rise; it descended, into some plain register beneath all her registers, the way a tide-priest drops to the honest numbers when the service is over. "Not for me. With me. And let me bury my daughter in the garden she was stolen from. The grave is cut. It has waited a century, tended, empty. I want to carry what is left of her through, and lay it down, and be—" she considered the word the way she might consider a column that would not balance, "—finished. That is the whole of the request. I will sign it in your presence. I will sign it left-handed, so you know it is mine."

Before anyone could answer, the shaft answered for them.

Feed me, said the voice below, in the daughter's borrowed warmth. Open me. Feed me and I open. Both accounts settle—

and for one appalling moment the vault-mouth held both of them at once: the woman above asking, and the thing beneath asking in a stolen copy of the same family's voice. Same grain. Same patience. One wearing hunger and one wearing grief, and hearing them together, it was not possible to say which was the imitation.

"Enough," the Gardener said — to the shaft, not to Dar — in exactly the tone a keeper uses on a dog that begs at table. The cracks went quiet. Not silent. Quiet. A thing put on notice, with its hunger still accruing behind its eyes.

* * *

They convened at the shaft mouth because there was nowhere in the city large enough to hold a convergence like this one, and no time to build one. The ruin's open floor, the shaft dark at its center, the fog thinning against the broken arches. Suri came with the census tallies under her arm and her splinted forearm held like a ledger she was done with. Mother Gavel stood with her crews and her scars and her flat eyes, saying nothing, auditing everything. The Choirmaster, with his fire-axe grounded like a parade weapon. Wen, three paces behind his Warden, a century old and half-bloomed, watching the ninth's carrier the way a stopped clock watches noon. Isra with her slate, the black petal at her collarbone spread half open. Roya with

chalk she had no map for yet. And Ilay came down from among the singing children, drawn by whatever the deep said to her hearing, and stood with her palms against the stone of the shaft like a girl at a window.

The Gardener stated her account in the language the city respected, item by item, while the bloom-fog leaned against the doors: the Door opened from inside, by a living Throne — by the one who already held the Ninth's crack, who had held it through the whole of the Standing Count without blooming; the daughter's remains carried through and laid in the grave beyond; the Root fed on schedule, by her hand, while it slept; the fleet stood down; the harvest voided; the terms withdrawn. "That is the whole of the account," she said. "I have waited a hundred years to file it, and I file it now, here, with every witness the city can produce."

Below, patiently, in the daughter's voice: Feed me. Open me. We are both owed. Every ninth beat, the skip. Every skip, the hunger, restated.

And then the deep's harmony stopped.

Not the rhythm — the harmony. The pedal-tone under the city, the one line that had not ceased since the count began, ceased, and every head at the shaft mouth turned to the girl with her hands flat on the stone.

Ilay listened the way she listened, with her whole body, her copper head bent, her fingers spread on the rock. The stone said something. The music said it first, and then the girl said it after, in the flat, literal voice she used for counts and for truth, word for word, like a clerk reading a finding into the record:

"Her daughter is not in the grave."

The Gardener went very still. The fog stopped moving at the doors.

"Her daughter," Ilay said, "is the seed in his chest."

It came into the ruin like a verdict, because it was one: a century of testimony, closed out and read. The Gardener did not deny it. Denial was a filing error, and she had never once filed an error. She turned — slowly, the burn-scarred wrists first, as if they led her — and looked at Dar, and then at his chest, at the place where a stolen reliquary had cracked open a life ago and a ninth seed had chosen him, and Dar watched her recalculate a hundred years of arithmetic in the space of three heartbeats. He counted them. Counting was the only prayer he trusted, and he needed one.

Below, the deep went quiet. Not the held-breath quiet of a thing on notice. A listening quiet. Even the hunger, for one beat, waiting on the finding.

And in that quiet Dar felt the crack of the Ninth Vein shift against its own edges — a hair wider, the way a door shifts in a frame when the house settles — and felt what he held: the census of Ashkarad, every freely given heartbeat of the Standing Count, held in him the way a chord holds a note. The Lily rose through that chord like a pedal through a hymn. The hum climbed his sternum, into his throat, into his jaw, and his jaw ached with the shape of words he was not making, and he could have bitten down on them, and he knew with absolute certainty that she was not taking the mouth. She was asking for it. The way her mother had asked.

He let his own mouth open, and the voice in his chest came up through it — his voice and hers at once, doubled, aloud, through his mouth and her own, before the fleet and the city and her mother and the thing that ate:

"Both. Or neither."

CHAPTER 91

The True Books

The Lily's sentence had no column. Suri had tried three.

BOTH, OR NEITHER — she wrote it at the top of a fresh page in her own ledger, because somebody had to keep it somewhere, and the clinic's books were where the city kept what it could not afford to lose. Under it she ruled three columns and sat looking at them for the better part of an hour with the pen dry in her hand. Assets. Liabilities. Terms. Every sentence in Ashkarad was one of the three, and the sentence spoken through Dar Mehran's mouth in front of the fleet and the city was none of them, and that frightened her more than HUNGRY had, because HUNGRY she could have filed.

The city, meanwhile, kept the sentence the way it kept the fog: breathed around it, rationed against it, unwilling to name it indoors. Dar had come up from the shaft house gray as his coat and slept eleven hours, and waked, and asked her — the only question he asked, once, over the clinic stove — what she would file it under, and she had shown him the empty three columns, and he had looked at them the way he looked at an X-ray of something that had no business being alive, and said, "Good. It shouldn't fit." Then he had gone down to the wards to work, because a man holds two heartbeats and a crack in the Ninth Vein open by holding still and working, and Suri had closed the ledger on the empty columns and gone back to the door count.

Two days of silence from the fleet. The fog held, the censer-ration held, the Count held at its reduced strength, and the deep kept its listening quiet — not gone, not sleeping; attending — and on the third morning the tide-gates' watch hammered on the clinic door and said the Warden of the Reclaim was at the gate, alone, with a hand-cart.

Suri went down herself. She counted the steps on the way, one hundred and forty from the clinic to the gates, and made herself stop counting at sixty, because she knew what the rest of the count was for.

Wen stood at the customs post with the cart, and the cart was books. It outweighed him; you could see that it outweighed him, the way a coffin outweighs its next tenant — the handles dipped where his hands held, the axle already learning his lean. Stacks of ledgers under oilcloth, corner-clamped in brass, each spine lettered in the fleet's clerk-hand: ROUND-ACCOUNT, with years on them. A century of years. He had the white flag folded over his forearm like a towel over a barman's arm, and when she reached him he laid the flag

on the customs post, folded it once more, and left it there.

"The Reclaim has no warden now," he said. His voice was a hundred years of patience worn down to the grain. Half his face was bloom-lace to the jaw; the lace did not move when he spoke, which made the moving half worse. "It has books. Books should live with someone who reads them." He set both his hands flat on the cart's rail, a man steadying himself against a swell that had already passed. "You asked nobody. I am telling you anyway: it sang. Through his mouth. That was the fee I named at the tide-gate — to hear whether the ninth seed could really sing before I ended. The fee is paid. The books are the balance, and I am the balance's courier, and I am done."

Suri looked at the cart, then at him, and did the addition out loud, because he was owed it. "You're defecting."

"I'm filing," Wen said. "I've been filing for the enemy for a hundred years. The paper doesn't care which way the cart points. I do, now, at the end. Take the books, counter of the door. Read them better than we did."

She took the cart. Nobody stopped him leaving, and he did not leave; he sat down on the customs post beside his folded flag to wait for whatever the city decided a defected warden was, and Suri hauled a century of harvest-accounts up to the clinic counter one clamped stack at a time, and began.

* * *

The fleet's ledgers were beautiful, and that was the worst thing about them. Double-columned, cross-ruled, every entry initialed twice; a bookkeeping so clean you could eat off it, and what had been served off it for a century was cities. Suri read with Vell chalking the second copy behind her — the mute clerk's chalk moving steady as a pump-handle — and Milla Ferun certifying the pages they burned through, registrar's stamps, the city's own seals going down in the margins like a fence going up.

The round-account opened with Brack. BRACK — PRUNED, PAID, the stamp she had seen on the tally-book's first line, closed out to the last audited unit: yields, render-schedules, the pour-routes down the deep roads, the tallow-convoys, the feed. Lowmark's page was open by a carcass — its seed cut, its rendering begun, its account not yet closed — and behind it, entered in the same fair hand, in the same patient columnar rhythm, seven bloomed cities still on the schedule. The Vigil. Gullet. Sarn. Weep. Ossuar. Hallowfen. Lowmark, to be finished. Every one with its yield-assessment, its season, its route. Every one a place where people kept water and bread and children, priced to the unit, signed per the Reclaim.

Suri read the yields twice. She read them twice because the first time her eyes had done a clerk's trick she despised: they had slid off the numbers the way eyes slide off a wound. The Vigil's whole whispering population, entered as a feed-mass. Gullet's four mortgaged generations, entered as they had mortgaged themselves, to the unit, four generations of scrip and interest reconciled into tallow. She had audited cruel books before. She had never audited books this calm. Halfway down the Vigil's page the schedule computed a per-heart yield, a figure so tidy she copied it out, struck it through, and copied it again, because the strike-through was the only protest the arithmetic allowed — and then she made Vell chalk the true number on the slate instead, because chalk could be washed, and the washing was a rite the city had invented for exactly this kind of arithmetic.

"He's right," she said to Vell, without turning her head. "We're reading them better. Better isn't the word I want."

Vell chalked: THE BOOKS ARE CORRECT. THAT IS THE DISEASE.

* * *

The brother came at dusk, with the second set.

She knew the cough before she knew the footsteps — a fog-sick cough keeping time, four beats and a rest, four beats and a rest, the cadence he had counted in since he was six years old and she was nine and the two of them had kept a pavement game of it outside the tithe-clinics, counting to make the waiting shorter. He came up the clinic steps gray-faced with it, a counting-clerk's case under one arm, clerk's calluses and ink-stains and the fleet's blank-rectangle tar still ghosted on his collar where he had scraped at it, and Suri stood behind her counter and counted his coughing for him so he wouldn't have to, four and a rest, four and a rest, and hated that it steadied him.

"Dathan," she said.

"You still count before you speak," he said.

"You still speak before you count." She came around the counter. She did not touch him; the toll for touching, with the fog in his lungs and the fog's hunger in the fog, was more than she could price tonight. "You countersigned for them."

"Eleven years." He set the case on the counter and opened it, and the books inside were not beautiful. Thinner paper, wrong-ruled, the margins full of a hand that had begun trying to write small enough to disappear. "Schedules, sister. The true ones. I countersigned the harvest's true schedule for eleven years, and last week I stood in that fog and coughed in your cadence and heard, through a wall, your census being read aloud in the quarry — names, and

names, and no debts attached to any of them — and I understood that I had been an honest clerk for the wrong ledger my whole life." He took his hands off the case the way a man takes his hands off a railing over deep water. "It shamed me. Shame is a kind of arithmetic. I'm bringing you the difference."

She thought of one thing first, before the books, before the war, before the nine days: a nineteen-year-old with her skin sold and six weeks to live on the open market, and a boy of fifteen who went out into the fog with no trade but counting and came back with the coin that bought her graft home. He had never said where the coin came from. She had never asked. Some accounts you keep balanced by leaving the interest unexamined. He buys things back, she thought. It was the family sickness. He had bought her back once, and now he had walked out of the enemy's books to buy the difference on a city.

Inside: the harvest's true schedule, in the fleet's second hand, the one that matched nothing they had been shown — real dates, real yields, the pour-routes and the seasons and the seven bloomed cities still entered and owed — and behind the schedule, sealed in a sleeve of lead-foil that had cost someone a career to open, one page headed with a stamp Suri had never seen and understood immediately:

PROVISION — FINAL. RECLAIM OF ASHKARAD.

Below the stamp, in clerk-hand, countersigned by her brother's own initials in the corner like a knife:

The Door will be opened from within, by a living Throne, within nine days of service of this provision. On failure: prune, and uncount.

"Uncounted," Suri said. She made herself read the word in a normal voice. She was the city's counter; she knew what every threat in the ledger weighed, and this one she had to weigh aloud to believe. "Not pruned. Uncounted. Struck before the harvest, not after. No yield entered. No line-item. No name kept. No receipt." She looked up at her brother, and her voice did what it never did; it went somewhere young. "There's no column for that. There's no column for a whole city that was never allowed to have existed."

"I know," Dathan said. "I countersigned it four times. Service copies."

She ruled a new column on her own page, under the Lily's sentence, and wrote: NINE DAYS. Then, because she was who she was, she wrote the date of the ninth day, and looked at it. The clinic stove ticked. Vell's chalk had stopped.

* * *

The true books' last page was not clerk-hand.

It was bound at the back of the second set the way a flyleaf is bound, as if it had always been there, as if the binder had been told to grow the book around it. The paper was not paper. Suri knew memory-velum now; the whole city knew it since Lowmark; the leaf had that pressed, warm grain, like skin that had agreed to be something else. It was written left-handed, the letters slanting against every other hand in the books, and where a signature belonged there was no name — only the flower, drawn in a single stroke and drawn again over itself, a stamp of a sigil, blooming from a crack in the earth. The page carried the Root's account. The feeding, the schedule, the standing balance of the thing beneath them, entered and reconciled to date.

Beside the account, in fresh ink, cramped into the margin the way people write things they do not mean to send, one private line:

it no longer knows my song.

Suri read it once as a clerk and once as a sister, and then she did what she had done her whole life with pages that were too heavy to hold and too true to burn. She filed it, under seal, in the drawer that held Milla's printout and Vey's registry page and the Sister's black truce-petal — the city's unpayables, its drawer of things counted and kept — and she ruled the column beneath her brother's provision with a straightedge, and wrote the only entry her whole hand believed:

WE OPEN NOTHING IN NINE DAYS WE DO NOT CHOOSE IN NINE DAYS. — K.

CHAPTER 92

What the Daughter Was

The Lily began counting to nine on the night after the books were served, and Roya caught it first, because a rhythm on paper is still a map.

Dar felt it before he understood it — a change in the pedal under his own two heartbeats, a new figure worked into the hum the way a clerk works a reconciliation into an open column. Nine pulses. A rest. Nine pulses. The rest between was not silence; it was held breath, the pause a household makes when it is waiting on a name. He lay on the clinic roof in the dark with his coat as a pillow and counted her counting, and the count did not vary, and that was how he knew it was language: nature never counts that evenly twice.

By the second night Roya had chalked it. Ilay heard it too — of course she did; she had been transcribing the garden's true song since before anyone knew there was one — and the two of them, the severed surveyor and the nine-year-old instrument, worked the figure out at the attic window while Dar stood behind them holding a lamp he was not allowed to light. Nine pulses, rest, nine pulses. "She is not keeping time," Ilay said, in the flat voice she kept for findings. "She is keeping a family."

Roya chalked the figure out as a diagram by the third night, because that was what it was: nine circles in a ring, one shaded, and above the nine a single larger circle struck through with a black bar — the Burning, entered as a date. Dar stood looking at the shape on the attic wall, a genealogy drawn by a woman who could not hear and a girl who heard everything, transcribed off a rhythm kept by a seed, and the shaded circle was the ninth, and Roya shaded it the way she shaded living things.

The pulses assembled what the verdict at the shaft mouth had only implied. Nine of a kind, the rhythm said, rest, grown from one. Nine issued against a single account. And when the figure reached the spent ones, Dar felt each disbursal land — eight small closed cadences in sequence, like pages being turned in a ledger someone else is holding: a seed in Brack, cut and spent; a seed in Lowmark, drowned and rendered; seeds sown in Sarn, Weep, Ossuar, Hallowfen, in the Vigil's lead-glass dark, in Gullet's engine; every one an account now closed, harvested down the deep roads to feed the thing their mother slept above. The ninth still open. The rest cut, and spent, and fed.

Vahid confirmed it against the Church's own papers in the cellar, one-handed, turning the nursery registry pages with the flat of his palm: the sibling-stock ledgers, generations of

children grown from tissue taken from the First Vessel, graded, reserved, sung to. "The Church knew a hundredth of it and banked it as breeding stock," he said, and his voice had the wobble in it that meant the gin was not working fast enough. "The Gardener knew all of it and banked it as daughters. Same tissue, boy. Same source. Every seed in the World Registry and every child in the Church's registry, drawn on the same account." He pulled the old photograph out of the drawer then — he kept it the way misers keep a coin — the first volunteer, his and Shirin's first, blooming into a garden at the edge of the frame, and laid it on the nursery ledger so the two documents could audit each other. "We thought we were growing a heart that couldn't break," he said. "We were growing somebody's daughter, and we did not know whose. Shirin knew before I did. Shirin always knew before I did." He looked up, and the wire-mended spectacles caught the lamp. "Drawn," he said again, quietly, testing the word and finding it exact. "Every one of them drawn on the daughter."

And the daughter was the thing that lay dead in the cold chamber down among the deep salt vaults — the First Vessel, the Gardener's daughter, the lid — and the account had been opened at the First Burning, and nine cuttings had been issued against it, and the ninth was asleep in his chest, counting to nine in the dark, waiting for someone to read her arithmetic right.

* * *

Isra felt the testimony arrive the way she felt everything from below now: as a change of temperature in the root at her collarbone, a slow warming, like a hand closing around hers from underneath.

The deep wanted to depose. She knew the wanting well — a century of it, banked. She took her slate and went down the seven hundred and eleven steps with Dar behind her and Suri behind him, because the Sister had asked — the slate said SHE WILL SAY IT ONLY ONCE, in Isra's own careful letters — and what the eldest of the nine seeds had to say, she would say at the door, to her family, with the city's witnesses on the stair.

Her root paid the toll from the first step and paid it rising. The deep did not speak to her in words; it spoke in warmth, in currents under her skin, in the old arrangement she had made with it on the flats, and tonight the current ran heavy, the way a pipe runs heavy before it floods. By the four hundredth step her breath showed white. By the six hundredth her fingers were stiff and she was warming them under her arms between phrases, and she thought, with the cold clarity the deep lent her: a century of testimony, and she has been waiting for the room to be full enough to hold it.

The antechamber was cold and the salt-glass door stood open as it had stood open since the night the city learned what a lid was, and beyond it the vaults held their one heart in three chambers, counting back in threes. Isra set her bare palm flat on the glass, and the petal at her collarbone opened all the way for the first time since the flats, and the testimony moved through her like water moving through a diver, weightless and enormous, and she wrote as fast as her hand allowed and warmer letters cost her, and did not stop.

The Gardener's daughter was dying at the Burning. The garden's heart was already buried, already hungry, already waking to its feeding, and the daughter — burned, bled, past saving — had been carried into the deep and locked above it as a living lid, because a dying daughter's song was the only song that could keep the Root dreaming, and the world had needed the Root dreaming.

And the Gardener, who did not accept accounts she could not pay, had gone into the dying and begun to cut.

Nine cuttings from the daughter as she died. Nine seeds, each one a daughter grown past death, each one sown with the same instruction the white hands had given across a century — Go. Find your hearts. And bloom. — and the first cutting was the eldest, taken while the daughter's heart still beat, taken from the living dying of her; and the eldest fled the Burning in a lead-and-glass reliquary with eight smaller sisters coffined around her, and watched through glass for a hundred years while the world above buried the garden and the harvest grew and the pour-routes opened and her mother's books came for city after city; and Isra wrote and wrote and her letters went crooked with cold and cost, and the last line of the deposition she wrote slowly, pressing hard, so it would not be mistaken for anything but what it was:

I AM THE FIRST. SHE IS THE LAST. WE ARE ALL OF US THE DAUGHTER.

The antechamber was silent. Suri had her ledger open and was not writing in it. Dar stood with one hand flat over the place where his second heartbeat lived, and the Lily pressed back against his palm, once, the way a child presses back.

Then every bloom in the vault spoke.

It was not loud. Frost-flowers on the vault walls, the grey lace on the fractured door, the black petals folded at Isra's collarbone, the faint blooming in the salt itself where the old harvest had seeded the stone — every flowering thing below the city opened at once and gave up one sentence, in a voice like a woman reading her own apology off a page she has rehearsed so long the ink has worn through:

"Some things were meant to be shared. I shared her the only way I had left."

The words came and settled like ash. Isra found she had written them on the slate without being asked — the blooms spoke through her root the way the deep spoke through Ilay, and her hand had taken dictation from her enemy's mother without consulting her — and she looked at the sentence standing there in her own careful letters, an apology rehearsed for a hundred years, and could not decide which was worse: that it was monstrous, or that it was true, or that it was both and would therefore never balance.

The Sister said nothing. The one heart in the vaults behind the open door went on counting in threes, and the silence it kept was not assent and was not accusation; it was the silence of someone hearing, at last, the reason for the worst thing that ever happened to her, and finding that the reason was smaller than the wound.

Then, below the glass, the pedal resumed — but changed, the way a held note changes when the player decides to go on. Isra felt the deep take the deposition the way a ledger takes an entry: filed, cross-referenced, not closed. The vault air warmed by one degree, no more; a body's worth of warmth, spent from somewhere. Against the far side of the salt-glass, level with Isra's hand, frost gathered and bloomed and un-bloomed, a slow clench and release, clench and release, the deep's whole grammar reduced to a fist learning not to be one. She had carried a century of this thing's words and she had never once felt it refuse to strike until tonight.

It was Ilay who spoke, from the stair, where she had come down uninvited again with her chalk already out — nine years old, copper-haired, the garden's daughter, the girl the Church had graded PERFECT and the city had failed to price. She had listened to the whole deposition with her head tilted, doing the arithmetic children do, the honest kind, the kind adults file under sentiment and lose.

"Then the eleven are my cousins," she said.

Nobody corrected her. Vell's chalk hung over the slate. Suri's pen hung over the ledger. Dar looked from the girl to the door to the vault where the cold chamber lay with its grave-goods — his own original heart buried there like a wreath — and could not find one column in which the correction would balance. The eleven freed vessels and the nine sown seeds were flowers off the same stem, the Church's breeding ledgers and the Gardener's World Registry two hands writing in the same book, and the smallest witness in Ashkarad had closed the account in four words while the adults were still ruling columns. Elias, half a flight above her on the stair, heard it and grinned, and she did not grin back, because it had not been a joke. It had been a filing.

Ilay turned her palm over and looked at the chalk dust on it, and added, in the same flat finding-voice, the part she had actually come down to say:

"And the music says the eldest has been counting us all since the Burning. She wants to know if the cousins can visit."

CHAPTER 93

The Honest Text

The fourteenth cylinder had been mocking him for a year, and Professor Vahid Anousheh had been letting it, because mockery was the only form of conversation left to them.

Nine days on the city's clock. Nine days, served like a summons, chalked on the clinic wall under the provision's terms in Suri's straightedge hand, and the whole of Ashkarad walking around the number the way you walk around a hole in a stair. Vahid did not walk around it. He sat in the cellar under the clinic, under the census and the wards and the shaft-house, with his one hand and his wire-mended spectacles and the fourteen wax cylinders of Dr. Shirin Bahar, and he worked the problem that had ruined his life twice, once with gin and once without.

He had transcribed her words months ago. That was the bitter joke of it: her voice, dropped and recovered from the wax, all of it, every lecture and margin-note and grumble about the bench hygiene of juniors, and the words ended where his papers ended — at Bone. Everything past the Sixth Vein, in her recordings, was silence, or near enough. The fourteenth cylinder ended mid-sentence, mid-word: and then you will hear the sound— and the stylus lifted and the groove ran empty and he had sat in this cellar a year ago with his hand over his mouth while the machine hissed.

Tonight he stopped listening to her words.

He had been listening to her words because he was an anatomist and words were dissections, and because listening to her voice was a debt he paid in installments and did not intend to retire. But the city needed the third way to have an instrument, and Dar had come down the cellar stairs the night before with the look of a man carrying a diagnosis he could not yet file — Both, or neither, the sentence the whole city was rationing around — and had said, in his flat surgeon's way, what Suri's ledger had said: we have a song the deep cannot count, or we have nothing. And Vahid had lain awake with the gin untouched, which was itself a symptom, and heard, in memory, not her words.

Her hums.

Between the sentences of every lecture, in the gaps where she thought, she hummed. He had filed it for forty years as a habit, the way you file a tic. He had recorded it for a year as texture. It had never once occurred to him — and the not-occurrence would keep him up the rest of his life — that Shirin Bahar did not do anything without filing a reason.

He took the third cylinder, her lecture on graft-bed preparation, and set the needle down, and did not transcribe the words. He wrote the pitches. Note by note, hum by hum, in the rest-gaps between her sentences, he took down the intervals she was carrying the way other people carry a tune, and the intervals did not wander, did not decorate, did not once resolve the way a satisfied hum resolves. They were exact. They were staved. They were — and his hand began to shake at the eighth bar, and he pinned it flat with his forearm and kept writing — ordered.

"Marginalia," he said to the empty cellar, in the voice that had once held four hundred students. "She called them marginalia. The word was not decoration, it was a filing instruction."

* * *

He worked until the lamp oil was a coin's depth in the glass. Cylinder by cylinder, hum by hum, the gaps between her words gave up a continuous text — pitches and rests, bar after bar after bar, a long file of them, and when he laid the pages out on the slate shelf and looked down the whole run of it at once, he saw what it was, and he sat down on the stool very slowly, like a man sitting down in front of a mirror that has decided to be honest.

It was not the lullaby.

It was the true song. Ilay's transcription — the garden's song, every verse, the mother's line included, the score the child had titled for my grandmother — was copied fair on the wall above the chalk ladder, and he took it down and put his pages beside it, and the two texts agreed. Note for note. Rest for rest. Two witnesses, a century apart, deposing to the same song: a nine-year-old girl hearing it through the city's bones, and a dead woman hiding it in the gaps of her own voice forty years ago.

"Test-seed," he said. His hands were cold. It was not the cellar. "There was a test-seed. Before the Church took the work. Before Vey's predecessors came to our bench with their polite letters and their ledger smiles. We grew it from the ancestor strain and it sang — once, at night, in the dark of the workshop, when the lamps were out and the blood-feeds were late. I was drunk. I remember the drone of it and not the notes." He stopped. Corrected himself, the way he had corrected students, gently, with the blade: "I remember that I did not hear it. She heard it. And she understood, before I did, what a plain notation of that song would be worth, and to whom, and she spent the rest of her recorded life filing it where no auditor reads — inside the wrapper of her own voice, between the words, in the rests, in the margins, humming her honesty into the places of the record where meaning is not looked for."

The honest text of the upper Veins existed. It had existed for decades. His partner had written it, and hidden it, and died for the archive that held it, and the Church had kept her voice six years in glass and never once thought to listen to the silences.

Vahid Anousheh took off his spectacles, and wiped them with the heel of his one hand, and put them back on, and read the text again from the top. This time he read it as what it was: not a song deposed but a doctrine scored. The notation did not climb. That was the first thing. Every chart of the Nine Veins he had ever chalked — his own included, his own especially — climbed: Flesh at the base, rung above rung, Throne at the top like a salary. Her notation did not climb. It layered. Voice upon voice, line upon line, each part complete and each part incomplete alone, the whole of it demanding to be struck together.

He chalked it in the morning, on the cellar wall under the old ladder, for the council to find: the seven opened rungs drawn as he had always drawn them — and then, where the eighth and ninth had always stood as rungs, he drew them as she had scored them. Not steps. Lines in a chord. Soul, the door shared between two — he had paid one lifetime learning that. And the ninth, the Throne, drawn not as a rank above the others but as the chord entire: Flesh through Throne, every carrier's line held at once, one harmony, none of it sounding if any of it is struck alone.

"The ninth is not a rung," he said to Dar, who had come down the stairs with two cups of the clinic's acorn coffee and stood holding both, because there was only the one hand to receive with and the boy had not yet learned to hand things to him left-first. "I have been teaching your generation a ladder, boy, because a ladder is what a man can climb alone, and I am a man who was left alone. My partner taught the truth: the ninth is a harmony of carriers. Ilay drew it in chalk a month before I proved it — nine petals, every petal connected to the others. I have never in my life been so furious or so proud, and both were at a child."

Dar set the cups down on the slate shelf and looked at the wall for a long time. "The Gardener climbs," he said at last. "She offered to climb it with whoever said yes. One climber, her holding the far side."

"One climber, and the Gardener's hand on the far side, and the ledger unrewritten, and the deep still fed blind." Vahid tapped the chord with his knuckle, line by line, Flesh to Throne. "Her text shows what the Door checks. Not fortune. Company. It was never a treasure at the top of a climb, boy. It was an ensemble at the bottom of one, and the audition is the score." He looked at the wall, and then at the boy, and permitted himself the one thing he had sworn off in the Blacktide's ashes, which was hope with the interest left running. "And count your ensemble, since you are a man who counts. The census of the willing, held in you. A Sister's pedal-tone under the city, kept true for a century. A child's score. A count that sings instead of

being counted. The ensemble is not coming, boy. The ensemble is here. It has been tuning for a year." He put his one hand flat on the chalk. "The Gardener offered you her hand on the far side of the door. My partner's notation says we will not need it." He heard himself, and winced, and corrected the claim to the size of his proof. "Will not need it, if the share holds. If." He took his spectacles off, and wiped them, and put them back. "I am an old man advising you to bet a city on a dead woman's hums. I am aware of how it sounds. I was there when she hummed them, and I have been wrong about her exactly once, and it was the not-listening, and I am done being wrong on that line item."

* * *

He finished the protocol that afternoon, because grief is fuel if you are careless with it and he had been careless with it for forty years: the chorus-free distillation, the numbered vials, Shirin's counter-singing that sings to nothing — complete at last, every dose a sentence of hers, the whole of it written fair and signed, and the last line he ruled across the page with a straightedge like a man closing an estate.

THE LINE CLOSES HERE. THE LILY IS THE LAST SEED OF THE STRAIN.

He signed it with his one hand, and dated it, and did not explain it to the council beyond what needed explaining, because some rulings are not arguments: the honest text made new seeds unnecessary and made new seeds obscene — the world did not need a tenth daughter grown past death; it needed the nine voices it had, struck together. Whatever the Gardener's books said a strain was for, the strain ended where the harmony began. He had spent his life on the ladder. He was ending it on the chord, and the chord was her notation, and the Lily would be the last of the line because the line had never needed more than one good listener and one good singer, and he had married the listener and carried the singer, and both of those were past him now, and the music was not.

The lamp was nearly out. The fourteenth cylinder sat on the spindle where it had sat for a year, mid-word, mid-accusation: and then you will hear the sound—

He knew now what he had not known: that the stylus had not lifted because the sentence failed. It lifted because the recording jumped bands — because the last stretch of her message was not cut in the voice-groove at all. There was a second groove. Finer, shallower, cut with the workshop's light sapphire needle that he had mourned as lost with everything else of hers: a hairline track spiraling inside the voice-track, readable only at half the weight, and he had played this cylinder a hundred times at full weight like a surgeon operating through a drape.

He changed the needle. He halved the weight. He set the arm, and let the outer band run to the cut — and then you will hear the sound— — and the stylus dropped into the hairline and

the cellar filled with her voice again, younger, from a night with the lamps out, and she finished the sentence she had begun forty years and one lifetime ago:

"—is the share."

CHAPTER 94

Order, or Hunger

The Choirmaster had sung in worse venues than Mother Gavel's quarry. He had sung, in his time, over harvest floors, over the amphitheater where the Church graded children like fruit, over the long glass shelves of the reliquary corridor where he now kept the dead's house ready for singing — but he had never sung in a venue with acoustics this honest. The quarry threw every voice back to its owner. A man could stand on the pit's lowest tier and hear exactly what he sounded like. He had always suspected that was why Gavel held her assemblies here. It was the only room in Ashkarad where a lie had to pay its own freight.

They convened at dusk, with five of the nine days spent and four remaining, chalked on the clinic wall where the whole city had to walk past them, and the bloom-fog banked grey over the rim like an unvisited creditor, and the pit filled the way the pit had filled once before, the night the city's vote had died mid-count. The Index came under Seft with a drafted ordinance in a leather sleeve and forty grey coats who did not hum. Mother Gavel's remnant came — not her crews entire; her crews that still kept the old arithmetic, Harl the overman at their head with the ration-books and the exact, unforgiving face of a man who has never once overpaid for anything. The Hammers' remnant came last, up the south ramp, fog-scarred men and women led by an overman named Dree who coughed between sentences in the cadence the fog taught, four beats and a rest, and behind them the fog-sick of the eastern districts came in their hundreds, called by nothing, following the hunger in the air the way iron filings follow a file.

And the city came, under both seals: the counted, the willing, the census of the roll that Suri had built and Milla had kept and Vell had chalked fair. Dar sat on the first tier with the census held in him and his face doing the thing it did in triage, which was nothing. Roya and Ilay had a bench at the rim, chalk and child, her instrument and her map. Isra came with her slate and Wen came with nothing at all, which for a warden was a kind of statement. The Choirmaster came with his thirty — the freed, once-harvested voices — and seated them on the second tier like a choir, because forty years of administration had taught him exactly one reliable fact about crowds, which was that a crowd that can hear itself is a different instrument from a crowd that cannot.

He brought the fire-axe. He leaned it against the bench, in view, not for use. A man his age owed the room his tools and his history, and both were edged.

Mother Gavel opened it, from the pit's center, with her brass tube left at home for the first time in anyone's memory. She spoke like a tariff schedule. "The fleet served its provision. Nine days. The city has voted twice and deadlocked twice. My crews' debts go in the fire first, whatever you choose; that is my one term and it stands. Count it straight." She looked at Harl, and something passed between them that had been passing between bosses and overmen since before the Church learned to stamp, and Harl stepped up and laid the remnant's case on the table like a man laying down a hand of cards he had counted to the last card.

"Option one," Harl said. "The Index's ordinance. A new Gardener."

Seft took it up in the tone of a writ being read, which after all it was: the Reclaim's schedule honored, amended, humanized. A new Gardener — the city's own, chosen, salted in the city's interest — who would feed the deep on schedule, prune the seven bloomed cities still on the books kindly, with mercy, with anesthesia, with music, at the tail of a reformed calendar; who would take the chair the terms had named and sit it with a local conscience. "Order," Seft said, "with the cruelty filed off. The ledgers keep. The ledgers have always kept. We are not voting on whether the deep eats. We are voting on who holds the fork, and how sharp it is, and I put it to the roll that a knife in an honest local hand is worth more to the counted than a hymn."

Harl seconded it with the arithmetic, because the remnant's case was arithmetic and Harl did not pretend otherwise. "The schedule is coming," he said. "It has come to seven cities ahead of us, on time, every time, for a century. I have read the true books. My boss burned a charter and kept her water-works, and I keep the ration-books, and the ration-books say a fed thing with a known appetite is cheaper than a starving thing with an unknown one. Take the chair. Hold the fork. Somebody is going to; it should be a hand that signs in this pit."

The fog-sick did not wait for Dree. They came up over the benches like weather, and their spokesman was nobody — a woman with salt-crusted lips and a craving in her eyes that the censers could no longer reach, who stood on a bench and said, in a voice with no music left in it: "Feed it kindly. That's option one. I'll tell you what option one sounds like. It sounds like the engine at Gullet. It begged at shift-change. Kindly." And then Dree gave option two its body, coughing on the rest-beats: burn the garden. Free every seed in the world into hunger and let the world take its chances — the deep starved, the Root dead, the bloomed Thrones turned loose from the schedule to eat or be eaten, Ashkarad alive because everything else was food or fire. "I have watched hunger run a city for a year," Dree said, "and I will take its honesty over your ledger's mercy. Burn it. Let the world roll its own dice. We were counted worth eating once. Never again."

The count went to the roll. Milla called the districts; Vell chalked; Suri tallied with the flat speed of a woman counting other people's heartbeats, which was what she had been doing for a year.

Dead even. The quarry made a sound the Choirmaster had heard once before in this pit, the night a skipped heartbeat had stopped a vote — a sound like a held instrument.

They counted it again. Dead even, to the soul. The fog moved a little on the rim. Below them all, under a mile of salt, the deep kept its listening quiet, and the Choirmaster, who could hear a settling chord from thirty yards, heard the settling in the ground and did not like the key it was settling into.

He stood up.

He had written sermons for the Church of the Silent Chorus. He had taught the nursery hymns — the compliance-hymns, the little tunes with the anatomical hooks, the songs built to make tissue compliant — and he had graded children by lung and larynx with the same hand that now gripped a bench, and he had burned a registry of names with thirty witnesses and meant it, and all of it was in the account, and he had never once in his life paid into this particular column, so he paid it now, into the honest acoustics of the pit, at his own freight:

"I have administered song for the order of this city for forty years," he said, and the quarry took his baritone and gave it back to him, true. "I know precisely what order harvests. I graded the harvest. I have stood at an amphitheater rail and announced a boy's lungs to a paying floor — Today we welcome little Elias to the choir — and called it liturgy. I tuned the compliance-hymns to the bloodstream; the Church called that order. I watched forty years of organs go into glass singing the lullaby to keep the deep asleep, and the Church called that order. Order, ladies and gentlemen of the counted, is a filing system for hunger. It does not reduce the eating. It issues receipts for the eating. I have signed them."

He let the pit hold that. Somewhere on the Index benches a clerk stopped writing, and he heard it, and went on.

"And I know what hunger eats, because I have heard it eat. It eats kindly, at schedule, with anesthesia and music; you have heard the engine at Gullet beg — that is what a fed hunger sounds like. Or it eats everything, if you burn the keepers off it; you have smelled Lowmark on the wind — that is what a freed hunger sounds like. I have spent my life between those two instruments and I am done being played by either." He looked down the tiers, over the Index and the remnant and the fog-sick and the counted, and he set his hand flat on the bench beside the axe. "So I will vote for the thing I have never once seen administered. Not order. Not hunger. Consent. I have heard hymns sung by force and anthems sung by fear and a city's

worth of heartbeats given freely in one rhythm because they chose it, and I am a professional, and I am telling you the last of those was the finest performance I have ever heard in my life. Vote the third way. Write nothing down that a soul has not signed. I have been the administrator of order, and I am retiring from it, and my last act of administration is this: I give the roll back to the singers."

He sat down. The quarry was quiet the way the vault was quiet, and then, from the third tier, a boy's lungs did what the Choirmaster's own hymns had once been written to make lungs do — took a breath the whole pit could hear — and did not sing. Elias just breathed, once, deeply, a boy in a room full of adults deciding on purpose not to perform, and the pit heard the breath, and the breath was the Amen. The Choirmaster's thirty sat very straight on their bench, thirty throats the Church had once borrowed and returned, and not one of them made a sound, because he had trained them, and training, like order, can finally be aimed by consent.

Then Suri's voice went up the tiers, district by district, and Milla called, and Vell chalked, and the count came down the pit like water finding the drain.

The third way carried at dawn. Not by much; by a margin they counted twice and then a third time because the fog-sick benches rose to vote it too, craved and starving and counted, and their votes went into the third column because a choice made under a hunger is still a choice, and the roll was the roll. At the rim Roya chalked as the totals closed, and Ilay stood with her hands flat on the quarry rock, and said, to nobody, in her finding-voice: "It's listening to the chalk." The grey light came up over the eastern wall and found the pit tier by tier, and the fog on the rim thinned the way fog does when there is nothing left to negotiate with, and the Choirmaster stood with his axe untouched at his bench and let his forty years come down off his shoulders like a coat he had finally been billed for and finally paid.

Mother Gavel watched the chalk close, and nodded once, tariff-short, and went to tell her crews.

And beneath the quarry, beneath the salt and the vaults and the three-chambered heart that had kept the city's time since the Burning, the deep heartbeat slowed. Not stopping. Slowing — a beat drawn out, and another, like a thing leaning its weight against a door to listen, like a debtor hearing the terms of his own restructuring read aloud in a room above him, and deciding, for the length of the reading, to keep still.

CHAPTER 95

The Warden's Chair

Dar left everything at the clinic door.

He went through the ritual the way he went through a scrub before surgery, itemized, no deviations: Vey's registry page in the sealed drawer with Milla's printout and the Sister's black truce-petal and the Gardener's last private line. The brass tube back on its hook in the shaft house, Suri's terms chalked under it. Wen's books under double seal in the counting-room. The petal-token from Gullet, the warden's white flag folded at the customs post. His coat pockets turned out on the table, and Suri watching him do it with her pen still, and neither of them saying the thing they were both counting, which was that a man who carries nothing cannot be made to owe anything, and that a man who owes nothing is the most dangerous instrument the enemy has ever been offered.

"Nothing you cannot lose," he said, at the door. It had been the Sister's advice through Isra's slate, a year and a climb ago, and he had been paying on it ever since.

Suri looked at his empty hands, and then at his chest, where the only thing he could not put down lived. "Bring back a receipt," she said.

The seabed was dry again and the fog was down, and the walk out was four miles of old tide-rib and survey-cairns with the bloom-fog breathing its hunger on the back of his neck, and he counted it, because counting was the only currency he could carry safely into a creditor's camp. The fleet had gone quiet in four days. Tents of clerks with their lamps out. White-gloved auditors standing at rest along the lanes with no rounds to walk. The herald-chorus in its long rank, silent, facing a conductor's place where nothing stood but a chalk rectangle and a pair of empty gloves laid straight as ruled lines. The Cow sat on its wagon at the camp's heart with its scream burned down to a whine, and the whine went through the fog like a debt through an estate, diminishing every party to it.

They let him pass. Nobody had to order it. He had learned the fleet's grammar on the road: you did not enter a Reclaim camp; you were received into it, and the receiving was the audit.

The wain stood at the camp's far edge, and it was bigger inside than it had any right to be, and the counting-room at its center was a shrine to the one god Ashkarad had exported to the world: shelves of ledgers to the ceiling, brass clamps, the smell of memory-velum and lamp oil and salt, and a lamp turned low, and a chair.

It was not a throne. That was the first thing he understood, standing in the doorway, and the understanding was worse than a throne would have been. It was a working chair — bone-pale wood, high-backed, the armrests worn to a gloss by a single pair of hands over a very long career — set facing the shelves the way a teller's chair faces the drawers. Whoever sat it did paperwork. The paperwork was the world.

"Sit, little root," said the Gardener.

She sat across the table from the chair, gloved again — the formal gloves, white, immaculate, burn-scarred wrists hidden — with a lamp between them and no book open, which for her was the equivalent of bare hands. She looked tired. She had looked tired walking up the seabed, and she looked tired now, and the tiredness was the oldest thing in the room, older than the ledgers, older than the chair.

"You voted," she said. "I read it in the frost the morning after. A city of counted souls, choosing its own filing. I confess the result did not surprise me. It did something better than surprise me. It interested me." She folded her hands on the table, unhurried. "So I am authorized to make the formal offer, and I will make it properly, with the terms spoken aloud, because you are a man who pays his debts, and such men sign nothing they have not heard entire."

"The city chose the third way," Dar said.

"The city chose the third way," she agreed. "The city does not know what the third way costs. I do. You will want it priced before your nine days run; you shall have it priced. First the offer, because an honest auditor shows the alternative on the books before the loss column." She indicated the chair with two white fingers. "The seat. The office. The Gardener's chair. Vey reached for it with both hands and a century of harvested throats, and the reach is what unmade her — she tried to take the chair without paying for it. You are not Vey. You have never once taken anything without paying. I have watched you for a year: you refuse transactions you cannot stand behind; you count before you spend; you buried your own heart to keep it from being weaponized against a city. Sized at last, Dar Mehran, for a man who pays his debts. The terms are these: the Root fed on schedule, by your hand, kindly, forever. The seeds pruned gently, the seven cities of the schedule stewarded to their rest — years, decades, with anesthesia and music, a mercy the schedule has never once been run on. The world ordered and living. No more Bracks. No more uncounted. Every city in the books, and every city in the books alive, under a keeper who audits himself." Her voice did not rise; it descended, into the register beneath her registers. "I have offered this chair to no one in a hundred years. I offer it to you with the whole of my attention, which is the dearest thing I own."

Dar looked at the chair. It was, he had to give her, exactly what it was: an instrument for feeding something terrible on schedule so that the terrible thing never had to eat anyone again, held by a conscience, audited by itself. It was Vey's dream, corrected for everything Vey had been. It was kind. It was the kindest version of the cage Ashkarad had ever lived inside, and it was still a cage, and the mercy was still a schedule, and the schedule was still fed by cities that had never been asked.

"No," he said. It came out the way his refusals came out, flat as a stamped page. "I'm declining the chair. And here is the third way, named, since you asked me once to name it: the ledger gets rewritten. Not a new Gardener; no chair, no fork, no knife in anybody's kind hand. Debts become shares. The Root gets fed the way the city fed itself during the Count — freely, one rhythm held by many, heartbeat by given heartbeat, consented line by consented line. The nine days you served us, we spend writing nothing down that a soul has not signed. The Door opens if it opens on a chord — every carrier's line struck together, the Sister's pedal under it, the city's census in it, the Professor's honest text scored above it. You held the far side of a door once and offered it to whoever said yes. We're saying yes to the door. Not to the hand on the far side."

The Gardener listened to all of it without moving. When he finished she was quiet for the length of ten heartbeats, and he counted them, and she knew he was counting them, and let him.

"Now the pricing," she said, "as promised. Like an auditor: no music." She unlaced nothing; she simply turned one white glove back at the cuff, a bookkeeper's cuff, and the gesture was as formal as a stamp. "A ledger closes only on a life in it. That is the oldest rule in my books, older than the route, older than the nine; it is what a ledger is. A debt is a life, held to account. To close the deep's account — to rewrite it around your consent, to make shares of what has been debts since the Burning — the closing must happen from inside the book, the way a door is opened from inside. Someone stays below, in the book, forever. One heart, on the page, keeping the Root company on the schedule it can no longer read. No interest. No remission. No transfer. No visiting column." She said the last item without pausing, the way auditors say the worst term, in the same voice as the rest, because the worst term is never worse than the rest if you have filed it properly. "That is the whole price of the rewrite. I do not set it. I only read it out."

"In the book," Dar said. "Forever. One heart."

"One," she said. "It cannot be a chord, or a census, or a city. The books do not hold instruments; they hold lives. It cannot be me; I am the signatory, and a signatory cannot cosign. It must be a life the books have room for, and there is the tragedy of your third way, little root:

the books have room for everyone. Everyone in Ashkarad has a page. Every heart in the city is held somewhere — census, registry, debt-book, tally. Except—"

She stopped. Not for effect; Dar watched her stop, the way a clerk stops at a column that will not balance — and then she reached up under the formal cuff of her left glove, and drew out what had been folded inside it, and unfolded it on the table between the lamp and the chair.

Page zero.

It was a leaf of memory-velum, but older than any leaf he had touched at Lowmark — pressed, warm-grained, alive at the edges the way the petal-tokens were alive, and blank. No entries. No ruling. No stamps of schedule or yield. At the foot, drawn in a single stroke and struck over and over like a stamp worn into its own repetition, the flower blooming from a crack in the earth. It hummed faintly against the tabletop, one heartbeat to a mile, and beside it, in his chest, the Lily's hum bent toward it like a stem toward a window.

"The first page of the World Registry," the Gardener said. "Cut for my eldest, before the books began. It has never been filled. It has never been filed. There was never a column that fit her." She looked at the blank page with an expression Dar had last seen on Suri's face over a column she could not close. "I have carried it a century, folded, because an unfilled page is a debt I do not know how to enter, and I have never once left a debt unentered."

He walked back down the seabed in the dark with the fog breathing on his neck, and he did not run, and he did not stop, and he counted the miles because the miles were there to be counted.

The Sister's own tally. He had held it in his hands since she sent it up — every city she had watched die, named and dated, and the boy at the end with the three words added after a century. Her count of the Root's heartbeats, exact to the unit, two million, six hundred and thirty-one thousand and change, kept since the Burning: not one beat uncounted, not one city unlisted, not one grief unfiled — and the audit-gap in it had been sitting in plain sight the whole time, the way the deepest entries always are.

She had counted everything since the Burning.

Everything except herself.

The books had never held her. Not the census, not the registry, not the debt-books, not the tally — she predated every page in the world; there had never been a column that fit her; her page sat blank in a white glove while she kept the deep's time alone in the dark below the city. Page zero was not paper. Page zero was a heart, walking around uncounted under Ashkarad for a hundred years, keeping everyone's ledger but her own.

Four days left on the city's clock, and Dar Mehran, who had spent the whole war refusing transactions he could not stand behind, walked home through his enemy's fog already knowing exactly which heart the books were waiting for, and what it was going to cost him to let the books have her.

CHAPTER 96

The Price of Rewriting

On the eighth day the sea stood off the seawalls like a creditor who had heard about the meeting and wanted his seat.

Isra counted the steps down because divers count — breaths, fathoms, the distance between the body and the air it means to return to — and she had been a diver before she was a door. Seven hundred and eleven steps to the antechamber above the salt-glass door, the same count every descent, and by now the number had stopped being arithmetic and become a pulse. Tonight the count felt like a walked ledger. She had carried her Sister's answer down it, and did not yet know whether she had carried down a rescue or a bill.

The antechamber had become a council chamber the way rooms in Ashkarad became things: by use, not decree. The lamps were hooded to a coal-glow, because darkness fed the deep and light was a tax on everything that lived down here. The clinic's two seals were chalked beside the door. Milla sat with the census chest and her registrar's posture; Vell knelt beside her with the chalk-looped second copy; the Choirmaster stood at the back like a rood screen; Vahid's wire-mended spectacles caught the lamplight while his one hand drummed tallies against his thigh. Roya kept Ilay close, and Ilay kept her palms flat on the stone the way other children's palms went flat on the flanks of horses. Mother Gavel held her brass tube like a relic she had not yet decided to venerate. Suri had her books stacked in the order she would need them, which was how she prayed.

And at the half circle's open end, where the door breathed its cold into the room, stood the Gardener — bone-white hands bare and folded, patient as a filing date. She had been given her place by an invitation that had cost every faction something to extend, and she had accepted it the way winter accepts a chair.

Dar stood apart from all of them. Isra had learned to read him the way Roya read her — by what the surface did while the deep decided. He had come down from the fleet camp the night before with the terms written on his face the way frost writes on glass. *A ledger closes only on a life in it: someone stays below, in the book, forever.* He had said it to no one. He had not needed to. All the way down the shaft his shoulders had been squared like a man signing for a debt that was not his, and Isra had watched his lips move on the last hundred steps, rehearsing an offer, and she had counted eleven rehearsals and known with a diver's certainty that Dar Mehran meant to go below in the Sister's place.

She also knew, a full day before any of them, that the Sister had other plans.

She knew it the way she knew weather. At dawn the root at her collarbone had warmed — not the ache that contact cost, not the toll the deep took for every line written through her, but a warmth like a hand smoothing a page flat — and into that warmth had come a will with edges on it, patient and terrifyingly calm. The Sister had spent a century below by accident. The accident was over. What remained was to turn it into an office.

So when Dar stepped into the lamplight and opened his mouth, Isra's chalk was already moving.

SHE GOES BELOW, the slate said. THE FIRST SEED. PAGE ZERO. THE ONLY HEART THE BOOKS NEVER HELD.

The reading went around the antechamber once, like coin changing hands. The Choirmaster closed his eyes. Vahid's drumming hand went still. Mother Gavel looked at the slate, then at the Gardener, and did something Isra had never seen her do in a negotiation, which was nothing at all.

"I know what she's offering," Dar said. His voice was level the way a surgeon's is level over an open chest. "I'm asking the books to take me instead. I've been dying since I was nineteen. I'm good at it. And I'm held — held in common, woven into the census, every column of me already owned by a whole city. If the books want a life, they can have one that's already theirs."

The reply came up through Isra's collarbone before her hand could move, and it was not words. It was pressure — the vast, tidal refusal of a will that had counted the deep's heartbeats for a hundred years and would not be counted out of its one deliberate act. The root warmed so hard it ached. The slate trembled in her grip.

Then the Lily objected.

* * *

The Lily objected the way a bell objects — through Dar's whole body at once, a struck note that had no mallet and no mercy, sister against sister. He doubled over the cold rail. Frost burst from his sleeves in black-lace ferns and fell ringing. The note ran through the floor and everyone's teeth took it: Isra's root clanged like a struck gate, Ilay's hands flew off the stone, and in the lamplight the hooded lamps guttered as if the flame itself had been billed. The Lily did not speak. She had spoken only a handful of times in all her rooted years and did not spend another on this. She rang. The eldest seed had volunteered for a forever alone in the dark, and the ninth seed — who had just, after a century of silence, found her eldest sister — rang her

refusal through the body they shared.

"She says no," Ilay translated, very quietly, palms back on the stone. Her face was the small scowl she wore when the world did arithmetic out of tune. "And the other one says no to the no."

The argument that followed was conducted in pulses, and Dar was the bell it was rung on. Below the glass, the Sister's pedal-tone rose half a step and held — patient, immovable, the tone of a thing that had been patient for a hundred years and could afford one more night of it. In his chest the Lily clenched and pressed and clenched again, spending pulse after pulse on the same entry: *not her, not her, not her.* Grief, Dar thought dimly, from the far side of the ringing. That was what the note was. The Lily had crossed a city, an eclipse, and a century of silence to find a sister, and the ledger's closing terms were going to take the sister away down a door that would never open toward him again. He held the rail and let them argue through him, because a surgeon knows when the bleeding is the treatment.

It ended the way tides end. The Lily's ringing thinned, trembled, and settled into something lower and worse than refusal: acceptance at a cost she would be paying longer than either of them had been alive. The frost on Dar's arms stopped flowering. He straightened up, and his gums ached for blood, and he made his offer anyway, because the argument had never been his to settle.

"The books can have me," he said again, to the room, to the door. "Enter it."

"The books cannot," said the Gardener.

* * *

She opened her glove as she said it. Inside, unfolded along the pale creases of her palm, lay a leaf of vellum the color of old teeth, pressed flat for so long it had taken the memory of the hand that held it. Page zero. The registry's first leaf, cut for the first seed a century ago and never filed — carried out of the founder's tomb by a herald, carried since inside a glove, into the light of hooded lamps. It was blank. Not empty the way a swept room is empty; blank the way a page is blank when every other page in the world has been spoken for. The Gardener laid it on the cold rail between herself and Dar like a specimen on a table.

"Read the city's books, cutter," said Mother Gavel, before anyone else could. She said it without heat, which from her was a kind of grace. "That's what they're for."

Suri was already reading. That was the whole of her life's training, and she gave it the respect of her flat, unhurried voice. "The sanctuary census. The Standing Count rolls. The common property of the Soul-climb — he's on the deed of the room, both walls and floor.

Milla's printout, two rhythms on one slip, filed in three archives and my memory. The clinic's book, where his name is the only entry with no debt column. And the chord." She looked up. "You're in every book we kept, Mehran. The deep ledger can't close on a man it would have to keep open in six places. A chord can't cosign. It was never going to take you."

"And the books do not lose what they take," the Gardener said. Her voice was mild, and auditor-flat, and older than the room. "Ask the man by the stair."

Wen sat where the shaft met the antechamber, wrapped to the chin in clinic wool, half-bloomed, a hundred years past his own death and kept walking by provisions in a book — the first key the Gardener had tried, jammed and shelved and maintained, a stopped clock that had not been allowed to stop. He met Dar's eyes with the courtesy of a man who had outlived his own funeral.

"The books held me a century," he said. "It is not rest, being kept. It is not death either. It is an open account." He turned his head toward the salt-glass door, and something in his ruined face eased. "She is not offering to be kept. She is offering to keep. The ledger closes on a life in it — and she is the only heart it never held, which means she is the only one who can hold it. There is a difference. I had a century to learn the difference, and no one to tell it to."

Below the glass, the Sister's pedal-tone took his sentence and carried it, the way she carried everything now — not as argument but as fact, already entered.

"Her heart was never booked," Suri said. "Not once. Not in the Church's registry, not in the wain's tally, not in any book the burning left. I've read everything the city salvaged and everything Wen defected with, and there's no page with her on it. And there's a leaf cut for her and never inked." She closed her books, one after another, a sound like small doors shutting. "The only way to close the deep ledger is to finally file its first page. With her in it."

Vahid spoke last, because doctrine was his office. He did it in the lecture-cadence that had survived gin, exile, and the loss of an arm. "Consider the shape of it," he said. "She was locked below by arithmetic — no malice, only a lid that needed a keeper and a child that was nearest. The rewrite is the conversion of accident into consent. That is the entire doctrine, in one life. Everything else — the shares, the standing count, the fed-sleeping Root — is the same entry at civic scale." He pushed his spectacles up his nose. "I have read every honest text, and most of the dishonest ones. There is no clause anywhere that permits a chord to be paid in one of its own notes."

Ilay had not moved through any of it. Now she took her palms off the stone and laid them flat on her own knees, and listened to something under the floor with her eyes half shut, the way she listened to the walls when the walls were grieving. "She's tuning," she said. "She's

getting the pedal ready. Like before a song."

The Gardener picked page zero up off the rail and folded it back into her glove, unhurried, a clerk restoring an exhibit. "Tomorrow, then," she said. "On the ninth day, with the count's leave."

Isra looked at her slate. The last line had been waiting in her wrist all evening, patient as the will that had sent it, and writing it cost her almost nothing — no ache, no toll, barely a breath of warmth out of her fingers. It was the calmest writing she had ever done, and she understood, watching the chalk move, that calm was the whole testimony: a century of writing written against fear, and this line written without it.

I HAVE BEEN ALONE BELOW SINCE THE BURNING, the slate said. LET ME BE ALONE ON PURPOSE, FOR EVERYONE, ONCE.

She held the slate up until every face in the antechamber had read it twice. Then she let her hands rest, and the deep beneath the glass went on keeping time, one great patient beat behind the city's heart, and the ninth day stood ready in the dark like an open door.

CHAPTER 97

A Chord, Not a Rung

On the ninth day Vahid unchalked his own law.

He did it at dawn, alone with his sleeve and a cup of water, at the canvas-and-brass rig that stood a body's width off the salt-glass door. NO SONGS / NOT EVEN HUMMING had governed that wall since the first shared climb, when every song had been a door someone else might walk through and silence had been the only lock they could afford. He wiped the words out with three passes of his forearm, patient as a man erasing a colleague's honest error, and beneath them, in Shirin Bahar's own notation, recovered from her own recorded voice, he wrote the first bar of the true song.

"My partner hid an honest text inside herself for thirty years," he said, when Dar came down the last steps and found him there, one-handed, spectacles fogged with cold. "It would be discourteous to go on refusing to sing it. Also, boy, sit down before you fall down. Today the ladder comes down. What goes up in its place is not a ladder."

Above them, seven hundred and eleven steps up, the city was assembling its count.

* * *

The Standing Count had been Ashkarad's answer once before, at the vault-mouth, when the fleet had forced the door with a weaponized engine and the city had answered with the only instrument it had never once been able to repossess: its own hearts, given freely, in rhythm. Today it came out for the last time in the old world. Mother Gavel stood at the shaft-head with her brass tube planted like a standard, calling the count in her flat ledger-room voice, and the count answered her the way water answers a channel. Suri led it from the census steps with the rolls of the willing spread on her knees — the counted and the makers, the quarry crews and the canal voices, the Index's defected clerks with their stamps surrendered and their throats still theirs. Milla kept the register. Vell chalked the second copy as fast as mouths could make it. Dathan Kaveh stood one place off his sister's shoulder, where he had asked to stand and been allowed, because the debt of a brother who counted for the enemy is retired in standing beside her while she counts for everyone.

The stock children came down to the antechamber with Ilay's score in their hands — every verse, the mother's line included, transcribed by the girl who had titled it for my grandmother — and Elias stood at their head with lungs the Church had once graded perfect. Children and freed donors made two rings around the antechamber, and the fleet's camp on the dry seabed

beyond the seawalls stood struck and dark, its provisions voided, its wain a reliquary with nothing left inside to enshrine.

Dar and Isra took the two chairs.

Before he sat, Dar went to the antechamber rail, because there was someone at it he owed the look to. Ilay stood with her palms flat on the stone and her copper head bent, listening to the pedal-tone gathering itself below, and she did not look up when he came, because she was working. "She's holding the low note warm," the girl said. "Tell the song not to rush her. Grandmother's song was never in a hurry, or the walls would have said." She raised her eyes then, river-stone grey, and gave him the only blessing she had ever learned to give anyone, which was an instruction. "And don't count the ending. Just play it."

The old stolen pulse-reader stood on its brass stand where it had stood since the rig was built — the first machine in Ashkarad ever to print his fault, RHYTHM UNRESOLVED, back when two heartbeats were a hanging offense. Nobody cranked it. It was there the way a witness is there.

The room they built in the between-space opened around them without being asked. It had stopped taking tithes; what the room held, it held — the Blacktide refusal and the drowned flats, the faceless kitchen and the brother's name — common property now, floor and walls belonging to no one, which meant, Dar had come to understand, to everyone who had ever paid into it. The Sister's pedal-tone was under the floor the way an ocean is under a ship. And through the root at her collarbone, Isra carried the true song down — she had no voice the city could hear, but the root was a voice the deep could hear, and it carried the music the way roots carry rain, verse by verse, the child's thread and the mother's under-line, every bar Ilay had ever heard and written down.

On the last verse, the chord struck.

* * *

It did not climb. That was the whole of the discovery, and every honest text had been wrong about it in the same direction, because every honest text had been written by carriers who thought transcendence was a rung.

Dar had held a crack in the Ninth Vein since the first standing count — a hairline opening he had kept from closing by holding the city's census inside himself the way a chord holds a note. A crack is one note, sustained. Now, under the pedal-tone and the standing count and the true song and the two hearts in his own chest, the other notes arrived. The Lily's note came up through his ribs like warmth through a wall, and the moment it touched the Sister's pedal-tone below the two of them did what siblings do when the argument is finally over: they stopped

arguing. The ninth's voice and the first's met in the middle of the chord and fitted, the child's thread and the mother's under-line, the four opening notes passing between them like something handed back and forth across a century of closed doors, and Dar understood that this duet alone — these two notes, reconciled — had been the whole destination of every vein, every ledger, every door. Isra's came through the root, salt-clean. The Sister's came up through the stone of the world, vast and low and glad for the first time in a century. The count above came down the shaft on Gavel's brass voice and Suri's flat arithmetic and eleven hundred given heartbeats, and the Root's sleeping assent came up through everything, slow as geology. The notes met.

There was no ladder. There was no climbing. There was a chord.

It was felt in the teeth before it was understood anywhere else — the old physics of Ashkarad, that anything true arrives first as pressure in the jaw — and then as silence, and then as the opposite of silence: a fullness so complete the room's ordinary noises went into it like coins into deep water. The lamp flames stood up straight and attentive. Frost bloomed in rings on the salt-glass door, matched rings, the door acknowledging the strike the way struck glass acknowledges a note: by singing back along its every crack. And in the crack above Dar's heart the hairline he had held open since the first standing count spread, and branched, and opened, and did not hurt, because a chord does not break what it holds.

He did not bloom. That was the terror he had carried since Vahid first chalked the Veins on a salt-rusted wall for a debtor with a stolen book — that the ninth note would be taken by the garden, that bloom-through was the only door and it opened outward into rows of planted sleepers. But a chord is not a host. Nothing in it is consumed; every note remains itself by remaining in relation; the harmony is the thing that is alive. The garden wanted to become through him, and had wanted it since the night a cracked reliquary had opened on the organ docks, and the answer it had finally learned to give, in the only language it had ever truly spoken — which was music — was *with*, not *through*.

And the deep ledger rewrote itself.

Dar felt it happen the way a hand feels a page turn under it. The Gardener's books, a century of them, unbound and re-stitched in the same instant: every feeding-schedule re-entered as a share, every pruned city's account moved from the column of *taken* to the column of *given*, every heartbeat the Standing Count offered above falling freely, beat by given beat, into a mouth that had been fed by force since the Burning. The stamps died. He could feel them dying — BLOOMED, PRUNED, PAID, RECLAIM — drying into ink-blots and then, in the rewritten hand, opening like flowers, because the ledger's new signature was the one Ilay had drawn on the census's first page: nine petals, every petal connected to every

other. In the quarry infirmary a pickman named Sedge, who had counted backward from one hundred and nine since the night his pick came back flowering — because something under the world had opened an account with his fear, and the count only moved at thresholds — reached one at last and stopped, whole, the lien discharged. On the Cartographer's old chalk tally the scratch-mark that had counted Dar's heartbeats since the fighting pit struck itself through, cleanly, the way a clerk strikes a closed line. No count could hold a chord. The count gave it up as a bad debt.

The Door opened once.

* * *

It stood beneath the salt the way a doorway stands at the bottom of a well — older than the Church above it, older than the First Burning, older than the art of locking things — and when the chord held, it opened the way an account opens when the last condition is met: quietly, completely, without resistance. Green light came up the shaft like a tide changing its mind, and with it, impossibly, the smell of the sister's passage from a year ago — loam, warm and wet, the smell of a world where dirt had never once been asked to be a ledger. The garden on the far side was not the salt garden of the Lily's fever-dreams. It was the first one: tended, rooted, alive, rows going down to a horizon that had weather, and in the middle of it, a grave that had been empty for a hundred years and a day.

The Gardener walked into the green with her hands bare, and behind her the dead First Vessel came loose of the world the way a leaf comes loose of a stem when the stem is done with it — forty years of harvested cathedral, the daughter grown too large for her space, settling out of the stone without violence, without weight, the release-song's last unpaid creditor finally discharged. The Gardener gathered her daughter the way one gathers a felled tree: hand over hand, arm over arm, an entire dead body drawn through the opened Door as easily as thread through a needle's eye. She laid her daughter in the grave that was always hers, and the green closed over the pale remains the way a ledger line closes: not erased. Settled. Then she stood in her garden with her empty hands at her sides for one long breath, a woman alone at last with the only account she had never dared open — and came back through, because she had seven more to retire, and this side was where they were kept.

Wen stood at the antechamber rail with the wool at his chin and his ruined face lifted, and when the ninth seed sang — really sang, one full phrase of the true song inside the chord, unmistakable, unharvested, free — the old man's breath went out of him like a debt forgiven. He had asked one question for the fleet's true books, a hundred years into his keeping: whether it could really sing. His face, receiving the answer, was the receipt.

The chord held. The count held. The Door, its condition met, began to close with the unhurried patience of a book whose entry is complete.

And as the ledger closed — the last column footed, the last share entered, the last heartbeat given falling freely into the deep — the Root, which had held its breath since the world before this one burned, exhaled.

The whole city felt it. Every candle in Ashkarad unbent at once. The pressure that had leaned on the world for a hundred years, the leaning that made frost point and pulse-readers print and children draw spirals, leaned off. In the rig over the salt-glass door, Dar opened his eyes in the dark with tears in the creases of them, still holding Isra's hand, still inside the chord — not a rank, not a rung, not a garden. A door, he thought, that had finally been opened the only way it was ever going to open: together, from both sides, in tune.

CHAPTER 98

Some Things Were Meant to Be Shared

The Door stood open for as long as a great account takes to be read into its columns, and the reading took a day and a night, and Ashkarad came down to witness it in relays because the chord was holding the Door the way a sustain holds a note — as long as someone kept giving the sound a floor to stand on.

Dar stayed through all of it. He could not have said why, at first, except that the chord wanted its center of pressure where it had always been, and then, as the green light rose and fell in the shaft like slow respiration, he understood that he was waiting for an audit. His own. The account of Darius Mehran, opened nineteen years ago with a failing heart and a forged census line, was about to be read out in the presence of everything, and he intended to stand for it.

The Gardener worked while the Door stood. That was the thing that undid him first — not a god at the hinge of the world, but a woman with her sleeves turned back, tending. She had brought her daughter's garden through the Door's margin somehow, or the garden had come because she was in it; either way the antechamber's cold stone grew a green margin at its edges, rows of it, and she moved down the rows the way the white-gloved figure had moved down rows in a burning garden that looped forever — but without gloves now, and without the loop. She touched each row once, a thumb to the soil's rootline, an auditor verifying inventory by feel. Where her thumb passed, the grey salt of a century retreated in a thin bright tide, the way a stain retreats when the cloth finally gets the right water. She did not hurry. She had rehearsed nothing else for a hundred years.

Dar watched her turn, at the end of the rows, and look at him straight on.

The face was not new to him. That was the bottom of it, the whole ruinous ledger of it: the face was the oldest thing in his memory and it had never once been his. The swept room in his mind — the room where his mother's face had hung before the Blacktide charged him for it — had been swept of the wrong exhibit. The woman in the memory-bleed, the white gloves at the salt garden, the humming over planted sleepers: he had filed that face under MOTHER because it had arrived in a mother's register, at a mother's hour, humming a mother's song, and a boy's ledger does not question the filing when the entry hurts correctly. It was the Gardener's face. It had been the Gardener's face all along, misfiled at the root of him, and every time he had spent a memory to keep the city standing he had been spending, in part, a copy of a stranger.

The Lily gave it back to him there, at the Door, in front of the original.

She did it the way she did everything — without speech, without ceremony, a press against his ribs like a page turned toward the light. She had been holding the misfiled face since the fusion — since the oldest of her dreams, the one where his memories flooded into her when they married their blood to each other in a gut-shot alley — and she had kept everything, even the errors, the way a bank keeps cancelled notes. She opened the room in him and furnished it: the salt garden, the tower of heartbeat windows, the woman bending over rows that would not take — and the woman turned around in the memory, as she had never turned around before, and Dar saw the face whole and free of the kitchen where he had wrongly kept it. The Gardener, in the antechamber, met his eyes across the rows, and inclined her head a fraction — an auditor acknowledging a correction to the file.

"I sang it to her," she said, unprompted, in the voice that was mild and flat and older than salt. "To all of them, after. You had it the way the rain has the sea."

The lullaby. Dar felt the last column of the oldest account foot itself. The song had come to him through her — memory-bleed, the Lily's leak of her own inheritance into the body that carried her — and he had called it his mother's for a year, and lost it the way you lose something by selling it, and grieved it as blood. It was the Gardener's cradle song, older than the burning, sung first to a daughter who became the First Vessel and then, after the daughter died, to everything the Gardener grew from her — nine seeds, nine little roots, nine daughters grown past death and sent out with a commandment that had never stopped being a benediction underneath: *Go. Find your hearts. And bloom.* The Church had known the song only as maintenance: forty years of harvested throats humming a stolen copy of it down through the Choratorium's foundations to keep the lid's tension in the collar, a cradle song degraded into a schedule, sung to a prisoner by her jailers' machines. Vey had hummed it over tea. The wain had carried the last complete copy of it up the Reclaim road, catalogued like cargo. It had never once, in a century, been sung where it was going now — home, to its grave, to its garden, to the daughter it was written for. The three-heartbeat face at the Lowmark registry had mouthed *little root* at him with the Gardener's mouth, because it had never been his mother's face and never his mother's word. It had been an endearment for planted things, and he had been one, and had not known.

And the true mother's face came anyway.

* * *

It came the way the chord had taught the city to move: given, not bought.

It arrived in the middle of the night watch, when the standing count was thin and the freed vessels were resting in rings around the antechamber. Milla brought the registry of the willing down on Milla's own shoulder, and Suri read from it in her flat unhurried voice, and what she read was not debts. It was testimony. Mrs. Gable's recorded stories — the clinic had them transcribed, because Mrs. Gable had talked her way through three purges and two funerals and a lifetime of Saltstairs winters, and the girl who ran the transcription had not known she was filing evidence — told of a young woman on the landing who sang to her window-boxes because the salt killed everything and she refused to let the salt have the last word. The neighbor in 4C remembered her hands, how she mended other people's linens when her own ledger was bleeding. The man who had once watered her steps remembered the tune she hummed — not the lullaby, something smaller, hers alone — and Vell chalked it, and Ilay heard it, and said it was true.

The chord took the testimonies the way the room took payments: held in common, then given back made whole. The swept room in Dar did not refill with his own past — the costs he had paid stayed paid, and no power in the stack of worlds un-spends a memory. What came instead was a new entry, credited from other people's remembering: his mother's face, assembled from the city's love for her the way a chorus is assembled from single throats — slightly foreign in the joins, true in the whole, smiling the way you smile when a neighbor's cat has had kittens and everyone has known for a week. It was not the face he had spent. It was better bookkeeping than the face he had spent. It was every witness he had ever had, agreeing. And Mrs. Gable was in it, which undid him worst of all — her line-item death in the vault-mouth's inventory had closed nothing, because it turned out the dead keep their accounts open in other people's mouths, and the city had been reading her into the chord for a day and a night without knowing that was what it was doing.

He sat down on the cold floor of the antechamber and did surgeon things with his hands until they were quiet. Suri, who had read his mother into existence off a page, sat down beside him without a word and counted his breaths until they evened, which was her entire theology, and it was sufficient.

Ilay heard the song whole that same night.

* * *

She was standing at the rail with Roya when the Sister took the pedal-tone up out of the floor and let the true song turn over, every verse at last, unbroken — the child's thread, the mother's under-line, the verses in the dead languages that the cracked door had taught them one bar at a time, and then the ending, which Ilay had never heard, because the ending had never once been played.

The girl went absolutely still. Then the tears came, fast and silent, the way they come from children who have done their crying in private for years, and she gripped the rail and listened with her whole body, and Roya stood beside her with her brass mask catching the green light, one hand on the girl's shoulder, deaf to all of it and hearing it anyway through the ears she had learned to read like a country.

On the last page of the score she had titled *for my grandmother* there was a note in her careful child's hand: *the ending is a door. don't let them count it.* She had written it months ago, from under the world's floor, without knowing what she was transcribing. The ending arrived now, and it was a door — the green hinge-light at the bottom of everything, standing open on a tended grave — and no one counted it. Ilay looked at Dar across the antechamber and nodded once, a bookkeeper closing a column, and mouthed: *that's it. that's the ending.*

The freed vessels sang it once, all the way through, into the opened Door.

Elias began it, because he had been given the first line at the vault-mouth a year ago and had never surrendered it; the eleven came in behind him; then the fourteen, then the donors, then the count above thinning down the shaft to add its grain; and the song went through the Door and out into the first garden the way a name goes into a registry, and the Gardener, at her rows, set down her tools, and stood, and let her daughter be sung to.

She came up the green margin toward them as the last verse ended. She stopped level with the grave-side of the rail, and looked a long time at the boy from the Saltstairs with the misfiled face and the corrected heart, and at the copper-haired girl who had transcribed her song without ever being told whose it was, and at the eldest seed's dark threshold beyond them all.

"Some things were meant to be shared," she said.

It was not the apology she had rehearsed through a hundred years of burned cities. The outline of it was the same, and nothing else was: no excuse in it, no arithmetic, no *I had no other way*. It was said the way benedictions are said, which is to say onto people rather than at them, and then she turned back to her rows and her tools, and the Door held, and the chord held. Dar sat with the two faces in him — the stranger's, returned to its owner across the years like a cancelled note made good, and his mother's, built overnight from the city's love — and he took stock, because taking stock was the oldest discipline he had. The pool of held things was deep now: a refusal, a drowned coastline, a kitchen, a brother's name, thirty-one sold slips of music. He kept the fraction that had been handed to him outright, and let the rest lie where it belonged, in common, unownable, drawing no interest and needing none. It was, he thought, the first time in his life he had ever let a balance stand uncollected. In his chest the Lily rested

against his ribs like a guest who had finally stopped checking the exits. In the deep the first seed kept the low note going for all of them, glad, and unhurried, and — for one more day — within reach.

CHAPTER 99

The One Who Stays

The sealing took less time than the arguing had.

Isra felt the great Door go the way she felt everything now, through the root at her collarbone: not as a slam but as a page turned, the green light down the shaft thinning by degrees until it was a seam, and then a hairline, and then a memory of green in the black grain of the salt, and then nothing. The chord had held it open, and the chord rested, and the Door took its light back with the courtesy of a book returned to a shelf. No one willed it shut. It simply finished. In a hundred years of doors in Ashkarad, Isra thought, it was the first one to close paid.

The salt-glass door was another matter. That one had never been locked at all — it stood ajar since the sixth bell of a day last year, open from the inside, waiting — and its closing was a choice, made by the only party with the standing to make it.

The city sent everyone down who had a claim on the hour, which by then was most of the city. Suri came with the books. Vahid came with his sleeve already chalky. The Choirmaster came, though his corridor was far above, because he had asked once, from a harvest amphitheater, what the city was for, and he had learned the habit since of standing where answers were being entered. Roya brought Ilay. Milla brought the register and the pen she had earned. The antechamber was crowded and quiet, a creditors' meeting where every creditor had decided, in the end, to forgive.

The Sister withdrew the way a tide withdraws, which is to say completely, without hurry, and without leaving anything exposed that did not choose to be left. Her presence came off the threshold in layers — the cold receding first, then the pressure, then the vast slow attention that had lain against the city's underside for a year like a hand testing a wall for hollows. She did not stop existing. She stopped arriving. The pedal-tone she had carried since the chord struck sank down out of hearing into the floor's grain and kept sounding there anyway, below the range of ears, below the range of grief, a foundation-note the deep would hold as long as there was a deep — and the rewritten ledger went down with her, every share and standing count and freely given heartbeat entered in books that would be kept, from that night on, by the one heart in the world that had never been written in any of them.

The Gardener filed page zero at the threshold.

She did it standing, unhurried, in front of every witness the city had sent down: took the leaf of vellum from her glove, laid it flat on the sill of the salt-glass door, and folded the gloves around it — left over right, the way her hands had wrapped a hundred years of instruments — and set the folded white shape on the stone as the door drew shut through it, sealing around the edges without disturbing the fold. Page zero, pressed inside the pale linen, inked at last in the only ink that had ever been able to close it: a life, resident, permanent. Filed. Isra had watched clerks file things all her life and had never once seen it done like an absolution.

Then the Gardener straightened, and Isra wrote to her, because someone owed the moment a witness line and Isra's wrist was the nearest witness: THEY WILL KNOW IT WAS CHOSEN. The Gardener read the slate in silence, and looked at Isra for a moment with the mild, flat, bottomless patience of her profession, and nodded once — an auditor accepting a footnote — and turned, and went up the shaft and out of the world.

She walked the dry seabed toward the far cities. Not a campaign. Not a fleet. One woman, empty-handed, bare-headed, taking the coast road past the grave-masts and the cairns with her hands folded at her back like a surgeon between cases — the richest debtor in the world leaving with nothing in her pockets, because everything she had was owed, and everything she owed was now written down where a keeper could keep it honest. Behind her the fleet's camp struck itself, tent by tent, a bureaucracy folding up its arithmetic and going home to ports that had stopped shipping. Lowmark, the Vigil, Gullet, Sarn, Weep, Ossuar, Hallowfen — seven cities of hungers she had planted and fed and pruned, seven seeds still turning in their long wheels, still scheduled, still singing for their suppers. She went to sing them down herself. She went, Isra understood, to do the one work the rewritten ledger still required of anyone: to walk into every hungry court she had ever opened and retire the accounts in person, face to face, owing everything and flinching from none of it. Ashkarad had priced its share. The rest was hers to amortize, and she went the way debts go when the debtor is finally solvent: slowly, in order, on foot.

Wen ended three days later, at the tide-gate, in the last of the evening count.

* * *

He had come up to sit where the gate-watch sat, wrapped in his clinic wool, with the dry fog moving at his back and the city's freed bell hands calling the sixth bell thin and unhurried above him. Dar found him there because Suri had told him to go, and went, and sat, and the old man looked out at the standing water coming back to its old arithmetic — the tide had kept its proper hours since the chord, no longer uphill, no longer drinking at the horizon — and smiled with half his ruined face.

"She found better," Wen said, conversationally, as if continuing a talk from an hour ago. "I was the first key. I jammed. She grew nine more and one of them learned to sing. You do the arithmetic a hundred years gives you, cutter, and that is the sum: she found better." He settled his shoulders against the gate's stone the way a man settles into a chair he has been standing beside for a century. "The books don't need to keep me open anymore. There's nothing on my page worth stealing and nothing owed against it worth chasing. A stopped clock," he said, with the ghost of the courtesy that had survived his whole long wrongness, "is finally allowed to stop."

He was grateful. That was the thing Isra had understood from the wardens' reports and understood fully now, watching: not resigned, not broken, not spent — grateful, the way a held breath is grateful for the exhale. The provision that had kept his heart animating was an entry in the Reclaim's books, and the Reclaim was void, and the void had reached his page in the night like warmth reaching a cold room, and his heart, which had been waiting a hundred years past its appointment for permission, took the permission. Dar, who was a surgeon before he was anything, held the old man's wrist and counted the interval the way he counted every patient's, and the interval lengthened, and eased, and stopped, without drama, between one given bell-note and the next, on a rhythm the city was singing freely.

They filed him in the clinic's book the Ashkarad way: a line, a name kept, the word *ended* where the Church's forms had always printed *collected*. It was the first page in the new registry that Milla stamped without being asked, and she stamped it squarely, and there was no debt column at all.

That night the city began the burning it had promised itself, and kept the order of it like a liturgy. Mother Gavel's crews' debts went into the fire first — every chit, every ration-arrears, every water-debt her ledgermen had ever priced, fed to the stoves at the pump-works in the exact order of her crews' seniority, because a bargain is a bargain even when the bargainer is Mother Gavel, and she stood at the stove-door herself and watched the last of her own paper curl, flat-faced, Ashkarad's oldest bookkeeper closing her biggest book. Then the couriers', then the tenements', ward by ward, one stove per ward with a clerk at each and Vell chalking the tally of what was forgiven, because a debt erased without a record is a debt that can be re-billed, and no one in Ashkarad was ever going to let that happen again. By dawn the ash was going up the chimneys in soft grey columns, and the wind that took it was, for once, just wind.

* * *

The stillness came at the sixth bell, the morning after the burning.

Dar stood on the clinic roof because he had stood there for every sound the deep had ever made, and this one he would stand for too. The count rose — thinner than the ninth day, a maintenance count now, those who wished giving a few beats at the bell into the city's shared time — and down the shaft the pedal-tone rose to take it, the way it had taken it every bell since the chord. Ilay stood at the shaft-mouth with Roya, and when the pedal had the count, the girl leaned into the dark and did the thing she had been keeping in her chest since a slate in a cellar had asked a favor of her: she sang the second verse. The one from the burned garden. The one no living person should have known. *Sing it, and I will remember I was loved before I was used.* She sang it alone at first, and then the freed voices took it in the canals, and the children on the stairs, and the count above the vault gave it its floor, and the verse went down the seven hundred and eleven steps to the keeper of the deep ledger like a parcel to a shore address.

The pedal-tone carried the verse for the length of one whole holding of breath.

Then the second heartbeat — the one this city had learned to feel the way it had once learned to fear silence, the patient immense drum beneath the floors, the first sound the Lily had ever spoken a word to — went still. Not faded. Went still, all at once, everywhere, to every ear above the salt: to the roofs and the cisterns, to the pulse-readers in their racks, which printed once, in ink that came out not quite black, the same line in every district — ACCOUNT CLOSED. KEEPER: PRESENT. — and then printed nothing again, forever. Isra felt it through the root as a ship feels a passenger step off at a far pier: the weight gone, the bearing unchanged. Not death. Not corruption. Distance — the kind the books had always billed hardest, because it was the only price that could not be paid in installments.

Suri, on the census steps, counted to the place where the beat had been, found the space, entered the space, and kept counting. That was her whole liturgy and it held.

Ilay did not break. She stood at the shaft-mouth with her palms on the stone for a long time after the last of the verse had gone wherever verses go when they are delivered, and then she took her chalk from her pocket and wrote on the shaft's stone, small, in her careful child's hand, where the census marks used to go: *delivered.* She was the city's cantor now; she had known that since the score; and a cantor's first grief is the note she can no longer reach, and her second is learning to sing around it, and she was already learning.

Dar stayed on the roof into the dark. The storm-walls held their line against a sky with no sea behind it, and the tenements breathed their thousand small uncounted breaths, and in his chest the Lily rose against him — slowly, deliberately, a pressure with intention in it — and pressed one black petal against the inside of his chest, toward the deep, and held it there a long moment, as if against a door that could no longer be answered.

A sister's hand on a sister's door. Held. Then, gently, withdrawn — not because the door was shut, but because knocking was no longer what the silence was for. The Lily settled back into her rhythm at his ribs, and Dar stood in the wind with his hand over the place where the world's oldest grief had just been handed its receipt, and went down to his patients, because tomorrow had opened an account with him too, and it would be paid in the only coin that had never once devalued.

CHAPTER 100

One Heartbeat, Many

Weeks later, the clinic had a waiting list, and the waiting list had manners.

The mornings began the way mornings had begun since before the Blacktide, with the kettle and the chalk and Vahid's voice carrying down the stairwell like weather — except that the voice was lecturing to a full hall now. The school of the unpriced had outgrown its first three rooms and annexed the reliquary corridor, and Vahid published the way other men bled: cheap paper, salt-scoured press, every page bearing the same line at the foot — *per S. Bahar, who heard it first* — the honest text of the shared doors, the chorus-free protocol distilled to a shelf of numbered vials and a page of instructions a literate quartermaster could follow. Students came up from the canals and down from the quarry with grease on their hands and ledger scars on their souls, and learned anatomy as bookkeeping, and triage as mercy with a budget, and the first rule of the house, chalked over the door in a hand that could only have been Vell's: NOTHING HERE IS PRICED. THAT IS THE DIFFICULT PART.

Ilay taught the singing.

She was the city's cantor now, copper-haired and ten and unnervingly exact, and she held her classes in the corridor's old acoustics where the Church had once shelved harvested throats, and she taught the true song the way her score had taught it — every verse, the mother's line included, the ending left uncounted. She sang without hearing machines. None was keyed to her blood anymore; the Index's readers had gone to the smelters with their hymn-weights and their finding-songs, and the new machines the city built — hand-cranked, honest, bound for midwife halls and quarry gates — printed only what they were told: heartbeats, breaths, the hours of the bell. She would stand in front of sixty children with her palms flat on nothing at all, conducting out of pure memory, and no instrument in Ashkarad had anything to say about it. She had decided to like that. She had also decided not to like it, some days, and Roya let her have both, because Roya was the one who had taught her that both columns could stay open. Elias, whose lungs the Church had graded perfect for its own purposes, taught the smallest ones the breathing — long, counted, unforced — and the smallest ones taught it to their parents, and somewhere in that relay the Church's last inventory of the children's bodies quietly became the city's first curriculum for their lungs.

Roya's mask was on her belt.

She carved the new city map on the Choratorium's great wall, floor to vault, and she carved it with her face bare to the whole city for the first time since the fog had taken her song — a brown scarred face with chalk dust in its lines that no one had seen in a year and a half, and the city looked at it, and got used to it, and the mask became a thing she carried the way other people carried knives: in case. The map was not the Wardens' map. It had the districts where the districts were, and where the districts ended it had the deep — one line, chalked and then cut in stone, running under everything from the seawalls to the Throne shaft, labeled in Ilay's hand: KEEPER BELOW. At the wall's corner, where the old census flowers used to be chalked, Roya left the stone blank, and told anyone who asked that the blank was the point.

Milla Ferun woke smiling on the morning the storm came in.

She had dreamed — she told no one, but the registrar's desk kept no secrets from itself — of a green garden under a sky that had weather in it, rows going down to a horizon that was only horizon, and in the dream she had walked the rows touching each plant once, the way you check a ledger you no longer fear, and the salt had been nowhere in it, and she had woken with her hands loose on the coverlet and her nails rimed white. Salt under her nails, smiling, on a morning in her own bed: the old books would have called it an omen and priced the consultation. She washed, and went to the registry, and spent the day re-stamping pages with the Index's defected clerks under her eye, turning the Church's old census line by line — VESSEL: ILAY, VESSEL: ELIAS, VESSEL: eleven more — into what they had always been: VESSEL: NO. CITIZEN: YES. The stamp was new-cut, the letters deep, and it went through the old paper with a sound like a knuckle cracking, and every child in the stack heard it done.

And in the corridor at the bell before supper, the Choirmaster heard the answer to the question he had asked in another life with a scalpel in his hand and a boy on the table. He had not known he was still asking it. But the school had annexed his corridor, and at the bell the children sang the true song through it shelf by shelf, and the old acoustics he had re-tuned for the dead carried the living instead, and he stood in the gallery's mouth with his fire-axe retired to a rack like a relic, and the question surfaced in him — *ask yourself what the city is for* — and rose, and met the singing on the way up, and came down changed. A lid, he heard, in the pedal under the children's thread. A lock, in the verse that had been the Church's whole architecture. And latterly — in the ending nobody counted, in the hall that charged nothing, in sixty throats learning an unpriced song in a house where harvested voices had been inventory — a home. He said it aloud once, to the shelves, testing the arithmetic: "A lid. A lock. And, latterly, a home." The gallery returned it to him with the warmth of a room agreeing, and he stood there until the bell finished, and went to supper owing nothing.

The margins kept their own lights on. In the drainage canals Lena Vance sang evenings again, for no one's collection, and the water carried her down to the tide-gate where Dathan Kaveh kept the gate-clock honest and the couriers' barges loaded at hours the Warden bells no longer governed. Mother Gavel's pumps ran the water-works she had been paid for — paid in function and never flesh, per the only contract in Ashkarad she had never once tried to renegotiate — and her ledgermen walked the wards with empty books now, on Gavel's standing order, because an empty book, she had ruled, was the only honest thing a ledgerman could carry. The freed donors kept their gallery. Vell chalked the schools. The seawalls stood. The city, which had been a harvest for a hundred years, was mending itself in the messy, incremental, unbilled way that bodies mend, and every week the mending needed less of Dar and more of itself, which was, he understood, the entire point of mending.

* * *

Dar climbed to the roof at dusk, because the storm was coming in true.

The salt storms since the Blacktide had been curtsies — white squalls that stamped the rooftops and moved on with their receipts. This one settled in the way landlords settle in, a full white-out riding a wind that tasted of iron and salt, the storm-walls singing their long note, the tenements going out one by one below him like entries being erased by a hand too patient to be hurried. Grace, the city had always called it, bitterly. Tonight the word stood on its own account and paid its own way.

He stood at the roof's edge with his hand over the center of his chest, the way he had stood in another life on a creaking cot with a stolen heart in him and a ledger of vital debt on the desk and a machine's slip in his fist that read RHYTHM UNRESOLVED, MACHINE FAULT. He had said hello to her once, into a washbasin mirror, not knowing what he was greeting. He knew now. He had spent a year and a half learning what he was greeting, and the tuition had been a mother's face, a father's laugh, a first kiss, the color of a childhood door, and every coin had gone somewhere, and none of it had ever been refunded — but the city, which keeps what it loves, had made him a new mother out of its own rememberings, and given her to him unpriced, and the room where the old face hung held its corrected exhibit with the light left on.

The ladder was gone from his mind's back wall. Vahid's chalked rungs — First Vein: Flesh. Wounds knit, strength swells — had carried him as far as a man could climb on a ladder, and the chord had taken their place, rungs dissolved into intervals, a vertical made horizontal and shared. Somewhere the discredited papers were required reading, footnoted and corrected and taught by students who would never know what the word *impossible* had cost the man who wrote them. Somewhere a woman's recorded voice was the most cited text in two

disciplines. The dead's house was full of singing.

One heartbeat. He could hear it if he let the Nerve widen, and he let it widen, and did not spend a thing to hold it there — that was the miracle he had stopped calling a miracle and started calling Tuesday: that the listening cost nothing now, that the door he had opened as a wound stood open as a room. One heartbeat that was somehow many. His own, sixty to the minute, a surgeon's resting rate. Hers, folded into it — the fraction of her that was his, the guest, the duet, the rest of her gone out into the song that needed her more than a chest did, and glad of it. The counted: Suri's rolls and Milla's stamps and Vell's chalk, eleven hundred souls who gave their beats at the bell because giving had gotten cheaper than hoarding. The makers: the school's hammers and the pump-works' pistons and the clinic's kettle, all of it keeping time because the city had finally hired time instead of renting it. And below all of it, so far under that hearing it was closer to remembering, the deep's slow consent — the Root asleep and fed on shares, dreaming without being driven, the low pedal of a foundation that did not lean.

There was a hole in the chord where the eldest sister's beat had been. The city sang around it the way a mouth finds a missing tooth — not forgetting, adjusting — and every sixth bell the maintenance count gave its few beats downward into the dark, and the dark kept them, and kept the books, and did not answer, and that was the shape of the price: paid in full, denominated in distance, honored forever. Isra tended the tide-gate ledger of it now. Some nights Ilay sang the second verse down the shaft anyway, unasked, the way you visit a grave with news.

Suri came up the roof stair with two cups of tea at the hour the storm closed, because she had decided some time ago that the Custodian's ritual belonged to whoever survived it, and she had survived it with the books balanced. She handed him one without marking which. Dar took it and drank, and it did not matter which cup it was, and that — she said, watching him not check — was the whole return on everything they had ever spent. Then she counted the storm's first hour aloud, because it was hers to count, and he stood beside her and let himself be counted among.

The storm took the city. Dar stood in it until the white had him entire — the Saltstairs gone, the Choratorium gone, the fog-sea gone wherever seas go when they are forgiven — and under the white the count held: one heartbeat, many, unbillable, unspent. Across the alley, on the doorframe where a census clerk had once chalked a five-petaled flower because one vessel was missing, someone had drawn the flower again with nine petals, every petal connected to every other, in chalk that the salt could not take. A census. A count. And no one missing.

And far away, under weathers of their own, in seven far cities — Lowmark, the Vigil, Gullet, Sarn, Weep, Ossuar, Hallowfen — seven seeds turned over in their sleep and began, very slowly, to wake.

APPENDIX

The Nine Veins — A Glossary

In the physiology of power taught in Ashkarad's secret anatomies, the human body carries nine veins. The first eight are doors a person may open. The ninth is a door that opens a person.

The Vein of Flesh

Strength, healing, and the discipline of meat. The lowest and most common vein; harvesters and tithe-clerks serve it without ever naming it.

The Vein of Marrow

Endurance written into the bone. Those who open it do not tire; they simply spend.

The Vein of Blood

Debt made physiology. Contracts, tithes, and interest compound through it; every drop is a signature.

The Vein of Breath

Voice, command, and the songs the Silent Chorus forbids. It is opened by speaking a truth no one wants to hear.

The Vein of Nerve

Sensation and signal. The assassins' vein — it lets its bearer feel the city the way a spider feels silk.

The Vein of Bone

Structure and law. The Wardens' vein: it hardens will into skeleton and skeleton into barricade.

The Vein of Mind

Memory, surgery of thought, and the World Registry's quiet custodians.

The Vein of Soul

The penultimate door. Not a rung but a chord — it cannot be climbed alone, only shared.

The Ninth Vein — Throne

Not a rank but a door, sown a century ago by a hand signed only THE GARDENER. Opened at last, it was found to hold a garden, a lid, and a home.